

The Holy Age

LINN AN TEINE

The Legendarium OF Dia-tìr

— The Holy Age

(An Aois Naomh)

being the Books of the age, the Annals of its years,
a Gazetteer of its towns, and the Appendices
the Flame Era, FE 1 – 2,960

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PART ONE

The Cord

CHAPTER ONE

OF ÌOMHAR DEARG AND THE BIER OF SPEARS

FE I

Cha do leag aon duine e; leag an sluagh uile e. No one man brought
him down; the whole host brought him down.
— said on the east bank at Àth na Fala, the night the king fell

I

Of the Fires on the East Bank

The people of Dùn dhearg tell this, and they tell it low, for it is their own shame and their own lord's pride together.

On the night the king fell the host of the east did not sleep. It stood a long while in the water where he had gone down, and then it came out of the river by twos and threes, as men come away from a barrow of their own dead, and lit its fires again along the east bank. Nobody gave the order. The fires were lit because it was dark and the men were wet to the breast and the river had turned cold all at once.

There was a lad at one of those fires, a lad of the eastern hills who had been in the river on the second day and had come out alive. He sat with his knees drawn up and his spear across them, and the older men about him kept asking what the king had been like, close to. He told them the king had been warm. After that they let him alone.

Nobody went back across the ford that night to take the body up out of the river. They had drawn it onto the west bank, where the stone was, and there they

had left it; and nobody on the east bank would say why he did not go and stand over it, or strip it, or cut the grey head off to carry home as the old wars were said to have done. The lad thought afterward that it was fear. He thought also, when he was old, that it was something else that has no plain name, the thing a man feels in a hall when the fire has gone out and the house is still warm from it.

The greybeard who had given the counsel for the third day walked up and down behind the fires until near dawn. At every fire he stopped and said, "It is done. We have done it." At the lad's fire a man threw a stone at him, and he went on.

Before first light the saying had gone the length of the bank: *no one man brought him down; the whole host brought him down*. The households of Dùn dhearg meant it as a boast when they first said it, and by morning it had become an excuse, and before a year was out it was the only thing any of them would say at all.

II

Of the Son Who Came Late

Iomhar Dearg left the valley under Dùn ìseal at noon on the third day of the fighting, which was the day his father fell, and he left it in a temper.

He had been three days in the gathering-house arguing for a stretch of river-grazing below the Red Hill that a nephew of his claimed by his mother. He was fourteen hundred years old, near enough; he had been a grown man when the stones were first raised at Tobar dhìreach round the slab, and there was not a cattle-path in the east he had not ridden. On the first day word had come that the spears of Dùn dhearg were out and that the king had gone down to the ford. He had heard it as they all heard it, with half his mind, as one hears that a neighbour's roof is being mended. The king had gone down to fords before. He had come back from all of them.

On the second day a man of his household came in from the eastern road and said that the host was greater than anyone had thought, and that the king had sent the handful of his own people back up the road and held the ford alone. Ìomhar said that he would go when the grazing was settled. He remembered afterward that he had said it standing up, with his hand on the post of the gathering-house door, and that his nephew had laughed.

On the third morning the grazing was still not settled, and he found that he could not sit still. He went out into the valley and looked east. From the lip of the valley on a clear day a man can see the smoke of Dùn dhearg over the shoulder of the hill, and that morning there was smoke all along the low ground where the river runs, the smoke of many fires, and none of it moving. He stood there a long time. Then he went down to his own camp and told his steward to call up the household, every man who could carry a spear, and the steward asked him whether the grazing was settled.

"It will keep," said Ìomhar Dearg.

"Your nephew will have it by tonight."

"Then he will have it," said Ìomhar, and the steward looked at him, and went.

He rode east with a little over two hundred at his back, and he did not hurry them, which he never forgave himself. The road from the valley to the ford is a few miles, no more than a morning's walk for a carrier with a basket. He could have been at the water by the middle of the afternoon. But the host held the road beyond the second rise, and his scouts came back and told him so; and he turned his people north over the hill-grazing to come down on the ford from above, out of the heather, where the host would not look for them; and the hill was wet and steep and the light went. They lay that night in a fold of the hill a mile above the river. From there they could hear the fighting, and then, toward midnight, they could not.

Ìomhar did not sleep. He sat against a stone with his cloak over his knees and listened to the silence come up out of the valley, and he knew what it was. His steward came and sat by him in the dark and said nothing for a while.

"Maybe he has driven them off," the steward said at last.

"Then we would hear them running," said Ìomhar Dearg.

III

Of the Ford in the Morning

They came down out of the heather in the grey light.

What he saw first was the water. The river below the ford had spread out over the meadow in a sheet, brown and still, with the grass standing up through it, and it did not look like a river at all. It looked like a field in a wet spring. Then he saw why. At the shallows below the ford the dead lay across the

whole width of the stream, piled on one another, thrown up against the gravel as the current had rolled them, so thick that the water came over them in a low fall and made a sound like a mill-lade. The ford itself lay above the dam, wide and slow and dark. Crows were already walking on it.

On the west bank, by a grey stone at the head of the ford, there was one body lying by itself on its back, with nothing near it.

He knew it from the hillside. He knew it by the length of it and by the grey hair, which was the only grey on that bank. Ìomhar did not go to it. He said afterward that he could not have gone to it then and done what came next, and that he chose what came next.

On the east bank the host of Dùn dhearg lay in the heather where it had dropped. It had come out of the river in the night and lit its fires, and the fires had burned down, and the men had gone to sleep where they sat, three thousand of them or what was left of three thousand, wet and bloodied and spent, some with their spears still in their hands and many without. A few were awake. They saw the spears come down out of the hill on the far side of the ford, and they stood up and shouted, and the shout went along the bank; and the men who heard it got up slowly, like men in a dream, and looked for their spears and did not find them.

"They are finished," said the steward, at Ìomhar's elbow. "Look at them. They can't lift their arms."

"Neither could he," said Ìomhar Dearg. "At the last."

He took his household across the ford at a run, over the stones his father had held for three days, through water that was still red at the edges and stank, and up the east bank into the host. It was a slaughter, and the tellers of Dùn dhearg, who have never had much to say about that morning, say at least that much. The men of the east had spent everything they had on the king and had nothing left for his son. Some stood and fought and died. More ran, up the valley toward Dùn dhearg, and Ìomhar's people ran after them and killed them in the heather. Some sat down where they were and put their hands over their heads.

Ìomhar himself fought at the head of it until noon, and then he stopped. He found that he had come to the end of wanting to. He stood on the east bank above the dam of the dead and looked across at the grey stone and the body beside it, and his steward, coming up, found him weeping, and waited a while before he spoke.

By evening he held the ford. It was the thing his father had held, and he had it now; and none of the host who were left alive could have taken it from a child.

IV

Of the Double Bank of Dùn dhearg

Dùn dhearg stands on its hill above the river a few miles from the ford, and in those days it was a fort of the old kind, with two banks of earth about its crown and a ditch between them, and timber halls within where the households of the east met to swear that they owed nothing to Dùn ìseal or its king. It had never been taken. It had not often needed to be.

Ìomhar Dearg came up to it on the second morning after the ford with his household and some hundreds of the host who had surrendered to him and had nowhere else to go. The gate in the outer bank stood open. There was nobody on the bank at all. The women and the old men of the households had heard what had happened at the ford, and many of them had gone up into the eastern hills with the cattle, and those who had not gone stood in the doors of the halls within the inner bank and watched him come.

He walked in through both gates. He did not draw. In the middle of the inner ground, where the households had sworn their oath against his father, he stood and asked who among them had given the counsel of the third day, that every spear should go into the river together and keep going in.

Nobody answered. Nobody had to; the greybeard was not among them. He had been found at dawn of that same morning lying face down in the shallows at the head of the ford, below the grey stone, and whether he had fallen or gone in of his own will, nobody on the east bank would say.

Then Ìomhar asked who had struck the blow that brought the king down in the dark. Nobody answered that either, and this time it was not from fear. He went from face to face, and every face he looked into told him the truth, which was that no one knew, and that no household there would own it if it could. He understood then what the saying on the east bank meant. The whole host had brought him down. It was the only boast they had, and it was also the only thing they could bear to have done.

He burned the halls. He had the people carry out what they wanted first: cloaks, pots, the old men's stools, a loom with the web still on it. Then his household set fire to the thatch, and the halls within the double bank burned through the afternoon, and the smoke went up over the hill and was seen in the valley under Dùn ìseal, where some of the heirs took it to be the host of the east coming on, and armed themselves at last.

When it was done Ìomhar Dearg stood on the inner bank with the hot ash blowing past him and said, loudly enough for the whole ground to hear, that the households of Dùn dhearg had sworn they owed nothing to Dùn ìseal, and he would hold them to it. They owed nothing to Dùn ìseal. They owed everything to him.

Among the people who came in from the hills in the following days there was a lad who had been in the river on the second day and had lived. Ìomhar's steward brought him forward, because the lad had said to someone that he had been close to the king, and the steward thought his lord would want to hear it. Ìomhar asked him what his father had been like at the end.

"He was warm," the lad said.

Ìomhar Dearg looked at him a long time, and then sent him back to his mother, and gave orders that nobody was to touch him. The lad lived to be old, and he never went back to the ford, and it is his telling of the ford that the east keeps.

V

Of the Bier of Spears

On the fifth day after the ford Ìomhar had the body brought up from the west bank.

He went down to it himself at last, alone, with the rest held back on the east side. He had expected to find the face changed, as the faces of the dead are changed. What he found was a young man's face, with no line on it, and the grey hair lying wet across the brow as if he had only that moment come up out of the river. The eyes were open. The wounds were all in front, many of them, and none of them seemed to be enough. He knelt by the stone, where his father had sat between the rushes of the host and drunk from the river and washed his hands, and he closed the eyes. Then he did what his father had done on those evenings. He went down to the edge of the ford and washed his hands in the water, which was clean now above the dam, and cold.

He sent for spears. There were more than enough; they lay in the ford and along both banks and in the heather where the host had dropped them, ash shafts and hazel shafts and a few of old dark oak, and his people gathered them by the armful. The wrights of his household lashed them into a bier with thongs cut from the host's own belts, two long spears for the poles and a lattice of shorter

ones across them, and over the lattice they laid the cloaks of the east. Then they set the king on it.

It took twelve men to carry him. The bier was heavy with the spears, and he had been a big man, bigger than anyone living. Ìomhar chose the twelve from among the host of Dùn dhearg: twelve who had been in the river. He told them that they had brought the king down between them, and between them they would bring him home.

Some of his own household thought that a hard thing to ask. Some thought it a mercy. The twelve went without a word.

Ìomhar Dearg did not go with the bier. He said that he had the east to settle, which was true. He said also, to his steward only, that he would not walk up the valley road behind his father's body among the fires of his brothers and sisters and nephews and cousins who had not come, and be looked at by them as one who had come and been too late; and that when he went up to Dùn ìseal he would go as what he was, and not as a mourner who had been at the wrong gathering.

So the bier went up the valley road without him. It went slowly, with the twelve changing their grip at every stream, and a few of Ìomhar's household walking before it with green branches, as the old custom was for a death on the road. At the lip of the valley two of the king's sons came down to meet it. They had seen the smoke from Dùn dhearg and heard the herd-boy's news, and had ridden out at last, with the spears of their households behind them, and met the bier coming up instead. They got down and walked behind it. Both of them were grey.

VI

Of the Twelve Who Came Back

The twelve came back to Dùn dhearg on the evening of the eighth day, walking, with the two long poles of the bier over their shoulders and nothing on them. The heirs had kept the lattice of short spears and the cloaks, and sent the poles home. Nobody in the valley had wanted to burn them, and nobody had known what else to do with them.

Ìomhar had them brought to him where he sat by the new posts on the inner bank. They stood in a row in the dusk and would not sit, though he told them to. The eldest of them was a man of the barley-fields named in no telling, grey-

bearded, with a cut across one hand from the second day of the ford that had gone bad and smelled. He did the talking.

He said that the bier had gone up the valley road slow, as it had been ordered, and that the two grey sons of the king had walked behind it all the way. He said that the heirs had come out of their tents on both sides of the road to see it go by, more of them than he could have counted, the old and the young together, in good cloaks, and that none of them had said a word to the bearers, good or bad, but only looked at the king.

"And they looked at you," said Ìomhar Dearg.

"Some did," said the man. "Most did not. We were only the bier."

He said that a woman of the valley had come down from the spring with a pail and given each of the twelve water as the bier passed, and had not asked who they were, though she must have known. He said that the keening had started up again as the king went by, at the upper camps first, and run down the valley from fire to fire until it reached the bottom of the road, and that he had heard nothing like it in his life and did not want to again. He said that they had carried the king as far as the long house below the hill, and that there the old men of the slab had taken him from them, and the twelve had been given bread and sent away.

"Was anything said of me?" said Ìomhar.

The man thought about it. "One of them asked where you were," he said. "A young one, laughing. He asked whether you had come up with the bier, and when he heard you had not, he said, 'He has found something to hold, then,' and some of them laughed with him and some did not."

Ìomhar Dearg was silent a long while. Then he asked the man's name, and the man gave it, and the telling has let it go. Ìomhar gave each of the twelve a cow from the herds of the east that had come down out of the hills, and a place on the new ground within the bank, and told them that they were his people now, first of all his people, and that if any man of Dùn dhearg ever threw the ford at them he was to answer for it to him.

The poles of the bier he had set up on either side of the inner gate, where they stood for many years, bleaching, until the weather had them.

VII

Of What Ìomhar Kept

For nine days Ìomhar Dearg stayed at Dùn dhearg.

In those nine days he had the dead of the ford drawn out of the river and buried on the meadow in long trenches, the host of the east all together, because there was no telling them apart. He had the bank of the ford cleared and the grey stone left standing, and he forbade anybody to move it. He sent riders round the eastern hills to the households who had gone up with the cattle and told them to come down, and that they would keep their cattle and their lives if they came down to him and to nobody else. Most of them came. Those who did not were hunted, and the tellers of Dùn dhearg do not say how those hunts ended.

He counted what he had. It was a hill with a double bank and a burned crown, and the valley under it, and the lowland fields toward the south where the eastern households had their barley, and some thousands of people who had come against his father and now had nobody to answer to but him. It was more than any share he had been arguing for in the gathering-house. He had not been given it. He had taken it with a sword, on the morning after the king fell, from men who could not lift their arms, and he knew very well what his kin would say of that, and he did not greatly care.

On the ninth day word came from the valley that the king was laid in the earth, and that the heirs were sending to every coast of the island for the kin who had not come in, so that the whole of the king's blood might sit down together at Dùn ìseal to part what he had left.

"Part it," said Ìomhar Dearg. He was standing on the inner bank where the halls had been. The ash had been cleared and the first new posts were in the ground. "Let them part it. They will not part this."

He went up the valley road the next morning, riding, with his household behind him in the cloaks of the east. The heirs came out of their tents to watch him pass as they had come out to watch the bier. He did not look at any of them. He went up past the fires of the valley to the long gathering-house below the hill, and got down, and stood in the door with the light behind him, and the people inside stopped talking.

His holding was called afterward *an Earrann Dhearg*¹, the Red Share, for the hill and for the blood. It was the one share on the island that was won with a

1. the Red Share of Ìomhar Dearg at Dùn dhearg

sword before the parting and never given in it; and the heirs who sat down to part the rest had to part it around him, as a river parts round a stone it cannot move.

CHAPTER TWO

OF THE RUNNER AT THE SPRING

FE I

I

Of Sìne and the Cord of the Households

At Dùn ìseal the knot-keepers tell this, and they tell it with a cord across their knees.

Sìne nan Snaidhm kept the cord at Dùn ìseal in the year the king fell. It was the cord of the households, of the kind Catrìona Mhòr's people had first made: a long rope of twisted flax, grey with handling, with a knot in it for every hearth in the valleys about the hill. A birth was a small knot tied beside its hearth's knot, a death was a small knot untied, and a household that went away over the hills was cut out and the two ends spliced. Sìne could run it through her fingers in the dark and tell you who lived at the head of every glen from the slab to the salt road, and how many mouths they fed, and which of them had burned their measure early the winter before.

She was of no one's blood that mattered. Her mother had kept the cord before her, and her mother's mother, and nobody could remember why it had gone down that way and not through some better family. She had the tying of it because her fingers were quick, her memory was good, and she could not be bribed, having nothing that she wanted. She had a house of turf and stone below the spring, a husband who cut peat, two daughters who were learning the knots, a goat, and the cord. The cord lived in a basket by the hearth with a lid on it, and when there was news in the valley people came to her door to see it written.

That summer the valley was full of the king's kin. They had been coming in since the spring, from every coast of the island, to wait about the king for their shares, and there were so many of them now that the cord of the households had nothing to say about them. Each of them was a fire and no household: there was a fire for every son and daughter of the king who had come, and every grandchild, and every great-grandchild, and all the fires down the length of the valley had stewards to argue for them and servants to fetch their water and grievances against the fire next door. Sìne fetched her own water, and on most evenings she was the only woman at the spring who did.

The king had gone down to the ford seven days before the runner came. Everybody knew he had gone. The talk at the spring was that the spears of Dùn dhearg were out, and that the old man had taken a handful of his own people and gone to meet them, and that the kin would follow him in a day or two when the grazing and the salt and the shore-rights were settled. Sìne had heard it every evening. On the second day the smoke of many fires had stood over the low ground to the east, and nobody moved. Two days after the fighting stopped, a great smoke went up over Dùn dhearg itself, a black smoke that leaned north in the wind, and the fires in the valley took it for the host of the east coming on at last, and there was a great running about and arming, and stewards shouting at each other about whose spears should stand at the head of the road. Then nothing came, and the smoke thinned, and the kin put their spears away again and went back to arguing.

II

Of the Herd-Boy

She was at the spring with her pails on the fourth evening after the battle when the runner came up the valley road.

He was a herd-boy of the eastern hills, barefoot, in a shirt that had been white at some time and was now the colour of the heather. He came up the road at a run that had gone past running, the run of a body that has forgotten how to do anything else, and he had run so far that he could not stop when he reached the spring. He went on past it three or four steps, and then his legs folded and he sat down in the mud with a grunt, as if someone had pushed him.

Sine put her pail down beside him and gave him water in her cupped hands, because the pail was too heavy for him to lift. He drank half and was sick, and drank the rest.

"Where is the camp of the king's son?" he said. "Any of them. I was told to tell the king's sons."

She looked down the valley at the fires, which were being lit for the evening, one after another, all the way to the bend of the road and past it.

"There are sixty camps in this valley that call themselves the king's sons," said Sine. "Tell me, and I'll tell them."

His name was Donnan, and he came from the high grazings north of the ford, where his people had summer shielings. He had been with the cattle on the ridge above the river when the host of Dùn dhearg came down the valley, and he had stayed there, because the cattle could not be left and because he wanted to see. He had seen all of it. For three days he had lain in the heather on the ridge with a crust in his shirt and watched.

He told her, sitting in the mud, in the plain words of a herd-boy, with his teeth going. The king had held the ford alone, three days and three nights. The host had come at him through the water and across the deep channel above it, all the first day and all the second, and the dead had piled at the shallows until the river backed up behind them and spread out over the meadow. On the third day every spear of the east had gone into the river together, and had kept going in, and there had been a light round the king in the afternoon that the boy could not describe, and did not try to twice. On the third night the king went down. No one man had done it. They had come at him until there were no more of him to come at.

"I would have come the straight road," he said, "but they are all over it. The host. Those that are left of them. And then there were other spears coming down off the hill in the morning, the day after, and I didn't know whose they were, so I went round. Over the tops. I have been two days coming over the tops."

"Whose were they?" said Sine. "The spears in the morning?"

"I don't know. They came from this side. They killed the rest." He looked past her at the tents, all down the valley, and the smoke of the cooking fires going up straight in the still evening, and a woman laughing somewhere, and a dog. He had come a long way. "Where were his kin?" he said. "The king's kin. Where were they?"

Sine did not answer that. She picked up the boy by the arm, and left her pails at the spring, and took him up to the tents.

III

Of the Question in the Valley

She remembered afterward, and told it to her daughters, and they to theirs, that the first thing said when the news went into the camps was a question about the hill.

The nearest fire-circle was where she took him, because it was the nearest, and because she did not know which of the sixty was the right one and did not believe that any of them was. A steward in a blue cloak came out to see what the knot-woman wanted, and she told him to hear the boy, and he heard him through. He was a man of middle years, clean-shaven, with good shoes, and he heard the whole of it without a word, looking at the boy's feet. When it was finished he turned round to the men behind him at the fire, and he said:

"Who holds the hill now?"

Sine watched that question go down the valley faster than the grief did. It went from fire to fire as a spark goes along dry heather. She saw men get up from their suppers and walk quickly to the next fire, and men come out from the next fire to meet them; she saw stewards running, and a boy sent up the slope toward the upper camps at a gallop on a pony; she heard the question asked at a dozen fires before she heard anybody weep. For a while nobody keened at all. The valley was full of voices, and all the voices were talking about the hill.

Then a woman in one of the upper camps began to keen alone.

She was a daughter of the king, and her name was Mairsile. She was so old that her hair had gone white and then gone thin, and she had come in from the north coast in a litter that spring because she could no longer ride, and she had sat all summer at her fire in the upper valley with a blanket over her knees and taken no part in the arguing. Her keen was thin and cracked, like the voice of a very old bird, and at first it only made the voices below it louder. But it did not stop. After a while the fire nearest hers took it up, and then the next; and it came down the valley from fire to fire as the question had gone up it, slowly, until the whole of the valley was crying in the dark, the old and the young, the stewards and the servants, the sons and daughters and grandchildren of the king; and the herd-boy with it, sitting on the ground by the fire of the blue-cloaked steward with his face in his arms.

Sine did not keen. She stood a while and listened, and then she went back down to the spring, where her pails were still standing in the dark, and carried

them home, and put the lid more firmly on the basket where the cord was. Her husband asked her from the bed what the noise was. She told him the king was dead, and that the kin were asking who had the hill. He said nothing for a while, and then he said that the peat would want cutting the same, whoever had it; and she lay down beside him and did not sleep.

IV

Of the Bier Coming Up

The bier came up the valley road three days after the boy.

Sine was at the spring again, because the water had to be fetched whatever happened, and she saw it come round the bend of the road below, slowly, with the evening sun behind it. It was a strange long thing, black and bristling, and at first she did not know what it was. Then she saw that it was made of spears: two long spears for the poles and a lattice of shorter ones lashed across them, with cloaks laid over the lattice, and on the cloaks a man lying.

Twelve men carried it, men of the east and none of the valley, in the rough brown cloaks of the eastern barley-country, and some of them had cuts on their arms and faces that had not healed. Before them walked a few men with green branches, as the old custom was for a death on the road, and behind them walked two old men, tall, with grey heads, who she knew were sons of the king because she had seen them at the gathering-house door; and behind those came the spears of their households, who had ridden out that morning to meet the bier and were now walking home behind it.

The heirs came out of the tents on both sides of the road to see it pass. Sine stood among them with her pail.

She had seen the king three times in her life, and each time far off: a tall man on a horse at the edge of a gathering, with people falling back from him on either side. She saw him now close to, for the first time and the last. He had not grown old. His hair was grey, as it had been since before anyone in the valley could remember, but his face was a young man's face, and his eyes had been closed. The wounds were all in front. There were a great many of them, and none of them, to look at, seemed enough.

The bearers were thirsty. She could see it in their mouths. None of the heirs had thought to give them anything, and the bearers would not ask. When the bier

came level with the spring she stepped out into the road and gave each of the twelve water from her pail, in a cup she carried at her belt, one after another as they walked, without stopping them. None of them looked at her. The last of them, a grey-bearded man with a bad hand, said "Thank you," very low, in the speech of the east. She did not ask who they were. She thought that she knew.

The keening began again as the king went by, at the upper camps first, where Mairsile's fire was, and ran down the valley to the bottom of the road. Sìne walked beside the bier as far as the long gathering-house below the hill. There the old keepers of the slab were waiting, nine of them, on the bench before the door, and they stood up and took the king from the twelve men of the east, and the twelve were given bread and sent away.

As they went a young man of the kin, standing at the gathering-house door with his thumbs in his belt, asked loudly whether Ìomhar Dearg had come up with the bier. When he heard that Ìomhar had not, he said, "He has found something to hold, then," and laughed. Some of the kin about him laughed too. Sìne knew him. He was a grandson of the king, some nine hundred years old, who laughed at most things, and whom the kin called Niall Òg, Niall the Young; and she saw that when the others had stopped laughing he went on looking after the twelve men of the east, down the road, and did not laugh any more.

V

Of the Two Mounds

Where they laid the king, the tellers of Dùn ìseal and the tellers of the Ma-son's line do not agree, and each has a mound to show.

This much all agree on. He lay for three nights in the gathering-house, on the lattice of spears, with the keepers of the slab sitting by him in turn and the kin coming in to look at him and going out again. On the fourth morning he was carried out before dawn, with the nine keepers walking before and his two grey sons behind, and a few of the eldest of the kin; and he was laid in the earth that same day, and a mound raised over him, and nobody who was not there saw it done.

The tellers of Dùn ìseal say that they laid him on the slope of the hill, on the side that faces the vein, with his face toward the mountain, as the keepers of the

slab were laid. There is a long low mound on that slope, grown over with heather, and the knot-keepers of Dùn ìseal will take you to it if you ask.

The tellers of the Mason's line say otherwise. There was a man of Clann na Ceiste¹ in the valley that year, a reciter from Tobar dhìreach named Seathan Crom, who had walked down to Dùn ìseal at midsummer to see the king once more before he died, for he was an old man and the king had been kind to his father. He was lame in one leg, which is why they called him Crom, and he was at the gathering-house when the bier came in. The reciters of the Mason's line say that it was Seathan who went to the grey sons on the third night and reminded them of what the king was: that he had been crowned in a grove by the gods themselves and was the heir of the mason's fire, and that he should lie where the fire had first come to his people, and not on a hillside among keepers. They say the grey sons heard him, and that the bier went out before dawn by the north road and not by the slope; and the reciters of the Mason's line have a mound of their own to show, older-looking, in a place they will name only to their own.

Sine was not there, and she said so to her daughters. She said that she had seen the bier go out of the gathering-house in the dark, and the lamps go with it, and she had not followed. She said that when the grey sons came back in the evening they were very tired and their shoes were wet, and that the shoes might have got wet on either road.

The knot-keepers who tell this tale after her leave the matter there.

VI

Of the Lord of Dùn dhearg

On the day after the burial, Ìomhar Dearg came up the valley road.

He came riding, which nobody did in that valley any more except the king, and he came with his household behind him, two hundred spears or more, all in the rough brown cloaks of the east. The valley had heard by then whose spears had come down off the hill on the morning after the ford, and what they had done, and what they had done after that at Dùn dhearg. The heirs came out of their tents to see him pass as they had come out to see the bier, and they did not keen this time. They stood in silence on both sides of the road, and Ìom-

1. the Children of the Question

har Dearg rode up between them, looking at nobody, a big red-bearded man on a big horse, and got down at the gathering-house door.

Sine was inside, because she had been sent for. The keepers of the slab had asked her to sit at the back of the house with the cord of the households, in case there was need to say who lived where. She saw him stand in the door with the evening light behind him, and she saw the talk in the house stop as if a knife had cut it.

"I have come," said Ìomhar Dearg, "as the lord of Dùn dhearg."

Nobody said anything. It was the eldest of the keepers of the slab, an old bent man named Aodh Crom, who stood up at last from the bench by the hearth and said that the lord of Dùn dhearg was welcome under that roof, as anyone of the king's blood was welcome, and that he might sit.

Ìomhar Dearg sat. He did not take off his cloak. He sat a little apart from his brothers and sisters, on a stool his own steward carried in for him, and he said nothing more that evening. But Sine, who watched him from the back of the house with the cord in her lap, saw that the others kept looking at him when they thought he did not see; and that when they spoke of the shares, as they were already speaking of them, they spoke of them around him, as a stream goes round a stone.

VII

Of the Runners to Every Coast

That night the heirs sent to every coast.

There were kin of the king who had not come in that summer: some who were too old, some who had quarrelled with the others, some who had held that there was no hurry, since the king had lived four thousand years and would plainly live four thousand more. Now there was a hurry. Runners went out of the valley before dawn by every road, north over the high passes, west toward the lake shore and the salt, south to the barley-country and the southern sea. They went in pairs, one from each of two fires that did not trust each other, so that neither fire could send a message the other had not heard. There were so many pairs of runners on the roads in the week after that the carriers coming up from the coast to the slab with their baskets of fish thought there had been a war.

The kin who had come in waited. They buried nobody else, and they did not go home. They sat at their fires and argued about who held the hill, and who should, and by what rule, and they began to count one another.

The counting was the trouble. Every fire in the valley had its own reckoning of how many of the king's blood there were, and every reckoning left out somebody that another fire said was owed, and put in somebody that another fire said was nobody. The stewards went from fire to fire with notched sticks and came back with different numbers. Nobody believed anybody else's sticks. A steward of the salt shore came to blows with a steward of the western lake over a great-grand-child whom one of them counted twice and the other not at all, and the child's mother, when they asked her, said that she had four sons and had not come all this way to be counted as half of one.

Three nights after Iomhar Dearg came up, there was a knock at Sìne's door, late, when the fire was banked and the children asleep. She opened it and found Aodh Crom there, the eldest of the keepers of the slab, leaning on his staff in the dark, with the rain running off his hood.

He was older than any keeper of the slab had been before him, and he looked it. His people said that there was a thin strain of the king's long years in them somewhere far back, through some marriage in the old days that nobody would name, and he had outlived three wives and most of his grandchildren. He had sat on the bench by the slab at Tobar dhìreach for longer than Sìne's mother had been alive. She had never had him at her door before.

"I want a new cord," he said.

"The households are counted," said Sìne. "I have them all. You saw them to-night."

"Not the households," said the keeper. "The heirs. They will want to know how many there are before they start. And they will not believe each other."

She looked at him a long time in the dark doorway, with the rain coming down between them. Then she said that she would need flax, a good deal of it, and a place to sit where every one of them would have to come to her, and not she to them.

"The door of the gathering-house," said Aodh Crom. "They will all come through that."

"And who will they believe," said Sìne, "when they won't believe each other?"

"You," said the old man. "Because you want nothing." He pulled his hood forward over his face. "And because none of them will have thought yet that you are worth the trouble of buying."

He went away up the path in the rain. Sine shut the door and stood a while in the dark by the banked fire. Then she took the lid off the basket, and took out the cord of the households, and began to run it through her fingers, knot by knot, from the slab to the salt road; and she was still at it when the grey came into the smoke-hole at dawn.

CHAPTER THREE

OF THE BINDING OF THE FIRST FLAME

FE I

Cha tèid an fhèith a roinn. Gearr i, agus silidh i fuil. The vein will
not be parted. Cut it, and it bleeds.

I

Of the Keepers of the Slab

This is told at Tobar dhìreach, where the slab lies, by the households whose turn it is to sit by it.

Under the king the hill-folk of Dia-thìr had burned the coloured coal by the handful and shared their grain before the storms, and at every gathering they said that they had always been on the island and had come from nowhere. Nine keepers, one drawn by lot for each district of the hills, watched the slab over the crack at Tobar dhìreach where the mason had broken the vein at the beginning of the count. All of it was custom. None of it was law, for there had been no law but the king's word, and the king was in the earth.

Aodh Crom had been drawn for his district so many times that the households had stopped drawing and simply sent him. He was the eldest of the nine that year, and the eldest keeper there had ever been. His people said that some grandmother of his, far back in the long reign, had married a grandson of the king whose name the family did not say, and that a little of the long years had come down to them in the blood, thinned out like a dye in a great vat of water. Aodh had lived a hundred and eighty years and walked with a stick. He had buried three

wives and four of his seven children. He was older than any keeper had been before him, and younger than the youngest of the king's sons in the valley, who were none of them less than some centuries old; and he knew both things about himself, and thought about the second more than the first.

When the runners had gone out to every coast, the nine keepers came down from Tobar dhìreach to Dùn ìseal together, walking, with the fire of their hut carried before them in a covered pot.

That fire was the only thing in their charge besides the slab. It had burned in the keepers' hut beside the slab for as long as anyone could remember, fed with a little of the coloured coal each night and never let go out, and the keepers passed it from hand to hand at the change of the lot as they passed the slab. The reciters of the Mason's line held that it had been lit from the mason's own fire, the fire the lightning had kindled in the broken vein, and carried from hearth to hearth down all the generations until it came to the keepers. The keepers did not say that. They said only that it was old, and that it was not allowed to go out, and they did not quarrel with the reciters, who were welcome to their telling.

They brought it down to Dùn ìseal in the pot because Aodh Crom had told them to. The others had asked him why.

"Because they are going to fight over the hill," he had said, "and I want something in the room that is older than they are."

On the road down the nine keepers passed a great many carriers going up and down between the slab country and the coast, as they always did at that season, with their baskets on their backs; and every carrier stopped and asked them the same thing: whether the handful would still be given out at Samhain. None of them asked who would hold the hill. Aodh Crom told each of them that it would. He did not know it. He said afterward that it was the first promise he made in the matter of the Binding, and that he made it to people who had no knot on anyone's cord and no voice in the gathering-house, and that it was the one he minded most about keeping.

II

Of the First Quarrel

The heirs' first quarrel was over the hill, and it came before any other, because the hill stands over the vein.

They met for it in the long gathering-house below Dùn ìseal on the twentieth day of the month, when the nearer coasts had come in and the farther were on the roads. The house was built for the gatherings of the valley and held some hundreds at a pinch, and that day it held more than it could, and the rest stood outside the doors in the drizzle and passed back what was said. The kin sat on the benches along the walls by the age of their lines, as near as they could agree on it, which was not near. The nine keepers of the slab sat at the back of the house on a bench of their own by the hearth, with their covered pot on the floor between their feet, and nobody paid them any heed.

The king had held the hill of Dùn ìseal in his own hand at the last, and had given it to no one. Every line in the house claimed it, and every line by a different rule.

Murchadh Mòr claimed it by the rule of the eldest. He was the king's eldest living son, close on two thousand nine hundred years old, a heavy slow man with a white beard to his belt and a voice like a door on a cold hinge, and he did not argue his claim so much as stand in it. He said that the eldest son took the father's hearth, as every household in the hills knew, and that the hill was the king's hearth, and he was the eldest son, and there was an end of it.

Eithne nic Ailein rose before he had sat down. She was a daughter of the king, some nineteen hundred years old, small and quick, with a sharp chin and a sharper tongue, and she held the lowland barley-country toward the south sea in all but name. She said that if the hill went to the eldest, then the eldest had only to die for the hill to be parted among his eleven sons, and each of those among his, and that she for one would sooner not live to see it.

"You are not likely to," said Murchadh Mòr.

Eithne's hand went to her belt, and so did the hands of the men behind her; and the men behind Murchadh stood up; and there was very nearly blood on the floor of the gathering-house on the first day. It was Niall Òg, the laughing grandson, who got between them, with his hands open and spread, saying that he had not come all this way to see his aunt and his uncle kill each other before he had been given anything to be killed for. Some laughed. Enough of them sat down.

Then the others began. There were those who claimed the hill by the rule of the living: that the king's children who were alive, and there were more than a score of them, stood before the children of his dead children, whose lines were only grandchildren. The lines of the dead answered that the king had loved their fathers and mothers as well as he had loved anyone in the house, and better than

some, and that a grandson of a firstborn stood higher than a fifth daughter. There were those who said that the hill should go to whoever the king would have chosen, and each of those had a different notion of whom the king would have chosen, and a story to prove it. A cousin from the western shore, whose name the tellers have let go, stood up and said that there was no call for all this. The hill could be cut like any other ground. Give each of the great lines a gallery, he said, and let each dig its own, and the one that dug deepest would be the one the vein loved best.

There was a noise in the house at that, half laughter and half a growl. Aodh Crom, on the keepers' bench at the back, looked down at the pot between his feet.

III

Of What the Old Keeper Said

The heirs argued through that day and into the night, and on the second day, and into the third.

Aodh Crom listened to all of it. He heard the rule of the eldest put twenty times and the rule of the living thirty. He heard the western cousin's galleries taken up by a dozen young heirs who liked the sound of digging for themselves, and heard their fathers shout them down. Once a great-grandson of the king explained at length that he had a better claim than anybody present through a marriage in the second millennium of the reign, and the whole house groaned. Once, late on the second night, when the lamps were low and most of the old heirs were asleep on their benches, he heard a young woman near the door say quite quietly to her neighbour that the king had been dead eighteen days and nobody in the house had yet said his name.

On the third day, toward evening, he got up.

He did it slowly, because of his knees and his stick, and at first nobody noticed. Then the keepers on either side of him stood up too, to help him, and then the whole bench stood, and the heirs nearest the back turned round to see what the old men were doing, and so it went up the house, until the house was looking at him and had fallen quiet, more from surprise than respect.

He was a small man, bent almost double, and his voice was thin. He did not raise it. The heirs at the far end of the house had to lean forward, and they did.

"Cut the vein," he said, "and it bleeds."

He waited, and then he said the rest of it. "You will be parting it for as long as there is any of it left to part. Every one of your children will want a gallery, and every one of theirs. You will be cutting the mountain into slices for the rest of your lives, and your lives are long. And when there is nothing left in it you will part the hole."

Nobody laughed.

Then he reminded them what the keepers of the slab had asked of Catriona Mhòr in her time, when she held the hill under the king: that the keepers' charge be declared before a whole gathering, so that it should stand on something firmer than custom. Catriona Mhòr had told them to ask again when the king was gone, since while he lived his word was all the declaring anyone needed. The king was gone. He was asking again.

"And I ask more," said Aodh Crom. "I ask that the vein, and the hill over it, be put into no share at all. Let no one of the king's blood hold it. Not the eldest, not the living, not the dead. Give it to the keepers, who are nobody's, and let the keepers answer for it to the gods."

He sat down. The keepers on either side of him sat down with him.

The heirs were quiet a long while. It was the longest quiet in the gathering-house in three days, and Aodh Crom said afterward that he had counted his own breaths through it, and got to forty.

Then Eithne nic Ailein laughed. It was a short laugh, and not a kind one. "I would sooner nobody had it," she said, "than Murchadh."

Murchadh Mòr turned his great head and looked at her. "I would sooner nobody had it," he said, "than Eithne."

So it went down the house, line by line. The lines of the living would sooner nobody had it than the lines of the dead, and the lines of the dead than the lines of the living. The western cousin would sooner nobody had it than whichever of his uncles would have taken it from him. Ìomhar Dearg, who had sat three days on his stool apart from the others and said nothing, stood up when it came near him and said that he held Dùn dhearg, and that the hill was nothing to him either way; but that he would sooner it went to the old man's pot than to any of his brothers; and sat down. Niall Òg said he would sooner nobody had it than anybody, since he was plainly never going to be given it himself, and at least this way he would not have to watch someone else enjoy it.

Each of them was willing to give the thing away sooner than see a cousin get it. The tellers of Dùn ìseal, who love the Binding more than any other tale they tell, admit that this is how it was won.

IV

Of Murchadh at the Hut

That night, the night between the old keeper's words and the swearing, Murchadh Mòr came up the slope to the keepers' hut alone.

Aodh Crom was sitting by the pot with the lid off, feeding the fire. He heard the heavy step outside and the door-skin pushed aside, and the king's eldest son came in stooping, for the door was low and he was a very big man, and stood a moment getting his breath. Then he sat down on the ground across the fire from the keeper, as a carrier sits, with his knees up.

"You'll not have the hill for yourself," said Murchadh Mòr. "You understand that. None of you. It goes to the fire and not to the man who feeds the fire."

"I understand it," said Aodh Crom.

"Then what do you want?"

The old keeper thought about it. "To die before I see you cut the mountain," he said. "And I am a hundred and eighty, and you are nearly three thousand, so I have the better chance."

Murchadh looked at him. Then, to Aodh's surprise, he laughed, a short creaking laugh like a gate, and put out his hands to the fire.

They sat so a long while. The king's son said nothing for a time, and then he began to talk about his father: how he had ridden with him to the salt shore in the first thousand years of the reign, when the salt-folk would not kneel, and how the king had gone down alone to the edge of the water and stood there until they came out to him. He said that his father had never told him anything he did not need to know, in two thousand nine hundred years, and that he had thought there would be time.

"I was on my way," he said. "I want you to know it. I was on my way to the ford. I had the spears called up. I was going in the morning, when I had the salt-rights settled with my sister." He looked into the fire. "They are still not settled."

Aodh Crom said nothing, because there was nothing to say that would help, and the king's eldest son knew it. After a while Murchadh got up, stooping, and went to the door, and turned there.

"Tomorrow I swear first," he said. "Because I am the eldest. You will see to it."

"You will swear first," said Aodh Crom.

When he had gone the old keeper sat a long while looking at the door-skin, which was still swinging. The young woman by the gathering-house door had been wrong, he thought. Somebody in the valley had said the king's name at last. It had taken eighteen days, and it had been said in the dark to an old man of no account, where no one else would hear it.

V

Of the Swearing

They swore it the next day, the twenty-third of the month, three weeks after the king fell. It was the first oath the heirs took, before they had agreed on anything else; and it was the one oath all of them could take, then or afterward.

The keepers had asked for it to be done out of doors, on the slope above the gathering-house where the ground runs up toward the mountain, and the heirs had agreed, since the house would not hold them all and nobody wanted to swear in a room where somebody else had been given the best seat. They stood on the wet slope in the order of their lines, as near as they could agree on it, with their households below them, and the valley people below the households, and the carriers who had come up from the coast with fish and found the whole kingdom on a hillside standing among the valley people with their baskets on their backs.

The nine keepers stood at the top of the slope with the pot. Aodh Crom took the lid off it with his own hands, and lifted out the fire in its dish of clay, and held it up so that the whole slope could see it: a small red fire of the coloured coal, burning low, with a thread of smoke going straight up in the still air.

He said whose it was from then on. He said it was Bride's, who keeps the hearth and the undying flame, and that it would not be let go out while there was anyone on the island to feed it. He said that the vein under the mountain, and the slab over the first break in it, belonged from that day to Crom Cruaich, the bent one of the mound, whose price is measured, and that what was taken from the

vein would be answered for to Crom. He said that the keepers of the slab would keep both, the flame for Brìde and the vein for Crom, and that they would keep them for no one's share and in no one's name; and that no one of the king's blood would ever hold either, though every one of the king's blood might warm his hands.

The reciters of the Mason's line, standing among the valley people, say that the flame Aodh Crom held up that day had come down from the mason's fire. The keepers never said so, and they kept the two apart after, as the reciters did too, at the last. The mason's fire is the first fire, which the lightning lit in the broken vein at the beginning of the count. The First Flame is the flame that was sworn to on the slope below Dùn Ìseal, and it is from that swearing that the Holy Age has its name.

Then the heirs came up the slope one by one to swear, and it took until dark.

Murchadh Mòr came first, as the eldest, and he put his great hand over the fire in the dish and held it there till the heat made him take it away, and said that he would never hold the vein, and went down again without looking at anyone. Eithne came after him and did the same, quickly, and said something to Aodh Crom under her breath that the old man would never repeat. Ìomhar Dearg came in his brown cloak of the east and swore with his left hand, since his right was cut, and nobody asked how. Niall Òg swore, and grinned at the old keeper, and said, "There. Now I've given away something."

The last of the king's blood to come up the slope that day was nobody the heirs knew.

He was a man of middle height, weathered, in a plain hill cloak, and he had walked down out of the high valleys to the west of Tobar dhìreach when he heard the king was dead. His name was Gille-Brìde. He was of the line of Somhairle, the king's son who had lived among Clann na Ceiste¹ by the slab and died long before his father, and who had taken no share of anything, and whose children had kept to the high valleys ever since and asked for nothing. Gille-Brìde was a man of a hundred and seventy-two, which was young for a man of the king's blood and old for anyone else, and he had the long years in him, though they were running out.

He put his hand over the fire and swore that he would never hold the vein. Then he asked Aodh Crom, very courteously, whether he might take a coal of it home.

1. the Children of the Question

The keepers looked at one another. Nobody had asked that. Aodh Crom said that he might, since the flame was sworn to no one and so was the one thing on the island that anyone might have a little of. Gille-Bride took a coal from the dish on the end of a stick, and dropped it into a small clay pot he had carried at his belt for the purpose, and put the lid on it, and went down the slope past the heirs, who stared at him.

"And your share?" said one of them. "You're of the blood. You'll want your knot."

"I've got what I came for," said Gille-Bride, and he walked back up into the high valleys with the pot under his arm that same night; and no knot was ever tied for him on anyone's cord.

VI

Of the Night after the Binding

Aodh Crom sat that night in the keepers' hut on the slope above the gathering-house, where they had carried the dish, and fed the flame.

It was a small hut, of stone and turf, with one low door. The flame burned on a flat stone in the middle of it, in its dish, and the old man sat on the ground beside it with a basket of coal and put a little on from time to time with his fingers, as the keepers had always done, and listened to the valley.

The valley was loud. The heirs had gone back to their fires in a good humour for the first time since the king fell, pleased with themselves for having given a thing away, and they were drinking to it. He could hear singing from the upper camps. He could hear Niall Òg's laugh, which carried. Below all of it, down on the valley floor, he could hear the carriers, who had stood all day on the slope with their baskets and now had to go back down to the coast in the dark with them, calling to one another on the road.

After a while another of the keepers came in and sat down across the flame from him. She was the youngest of the nine that year, a woman of the southern districts named in no telling, and she had not said a word all day.

"They'll go back to the hill tomorrow," she said.

"They will," said Aodh Crom. "Tomorrow they'll start on the rest of it. The shares. And they'll count each other, and they'll cut each other, and they'll hate

each other for a thousand years, some of them, for they have the years to do it in." He put a coal on the flame. "But not over this."

"And who holds this?" said the woman. "When you are gone? And the rest of us?"

For a while he gave her no answer. He was thinking of the young woman by the door of the gathering-house, on the second night, who had said that the king was eighteen days dead and nobody had said his name.

"Somebody of nobody's blood," he said at last. "They will need to find somebody of nobody's blood. That will be the hardest thing they ever do." And he put another coal on, and the flame took it, and the smoke went up straight through the hole in the roof into the dark over Dùn ìseal.

CHAPTER FOUR

Of the knots

FE I

I

Of the Flax and the Door

At Dùn ìseal the knot-keepers tell this, and they tell it with a cord across their knees.

Sine nan Snaidhm sat down at the door of the long gathering-house below Dùn ìseal on the second day of an Dàmhair, in the morning, with a basket of flax beside her and a stool under her and a new cord in her lap.

She had spent the days since the old keeper's knock making the cord. It had taken the flax of three households, bought with the keepers' coal, and she and her two daughters had twisted it on the long walk behind her house, the elder girl turning the hook and the younger walking backward down the walk with the strands, until they had a rope as thick as a thumb and longer than the gathering-house, coiled in the basket like a sleeping snake. It was pale and new and smelled of the retting pond, and she had never had one so long in her hands.

She had worked out the knots at night, by the fire, on a spare length. The cord of the households had one knot to a hearth, and small knots beside it for the mouths the hearth fed. That would not do for the heirs. The heirs had no hearths that mattered; they had lines. So she had taken threads of dyed wool, one colour for each child of the king who had living heirs in the valley, as near as the keepers could tell her how many that was, and she meant to tie each heir's knot with a turn of his line's thread caught in it, so that a knot could be traced back by its colour to the child of the king it came down from. It was not a new thing. The households did something like it for marriages. But nobody had ever done it with so many colours, and she had had to send to the dyers of the lowlands for some of

them; and by the first morning she had twenty-three colours of wool in a bag at her belt, and knew she would want more.

The keepers had chosen the door because every heir had to come through it. Aodh Crom had said to the heads of the lines that no one would be heard in the gathering-house on the matter of the shares who had not first been knotted at the door. The heads of the lines had agreed, each thinking that it would keep out somebody else. So when the doors were opened that morning there was a crowd outside them that went back down the path and round the side of the house and out onto the grass, all in their good cloaks, all watching the woman on the stool.

"Say your line," said Sine nan Snaidhm to the first of them, "and I'll tie your knot."

II

Of Murchadh Mòr

The eldest came first. That had been agreed without argument, because none of the others could think how to argue it, and because nobody wanted to stand in front of him.

Murchadh Mòr stood over her in the doorway so that his shadow fell across the cord, and he gave his line in two words.

"Ailean's son."

Then he looked down the valley to see who would argue. Nobody did.

Sine took the thread of his colour, which was a dark blue, and caught it into the cord, and tied the knot. She tied it slowly and hard, because she could feel him watching her fingers, and she did not look up. He stood over her the whole time she tied it, as if she might tie it loose. When it was done she ran her thumb over it and said, "That is you," and he bent down, a very long way, and felt the knot himself between his great fingers, and then straightened up and went in without another word.

After him came his sons, eleven of them, all old men, and each gave his line in three words, "Murchadh's son, Ailean's grandson," or near enough; and after the sons their sons, and theirs. The blue went into the cord at every knot, and the cord began to come out of the basket and lie across Sine's lap and over her knees and down onto the step, and the elder daughter, who sat behind her, began to coil it into a second basket as it came.

It took the whole of the first day to knot the line of Murchadh.

III

Of Eithne's Knot-Keeper

Eithne nic Ailein came on the second morning, and she did not come alone. She had brought a knot-keeper of her own from the lowlands, a thin young man with long clever fingers and a face like a heron, named Fionn Beag. Why she had brought him she did not say, and had no need to. She set him on the step beside Sìne, close enough that their elbows touched, and told him to count the count after her.

Sìne said nothing. She gave Eithne her knot, with green for her line, and Eithne gave her line crisply, "Ailean's daughter," and stood back and watched Fionn Beag bend over the cord and run the knot through his fingers and nod.

After that Fionn Beag counted every knot. He counted Eithne's children and grandchildren, and he counted the lines that came after them, the grey of the line of Fionnghal of the western shore, the brown of Artair's line of the salt shore, the yellow of Cormac's in the east. He counted them all day. When Sìne tied a knot he reached across and felt it; when she caught a colour into it he checked it against the bag; when an heir gave a line he listened with his head on one side, and more than once he stopped an heir and asked him to say it again. Sìne let him. She did not hurry and she did not slow down.

On the evening of the fourth day he went to Eithne at her fire and told her that the knot-keeper of Dùn ìseal had made no mistake. He said it had been four days and near two hundred knots, and that he had never in his life seen fingers like hers, and that he did not think he could have kept up with her if she had not been letting him.

Eithne sent him home in the morning.

Before he went he came to the door of the gathering-house and stood a moment on the step, looking at the cord coiled in its baskets, and then at Sìne.

"How do you do it?" he said. "Four days, and your hands aren't tired."

"They are tired," said Sìne. "It isn't my hands that are doing it."

He did not understand her, and she did not explain, and he went back down to the lowlands, where he kept the cord of Eithne's households for the rest of his life and was reckoned the best knot-keeper in the south. But he told his own chil-

dren that there was a woman at Dùn ìseal who could hold seven hundred people in her head at once and tie them in the right order, and that the heirs of the king did not know what they had sitting on their doorstep.

IV

Of Niall Òg and the Knot Tied Once

Niall Òg came on the fifth day, laughing.

He was a grandson of the king, nine hundred years old, and at nine hundred he was a boy beside his uncles and his aunts. So they had called him the Young since before he could remember, and he had never got rid of it and had long since stopped trying. He had a round face and quick brown eyes and a mouth that was always about to smile, and he had been in the valley all summer at a small fire of his own on the edge of the upper camps, where he argued for nothing in particular and listened to everyone.

He gave his line through his mother, who was a daughter of the king, dead these two thousand years; and Sìne took the colour of that line, which was a pale red, and began to catch it in. Then he gave his line again through his father, who was a son of a son of the king, of another line altogether, the grey line of Fionnghal; and when Sìne looked up at the second he grinned at her and said, "I'm owed twice."

She tied the knot once.

She tied it with the pale red of his mother's line, since he had given that first, and left the grey out; and when it was done she ran her thumb over it and said, "That is you."

"And my father?" said Niall.

"Your father has a knot of his own," said Sìne. "Two, if you like. His own, and his line's. You are one man."

Niall Òg looked at her. For a moment she thought he would argue, and she saw the men of the lines standing behind him lean in to hear it. Then he laughed again, differently, and put his hand on the cord for a moment, over his knot, and said, "So I am," and went in.

He told it for the rest of his life. He told it at inn tables and by hearths and in the halls of three great shares, and he always told it against himself. His saying was that he had been nine hundred years in the world and had never been told so

plainly what he was, and that it had been done by a woman on a stool who had nothing she wanted. And once, when he was very old and had had a good deal of heather ale, he said that he had gone into the gathering-house that morning and sat on his bench and cried for his grandfather for the first time since the ford, and that he did not know why it was the knot that had done it.

V

Of the Cow That Was Not Taken

By the sixth day the heirs had learned that a knot on the cord was worth something, and had begun to think about what it was worth.

It was then that the stewards began coming to Sine's house at night.

The first was a steward of one of the lines of the dead, a line that came down from a son of the king who had died in the second millennium of the reign and had left a great many grandchildren. He came to her door after dark with a boy leading a cow behind him, a good red cow in milk, and he said that his lord's line had some great-grandchildren who might be hard to place, and some cousins by marriage whose claim was not quite clear, and that it would be a kindness if the knot-keeper could see her way to tying them close in to the line, and tightly, so that they could not be picked out afterward; and that the cow was hers in any case, for her trouble, since he could see she had only a goat.

Sine looked at the cow, and at the steward, and at the boy.

"Take it home," she said. "I have a goat."

The steward said that he did not think she understood him.

"I understand you," said Sine. "Tell your lord's great-grandchildren to come to the door and say their lines. If they are his, I'll tie them to him. If they aren't, I won't. And if you come to my house again with a cow I'll tell Aodh Crom, and he'll tell the gathering-house, and then every line in the valley will know that yours has cousins it needs to buy knots for."

The steward went away with the cow. Two more came in the nights after that, one with a pin of carved bone and one with the promise of a stretch of summer grazing for her husband's sheep, which he did not have. She sent them both away. Word went round the fires that the knot-woman could not be bought, and after that the stewards left her alone, and began instead to watch each other's lines at

the door, very closely, for anyone the knot-woman might be tying close in who had no business being tied at all.

Sine said to her daughters that this was the best thing that had happened. She said that a cord that no one could buy was a cord everyone would watch; and that a cord everyone was watching was a cord that would be believed.

VI

Of the Knots of the Dead

On the eighth day the lines of the dead began to come to the door, and Sine had to decide what to do with them.

The king had been having children for four thousand years, and a great many of them had died before him: some in the long wars of the reign, some of accidents, some of the slow thinning that came even to the long-lived in the end, and a few, the eldest, simply of years, having been born before the long years were in the king's blood at all. They were more than the living. Their children and grandchildren were in the valley in hundreds, and every one of them came to the door and gave a line that began with a name nobody living had seen.

Sine could not tie a knot for a dead man in the heirs' cord. The dead were not heirs. But she could not tie his grandchildren to nothing, either, and have them hang loose in the cord between the living lines with no colour to say whose they were. The lines of the dead watched her at the door that morning to see what she would do, and so did the lines of the living, more closely.

She tied a knot of the dead.

She took a length of black wool, and tied it round nothing, in the old way the households tied a knot for a child who had died at birth, so that there was a small hard ring in the cord with a hole through the middle where a knot should be. Then she tied the grandchildren's knots after it, each with a turn of the black in it and a turn of the dead child's own colour beside, so that anyone running the cord through his fingers could feel the hollow and then the knots that hung from it.

There was a murmur in the crowd at that. A grandson of a dead daughter of the king, an old man with a stick, came up and felt the hollow knot for a long time.

"That's my mother," he said.

"That's where she would be," said Sine.

He nodded, and gave his line, and she tied him after the hollow knot. After him came the rest of that line, eleven of them, and each of them stopped before giving the line and put a finger on the hollow knot first, as one touches a door-post on coming home; and the custom stayed, so that for the rest of the gathering nobody of the lines of the dead was knotted without first touching the black ring of the parent they came down from. When he went in he said to the lines of the dead who were waiting that the knot-woman had put their fathers and mothers in the cord, and after that they gave her no trouble. But the lines of the living went in muttering that the dead were being given places in the cord; and Aodh Crom, when he heard of it, went and looked at the hollow knots a long while and said nothing, and Sine thought afterward that he had seen before any of the heirs did that the dead would have to be given a place in the shares as well.

By the eleventh day there were more hollow knots in the cord than there were knots for living children of the king. The heirs walking the cord on the last night felt them under their fingers in the lamplight and counted them too.

VII

Of Ìomhar's Knot and the Child in Arms

Iomhar Dearg came on the seventh day. He came at the head of his line, which was the line of a living son of the king, and gave it plainly, "Ailean's son, and lord of Dùn dhearg." Sine tied the knot with his colour, a rust red, and did not tie in the lordship, because there was no colour for it.

Behind him in the crowd four men of four different lines began to mutter, and one of them said out loud that the cord ought to have a knot for what Ìomhar had taken as well as for what he was owed. Ìomhar turned round and looked at him. The man stopped. But the muttering did not stop; it went back through the crowd and round the side of the house, and the next day four lines sent their stewards to Aodh Crom to say that when the shares came to be cut, they would not agree to Dùn dhearg being counted as one.

Most of the knots were not like that. Most of them were people Sine had never seen before and would never see again: sons and daughters of the king's great-grandchildren, come in from the far coasts in the last days before the gathering closed, who had never been in the valley and stood blinking at the door in their travelling cloaks and gave their lines slowly, as if they were not sure of them. Many

of them were not sure. Sine helped them. She knew the lines by then better than most of the people in them.

There were old men and women, grandchildren of the king, who had been born in his second thousand years and looked it. There were young ones, great-great-grandchildren, who were the age of her own daughters and had the long years in them so faintly that they might live no longer than anyone. And on the ninth day there was a child in arms.

The child was the youngest of all of them: a great-great-grandchild of the king, some months old, of the salt-shore line. The mother came to the door with the child wrapped in a shawl and held it up in both hands for Sine to see, and gave its line for it, one name after another, back to the king. The crowd behind her went quiet to hear it. It was the longest line anybody gave at the door, and the child slept through all of it.

Sine tied the smallest knot she tied in those eleven days, with a turn of the brown in it. Then she put out her finger, and the child woke and took hold of it, and the mother laughed, and some of the crowd laughed with her; and for the only time in eleven days Sine found that she had to stop, and wait, before she could tie the next.

VIII

Of the Cord on the Floor

The cord took eleven days. On the evening of the eleventh the last heir came through the door, a great-grandson of the king who had walked from the far north-west and arrived with his shoes in his hands; and Sine tied his knot, and put her hands flat on the cord in her lap, and sat a while without moving.

Then she told Aodh Crom the count. She had not counted as she went. She had not needed to. The cord went through her fingers from the beginning, knot by knot, from Murchadh Mòr's dark blue to the tired man of the north-west, while the old keeper stood over her, and the count came to seven hundred and twelve.

That night the keepers had the cord laid out on the floor of the gathering-house. It ran from the hearth at the upper end all the way down the length of the floor to the door, and turned there, and came back up the other side to the hearth

again, and still there was some left over, coiled at the hearthstone. Lamps were set along it. The heirs were let in.

They walked along it in their good cloaks, slowly, bending down with the lamps. Each of them was looking for his own knot, and when he found it he stopped, and knelt, and felt it with his fingers, as Murchadh had done on the first day; and then he stood up and looked at the knots on either side of it, and counted them.

Sìne watched from the door. She watched them all evening. She saw an old grandson of the king find his knot and kneel by it for a long time, and then get up and walk three knots down to where his brother's knot was, and kneel by that, and look back at his own, and frown. Eithne nic Ailein walked the whole length of the cord twice without stopping at her own knot at all, and Sìne saw it. She saw two cousins of the western shore stand on either side of the cord at the turn by the door and argue across it about a knot that lay between them. She saw Ìomhar Dearg stand over the rust-red knots of his line with his arms folded, and the four lines who had muttered at him standing at the far wall, watching him.

She saw Niall Òg find his own knot and sit down on the floor beside it and look at it for a long time, and then look up and catch her eye across the house, and nod.

She said to her daughters afterward that the heirs had not come to see their own knots. They had come to see everybody else's. She said that she had tied seven hundred and twelve people to a rope, and that every one of them had walked the length of it that night to see who was tied too near.

On the next day, the thirteenth of an Dàmhair, the keepers of the slab declared to the whole valley that the heirs of Ailean Mòr were counted, and that there were seven hundred and twelve of them; and the heirs agreed, because every one of them had watched every knot being tied, and none of them could say otherwise. It was the first thing they had agreed on since the Binding, and the last for a long while.

That evening Aodh Crom came down to Sìne's house for the second time, and this time he came in and sat by the fire. He had brought her a basket of the keepers' coal, a season's handful and more, and he set it down by the hearth without a word. She kept it. It was the only thing she took for the cord, and she said afterward that she took it because it came after the work and asked nothing of her. The old man sat a while and watched her daughters coiling the spare flax.

Then he asked her whether she thought the heirs would keep to what the cord said, when it came to the cutting.

"They'll keep to the knots," said Sìne. "It's what lies between the knots that they'll fight over."

Aodh Crom laughed, which she had not heard him do before, and said that she should have been a keeper of the slab, and she said that she had enough to keep.

That gathering is called *Cruinneachadh nan Oighrean*¹, the Gathering of the Heirs; and the cord Sìne tied at the door of it was kept in the gathering-house in a chest of its own, and was called *Sreang nan Oighrean*², the cord of the heirs, and was not cut until the night of the handful.

1. the Gathering of the Heirs

2. the knotted cord of the 712 claimants, cut at the Roinn

OF the Four Rules

FE 1 – 2

I

Of the Grass That Did Not Come Back

Seven hundred and twelve knots had been counted, and not one thing settled by the counting. That was what Niall Òg came to understand in the days after the cord was carried out of the gathering-house and put by, and he was slower to understand it than most, because he had gone about the valley all that autumn in the good humour of a man who has just watched something enormous be done, and it took the first frost to teach him that the doing was only the naming of the trouble, not the end of it.

The camps did not break up. He had thought they would: that the heirs, having stood up and given their lines and had them tied, would scatter back to whatever hall or headland or hill-farm they called their own and wait to be sent for. A handful did. Most did not. Word went about the fires that the shares could not be cut until it was agreed how they were to be cut, and that this could not be agreed in a day, and the heirs, who had waited weeks for the tying of a cord, found that they could wait a good deal longer for the cutting of it, so long as they were near enough to have a voice in how it went. By the turn of the month there were more tents in the valley than there had been at the king's death, because every heir who could afford to had sent home for more household, more baggage, more argument.

The valley could not carry it. It had fed the king's own following for a season and the host of the ford for three days and the whole gathering for a fortnight of knotting, and each of those had left a mark on it that the next one found still raw.

The grass along the river, which had been grazed to the earth by the second week of the gathering, did not come up green again that spring; it came up thin and grey and was grazed to the earth again before midsummer, and it did not come up at all the spring after that, or the spring after that. Sine's daughters said afterward that it was three years before a beast could get a full belly on that ground, and that carriers coming down from the north for the first time after the Roinn asked what blight had struck the valley, not knowing that the blight had been seven hundred and twelve households and their horses camped on it through two winters running.

Niall walked the camps most days, because he had nothing else to do that anyone would let him do, and because he found that people would say things to him on a walk that they would not say sitting down. He was not one of the great lines. His mother had been a daughter of the king who died two thousand years before the ford, and his father, a grandson of Fionnghal's line, had died a hundred years back of a fever that a longer-lived man might have thrown off; so Niall stood in the cord as a small knot in a small line, owed twice over as he liked to say, and owed little enough by either half. It left him free to walk where the greater heirs could not, because nobody thought his good opinion worth buying and nobody feared his bad one. He carried word between fires that would not otherwise have spoken, and he came, before that year was out, to know the shape of every quarrel in the valley better than any of the men who were having it.

There were four shapes to it, when he had walked enough camps to see them clear. Four rules, and each one had a hundred heirs standing behind it, and every heir standing behind one thought the other three so plainly wrong that he could not understand how a grown man came to hold them.

II

Of the Eldest and the Living

The first rule was Murchadh Mòr's, though he did not call it a rule; he called it the way it had always been done, in the households he knew, when a man died and left more than one child. The eldest took the whole and owed the others a living out of it. Murchadh was himself the eldest of all the king's living children, near three thousand years old and built like a doorway, and he put the case the way a man puts a case he has never had to argue before because everyone

around him has always agreed with it: the eldest holds, because the eldest is closest to the blood and was longest at the king's side, and the rest are fed from the eldest's hand as they always were. He did not trouble to say what this would mean for himself. Every heir in the valley could count that it would mean Murchadh Mòr holding the whole of Ailean Mòr's kingdom and everyone else in it standing at his table for their supper, and this was, as Niall said to Eithne one evening, a reason Murchadh liked the rule a good deal better than most people did.

The second rule was harder to fix on one mouth, because half the lowland heirs held it and none of them had thought it out past the shape of their own complaint. It said that the living should hold, in the order of their nearness and no further back than that: sons and daughters first, if any lived, and their children after, but no weight given to a man's place in the birth order, only to whether he still drew breath. Eithne, who was herself the youngest living child of the king and stood to gain a good deal by it, argued it hardest and argued it well, because she had the wit to see that a rule of pure age would leave her with nothing at all, being the youngest, while a rule of nearness to the living blood put her on a level with Murchadh whatever the years between them. Niall did not think the less of her for arguing her own good; he had never met an heir in that valley who was arguing anything else, under whatever coat of principle he wore over it, and he thought Eithne wore hers more honestly than most, because she never once pretended the rule was fair to the dead.

It was over the dead that the third rule stood or fell, and it was the hardest fought of the four, because it was fought less between the living heirs than between the living and a silence. Ailean Mòr had been having children for four thousand years, and a great many of them had died before him, in wars and by accident and by the slow thinning that came even to the long-lived at the last, and their children and grandchildren stood in the valley in their hundreds, wearing black wool at the throat as Sine had knotted it, and they said, through whichever of their number could speak loudest, that a line did not end because the man at its head had died before his father; that the dead's children stood in his place exactly as they would have stood in it had he lived one day longer than the king; and that any rule which forgot the dead was a rule made by people who found it convenient to forget them, which was true, and said so plainly that even the heirs who found it convenient did not much enjoy hearing it.

The fourth rule Niall heard first from a boy of perhaps four hundred years, a great-great-grandson of the king who could not have told you the name of his

own great-grandfather, who said to him at a fire one night that the whole of the argument was foolish, because the fairest thing, the only thing that could not be quarrelled with afterward, was to throw lots for the shares and let the ancestors decide it as they decided everything else worth deciding. Niall asked him whose idea this was, and the boy said it was his own, and Niall believed him, because he heard the same idea independently from a dozen more of the youngest heirs before the winter was out, always from someone with the least claim and the least to lose by chance, and never once from anyone with an old man's memory of exactly how many grandchildren stood ahead of him.

"You want the lot," Niall said to one of them, "because you're young enough that anything is better than what the other three rules would give you."

The boy said that was so, and did not seem ashamed of it, and Niall found he liked him rather better for saying so than he liked most of the older heirs, who wanted exactly the same thing and dressed it up as justice.

III

Of the Words Niall Carried

he did not mean to become a carrier of words between the two loudest voices in the valley, Eithne and Murchadh, and he told it afterward as though it had happened to him rather than by his own doing; but the truth, which he told less often, was that he had gone to Murchadh's fire of his own will in the second week of the sitting, to ask a question about grazing on his own account, and had found himself asked in turn what Eithne had said of the eldest's rule that morning, because word had come to Murchadh's fire garbled, and Murchadh wanted it straight. Niall told him straight. He had heard Eithne say it herself, at her own fire, not an hour before: that a man's eldest right to his father's cattle did not make him fit to hold nine hundred grandchildren's worth of a kingdom, and that the day the eldest rule was sworn, half the lines in the valley would begin quietly arming, because no one under the age of a thousand years would sit still under it. Murchadh heard this without moving his face, which Niall came to know was how the old man showed that a thing had gone home.

After that it became a habit. He went from Eithne's fire to Murchadh's and back several times a week, carrying nothing that either of them could not have sent by a steward, except that a steward would have softened it, and Niall did not.

He found, to his own surprise, that both of them preferred it that way. Murchadh told him once, gruffly, over the head of the fire, that Niall was the only man in the valley he could be sure was repeating the words and not the meaning some go-between had decided to give them; and Eithne told him much the same thing in her own way, which was to say nothing and simply begin, when he arrived, "Tell him this," without wasting breath on why she trusted him to carry it straight.

He did not always enjoy it. There were nights he came away from Murchadh's fire with words in his mouth that he knew would put Eithne into a rage before he had finished the sentence, and he carried them anyway, because a message half-told was worse than one told whole, whatever it cost the teller. He watched the two of them, over that winter, come to understand each other's positions better than either understood any of the smaller lines, and hate each other's positions no less for the understanding; and he thought, though he did not say it to either of them, that this was very likely the nearest thing to peace that the eldest rule and the rule of the living were ever going to manage, two people who despised each other's case and had stopped mistaking the other for a fool.

The lines of the dead he did not carry for, not at first, because no single mouth spoke for them the way Murchadh spoke for the eldest or Eithne for the living; they spoke through whichever grandson had the readiest tongue that week, and the readiest tongue changed. But by midwinter one voice had risen above the rest among them, an old man with a stick who had felt the hollow knot at the door and said, "That's my mother," and who now stood at the gathering-house steps most mornings and told anyone who would listen that the dead's children were being asked to disappear twice, once by their fathers' early deaths and once by a rule that would not count them; and Niall began carrying his words too, to Murchadh and to Eithne both, because he saw that neither of the two great voices had troubled to hear the old man out in full, each being too busy answering the other.

IV

Of Mairsile in the Cold

The first winter of the sitting was hard on the valley's ground, and harder on some of the people in it than on the ground.

Mairsile nic Ailein, the king's white-haired daughter who had begun the keen-ing in the valley on the night the herd-boy's news came, was old even among the king's children, older than Murchadh, and the long years in her were nearly spent; and she had outlived a husband and two of her own children already before that autumn. She had sat through the knotting with her women about her, near the upper fires, and had said little in the councils of the four rules, being past the age of the kingdom mattering to her the way it mattered to the younger heirs. What she wanted, she told her women, was to go home before the snow; and she did not go home, because there was always one more day's argument that her line's steward thought she ought to hear, one more vote of the assembled dead that could not be taken without an elder of her age to lend it weight.

She died in the cold, in the second month of the new year, in a tent on the upper slope with her women about her and a brazier that had run low in the night because the wood had run short in the whole valley that winter, every hearth burning the same short ration as every other. Niall was not there. He heard of it in the morning from a woman of her household who came down to the lower fires white in the face, and he went up with her, because there seemed nothing else to do, and stood at the tent door while Mairsile's women wound her in her own cloak, and thought, not for the first time that winter, that the argument over who should hold the kingdom had already begun to cost the kingdom people who had never asked to be part of it.

She was carried down to the river two days after and laid in the ground there, near enough the ford that the carriers passing with their baskets could see the mound from the road; and for once in that whole long sitting there was no quarrel over where she should lie, because she had asked for the place herself before she died, plainly, to her women, and nobody thought it worth their trouble to dispute a dying woman's one wish when there were nine hundred living wishes still to be fought over. Niall stood at the graveside with Eithne on one side of him and, a little apart, Murchadh on the other, and neither of them spoke to the other across it, but neither of them left before the mound was closed, and Niall thought that this too, in its way, was a kind of agreement, the only one the valley had managed since the cord went on the floor.

He carried the word of her death to every fire in the valley himself, that day and the next, because he found he could not sit still with it; and at more than one fire he heard the same thing said, in different words, by people who had never met her: that the sitting had already killed one of the king's own children, and that

whatever else the shares came to, they had better come to it before the next winter found another.

V

Of the Share That Could Not Be Taken

Through all of it there was one line in the valley that argued for none of the four rules, because none of the four rules touched what it already held.

Ìomhar Dearg sat that winter much as he had sat through the knotting, apart from the loudest fires, with his own household about him and little enough said. He had held Dùn dhearg since before the cord was ever tied, taken it by the sword in the days after the ford, and he had made no claim on the four rules at all, because he did not need one; what he had, he had, and the argument of the valley was over what the rest of them were to have. This did not sit well with everyone. Four lines in particular, none of them close enough kin to Ìomhar to have any hope of the fort themselves, took to saying at their own fires, and then at other people's, that a kingdom parted by rule ought to be parted by rule entire, and that Dùn dhearg with its double bank and its burned halls and its living taken under one man's hand was as much a part of Ailean Mòr's kingdom as any acre still standing green, and ought to come into whatever settlement the rest came into rather than sitting outside it as a thing already decided.

Niall carried this to Murchadh, who said only that he did not see how it was to be done; and he carried it to Eithne, who said the same in fewer words; and when he pressed her on why, since she plainly agreed the complaint was just, she told him something he thought about for a long while after. "Ask any of the four how they mean to take it from him," she said. "Ask them who is to stand in that gap in the bank and tell Ìomhar's household that they answer to somebody else now. He didn't win it by a rule. He won it because he was there and the rest of us weren't, and a rule made after the fact can't put us there instead of him. You can make a hundred rules for dividing what nobody has taken yet. You can't make one that takes back what's already held."

He put this to the four lines himself, more than once, in something like her own words, and none of them had an answer for it beyond repeating the complaint louder, which told him, as much as anything did that winter, that the complaint and the remedy were two different things, and that a valley could go on be-

ing angry about a wrong for a very long time without ever finding a hand strong enough to put it right.

VI

Of the Word Nobody Would Wear

There was one more thing that came up at every fire that winter, sooner or later, and it came up so often, and was refused so often, that by spring it had stopped being argued at all and had simply become understood: that whatever the shares came to, and whoever held the largest of them, no one of the nine was to be called what their father had been called. Niall heard it first from an old steward of Murchadh's line, half as a joke, that the great share of the north would want a rìgh over it the way the whole island had once had one, and heard Murchadh himself answer, not laughing, that he would sooner burn the share to the ground than sit in his father's seat and be called by his father's name for it, because he had seen what the name had cost the man who bore it and had no wish to invite his own kin to come and try to take it from him the same way.

It was Eithne who put the clause first in words that could be sworn to, at a fire late in the summer when the heirs of the nine strongest lines had begun, almost without anyone declaring it so, to meet apart from the rest: that none of the nine, whatever they held and however they came to hold it, should ever be called rìgh, or take the word for themselves, or suffer it to be given them by their own households; that the kingdom Ailean Mòr had made was ended with him, and what came after it was shares, held by heirs, and not a kingdom held by a king. Murchadh swore to it first, and swore it hardest, because he above all of them had spent a winter watching what the shape of a single crown could still do to men three thousand years old who ought to have known better. Ìomhar Dearg swore to it from his own fire, sending word rather than coming himself, which some of the others remarked on and none of them pressed. Every one of the nine swore it in the end, and Niall, standing near enough at more than one of the swearings to see the faces as well as hear the words, thought that a good half of them swore it the way a man swears off a thing he still wants, with the private thought that the word might yet come to one of their own children or grandchildren, once enough years had passed that nobody living could object; and he judged, rightly as it

turned out, that this reservation would trouble nobody at all so long as the nine kept it out of their own mouths in their own lifetimes.

VII

Of the Settlement

It was Aodh Crom, in the end, who put the four rules together, though it was not his place to put anything together, being no heir and holding no share; but he had sat through enough of the councils that summer, at the edge of the gathering-house with the flame's business finished for the day, that the heirs had come to ask his opinion the way men ask the opinion of someone who has nothing to gain by giving it.

He did not choose between the four rules. He told the assembled heads of the strongest lines, one evening in the last days of summer, that he did not think any one of the four could be sworn alone without half the valley taking up arms against it before the winter turned again, because each rule left out a claim that a great many people in that valley were not going to consent to seeing left out; and that the only settlement he could see holding was one that gave each rule enough to keep its people quiet, though none of them all it asked. Let the eldest lines hold the great shares, since the living heirs of most substance were, in the main, the eldest surviving of their branches in any case; let the shares run to nine, since nine lines could be found among the living with claim enough and following enough to hold a share and defend it; let a portion be set aside out of all nine together for the lines of the dead, so that no line vanished from the reckoning because its head had died a day too soon; and let the youngest, who wanted the lot, take some comfort in this much of it, that within each of the nine shares the parting among the living children and grandchildren should still be settled by drawing, where an equal claim could not otherwise be told apart.

It satisfied nobody entirely, and Niall came to think that this was very likely why it held. Murchadh had the great share of the north, which was the largest thing on the table and more than answered the eldest's rule so far as he was concerned; Eithne and her allies among the living heirs had shares of their own, proof that nearness of blood counted for something whatever a man's place in the birth order; the lines of the dead had their portion, grudging and smaller than they had asked for, but a portion, and a name for it, *Cuid nam Marbh*¹, so that it could never afterward be said the dead had been forgotten; and the youngest, muttering, had their throw of the lot within whatever share they fell under, which was not the throw across the whole kingdom that the boy at the fire had wanted, but was a throw, and kept a few hundred of the youngest and least-landed heirs from making trouble that autumn over having nothing at all.

Ìomhar Dearg's share was let stand where it stood, Dùn dhearg and the ground he had already taken, let stand beside the nine as a tenth that no rule had made, won by the sword and not by any of the four rules; the four lines who had argued against it argued once more, at the council itself, and were heard, and were not answered beyond Eithne's old words given back to them in Aodh Crom's mouth, that no rule made that day could put them where Ìomhar already stood; and they gave way in the end: nine of the strongest lines in the valley had already agreed among themselves, and there was no tenth strong enough to stand against the nine.

VIII

Of the Agreement to Cut the Cord

They settled it, in the shape it would keep, in the last days before the turn of the year, at a council that ran two days and a night without the heads of the nine lines leaving the gathering-house floor; and Niall, who had carried words between them all that year and stood at more firesides than any other man in the valley, was let in to hear the end of it because Eithne asked for him by name, saying she wanted one honest ear in the room besides her own.

It was agreed, when it was agreed, without much ceremony. There was no swearing that night; the clause against the crown had already been sworn separ-

1. the lands set aside out of all nine great shares for the lines of the king's dead children

ately, at a dozen fires, over the summer, and needed no repeating. What was agreed was simpler and, to Niall's mind, colder than anything that had gone before it: that the cord Sine had tied, seven hundred and twelve knots long, should be carried back into the gathering-house and laid on the floor again as it had been laid before, from the hearth to the door and back; and that on the night of the handful, when every hearth in the hills burned its measure together, as it always had, the heads of the nine lines should each take a knife to it in turn, and cut it into nine lengths where the shares fell, each length carrying the knots of the heirs who stood under that share; and that whatever oaths needed swearing over the cutting, the clause against the crown and the peace of the Hall's own ground among them, should be sworn that same night, once, in front of the whole valley, so that no line could say afterward it had not heard.

Murchadh Mòr agreed to it first, with the same still face he had shown all that winter. Eithne agreed after him, and looked once at Niall across the fire as she did, which he took, and told her afterward he had taken, for something between thanks and warning: thanks for a year's carrying, warning that the carrying was not finished, only changed. Word went out that night from line to line, fire to fire, down through the valley and up into the hills where the smaller households were camped, that the cord would be cut at the handful, and that every heir who meant to hold anything under the nine great shares had better be at Dùn ìseal to see it done.

Niall walked the camps a last time before the year turned, as he had walked them at the start, and found the valley much changed from the one he had walked with a light heart the autumn before: the grass gone from the riverbank, three winters before it would come green again though none of them yet knew that; the mound by the ford with Mairsile under it; Ìomhar's fires apart from the rest as they had always been; and at every hearth, instead of the seven hundred and twelve separate quarrels he had carried between all that year, one single date now, the night of the handful, that every line in the valley was waiting on together, for the first time since the cord went first upon the floor.

He came back down to the lower fires as the light went, and found Eithne's steward waiting for him with a message, which was, he said afterward, the last one he ever carried that winter, and the shortest: that she wanted him at her own fire that night, to hear how the cutting was to be done, so that when it came he would know, better than most of the valley, exactly what he was watching.

CHAPTER SIX

OF the Night of the Handful

FE 2

Aon oidhche, aon teine, aon scian. One night, one fire, one knife.
— said afterward of Oidhche an Dòrlaich at Dùn ìseal

I

Of the Telling

Niall Òg told this in his old age to whoever would sit and hear it, and by then he had told it so many times that the households of the salt shore could say the ending with him. He always began the same way.

There is one night in the valley below Dùn ìseal, Niall Òg would say, that every hearth on the island still keeps some memory of, though not one hearth in a hundred could tell you why. It is kept without being understood, the way a child keeps a game its grandmother taught it and never asks what the game was for. On the night of the handful every household burns its whole season's measure at once, though the Small-Burning Law was not yet made and would not be made for six generations, and no household then owed the Hall a handful of anything. They did it because the heirs did it. The heirs did it because there was a night in the second year of the Holy Age when every fire in the gathering-house below Dùn ìseal burned at once, and by morning the kingdom of Ailean Mòr had nine lords and one that would not be sworn to any of them.

Niall was there. He was some nine hundred years old, a grandson of the king in one of the lesser lines, and he had spent the year since the ford carrying words

between his aunt Eithne and his uncle Murchadh because he was the only one of the family either of them would let into a room with the other. He used to say that this made him, of all the king's grandchildren, the one who least wanted the cutting of the cord to come, because a peace was a thing he could carry messages about, and a division was a thing that was simply done, after which there would be nothing left for him to do at all. He was wrong about that, as it turned out, but on that night he did not know he was wrong, and he watched the whole of it the way a boy watches a house being pulled down that he has played in all his life.

The year between the agreement of the four rules and the cutting had been a long, watchful one. The grass of the valley, trodden by seven hundred and twelve heirs and their households and their stewards' households besides, had not come back green that spring, and the summer after it had been worse, so that a man riding down from the passes that autumn said the valley looked less like the floor of a kingdom than the yard of a fair that had gone on three years too long. The nine who would cut the cord spent that year each in his own tent or hall, sending stewards to argue small points that had been thought settled and were not, and Niall carried more words in those twelve months than he had carried in the nine centuries before them. He grew, he said, very tired of being trusted by everyone and believed by no one, which he came in time to think was most of what it meant to be neither eldest nor first.

II

Of the Waiting Out the Year

The stewards of the nine lines spent that year haggling over things the four rules had left unsaid, and most of what they haggled over came down, in the end, to boundaries: whether a line drawn "from the ford to the hill" meant the near hill or the far one, whether a wood belonged with the pasture beside it or the stream beyond it, whether a fishing-weir built by a household now claimed by two lines paid its catch to one or split it. None of it could be settled before the cutting, because none of the nine would agree to a line on the ground before they had agreed to a line on the cord, and so the small quarrels piled up outside the gathering-house all that year like unswept snow, waiting for the one night that would let them all be argued at once, by daylight, with a boundary-stone instead of a steward's word.

Aodh Crom aged visibly in that year, more than a man of his hundred and eighty-odd years by rights should. He had carried the asking of the Binding and the counting of the knots and now the setting of this last night, and he told Sine, when she asked him once at her own door whether he slept, that he did not think a man his age was owed sleep on top of everything else the valley wanted of him. The eight other keepers of the slab watched the hill and kept the flame and let the old man carry the heirs' business, because none of them wanted it and he had never once refused it.

By the time autumn came round again and the heirs began riding back down into the valley for the second time in two years, the grass under their feet had given up trying to grow back at all, and the gathering-house, which had stood through the knotting with its thatch still new, wore the black smudge of eleven days' smoke over every door. Niall rode down with his uncle's household, as he had the year before, and found the valley smaller than he remembered it, though nothing in it had shrunk; only the crowd in it had grown used to being crowded, the way a room grows smaller the longer a family sits in it.

III

Of the Cord Laid Twice Round the Floor

They chose Oidhche an Dòrlaich¹ for it, the night of the handful, because it was already the one night of the year on which no household in the hills held anything back. Whatever coal a family had put by against the winter it burned that single night, all together, so that the dark half of the year should begin with every hearth in the valley alight at once and none of them alone in the cold. It was an old custom and older than the king, and Aodh Crom said, when the heirs asked him to set the night, that it was fitting the kingdom should be cut on the one night when nobody kept anything back.

The keepers had the cord of the heirs brought down from its chest and laid along the floor of the gathering-house as it had been laid on the last night of the knotting, from the hearth to the door and back to the hearth again, with the length that was left over coiled at the hearthstone. Lamps stood along it the whole way, one every few paces, so that a man walking beside it in the smoke could see

1. the dark of the year when every hearth burns its measure; the Roinn was sworn on it

his own feet and not much else. There were more people in the house that night than there had been on any night of the eleven days of knotting: every heir who had given a line to Sine nan Snaidhm was there, or had sent someone in his place, and the nine who would cut the cord stood each at the place along it where his own colour began, with a household's worth of kin crowded behind him against the wall.

The hearths outside were doing what the gathering-house's own hearth was doing, burning the whole valley's measure at once, and the smoke of it lay over the roof and came in under the eaves and hung along the beams until a man's eyes stung with it before the night was an hour old. Niall said afterward that he had never in his life, before or since, been in a house so full of smoke and lamplight and people that he could not see across it, and that the cord itself, when he first looked for it on the floor, seemed to swim.

Nine knives were laid out on a cloth by the hearth, plain knives, none of them marked, because no one wanted it remembered afterward which knife had been whose. Aodh Crom stood over them. He had grown old fast that year, faster than a man of his years should, and he leaned on a stick he had not needed at the Binding. He said only one thing before the cutting began, and Niall remembered it word for word because it was so short: that the cord had been laid once for the whole kingdom, and would now be laid nine times for nine lines of it, and that whoever cut wrong would have to live with his own hand and no other's to blame.

Each of the nine walked the cord first with a lamp, bent low, before he was let touch a knife. Murchadh Mòr went first because he was eldest, and the house went quiet enough to hear the cord's fibres creak under his hand as he ran it through his fingers, counting. Then Eithne went, and after her the rest in the order they had agreed among themselves that summer, an order none of the tellers give the same way twice, because none of the nine were there afterward to be asked and cared to be remembered as having gone last. Each of them walked the whole length twice: once toward the door, once back. By the time the last of the nine had walked it the lamps had burned low enough that servants came along the wall refilling them, and the night was not young any longer.

IV

Of Murchadh's Cut

Murchadh Mòr was near two thousand nine hundred years old that night, the eldest living son of the king by more than seven hundred years over the next, and he had known for a summer exactly where along the cord he meant to cut. He did not walk it twice out of doubt. He walked it twice because the keepers had told the nine to walk it twice, and Murchadh did what he was told when he had already decided to do it.

Murchadh knelt at the place, took up his knife, and cut. It went through clean, one stroke, and the two ends of the cord lay apart on the floor with the lamp between them, and he stood up without looking at either end again. A murmur went along the wall, the first sound the house had made since the cutting began, because everyone there had been waiting to see whether the eldest of them would flinch at doing with a knife what he had spent a summer arguing for with his tongue, and he had not flinched at all.

"There," he said, to no one, and went to stand by the hearth with his length of the cord already gathered over his arm, and did not speak again that night, though he watched everything.

His length ran from the hearth almost to the turn by the door, the longest of the nine, for it held more knots than any other line: the great share of the north, from Baile Mòr mhòr to the high passes, with eleven sons of his own body already knotted into it and their children's children besides. He had asked for nothing more than the rule of the eldest gave him and had got exactly that, and Niall, watching him stand at the hearth with the whole length of the north over his arm, thought that this was the last time in his life he would see Murchadh want for nothing.

V

Of Eithne and the Woman Who Would Take Both

Eithne nic Ailein was the youngest of the nine, not yet two thousand years old, and she had argued harder for the lowland plain than anyone had argued for anything else that summer, on the plain grounds that it was flat, it was rich, and it was hers by right of being loudest about it longest. She knelt at her place a long while before she cut, longer than Murchadh had, running her thumb back and forth over a single knot as if she were counting it more than once.

When she cut, her knife went through the knot itself.

The house went silent in a different way than it had for Murchadh, a silence with an edge on it. Aodh Crom, who had been standing by the hearth with his stick, came forward at once and looked at the cut end, and asked, in a voice that carried the length of the house because every other voice in it had stopped, whose knot that had been.

A woman came out from the wall with her hand over her mouth. She was a cousin of Niall's own generation, of the line of the salt shore, and her name was Ciorstaidh; Niall had known her since they were children together at the spring below Dùn ìseal, before either of them had learned to count the years in their blood, and he said afterward that he had never seen anyone go so white so fast in a room already full of firelight.

"That is mine," said Eithne, looking at the cut end in her own hand.

"That is mine," said the man who held the length beyond it, the head of the next share down the cord, and he was not smiling either.

Ciorstaidh stood between the two ends with the whole house looking at her, and for a moment she said nothing at all. Then she took her hand away from her mouth.

"I'll take both," she said.

Nobody had thought to ask her whether she wanted to be part of the argument at all, and it was the first time in the whole of Roinn na Rìoghachd¹ that anyone had answered a question no one had put to her. Eithne looked at her for a long moment, and then laughed, short and without much warmth in it, and said that the girl had more sense than either of the two lords quarrelling over her knot, which was not a kind thing to say in front of both of them, and was also true. The man beside Eithne did not laugh. But neither of them wanted, on the first night of the Roinn, to be seen arguing over one knot in front of seven hundred witnesses, and so it was let stand: Ciorstaidh of the salt shore swore to both lines that night, the first of the double oaths, and carried both colours in the wool she kept afterward, and her children after her carried both, until the lands under each grew so far apart that no one family could ride between them in a season and the two oaths quietly went their own ways.

1. the Division; lit. 'the parting of the kingdom'

VI

Of the Rest of the Nine

After Eithne the cutting went on, and it did not go cleanly again. Some of the nine had chosen their places with as much care as Murchadh, and their knives went through the cord and nothing else; some had not, and where the cord ran thick with the knots of the portion of the dead, thick enough that no eye could be sure which knot lay exactly under a knife in that light and that smoke, more than one blade went through wool that had a name tied into it. By the time the ninth of them had cut, eleven knots along the whole length of the cord had been cut through and not between, and ten households besides Ciorstaidh's found themselves sworn that night to two lords at once, though none of the others made so short and plain an answer to it as she had. Some quarrelled for a season over which oath should stand and which should lapse; most simply paid both, the way a man pays two tolls on a road he cannot avoid, and grumbled about it at both ends.

Fionnghal nic Ailein cut her length clean, and it ran west to Ros dhomhain and its harbour, and she was some twenty-five hundred years old that night and had wanted the sea more than she had wanted the plain or the hills, and got it. Artair mac Ailein took the salt shore, with its seat at the western Baile ghorm, a little more than twenty-three hundred years old and the quietest of the nine, who had said less in the whole summer of argument than any of his brothers and sisters and had ended, all the same, with a coast the length of two days' sail. Cormac mac Ailein cut through to the eastern share, seated at Caol shean, a little over two thousand years old, and did not yet know, and could not have known, that a seam of silver lay under a hill in his own share that no one then living had found.

The last four cuts went quicker, because the smoke was thick by then and the lamps were burning down and everyone in the house wanted the night over. Ùna nic Ailein took the north-west, with her seat at Muileann àrsaidh; Coll mac Ailein took the hills east of the Red Hill, along the Abhainn fhionn, with his seat at Ceann àrsaidh; Gormlaith nic Ailein took the south-east, seated at Tobar dhearg; and Tadhg mac Ailein took the Abhainn íseal and the bay the hawks fished, with his seat at Cnoc bheag. The tellers who came after did not agree on the order in which these four cut, and Niall himself, asked about it in his old age, said only that he had been watching Ciorstaidh at the time and could not swear to it either, which the tellers took as leave to put the four in whatever order suited the telling.

When the ninth cut was made the cord of the heirs no longer ran the length of the floor. It lay in nine pieces, each gathered over the arm of the lord who had cut it, with the loose ends of the eleven double knots hanging free where two lords held the same knot between them; and the Red Share of Ìomhar Dearg, which no knife had cut that night because it had never been tied into the cord with any colour of its own, stood as it had stood since the summer after the ford, needing no cutting because it had already been taken.

VII

Of the Red Hill Sworn to Nobody

There was one length of the old kingdom that no knife touched that night, because no line of the nine could say it was theirs to cut.

The Red Hill was not the Red Share. The Red Share was Dùn dhearg and the ground about it, which Ìomhar Dearg had taken with his own hand at the ford and no one had found a way to take back. Far to the west, above the lake shore, lay the Red Hill, another place entirely, where a settlement had stood since before the king's grandfather's time, and its holders had sworn to Ailean Mòr and to no one else in all the years of his reign; not to Dùn ìseal, not to any lord of a share, only to the king himself, man to man, in a way that no other holding on the island had sworn.

On the night of the handful the Red Hill's holder stood up in the smoke and the lamplight, when the nine had finished their cutting and the house had begun to think itself done, and said what everyone in the house had known he would have to say sooner or later: that his oath had been to Ailean Mòr, and Ailean Mòr was in the ground beside his stone, and there was no man now living he had ever sworn to. He did not ask to be released. He said only that he was already free, and that the Red Hill was, as it stood that night, sworn to nobody at all.

It was the quietest claim made in the whole gathering, and it caused the loudest argument. Before he had well finished speaking three of the nine had crossed the floor toward him at once, Murchadh from the hearth end and two others from nearer the door, each saying that a holding sworn to nobody could not simply remain so, and each meaning, though none of them said it so plainly that first night, that it ought to be sworn to him. The Red Hill's holder said nothing further. He had said his piece, and the three lords could argue over an empty

answer as long as they liked; it changed nothing that he had said. They argued a good while, there on the floor among the cut ends of the cord, with the fires burning low outside and the smoke thinning at last through the roof, and came to no settlement that night or for a long while after. The Red Hill stayed as its holder had left it, claimed by three and kept by none, a small stubborn place that grew no faster than a place claimed by three lords and served by not one of them ever does.

Aodh Crom, who had watched the argument from the hearth without joining it, said one more thing before the house began to empty. He reminded the nine, in the same short way he had reminded them of everything else that night, that the ground on which they stood, the whole hill of the slab and the gathering-house and the valley below it as far as the boundary the keepers themselves had walked, was in no share and never would be; that this had been sworn at the Binding and was not to be argued afresh on a night when everything else in the kingdom was being cut apart. No one answered him. No one, that night, had the appetite left to argue with the one thing in the valley that nobody wanted for himself.

VIII

Of the Grey Light and the Lengths of Cord

Dawn found the gathering-house half empty and the fires outside burned to grey ash, the whole valley's measure spent in one night as it was spent every year at the turning, though this year it had lit a division that would run for centuries where every other year it had only lit the dark. The nine lords went out through the door one after another, each with his length of the cord folded or coiled over his arm, and their people went with them, carrying baskets and rolled hides and children still asleep against a shoulder, so that the road out of the valley by full light looked less like the end of a gathering than the start of nine journeys that all happened to begin at the same door.

Niall stood by the door a long while and watched them go. He had no length of cord of his own to carry; his knot hung in the portion of the dead, after his mother's hollow knot, for Niall held no share and would hold none, being neither eldest nor first among the living children of the eldest line, only "owed twice," as he put it himself, by two different accountings that had never yet paid him any-

thing. He watched Ciorstaidh go last of all, with two colours of wool wound together over her wrist where the others each carried one, and she caught his eye at the door the way she had caught it across the house the night before, and neither of them said anything, because there was nothing yet to say that the whole valley had not already seen.

He told it afterward, in his old age, always ending the same way: that he had stood at that door and thought the division was finished, the cord cut, the kingdom parted, the worst of the year's work done, and that he had been a young fool of nine hundred to think so, because a cord, once cut, does not stay cut in the same nine pieces forever, any more than a family, once parted, stays parted along the lines its parting first drew. The Red Hill alone, he would say, sworn to nobody on that grey morning, outlived every one of the nine who had argued over it, and was still sworn to nobody when he himself was an old man; and of all the things cut and given and sworn on the night of the handful, it was the one piece of the old kingdom that belonged, in the end, to no one at all.

CHAPTER SEVEN

OF THE STONES AND THE FIRST BLOOD

FE 2 – 4

Mharbh mi mìle bliadhna. I have killed a thousand years.
— said by Ruairidh Glas of the line of Ìomhar, kneeling in the mud
at Dùn thais

I

Of the Stone on Each Bank

Ruairidh Glas was a grandson of Ìomhar Dearg, some three hundred years old that autumn, and he had never in his life killed a man.

He had not been at the ford the autumn his grandfather took Dùn dhearg; he had been in the western grazings with the Red Share's cattle, and what he knew of that morning he knew from other men's mouths. Since then he had grown up in the granaries and the cattle-yards of the Red Share, learning what a grandson of the man who held it by the sword was supposed to know, which was mostly where the boundary of a thing ran and how to hold it, and he had come to think of himself, without ever quite saying so, as a man who held ground rather than a man who fought for it. He was wrong about that, though he did not yet know it, any more than Niall Òg on the night of the handful had known he was wrong to think the cutting of the cord was the end of the trouble rather than its beginning.

The cord was cut, and had been cut for a year by the time the boundary stones went up. It had taken that long for the nine lines to agree even roughly where

their shares began and ended on the ground, because a line drawn on a cord with a knot is one thing and a line drawn across a hillside with cattle on it is another, and the two did not always answer to each other as neatly as the heirs at the gathering-house had supposed they would. Through the winter after the handful the stewards of the nine lines rode the boundaries with the reciters who had carried the tale of the cutting in their heads, arguing over fords and ridgelines and the exact course of streams that moved their own banks between one flood and the next, and where they could agree a mason cut a stone with the sign of the share that looked into it and set it up on the line.

They called them *clachan-crìche*, the boundary stones, and there came to be a great many of them before the winter was out, more than the stewards themselves could always account for, because a lord's man who did not like where a stone stood would sometimes move it in the night, a hand's breadth or a field's width, and set it again facing the same way as before, so that in the morning it looked as though it had always stood there. The keepers of the slab, who had no share and wanted none, said nothing about this, because it was no business of the Hall's what the heirs did with their own boundaries, so long as none of it came near the ground under the mountain. Aodh Crom, when a steward once asked him to witness where a stone had truly stood the week before, said only that he had not been watching, and that he did not think any man alive had, which was as near as the old keeper ever came to naming what everyone already knew.

Dùn thais stood on its hill north of Dùn dhearg, the first fort the island's people had ever banked away from the mountain and the Red Hill both, in years so far back that the reciters could put no king's name to the raising of it. It sat close by the line the cord had drawn between the great share of the north, which was Murchadh Mòr's, and the Red Share of Ìomhar Dearg, and it sat close enough that nobody could say with any confidence on which side of the line it truly fell. The stewards who rode that stretch that winter argued it for the better part of a month and came away no nearer agreement than when they had started, and in the end, because neither side would give way and neither side would let the fort stand for the other, the masons of both lines did the one thing that let each of them go home believing he had lost nothing: they set a stone on the north bank of the burn below the hill, cut with the sign of Murchadh's share, and another on the south bank, cut with the sign of the Red Share, and left the fort, and the slope above it, lying between the two.

Ruairidh had ridden that ground twice that winter with his grandfather's steward, an old man named Lachlann Glas who had held the same office under Ìomhar since before the ford and had grown grey in it, and both times Lachlann had stood a long while looking at the two stones and said nothing worth remembering. The third time Ruairidh rode it, in the wet spring of the third year of the Holy Age, he rode it alone, with twenty men of the Red Share behind him and the cattle of the northern slope in front, because his grandfather had said, over supper the week before, in the flat voice he used for things he did not expect to be argued with, that the grazing above Dùn thais was theirs and had always been theirs, whatever a stone on the wrong bank of a burn might say, and that it was time somebody drove the beasts down off it before another season's grass went to a share that had never paid for it.

II

Of the Rain at Dùn thais

It rained the whole of that day, the low, steady rain of early summer that does not so much fall as hang in the air and soak a man through by evening whether he has stood still or ridden hard, and by the time Ruairidh came up under the hill of Dùn thais the ground on the northern slope had gone to mud past the fetlock, and the cattle he had come to move were bawling and slipping and turning back on themselves faster than his twenty men could turn them again.

Aonghas Bàn mac Mhurchaidh was on the bank above with twenty men of his own, and Ruairidh did not at first know why. He had ridden that slope twice before without meeting a soul of the northern share on it, and it did not occur to him, coming up through the rain with his mind on the cattle, that word of his grandfather's supper-table decision could have crossed the boundary faster than he had. It had. Somebody in Ruairidh's own household, or in Lachlann's, had said something to somebody who ought not to have heard it, the way such things always went in a country that had nine great households and every one of them full of cousins married into every other, and Aonghas Bàn, a grandson of Murchadh Mòr some four hundred years old, had come up with his own herdsmen the night before to hold the ground his own grandfather had said was theirs.

He stood above the beasts with a herding-stick in his hand, not a spear, because he had come to move cattle, not to fight for them, and Ruairidh saw him

first as a shape on the bank in the rain, grey against grey, and did not know for a moment whose man he was. Then Aonghas Bàn called down, not unkindly, that the grass under Ruairidh's cattle belonged to the north, and that he would be glad to help drive them back across the burn if Ruairidh's men were finding the going hard in the wet.

It might have ended there. Ruairidh said afterward, many times, to anyone who asked him and to a good many who did not, that it might have ended exactly there, with two grandsons of two brothers standing in the rain arguing amiably enough over a hillside neither of them had ever slept on, and going home each to tell his own household that the other side had been reasonable, for northerners, or for the Red Share, whichever way the telling ran. It did not end there, and the reason it did not, as near as Ruairidh could ever afterward make out, had less to do with the grass than with the twenty men behind each of them, none of whom had ridden up that hill expecting to be reasonable, all of whom had grown, in the year and a half since the cutting of the cord, thoroughly used to hearing that the other lines were thieves and liars and worse, and none of whom, when the shouting started somewhere down among the cattle, over whose beast had trodden whose man's foot, waited to hear whether their own lord meant to answer it with words.

Ruairidh's spear was up before he had decided to raise it. He said that afterward too, more than once, in the years he had left to say it in: that his hand had done it before the rest of him had caught up, the way a man's hand closes on a hot stone before his mind has finished telling him it is hot. He did not remember aiming. What stayed with him was the shape on the bank turning toward the shouting below, the herding-stick still in his hand and not a weapon raised anywhere near him, and the spear going, and then, after it had gone, the knowledge that there was nothing in the world he wanted less than to have thrown it.

Aonghas Bàn went down into the mud without a sound that carried over the rain and the cattle and the shouting, and for a moment neither side seemed to understand what had happened, so that the noise of the quarrel went on a little while over his body before it died away into something worse than quiet, a kind of ragged stillness broken by the bawling of beasts that did not know or care what the men around them had just done.

Ruairidh came down off his own horse and knelt by him in the mud. Aonghas Bàn had the face of a man of thirty, though he was four hundred years old and had, by the long years of his own line, perhaps a thousand more before him that

he would never now come to; and Ruairidh, kneeling there with the rain running down both their faces, one living and one not, said the same six words over and over to the men who came to lift the body, because it was the only true thing he could find in himself to say and no other words would come in its place.

"I have killed a thousand years," he said. "I have killed a thousand years."

III

Of Eachann Ruadh's Oath

They carried Aonghas Bàn down off the hill in a cloak between two spear-shafts, the rain not yet finished with them, and word went ahead of the party faster than the men carrying him could travel, the way it always does when a man dies who was not expected to, so that by the time they came within sight of his own hall the household was already out at the gate, and his brother Eachann Ruadh was already standing at the front of it, having heard, and not yet having been told, and already knowing from the shape of the party coming down the road what he was about to be told.

Eachann Ruadh was a year or two the younger of the two brothers, red-haired where Aonghas had been fair, and he had been, until that afternoon, the quieter of the pair by a wide margin, the one who let Aonghas do the talking at councils and the deciding at boundaries and was glad enough to let him, having, as he said of himself more than once, no great appetite for either. He stood at the gate while the party came up, and he did not go to meet it, and he did not ask the question everyone standing near him could see forming on his face, because by the time the two spear-shafts were near enough for him to see what lay between them, there was no longer any question left to ask.

He knelt by his brother's body in the yard of their own hall, in front of the whole household and in front of Ruairidh's men, who had carried it down themselves and would not have trusted the carrying to anyone else, and he put his hand flat on the dead man's chest, over the wound the spear had made, and swore an oath there that the reciters of both lines kept afterward, word for word, though they never agreed between them on quite what it meant to keep an oath of that kind. The blood on the grass at Dùn thais, he swore, would be answered, blood for blood, by his own hand or his sons' or theirs after them, for as long as there was a man of Murchadh's line living to remember whose spear had thrown it; and

he did not name Ruairidh Glas in the oath, though everyone standing in that yard understood well enough whom it was aimed at, because to name a man in a blood-oath was, by the old custom of the households, to close the door on any settling of it that did not end in a second death, and Eachann Ruadh, red-haired and quiet and not yet altogether sure, in that first grey hour, what kind of man his brother's dying had made of him, left the door open that far and no further.

Ruairidh did not go back to Dùn thais. He rode home to his grandfather's hall with his twenty men in a silence none of them broke the whole way, and he told Ìomhar Dearg what had happened in as few words as Eachann Ruadh had used to swear his oath, and his grandfather, who had taken a fort by the sword and burned the halls inside its double bank and thought little enough of a single death on a wet hillside, told him only that he had done what a man does when his own are threatened and that he was not to trouble himself with an oath sworn by a boy over his brother's body. Ruairidh did not answer that either way. He was three hundred years old and had, by his own line's long blood, some centuries yet before him in which to find out what it meant to have killed a man with a thousand more coming to him than Ruairidh himself was ever likely to see, and he spent a good many of the years he did have turning the six words he had said in the mud over in his mind, and found, each time he turned them, that they had not worn any smoother.

With that death began *Aimbreit nan Oighbrean*¹, the strife of the heirs. It was a feud first between the line of Murchadh and the line of Ìomhar only, a matter of raided byres and burned haystacks and the odd broken head at a boundary market, the kind of quarrel two great households might, in another age, have let cool over a generation or two. It did not cool. As the years went by and the lines married into each other, as they had married for a hundred years before the Roinn and went on marrying after it because there was no one else on the island of a rank fit to marry, the quarrel married too, carried into new households on both sides by every wedding that was meant to end it, until there was scarcely a line of the nine great shares that did not, sooner or later, find some grievance of its own tangled into the old one from Dùn thais, and the strife that had begun with one spear on one wet hillside went on, by fits and lulls and fresh grievances, for the better part of five hundred and fifty years. Every man who had stood on that slope

1. the Strife of the Heirs

in the rain was dead and past caring who had thrown first before it burned itself out.

IV

Of the Shares of Shares

The stewards who had ridden the boundaries that winter had done the easy half of the work, and knew it. Nine great shares, agreed on a cord and marked, more or less, with stone, were the whole of what the Roinn had settled; but under each of the nine lay the households that had knotted their own claims into it, some of them the direct line of an heir's own children, some of them cousins six times removed who had stood up at the gathering-house because a great-uncle's blood gave them a right to stand, and none of them, once the great sharing was done, willing to be governed as one undivided thing by a single lord when the cord had already recorded them as separate strands.

So the shares were parted again, and parted a second time under that, in the two years after the stones went up at Dùn thais, until what had been nine great shares on the cord had become countries under each of the nine, and provinces under the countries, and counties under the provinces, and under the counties holdings smaller than any of these, some no bigger than a single steading and its grazing, sworn by the household that held it to whichever county's steward stood nearest and could be bothered to ride out and take the oath. It was not done tidily, and it was not done once. A holding whose old boundary had run along a stream that changed its course in a wet winter was claimed the following spring by two counties at once, each steward certain the stream had always run where it now ran, and more than one such holding, rather than let the matter be settled by force, simply swore to both and paid both, and hoped the two counties would forget to compare their tallies, which for some years they generally did.

The mill on the Abhainn dhomhain, a little way below where three counties met at a bend in the river, came to be held by three lords at once in exactly this fashion, none of whom had ever laid a stone of it or ground a single sack of grain in it, and all three of whom claimed, with equal confidence and no writing at all to settle the matter, that the eels taken from the millpond in the autumn run were theirs by right of the ground the pond stood on. The miller, an old man who had built the wheel himself before the Roinn was so much as thought of and cared

nothing for whose ground it stood on so long as the water kept turning it, took to paying each of the three lords a third of the eel-catch every autumn without being asked, on the plain reasoning that a third paid three times over cost him less in the end than a whole season's catch seized by whichever lord's steward arrived first and angriest, and the three lords, who might otherwise have come to blows over it the way Ruairidh and Aonghas Bàn had come to blows over a hillside, found that a miller who paid all three punctually and complained to none of them was a peace easier to keep than a war worth fighting, and let the matter stand at that for longer than any of them lived to see changed.

It went on so, boundary by boundary, holding by holding, all through the two summers after the stones went up at Dùn thais, and the boundary stones themselves went on being set up and moved in the night and set up again, until it was said, by carriers who came to know that stretch of country better than any lord's steward ever did, that a man could walk from the Red Share to the great share of the north in a single day and cross nine stones that all claimed to mark the same line.

V

Of the Count That Gave Up

The knot-keepers of Dùn ìseal, who had counted the seven hundred and twelve knots of the Roinn on Sine's own cord and never once lost the tale of it, tried in those same two years to keep some count of what the shares had become underneath, because it seemed to them, as it seemed to Aodh Crom and the other keepers of the slab, a foolish thing for a kingdom to be cut so fine that no one living could say how many pieces it had been cut into.

They began well enough. Nine great shares, no one disputed; and by careful asking, county steward by county steward, riding the boundaries themselves with cords of their own to notch a knot for every claim they were shown, Sine's daughters and the women who had learned the craft from them came, in the second summer, to a count of forty-four countries under the nine, which held for a season and was believed, and then had to be unmade and made again when two of the forty-four turned out, on a closer asking, to have quietly divided themselves into three apiece without troubling to send word to Dùn ìseal that they had done so. Under the countries they counted a hundred and thirty-one provinces, and

were reasonably confident of that number for the better part of a year, though even as they counted it two provinces of the eastern share fell to quarrelling over a fishing-weir and split into three between them before the ink of the notches, had there been ink, could have dried.

Below the provinces lay the counties, and there the knot-keepers gave up.

It was not laziness, and none of the tellers who carried the story afterward ever said it was. There was, in those years, no writing on the whole of the island, no mark on hide or stone that could hold a name still while a man's memory went on to the next thing; the rolls of the kingdom lived nowhere but in the knotted cords and the notched sticks and the heads of the women who kept them, and a head, however well trained to the craft, could hold only so many counties before the eight hundredth or the nine hundredth began to crowd the first out. Anna nan Snaidhm, Sine's eldest daughter, who had ridden more of those boundaries herself than any woman then living, told Aodh Crom plainly, the autumn the count of counties passed nine hundred and showed no sign of stopping, that she could keep the nine great shares in her head until she died and her daughter's daughter could keep them after her, but that the counties changed their own borders faster than any cord could be tied to hold them, and that a knot-keeper who tried to count them all would spend her whole life chasing a number that was never the same number twice.

Aodh Crom, when she told him this, said only that a kingdom too fine-cut to be counted was a kingdom that would have to be governed, in the end, by something other than counting, and that he did not envy whoever was given that task, because it had not yet been given to anyone, and would not be for a long while after his own death. He did not say what he thought that something might be. He was an old man by then, older than his years by rights should have made him, and he had carried the asking of the Binding and the counting of the first cord and now the setting of the stones, and he told Sine once more, at her own door, much as he had told her once before, that he did not think a man his age was owed rest on top of everything else the valley wanted of him.

VI

Of the Ground No Feud Might Follow

In the second summer after the stones went up, a household of the Red Share that had suffered a raid from across the boundary at Dùn thais, a matter of burned hay and two calves driven off in the night, brought its steward to the Hall's own ground under the central mountain to lay the complaint before the keepers, not because the keepers had any authority over a boundary quarrel between two lines of the king's blood, but because there was nowhere else on the whole of the island that both sides of the quarrel could be brought to stand together without one side or the other coming armed.

The steward of the northern line came too, when word reached him, and for a moment it seemed to the keepers watching from the door of their hut that the quarrel meant to follow the two men up the hill and finish on the very ground where the Binding had been sworn. Aodh Crom, old and slow on his stick by then but not too slow to see what was coming, came out and stood between the two stewards before either had raised a hand, and said what he had said once before on the night of the handful, in much the same short way: that the ground under the mountain, from the slab to the boundary the keepers themselves had walked at the Binding, was in no share and never would be, sworn so before any cord was cut, and that no man's spear, thrown or carried, was to come onto it in anger, whatever quarrel had brought him there.

It was not a new law. It was the same word Aodh Crom had spoken over the flame three summers before, said again because a new kind of trouble had come along to test whether the old word still held, and it held. The two stewards laid their complaint before the keepers instead of before each other's spears, and went away no more satisfied than men in a boundary quarrel generally go away, but they went away on their own feet, and the Hall's ground kept, that summer, the one thing it had always claimed: that whatever a man had done, or had had done to him, on the wrong side of whichever stone claimed to be the true one, he could stand under the mountain and not be answered for it there.

The heirs went home from the valley in the last of that summer, most of them for the first time in nearly two years without a boundary still open to argue, though a good many boundaries would open again before the strife of the heirs was done, and Ruairidh Glas went home to the Red Share with them, older than his three hundred years by more than the calendar could account for, and never, in all the centuries that were left to him, rode the ground above Dùn thais again. Carriers who came that way in the seasons after learned to walk the road between the two stones without troubling to read what was cut on either face, the way a

man learns to step over a root in a path he has walked often enough not to need to look at it, and if any of them ever wondered, crossing the burn at the fort's foot, whose grass they were walking on that day, none of the tellers who carried their sayings afterward thought it worth setting down which of them asked, or what answer, if any, they were given.

PART TWO

The Flame without a hand

CHAPTER EIGHT

OF Beathag Bhàn

FE 4-15

I

Of the Rush on the Slope

The mud was cold before it was anything else. Beathag Bhàn stood at the back of the crowd on the slope below the slab, and the wet of the path had climbed past her ankles and found her shins, and she thought, before she thought of anything grander, that she should have worn the other shoes. It was the twenty-eighth day of an t-Ògmhios, the fourth year since the fall of the old king, and half the valley had come up the hill to watch nine old men and women decide who would hold a fire that no one else was allowed to touch.

She had come for the barley, if she was honest with herself after, not for the choosing. Her mother's household sent her up with two others to trade a basket of it for salt, and the trading had not gone well, and she had stayed to watch because there was nothing better to do on the walk home. The keepers of the slab sat on their stones in a half-ring below the shoulder of the mountain, old people in undyed wool, and behind them stood the households who had sworn the Binding in the first weeks after the fall, smelling of wet fleece and peat-smoke and the black dust that does not wash out of a hill-woman's hands even after she has stopped mining. Further up the slope, apart from the rest and from each other both, stood the heirs who had sworn it first: men and women in good cloaks who did not look at the crowd, and did not much look at each other either.

A wind came down off the high passes and worried at every cloak on the hill, hers included, and she pulled it tighter and thought about her wet feet and did not hear her own name the first time it was said.

The second time she heard it because the woman beside her turned and stared, and then the man on the other side, and then the whole crowd around her seemed to draw its breath in together and step back, the way a field of standing barley parts when something runs low and fast through it. She had seen a hare do that once, seen the grain lean away on either side of a path the hare made and had not asked to make, closing again behind it as though nothing had passed. She understood, standing in the gap the crowd had opened for her, that she was the hare.

The walk down the lane the crowd had made left no mark on her memory at all. What she kept was the arriving: the bottom of it, in front of the nine, with mud on her shins and salt still owed to her mother's household, and the eldest of the keepers holding out a rush already lit, cupped in both his hands the way a man holds water he is afraid to spill.

His name was Aodh Crom, and she had seen him before at a distance, at the swearing that bound the flame to no one's blood, though she had not known his face up close until that morning: an old man bent sideways from some hurt long healed crooked, with eyes gone the pale grey of woodsmoke.

"Hold it for Bride," he said, in a voice pitched to carry to the heirs on the slope above as much as to her. "And answer to Crom for what is taken from the vein."

She took the rush. It stank of tallow and the little flame bent sideways in the wind, away from her and toward the mountain, as though it too would rather be somewhere else. She found she had nothing to say. The silence went on long enough that she heard, behind her, one of the heirs shift his weight and someone's dog bark twice down in the valley, and still she said nothing, because nothing she could think to say seemed large enough for the size of what had just been put in her hands, and in the end she only stood there holding the flame steady against the wind with her whole body turned to block it, the way she would have sheltered a lamp carried across a dark yard.

The keepers counted that silence in her favour. She learned this only afterward, from one of them, an old woman named Beitris who had sat nearest the fire and had watched her rather than the flame. "A mouth that has nothing ready is a mouth that has not been planning," Beitris told her, months later, when the two of them knew each other well enough for the old woman to say such things plainly. "We had had enough, that spring, of mouths with something ready."

Of what Beathag Bhàn had been before that morning, little enough was thought worth keeping even by those who had known her. She was of no heir's line: her mother's household held no share and traced its blood to none of the sev-

en hundred and twelve who had stood up to claim the old king's leavings, and no lord in the valley, however the shares fell out in the months after, could call her his by right of birth. That was the whole of why she had been chosen, and the keepers, whenever asked, gave no other reason and seemed to feel that none was wanting. She was six-and-twenty that summer, by her mother's counting of the winters, which made her younger than most of the keepers' own grandchildren and younger by some centuries than the least of the heirs standing above her on the slope, several of whom had outlived kingdoms she had never heard named.

The heirs did not come down from their place on the hill to speak to her. She stood at the bottom of the slope a long while after the keepers had risen and gone, still holding the rush, until someone from the households below came up and told her, not unkindly, that a fire held that long in the wind would want feeding soon, and showed her the way down to where they had made her a bed of dry heather in a turf hut at the mountain's foot, the nearest shelter anyone had thought to build before the choosing was done. She carried the flame in with her, set it on a flat stone in the hut's one room, and sat up with it through the first night telling herself, without much success, that she would think of the right words in the morning. The right words never came, that morning or any other. In time she came to believe that the keepers had been right, and that no words would have served her better than the silence had.

II

Of the Slab and the Nine Households

The keepers of the slab were an old order and their own, older than the fall of the king and older, by their own telling, than the coming of Ailean's people to the mountain at all, and they kept a reverence that ran alongside the new Binding rather than under it: the ancestors, the sìth of the hollow hills, the vein itself, and the weather that ruled when a gallery might safely be opened. They had no wish to keep the flame themselves, and said so plainly to anyone who asked why they had chosen a girl of no line to do it rather than one of their own: a thing given to no one's blood, Aodh Crom said, could not afterward be claimed back into any blood, theirs included.

They taught her what they judged she needed and no more. In the first weeks it was the shape of the mountain from outside: which slope held snow longest

and which shed it, where the galleries ran under which fields, which of the cairns above Cnoc ghlais the watchers climbed to read the cloud on the high passes before a gallery was let open for the season, for a coal cut when the weather above was wrong could bring the roof down on the cutters, and the watchers had died more than once proving it. Beitris took her up to the nearest cairn herself, on a morning cold enough to whiten their breath, and taught her to tell a cloud that meant rain from a cloud that meant only wind, a distinction Beathag never afterward managed with the old woman's certainty, though she learned to fake it well enough that no one below the cairn could tell the difference.

Of the galleries themselves she was told less, and told it slowly, a little at a time, as though the keepers were feeling out how much a stranger's mind could safely hold before it began to want too much. She went down once, in her second month, on Aodh Crom's arm, into a low black gallery lit by nothing but the lamp he carried, and heard the coal answer his pick with a sound she never found the word for afterward, a note somewhere between a knock and a sigh. He did not let her cut it herself. "The hand that holds the flame does not also cut the vein," he told her on the climb back up into daylight, sounding, for the only time she ever heard him, almost apologetic. "That was decided before either of us was born, and it will not be undecided for us."

He named the galleries for her one by one as they went, in a low even voice pitched for the dark rather than for teaching, as though he had said the names so many times to himself that saying them to another person cost him nothing extra: the first gallery, the low gallery, the gallery under the stone that fell, the gallery of the cold spring. She asked him once why none of them bore a person's name, as she had heard was the custom in the eastern hills, and he was a long while answering, long enough that she thought he had not heard the question over the drip of water somewhere ahead of them in the dark. "A gallery outlives the man who cut it," he said at last. "Name it for him and you've promised the mountain will remember a debt it never agreed to. Better it owes nothing to anybody, the same as the flame." She did not fully understand him that day. She came, over the years that followed, to think it the truest thing he ever told her, and to repeat it, in her own turn, to keepers who asked her the same question in the same dark.

That first winter taught her, too, what it was to be looked at rather than to look. Word of her went down the valley faster than she herself ever travelled, so that she came, in households she had never visited and among people she had never met, to be a figure fixed and finished in other people's mouths before she had

finished becoming anything in her own eyes: the girl of no blood who had said nothing at the choosing, who fed the flame Bride's fire and answered to Crom for the coal, who was already, by the second winter, being credited with a wisdom she did not feel she owned and a coldness she did not feel she deserved. She minded it less as the years went on, since a face seen only from a distance will always be simplified into whatever the distance requires, and she came to understand that the valley's Beathag Bhàn and her own were never going to be quite the same woman, and stopped trying to correct the gap between them.

Nine households stood about the mountain's foot, one for each of the old slab's districts, and it was settled among the keepers, in a summer of arguing she was not asked to sit through, that the tending of the flame through each season would pass among the nine in turn, a son or a daughter of each house sent up to sit with her and learn what she herself was only just learning. There was more argument in the settling of it than the keepers ever told her outright, though she pieced enough together over the years from things half said: two of the nine districts had wanted the office kept wholly among themselves, on the grounds that their people had sat nearest the old slab the longest, and had been outvoted by the other seven, who pointed out, not gently, that the whole reason for choosing a girl of no blood at all had been to keep exactly that kind of claim from ever taking root again. The two districts did not forget the vote, and their grudge over it outlasted every one of the keepers who had cast it, though it never once, in Beathag's own years, rose to more than a cold word at a gathering.

The first of the nine to come up the path was a broad quiet boy named Cailean, from the northern district, on the twenty-seventh of an t-Iuchar in the tenth year, who arrived expecting, he admitted to her much later, a shrine rather than a cold hut with one girl in it barely older than himself, and adjusted his expectations within the first evening. He turned out a poor hand at the fire and a good one at silence, which she came, over the season, to value rather more. After him came a sharp-tongued girl of the western district, then a widower's son who cried the first three nights and never once afterward, then in their turns the rest of the nine, each carrying up whatever their own household's gossip had made of the Hall before they arrived, and each, by the season's end, carrying something truer back down.

More households claimed some thread of blood back to one or another of the nine than nine hearths could ever truly have bred, and the keepers learned to let such claims stand unchallenged, since nothing was gained by disputing a thing

that cost nothing to grant. In her own years the nine were still few enough, and near enough, that she knew every face that came up the path by name before it reached the top.

III

Of Niall Òg's Gift

he came up alone, without the household guard that most heirs, even the least of them, thought beneath their dignity to travel without, in the twelfth year, on a morning when the mist had not yet lifted off the lower slope and the mountain above the mist looked, from where she stood, like an island in a grey sea. She knew him before he reached her only because Beitris, standing beside her, went very still and said his name under her breath as though it might carry uphill ahead of him and give warning.

Niall Òg was young among the heirs, as they reckoned it, and old by any other reckoning. He had stood among the heirs at the fall of the king and again at the cutting of the cord, though he held no share of his own and never would, and he carried his years the way some carried a limp, lightly enough that a stranger might not notice it until he moved wrong, and then would notice nothing else. What she noticed first, coming up out of the mist toward her, was that he was smiling, and that the smile did not look practised, which she had been told to expect of any heir who troubled himself to climb this far.

He had brought a cup of dark polished wood, small enough to sit in one palm, its rim carved into a pattern of running deer. She had never in her life held a worked thing so fine. "For the hut," he said, holding it out, "since a girl who feeds a fire for the whole valley ought to have one cup that is only hers."

She looked at it a long moment before she answered him, long enough that Beitris shifted beside her, and she understood, looking at the cup and at the man holding it, that whatever he meant by it, and she believed afterward that he meant it kindly and simply, the valley below would read it another way entirely: an heir's gift to the Keeper of the flame, a gift into the hand that was sworn to hold nothing of any blood but its own, and by evening every household on the mountain would have heard some version of it, most of them wrong.

"I have no cup that is only mine," she said, "and I am not to have one. Whatever I hold, I hold for all of them." She nodded down toward the house-

holds scattered below the slope, and did not name the heirs standing further off in their good cloaks, though both of them understood she meant them as much as the crofters. "If I take a gift from your hand, I must take one from every hand in the valley before winter, or answer for why yours was different. I'd rather answer for nothing."

He did not press it, which she had also been warned an heir would do, at length and with wounded dignity. He turned the cup over once in his own hand, looking at the running deer as though seeing them for the first time, and put it back inside his cloak. "That's a harder rule than the one I swore," he said, "and I swore it standing in the mud with everyone watching, and you're keeping yours alone on a hill with nobody watching at all." He looked at her a moment longer, not unkindly. "I think you'll keep it longer than I keep mine."

He left the way he had come, down into the mist, and she never heard that he tried the like again, with her or with any other Keeper. The keepers of the slab, when the story reached them, said it was the first proof they had that the choosing had been rightly made, since a girl of no line, offered a gift by one of the king's own blood, had known without being told what the gift was for. Beathag herself gave it less weight than they did, whenever the tale was told back to her. "I was afraid of the talk," she told Beitris once, "more than I was strong. A stronger woman might have kept the cup and answered the talk down. I only wanted the talk not to start."

IV

Of the Raising of Talla na Lasrach

The turf hut held the flame for eleven years, and it was never meant to hold it longer, but a hall is not raised quickly by nine households who must also mine their vein and mind their sheep and pay their measure of coal at the season's end, and the work went forward the way such work goes, in a week here and a week there between the harvest and the first snow, so that it was the fifteenth year before the last stone went into the wall.

They built it of dry stone below and turf above, on ground a little higher than the hut, where the wind could not so easily find the door. Aodh Crom, older now and slower on the slope than he had been at the choosing, walked the ground

with Beathag before the first stone was set and marked with his stick where the one door should stand.

"Toward the vein," he said, "and none toward the sea." He would not say more when she asked him why, only that the sea had no claim on the coal and ought not to be given one by a door left open to it, and she let the matter rest there, as she had learned to let most things rest that the old keeper judged better left unexplained. In the years after, other keepers gave other reasons for the same rule, none of them the same as each other's, and none of them, so far as anyone could later discover, the reason Aodh Crom had actually meant.

The masons were the nine households' own sons and daughters, taught as they built, and the walls show it: straight enough where the ninth hearth's people laid them, and less straight where the second hearth's did, and the keepers who came after Beathag Bhàn learned to tell one household's work from another's by the set of a stone as surely as by a face. She herself carried water up the slope for the mortar through two whole summers, since the flame could not be left untended long enough for her to do heavier work, and her arms, she said once to Beitris, learned more of the Hall's building than her hands ever did.

It stood finished by the last month of the fifteenth year: one long room of dry stone under a turf roof, a hearth-pit at its centre lined with the same grey stone the old slab was cut from, and the one door facing east along the line the vein ran under the mountain. No window looked toward the sea, or toward anything else; what light the hall had came in at the door, or from the flame itself.

V

Of the Two Who Did Not Speak

Before the roof was finished the valley kept its Samhain at the foot of the new walls, since the ground below the Hall, unlike every other ground on the island by then, belonged to no lord and could be walked on by every lord without any of them owing thanks to another for the standing room. Beathag watched the fires lit that night from the door of her hut, the last Samhain she would keep there, and saw among the crowds below two men she had not seen stand near each other since the choosing.

One was Ruairidh Glas, of the line of Ìomhar, who twelve years before had put a spear through Aonghas Bàn mac Mhurchaidh at the stones of Dùn thais

over a boundary neither of them, in the end, had been sure which side of the line it stood, and had not gone back to that ground since. The other was Aonghas Bàn's brother, Eachann Ruadh, who had sworn over the body that the debt would be paid, and had spent the years since finding no ground on which he was willing to be the first to speak and no ground on which Ruairidh Glas was willing to be found. Between the households sworn to each of them lay a dozen years of raids and reprisals that the tellers had already begun to call *Aimhreit nan Oighrean*¹, the strife of the heirs, and would go on calling it for five centuries more before either side found reason to stop.

They stood, that Samhain, on opposite sides of the same fire below the unfinished Hall, close enough that either could have crossed to the other in a dozen steps, and neither did, and neither, so far as anyone standing near enough to hear could report, said one word to the other across the flames the whole night through. But they stood. Every other ground on the island that year would have put a spear between them before the fire had burned an hour, and this one did not, and both of them, whatever they felt about it, seemed to understand that this was the one ground on which they could not afford to be the man who broke it first.

Beathag watched them from the hut door a long while, and told Beitris afterward that it was the first time she understood what the flame was actually for. The mountain would have gone on giving its coal whether anyone tended a hearth over it or not; the ground the Hall stood on was another matter, ground that could hold two men in the same firelight who would have killed each other anywhere else on the island, and ask nothing of either of them but that they stand there and not draw.

VI

Of the Flame Carried In

The carrying was done at midwinter, on the shortest and coldest day of the fifteenth year, with the last frost of the old hut's floor still white on the heather when Beathag lifted the flame from the hearth-stone where it had

1. the Strife of the Heirs

burned, unmoved, for eleven years, and carried it out into the grey morning in a covered lamp that Cailean's own hands had made for the crossing.

The nine households came up for it, and the keepers of the slab, Aodh Crom leaning now on two sticks where one had served him at the choosing, and a scattering of the valley's crofting families who had no particular right to be there and came anyway, since a flame does not move house every day and a person likes to have seen a thing once that she can tell of afterward. Sine nan Snaidhm came up from the gathering-house below with her cords, as she came to every gathering that seemed to her worth a knot, and she tied one that morning into the long record she kept of such days, a plain unmarked length beside the tangled record of the Roinn, and told anyone who asked that it was the first knot she had ever tied for good news alone. No heir came. None had been asked, and none, that morning, seemed to feel the lack.

Beathag walked the short distance from the old hut to the new door slowly, shielding the lamp with her body against a wind that had dropped, for once, to nothing worth shielding against, out of what she admitted afterward was pure habit and a little vanity, since a Keeper who let her flame gutter on the one morning everyone was watching earned no other name for the rest of her days. She set the lamp down inside the door, on the grey stone hearth cut to match the old slab, and opened it, and the flame that had burned eleven years in a turf hut at the mountain's foot burned that evening for the first time under a roof built to hold it, with its one door facing east along the vein, and no door at all toward the sea.

Aodh Crom stood at the door through it all, leaning on his two sticks, and said nothing while the flame was set, though Beathag, glancing once at his face across the new hearth, saw a look there she had not seen at the choosing eleven years before, on the slope in the mud and the wind: the particular stillness of a man watching a thing he had built with his own hands begin to stand on its own. He had never told her the reason for the door, and that evening, watching the flame settle into its new stone as though it had always meant to end up there, she found she no longer much minded not knowing it.

CHAPTER NINE

OF THE CAIRNS AND THE UNENTERED TEMPLE

FE 16 – 44

Chan eil dia air a' bheinn; tha cuimhne. There is no god on the
mountain; there is memory.

— said still among the nine hearths, of the reverence that took no
priests

I

Of the Name the Hearths Gave It

It is told at Dùn ìseal, by those who keep the memory of the nine hearths the way the knot-keepers keep the memory of the cord, that the reverence they practised about the mountain had gone a long while without any name at all, because a thing done by everyone from birth has no more need of a name than breathing does, until a stranger asks what it is called and there is, for the first time, nobody ready with an answer.

The stranger, when he came, was no stranger to the valley: a walker of the eastern share who had married into the ninth hearth and came to sit his season with the flame in the eighteenth year after the choosing of Beathag Bhàn, and who asked, on his first evening in the Hall, what the households called the thing they did at every dawn and every dusk and every turning of the moon, the small bowl of milk left on the sill for the dead, the coal-dust rubbed into a threshold before a birth, the silence kept on the ridge above Cnoc ghlas when the cloud came wrong. Beathag herself did not know the answer. She had grown up inside the doing of it,

as everyone about the mountain had, and had never once needed a word for a thing that was simply what a morning was for.

It was Beitris, old by then and past climbing to the cairns herself, who gave it its name that winter, sitting by the Hall's own hearth with the flame between her and the stranger's question: *Seann Spioradan nan Dia-thìreach*¹, the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich, and when the stranger asked what that meant, exactly, whether it was one spirit or many, whether it was the ancestors or the hills or the vein itself that a person honoured with the milk and the coal-dust, Beitris told him it was all of these and none of them separately, the way a man does not honour his own left hand more than his right, and that the reverence kept no priests because it needed none, having nothing to teach that every child did not already learn at its mother's knee: that the dead were owed remembering, that the sìth of the hollow hills were owed courtesy, that the vein was owed its season and its silence, and that the weather ruled all three and was owed the most careful watching of anybody's.

The name went down the valley faster than most things went, carried by carriers who had no carrying yet to speak of beyond their own two legs and the goods they could sling across them, and within a few years it was the name every household used for what it had always done without a name, so that a thing that had been nameless for the whole of living memory came, in the end, to seem as though it had always been called that, and the households who used the name forgot, within a generation, that anyone had ever needed to ask.

Beathag Bhàn heard the name from Beitris's own mouth, and turned it over for a long moment before she answered, the way she turned over most things that came to her fast. "It will do," she said at last. "It says what it needs to and claims nothing it shouldn't." She meant, though she did not say so plainly even to Beitris, that a reverence that kept no priests and claimed no single mouth to speak for it was of a piece with the flame she herself kept: a thing held by everyone's hands together and by no one's alone, which was, as near as she could tell, the whole of what the choosing on the slope had been for.

II

Of Mòrag nan Càrn and the Watch on the Ridge

1. the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich (the full name)

Above Cnoc ghlas the ground climbed in long grey shoulders to a ridge that caught every weather coming off the high passes before the valley below had so much as felt the first of the wind, and it was there, in the years after the Hall was raised, that the watching of the cloud was given its proper cairns, three of them at first and more after, built by hands that knew already, from a hundred years of losing coal to a bad reading, that a pile of stones on a height could save a season if a person only troubled to read it right.

Mòrag was of the fifth hearth, a quiet child who had shown, from the time she could walk the slope without being carried, an unaccountable gift for telling one grey sky from another that no one in her own household could match and no one much troubled to explain. She could stand at the door of her mother's house on a morning that looked, to every other eye in the yard, exactly like the morning before it, and say whether the day would hold or break by noon, and be right often enough that by the time she was grown the old watchers of the ridge had stopped asking her how she knew and started simply asking her.

She went up to the cairns for the first time in the tenth year, not yet twenty and sent, at first, only to carry water and turf for the watchers' fire, and stayed, by the end of that first season, because Aonghas Ruadh, the eldest watcher then living, told her plainly that he had watched that ridge for forty years and had never once seen a child read the western cloud as fast as she did, and that a man who did not use a gift like that when it stood in front of him was a fool twice over, once for having it wasted and once for knowing it was wasted and doing nothing. Within three years the elder watchers named her to the cairns in her own right, the youngest ever given them to keep, and she went on keeping them, by the end, longer than anyone before her.

The three cairns had not always stood where they stood. The first watchers, in the years before Mòrag's own grandmother was born, had kept no fixed mark at all, only a habit of climbing whatever height seemed nearest and trusting their own eye to the cloud, and it was a watcher of that older kind, an eastern woman named Sorcha whose grave no one now could point to, who first began piling stones at the three places on the ridge where she found she read the sky truest, so that a watcher coming after her would have the same three points to stand on rather than a fresh guess every morning. The households never troubled to hallow the cairns with any rite, and Mòrag herself thought that fitting, since a cairn's whole worth lay in standing exactly where the last watcher's eye had proved it useful, and a stone moved for the sake of ceremony was a stone moved for the worse.

The watch was simple to describe and hard to do well. Three cairns stood along the ridge, each built to a height a watcher's own eye could use as a mark against the sky, and from each of them, on any morning the galleries below were meant to open for the season's cutting, a watcher climbed before first light and read the cloud coming over the high passes: whether it carried only wind, which the coal-cutters could work under well enough with their cloaks drawn tight, or whether it carried the wet, low weight of rain that would find its way down through every crack the mountain had and turn a gallery's footing to mud before the cutters below had cut a single basket. A wrong reading either way cost something. A watcher too cautious kept the galleries shut on a day that would have given good coal, and the households went short for want of coal that was there for the taking; a watcher too bold sent the cutters down under a sky that broke by mid-morning, and more than once, in the years before Mòrag climbed the ridge, a gallery had come down on men working under rain they had been told would hold off.

"The sky doesn't lie," Mòrag told the two youths sent up to learn the watch from her in the twentieth year, standing with them at the first cairn in a wind that had already found every gap in their cloaks. "It only speaks a tongue most people never learn to hear right, and it doesn't repeat itself for the slow." She showed them the shape a cloud took when it meant only wind, high and torn and moving fast, and the shape it took when it meant the wet, lower and thicker and slower, though the difference, to the boy from the second hearth who had come up mostly because his household had nowhere else to send him that season, looked for the first two months like no difference at all, and he said so plainly, and she did not scold him for saying it, only told him to come back up the next morning and look again, and the one after that, until the difference stopped needing to be pointed out to him.

III

Of the Season the Mountain Lost

It was in the twenty-ninth year, on a morning that Mòrag herself was not on the ridge to read, that the wrong reading came that the tellers still speak of, and it came, as the worst of such things generally do, from a watcher who had done the work long enough to trust himself past the point his own eyes deserved.

Fearchar Glas had watched the second cairn for six years by then and never once been badly wrong, and on the morning in question he read the cloud coming low and grey off the passes and judged it wind only, the kind a cutter could work under with a cloak drawn tight, and sent the word down to the Hall that the galleries might open. The cutters went down in good spirits, since the season had been slow to start and every household wanted its measure filled before the shorter days came, and they had not been at the coal three hours before the sky that Fearchar had judged wind-only opened into the heaviest rain the mountain had seen that year, water finding every seam and crack above the low gallery and running down into it faster than any hand could bail, so that the gallery had to be given up entirely, its footing gone soft and unsafe for the rest of the season, and with it the whole autumn's cutting that the households had been counting on.

Fearchar did not try to excuse it. He came down off the ridge himself that evening, before anyone had sent for him, and stood before the keepers of the slab and told them plainly that he had read the cloud wrong and knew it the moment the rain began, and that he would not watch the cairns again unless they told him to. They did not tell him to. The tellers say it was never spoken as punishment, and Fearchar himself never called it that; the keepers judged, plainly, after that season, that a watch on which a whole mountain's coal for a whole season could turn deserved a choosing at least as careful as the choosing that had once put a flame in a girl's hands on the slope below the slab, and from that year the cairns were given to no one who had not first stood a full season under an elder watcher's eye and been judged, by more than one pair of eyes, fit to read a sky alone.

Mòrag herself sat on the small council that judged the new watchers after that, and she was harder on the youths who came to her than Aonghas Ruadh had ever been on her, because she had watched a season lost from a mistake she herself might have made on a lazier morning, and she told anyone who asked why she pressed the young ones so hard that a watcher who had never once doubted himself had simply not yet met the morning that would teach him to. "Fearchar wasn't a fool," she said, more than once, in the years after. "He was only sure. Sureness is the one thing this work can't afford, and it's the one thing that comes free to anyone who does it long enough not to be careful."

IV

Of the Cold on the Doire uaine Slopes

The Doire uaine hills lay north-west of the mountain, a low green country of birch and rowan where the old inscriptions on the standing stones, cut by hands nobody living could name, forbade any fire, of wood or of coal, to be lit within sight of them, and the keepers of the slab held to that prohibition as strictly as they held to anything the Binding itself demanded, though none of them could say, when asked, what the inscriptions meant by it or whose the hand had been that first cut the warning into the stone.

It fell hardest on the herders who wintered their flocks on those slopes, since a hillside with grazing enough for sheep through the cold months is not a hillside a household gives up lightly for want of a fire, and the households that held grazing rights on the Doire uaine slopes had held them since before the fall of the old king and were not about to move their flocks elsewhere on the strength of an inscription none of them could read. They wintered there instead as they always had, and ate cold, as they always had, boiling nothing, warming nothing, wrapping themselves in as much wool as a body could carry and moving enough, through the short grey days, to keep the blood working, and told their children, as their own parents had told them, that a fire lit within sight of those hills was a debt taken out against something none of them wanted to meet the collector of.

The thirty-third year was harder than most, a winter that came early and stayed late, with a wind off the western sea that found its way through wool the way water finds its way through unfired clay, and it was that winter the tellers remember best, because it was the winter a boy of nine, sent out from Doire uaine's northern steading to bring in a ewe caught in a drift, was himself caught by the same wind and found two days later, alive but barely, huddled in the lee of a boundary stone with no fire he had dared light to warm him, though he had carried flint enough to strike one and had chosen, even half out of his mind with cold, not to strike it within sight of those hills.

His mother carried him down to the Hall herself rather than risk the shorter road past the standing stones, and Beathag Bhàn sat with the boy through the night he was brought in, since a Keeper's hearth was the one fire on the mountain that had never asked anyone's leave to burn, and she asked him, once he was warm enough to speak, why he had not struck the flint, cold as he was and alone as he was and with no one there to see whether he broke the old rule or kept it. "Because it isn't only about being seen," the boy told her, through teeth that had not yet stopped chattering. "My grandmother says the hills know a fire whether anyone's watching for it or not." Beathag did not answer that at once. She had, by

then, kept a flame for near thirty years that the whole valley had agreed to trust without watching over her shoulder every hour of it, and she found, turning the boy's words over, that she had no better account of her own reverence than his grandmother's, and did not try to find one.

The ban was never lifted in all the years after, and no herder of those slopes, so far as the tellers know, was ever proven to have broken it, though more than one household lost a beast, and once very nearly a child, to a winter they might have made easier with a fire they would not strike.

Beathag sent word to the northern steading that winter that any household of the Doire uaine slopes was welcome, whatever the hour, to bring a sick child or a frost-bitten hand up to the Hall's own hearth, since the ban spoke of fires lit in sight of those hills and said nothing at all of a fire kept a good many miles off at Dùn ìseal. Few households made the journey, the distance being what it was and a sick child a hard thing to carry so far in the cold, but the offer was remembered longer than it was used, and the boy who had chosen the drift over the flint told his own children, in his turn, that the Keeper's hearth had once been held open for his sake, and that he had never once needed to walk to it to know the offer had been meant.

V

Of Beathag's Walk to the Ruin

There was a place, some way east of the mountain along a spur no gallery had ever been cut into, that the valley called Làrach an Teampaill¹, the temple ruin, and had called it that for longer than any household could account for, a low broken wall of dressed stone standing in bracken with an altar-slab at its centre that had clearly been shaped by hands and clearly, from the wear on it, had not been shaped recently.

It belonged, by every account the households gave, to nobody: not to the keepers of the slab, whose reverence had its slab at Dùn ìseal and no other; not to the Hall, whose flame was sworn to touch nothing outside its own hearth; not to any heir's line, since no share's boundary had ever been drawn to take it in, whether by accident or by the deliberate choice of stewards who wanted no part of a

1. the temple ruin

ruin nobody could explain. It sat in the bracken, uncounted and unclaimed, and every teller who spoke of it in those years said the same thing in more or less the same words: that it had stood before the Roinn, before the Binding, before, by the look of the moss on its oldest stones, the fall of the old king himself, and that nobody now living had ever heard a true account of who had raised it or for what.

Beathag walked out to it alone in the thirty-fourth year, on a morning she told no one she meant to keep, not even Beitris, though Beitris guessed something of it afterward from the mud on her shoes and said nothing until Beathag was ready to speak of it herself. She had heard, by then, every account the valley gave of the ruin, each one different from the last, and had come to feel, tending a flame she herself had been given by no explanation better than "hold it for Brìde, and answer to Crom", that a place so near her own mountain and so wholly unaccounted for was a thing she owed it to her own office to see with her own eyes rather than take entirely on other people's word.

The walk took the better part of a morning, over ground broken enough that she lost the path twice and found it again by the shape of the spur against the sky rather than by any mark on the ground itself, and she came on the ruin from the north, through bracken taller than her waist, before she quite expected to, so that the first stone of the old wall was almost under her hand before she saw it for what it was.

What she found inside the broken walls was less than she had braced herself for and stranger for being less. No image, no carved face, no sign she could read as belonging to any god or spirit the valley named by any name she knew: only the altar-slab, waist-high and long enough for a person to lie on, standing at the ruin's centre with its face turned, unmistakably and without any accident of the ground to explain it, toward the mountain, toward the very shoulder of rock under which she herself kept the flame. She stood before it a long while, in a stillness broken only by wind moving through bracken that had grown up through gaps in the old paving, and found, the longer she stood there, that she could not decide whether the turning troubled her or steadied her, since a thing that faced her own mountain might have been raised in reverence of it, or might, for all she could tell standing there with the wind pulling at her cloak, have been raised to keep some older watch on it that had nothing to do with reverence at all.

She came back down off the spur before the light went, and told the keepers of the slab what she had found, plainly and without adding to it what she could not swear to. "It is not Brìde's," she told them, "and it is not Crom's. Whatever hands

turned that stone toward the mountain, they were not ours, and I would not have us claim a place we cannot account for, the same as I would not have any of the heirs claim the flame." Some of the keepers wanted to send masons out to clear the bracken and set a watch on the place, the way a watch was kept on the cairns; others wanted it left exactly as it stood, on the plain reasoning that a place three ages might have left alone was not a place four ages ought to disturb on a guess. Beathag herself, when the argument had gone on longer than she cared for, put an end to it the way she had learned to put an end to most arguments that could not be settled by evidence: she said that no keeper of the slab, and no Keeper of the flame after her, would set foot inside that ruin again, since a reverence built on remembering the dead and courtesy to the sith was no reverence at all if it went stamping over ground it could not read.

The vow held. Whose place it truly was, the tellers say, the keepers never afterward claimed to know, and it seems, from everything that has come down of those years, that they did not know, and were, in the end, content not to.

VI

Of the Flame Passed On

Beathag Bhàn kept the flame ten years more after her walk to the ruin, quieter years than the ones before them, in which the nine hearths came and went in their turns and the Hall's roof held against every winter it was given, and if she thought often of the altar turned toward her own mountain, she said little of it to anyone but Beitris, and Beitris, by the time the two of them were old women together, had learned not to press her on it.

She died in the forty-fourth year, at Dùn ìseal, within sight of the mountain she had answered to for forty years, and the manner of her dying was as plain as the manner of her choosing had been: no illness anyone could name, only a slowing, over one winter, of a body that had carried water up a slope for two summers and shielded a flame against every wind the high passes could send down, until one grey morning near the year's turn she did not rise from the bed Cailean's own children had built her, and Beitris, sitting with her as she had sat with so many others by then, understood before anyone told her that the watch had changed hands.

They laid her on the slope below the Hall, facing the vein under the mountain, with her back to the sea, though every teller in the valley knew, and said so plainly at the burial, that the dead of the Dia-thirich went west over that same sea to whatever waited for them there, and more than one of the nine households wondered aloud, in the days after, whether a Keeper ought not to be laid the same way as everyone else who had ever died on the island. Beitris answered that question before it could grow into a quarrel, standing at the graveside with a certainty she had not always owned in her younger years: "She never once, in forty years, turned her back on the vein while she lived. I'll not have her do it the one day she can't choose for herself." No one argued the point further, and every Keeper after Beathag Bhàn was laid the same way, facing the mountain, though the reason given for it, in the generations that followed, slowly stopped being Beitris's grief and became simply the custom, the way the reverence itself had gone, in Beathag's own lifetime, from an unnamed thing everyone did to a name everyone used without asking why.

The nine hearths gathered within the week to choose who should hold the flame after her, as they had gathered once before to choose Beathag herself, though this time there was no slope crowded with heirs looking on, only the households and the keepers of the slab and Sìne nan Snaidhm's daughter come up with a fresh length of cord in case a knot should be wanted, which in the end it was not, since the choosing this time needed no long argument to settle it.

Beathag had a sister, long since married into a household of the fourth hearth, and that sister had a son named Muireach, quiet and grey-eyed even as a boy, who had come up to sit his own season with the flame twice already and had shown, both times, a stillness about the work that more than one of the keepers had already marked without saying so aloud. He was named that week, the nine hearths agreeing on him faster than any choosing the mountain had yet seen, and Beitris herself, old now and near the end of her own years, put the rush into his hands with words close enough to the ones Aodh Crom had once used that more than one person standing near enough to hear thought, for a moment, that the old keeper had somehow come back to say them himself.

"Hold it for Bride," she told him, "and answer to Crom for what is taken from the vein." Muireach Liath took the flame the way his aunt had taken it before him, without much to say for himself, and carried it into the Hall that same evening, past the door that faced the vein and away from the sea, to keep it there through years the mountain had not yet begun to ask of him.

CHAPTER TEN

OF MUIREACH LIATH AND the Luck-Stream

FE 45 – 68

Bheir an fhèith an gual; bheir an t-sruth an t-àgh. The vein gives the
coal; the stream gives the luck.

— said of Muireach Liath's ruling on Allt an Àigh

I

Of the Basket Once a Season

Muireach Liath had held the flame a year before he asked the nine hearths for anything, and what he asked for, when he asked it, was so small a thing that Beitris laughed when she heard it, and then stopped laughing, because he had not meant it as a jest.

"A basket," he said. "One to a household. Filled once a season, and not before."

He had watched, in that first year, what his aunt Beathag had watched for forty and never fixed: that a household near the mouth of a gallery sent its baskets down for coal whenever the weather turned, and a household two valleys off sent a boy with a creel only when the cold had already got into the old people's hands, and that the households near the mouth thought themselves no more favoured than anyone, because they had never once had cause to think about it at all. Muireach had grown up the son of no great house, in the fourth hearth, and he had carried a creel himself as a boy on more than one bad morning when the family nearer the gallery had already had theirs filled twice. He did not put it to the hearths as a grievance. He put it to them as a measure, the way Catrìona Mhòr's

people had once measured a knot to a hearth, and let them argue over the size of the basket until they had argued themselves into agreeing on one, a lidded thing of plaited heather that a strong arm could carry full and an old woman could carry a quarter full, so that no basket asked more of a household than the household had to give, and none took more than its neighbour's.

There was grumbling. A household with six mouths said the same basket that fed six ought not to feed a widow and her one grandson at the same measure, and Muireach heard that out and answered that the basket measured coal, and a widow's hearth burned the same whether one sat by it or six. The grumbling thinned within the season and did not return. The weavers of the third hearth took the making of the baskets on themselves, since the weave wanted a particular closeness of plait to hold its shape under a full load, and it became, before Muireach had held the flame five years, a thing a household was almost proud to be known for, that its basket had lasted three winters unmended while a neighbour's had gone soft at the rim after one. Baskets of that weave are made at Dùn ìseal still, long after the cup took the measure from them, and are made now for no purpose the weavers themselves could tell you but the making.

Beitris, who had kept the slab since before the Binding and buried a Keeper, said of Muireach in those years that he ruled the way water finds a channel: patient, going round whatever stood in the way so quietly that the thing in the way did not notice it had been gone round until the water was already past. It was not entirely meant as praise. She had known keepers who pushed, in her time, and one or two who had needed to. But she said it to his face once, in the third year, sitting by the hut's fire with her hands gone stiff from thirty winters of carrying water up the slope, and Muireach only turned the question back on her, saying little, as he did most things.

"Would you rather I pushed?"

"I'd rather you knew when the water can't go round," she said, "because there'll come a stone in your channel one day that won't be gone round, however patient you are with it. I only hope you know the stone when you meet it."

He said nothing to that. In the third year of his keeping he did not yet think himself a man who had met such a stone, and Beitris, watching him carry the rush-lamp in through the door that faced the vein that evening, let the matter rest, being by then an old woman who had learned there was little use pressing a young one before the world had done it for her.

II

Of the Stream Named for Luck

There was a stream that came down off the mountain's northern shoulder, no more than a stride wide at its narrowest and never dry even in the driest summers the valley had known, and it had no particular name in the years before Muireach's keeping beyond the plain one the households gave any small water, until a woman of Caol shean, whose boat had gone down twice in one season and come up both times with every man in it, said openly at a gathering that she had drunk of that stream on her way inland the week before each sinking, in what she swore was the right quarter of the moon, and had thought no more of it until the second boat came up whole as the first had. She was not believed at first, or not much, and the tellers say the households of the eastern share laughed at her more than they credited her, until a second man, and then a third, came forward with tales enough alike that the laughing thinned out.

By the time Muireach had held the flame ten years the stream had a name of its own, Allt an Àigh¹, the stream of the luck, and a season had not gone by without someone walking the long way up from the coast to drink of it under a moon they judged right, though no two households agreed entirely on which quarter that was, and the tellers of a later age would say only that the pilgrims never wholly ceased to come, without ever once agreeing among themselves on the reason.

The path they wore was walked mostly by night, since the right quarter more often than not fell in hours when a fisherman or a herder had no other business being anywhere but asleep, and it ran up from the river landing at Caol shean along the valley's eastern flank, worn deeper each year by feet that trusted the dark better than they trusted daylight questions about what exactly they were doing out in it. A boy of that landing, sent with his grandmother on the walk in his ninth year because she would not make it alone and would not be talked out of going, told Muireach himself, years later, that he had asked her on the way up what the stream would do for them, and she had told him she did not rightly know, only that her own mother had walked it and lost fewer nets in a lifetime of fishing than any other household on that stretch of coast, and that a woman did not need to know why a thing worked to know that it did.

1. the stream of the healing water

Muireach heard a great many such tellings in those years, sitting outside the Hall on evenings when the pilgrims passed below on their way up, and he listened to all of them the same way, without correcting any and without endorsing any, a habit that more than one of the nine hearths took, in time, for wisdom, and that Beitris, who knew him better, took for what it more plainly was: a man keeping his own counsel until he had heard enough tellings to trust his own judgment over any single one of them.

III

Of the Hall's Ruling

The stone under the mountain had never wanted for people willing to claim more of it than the Binding allowed them, and it was perhaps only a matter of years before someone thought to ask whether a stream that brought luck to those who drank of it might not, in some fashion, belong to the same reckoning as the vein it ran down from.

It was a keeper of the older reverence, one of the hearth-elders who had kept the ancestors' watch and the sìth's courtesy since before Beathag Bhàn had ever climbed the slope with a lit rush in her hand, who put the question to Muireach directly, on a morning when the mist still lay in the valley and the Hall's own hearth had not long been fed. She was old enough to remember Aodh Crom, or said she was, and she had walked up from the third hearth with a question she had turned over, by her own account, for the better part of a winter.

"The stream runs off the same mountain the vein runs under," she said. "If the vein is the Hall's to answer for, why not the stream?"

Muireach was quiet long enough that she thought, for a moment, that he meant not to answer her at all, which was a thing he had a name for among the nine hearths by then, though not always a kind one.

"Because the vein is stone that doesn't move," he said at last, "and coal that only comes out when a hand goes in and takes it. The stream moves on its own, the way weather moves on its own, and it was giving luck, if it gives it, long before any keeper stood on this mountain to answer for anything. I won't have the Hall claim what it never gave and can't take back."

"Then who does answer for it?"

"The same as answers for the wind, and for the dead under the ground it crosses. Not the vein. Not us."

It was said plainly, in a few sentences, on a morning no teller thought to mark as anything unusual while it was happening, and it was only afterward, looking back on it from years further on, that the households came to see it as the first time the Hall's own reckoning and the older reverence of the nine hearths, which up to then had run alongside each other without much need to define where one left off and the other began, had been made to stand apart and be named separately. The hearth-elders who kept the ancestors' watch took Muireach's ruling as the Hall admitting, plainly, that there were things on the mountain older than the vein and outside its claim, and said so with some satisfaction to anyone who would listen. The keepers of the slab, for their part, took it as proof that the Hall's flame answered only for what it had been sworn to answer for and reached for nothing beyond it, which they judged, on the whole, the more honest position, and said so with satisfaction of their own. Both sides have cited the same handful of sentences ever since as proof that Muireach Liath had been right, though they have never agreed on what, exactly, he had been right about.

Muireach himself, asked once late in his years whether he had known, standing in the mist that morning, that he was drawing a line the whole valley kept walking along in the years after, said only that he had not been thinking about lines at all, only about a stream and a question that deserved a true answer rather than a convenient one, and that anyone who found more in it than that was welcome to, so long as they did not ask him to agree with them.

IV

Of the Carrying to Muileann ruadh

West of the mountain, where the ground broke into a shoulder of grey rock above a wooded glen, the warm springs of Muileann ruadh had run since before any teller could set a beginning to them, water that came up from some depth in the mountain's roots already heated, without fire and without any hand breaking the stone to make it so, and pooled in hollows a man could sit in to his chest.

The sick had been carried there in litters for longer than the Roinn itself, but it was in Muireach's years, when the roads down from the high valleys had worn a

little smoother under the traffic of pilgrims going the other way to Allt an Àigh¹, that the carrying became a thing the households did as a matter of course rather than a last resort. A fevered child, a shoulder that would not set right, an old man whose joints had stiffened past what any winter fire could ease: the litters went up before dawn, so that whoever was carried could be bathed in the springs at first light, which the households held, without much argument among themselves, to be the hour the water worked best, though no one could say why that hour and not another.

Muireach let it stand without ruling on it at all, which was itself a kind of ruling, since more than one of the keepers of the slab thought the practice wanted the Hall's blessing, or its restraint, one or the other, and got neither. "The heat comes up from the mountain on its own," he told them, when they pressed him on it, "the same as the vein's coal sits in the mountain on its own until a hand goes in for it. No one breaks the stone for this water. I'll not break anything by speaking on it."

He went up himself once, in his fourth year, carrying nothing more than a walking-stick and a mind, by his own later account, to see what the households saw in the place before he let it run past him unquestioned as he had let the stream run past him. He found an old woman of the second hearth sitting waist-deep in the nearer pool with her granddaughter beside her, the girl's arm bound from wrist to elbow in a splint that had not set true the first time and was being given, the grandmother said, one more season in the warm water before anyone spoke of breaking it again to reset it. Muireach asked her, as he had asked no one about Allt an Àigh, whether she believed the water did the mending on its own, or only the rest that came with sitting in it a while each dawn.

"I believe my granddaughter's arm hurts her less after than before," the old woman said, "and I've stopped asking the water to explain itself, the same as I've stopped asking most things that help me to explain themselves. You might try it yourself, Keeper. It's restful, not knowing everything."

He did not answer that either, though Beitris, hearing the tale from him afterward, said it was the nearest thing to a joke she had ever heard him repeat against himself, and that she took it as a good sign in a man who did not, as a rule, find much in his own work to laugh at.

1. the stream of the healing water



Of Gille-Bride in the High Valleys

Word came down from the high valleys in the ninth month of Muireach's ninth year that Gille-Bride, of Somhairle's line, who had carried a coal of the First Flame home from the Binding and asked for nothing since, had died in his own bed among his own people, two hundred and twenty-four years old, in a winter that had come early to the passes west of Tobar dhìreach and stayed hard on the hill-folk who wintered there.

He had never come down to claim a share of anything in all the years since the Roinn, and the hearths at Dùn ìseal, who had grown used to seeing his sons and grandsons pass through on their way to trade wool for salt at the coast, had grown used also to thinking of Somhairle's line as a thing apart from the quarrelling of the nine great shares, a people who lived on the mountain's shoulders the way the sìth were said to live under its roots, wanting nothing from the valley below but leave to go on as they had always gone on.

It fell to his son Ceallach to keep the coal after him, on the same hearth it had burned on since the year it was carried up, and the tellers of the high valleys say that Ceallach did nothing on the day of his father's death that he had not already been doing for years, since Gille-Bride had grown too frail, in his last seasons, to tend the fire himself, and Ceallach had been feeding it quietly on his behalf for longer than either of them had thought fit to remark on aloud. What changed, the day his father died, was only that Ceallach fed it now in his own name and not another's, and the hill-folk who came to sit by that hearth in the months after, as they had always come to sit by it, found the fire no different for the change, which was, Ceallach himself said once, the whole point of a coal kept so long: that it should not know, or seem to know, whose hand fed it.

Niall Òg, who by then had outlived more of his father's kin than he cared to count on any cord, heard the tidings at Dùn ìseal from a wool-trader come down off the passes, and went up himself, alone, without asking leave of anyone, to sit an evening by that hearth before the year turned. He had known Gille-Bride only once, briefly, on the morning the Binding was sworn, a still man among heirs who none of them were still, and he had thought little of him since, in the way a man thinks little of a hill he has only once climbed. The fire he found there was small and steady, the household around it unhurried, Ceallach himself a grey-eyed man not unlike the father Niall dimly remembered, and Niall said afterward, to Muire-

ach, that it was the first death of anyone of Ailean's whole scattered kin, in the fifty-odd years since the ford, that had left him with nothing at all to feel bitter about, only a stillness he did not much know what to do with.

"He never asked for anything," Niall said. "Not the flame, not a share, not a knot on Sìne's cord. I keep waiting to hear what it cost him, and nobody up there can tell me, because as far as they're concerned it cost him nothing at all."

Muireach, who had by then buried enough people of his own to have a settled answer for most things, offered none for that one, and Niall, who had not come up the mountain looking for an answer so much as somewhere to say the thing aloud, did not ask him for one twice.

VI

Of the North Cut in Eleven

Murchadh Mòr, eldest of Ailean's living sons at the Roinn and the first of the seven hundred and twelve to be knotted on Sìne's cord, died at Baile Mòr mhòr in the eleventh year after Gille-Bride, close on three thousand years old, the eldest of Ailean's children to the last, with a score of his brothers and sisters still living to hear of it.

Niall Òg went north for it, as he had gone north for little else in the years of calm that had settled over the great shares since the shares of shares were first counted, because Murchadh had been the first man's voice he remembered from the gathering-house floor, the door on a cold hinge that had given the line "Ailean's son" and dared anyone to argue it, and because Niall, whatever else he had become in nine hundred years of watching people die, had never entirely stopped being the boy who had grinned at Sìne nan Snaidhm and said he was owed twice.

He found Baile Mòr mhòr crowded with a different quarrel than the one he remembered from the Night of the Handful, though it wore the same shape. Murchadh had left eleven sons, none of them by the same mother, each with a household and a following and a grievance old enough to have outlasted the grievance's original cause, and none of them willing to let the north pass whole to any one of the eleven the way the old man himself had let no cousin near it in his lifetime. There was no cord for it this time, and no knot-keeper sent for, since the households of the north had long since stopped trusting a cord to settle anything

a knife could settle faster; there were eleven knives instead, one to each hall of the north's chief holdings, and eleven nights of arguing over which hall went with which knife before a single cut was agreed on.

Niall stood at the edge of that hall on the night the cutting was finally done, an old man himself by the reckoning of anyone but the line he had been born into, and watched Murchadh's sons divide their father's great share the way he had once watched the nine eldest divide their father's kingdom, with lamps and cords and the same brittle courtesy men use when a wrong word might cost more than either side can afford. Lachlann Mòr, the eldest of the eleven, took the seat at Baile Mòr mhòr itself and the name that went with it, and was given it, in the end, with less argument than Niall had expected, since none of his ten brothers much wanted the burden of a hall their father had held so long that half the households under it remembered no other lord. Donnchadh Iar, the fourth of the eleven and the sharpest-tongued, took the western glens after an argument that ran two nights longer than any other, and made no secret, in the years after, that he judged the division unjust and Lachlann's seat too easily won.

"Eleven knives for one man's share," Niall said to Muireach, when he came back down to the mountain some weeks after, "where Ailean's whole kingdom took nine and a cord besides. I watched my grandfather's kingdom cut, and I've now watched my uncle's, and I'll tell you the only thing that's changed: nobody troubles now to call it holy."

"Does it need to be holy to hold?"

"I don't know yet," Niall said. "Ask me again once I've seen what eleven small lords do with a share too small to feed the quarrels their father used to feed on his own."

The north that came out of Baile Mòr mhòr's last division was a floor of counties smaller than any that had stood on the mountain's other flanks since the Roinn, each with its own hall and its own small lord and none of them, singly, able to raise so much as twenty spears, a fact the tellers already read as the plainest proof the long-lived blood was fading from that line faster than from any other, though at the time no one troubled to say it in so many words, being too occupied with the counting of glens to count anything so far off as a generation not yet born.

VII

Of the Cattle Taken at the Ford

It was in the third year after Murchadh's dividing that Eachann Ruadh, of the line that had shed the first blood at Dùn thais and never wholly laid the feud down since, rode with a dozen men across the boundary stones into the Red Share's northern grazing and drove off near forty head of cattle before the herders of that ground had done more than raise the alarm.

No one on either side called it the opening of a new quarrel, since the old one between Eachann's line and Ìomhar's had never closed enough to need reopening; it was, by every account the tellers give, simply the feud finding, after some fallow years, a fresh grievance to spend itself on, the boundary stones at Dùn thais having stood long enough by then that a generation had grown up on each side of them who knew the stones only as a line to be tested rather than a wound to be remembered. The Red Share's steward sent word to the Hall asking whether the cattle, once recovered, might be driven onto the Hall's own ground for safekeeping until the matter was settled, on the reasoning that no feud had ever been permitted to follow a man onto that ground since the days of Aonghas Bàn's death, and Muireach refused him as plainly as he had refused the hearth-elder over the stream.

"The Hall's ground keeps a man safe from a knife," he said. "It was never sworn to keep cattle safe from a drover. Settle it the way the shares of shares are settled, or don't settle it at all, but don't ask me to make holy ground of every quarrel that finds its way to my door."

The cattle were never fully recovered, and the two lines went on, in the years after, much as they had gone on before, trading raids and grievances across a boundary that had cost one man his life already and would, before the long years finally ran out of that blood, cost more than one more. Niall Òg, hearing of it at Dùn iséal, said only that he had stopped being surprised, some centuries back, by how little either side needed to remember why they were fighting so long as they still remembered that they were, and went back to whatever quieter business had occupied him before the news came, being by then a man who had learned, as Muireach had learned on his own mountain, which stones in the channel could be gone round and which could not, and who no longer troubled himself overmuch trying to move the ones that could not.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

OF the Silver of Muileann Chiar

FE 69 – 96

Chan eil fuil san airgead. There is no blood in the silver.
— Muireach Liath, of the seam apart from the vein

I

Of the Furnace that Answered to Nobody

The smiths of Muileann Chiar say still, when they tell the making of their own trade, that it began on a morning when three men stood about a wet fire and waited for a thing they had never made before to decide, on its own account, whether the fire held metal or only ash, and that no one among them could have told you, had you asked, what they meant to do if it chose ash. Fearchar Airgeadach was the youngest of the three, and it is his name the households kept, though he himself said, in old age, that the finding was none of his and the waiting that morning belonged as much to old Tormod who had fed the peat as to the seam, which had lain under the hill a great while before anyone troubled to ask what it was.

The seam was found in the sixty-ninth year of the Keepers' count, a few miles north of Dùn ìseal along a spur the mountain's own vein had never reached, where a shepherd looking for a ewe caught in bracken saw a grey stone with a bright wound in it where her stick had scraped the moss away, and carried the stone down to the Hall more out of curiosity than any thought that it might matter. It was the first thing dug from the ground of the island that was surely not

coal: no household could name a use for it, no keeper could say whose it was, and it sat on a sill at Dùn ìseal for the better part of a season, turned over now and again by whoever passed, bright where the shepherd's stick had scraped it and dull everywhere else, until Fearchar, who carried baskets for the ninth hearth and had spent more hours than most men watching the fires that fed the vein, asked to take it away and see what a fire hot enough would do to it.

He was not a smith. There were no smiths on the island in those years in the sense the word later came to carry, only households that shaped bone and horn and wood, and heated stone for building, and Fearchar's whole claim to the work was that he had watched the vein's fires longer and more closely than most, banking them and starving them and coaxing them by turns through three winters of carrying baskets for keepers who trusted him with the watching precisely because he asked so few questions of it. He built his own fire apart from the Hall's, on the spur where the grey stone had been found, of wood first and then, when the wood alone would not answer, of peat cut and dried the way the vein's own peat was cut, and he fed it through most of a day and half a night before old Tormod, dozing against a rock with the second basket of peat still unopened beside him, woke to find Fearchar standing over the ashes with something in his hand that had not been there when the fire was lit: a bead of metal no larger than a thumb-nail, soft enough to press a mark into with a fingernail, and brighter, where it caught the last of the firelight, than anything either man had ever pulled whole out of the ground.

It is told that Fearchar said nothing for a long while, turning the bead in his fingers the way the Hall's own keepers turned a coal to judge its burning, and that when he did speak it was only to ask Tormod whether the fire had answered to the Hall in any way that either of them could account for, since he himself had lit it on the spur and fed it with his own hands and asked leave of no one to do either. Tormod, who had spent thirty years of his life keeping fires that answered to nobody but the Hall, said that this one, so far as he could tell, answered to nobody at all, and the two men sat a while longer by the dying peat without either of them saying what they both plainly thought, which was that a fire owing nothing to the vein and nothing to the flame was a new thing on the island, whatever else it turned out to be.

Word of the bead reached Dùn ìseal within the week, carried by Tormod himself, who could not keep from telling it, and within the month Fearchar had built a proper furnace of clay and dry stone on the same spur, banked into the hillside

the way the vein's own galleries were banked, and was smelting the grey stone by the basketful into beads and then into small ingots and then, once he had learned to hammer the soft metal without cracking it, into rings. The households of the ninth hearth called the place Muileann chiar, the dark mill, after the smoke that hung over it on a still morning, and the name held, though there was already another place of that name far to the east, near a holy wood, and the two were never once mistaken for each other by anyone who had walked to both.

II

Of the Ring that Showed No Colour

The seam lay apart from the mountain's own vein by a distance no gallery had ever crossed, and it was not long before someone asked, as someone always asked of anything new on the island in those years, whether the new metal fell under the flame the way the coal did, and whether Fearchar's furnace, answering to nobody, ought in fact to be made to answer to the Hall the same as every other fire that burned near Dùn ìseal.

Muireach Liath heard the question at the Hall's own hearth, from two of the ninth household who put it to him plainly enough, and it is said that he asked first to see the metal before he answered anything, and sat a long while with one of Fearchar's rings turned in his fingers by the light of the flame he himself kept, much as Fearchar had turned the first bead by the light of his own fire on the spur. Whatever he was looking for in the ring, the Hall's own coal never showed it to anyone: a coal, cracked open at the vein's own edge, showed its colours in the break, now one of the seven and now another, to any eye of the island that looked, and it was that colour and nothing else that the flame answered to and the households paid dues on. The ring showed nothing of the kind. It broke, when Muireach pressed a thumbnail hard enough into the softest part of it, with no colour at all beneath the break, only the same pale sheen the whole ring already wore, and Muireach set it down on the hearth-stone between himself and the two who had asked and said the thing that every teller of the Hall's history repeats afterward in nearly the same words.

"Chan eil fuil san airgead," he said. *There is no blood in the silver.* He meant, and said so plainly when one of the two asked him to say more, that the coal of the vein bled a colour when it broke that every keeper since the first had sworn to

answer for, and that this new metal showed nothing of the kind under any breaking he could give it, and so belonged, so far as the flame's own oath reached, to nobody at all. "Fearchar dug it, and Fearchar may dig on," he told them, "and whatever comes of the digging is his to keep or give as he sees fit, since the Hall has no claim on a thing that shows no colour when it breaks." He gave the ruling once, at the Hall's own hearth, and never troubled to give it again, though more than one household, watching the digging swell, muttered afterward that they wished the flame had claimed a share of it.

Muileann chiar dug on. Within two years the spur held four furnaces where Fearchar's one had stood, worked by his own kin and by a handful of households of the ninth hearth who had grown tired of carrying baskets for a vein that gave them coal and asked for their whole lives in return, and the place that had been a shepherd's path a few years before had a name of its own on every carrier's tongue between Dùn iséal and the coast. Fearchar himself kept the first furnace and taught the others what he had learned of the fire's temper by trial and by the burns on his own hands, and it is remembered of him, by those who worked the spur in his own lifetime, that the first ring off every new furnace he raised was never sold nor worn nor traded but set instead, whole, on a flat stone at the mouth of the workings, an offering to Goibhniu, the smith beyond the smiths, before the second ring was so much as begun; and that no furnace of his ever failed in its first season, which the smiths of Muileann chiar took, for as long as the custom held, as proof enough that the god had taken the offering kindly.

III

Of the Two Cousins and the Ground Between

The seam's freedom from the flame did not make it free of every other claim a household on the island knew how to press, and it was not two years before the ground the seam ran under was claimed, in the same season and with equal certainty, by two cousins of the eastern share who had never before had cause to trouble themselves over a stretch of hillside neither of them had thought worth a boundary stone.

The two were grandsons of one grandfather through different daughters, and the boundary between their households had run, since their grandfather's own day, along a burn that dried in most summers and was never once in living

memory worth arguing over, since the ground either side of it was thin pasture that fed a scattering of goats and little else. The seam changed that reckoning inside a single season. Both cousins sent word to Dùn iséal within days of each other, in the seventy-fifth year, each swearing that the spur where Fearchar's furnaces now stood lay on his own side of the dried burn and not his kinsman's, and each bringing, when the keepers of the slab asked for it, an account of the boundary that agreed with his own claim to the seam and disagreed with his cousin's in every particular that mattered.

It was not a matter the flame could rule on, the seam having already been ruled outside its reach, and the keepers of the slab, who had no more standing over a boundary between two heirs' households than the flame did, sent the two cousins back to settle it as households of their kin had always settled such things, by the word of elders both sides trusted and, failing that, by whatever each side could hold and defend. Neither cousin would yield the claim, and for the better part of a year the smiths of Muileann chiar worked their furnaces under the eyes of two households who watched each other across the dry burn more closely than either watched the fires, until a solution presented itself that satisfied neither man's pride and both men's purses at once: Fearchar himself, weary of digging under a dispute he had not started and could not settle, offered a ring to each cousin from the season's working, in the seventy-sixth year, on the plain condition that both let the digging go on undisturbed while their elders argued the boundary at their leisure.

Both cousins took the ring, neither gladly, since taking it looked, to anyone watching from the valley, a good deal like admitting that the ground in dispute was worth less to argue over than a season's silver was worth to hold; but neither man found, once the ring was in his hand, that he could think of a dignified way to give it back, and the digging went on. The burn's true course was settled at last by a boundary stone the two households raised together at the driest point of the burn's bed, cut with a mark on either face and set so that each cousin's flock could be seen from his own side of it, and the stone came to be known, to every household of the eastern share, simply as the silver stone, though not every household that used the name could have said why.

IV

Of the Rings for Salt and Sealskin

It was carriers, not smiths, who first thought to take the new rings anywhere beyond the spur that made them, and it was to the river quays at Ros fhionn, a day and a half's walk north along the old path the pilgrims of Allt an Àigh¹ had first worn, that the earliest of them were carried, in the same season that Fearchar's second furnace first began to answer as steadily as his own.

Ros fhionn stood where the river widened enough for boats out of the northern coast to come up on a rising tide and go down again on the next, and its households had long since learned to want more of everything than the land immediately about them could give: salt, which no household inland could make for itself in any quantity the winter's fish-curing wanted, and sealskin, which the boats brought down from the colder waters north of the cape and which no inland household had any way to come by at all except through a coast-dweller willing to trade it. What Muileann chiar's smiths had that Ros fhionn's boatmen wanted was less obvious to either side at first than it seems from this distance, since a ring of soft grey metal fed nobody and mended no net and kept out no weather, but a boatman who had carried salt fish up every river landing on that coast for twenty years put the two things together within a single evening's talk at the quay, reasoning that any household inland that wanted salt badly enough would find some way to want the rings too, once it was known that the coast would take them.

He was proved right within the season. The first exchange the quays remember plainly was a single ring for a full boatload of salted fish and sealskin together, struck between a carrier of the ninth hearth and a boatman whose name the tellers no longer agree on, and it stood, once it was known, as the measure every later trade was weighed against, so that for a long while afterward a boatman naming his price for a load of any size would say simply "a ring's worth" or "half a ring" and be understood by anyone on the quay without further reckoning. It was the first trade the island had ever struck in anything but food and shelter and labour owed, and the first whose price outlived the season it was struck in, carried in memory from one bargaining to the next the way a coal's colour was carried from one keeper to the next, and carriers who had grown old walking the path between Muileann chiar and Ros fhionn said, when they were old themselves, that they had watched a whole new kind of reckoning grow up on that path within their own lifetimes, though none of them, pressed to explain what the reckoning was

1. the stream of the healing water

for, could give an answer much better than that a ring bought what a ring bought, and everyone on both ends of the path had come, somehow, to agree on it.

The salt came back up the path in barrels lashed to poles carried two to a load, and the sealskin in bundles that smelled, more than one household said, of the whole northern sea at once, and Muileann chiar, which had been four furnaces and a scattering of turf huts a year before, grew a smokehouse and a salting shed within two more, until a traveller coming up from the coast could smell the place before the smoke of its furnaces ever came in sight of him. Fearchar himself went down to Ros fhionn only once, in the last years before his hands grew too stiff for the hammer, to see with his own eyes the place his rings had been going all that time, and is said to have stood a long while at the quay watching a boat unload salt he had never once thought, when he stood over his first bead of metal by a dying fire on the spur, to have any hand in bringing ashore.

V

Of Ceallach's Long Years Ended

Not every household of that generation measured its years the way the smiths of Muileann chiar measured theirs, in furnaces raised and rings hammered, and it was in the seventy-ninth year of the Keepers' count, while the boundary stone between the two cousins was still new-set and the salt road to Ros fhionn still young enough that old men remembered walking it for the first time, that Ceallach mac Ghille-Bhríde died in the high valleys at the age of a hundred and forty years, the last of Somhairle's line in whom the long years still showed.

He was Gille-Bhríde's son, and had kept, since his father's death twenty-six years before, the coal of the First Flame on his own hearth in the high valleys where the air ran thin and cold and few households troubled to build above the tree line at all, tending it the way his father had tended it since the Binding, while his own line reached back through years that the valley itself could no longer count with any certainty, since every teller who tried gave a different tally. His own years had begun to fail him some seasons before his death, the way a slope fails under snow that has been building a good while before anyone marks the first crack in it, and by his last winter he no longer walked the high paths himself but sat by his own hearth and let his grandchildren carry word up and down to

him, watching the flame he kept grow, in his own words to more than one of them, "no dimmer, though I am."

He died in his sleep on a night no household afterward could fix with certainty, since the valley learned of it only when a grandson came up at dawn with bread and found the old man cold and the hearth-coal, by some account or other, already grown ash, though other tellers of the same death swear the coal still glowed when the household gathered and was carried down, in a covered dish, to be given at last to the Hall's own flame, the line of Somhairle's long keeping ending where the line of Beathag Bhàn's shorter keeping had begun. His children, none of whom had inherited anything of his years beyond the ordinary span any household on the island by then expected of itself, did not stay in the high valleys once he was gone. They went down into the lower ground within the year, scattering among households of the ninth and the fourth hearths, and though the name of Somhairle's line was remembered a good while longer in the telling of Ceallach's own death, no household after him in that line was ever again spoken of as one that a stranger might mistake, meeting an old man on a slope, for someone who had watched the mountain since before the Roinn.

It is told, and no teller of the Hall's history has ever thought to doubt it, that word of Ceallach's death reached Fearchar at his furnace on the same day the last ring of that season was set out on the flat stone for Goibhniu, and that Fearchar, hearing it, set the tools down for the rest of the day, though the two men had never once met in life, on the plain reasoning, as he gave it to Tormod that evening, that the island had just grown a great deal younger all at once, and a man ought to mark that the same as he would mark anything else worth marking.

VI

Of the Flame Passed to Gormshuil

Muireach Liath kept the flame ten years more after Ceallach's death, years in which the Hall's roof held and the nine hearths came and went in their turns much as they had under Beathag Bhàn before him, and if he thought often, in those years, of the ring he had once turned in his fingers and found to show no colour when it broke, he gave the Hall no further ruling on it, the first one having settled, so far as anyone could tell, every question the households afterward thought to ask him.

He died at Dùn ìseal in the eighty-ninth year, at eighty-one years of age, in much the same manner Beathag Bhàn had died before him: no illness the households could put a name to, only a slow failing of strength over one winter, until a morning came on which he did not rise, and the nine hearths were called together within the week to choose who should carry the flame after him, as they had been called to choose him after Beathag. Three of the households put forward candidates of their own that year, each with a claim the keepers of the slab judged sound enough to weigh seriously: a grandson of the sixth hearth who had already sat two seasons with the flame and shown, by every account, a steadiness the keepers valued; a daughter of the third hearth whose grandmother had been one of the nine who chose Beathag Bhàn herself, and who argued, through her own household, that the choosing owed something to that memory; and a nephew of Muireach's own, of the ninth hearth, whose chief claim, as more than one keeper noted privately, was blood and little more. The nine hearths heard all three argued for at length, over the better part of two days, and passed over all three in the end, choosing instead Muireach's own daughter Gormshuil, then forty-nine years of age, who had sat her own seasons with the flame without either household or grandmother's memory to speak for her beyond the work itself.

It is told that the three passed-over candidates took the choosing, each in his or her own fashion, better than the households behind them had expected: the grandson of the sixth hearth is remembered to have said only that the flame had chosen rightly before and would likely go on doing so without his help; the daughter of the third hearth kept her own grandmother's memory alive in another fashion, knotting at last, on a cord of her own, the names of every household that had sat a season with the flame since Beathag Bhàn, a cord the Hall kept and went on adding to; and Muireach's own nephew, who alone among the three might have pressed his claim further on the strength of blood, chose instead to go north to Muileann chiar within the year and take up work at one of Fearchar's furnaces, where it is said he prospered a good deal more than he might have as a Keeper who had come to the flame by kinship rather than by the households' own choosing.

Gormshuil nic Mhuirich took the flame from her father's own hands before he died, in the last days when he could still hold it steady enough to pass it on, and carried it into the Hall the evening the nine hearths' choosing was made known, past the same door that faced the vein and away from the sea that every Keeper before her had passed through. Seven years into her keeping, in the ninety-

sixth year, when the smiths of Muileann chiar had grown from Fearchar's single furnace to a settlement the carriers named without needing to explain which Muileann chiar they meant, the kin of Gormshuil herself at Dùn ìseal began to be spoken of, by households up and down the valley, by a name of their own, and no longer by their hearth alone: Sliochd Mhuirich¹, the house of Muireach, the first house of the flame's keeping that the island had ever troubled to call by a name rather than a number. No account that has come down of those years tells of the other eight hearths raising any objection to it, whether because none was raised or because none thought worth remembering, and the name held, as the ring's silver had held against every argument brought to keep it from the smiths who first hammered it, and no household of the ninth hearth troubled any further to ask why a house needed a name at all when a hearth had always done well enough.

1. the house of Muireach

Of Sìleas and the Stas

FE 97 – 125

Carson a tha an fhèith a' freagairt aon làmh, is a' diùltadh làmh eile?

Why does the vein answer one hand, and refuse another?

— asked first by Sìleas nic Coinnich in the grove at Muileann chiar

I

Of the Coal that Would Not Answer Evenly

At the far-eastern Muileann chiar, where the seam ran shallower than under the mountain and a cutter could work standing instead of on her knees, Sìleas nic Coinnich had cut coal since she was twelve years old, and she had never once, in all that cutting, seen the thing she began to see in her twelfth year at the face.

It was a small thing to begin with, the kind of thing a tired woman notices and puts away with the rest of the day's noticing, meaning to look at it again when there is less to do. Two cutters worked the same wall that season, she and a broad, slow, good-natured man named Dòmhnall Beag, and where his pick broke the coal it came away dull, dark, honest coal that burned steady and gave no more light than coal ought to give; where hers broke it, now and again, some strokes and never quite all of them, often enough that she began to count, it came away threaded through with colour, a green and a blue and a deep red running in it like oil on water, and that coal, burned in the evening at the hearth, gave a light that made the women mending by it complain they could not tell their thread.

She said nothing of it for a year. The vein was the vein; it gave what it gave, and a cutter who asked too many questions of it, the older women said, was a cutter

who would end by asking it for more than her handful, and no good had ever come of that. But she went on counting, in her head, at the face, which strokes broke bright and which broke dull, and she began to notice that it was not always her stroke and never Dòmhnall's; sometimes his pick broke bright too, on a day when hers broke dull the whole shift, and once, memorably, a boy new to the galleries who had never in his life given the coal a moment's reverent thought broke three bright pieces running before the overseer took the pick from him for wasting his strokes on show.

"It isn't the hand," she said to Dòmhnall one evening, over the ale that ended every shift at Muileann chiar. "I thought it was the hand. It isn't."

"What is it, then?"

"I don't know. That's the trouble of it." She turned her own hands over, looking at them as though the answer might be written on the palms and she had simply not held them to the light the right way. "Carson a tha an fhèith a' freagairt aon làmh, is a' diùltadh làmh eile? Why does the vein answer one hand and refuse another, if it isn't the hand at all?"

Dòmhnall, who was not a man for questions that could not be answered by supper, said only that she would wear herself thin asking a wall of rock why it did what it did, and went to his bed, and thought no more of it. Sileas did not go to hers for a long while after. She sat by the last of the fire with a lump of the bright-veined coal in her lap, turning it in the light, and it was that night, though she did not know it yet, that the question took hold of her in a way it would not let go of again for the rest of her life.

She was twenty-six years old, cutting coal in the galleries of a mountain her whole family had cut coal in since before her grandmother's grandmother, and she had a question nobody at Muileann chiar could answer and, so far as she then knew, nobody anywhere on the island had ever thought to ask.

Her mother, who had cut the same wall before her and had never in her own long life seen anything in the coal but coal, told her plainly that a question like that one was better left where she had found it. "The vein gives what it gives," she said, "and it has given this house bread for four generations without being asked why. Ask it why, and the next thing it gives you may be nothing at all." Sileas did not argue with her, having been raised to a proper respect for the vein and for her mother both, but she noticed that her mother, saying this, would not meet her eye, and that the coal her mother's own pick broke that season ran bright as often as dull, though her mother never once remarked on it herself. It was the first time

Síleas understood that the not-asking was a kind of answer in its own right, chosen by people who had looked at the same thing she looked at and decided, long before she was born, that looking was as far as a body ought to go.

II

Of the Wood and the First Lesson

She stopped cutting, in the end, when she had run out of people at the face willing to be asked, and the galleries, whatever else they might still have taught her, had nothing left to say to a woman the overseer had learned to watch. A cutter who wanted to know whether the coal answered her better on a fast day or a slow one, on an empty stomach or a full one, standing or kneeling, singing or silent, was a cutter the overseer began to find reasons to move to another wall, and after the third such moving Síleas understood that Muileann chiar's galleries would give her no more than they had already given, and that whatever came next would have to come from somewhere else.

There was a wood above the town that the town called holy without being able to say, if pressed, precisely why: Coille Naomh Muileann chiar¹, oak and rowan on the shoulder of the hill behind the workings, older than the cutting by anyone's reckoning, where a woman who had lost a child or a man whose luck had turned against him went sometimes to sit alone among the trees, and came down again saying only that it had done him good, without ever saying how. Síleas went up into it one evening in the autumn of her thirty-third year with no more plan than to sit where it was quiet and think, and she found, when she got there, that three others from the galleries had followed her without being asked, having heard she meant to go and having questions of their own that the face had never answered either.

She did not set out to teach. She set out only to say aloud, among people who would not move her to another wall for the saying of it, the question that had kept her from her bed a year before, and to hear whether anyone else in the wood that evening had noticed the same thing at their own face and never spoken of it, for fear of being thought a woman who asked more of the coal than the coal owed her. Three had. By the second evening there were nine. By the spring there were

1. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

near forty, cutters and basket-carriers and two of the overseer's own children, sitting on roots and fallen trunks in a clearing where the light came down thin and green through the oaks, and Sileas, who had never meant to be anyone's teacher, found that she had become one without noticing the day it happened, in the same way she had noticed her own question without meaning to.

She taught them nothing she did not herself believe, which was very little, set against how much she did not know. To count as she counted, first: which strokes broke bright, which broke dull, on what day, by what hand, after what meal, in what temper. That the counting was worth doing even when it answered nothing, next, because a question said aloud and returned to was a question that might one day be answered, where a question only felt and never spoken sank back into the dark of the gallery and was lost. And, most of all, that revering the vein and asking a question of it were not the same act, whatever the old women at the hearth believed, so that a hand might do both in the same day without offence to either.

The clearing had grown too full for the old fallen trunk she liked to sit on by the eighth spring of the teaching, and it was that spring the stag came.

An ordinary stag, or so the tellers who came after always insisted on saying, a red stag such as any hunter on the eastern slopes might raise in a season and take without ceremony, came out of the trees at the clearing's edge on an evening in early summer while Sileas was in the middle of setting out, for the fortieth time that spring, the question of the bright coal and the dull, and did not run. Its head up and its ears turned toward the clearing, it stood at the tree-line the whole length of the lesson, through the counting and the arguing that followed the counting and the long quiet in the middle where nobody spoke and Sileas herself said afterwards she had not known what to say next; when the lesson broke up at dusk the beast turned and went back into the wood as though it had somewhere else to be, and was not seen again that season.

Nobody in the clearing that evening claimed it meant anything. Sileas herself, asked about it many times over the years that followed, would say only that a stag had stood at the tree-line through a lesson once, and that she did not know why, and that she had never claimed to know why, whatever was made of it afterwards by people who had not been there. But the forty who had been there told it to others who had not, as tellers do, and by the autumn the school in the wood above Muileann chiar had given itself a name, claiming nothing about the stag's meaning, wanting only a name and taking the thing that had happened to them

that nobody else's teaching could boast of: they called themselves the stag's people, and the wood's own name, Coille Naomh Muileann chlar, began to be spoken alongside the older reverences as somewhere a different kind of asking was done.

Sileas let the name stand. She had never had much patience for naming things, holding that a name settled a question before the question had earned its settling, but she saw well enough that forty people needed something to call themselves besides Sileas's people, which she liked less than any name they might have chosen instead, and the stag's people cost her nothing to allow.

What the name cost the school was harder to weigh, and came only later. A stag that stands still through one lesson and is never seen again is, to the forty who saw it, a fact and nothing more; told a second time, by someone who was not there, it becomes a wonder; told a third time, it wants a meaning, and Sileas spent more evenings than she cared to count turning aside hearers new to the clearing who arrived already certain that the stag had been sent, and by whom, and for what purpose, none of which she had ever claimed and none of which she was willing to teach as though she had. "I saw a stag stand at the trees while I talked too long about coal," she told one such hearer, a girl down from the northern shore who had walked a fortnight to sit in the clearing on the strength of a story grown taller with every telling between her home and the wood. "That is the whole of what I know of it. If you have come for more than that, the wood will not give it to you, and neither will I."

The girl stayed anyway, and cut coal beside Dòmhnall within the year, and learned, as most of the forty learned in time, that the counting was the true teaching and the stag only the door that had brought her through it.

III

Of the Ford

Word of the school in the wood travelled slowly east to west, the way most word travelled that was not carried by a runner with a reason, and it was two years and more before anyone at Dùn ìseal troubled to ask what the far-eastern Muileann chlar was teaching under its trees. What travelled faster, that same year, went the other way, west to east, carried by carriers who had it from other carriers at the waypoint houses and told it at every fire they stopped

at from the Red Share to the last inn before the eastern wood, and it reached the clearing above Muileann chiar on an ordinary morning in the autumn of Sileas's forty-fourth year, brought by a basket-carrier who had walked three days out of his way to be the one who told it.

Ìomhar Dearg was dead.

He had ridden out from Dùn dhearg that spring, old even by the reckoning of his own blood, fifteen hundred years and more behind him and not a grey hair to show for it, to see for himself a boundary stone on the Red Share's northern march that his stewards swore had been moved in the night, a small thing, the kind of thing that on any other share would have been settled by two men and a rope before noon. At a ford on the Red Share's northern march, which he had crossed with four riders a hundred times before, Eachann Ruadh mac Mhurchaidh, who had sworn over his brother's body six score years before that the blood spilt at Dùn thais would be answered by his own hand or his sons' after him, without naming the man he meant, had been waiting in the alders on the far bank with a spear he had carried, by his own account afterwards, every day of those six score years, though no one had ever seen him carry it before that morning.

He did not throw it from cover. That much was granted him, by friend and enemy both, in every telling that came after: Eachann Ruadh stepped out onto the ford in plain sight, called Ìomhar Dearg by name across the water, and said only that Aonghas Bàn had waited longer than a man ought to wait, and threw the spear when Ìomhar's own guard was already turning their horses toward him. It took Ìomhar Dearg in the throat. He was off his horse and into the water before his riders understood what they had seen, and Eachann Ruadh was back into the alders and gone north before they had him out of the current, and the fords of the east, which had taken the first king a hundred and twenty years before, took now a son of his, one more child of the king to die at another's hand as Iain Dubh had died, in a quarrel begun before either of the men who fought it that morning was born.

Sileas heard it standing at the edge of the clearing with the basket-carrier still catching his breath from the last of his three days' walking, and she found, turning the news over as she had once turned the bright coal over in her lap, that she felt less for the dead man, whom she had never seen and whose quarrels were no quarrels of hers, than she did for the plain unfairness of a thing that had waited six score years to be paid, on a morning that began, for Ìomhar Dearg, with nothing more than a moved stone.

"They'll cut the Red Share now," Dòmhnall said, at her side. "Four lines have been waiting since the Roinn for an excuse to claim a piece of it."

The Red Share held whole. That was the second part of the news, arriving a season later and travelling more slowly, since it interested the carriers less than a king's son dead at a ford: Dùghall Dearg, Ìomhar's eldest son, eight hundred and twenty-three years old and already grey at the temple in the way his father had never been, took up the Red Share whole the week his father was buried, and told the four lines who came to Dùn dhearg with their old claims in hand that the share had been won with a sword once and would be kept with one again if it came to that, and none of the four, weighing what it had cost the last man who tried Ìomhar Dearg's household, thought the claim worth pressing. It was, the tellers said afterwards, the one wise thing the line of Ìomhar ever did in all its long history of feud and grazing-right and boundary stone, and it did it, as the same tellers were careful to add, for no better reason than that nobody wanted to fight for a piece of what a dead man's son had made plain he would defend to the last of his household.

Eachann Ruadh did not go home. He rode west through the night of the killing and the day after, past his own hall and past his own household, who would have hidden him gladly and been hunted for it, straight to the ground before the Hall of the Flame at Dùn ìseal, where he threw down the second spear he carried, the one he had not thrown, and sat on the bare earth within sight of Brìde's flame until the Keeper's cutters came out to him. The Hall's ground had been declared, in the first years after the Roinn, the one place on the island a feud might not follow a man, and it had never yet been tested by a killer walking onto it with the blood still on his hands. Gormshuil nic Mhuirich, who had held the flame thirty years by then and buried more of her own certainty than she cared to count in that time, came out herself to look at him.

"You have killed the king's son," she said.

"I have. Six score years late, and he never threw the first spear at Dùn thais. I have killed him all the same, and I'll not pretend to you or to Crom that I haven't." He did not raise his eyes to her. "I ask nothing of the flame. I ask only the ground."

"The ground was never yours to ask. It was sworn to every hand on the island, killer's and king's alike, or it was sworn to nothing." She looked at him a long while, an old woman by then, though not so old as the man she looked down at,

and said at last, "No spear follows you past that boundary stone. What follows you past it, into whatever household still owns you, is not mine to answer for."

He lived out the rest of his life on the Hall's ground, in a hut the Keepers let him raise at its edge, cutting turf for the Hall's own fires and speaking to almost no one who came to the mountain, and when Sileas heard the whole of it, months later and third-hand as she heard everything that happened west of the eastern wood, she thought less about the killing, which was an old story dressed in a new man's blood, than about the ground itself, sworn to hold a killer as safely as it held anyone else who stood on it, and what it meant that a place could be asked to be fair to a man in a way that no household, weighing six score years of a debt unpaid, had ever been asked to be.

IV

Of the Shut Galleries

Gormshuil nic Mhuirich heard of the stag's people in the same season she heard of Eachann Ruadh's flight to the ground, though it came to her by a slower and quieter road: a cutter of her own galleries, home from a season working the far-eastern seam on loan to Muileann chiar's overseer, who mentioned at the Hall, without thinking much of it, that the eastern cutters had taken to counting their strokes and asking why the coal answered one hand and not another, as though the coal were a thing that owed an answer to anybody.

She did not act on it at once. Gormshuil had held the flame long enough to know that most things said of a season's loaned cutter came to nothing by the next, and she let two more years pass, hearing the same report grow a little each time it reached her, before she sent a cutter of her own east to see the wood above Muileann chiar with her own eyes and bring back a plain account of what was taught there.

The account she got back was plain enough to trouble her. The stag's people did not deny the flame, did not refuse the handful, did not set themselves against Brìde or Crom in word or in oath; what troubled Gormshuil, hearing the cutter's account by the light of the flame she alone was sworn to carry, was something harder to answer than a rival reverence would have been, because a rival reverence could be met with the flame's own claim and weighed against it before the council. The stag's people asked, beyond any question of whether the vein should be

revered, why it behaved as it behaved, and a Keeper who had spent thirty years learning that the vein's behaviour was not hers to question, only to serve, found she had no ready word for a school that treated the asking as a kind of reverence, and a better one, some of its own hearers were beginning to say, than kneeling and asking nothing.

She summoned Sileas to Dùn ìseal in the spring of Sileas's forty-eighth year, and Sileas came, because the mountain under the Hall was where the vein itself was thought to run truest, and she had never in her life had the chance to put her question to it directly.

They spoke in the keepers' hut, the two of them and no one else, on either side of the same fire Beathag Bhàn had once been given to hold, and neither afterwards ever gave a full account of what passed between them, holding, both of them, that some things said in that hut were said to each other and not to be carried further. What is known is only what followed. Gormshuil forbade the hearers of Sileas nic Coinnich to cut in the galleries of Dùn ìseal, holding, when the ruling was given out at the Hall, that a question asked of the vein was a demand made of it, and that a Keeper who let a demand stand unanswered in her own galleries answered for it to every hand that trusted the flame after her. She did not forbid the school itself, having, whatever passed between them in the hut, no ground and no wish to forbid a woman from asking why a stone burned bright under her own hand and dull under her neighbour's; she forbade only the mountain to the asking, and left the wood above Muileann chiar to it entire.

Sileas walked out of Dùn ìseal that same week and did not come back to it in the years that were left to her. She said little of the ruling to the forty and more who waited for her at the wood, beyond the plain fact of it, that the galleries under the mountain were shut to any hand that had sat in her clearing, and that the school would go on where it had always gone on, under its own trees, asking its own question of its own seam, and troubling the Hall's mountain no further.

"She is not wrong to be afraid of it," Sileas said once, to Dòmhnall, who had never stopped asking her, all those years, what the coal would answer next. "A question, once it is let loose in a gallery, doesn't stop where the asker meant it to stop. I have never once pretended otherwise to her or to anyone."

"Are you afraid of it, then?"

"No," she said. "I only think it fair to be afraid of the thing you have started, if you mean to go on starting it."

The stag's people went on where they had always gone on, cutting their own seam in the far-eastern hills, counting their strokes, teaching a lesson that had once been interrupted by a stag and had, by then, grown too large for any single clearing to hold in comfort. In the last years of Sileas's teaching a dozen of her oldest hearers walked east out of Muileann chiar altogether, following the wood where it thickened and the seam where it ran deeper, to raise a house of their own further from the mountain's shadow than the first clearing had ever stood, and it is that walking, the last of the mountain's cutters going east under their own trees with their own question still unanswered, that the tellers of the school still keep, in the years after Sileas nic Coinnich, as the true beginning of all that came from her question: not the day the stag stood at the tree-line, which anyone might have seen and made nothing of, but the day forty of the eastern cutters chose to walk further from the flame than any reverence on the island had walked before, asking nothing of the mountain any longer but to be let alone with their own coal, and their own counting, and the question that had kept one woman from her bed on an ordinary evening a lifetime before.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Of the Smoke and the Stone Cup

FE 126 – 148

Cha do dh'iarr mi mo shùilean air ais. Dh'iarr mi làmban a b' fheàrr na sùilean. I did not ask for my eyes back. I asked for hands better than eyes.
— said of Fionnlagh Dall, called the Blind Keeper

I

Of the Death of Gormshuil

Fionnlagh had been three days without sleep worth the name before anyone thought to tell him that Gormshuil nic Mhuirich was dying, and when the word came at last it came by a boy's hand on his sleeve rather than by any voice raised for him, since the household at Dùn iséal had fallen into the habit, over the years of his sitting with the flame, of forgetting that a thing said across a room was no use to him at all unless someone thought to walk it over.

He had sat with the flame himself on and off since he was a boy of fourteen, one of a dozen or more the nine hearths sent up in their turns to learn the slab and the galleries under the Keeper's eye, and in all that time he had never once seen Gormshuil's face, having lost the last of his sight to a fever in his childhood, long before either of them came near Talla na Lasrach¹. What he had of her he had built the way he built everything, out of what came to him by other roads: the particular dryness of her voice when a household pressed her too hard for a ruling

1. the Hall of the Flame

she had not yet made up her mind to give; the way she paused, always, a full breath before she said a hard thing, as if weighing whether it still wanted saying; the smell of the oil she rubbed into her hands against the cold of the galleries, which he could pick out of a crowded room before anyone spoke a word. He built her out of these the way a man born blind builds a mountain out of the wind that comes off it, and he had come, over eighty-seven years of her life and near forty of his own, to trust the picture he had built better than he trusted most things he was told he could see.

She died on the ninth night of the second month of the hundred and twenty-seventh year, in the small room off the Hall where the Keepers slept, with her cutter's daughter holding one hand and Fionnlagh, sent for late, holding the other, and the last thing she said to him, in a voice gone thin as the last of a coal's colour, was a complaint, plainly meant to be his last memory of her and, by every account he was given afterward, exactly the thing she would have wanted it to be: that the room had always been colder on his side of the bed than on hers, and no one in eighty-seven years had troubled to find out why.

He sat with her body until the household came to wash it, and when they had gone he sat a while longer with the empty bed, and it was there, by his own telling of it in the years that followed, that he first let himself think what half of Dùn ìseal had already begun to think for him, which was that the nine hearths would meet within the week to choose who carried the flame after her, and that his own name, sitter of more seasons than any man living who was not already too old to be chosen, could not honestly be left off whatever list the hearths drew up, blindness or no blindness.

II

Of the Nine Hearths and the Boy who Led Him

The nine hearths met at Dùn ìseal on the appointed day, as they had met to choose Gormshuil after Muireach Liath and Beathag Bhàn before either of them, and heard the households argue for their own candidates through the better part of an afternoon: a strong young cutter of the fourth hearth who had never once, in six seasons, let a lamp gutter in a gallery; a niece of Gormshuil's own who carried her aunt's dry manner and, some said, a fair measure of her judgement besides; and Fionnlagh, put forward by three keepers of the slab to-

gether, no household of his own eager to claim him, on the plain ground that a man who has read the mountain by touch and hearing for twenty years knows it in ways a man who reads it by sight has never had cause to learn.

It was the niece's own household, in the end, that settled it, standing up before the hearths were done arguing to say that a Keeper's hands mattered more to the measure than a Keeper's eyes, and that they had watched Fionnlagh's hands fill a lamp steadier than any two of the other candidates' together, blind hands having no choice, as sighted hands sometimes did, but to feel exactly what they held. The nine hearths chose him before the light failed that day, the first blind man ever set to keep the flame, and it is told that when the choosing was carried to him where he sat waiting in the passage, he asked only one question of the elder who brought it, which was whether anyone had thought to ask who would walk him from the Hall to the slab and back on the mornings his own feet did not yet know the way, the galleries having grown, in Gormshuil's years, a good deal further than they had been in his own boyhood.

The answer to that came from an unlooked-for quarter within the week, in the shape of a boy of ten named Calum Beag, a grandson of one of the nine-hearth households who had taken to following Fionnlagh about the Hall since he was old enough to walk, out of nothing more than a child's plain curiosity about a man who moved through rooms he had never seen without once putting a hand wrong. The boy's own mother brought him to Fionnlagh on the third morning of his keeping and said, more or less, that the child would follow him whether she gave leave or not, and that she would rather he did it with her knowledge than without it. Fionnlagh, by his own later telling, asked the boy a single question before he agreed to anything, which was whether he could hold his tongue about what he saw in the galleries, since a Keeper's eyes, borrowed or his own, owed the vein the same silence either way; and Calum Beag, who had clearly given the matter no thought whatever before that moment, said yes so quickly and so solemnly that Fionnlagh laughed for the first time anyone at Dùn ìseal had heard him laugh since Gormshuil's death, and took the boy's shoulder in his hand, and from that day the two of them went about the Hall together, the blind Keeper and the boy who told him, in a voice pitched low enough for no one else to hear, what step came next and which face of which gallery he was standing before.

III

Of the Smoke at Cnoc dhubh

The winter that came on within the year was harder than any the Hall's own memory reached back to plainly, and it fell hardest of all on the households of the high ground above Cnoc dhubh, a scatter of turf-roofed houses a few miles from Dùn ìseal where the wind off the mountain ran cold enough, in a bad season, to freeze the milk in the pail before a woman could carry it from byre to hearth. One household there, whose name the Hall's own roll kept afterward with a plainness that spared no one, had burned its measured handful through the early cold and found, by the turn of the year, that the handful had not been enough to keep three small children and an old woman through the worst of the nights, and so had begun, in the desperation of a house going cold around people it could not warm any other way, to burn the coal by the basketful instead, a measure no household on the island had ever burned before, since no household before that winter had ever needed to find out what a basketful would do.

What it did, over three nights of steady burning in a turf house with no chimney worth the name and a wind outside too fierce to let a door stand open, was lie down in the valley the way smoke from a green fire lies down on a still evening, thick and low and unwilling to lift, filling first the house that made it and then, before the wind changed, the two houses nearest it as well. Calum Beag was the one who brought Fionnlagh the word, three days after, having heard it first from a carrier who had smelled the valley from half a mile off and turned aside to see what burned; and it was Calum's own voice, cracking somewhere in the middle of the telling in a way that had nothing to do with a boy's changing years, that told Fionnlagh before the carrier's own account did that this was worse than any winter's ordinary grief. Five were dead of it in the end: three of the burning household, a grandmother of the house beside it who had gone in to see why no smoke rose properly from either chimney and never came out again on her own feet, and a neighbour's infant carried in its mother's arms through air that should have been safe a full house-length from the fire and was not.

Fionnlagh went up to Cnoc dhubh himself before the case was ever argued at Dùn ìseal, led by Calum Beag over ground neither of them knew well, and stood in the burned household's own doorway while a neighbour described to him, in the flat voice of a man too tired for grief to sound like grief any longer, what five bodies carried out of two houses in a single morning had looked like laid side by

side on the frozen ground before anyone could dig a grave for them. He asked to touch the hearth before he left, and knelt with his hand flat against the cold stone a long while, Calum Beag said afterward, longer than seemed needed for any purpose the boy could name, until an old man of the third house, watching him, said aloud that a hearth-stone could tell a blind man nothing a burned house had not already told the whole valley. Fionnlagh, rising, answered that he had come to know what his own hands had been set over, and the stone was the surest way he had of learning it.

IV

Of the Season of Argument

The case was carried to Dùn ìseal within the week and argued there, on and off, for the better part of the season that followed, and Fionnlagh, new to the flame and new to judgement of any kind that mattered beyond a lamp's filling, found himself sitting through arguments that circled the same ground again and again without ever quite landing on it. The dead household's kin said plainly that a house with three children and an old woman in it and only a handful of coal to warm them through the worst nights the Hall's own memory could name had no choice at all, and that a law which let people freeze rather than burn what the mountain held in more than enough for every household living was no law worth keeping. The households of the other eight hearths, frightened by what a single family's basketful had done to two houses that had burned nothing at all, said with equal plainness that the handful had held the island's peace since before any of them was born precisely because it was never argued with, and that the day a household could burn what it judged it needed rather than what the Hall measured out was the day the measure meant nothing to anyone.

Fionnlagh listened to both sides argued past each other for the better part of two months without once giving a ruling, which some of the households took, in those early days of his keeping, for a blind man's slowness and others, more rightly, for a new Keeper's unwillingness to answer a hard question before he had turned it over as many ways as it would turn. What he came to, sitting alone with it through the nights Calum Beag had gone home to his own mother's hearth, was neither of the two things argued at him: not that the measure should be loosened, since he had heard enough that season of what five deaths from too

little coal could look like beside five deaths from too much of it to know the mountain's own patience was not the question, and not that the law needed no change at all, since a law no one could be certain of, held only by custom and the memory of what Beathag Bhàn and Muireach Liath had once ruled by word of mouth, had let one frightened household burn its way past the edge of what any hearth could survive before anyone stopped it.

What the mountain wanted, he came at last to think, turning the question over the way his own fingers turned a lamp's wick when he could not yet tell by touch alone whether it was trimmed even, was a measure no household could argue with, because no household could argue with its own two hands.

V

Of the Grey Stone Re-cut

There had been a stone cup at Dùn ìseal since the Age of Ailean, a plain thing of soft pale rock that the earliest keepers of the slab had used, by tradition rather than by any law, to measure out the coal each household carried home from the galleries; but it had cracked across one side in Muireach Liath's day and been mended with clay so many times since that no two households, filling it in turn, ever quite agreed how full it ought to sit before the measure was met. Fionnlagh sent Calum Beag up into the hills above Dùn ìseal in the hundred and thirty-eighth year to find him a stone the boy judged hard and fine-grained and free of any crack a mason's eye could find, and when the boy came back three days later leading a cutter of the fourth hearth and a slab of grey stone slung between two poles, Fionnlagh spent the better part of a month with his own hands upon it before he would let the cutter's chisel near it at all.

He had the mason cut it hollow to the exact measure of his own two hands cupped together, palm to palm, the fingers curled just short of touching, since his own hands were the one instrument he trusted absolutely to be the same hands every time; and when the cutting was done he tested it himself, again and again, filling it by feel alone until he could say, blind, with his fingers alone against the stone's cold lip, whether a fill sat a hair short of the measure or a hair over it, the way another man might have tested it by eye. Calum Beag, watching him do this through most of an autumn, asked once why he did not simply mark a line on the stone's inner face for a sighted keeper to judge by, and Fionnlagh's answer, which

the boy carried about the Hall afterward as though it were a thing worth keeping, was that a line could be read generously by a friend and meanly by an enemy, and a blind man's fingers, having no friends and no enemies among the coal, could not.

VI

Of the Threshold Found by the Foot

he set the finished cup, when it was done, on the threshold of Talla na Lasrach¹, the worn stone slab between the Hall's own ground and the path that every household walked to reach it, rather than inside the Hall where the old one had always stood within reach of whichever keeper the council favoured that season. There any man or woman with a claim to the coal could see, or be told by a neighbour who could see, that the cup sat in the open where no keeper's favour could shield it from any eye.

He found the threshold's exact centre himself, on the day he set the cup, by walking the width of the doorway with his own bare feet until he felt the worn place where centuries of households had crossed it evenest, the stone smoothed to a hollow no deeper than a fingernail's width by feet that had none of them meant to wear it so, and it was there, kneeling with the cup before him and Calum Beag standing silent at his shoulder, that he filled it for the first council to come and ask.

The household of the fourth hearth that came first that morning was a poor one, its elder an old woman whose hands shook with a palsy the cold made worse, and Fionnlagh, hearing the shake in her own voice before he ever touched her hand to guide it, filled the cup by touch alone and held it out to her level, not favouring the low reach an old woman's trembling arms might have asked for nor demanding the steady one a young man's would have given without thought. "Give me the coal," he said, and she gave it into the cup's mouth handful by handful from the household's own store until his fingers, resting light along the stone's rim, told him the measure was met; and when it was met he said only "Enough," and closed his own hand over the cup's lip so that no more could follow, whether the old woman's shaking hand meant to give more or not. It is told, and the

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households of the fourth hearth kept the telling a long while, that she wept a little at the fairness of it, having gone to every council for three years certain that a sighted keeper favoured whichever household stood nearest his own eye, and having found in a blind one's hands the first measure she had ever trusted absolutely.

VII

Of the Law Sworn at Samhain

Word of the cup on the threshold ran ahead of Fionnlagh through that autumn faster than any ruling he had yet given in council, and by the time the lords of the shares gathered at Dùn ìseal for the Samhain gathering of the hundred and forty-second year, most of the island's households had already heard, from a neighbour or a neighbour's neighbour, that a blind man's hands had found a measure no one could quarrel with. Fionnlagh put the custom to the lords plainly that Samhain, standing before the assembled council with Calum Beag's hand light at his elbow: that the measured handful, held till then by nothing firmer than a Keeper's word and the memory of two dead Keepers before him, should be sworn as a law binding on every share alike, north and south, the Red Share and the lowland plain together, so that no household anywhere on the island might burn more than the cup on the threshold of Talla na Lasrach¹ would give it in a season.

The lords grumbled, as lords of every share had grumbled at every measure laid on them since the Roinn, several rising to say that a law was a poor thing to bind on people who had kept the custom faithfully enough without one, and that the Hall had never before told a share what it might or might not burn on its own hearths. But the five who had died at Cnoc dhubh were not so far behind any of them that the argument could be pressed very hard, and in the end it was not Fionnlagh's own words that carried the council so much as the memory, fresh in every lord's mind that autumn, of the old woman of the fourth hearth weeping over a cup that had measured her fairly for the first time in three years. The lords swore to the law that Samhain, one by one, each laying a hand on the stone cup where it sat on the threshold; and when the last of them had sworn, Fionnlagh, who could not see a single one of the hands that had touched the stone that day,

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said only that he trusted the measure to hold them to it better than any oath would, since a cup, unlike a lord, could not be argued out of its own fullness. So the custom of the handful hardened that day into the Small-Burning Law, the first law that ran the same in every share the island held, made by no lord of any share and grumbled at by all of them, and it held, unaltered by a word, for longer than any man living that Samhain would ever have thought to guess.

VIII

Of the First Sentence

It was a household of Seann Tarr, a fishing town on the north-eastern coast that had never before troubled the Hall's roll for anything worse than a boundary dispute over drying-racks, that gave the new law its first sentence, in the hundred and forty-fifth year, having burned twice its measure in a single season against a run of wet weather that had kept its boats ashore and its store of dried fish thinner than any winter before it. The household's elder came to Dùn ìseal himself to argue the case before the council, laying out plainly that a fisher's household without fish to trade for grain had needed the extra coal to smoke what little catch the weather allowed rather than lose it to the damp entirely, and that a law meant to spare lives had very nearly cost his own.

Fionnlagh heard him out at length, and Calum Beag, a man of seven-and-twenty by then and still standing beside the Keeper through a whole council's sitting without his attention wandering, told him afterward that the old man's hands had shaken through the whole of his telling in a way that had nothing to do with cold. But the law Fionnlagh had sworn at Samhain three years before allowed no household's need, however honest, to loosen a measure sworn the same for every hearth on the island, and he ruled at last, with what Calum Beag remembered as real reluctance in the set of his shoulders, that the household of Seann Tarr should lose its right to the coal for the season following, its name set upon the roll with the offence beside it. It was the harshest thing Fionnlagh had yet done as Keeper, and the household's own descendants, the tellers of Seann Tarr say still, petitioned Dùn ìseal for generation after generation afterward to have the offence struck from the roll, and were refused every time, the roll itself having become, by then, a thing the Hall would sooner let stand unaltered than

see loosened for any household's asking, however old the wrong or however honest the need that had first caused it.

I X

Of the Fires that Answer to Nobody

The last question the law raised that Fionnlagh had to answer came from the headland at Tobar dhearg, from no household's own hearth, where a beacon had burned, time out of mind, to warn boats off the rocks on a black night, fed by whatever coal the households nearest it could spare from their own measured store. A fisherman of that coast asked the council, in the hundred and forty-eighth year, whether a beacon lit for the safety of strangers who might never set foot on the island at all ought to be counted against a household's handful the same as a fire lit for its own hearth, since a light that answered to no one household's need seemed to him a different thing from a fire that warmed a family's own children.

Fionnlagh turned the question over for the better part of a day, Calum Beag told it afterward, sitting alone with the stone cup at his own hand the way he had sat with it through the season of the smoke at Cnoc dhubbh, and the ruling he gave in the end went further than the fisherman had asked for. No coal at all, he ruled, might feed a beacon meant to warn strangers off the rocks, since the vein's fire was the island's own and owed nothing to a boat that might never touch the shore it warned away from; and from that ruling the beacon at Tobar dhearg was kept after with driftwood gathered off the tideline and seal fat rendered down for the purpose, a poorer light than coal would have given and, by every account the fishermen of that coast kept afterward, a steadier one, since driftwood and seal fat answered to no measure at all and never once, in all the years that followed, ran short at the one hour a black night made it matter. Every sea-light raised on the island after Tobar dhearg's was kept the same way, on the same ruling, and the households of that coast, telling of it to their own children afterward, said that the blind Keeper had judged rightly what a fire owed to its own people and what it owed to no one at all, which was, they said, a harder thing to see plainly than it sounds, and a thing a man with his eyes about him might easily have judged the other way.

Fionnlagh himself, asked once in his old age by a stag's teacher passing through Dùn ìseal why he had ruled the beacon apart from every other fire on the island, gave an answer Calum Beag, by then long grown and still at the old man's side, remembered word for word to the end of his own life: that a man who cannot see a fire learns early to judge it only by what it is for, and that the coal under the mountain, whatever else it was, had never once in all the island's telling been for a stranger.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

OF THE CARRIERS AND THE FIRST BRIDGES

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Firinn nach do bbris i a rinn an drochaid làidir. The truth it never
broke made the bridge strong.
— the masons' saying at the crossing of Ros fhionn

I

Of the Carrier's Trade

Fionnlagh Dall was nine and fifty in the year the Small-Burning Law first bore hard on the households it bound, and Calum Beag, the boy who had led him about the Hall since his own choosing, was grown to a man who no longer needed telling which gallery he stood before, though he still told him anyway, out of a habit neither of them had ever troubled to break. The law that had hardened at Samhain three years before had made the Hall, for the first time in the mountain's memory, a giver-out rather than merely a keeper: a household came to the threshold of Talla na Lasrach¹ with its claim, and the stone cup filled and emptied, and what the cup gave out had then to travel, on somebody's back, to every hearth of every share that had sworn to take no more than its measure and not a handful over it.

It had travelled, before that year, along whatever track a foot had worn first and every foot after had worn a little deeper, up over the mountain's shoulder and down through country that had never once been asked to bear a laden basket

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every week of every year, in whatever weather a year chose to send. A carrier's trade had grown up around the coal the way a trade grows up around any need that will not go away of its own accord, households of no land and little standing who carried for hire or for their own dues both, their baskets marked by hearth so that a household's own measure could be told from its neighbour's on the road, and it was a hard trade and a thankless one, praised by no one when the basket arrived whole and cursed roundly when it did not, and it was the carriers, more than any lord or Keeper, who came first to know exactly which miles of the island's paths a winter's rain could not be trusted to leave standing.

The southern households, whose dried fish came up the same tracks the coal went down by, felt the want of a proper road before any other share did, since the last mile above the harbour of Ceann chaol dropped so steep between two shoulders of bare rock that a carrier with a full basket went down it sideways, one shoulder to the stone, or did not go down it at all in wet weather, and more than one had gone down it faster than his own feet meant to and come up afterward with an ankle that never again carried a load the same way.

II

Of Ailean Clachair and the Steps to Ceann chaol

Ailean Clachair was four and twenty that year, a cutter of the fourth hearth who had spent the better part of his growing years with a chisel in his hand rather than a basket on his back, the same boy, grown now to a man, who had gone up into the hills above Dùn ìseal eleven years before to help a child named Calum Beag carry down the grey stone the blind Keeper had wanted for his cup. He had cut stair-steps into a hillside before, for a byre that needed them and a well that needed them worse, and when the council at Dùn ìseal asked, in the hundred and forty-ninth year, whether anyone among the nine hearths' cutters would take on the steep mile above Ceann chaol, it was Ailean who stood forward first, more from a young man's wanting of a task worth his hands than from any thought of what the task would grow into.

He worked at it through the better part of two years with six others of the fourth hearth, cutting the steps where the rock allowed a step to be cut and setting fitted stone where it did not, a foot's width at a time down a fall that had killed no one outright but had turned more ankles than the Hall's own roll

troubled to count. That work taught him what stone would hold a man's step wet and what stone would not, a different knowledge from the knowledge of a well-shaft or a byre wall, and a knowledge, though he did not know it yet, that the whole of the rest of his life would be built upon. The path was finished in the hundred and fifty-first year, steps enough that a carrier with a full basket could go down to Ceann chaol on a wet morning without once setting a hand to the rock, and the Hall's baskets went down it after that, and the dried fish of the south came up it, faster and drier than either had ever gone before.

III

Of the Rising of the Abhainn dhomhain

It was the Abhainn dhomhain that took what the steps to Ceann chaol had spared, in the hundred and fifty-fourth year, on a night in the last days of an t-Samhain when a rain that had fallen steadily for three days turned, sometime past midnight, into a rain that fell as though the sky itself had broken open. The river ran deep in ordinary weather, deep enough that its name had never asked for any better reason, but it ran fordable at the one crossing the carriers' road used, a wide gravel shallow where a man could cross with a basket on his back and the water no higher than his knees on any day the Hall's own memory reached back to.

Eleven carriers crossed it that night, a party bound south with the Hall's baskets for the households beyond the ford, walking by the last light because the rain had already cost them half the day and a household waiting on its handful in a bad season was not a household a carrier liked to keep waiting past its need. They had crossed that ford a hundred times between them, in every season the mountain sent, and it is told that the leader of the party, a woman of many years on the road named Beathag nan Cliabh for the baskets she had carried since she was a girl, said only that the water looked no worse than a spring flood she remembered from her own youth, and led them into it on that word.

The river that had stood knee-deep at dusk stood chest-deep and rising by the time the last of them was halfway across, the current carrying down branches and, before long, whole trees torn out by their roots somewhere upstream in the dark, striking a man's legs from under him before he ever felt the water grow too strong to stand in. It stood over a tall man's head, by the account of the one carrier who

turned back at the water's edge rather than follow the rest in, before the party on the far bank could so much as call a warning across it, the sound of the river by then too loud for any voice to carry over. Eleven were lost that night, baskets and all, and the one who had turned back, a young man new enough to the trade that his own fear had not yet learned shame, walked the two hours to the nearest hearth in the dark and the rain to say so, arriving with nothing in his own hands but the knowledge of what he had watched happen and had not been able to stop, and it is told that he did not carry the Hall's coal again for the better part of a year afterward, though no one at the Hall ever once asked it of him.

IV

Of the Names of the Drowned

The bodies came down with the flood over the days that followed, most of them within a few miles of the ford, two of them not at all, taken out to the sea by a river running harder than any living carrier had seen it run before or would see it run again for the better part of a century. The Hall kept on its cords a tally of names it had never before had cause to keep in quite that shape, eleven names knotted together under one night, and it is told that Fionnlagh Dall asked to have each name said to him twice before he would let the tally be tied off, so that he might be certain he had heard each one and not merely the sound of a list.

Beathag nan Cliabh, who had led the party in on her own word that the water looked no worse than a flood she remembered from her girlhood, went into it near the last, having stood in the current a long while calling the others on before her own footing gave way beneath her; the households of the road kept her name afterward the way a trade keeps the name of one who is blamed by no one and forgiven by everyone, since a leader's word, honestly given from a life's worth of crossing, could fail a party as surely as a coward's could, and had failed no one before that night. Griogair mac Ailig went into the water early, by the turned-back carrier's account, having gone ahead to test the ford's depth as the party's habit was on a rising night, and Sìneag nighean Dhonnchaidh went in trying to reach a hand to him rather than let go of her own basket's strap, which the households afterward held against her not at all, though some said privately that a strap was a poor thing to die holding. A boy not yet come to his full growth, whose name the

Hall's tally gives only as young Tormod of the salt shore, had asked to go on the crossing that night in place of an uncle whose knee had gone bad in the wet, and it was that uncle, whole and dry on the near bank, who lived after to tell what his own knee had cost.

It is told, and told still by the households of that stretch of road, that the carriers who came after made a joke of their own grief within the season, saying that the Hall mourned its coal along with its dead, since eleven baskets of the mountain's own coal had gone into the sea with the eleven who carried them, and that a joke told against oneself in that manner was the only kind of grief a carrier's trade had ever found room for. Fionnlagh, hearing the joke repeated to him by Calum Beag, did not rebuke it. He said only that a mountain that measured its coal so carefully against a household's need might, in fairness, be allowed to grieve a basketful lost the same way its people grieved a life, and that he saw no unkindness in a carrier who let both griefs sit in the one sentence, since both, that night, had gone into the water together.

V

Of Fionnlagh's Asking

Fionnlagh brought the matter to the council himself within the fortnight, led to the Hall's own ground by Calum Beag as he was led everywhere, and asked the assembled lords and hearth-elders a question none of them, by the plain evidence of the silence that met it, had thought to ask in all the years the ford had served them. He asked for a crossing the river could not take, whatever weather might come against it, so that no household waiting on its handful should ever again cost a carrier's life for the waiting.

The lords who spoke first spoke of cost and of years, a ford having served well enough for longer than any of them had lived, and one of the elders of the southern hearths, a stout old man named Neacal who had buried two carriers of his own household to lesser fords in his own lifetime, said plainly that a river which rose once in a generation to kill eleven people was, taken across the whole of that generation, no worse a risk than a hill-track in winter or a boat on the western sea, and that the Hall could not build itself proof against every misfortune the mountain's own weather might send it. "You would have us throw stone at every ford on the island," he said, "against a flood that comes once in a man's life, and leave

the coal the poorer for the labour spent on it." Fionnlagh heard him out, as he heard out every argument brought against him, sitting with his own hands folded in his lap the whole of the old man's speaking, and answered only that his question was whether the risk could be made smaller. "A cup that measures fair by the fill of two hands," he said, "asks no household to trust its fortune to luck. I see little reason a carrier's life should trust to luck what stone and labour might answer for instead." It is told that he asked, last of all, whether any man in the hall could name him a mason who had already proved his hand against water and weight, and that more than one voice answered him with the same name, which was Ailean Clachair's, the cutter of the fourth hearth whose steps above Ceann chaol a wet winter had not yet found a way to break.

VI

Of the Forty of the Nine Hearths

A ilean was sent for the same week, and stood before the council a man of nine and twenty with stone-dust still under his nails from a well he had left half finished at another household's asking, and heard the Keeper's charge laid on him in fewer words than the council's own arguing about it had taken: a single crossing above Ros fhionn, where the Abhainn dhomhain ran narrower and its banks stood higher and firmer than anywhere else along its whole reach, built to stand against any flood the river might ever again choose to send it. He answered, by his own later telling of it, that he did not yet know whether such a thing could be built at all, a span of stone thrown clear across water that wide having been done nowhere on the island that any living mason could name him, but that he would rather try it and fail than tell a Keeper who had just buried eleven carriers that it could not be tried.

He went to Fionnlagh once more before the calling began, alone, without Calum Beag to hear it, and asked the Keeper plainly whether he understood that the thing might fail, that a mason of nine and twenty with nothing behind him but a stair of steps and a boyhood spent carrying a blind man's cup-stone might throw a season's labour and the Hall's own coal-dues into a river and have nothing to show for it but a heap of cut stone on either bank. Fionnlagh's answer, which Calum Beag had from Ailean's own mouth many years after and kept it word for word the rest of his life, was that he had asked no mason living for a cer-

tainty, having buried eleven carriers already on the strength of a ford everyone had called certain, and that he would rather trust a young man's honest doubt than an old man's easy promise, since a promise too easily given was, in his experience, the surest sign of a thing not properly thought through. Ailean carried that answer with him through the whole of the building that followed, and told the forty, more than once when the work went hard, that a Keeper who could not see the bridge at all had trusted it further than any of them yet trusted their own hands.

He drew from the nine hearths, over the winter that followed, every cutter and mason he judged worth the calling, forty in the end, men and women who had cut wells and byres and boundary-stones and the steps above Ceann chaol and had never, any of them, cut anything that had to hold a whole river rather than a roof. They quarried through the worst of the cold at a face of grey stone not far from Ros fhionn, close enough grained, Ailean judged, to bear the load without splitting, and spent the better part of a season only in learning how a stone cut to a wedge's shape would lean upon its neighbours and hold up its own weight by leaning, a thing none of the forty had understood in their bones before that winter taught it to them by the plain evidence of stones that fell when cut wrong and stones that stood when cut right.

VII

Of the Single Span above Ros fhionn

The span went up through the spring and summer of the hundred and sixtieth year, one course of fitted stone above another, each stone cut and set and tested by hand before the next was laid, Ailean himself walking the scaffold at every hour of daylight and, by Calum Beag's telling of what he heard from the masons afterward, at a good many hours of dark besides, unwilling to trust any course to the morning that he had not first trusted to his own eye by lamplight the night before. The forty worked from both banks toward the river's middle, on wooden centring that carried the weight of each course until the arch could carry it itself, and it was on that centring, in the sixth week of the building, that a mason of the ninth hearth named Aonghas Beag put a foot wrong on a wet timber and went down toward the water with a half-cut stone still in his arms, caught at the very edge of the fall by two others who had his belt in their hands before his own mind had understood what his feet had already done. Ailean

would not let the man back onto the scaffold that day nor the next. He told the forty plainly that he trusted Aonghas Beag as much as any of them; a mason frightened in his own body simply cut stone worse than a mason who had learned to steady his fright first, and a bridge meant to answer for other men's lives asked steadied hands before it asked anything else.

The arch closed at last on a morning in the height of summer when the key-stone, the single wedge of stone that would hold every other stone in its place by the same leaning weight that held them all, was raised on ropes and levers by every hand the forty could spare and set into the gap the rest of the arch had left for it. Ailean himself guided it the last hand's-width into its place, kneeling astride the gap with the river running loud beneath him, and it is told that the whole forty stood silent on both banks while the ropes came free, since a keystone wrongly seated could bring the two half-arches down together before anyone standing near enough to help could do more than watch it happen.

It held. The scaffold came down within the week, board by board, until the arch stood alone over the water on nothing but its own weight and its own shape, a single span of fitted stone thrown clean across the Abhainn dhomhain where eleven carriers had gone into it four years before, and it is told that Ailean, standing beneath it on the gravel bank where the ford had been, wept without shame in front of the whole forty, having not, by his own account, believed with his whole heart until that morning that the thing would truly stand.

VIII

Of the Hearth-Sign in the Keystone

Before the scaffold came down Ailean climbed back up to the keystone and cut into its face, with his own hand and no other's, a small mark that the fourth hearth had used among its own cutters for as long as any of them could remember, a sign no household outside the trade would have known to read but every mason of the nine hearths knew at a glance, meant to say, to any eye that troubled to look for it, that the stone above it had been raised by hands that answered for their own work. He had not been asked to cut it there, and told the forty afterward, when some asked why, that a bridge a man's own name might be forgotten from within a generation ought at least to carry some mark that said a living hand, and not chance, had set it standing.

The mark caught on faster than the bridge did, in the way of things a trade takes up before the wider Hall has quite noticed it happening. Every span the forty raised after Ros fhionn's carried the same sign cut somewhere into its key-stone or its central course, and within a handful of years it was said, first among carriers and then more widely, that a crossing without the mark was a crossing built by hands that had not troubled to answer for their own work. That was an unfair thing to say of many an honest builder who had simply never learned the fourth hearth's sign, and it was said all the same, often enough that it became, before Ailean himself was an old man, very nearly as good as a law.

I X

Of the Oath Sworn on the Stone Cup

It was in the winter following the bridge's raising that the forty, gathered at Dùn ìseal to be paid what the council had promised them for the season's labour, asked Fionnlagh whether they might swear something of their own before the Hall, a fellowship bound together the way the nine hearths were bound, so that a mason called to one crossing might trust a mason called to another to hold the same measure. Fionnlagh heard the asking with what Calum Beag remembered as a plain pleasure, and set the matter before them at the threshold of Talla na Lasrach¹, on the same worn stone where the cup that measured the coal sat open to any eye that cared to look.

They swore two things that day, each of the forty laying a hand on the stone cup in turn as the lords of the shares had laid their hands on it three years before, Aonghas Beag among them, his own hand steady on the stone though Calum Beag said afterward it had shaken through the whole of the walk to the threshold: that no span they raised would ever be closed to a traveller in the dark, a bridge shut against the night being, in a mason's own reckoning, no better than a bridge that had never been built at all; and that no span would ever be paid for in coal, since a crossing built to spare carriers' lives ought not be bought with the very coal those carriers' lives were spared to carry. Fionnlagh, who could not see a single hand laid on the stone that day any more than he had seen the lords' hands laid on it before, said to the forty what he had said to the council then, that he trusted the

1. the Hall of the Flame

cup to hold them to an oath better than any spoken word would, and it is told that Ailean answered him, half in earnest and half in the plain wit of a young man still giddy with his own bridge standing, that a mason trusted stone before he trusted anything else living or dead, his own self not excepted, and saw no reason a Keeper should not do the same.

X

Of the Lodge at the Western Ford

The forty did not scatter, once Ros fhionn's crossing was finished and paid for, the way a gathering of cutters called for one task commonly did, but kept themselves together under Ailean's leading and took on, over the two years that followed, three crossings more where the carriers' roads asked for them, the last and widest of the three above a ford in the country of Ros dhomhain that the western share's own herds had used, badly, for longer than any living herder's memory reached. They raised there, once the western span was finished, a plain stone lodge of their own beside the crossing, a hall no grander than any nine-hearth's own gathering-house, where a mason called from any share could find a roof and a fire and a fellow of the trade to hear what stone he had cut that season and how it had answered him.

It was at the western crossing, in the hundred and sixty-third year, not at Ros fhionn's own span, that the fourth hearth's mark was tested for the first time against a bridge that did not carry it. A wright of Ros dhomhain, impatient of the mason's slow season and the mason's higher wage, had thrown a lighter crossing of his own a half day's walk upriver, unmarked, over a narrower reach that his own eye judged safe enough for a laden carrier, and a carrier of the Hall's baskets, coming to it after dark on a night the western span lay a weary two hours further on, stood at its near end a long while by his fellow's account and would not cross it, saying only that he had sworn no oath himself, that he knew well enough whose oath a bridge without the sign had not been built under, and that he would rather sleep cold on the near bank than trust his basket, and his own neck besides, to a crossing no mason living would answer for. He slept cold that night, and carried word of it to Dùn ìseal within the week, and it is told that Fionnlagh, hearing it, asked Calum Beag to set the carrier's name on the same roll that had

once held the names of the eleven drowned, this time among the living the fourth hearth's mark and the oath sworn upon the stone cup had kept that way.

The Hall had been, in the years before the Small-Burning Law, a keeper only, a thing a household went up to and came down from, its business finished at the threshold where the cup filled and emptied. It was a giver-out now, and a giver-out, Fionnlagh had come to understand before that ninth year was out, owed its people more than a fair measure at the door; it owed them a road the measure could travel by without asking a life for every basket lost to bad weather or bad stone. The forty of the nine hearths went on cutting spans across the shares for a long while after Ros fhionn's, under Ailean's leading and, when he was old, under the leading of masons he himself had taught the trade to, and it was said of every one of their crossings, long after the flood on the Abhainn dhomhain had passed out of any living carrier's own memory into the Hall's roll alone, that a bridge with the fourth hearth's mark in its keystone was a bridge a man might cross in the dark without once wondering whether the stone beneath his feet had been asked to answer for its own standing.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

OF MÒR NIC DHÙGHAILL'S HOUSE AND THE BLIND KEEPER'S LAST ROAD

FE 164 – 189

Cha tarraing lann fo mo mbullach. No blade is drawn under my
roof.

— the carriers' word for the road-peace, kept first at the house of
Mòr nic Dhùghaill of Doire shean

I

Of the House at Doire shean

It is told at the long table still, by carriers who never knew her and never will, that Mòr nic Dhùghaill kept the first house on the mountain road for no better reason than that her husband had died leaving her a widow's third of a poor herd of buffalo and a worse third of a stony croft above Doire shean¹, and that a woman with more beasts than grass to feed them on had to find some use for the meat before the winter found it for her. The carriers' road had not long been cut then, the stepped path down to Ceann chaol still raw where the masons' picks had bitten it, and the baskets going west to the harbour households and the dried fish coming back passed within a stone's throw of her own door twice in every week the weather allowed it, which in the mountain's early seasons was not every week.

1. the mountainside croft and village where Mòr nic Dhùghaill was born and kept her house

She began, the telling goes, by boiling a haunch for her own table on a night three carriers stopped to ask shelter from a rain that had turned the stepped path to a chute of mud, and by finding, the next morning, that word of a widow who fed a wet man hot meat and asked no payment for it travelled the road faster than any basket on it. Within the year she had built a second room onto the croft with her own hands and a neighbour's, and within two she had given up the herd's wool trade entirely and kept buffalo for the pot alone, juggled slow over a low fire the whole night through the way her mother had taught her against a lean season, until the smell of it, carriers said afterward, could be caught a quarter-mile off on a still evening and would turn a tired man's feet toward her door before his own head had properly decided to. The Hall at Dùn ìseal, which had built the road for its baskets and thought little else about it, gained thereby a waypoint it had not asked for and would not, in all the years after, have known how to do without; and it is because of that house, raised for no purpose grander than a widow's grass and a widow's grief, that every circuit-house on the island since has kept a name rather than a number, the way the Hall's own galleries never did.

Mòr herself, by the account carriers older than these ones gave of her, was a broad, plain-spoken woman of thirty-four when the first three men came in out of the rain, grey-eyed like half the households of that mountainside, with a laugh that came easily and a temper that came more easily still to any man who thought a widow's table was owed him for nothing. She fed every traveller the road sent her the same portion in the same pot regardless of what share he carried a token from, a lord's man and a smith's boy and a beggar off the coast road eating from the one ladle in the order they arrived rather than the order their blood might have claimed, and when a steward of the Red Share once objected, early on, to eating below a fisherman who had come to the door first, she told him, in words the carriers still repeat nearly word for word, that the pot did not know one man's blood from another's and neither, under her roof, would she trouble herself to. He ate below the fisherman, and came back the following season, and ate below whoever the road had sent ahead of him that time too.

II

Of the Second House at the Meeting of the Roads

The road grew faster than any one widow's pot could feed it, and within a handful of years a second house stood where the carriers' way down from the mountain met the road running west to the harbours, raised by three families of the fourth hearth together, who had watched what a fed and rested carrier was worth to a basket's safe delivery and judged, rightly enough, that a second such house a day's walk from the first would lose them nothing and gain the road a great deal. They built it long and low of turf and timber both, a hearth burning at either end of the one room rather than the single hearth Mòr kept, so that carriers coming down off the mountain with the day's cold still in their bones might sit at one fire while carriers going up, dry and rested and dreading the climb ahead of them, sat at the other, the two fires never quite meeting in the middle of the room though the same roof covered both and the same door let a man choose which end he wanted before he had so much as shrugged off his pack.

It became the custom of that second house, within its own first year, that a man might cross from the down-fire to the up-fire and back as many times as he liked in an evening, trading news of the road behind him for news of the road ahead, and carriers who had never once spoken a word to each other on the mountain path, being strangers of different hearths with baskets to mind and no leisure for talk, found themselves, over a bowl at that long central table, telling each other things they had not troubled to tell their own households: where a ford had shifted since the spring flood, which of the lodgings kept a dog that bit and which kept one that only barked, whose basket had been light at the last weighing and whose scale a wise man watched. It was at that table, more than at any council held under the Hall's own roof, that the road first began to feel like one thing rather than a scatter of separate paths each household walked alone, and it is at that same table, the carriers say, laying a hand flat on the wood as they say it, that the custom which came to be sworn a law was first kept without anyone troubling to call it one.

III

Of the Chase Stopped at the Door

The custom found its first true test in the hundred and seventy-fifth year, when a man of the eastern shares came pounding down the mountain road at a run in the last light of an autumn evening with three of his cousin's

household not far behind him and a grievance between the two houses old enough that neither side troubled any longer to say aloud what had started it, only that a knife had been drawn somewhere upriver that morning and a man's arm opened to the bone, and that the arm's owner's kin meant to have the opening answered before the sun rose on a second day.

He came in at Mòr's own door, the telling has it, white to the lips and past speech for the first several breaths, and threw himself down on the bench nearest the fire with no more ceremony than a stranger begging shelter from rain, and Mòr, who by then had fed carriers and lords' men and beggars alike under that roof for near ten years and had learned to read a hunted man's face the way another woman read weather, did not ask him his business before she set a bowl in front of him, only told him, once the bowl was down, to eat it while it was hot, since a man eats slower with food in his mouth than with none, and a slower man was easier to talk sense to. His cousin's three came in not a quarter-hour behind him, knives still at their belts and their own faces set for whatever the door might hold, and found the man they had chased sitting at Mòr's own table with a bowl of her juggled buffalo half gone in front of him and Mòr herself standing between the table and the door with her arms folded and her feet planted as if she had grown there.

What passed between them the carriers tell several ways, and none of the ways quite agree on her exact words, but every telling keeps the shape of it the same: that she told the three men plainly there would be no blade drawn under her roof for any grievance whatever, old or new, hers or another's, because a house that fed every traveller from the one pot regardless of his blood could not, in the same breath, let one traveller's blood be spilled across the same floor, and that whatever the two houses owed each other could wait until both sides of it had walked back out through her door and off her own ground, at which point it was no longer any affair of hers what they did to each other on the open road. The three stood a long moment weighing a widow's word against a debt of honour older than most of them could properly account for, and then, the telling says, the eldest of the three sat down at the table's far end, a careful distance from the man he had chased, close enough to watch him and far enough to say nothing by it, and asked Mòr, in a voice gone suddenly and plainly tired, whether there was more of the pot for three hungry men who had run the best part of five miles for nothing they could now collect on. She served them, and the four of them ate in a silence that held the whole length of the meal, and when it was done the hunted man rose

first and walked out into the dark without a word to any of them, and the three cousins gave him a full quarter-hour's start, by Mòr's own later telling of it, before they rose themselves and went out after him into the same dark, and what happened on the road that night beyond her door the house never learned, and did not, the tellers say, greatly wish to.

IV

Of Niall Òg at the Long Table

Word of the chase stopped at Mòr's door ran the road faster than any basket that season, carried hearth to hearth and house to house the way the smell of her pot had once travelled it, and it reached, before the year was out, the ears of Niall Òg, who by then had outlived so many quarrels of blood that a new one seldom troubled him to cross a valley for, but who came anyway, on foot as he came everywhere, to see for himself the house where a widow's word had held two feuding houses to the one table.

He arrived unannounced on an evening much like the one that had made the house's name, and sat himself at the long table's middle without asking leave of anyone, an old man by the mountain's own reckoning though not so very old by the reckoning of his own kin, who ate what was set before him and said little for the better part of an hour, watching the room fill and empty around him the way a man watches a river he has crossed many times before. When Mòr herself came at last to see who the quiet stranger at her table was, he told her his name plainly, as he told it to whoever asked, and watched her face for the flicker of recognition that came to most faces at the hearing of it, the name of a grandson of Ailean Mòr being one that carried its own weight on any share of the island by then, whatever the man himself had done or not done to earn it.

She gave him no more and no less than she gave any other traveller, the same bowl and the same place at the same table, and it is told that he thanked her for it with more warmth than he had thanked a host in a long while, saying that he had sat at more tables in his life than he cared to number, heirs' tables and lords' tables and the Hall's own table more than once, and that most of them had given him a better seat than his neighbour's for no reason but his blood, which he had come, over the centuries, to find a wearying kind of courtesy rather than an honour. He asked her, before he left the next morning, whether she had ever turned a man

from her door for the house he carried a token from rather than for anything he had done himself, and when she answered that she had not and could not see the sense in starting, he laughed, the carriers say, longer and more freely than the household had ever heard a stranger laugh at that table, and told her that she had managed, without ever once sitting at the gathering-house floor or hearing the cord counted, a trick the whole of Ailean's scattered kin had spent a hundred and seventy years failing at among themselves. He left a ring of silver behind him on the table when he went, worth more than the meal by any measure, and when Mòr sent a boy running after him to give it back, as she gave back every payment offered under that roof, he would not take it, saying only that a man who had outlived every one of his own quarrels could afford, once in a great while, to pay for a peace he had not made himself.

V

Of the Names Kept at the Harbours

In those same years the road's reach carried households far past the mountain's own shoulder, down to two harbours on the western shore of Loch chrom that no one of the nine hearths had settled before, though both had stood, empty and roofless, since some earlier people's time the oldest tellers could not put a name to. Fishers of the nine hearths came first to the nearer of the two, finding a scatter of old house-footings above a good landing and a name for the place already fixed in the mouths of the few herders who grazed the ground nearby, a name not of their own tongue and not, so far as any of them could tell, of any tongue spoken on the island in their fathers' time either. They kept the name rather than giving it one of their own making, on the plain reasoning, passed down since in the carriers' own song of it, that a name found already standing on a place, like a house-footing found already dug, had more right to stay than any new one a stranger could invent to replace it; and Seann Mhorn' it remained, the carriers still singing, on the road between the mountain and the sea, that the stones came with the name and the name came with the stones, and no one who settled there afterward had ever troubled to ask whose.

Families walking the same road a season or two later found the second harbour a short way along the same shore, house-footings there as well and a name of its

own already fixed to it the same way, and settled it in the same spirit, building on the old footings without asking, the song has it, whose hands had first laid them. Seann Warr² they kept it, as their neighbours up the shore had kept Seann Mhorn, and the two harbours grew together in the years after as two ends of one growing town might grow, sharing a landing and a market day and, before long, a single waypoint house of their own where the road from the mountain came down at last to meet the sea, so that a carrier walking the whole circuit from Dùn ìseal to the western shore and back again might sleep, by the century's end, under a roof at every day's remove of the journey and never once lie out in the open unless the weather denied him a door.

VI

Of the Keeper's Last Asking

Fionnlagh Dall kept the flame at Dùn ìseal a full fifty-six years from the day the nine hearths first chose him, longer by a good margin than any Keeper before him, and it was in the hundred and eighty-fourth year, an old man of four-and-ninety with a body that had begun, in its last seasons, to fail him in ways his blindness never had, that he called Calum Beag to his own bedside in the small room off the Hall and told him, in a voice gone thin but not yet unsteady, what he wished done with him when the failing was finished.

He did not ask, he said, to be laid on the slope above Dùn ìseal with the Keepers who had gone before him, Beathag Bhàn and Muireach Liath and Gormshuil nic Mhuirich each in their own turn, though no one in the Hall would have thought it strange had he asked for exactly that. He asked instead to be carried south, to the old graves near Cnoc dhìreach that no household or share on the island had ever claimed for its own, a burying-ground older, by every account the mountain's oldest tellers could give, than any name the island now used for anything upon it. Calum Beag, who had led him by the elbow through the Hall's own galleries for more than fifty years and had grown, in that time, from a boy of ten who followed him out of plain curiosity into a man grey at the temples himself, asked him why, since a Keeper's own ground lay ready and waiting not a

1. a harbour on the western shore of Loch chrom, resettled with its old name kept

2. a harbour beside Seann Mhorn on Loch chrom, resettled with its old name kept

stone's throw from the Hall he had served his whole life. Fionnlagh's answer, which Calum carried afterward the whole rest of his own life and repeated to whoever asked though he never claimed to understand it fully himself, was that a man who had spent fifty-six years judging what belonged to whom, coal to household and household to share and share to the whole island besides, wished at the last to lie somewhere that belonged to no one, in ground that had never once been divided by any cord or counted by any hearth, and that if the Hall's own roll could not say who the old graves at Cnoc dhìreach belonged to, that was, to his own mind, the surest recommendation the ground could carry.

He died within the month, in the small room off the Hall with Calum Beag's hand in his own, and it is told that his last words were not a ruling of any kind, as some at Dùn ìseal had half expected of a man who had spent his whole life giving them, but a plain question to Calum about whether the boy — he called him that still, at the last, though the boy by then had grey in his own beard — had remembered to see the flame fed before he came to sit, since a Keeper's dying, Fionnlagh said, was no excuse for a household to go cold. Calum told him it had been fed, which was true, and Fionnlagh said only that he was glad of it, and closed his eyes, and did not open them again.

VII

Of the Eleven Days' Road

Word of the asking went out from Dùn ìseal before the body was a day cold, and by the time the bearers set out southward with Fionnlagh Dall carried between them on a litter of plain wood, every hearth along the twenty miles between the Hall and Cnoc dhìreach had already heard, and every hearth along that road asked, when the bearers passed, to be allowed to carry him some part of the way themselves, so that what should by any ordinary reckoning have been a journey of three days at most, twenty miles being no great distance for men walking a road they knew, stretched instead to eleven, the litter passing from one household's shoulders to the next at every waypoint house and every crossroads shrine the road offered, each hearth keeping him a night and sending him on in the morning with fresh bearers and, more than once, with the whole household walking some distance alongside out of a wish to have been some small part of the carrying.

Calum Beag walked the whole eleven days at the litter's head, by every account the only man on the journey who never once handed his own share of the bearing to another pair of shoulders, though he was by then a man of six-and-sixty and the road no easier for him than for anyone half his years. He led the way, as he had led Fionnlagh through the Hall's own galleries for more than fifty years before, though there was nothing now for him to lead a blind man's feet around, only the road ahead and the growing weight, the carriers who told it afterward all agreed, of a grief he did not trouble to hide from anyone who cared to see it plainly on his face. At the first waypoint house on the southern road, one of the houses raised after the manner of Mòr nic Dhùghaill's, the whole household turned out at the door as the litter passed, and its keeper pressed a bowl on every bearer in turn whether he had asked for it or not, saying, when Calum tried to refuse his own portion out of some sense that grief should go hungry, that a man could not carry a Keeper's weight on an empty stomach any better than he could carry a basket of coal on one; and word came to them there that Mòr herself, too old now to walk the width of the island, had sent from Doire shean¹ to say the same.

VIII

Of the Grave at Cnoc dhìreach

They came to the old ground on the eleventh day, a scatter of grave-mounds and standing stones so ancient that no household living could say with any certainty which of them marked what or belonged to whom, the whole of it grown over with the same rough grass that covered the hillside around it, undisturbed, the tellers say, since some people's time so far back that even the mountain's own memory did not reach it plainly. Calum Beag chose the spot himself, a low rise near the ground's centre from which, on a clear day, a man could see the smoke of three separate hearths without turning his head, and the bearers dug there, and laid Fionnlagh Dall in ground that had never before, so far as any record the Hall kept could say, held a burial anyone had troubled to mark by name.

The Keepers who came after him, when the question was put to them why he had asked for that ground rather than his own, gave two different answers between them and would not choose which was truer: some said he had wished,

1. the mountainside croft and village where Mòr nic Dhùghaill was born and kept her house

at the last, to belong to something older and larger than any measure he himself had spent his life keeping, and others said he had simply wished, being a man who had judged every household's claim to every handful for fifty-six years, to lie at last somewhere no one could claim at all. Calum Beag, asked the same question more than once in the years that followed, would say only that he had asked Fionnlagh himself and been given an answer that satisfied him, though he never repeated it whole to anyone, holding, he said, to the same silence a Keeper's own eyes owed the galleries, borrowed eyes included.

The ground was hallowed five years afterward by Keepers who travelled down from Dùn Ìseal to do it, the first burial the place had ever received that any living hand had set down by name, and from that hallowing the burying-ground that had belonged to no one at all became, within the year, a ground that belonged, by the Hall's own reckoning, to everyone. A handful of families from the households nearest Cnoc dhìreach settled by it after, to tend the grave and keep the ground from growing wild over it again, and the Hall paid them for the work one measured handful of coal each a season, the only payment the Small-Burning Law was ever known to allow in coal rather than in grain or kind, on the ruling that a service kept for a dead Keeper's own sake was owed the one payment a Keeper himself would have judged fitting.

I X

Of the Stone Calum Beag Laid

Mòr nic Dhùghaill did not live to hear the whole of how the burying finished. She died at her own house above Doire shean¹ in the hundred and eighty-sixth year, two years past sixty and grey as the buffalo she had jugged for near her whole adult life, found by her own daughter one morning sitting upright in the chair by the fire where she had sat every evening of the household's memory, gone as quietly, the telling has it, as she had lived loudly, and the road kept her house running without a single night's fire missed, the daughter and a niece taking up the pot the same week their mother was laid in the ground behind the croft, because a house that had never once in twenty years failed to

1. the mountainside croft and village where Mòr nic Dhùghaill was born and kept her house

feed a traveller was not, the household judged, going to begin failing on the strength of one woman's death, however dearly the road had loved her.

Calum Beag came to the funeral himself, walking the width of the island to Doire shean, two years after he had walked beside Fionnlagh's litter, and it is told that he stood longest of anyone at the grave's edge afterward, an old man himself by then, though he outlived her by a good many years still, and said to no one in particular that the island had lost, within two seasons of each other, the two people he had spent the better part of his own life walking beside, one who had taught him to see with another man's hands and one who had taught him, without ever once meaning to teach it, that a table with no blade drawn under it was as fine a law as any the Hall had ever sworn.

It was in the hundred and eighty-ninth year, some years past the burying, that Calum Beag went back to Cnoc dhìreach a last time, an old man now in truth, to finish a thing he had put off since the day of the burying, uncertain, he told the grave-keepers who met him at the ground, whether his own hand was the right one to do it. He had brought with him, carried the whole way on his own back rather than trusted to any carrier, a plain stone the size of two cupped hands, cut by a mason he had paid for out of his own purse and asked to carve nothing on its face but the shape of the stone cup Fionnlagh had set on the threshold at Dùn ìseal, since no name, Calum judged, could say what that shape already said of the man well enough to be worth the cutting. He knelt at the grave's head a long while, the grave-keepers standing back to give him the ground, and set the stone down with his own two hands, pressing it into the turf until it sat level and would not rock, and then rose, an old man's knees complaining of the kneeling, and stood looking at it a moment before he turned and walked back down the road toward the mountain, leaving the stone to mark, without a single word carved anywhere upon it, what the hands that had once filled a cup by touch alone had judged, by the last measure any of them ever needed, enough.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

OF the UNFORGOTTEN Wedding

FE 190 – 380

Cha do scuir an fhuil ged a scuir an sabaid. The blood did not stop
when the fighting stopped.
— a saying of the road, of the long strife between the king's blood

I

Of an Old Man's Telling

Niall Òg told this tale more often than any other he kept, and told it, by every account the carriers give of him, the same way each time, sitting at whatever hearth would have him with a bowl going cold in his hands and his eyes on the fire rather than on whoever sat across from him, so that a listener new to the man might have thought he spoke to the flame and not to them at all. He was well past a thousand years old before the tale's own ending caught up with him, and older still before he stopped telling it, and those who heard it from him more than once said he never shaved a detail from it nor added one, though the households he told it to grew, across those same centuries, from grandchildren to great-grandchildren who had not known the people in it and would not live to see how it came out.

It was not a tale of a battle, he would say first, by way of warning a listener not to expect one, and it was not much of a tale of a wedding either, whatever its name implied, but a tale of how little a household needs to begin a grudge that will outlive every soul who remembers what it was for. He had watched the whole

of it from somewhere near enough to see faces, being kin himself to both sides of the quarrel and welcome, or near enough welcome, at either table, and it was this, he said, more than his years, that let him carry the story whole from one end to the other where a teller born to only one side of it would have carried only half.

The strife of the heirs was old by the year he set his telling in, older by then than the mountain's own carriers' road, and it had long since stopped being, in any single man's memory, a quarrel about anything a living man could name. It ran instead the way a river runs, from a source no one now living had seen, through banks it had cut for itself over generations, carrying forward whatever fell into it without much caring what that thing had originally been. Men who had begun feuds in their own youth lived, by the strange mercy or curse of the king's blood, to grow old inside them, to see their own grandchildren born into a hatred they themselves had once started for a reason that no longer signified to anyone but them, and some, Niall said, forgot the reason before they forgot the hatred, which he judged the saddest thing a long life could do to a man.

He would say, to any listener young enough to ask why he troubled to tell so long and so joyless a tale at all, that he told it because it was the truest thing he knew of his own people, truer than any account of a war won or a Hall built, and that a man who wished to understand why the island's governors spent so many centuries governing so little beyond their own grudges had first to understand how small a thing a grudge could be at its beginning, and how patiently, given long enough years to work in, it could grow into something neither side any longer knew how to set down. He had buried enough of his own kin by the year he first told it this way to know the shape of the thing from the inside, having lost cousins and great-nephews to quarrels he himself had never once raised a hand in, and he counted himself, more than once in the telling, luckier than most of his blood only in having been born to no share worth fighting over, a grandson twice removed and content to stay so.

Those who carried his sayings on after him, hearth to hearth, kept this tale nearer the front of their own tellings than its length alone would have earned it, on the plain reckoning that a people who forgot how their own quarrels began were in danger of repeating them exactly, and that Niall's own telling, however sad its shape, was meant less as an entertainment than as a warning kept warm at the hearth for whoever next felt a boast rising in him at a wedding table.

II

Of the Wedding at Ros dhomhain

It began, so far as any beginning could be put to a thing so old, at a wedding held in the two hundred and fourteenth year of the age, at Ros dhomhain, in the western share that had come down by then, three generations removed, from Fionnghal nic Ailein, the king's own daughter, who had held it quietly from her own hall until that very year. The couple being married that day were of no great account in the quarrel to come, a daughter of one of Fionnghal's household stewards and a young mason of the fourth hearth, and it is one of the tale's own small cruelties, Niall would say, that neither of their names is now much remembered, though the day itself is remembered by everyone.

Among the guests, as was the custom at any wedding held on a share's own ground, sat a scattering of the wider kin: cousins of the bride's mistress, cousins of cousins, and among them a great-grandson of Fionnghal's own line named Griogair mac Lachlainn, a man of some five-and-forty years, quick-tempered by every account and quicker still with drink in him, who had come from the western share's own hall to stand for his kinswoman at her wedding. Across the same table, sent as guest by a marriage two generations back that had tied a thread of Baile ghorm's salt-shore blood into the mason's own family, sat Tormod mac Ruairidh, a great-grandson of Artair mac Ailein and near the same age as Griogair, a man no less proud of his own descent and no more patient with drink than his counterpart.

The two had never met before that day, and might, by every reasonable turn of chance, never have troubled to meet again, had the ale not run generous and the talk not turned, as talk at such tables will, to whose blood carried further in the island's reckoning. The hall at Ros dhomhain was hung that evening with rowan and late heather, the mason's own kin having brought down whatever the hillside above the town still offered so far into the season, and the long table had been set with three separate jugs of the western share's own brew, strong enough that a guest who drank steadily through the toasts might find, by the fourth or fifth, that his tongue moved somewhat ahead of his judgement. Niall himself sat near the door with a cousin of the bride's, an old habit of his at any gathering he had not been asked to lead, and watched, without much alarm at first, the talk at the middle of the table climb from the mason's own trade to the standing of the two families who had lent the wedding its wider guests.

Griogair said something of the western share's age and standing that Niall, questioned closely on it across the whole rest of his own life, would only repeat as "a boast no worse than any man makes drunk at a wedding": that Ros dhomhain had held its ground unbroken since the king's own daughter first claimed it, while other shares, he said, had passed through more hands than a common toll-stick. Tormod answered it with something sharper, a word about the salt shore's own dignity set against the west's, that carried, by the account of three separate guests who told it afterward and agreed on this much if nothing else, a plain slight against Fionnghal's own memory, dead scarcely a season by then, and the manner of her death, which he named, in front of her own great-grandson and half her own household, an old woman's slow going rather than the peaceful end the family itself preferred to speak of. Griogair struck him across the table with the flat of his own drinking-horn before a third word could be spoken, the horn's rim catching Tormod high on the cheekbone and drawing a line of blood that both families would remember, in later tellings, at very different lengths, and the wedding that had begun in a house garlanded for a mason's daughter ended with two great-grandsons of the king's own children dragged apart by six men apiece and sent home to their separate shares nursing separate grievances that neither, in the whole of his own life afterward, would consent to set down. The mason and his bride, by every account Niall gathered afterward, danced out the rest of their own wedding with as much cheer as they could summon, and are remembered, where they are remembered at all, only as the two people whose feast it had briefly, uselessly, been.

III

Of How a Small Thing Grows

It would have ended there, Niall always insisted, any ordinary quarrel between two ordinary men ending, as such things do, in a season's coldness and a slow forgetting, had the two men in question been of no particular blood. But Griogair and Tormod were each, in his own share, a man whose word carried weight beyond his own person, and each carried the insult home as an insult offered to the whole of his line through him, and never once, in all the years after, as a private hurt he alone might have chosen to forgive, so that within the year the western share and the salt shore, which had traded fish for grain across that same

stretch of coast for three generations without a cross word between them, found their carriers refused lodging at each other's waypoint houses and their tolls counted twice as carefully at each other's borders.

A raid followed within two years, a small thing as such things are first counted, a dozen head of cattle lifted from a salt-shore pasture by men who called it no more than payment owed for an insulted household, and answered within the season by a barn burned on the western share's own ground, and by the fifth year of the quarrel neither side could any longer say with certainty who had struck first, only that the other side had certainly struck since, and struck badly, and owed for it. Niall Òg, who had watched the wedding itself from a bench near the door and thought little of it at the time beyond the ordinary regret any man feels at a spoiled feast, told listeners across the centuries that he marked the moment the quarrel changed from a grudge between two drunk cousins into a strife between two households as the exact moment he understood, better than any lesson the Hall's own reciters had ever given him, how the whole vast tangle of the king's blood had come to hate its own kin so thoroughly for so long. A hundred small wrongs, each answered a little harder than it was given, had done the work no single great wrong could have managed alone, until the answering became the whole of what either side remembered wanting, and the wedding itself, the mason and his bride and the ale and the garlands, was forgotten by everyone but the two men it had made enemies.

IV

Of Eimhir nic Mhuirich and the Flame

The Hall at Dùn iséal kept its own business through these same years largely apart from the quarrels of the king's blood beyond it, as the Binding had always meant it to, though the Keeper who held the flame through the middle of this strife, a woman named Eimhir nic Mhuirich, of the hearth-line rather than the king's own, watched the widening feuds with a plainer eye than any heir could manage for want of a stake in either side of them. She was chosen by the nine hearths in the two hundred and thirty-sixth year, a woman then of six-and-twenty and thought young for the choosing, and she kept the flame four-and-fifty years after, longer than any Keeper since Fionnlagh Dall and calmer, the tellings say, than most before him.

Eimhir's own rule of the Hall, which she was heard to repeat to every heir who came to the threshold to plead one side of the quarrel or the other, was that the stone cup filled and emptied by measure and by nothing else, and that a household's dues were owed to whichever lord's stewards came first to the door in the season they fell due, whatever quarrel that lord's blood carried against his neighbour's. She would not judge between Sliochd Fhionnghail¹ and Sliochd Artair², as the two lines had come by then to call themselves, nor take either's account of who had wronged whom first, and it is told that when Tormod mac Ruairidh himself came to Dùn ìseal some years into her keeping of the flame to ask the Hall's blessing on a raid he meant to call justice rather than vengeance, she heard him out in full, sitting the whole while on the low stool the Keepers kept beside the stone cup, and asked him, when he had finished, whether the salt shore's own measure had gone short that season. He said it had not. She told him then only that the Hall blessed no man's raids, being in the business of coal and not of grudges, and that he was welcome to as much of the one as his household's measure allowed and none of the other whatever his measure, and when he pressed her a second time, naming his great-grandfather's blood as a claim on her sympathy if not her blessing, she answered that the flame she kept had been lit before Artair mac Ailein was born and would, with any luck the Hall was owed, still be burning after every quarrel his blood had raised was as forgotten as the ash of it, which she judged a truer measure of what mattered than any grudge he cared to bring her.

He left without the blessing he had come for, and it is told, though not by Tormod's own household, that he raided anyway within the season and lost two men doing it, and never again troubled the Hall to bless what he had already decided to do without it. Eimhir died in the two hundred and ninetieth year of the age, some eighty years old, having kept the flame steadier through the widening quarrel than the quarrel's own principals kept their tempers, and the nine hearths chose after her a younger Keeper who would hold much the same course, the Hall's own indifference to the king's blood's private wars having become, by then, as settled a custom as the measure itself.

1. the descendants of Fionnghal nic Ailein, holding the western share at Ros dhomhain

2. the descendants of Artair mac Ailein, holding the share of the salt shore at Baile ghorm

V

Of the Deaths of the King's Children

The old children of Ailean Mòr, who had held their shares since before the strife had any name at all, went one after another into the ground during these same decades, each death loosed a little more of the discipline their long presence had kept over their own descendants, whatever quarrels those descendants ran beneath them. Fionnghal nic Ailein, who had held the western share since the earliest days of the age and had watched the wedding quarrel begin from her own hall without living to see where it led, died in the two hundred and thirteenth year at some two thousand eight hundred years of age, the mountain's own reckoning agreeing that no soul born of the grove before or since had held so western and quiet a share so long or so lightly. Her own funeral, held at Ros dhomhain within the same season as the wedding, was the last occasion on which Sliochd Fhionnghail¹ and Sliochd Artair² stood under one roof without a blow struck between them, and even that peace, Niall said, was kept only because Griogair mac Lachlainn had the sense, sober at his own great-grandmother's grave, to send word to Tormod's household that no man of the salt shore would be turned from the door that day whatever lay between them, a courtesy neither line troubled to repeat afterward.

Artair mac Ailein, whose salt-shore blood ran now through Tormod's own veins, died in the two hundred and ninety-eighth year at two thousand six hundred years old, at his own hall above Baile ghorm, the tellings agreeing only that his last years were harder than his first, the widening feud a weight he had not asked to carry into his own old age and could not, by then, set down. Cormac mac Ailein, whose eastern share at Caol shean had taken no direct part in the quarrel between west and salt shore but felt its cold in every market that dealt with both, died in the three hundred and thirty-first year at some two thousand four hundred and fifty years, the last of the king's sons to hold a share, and it is told that his final word to his own household was a plain wish that they keep clear of a quarrel that was, by his own long reckoning, no business of theirs, a wish his descendants honoured for rather less than a generation.

"A death among the king's own blood," Niall would say at this point in the telling, looking up from the fire the one time in the whole tale that he looked up

1. the descendants of Fionnghal nic Ailein, holding the western share at Ros dhomhain

2. the descendants of Artair mac Ailein, holding the share of the salt shore at Baile ghorm

at all, "is a thousand years of patience lost all at once, and a household that has just buried two thousand years of it does not, in my long experience, grow more patient for the burying." He had watched three such funerals within his own span by the time he told the tale this way, and would watch a good many more before his own turn came, and he counted each one, he said, a small defeat for whatever peace the island might otherwise have kept.

VI

Of Niall's Peace at the Long Table

In the three hundred and fifty-second year, wearied at last of watching a quarrel he had first seen begin over spilled ale at a stranger's wedding grow, across well over a century, into raids that now cost real lives on both sides, Niall Òg did what he had done once before at Mòr nic Dhùghaill's own table and tried, on a larger and more deliberate stage, to bring the two lines to a peace. He sent word to the heads of both Sliochd Fhionnghail¹ and Sliochd Artair², by then men two generations removed from Griogair and Tormod themselves, that he would host a meeting on ground that belonged to neither, a long table set up in the open beside the carriers' road at the crossing near Ros fhionn, and that he asked only that both sides come unarmed and hear each other out before the day was through.

Both sides came, which Niall counted afterward the meeting's one true success, though it proved the only one. He had chosen the crossing near Ros fhionn deliberately, remembering the bridge Ailean Clachair's masons had thrown there near two centuries before with a hearth-sign cut into the keystone for luck, and thought a place built to be crossed by everyone might carry something of its own purpose into the men who sat beside it. He set two benches facing each other across a single board laid on trestles, no lord's own hall to lend one side or the other the comfort of its own hearth, and had a single pot of plain stew set between them, enough for both tables and belonging, by his own design, to neither.

The head of the western line, a great-great-grandson of Griogair's named for a grandfather Niall had known and buried, spoke first and at length of every wrong the salt shore had done his household across fourteen decades: cattle lifted, a barn

1. the descendants of Fionnghal nic Ailein, holding the western share at Ros dhomhain

2. the descendants of Artair mac Ailein, holding the share of the salt shore at Baile ghorm

burned, a cousin's arm broken at a market and never answered for. "You count your dead," he said, when he had finished, looking across the board rather than at Niall, "and I will count mine, and we will see whose column runs the longer, and that will settle it as well as anything else has." The head of the salt-shore line answered with an accounting no shorter and no less bitter, matching burning for burning and broken arm for broken arm down a list he seemed, from the ease of his own telling, to have carried ready in his head for years against exactly this occasion, and finished it by saying that he had not come to apologise for what his own blood had done in answer to what the west had done first, and would not, whatever an old man's long memory of a widow's table led him to hope.

By the time both accountings were finished the sun had gone down and the pot of stew sat cold and largely untouched between them, neither man having troubled to eat from it, and neither had once, in all that speaking, offered the other anything that could fairly be called an apology, only a longer and more particular list of grievances than either had troubled to draw up before. Niall, who had hoped the mere act of speaking plainly to one another might loosen something the years had knotted, told the two men before they parted that he had sat at this same trick of a long table once already in his own life and watched it work between a widow's guests who owed each other nothing, and that he did not understand, and did not expect ever to understand, why it failed so completely between men who shared the very blood he shared himself. "Because," the salt-shore man told him, rising, "your widow's guests had a debt between them that ended at her door. Ours has no door it ends at." Neither man answered Niall again after that. They rose from the table at the same moment, an agreement neither side would ever plainly own to, and walked back to their own shares by the same road they had come by, leaving the cold stew for whoever wanted it, and the raids resumed within the season, if indeed they had ever truly stopped for it.

VII

Of Eachann Ruadh's Bed

Not every death of the king's blood in these years came of the wedding quarrel or its like. Eachann Ruadh mac Mhurchaidh, who had killed Íomhar Dearg at the ford in vengeance for his own brother a full four generations before and had lived the whole of the strife's long middle as an old man at the

edge of the Hall's own ground, neither forgiven nor pursued, died in his bed in the three hundred and seventy-seventh year of the age, at seven hundred and twenty-nine years old, the last of his own generation of the king's kin and by some distance the quietest death among them. He had outlived the killing that made his name by longer than most men's whole lives run, and it is told that in his final seasons he spoke of it seldom and without pride, saying once to a grandchild who asked him of the ford that a man's youngest deed followed him further than any of his later ones, however small it had seemed at the time he did it, a lesson he offered, Niall said, with more weariness than wisdom, though the two are not always easily told apart in an old man's mouth.

His own line, unlike Fionnghal's and Artair's, took no fresh quarrel from his death, having settled, a generation before, into a peace with Dùghall Dearg's Red Share that neither side troubled to disturb, and it was remarked at the time, by those who kept account of such things, that the one death among the king's old blood in these years to pass without raising a single spear was the death of a man who had himself once raised one in earnest. Niall, telling this part of the tale, would let it sit a moment without comment, as though the fact spoke for itself better than any moral he could set beside it.

VIII

Of the Households Going On

Through all of it, the wedding's small insult widening across nearly two centuries into a habit of raids the households themselves had long since stopped troubling to explain, the ordinary business of the island went on largely undisturbed beneath the quarrelling. The handful was measured out at the stone cup as it had been measured since Fionnlagh Dall's own day, the tallies kept, the carriers walked their roads with their baskets, and a household sworn to whichever lord's stewards reached its door first in a given season paid its dues to that lord and troubled itself no further with which side of which grudge he stood on, so long as the measure he asked for stayed within the Law.

A household of the fourth hearth at Cnoc leathan, midway between the two quarrelling shares and sworn to neither, kept through these same generations a single tally-stick hung above its own door, notched once for every season the western share's steward called first and once, on the stick's other face, for every season

the salt shore's steward came first instead, a plain record kept for no reason grander than settling, at the year's turn, whose grain-store the household's own custom bound it to feed first at threshing. The stick, by the time of Niall's own telling, carried better than a hundred and fifty notches on each face, more marks by far than either quarrelling line's own reciters kept of the raids that had made the two households enemies, and it is told that the family who kept it could say, without hesitation, exactly which steward had called first in any given year of their own grandfathers' lives, while neither Sliochd Fhionnghail¹ nor Sliochd Artair² could any longer say with any certainty who had struck the first blow of the whole quarrel that had cost them both so dear.

Marriages continued to be made across the very lines that quarrelled, as marriages will, sons and daughters of Sliochd Fhionnghail wedding into households that owed nothing to either feud, the strife itself running always a little apart from the great slow ordinary current of ploughing and lambing and the mending of roofs that made up the greater part of any year for any household on the mountain, whatever its blood.

Niall Òg, closing the tale as he always closed it, would set down his bowl at this point, cold by then whatever hearth he told it beside, and say the one line that every listener across those centuries carried away with them whole, word for word, more surely than they carried any other part of the telling: that the island, in all his own long years of watching it, was never so well governed as when all its governors were too busy quarrelling with each other to trouble the rest of it. He meant it, those who knew him best agreed, only half in jest, and the other half of it, he would add if pressed, was the saddest thing he knew how to say about his own blood, three centuries deep into a grudge that had begun over nothing more than a boast and a drinking-horn at a stranger's wedding, and showed, in his own lifetime at least, no sign at all of ending.

1. the descendants of Fionnghal nic Ailein, holding the western share at Ros dhomhain

2. the descendants of Artair mac Ailein, holding the share of the salt shore at Baile ghorm

PART THREE

The LONG STRIFE and the Threshold

OF Eilidh nic Ìomhair and the Four Houses

FE 381 – 397

I

Of the Empty Threshold

The Keeper who had held the flame after Eimhir nic Mhuirich was an old woman of the hearth-line by the time Eilidh nic Ìomhair first came to Dùn ìseal to ask a season's grace on a debt of coal her household owed the Hall, and she remembered the meeting afterward only for the Keeper's hands, which shook badly by then pouring the measure, and for the patience with which the woman waited for them to steady before she would let anyone else pour it for her. That Keeper died in the winter of the three hundred and eighty-first year of the age, at an age nobody troubled to reckon exactly, having kept the flame quietly and without incident for longer than most people at Dùn ìseal could remember any other way of things being kept. She died on the low stool beside the cup, having sat down there after the evening measure was poured to rest her legs before the walk to her own bed, and the boy sent in at first light to relight her lamp from Brìde's own flame found her still sitting upright with her hands folded in her lap, so that he stood a long moment in the doorway unsure whether he had come upon a woman asleep or a woman dead, and only knew the second when he had gone close enough to see that the coal in the small lamp beside her had burned out in the night for want of any hand to feed it, the first time in living memory that any lamp in Talla na Lasrach¹ had been let go dark. The nine hearths gathered

1. the Hall of the Flame

at the Hall in the spring to choose whoever would keep it after her, as they had gathered eight times before since Beathag Bhàn first took the coal from the slab.

Eilidh was two-and-forty that spring, a granddaughter's granddaughter of Ìomhar Dearg through a line that had long since stopped naming itself anything grander than a household of Dùn dhearg, and she had spent the better part of her life doing exactly what any woman of that household did: keeping accounts for the Red Share's steward, walking the granary rolls at threshing, and raising three children on ground her own grandmother had walked before her. She had never asked to be considered for the flame, and said so plainly to the two hearth-elders who came to Dùn dhearg to sound her out, sitting her down at her own table and asking her, in the roundabout way such questions are always first asked, whether she thought a woman of her particular blood might be persuaded to sit a season with the coal.

"You mean the king's blood," Eilidh said, because she had never in her life found much use in letting another person finish a sentence she could see coming from three words off, and the elders admitted that yes, that was rather the difficulty they had come to discuss.

It was late in the evening when they came, the two of them having walked from Dùn ìseal since morning and eaten nothing since, and Eilidh's own household gave them bread and a bowl of the same broth her children were fed on before either elder was let say a further word about hearths or flames or blood. One of the two, a thin man with a cutter's scarred hands who had spent forty years in the galleries before the nine hearths thought his knees too poor for the climb and set him instead to walking their errands, watched Eilidh feed her youngest from her own bowl while the older two argued over whose turn it was to fetch water, and said afterward, to the other elder on the road home, that he had gone to Dùn dhearg half expecting a woman puffed up with her own blood and had found instead a woman who could not get a full sentence out of her own table without being asked twice for the salt.

The difficulty was old and plain enough that nobody at the table needed it explained twice. The Binding had sworn the flame to no one of the king's blood, and had been kept to that oath, without exception, since Beathag Bhàn herself had been chosen for no reason grander than that she was of nobody's blood at all. Muireach Liath, Gormshuil, Fionnlagh Dall, Eimhir, the woman just carried up to the slope: none of them had been able to claim so much as a great-grandmother among Ailean's own children, and the nine hearths had never, in all that time,

needed to ask themselves whether the rule still held, because no candidate worth considering had ever forced the question. Eilidh forced it. She was, by every reckoning the hearth-elders could make sitting at her own table that afternoon, plainly the ablest of the three names put forward that spring, and just as plainly a great-great-granddaughter of the man who had burned the halls of Dùn dhearg and sent a king home on a bier of spears.

"Then choose one of the other two," Eilidh said, not unkindly, and meant it; she had said as much to her own husband the night before, and he had told her that a woman who did not want a thing badly enough to argue for it seldom got it, and seldom deserved to.

II

Of the Season of Refusal

The nine hearths chose her anyway, in the spring of the three hundred and eighty-second year, by a count neither Sliochd Mhuirich¹ nor anyone else who kept the tally troubled to say aloud, and word of the choosing reached Sliochd Mhuirich at Dùn ìseal before Eilidh herself had finished packing a single basket to travel there. The house that had held the flame since Muireach Liath's daughter first took the coal from her father's dying hand did not send word back that it welcomed the choice. It sent word that it did not accept it, and for the better part of a year afterward the cup at Talla na Lasrach² sat under the care of the hearth-line's own eldest, unfilled by any new hand, while every household with an opinion on the matter found occasion to air it at every market and every threshing floor on the mountain.

The argument made loudest that year, and the one Eilidh herself was made to answer more times than she could count, was put to her first by a cousin of her own who meant it as comfort: that there was, by then, hardly a household left in the hills without some thread of the king's own blood run through it somewhere, a great-great-grandmother here, a disowned younger son there, so that the Binding's old rule against the blood had become, in practice, a rule against nearly everybody or nobody at all, and Eilidh's own blood was no different in kind from

1. the house of Muireach

2. the Hall of the Flame

half the blood in the valley, only better remembered. Eilidh heard the argument out from more mouths than her cousin's, and found it no comfort whatever the number of times it was offered her, because it answered a question nobody at Dùn ìseal had actually asked. Nobody doubted that half the mountain carried a drop of Ailean's line by now, diluted past any household's power to name it. What Sliochd Mhuirich doubted, and said so without troubling to soften it, was whether a woman who could stand up at any gathering of the Red Share and be named, plainly and without dilution, as a granddaughter's granddaughter of Ìom-har Dearg, could be trusted to keep a flame the Binding had sworn against exactly that kind of naming.

"They are not wrong to ask it," Eilidh told her cousin, the third or fourth time he brought the argument to her door meaning to cheer her with it, and the flatness with which she said it left him with nothing further to offer. She did not, in that whole season of waiting, once send word to Dùn ìseal pressing her own claim, nor did she withdraw it; she went on keeping the Red Share's granary rolls as she had always kept them, and let the argument run its course among people who had more patience for arguing it than she did.

The waiting wore harder on her household than it did on her. Her husband, a cutter's son with no blood worth naming on either side, took to answering for her at the granary door whenever a steward's runner arrived with some fresh word from Dùn ìseal, saying only that his wife was at the rolls and had nothing to add to what she had said the last time, until the runners stopped troubling to knock and simply left whatever they carried with him instead. Her eldest daughter, a girl of nineteen who had grown up hearing her own great-great-grandfather's name spoken at markets the way other households spoke of weather, asked her once, straight out at the supper table, whether she wanted the flame at all or only refused to be told she could not have it, and Eilidh considered the question longer than she considered most, turning her spoon in the broth a while before she answered that she had stopped, some years back, being able to tell the two apart in her own mind, and did not think the difference mattered as much as her daughter seemed to.

III

Of the Condition

What finally settled it was a condition offered rather than any argument won, and it came, as such things at Dùn Ìseal generally did, from the hearth-line's own eldest rather than from any voice on Eilidh's side of the question. She was a woman named for no one now living to remember, old enough to have helped carry Fionnlagh Dall's own body south along the eleven days' road, and she came to the Hall's threshold on the morning appointed for the nine hearths to meet again and said, before any other business could be raised, that Sliochd Mhuirich¹ would yield the flame to Eilidh nic Ìomhair on one condition and no other: that the stone cup Fionnlagh Dall had cut to the measure of two cupped hands should never, for any cause, for any lord's asking, for any war or famine or royal wedding the island might yet see, be carried out through the door of Talla na Lasrach².

It was not, on its face, much of a condition to ask, since no Keeper before Eilidh had ever once thought to carry the cup anywhere, and several of the hearth-elders who heard it said as much, wondering aloud what the house of Muireach thought it was guarding against that had not already been guarded a hundred times over by the Binding. But the eldest of Sliochd Mhuirich, when pressed to say plainly what she feared, answered only that a cup that never left a house could never be carried off by whoever next held the strongest claim to whatever else that house kept, and that she would rather ask for a small thing plainly than a large thing she could not name, and left it at that. Eilidh, told of the condition before she had even finished the walk up from Dùn dhearg to swear to it, said she would have sworn to it unasked, and did so before the nine hearths that same afternoon with her hand flat on the cup's rim, the coal poured level to her palm exactly as it had been poured for every Keeper before her, and the flame carried to her own lamp before nightfall.

It never did leave the Hall, not once in the whole of Eilidh's keeping nor in the reigns of any Keeper who came after her, and the tellers since, looking back on that single afternoon's bargain, would say that Sliochd Mhuirich had asked for the one thing it could be certain of getting and got, by the asking, a good deal more besides.

1. the house of Muireach

2. the Hall of the Flame

IV

Of the Four Houses Sworn

Eilidh had been three years at the flame, and had by then heard the argument about her blood raised so many times by so many mouths that she had stopped troubling to answer it at all, when the shape of a settlement came to her less from any single voice than from the plain fact of who kept coming to Dùn Ìseal to argue it. Four houses, and no more than four, had by then taken to sending their own elders to speak at every gathering of the nine hearths as though they alone had a right to be heard on the matter of the Keeper's office: Sliochd Mhuirich¹, holding the office by more than two hundred years of custom and now by Eilidh's own oath besides; Sliochd Ìomhair², claiming a voice through Eilidh's own blood and unwilling, now that the thing was done, to let anyone forget the connection; Sliochd Thormoid³, whose eldest stood up at the third such gathering and named, for the first time in anyone's hearing, an ancestor called Tormod Liath who was said to have held the hill under the old king before ever a flame was bound to it; and Sliochd Raghnaill⁴, whose claim ran through a man named Raghnaill Ceannfhionn and rested less on any hill than on the plain fact that Sliochd Raghnaill's boats had carried more coal down the coast in a bad season than any other house's carriers had carried inland.

Eilidh, who had grown tired of hearing four houses argue a question the other five hearths had long since stopped troubling to weigh in on, put the settlement to the nine in the spring of the three hundred and eighty-fifth year in words plain-er than any house had used to argue its own case: that the office of Keeper would be bound, from that season on, to these four houses of custody and no others, that the other hearths would keep their seats on the council as they always had but surrender any further claim on the flame, and that the four houses might settle among themselves, by whatever quarrel or marriage or patience the years gave them, which of their own would sit the flame when her own turn at it ended. Three of the four, she noted aloud before the nine hearths that same afternoon, claimed some thread of the king's blood or said they did, and only the house that had first raised the flame claimed none at all, which she thought, she said, a tidy

1. the house of Muireach

2. the house of Ìomhar

3. the house of Tormod

4. the house of Raghnaill

enough shape for an office the Binding had meant to keep clear of blood and had somehow, across three centuries, filled with almost nothing else.

It was sworn that same spring, on the same threshold where the condition about the cup had been sworn three years before, four elders standing where one had stood alone, each with a hand laid flat in turn on the same stone rim Eilidh's own hand had rested on at her own swearing, and a fifth hand, the hearth-line eldest's, laid last of all and longest, as if to remind the other three whose custom it was they had come late to share in. Most of the great families known on the island now trace themselves, rightly or by their own telling, to one of the four, and it had already become, within two or three generations, a common enough boast at any market to claim descent from one house or another of the swearing, though Eilidh herself, asked once by a grandchild years later which of the four her own blood belonged to, said only that she supposed it belonged to whichever house wanted the claiming least, since that was the one nobody troubled to dispute with her.

V

Of Seann Dunn and the Fullest Lamp

Sliochd Thormoid did not wait long to make its claim a visible one. Within the year its eldest had raised, at Seann Dunn on the river's northern bank, a hall and a shrine of squared timber facing the mountain across the water, with a coal-lamp set to burn at the Law's own measure day and night in a niche cut for it beside the door, so that any traveller on the road below could look up from the ford and see the house's light burning steadily whatever the season. The other three houses grumbled about it from the first, not because a lamp at the Law's measure was against any rule Eilidh had made, but because Seann Dunn's lamp, by every account that reached Dùn ìseal, always seemed to burn a shade fuller than anyone else's handful managed to, and no cutter sent to check the measure ever found so much as a grain over what the Law allowed.

"It is the same coal as everyone's," Eilidh told a steward of Sliochd Ìomhair¹ who came to complain of it on his own house's behalf, turning the man's own grumble back on him with more patience than the complaint deserved, "and if

1. the house of Ìomhar

Seann Dunn's hearth burns brighter on it than yours, I expect that says more for their draught than for their honesty." She did not trouble to have the lamp measured a second time, judging, as she told the hearth-elders privately, that a grievance a house could not prove was a grievance best left to wear out on its own, and it did, more or less, though Seann Dunn's neighbours went on saying it of the lamp for as long as the shrine stood.

Sliochd Raghnaill², meanwhile, made no shrine at all, having chosen for its own seat Seann Tarr on the north-eastern coast, the same town whose household had been the very first sentenced under Fionnlagh Dall's Small-Burning Law two centuries before, its name still carried on the Hall's own roll with the old offence beside it. The house that took its seat there kept no galleries and cut no coal of its own, choosing boats instead, and grew rich enough on the fishing within two generations that the other three houses stopped mentioning the old offence at all, which Eilidh privately thought a stranger silence than any grumble about a lamp.

VI

Of Tormod Ruadh and the Coast That Was Only Looked At

It was a household of Sliochd Raghnaill¹'s own boats, in the twelfth year of Eilidh's keeping, that did the one thing none of the other three houses had thought to try, and did it, by every later account, less from ambition than from an argument over a wager that had gone on rather longer at Seann Tarr's own quay than the ale served there could reasonably sustain. A steersman named Tormod Ruadh, no kin to Sliochd Thormoid² whatever the shared name might suggest to a stranger, had spent the better part of a winter's evenings insisting to anyone who would listen that a boat built to weather the open water past the skerries could as easily be sailed clean round the black island the fishers called Eilean dhubh as fished within sight of it, as every boat out of Seann Tarr had always done before him, and by spring enough silver rings had changed hands on the wager that Tormod found himself with a crew of four and no honest way left to back out of the claim.

They put out at the first fair tide of an Cèitean in the three hundred and ninety-seventh year, provisioned for eight days though the crossing and back, by

2. the house of Raghnaill

Tormod's own reckoning, ought to want no more than five, and the quay that saw them off did so with more laughter than blessing, a dozen wagers still being settled on the strand as the boat cleared the harbour mouth. The weather held fair the first two days, wind enough to spare the oars, and Tormod's own account, told afterward more times than any man should have patience to repeat a single tale, made much of the third night, when the boat lay becalmed under a headland none of the four crewmen could put a name to and a light rain came on that none of them troubled to shelter from, having by then long since given up any dryness worth keeping. The fourth day brought the cliffs of the island's far side into view, taller by half, Tormod said, than any cliff on the coast he had grown up fishing under, white with birds from the waterline to a height no stone could be thrown to, and the noise of them, he told the quay more than once, was a thing no teller before him had ever troubled to mention, a great ceaseless clamour that did not stop for the whole day they coasted under it, so that the crew found themselves shouting to be heard over birds rather than over any sea.

Eilidh heard nothing further of the voyage until word reached Dùn ìseal that the boat had been sighted rounding the island's far side by fishers of a strand that had never before had reason to look for any boat of Seann Tarr's coming from that particular quarter of the sea, and the word that reached her carried, along with the fact of the sighting, a good deal of alarm from a strand that had taken the strange boat, at first glimpse, for something worth lighting a warning fire over. They were nine days out before the boat came home, a day longer than provisioned and no worse for it, and the whole of Seann Tarr's quay turned out to meet them, less, by most accounts, out of any fear for their safety than out of an eagerness to settle the wager one way or the other.

What Tormod brought back, when pressed by half the quay at once to say what lay round the far side of Eilean dhubh, was rock, and birds enough to darken the sky over certain stretches of the northern cliff, and the plain fact of having gone there and come back, and nothing else that any teller since has been able to add to it however many times the tale has been told at Seann Tarr's own hearths. He had looked for a landing and found none worth the name; he had looked for any sign that another boat, of any coast, had gone that way before him, and found none of that either; and when a woman of the quay asked him outright whether the far side of the island was worth the wager he had won by seeing

1. the house of Ragnhall

2. the house of Tormod

it, he is said to have answered only that a man does not sail nine days to bring home an answer to a question nobody but a drunk crowd at a quay had thought worth asking, and that he would do it again all the same, given the ale and the wager to make him.

Word of the voyage reached Eilidh at Dùn ìseal within the month, carried up by a carrier who had heard it fresh at Seann Tarr's own quay and told it, by his own account, rather better than Tormod himself ever troubled to tell it again. She asked the carrier only one question in return, whether any of the four houses had claimed the voyage as their own doing, and was told that Sliochd Raghnaill had certainly not discouraged the telling, whatever truth there was in a wager settled over too much ale being any house's doing at all.

VII

Of the Watching from the Threshold

Eilidh kept the flame a further three-and-thirty years after that spring, long enough to see the argument about her own blood fade from something argued at every gathering into something an older generation remembered arguing and a younger one had simply always known to be settled, and long enough, too, to see boats out of all four coasts sail a little further past their own headlands than their grandfathers had thought worth the risk, though none again quite so far, nor quite so needlessly, as Tormod Ruadh's had gone.

She was at Seann Tarr herself in the last days of that same summer, come down from Dùn ìseal to see the new seat of the house her own settlement had sworn, and she stood on the quay on an evening with the tide making and watched the small dark shapes of the fishing boats come in past the headland in the last of the light, Tormod Ruadh's among them, each boat finding its own strand as it always had, none of them, that evening or any evening after, troubling to sail any further than the fishing required. It was, she thought, watching them come in, a smaller thing than the argument over her own blood had ever made it sound, and a larger one than any wager settled at a quay had any right to be, and she found, standing there with the flame two days' walk behind her and the cup that would never leave its house, that she could not have said with any certainty which of the two she believed the truer measure of what her own long season at the flame had actually kept.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

OF the PLUNDERERS and the THING under the Boat

FE 398 – 421

Cha do dh'fhaighnich a' mhuir cead. The sea did not ask leave.
— said still at the wake of Baile chrom, by whoever pours the first
cup

I

Of the Households Put Out to Sea

Anndra Ciobair was eighteen the year his uncle's household lost its right for the third time, and he remembered it less as a shame than as a leaving: three men going down to the strand at Baile chrom with what they could carry on their backs, a woman weeping without troubling to hide it, and his uncle Murchadh Ruadh saying nothing at all, which those who knew him thought the worse sign of the two. The Law took no pleasure in a third offence and no more trouble over it than over a first; it set the household's name on the roll that the waypoint-keepers cried at Samhain, and after that no hearth on the coast would give the household coal, nor grumble, nor discuss it, for the discussing had all been done at the first offence and the second. Anndra's father stood at his own door and watched his brother's household go down the path to the strand with their bundles on their backs, and said only, when Anndra asked him why he did not call out some word of parting, that a word said across a threshold the Law had

shut could do the leaving household no good and the speaker a good deal of harm, and that he had five sons of his own still under that roof to think of.

What the Law did not do, and had never troubled to do, was ask where a household went once its name was on that roll. Some went inland to kin who would have them on sufferance and cold porridge. Some starved slowly and were counted among the reverent centuries' quiet dead, a household here and a household there that the rolls simply stopped naming, no cause given because none was asked. And some, that year and in the years after it, went down to the strand instead and put out in whatever hull would still float, and lived off the north-western waters the way a household with no coal and no grain and no roof lives: by raiding the strands of households luckier than themselves.

They were not the first to try it. Baile chrom's own grandfathers told of a leaner year, generations back, when two brothers had done the same thing for a single winter and come home again once their own cousins forgave them, and no one had troubled to give it a name. This time the name stuck, because there were more of them, and because most did not come home, and because within three years of the first household's leaving there were boats enough on those waters, out of half a dozen strands and not one household among them, to make a raid worth calling a raid rather than a theft worth calling a shame. Spùinneadairean, the strand called them, plunderers, and by the time Anndra was a man grown the word had settled onto the north-western waters as a whole, the whole grey width of them from the sea-monster's rocks to the point where no boat of Baile chrom cared to go unescorted, as if the sea out past the headland had always belonged to thieves and always would.

Anndra's own household kept its right. His father fished the near grounds and paid the Law its handful without complaint or love, and taught his sons that a man who lost his right had lost it fairly, whatever pity a body might feel watching the boats go out, and that pity spent on a man already gone to sea was pity wasted on the one man who could no longer use it. But Anndra had grown up beside boys whose cousins were now spùinneadairean, and he had sat at more than one hearth where a mother would not say the word for her own son, only "my boy that's on the water now," as if he had merely taken up fishing a little further out than most, and Anndra never once heard any of those mothers say where the fish he brought her came from, or ask.

II

Of the Night the Southern Strand Burned

he was one-and-twenty, and two years wed, when the raid came near enough to his own coast that he stood in the smoke of it. It fell on a strand half a day's walk south along the shore, six households that kept goats on the machair above the tideline and dried more fish than they ate themselves, and it fell in the small hours of a night with no moon, which every teller after agreed was no accident, for a boat coming in dark and going out dark leaves little for a strand to swear to in the morning beyond smoke and empty racks.

Anndra was not there when the boats came in, only when the word came up the coast at first light, carried by a boy who had run the whole way and could barely stand by the time he reached Baile chrom's own hearths, and he went south with a dozen others of the fitter men, arriving to find two of the six houses burned to their stone footings, the drying-racks stripped bare to the last strip of fish, and a woman of that strand sitting on the ground before her own ruined door with a burned hand wrapped in her skirt, saying to whoever would listen and to no one in particular that she had known two of the men in the boats by their voices, though she would not, then or ever after, say the names aloud where the Law's own ears might carry them home to kin who still had a right to lose.

It was the first raid Anndra had seen the marks of rather than merely heard of, and it taught him a thing the tellings had never quite made plain, that the spùin-neadairean did not raid as strangers raid, taking what they could carry and gone before a strand woke, but as men who knew exactly which houses kept the fullest racks and which dogs barked loudest and which men slept furthest from the door, because most of them had grown up on those same strands themselves and had cousins sleeping in half the houses they burned. He said as much to his father that same evening, and his father told him only that a man does not choose his kin. He chooses, every day of his life, which of his kin's roofs he will burn and which he will not, and a household on the wrong side of the Law's third offence had made that choice already, whatever pity it earned it afterward.

III

Of the Calm Water

The year Anndra was five-and-twenty he crewed the boat of Cailean Buidhe, a broad-beamed hull that had brought in more herring than any other keel out of Baile chrom in a decade, with four men aboard besides himself: Cailean at the steering-oar, his two sons Murchadh Òg and Eachann, and Anndra's own second cousin, a quiet man named Torcall who talked to the nets more than to the crew and was thought lucky for it, though luck, as it turned out that year, is not a thing any man can lend another.

They went out past the headland on a morning so still that Anndra remembered afterward being able to hear, a mile from shore, a dog barking on the strand behind them as clearly as if it stood at his elbow. The water lay like poured metal, no swell in it at all, which the older men said was a thing to mistrust more than any storm, for a boat in a gale at least knows what it is fighting. Cailean himself said so that morning, easing the boat out past the point with the oar barely stirring, and Murchadh Òg laughed at him for it and said a calm sea had never yet drowned a careful man, to which Cailean answered nothing, only watched the water a while longer before he gave the word to shoot the nets.

They shot the nets in the flat calm and sat waiting on oars gone slack in their locks, the sea so smooth under the hull that a man could watch his own face in it if he leaned over the gunwale, which Torcall did, once, leaning far enough that Eachann told him to mind he didn't fall in and save the fish the trouble of being caught, and Torcall straightened without answering and said nothing about what he had seen there, if he had seen anything at all beyond his own reflection.

It came up without a wave to announce it. Anndra was watching the net-floats for the first tug of fish when the whole boat lifted: a slow, deliberate lift, the lift of something enormous passing beneath, as if the sea had drawn one long breath and held it. The floats went under. The boat tipped, righted, tipped again, and for three or four heartbeats every man aboard stood or crouched exactly where the lift had caught him, not one of them making a sound, for there was, in that silence and that stillness, nothing yet to cry out against: no shape breaking the surface, no fin, no eye, only the water gone taut and strange beneath the keel, as a drumskin goes taut under a hand laid flat on it before the hand strikes. Cailean said one word only, low, not a command and not quite a prayer either, and no man aboard remembered afterward what the word had been.

Then the boat went over.

Anndra never afterward could say, and would not for the rest of his life be made to say, whether the capsizing came from below or from the men's own

scramble to the one side, which is the ordinary way boats are lost in a calm as much as in a storm, five men throwing their weight the same way at the same instant out of the same fear. He went into water colder than the still morning had promised, came up under the hull's shadow, and swam clear of it without deciding to, the way a man's body decides such things for him when the deciding mind has nothing yet to decide with. Close by, once, he heard a great slow displacement of water that was not a wave and was not any fish he had ever heard broach, a sound with weight in it, the sound a hillside makes settling rather than a sound the sea usually makes, and he did not look toward it. He swam and did not look, and has never in any telling since said which of the two took more from him.

Of the five who had gone out on Cailean Buidhe's boat that morning, two came in: Anndra himself, and Torcall, who had somehow kept hold of an oar the whole way and gave it up to no one on the strand, not even when his hands had to be prised from it finger by finger once he was ashore and could no longer feel them. Cailean and his two sons were never found, not that day nor after, though the coast was walked for a week and the near rocks searched at every low tide, and the boat came ashore three days later a mile down the coast, upside down, its planking sound, not a mark on it that any man could point to and call a cause.

IV

Of What Was Not Said

The strand asked Anndra what he had seen, in the way a strand always asks, gently at first and then less gently as the days passed and no bodies came ashore to answer for themselves, and Anndra told them what he had heard and what the boat had done, and no more. He did not say that the lift beneath the keel had felt, for the length of one held breath, like a hand cupping something too small for it. He did not say what size he had judged the displacement to be, out of the corner of an eye that had refused, in the moment, to turn and look directly at it, nor did he ever, in the forty years he lived after, describe the sound of it to anyone in words closer than "a hillside settling," which satisfied no one who asked and was, he always maintained, the truest account he had to give. Torcall said even less, and within a year had stopped fishing the near grounds at all and taken instead to mending nets ashore, a trade no one begrudged him and which he followed, in near total silence, for the rest of a long life.

It was not the first such loss the north-western waters had given the coast, nor, the old women said, would it be the last, and there were tellers enough at Baile chrom's own hearths who called the thing by a name before the year was out, the Sea-Watcher, and swore it had been seen off that same headland since before any hearth now standing had been raised, some thirty feet of it by the tellings that kept closest to modesty and a good deal more by the tellings that did not. Whether it was one beast or many, or the sea's own way of answering a calm too still to trust, no one at Baile chrom claimed to know, and those who claimed to know were, as a rule, men who had not been in the boat.

What the coast did agree on, without needing to discuss it the way the household's third offence had needed no discussing, was that the loss should be kept, and kept every year, on the day nearest the one it had happened, with a bowl set out for the three who did not come home and the boat's name spoken aloud once by whoever poured the first cup. Anndra poured it the first year, because he was the one who had come back with a story to tell and would not tell it, and by unspoken agreement he went on pouring it every year after, growing old at the task the way another man grows old at a trade he never chose and could not now set down.

V

Of the Fire Relit

Four years after the loss, in a season when three more boats had gone missing off the same stretch of water, though none so strangely as Cailean Buidhe's, the fishers of Baile chrom climbed the headland and lit the old beacon on the point again, the one their grandfathers had let go dark once the Law's own coal-galleries made every hearth's fire a counted and measured thing and a fire kept for no household's own handful had come to seem, to a generation grown careful of the Law, a kind of waste no one wished to answer for. They fed it with driftwood, as the Law required of any fire kept outside a share's own handful, and a beacon fed with driftwood burns unevenly, now high and now guttering, so that a boat far out watching it learns to read its own danger in how steadily the point holds its light, and learns, too, that a fire which cannot be measured cannot be rationed, and will burn on whatever the tide happens to leave it, generous

some nights and mean on others, exactly as the sea it watches over is generous or mean.

Anndra carried wood up that headland himself more nights than he later cared to count, in the years the beacon was young and its keeping still fell to whoever happened to be ashore and willing rather than to any household by right. It became, before long, a charge some households took in turn the way other coasts took turns at a granary door or a toll-stick, a season each, and the fire on the point came to be called, by fishers from other harbours who steered by it once Baile chrom's own people had stopped thinking of it as anything but the fire, the light of Baile chrom, kept for no coal the Law could measure and asked for by no one but the sea.

He stood the watch there the night word came up the coast, carried by a trader's boat out of the east that had put in for water and stayed the night for the company, that other households far off had found other uses for driftwood and silt and old stone, and Anndra, who by then thought of little beyond his own headland and his own three names in his own bowl, listened to the news the way a man listens to weather from a country he will never sail to: with interest, and no great sense that it touched him, and asked the trader, more from courtesy than curiosity, whether the coast he spoke of kept any beacon of its own, and was told that it did not yet, having found, in the stone it had dug up, a better inheritance than any fire a household could feed.

VI

Of Seann Bhrenn and the Stone Quay

Far to the north-east, on a coast Anndra never saw and never expected to, fishers from the mountain's northern side had grown too many for the harbours they held and gone looking, as households on every coast of the island had gone looking before them, for a shore with room enough and water deep enough and no one already standing on it to say otherwise. They found such a shore at the old harbour the herders of that coast still called Seann Bhrenn, empty since some earlier age had emptied it, and settled there, and kept the name they found it under rather than giving it one of their own, the way the western settlers before them had kept Seann Warr's name and the road-builders before that had

kept Seann Mhorn²'s, the whole island by then grown used to the notion that a place's old name outlasted whoever had first worn it out.

They found more than an empty harbour. Digging back the silt that had swallowed the old shoreline, the first families to break ground there struck stone: a quay, cut and laid by hands none of them could account for, buried deep enough that only the lowest tides had ever shown a hint of it, and sound enough, once cleared, to take a hull heavier than any their own boats yet built. They used it without asking who had laid it, the way a household uses a well it finds already dug, and the harbour prospered faster for the finding than it would have prospered digging its own quay from nothing, which is the kind of luck a coast does not question closely once it has taken hold of it, though more than one household there was heard to wonder, at its own hearth and no further, what manner of hands had cut stone so true before any hand now living had learned the trade.

Word of the stone quay travelled the coast the way word of any strange find travels, mouth to mouth and boat to boat, gathering a little in the telling at every hearth it passed through, so that by the time it reached Baile chrom, three seasons and the width of the island removed from the digging, the quay had grown in some tellings to a whole buried town and shrunk in others to a single worked stone no bigger than a door-lintel. Anndra heard it told both ways at his own hearth in the same winter, from two travellers who had never met each other and neither of whom had seen the quay themselves, and believed neither telling more than the other, which struck him, he said once to Torcall over the mending of a net, as very much how his own boat's story must sound by the time it reached a hearth as far off as Seann Bhrenn, grown to a whole drowned town in one mouth and shrunk to a man's own fright in another, and neither telling any truer than his own silence had been.

VII

Of the Cairn at Cathair naomh

Further north still, at Cathair naomh, a smaller thing was begun in the same years that would grow, in its own way, larger than any stone quay: a cairn,

1. a harbour beside Seann Mhorn on Loch chrom, resettled with its old name kept

raised on the hill above the town for its own dead, with a single stone brought to it at every burial by whichever household had lost the body being laid down. It was not the island's first ancestor-cairn, nor even the first at Cathair naomh, whose people had marked their dead with stones since before any hearth there could say why, but it was the one that took hold and did not stop growing, so that within Anndra's own lifetime travellers who had seen it once and passed that way again years later swore the hill looked changed, heavier at the crown, as if the mountain had grown a second, smaller mountain out of nothing but grief carried up one stone at a time, each stone no bigger than a fist and the whole of it, by the time word of it had travelled the length of the island twice over, taller than any hall the Hall had raised.

Anndra never climbed that hill. He knew of the cairn the way he knew of the quay at Seann Bhrenn, as a thing told at a hearth by someone who had it from someone else, and it would not have occurred to him, hearing it, that a coast so far off from his own headland kept its dead in much the way Baile chrom kept its own three names in a bowl once a year, a stone against a cup, the two of them sharing one refusal: that a loss should go unmarked merely because the sea, or the years, offered no better answer to it than silence. He thought of it once, hearing the tale a second time from a different mouth some years on, and said to his own wife by the fire that a coast a man had never seen and would never see kept its grief the same as his own coast kept its, which she took, rightly, for as close to a kind thought as her husband ever spoke aloud about a stranger.

VIII

Of the Great Cats and the Southern Road

It was in the one-and-twentieth year after the boat went down that news came to Baile chrom of a ruling far to the south, carried up the coast the slow way such things travelled before any road ran the whole length of the island: that the carriers of the southern road had found the great cats' own crossing running straight over their own path, between the southern hills and the fens beyond them, at the same season every year without fail, the beasts coming down off the high passes in numbers no herder had troubled to count and crossing the road in

2. a harbour on the western shore of Loch chrom, resettled with its old name kept

a body rather than singly, so that a carrier caught on that stretch at the wrong hour might sit an hour or more waiting for the last of them to clear the road. Eilidh nic Ìomhair, Keeper of the flame these forty years and more, had ruled, on being asked what the Law made of it, that no panther might be killed on that road while the crossing lasted, whatever beast it cost a herd or a household to let pass, and that the carriers were to wait it out in the waypoint houses built along that stretch for exactly such waiting.

The carriers, the telling had it, had grumbled at first, as carriers grumble at any delay the Law lays on a basket already late, one waypoint-keeper of that road being quoted, by the time the tale had travelled as far as Baile chrom, as having asked Eilidh outright what a beast's road was worth set against a household's coal, to which she was said to have answered only that the beast's road had run there longer than the carriers' own, and that a Law which measured every handful to the grain could measure a few days' patience too, if it chose. They kept the rule, once it was made, the way the island had come to keep most rulings it did not much like: without gladness, and without the will to test what the Hall would do if they broke it, and it cost them, in the end, exactly what she had said it would, and no more.

Anndra, hearing the tale at his own hearth from a trader who had it third or fourth hand from the south, thought it a strange kind of law to trouble a ruling over, a beast's own road left alone for a season, and said so to Torcall, who by then mended more nets than he spoke words, and who answered, after turning the thought over a good while with his hands still busy at the mesh, that a coast which had learned to let its own dead go unnamed for the sea's sake could hardly grudge a road a few days for a beast's sake. Anndra had no answer to that, and turned the tale over again himself that night on the headland with the beacon guttering and flaring above him in its usual driftwood way, and it seemed to him, by the time the fire burned low, that a rule which cost carriers only time, to let something older than any road pass unhindered across it, was cheaper wisdom than most rulings he had heard of in his life, and dearer bought than most too, if a man reckoned rightly what it had taken to learn it.

I X

Of the Bowl at the Wake

For near forty years after the boat went down, Anndra kept the beacon and poured the wake's first cup, growing from the young man who had swum clear of a lift in the water he could not name into an old fisher whom the younger households asked, when a strange calm came over the bay, whether it was the kind of stillness that wanted watching. He told them honestly what the water had done and what he had heard, the lift and the sound like a hillside settling, and never once, in all those years, what he had seen out of the corner of an eye he had refused to turn. The younger households learned, in time, not to press him further than that, the way a strand learns which questions a tide will answer and which it will only ever wash back unanswered.

He died in his sixtieth year, in his own bed above the strand, with Torcall's grandson keeping the beacon by then and the wake's bowl already passed to other hands some seasons before, Anndra having grown too stiff at the last to carry the cup up from his own door to the shore without a boy's arm to lean on. The coast buried him within sight of the headland, as he had asked, and the fire he had carried wood to on so many nights burned that same night as it always burned, unevenly, fed with whatever driftwood the tide had left, watched by no one who had been in the boat with him, and answering, as it had always answered, to no measure the Law had ever troubled to keep.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Of the Reverent Centuries

FE 422 – 542

Chan eil fearann aig neach nach eil aig a shliochd. No one holds land
who does not hold it for those who come after.
— said of the granaries at Dùn dhearg, in the reverent centuries

I

Of the Granaries and the Debt of Bread

Coinneach Mòr mac Tormoid was two-and-twenty, and still counted among the young men of Seann Dunn who had not yet been asked to speak at a council, the year the storm season broke early on the lowland fields and Sliochd Ìomhair¹ opened the doors of the new granaries at Dùn dhearg for the first time to households that were not its own. He rode down with his father to see it, more from curiosity than need, for the house of Tormod held grain enough of its own that season, and what he remembered after, more than the stone walls or the measured piles of barley within them, was the queue: three hundred people or more standing in a line that bent twice round the yard, each with a sack or a basket, each waiting a turn that the keepers of the granary gave out with no more ceremony than a nod and a mark scratched on a tally, and none of them saying much to the ones ahead or behind, as people do not talk much while they wait on a thing they are glad of and ashamed of both at once.

His father, Tormod Bàn, had held no love for the house of Ìomhar and said so plainly enough at his own hearth, but standing at the edge of that yard he only

watched the queue a long while and said, at last, that a house which filled its granaries against the storm season and then opened them to whoever came short had done what the old custom of sharing always asked and no lord before it had troubled to do at this scale, and that a debt of bread was a debt like any other, save that it did not always feel like one to the man who owed it, not until the day his own field failed and he found he had nowhere else to go but Dùn dhearg's gate. Coinneach asked him whether that made the house of Ìomhar the better lord for it, and his father said only that it made the house of Ìomhar richer in people who owed it something, which is not the same question, and that a young man who could not tell the two questions apart yet would learn to before he was much older.

He did learn it, in time, though not from any single lesson. The granaries filled again the next storm season, and the one after, and within Coinneach's own lifetime it had become the ordinary shape of things along that stretch of the lowland, so ordinary that the households who came to the gate no longer thought of it as owing anything at all, only as the way grain was had in a bad year, the way water was had from a well that happened to stand on another man's land. Sliochd Ìomhair never called in the debt in words. It did not need to. A house that had filled every belly on the plain through three bad harvests running had no need to remind anyone of it at the fourth, and the households themselves, when the matter came up at all, spoke of Dùn dhearg the way a man speaks of the ford he crosses without paying it any particular gratitude, save that he would notice keenly enough if it were taken away.

At the foot of the high pass to the north, in those same years, a different debt was being built more quietly still. Carriers who took the Hall's baskets over the pass had long rested their beasts at the last flat ground before the climb began, a stretch of machair with a spring on it and little else to recommend it, and by the time Coinneach was a grown man there was a settled place there with byres and a smithy and an inn that never had an empty bed in the season the pass was open, called by the carriers themselves, before it had any other name, simply the resting-place, and afterward Baile Mòr dhomhain, the great deep town, though it stood on no deep water and had no claim to greatness beyond the beasts it fed and the rings it took for feeding them. It lived by the pass and little else, as the carriers said

1. the house of Ìomhar

of it without unkindness, the way a man says of his own trade that it is what he has rather than what he chose.

II

Of the Keeping of the Flame

Coinneach came to the flame in the month of Giblean, in his five-and-twentieth year, the first Keeper of Sliochd Thormoid¹, chosen by the four houses at Dùn ìseal on a morning cold enough that the breath of every man who spoke his name for the office hung visible in the air of the chamber before it reached the ears it was meant for. He had not sought the office with any great heat, being by his own account and everyone else's a young man of more patience than ambition, and it was that same patience, more than any gift for speech or arms, that the houses named when they chose him: a Keeper, they said, did not need to be clever, only steady, for the flame asked nothing of a man but that he keep it, and a man who kept it steadily for sixty years was worth ten who kept it brilliantly for five.

He kept it for two-and-sixty years, longer than any Keeper of any of the four houses before him, and it was said afterward, by those who lived to see the length of his keeping laid out whole, that he had changed nothing in all that time, which was meant, and taken, as the highest praise the office could earn rather than the smallest. The flame at Dùn ìseal burned the year he came to it exactly as it had burned the year before, and the year he died it burned the same still, fed the same measure, tended by the same order of hands, answering to no different rule than it had answered to when Sìne nan Snaidhm first tied the knots at Dùn ìseal, generations beyond counting before him. A visitor from a coast that changed its harbour-master every ten years and thought nothing of it once asked Coinneach, late in his keeping, whether it did not weary a man to hold one office so long without altering it, and Coinneach answered that a flame altered was a flame gone out under a different name, and that he had never yet met the man wise enough to alter a fire and be sure, afterward, that it was still the same fire he had lit. The visitor pressed him once more, asking whether he had never in sixty years wished to leave some mark of his own upon the office he had held so long, and Coinneach said

1. the house of Tormod

that a Keeper's mark, if he left one worth leaving, was that no one after him could point to any year of his keeping and say the flame had burned differently in it than in the year before, and that he counted himself fortunate to have found, in his own nature, so little wish to be remembered any other way.

In those same generations, in words the rolls themselves used and Coinneach might have used of his own keeping without changing one of them, the people of the lowland fields neither grew greatly in number nor dwindled, mined the same small measure of coal and burned the same small measure, whichever lord's stones a household happened to live between, and the rolls called them the reverent centuries: not for any reverence the people themselves professed, which was ordinary enough, but for the stillness of the years themselves, laid one on another like courses of a wall that never rose any higher, a wall built, if it was built for anything, only to keep standing.

III

Of the Headman of Achadh chaol

Not every household under Coinneach's keeping was so settled as the tellings of the reverent centuries made it sound, and the first council he sat through in the year after his choosing gave him a lesson in how much settling a household still had to do before the rolls would call it ordinary. Shepherds out of the eastern hills had taken up the upland fields at Achadh chaol some years before, sending their wool down to the harbours along tracks no cart had cut before them, and their headman, a broad, slow-spoken man named Griogair Ruadh who had never in his life sat under a roof he did not himself thatch, came down to the council at Dùn iséal that season to ask, on behalf of the whole settlement, for a seat among the houses that governed the plain.

He asked it plainly and without much art, standing before the four Keepers with his hat in both hands and his feet planted the way a man plants them on a hillside rather than a hall floor, and said that his people had held the upland fields long enough now to be called a share like any other share, and that a share which paid its dues as faithfully as Achadh chaol paid its had earned some voice in how those dues were spent. The houses heard him out, as the custom required, and then asked him the one question the custom also required, which was whether any household of Achadh chaol held hearth-right under the old grant, the right

knotted on the cord at the Roinn, without which no settlement, however long-standing, could claim a seat at the council rather than merely a place in its queue.

Griogair Ruadh had no answer to that question beyond the true one, which was that his people's grant was newer than the Roinn by some thousand years and carried no such right knotted anywhere. He did not pretend otherwise, nor try, as a lesser man might have, to talk the council past the question rather than answer it; he only stood a while longer with his hat still in his hands, looked once round the chamber at the four Keepers seated above him, and said that he had walked five days down off the hill to hear a thing he had half known before he set out, and would walk five days back up having heard it said plainly rather than merely feared, which was, in its own way, worth the walking. Having given that true answer he sat a single season on the council as courtesy allowed, said little in it that any teller thought worth keeping, and went home again to Achadh chaol at the season's end with no seat and no promise of one, only the courtesy he had been given and the dues he still owed. He bore it, by every account that reached Seann Dunn afterward, without bitterness, telling his own people only that a right knotted at the Roinn outlasted a right spoken aloud, however fair the speaking, and that a household wanting a seat at that council had best begin, if it could, by finding some old knot of its own to show. Coinneach remembered the sound of Griogair Ruadh's voice longer than he remembered the substance of what either side had said, a man asking plainly for a thing plainly refused, and thought, more than once in the years after when some newer household came asking the same question in gentler words, that the answer never changed because the cord never changed, and that a Keeper's whole use, in such a matter, was only to say so without pretending the saying cost the asker nothing.

IV

Of the Walkers and the List of Ruins

It was in his own seven-and-twentieth year of keeping, when the flame had settled into him as thoroughly as he had settled into the flame, that Coinneach sent out the walkers, four men and two women chosen for legs that had carried them the length of the plain more than once and tongues that did not run ahead of what their eyes had actually seen, with instructions to list every ruin standing on ground the four houses claimed and to say, of each, only who did not

own it, and never to guess who had built it or why. It was not a grand undertaking as the plain reckoned such things, and Coinneach himself, asked why he troubled with it at all, said only that a lord who did not know what stood on his own ground could not in honesty claim the ground, and that the plain had grown thick enough with old walls and older stones that no house any longer knew, without asking, which of them belonged to anyone living.

The walkers were gone the better part of two years, and came back with a list longer than any of them had expected to make. They brought *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire*¹, a walled outpost on a spur above *Cathair mhòr* with stones dressed smooth on the outward face only and a single gate blocked from within by rubble no living hand had put there; they brought *Làrach an Dùin*², three rings of broken wall and a cistern cut into the bedrock with room, by the walkers' own reckoning, for four hundred souls and their beasts, though what four hundred souls had ever sheltered there none of the households nearby could say; they brought *Làrach an Teampaill*³, a stepped platform of fitted stone whose altar, they noted with the same flat honesty they gave to everything else, faced the central mountains and not the sea, as no altar raised in living memory ever faced; and they brought word, too, of standing stones scattered singly across the plain that answered to no name at all, only a description each, a long stone leaning east, three stones in a broken ring, one stone alone on a rise with a hollow worn at its foot by nothing the walkers could account for.

Of not one of these did the list say who had raised it. Coinneach ruled, when the walkers laid their tally before him, that it should not, and held to the ruling against more than one house that pressed him afterward for a guess dressed up as a finding, saying that a Keeper who let his walkers guess once would have to let them guess every time after, and that a list which told the plain only who did not own a ruin was worth more, in the end, than a list which told it a comforting lie about who had. The list stood, unaltered, for the whole length of his keeping and beyond it, and it was from that list, more than from any single ruin in it, that the plain first learned to speak of the builders of such places, whoever they had been, as simply the old people, with no house's name attached to the phrase and no house troubled, thereafter, to attach one.

1. the watch-fort ruin

2. the fortress ruin

3. the temple ruin

V

Of the Ring of Stakes at Cnoc bheag

The standing stone above Cnoc bheag was the one ruin on the walkers' list that did not stay untended once it was named. It stood alone on rising ground just outside the town, taller than a man and cut, on its upper face, with marks none living could read, the lines of them running in no order a household of the plain could follow. No one at Cnoc bheag claimed to know whose hands had cut them, nor when, only that the cutting was old enough that even the oldest woman in the town, asked about it at her own hearth, could say only that her grandmother had called it old already.

It was the cattle grazing the rise around it that moved the people of Cnoc bheag to act, in the year the walkers' list reached them, more than any thought for the stone's age: they had taken, over some seasons, to rubbing themselves against its lower face the way cattle rub against any standing thing in a field with few trees, until the lower cut signs had begun to wear soft at their edges under hide and horn. A household whose byre stood nearest the rise raised the first ring of stakes about the stone that same season, driving them by hand into ground too stony for a proper post-hole, and the ring held the cattle off well enough that the household beside it raised a second length the year after, and within Coinneach's own lifetime the whole rise had a fence about it that no single household could claim to have built, only to have added to, each generation renewing the stakes its own grandparents had first driven and never once moving the stone itself so much as a hand's breadth from where the old people, whoever they were, had set it. It stands so yet, ringed and unmoved, the fence renewed oftener than any hall on the plain has been rebuilt, which Coinneach, hearing of it in his own old age from a Cnoc bheag man come to Seann Dunn on other business, allowed was as fitting a monument as any stone the old people themselves had ever cut, for it asked nothing of the plain but that the plain go on doing, every generation, the one small thing it had already learned to do.

VI

Of the Bath-House at Muileann ruadh

The warm springs below Muileann ruadh had been known to the plain longer than any hall now standing on it, a handful of pools where the ground ran hot enough to steam on a cold morning, and for as long as anyone could tell it they had been used the way a household uses any good thing it finds unclaimed, by whoever walked far enough to reach them and troubled to strip and wade in. It was in Coinneach's eightieth year, when a cousin of his own house fell sick of a wasting cough that the ordinary remedies had failed to touch and was carried the two days' journey to the springs on a litter more in desperation than in any settled hope, that the plain first saw what a roof over those pools might do that the open pools themselves had never managed, for the cousin lay in the steam of the covered spring through a hard winter that would have killed him lying anywhere colder, and came home in the spring thinner but breathing, and lived nine years more.

Coinneach, hearing the whole of it from the cousin's own mouth, gave the order that a proper bath-house be raised over the largest of the pools, roofed and walled well enough to hold the steam through a winter storm, with sleeping-places built along one side for the sick and rough benches along the other for whoever had carried them there and meant to wait out the cure with them. He named a keeper of the springs to tend the place, a task he gave, deliberately and against the grumbling of more than one house that thought the honour beneath a hearth-holder, to a widow of no great name who had nursed her own husband through a like wasting and knew, she said, more of steam and fever than any council was likely to teach her, and he set her office in the name of Dian Cècht, the healer, the first office the flame at Dùn Ìseal had ever made that answered to no measure of coal at all. It was, by his own accounting late in life, the ruling he was proudest of among all he had made or left unmade in two-and-sixty years, not because it altered anything about the flame or the granaries or the reverent stillness of the plain's own years, but because it was the one thing in the whole of his keeping that had cost the house of Tormod nothing and given a sick man breath he would not otherwise have drawn, and a Keeper, he said once to the widow herself, might do worse with sixty years than to find, somewhere in the middle of them, one such ruling. She kept the springs for four-and-thirty years after, and trained, before she died, two of her own grandchildren to the same office, so that the keeping of Muileann ruadh's steam passed from hand to hand within one household long after the household that had first carried a dying man there had any other claim on the place at all; and Coinneach, who lived only a few years past the rais-

ing of the roof, said of that alone among his rulings that he hoped it would out-grow him.

VII

Of the Weights of Muileann chiar

The silversmiths of Muileann chiar cast their set of weights in the same decade, though not at Coinneach's asking nor at any house's, being a matter the smiths took up among themselves after one too many disputes at their own market over whether a given lump of silver weighed what the seller claimed for it. They cut the least of the set to the weight of a single barley-corn and the greatest to the weight of a newborn lamb, with a dozen steps between carefully checked one against another until the smiths themselves would stake their own trade's name on the set's honesty, and set the whole of it out for any trader on the carriers' roads to use, asking nothing for the use beyond the courtesy of returning the weights to their proper rack when the weighing was done.

It spread the way an honest thing spreads among people grown weary of dishonest ones: no ruling of any house sent it abroad, only traders themselves carrying word of it from market to market, until within Coinneach's own lifetime a thing weighed at Muileann chiar was spoken of on every stretch of the carriers' roads as weighed fairly, a phrase that outlived, in the plain's own mouth, every other thing the smiths of that town were known for. Coinneach, who governed no market and claimed no credit for the weights, said of them only, when a visiting Keeper of another house asked him how his own flame had managed so useful a thing, that the flame had managed nothing, that the smiths of Muileann chiar had managed it themselves out of their own weariness with liars, and that the plain would do well to remember, watching the weights spread unbidden from market to market, that not every good thing on it had needed a Keeper's hand to make it good.

VIII

Of the Marriage and the Double-Sworn Fields

The dark thread of Coinneach's own old age began, as such threads so often do, with a match that pleased everyone who arranged it. Torcall Donn, great-grandson of Eithne nic Ailein and a landed man of the lowland plain about Cathair mhòr, was five-and-eighty and long past the age most men on the plain married a second time, when he took to wife Muireall nic Ìomhair, a young kinswoman of the house of Ìomhar not yet four-and-twenty, in a match both houses spoke of afterward as having cost neither side anything and gained both a great deal: Torcall a young wife and heirs still to come of her, and Muireall's own kin a tie of blood into the line that held Cathair mhòr's great share, which no marriage before had managed. The wedding was held at Dùn dhearg, by Muireall's own family's wish, and Coinneach himself, though the match was no business of his flame, travelled down to bless it at the asking of both houses, and said afterward to no one in particular that he had rarely seen two houses so pleased with an arrangement that neither of them, strictly, needed.

Muireall died in her first winter as a wife, of a fever that took hold in the space of nine days and gave the physicians of Cathair mhòr no chance to do more than watch it run its course, and she left behind no child, only the lands that had come to her at her marriage and the lands she had brought into it, held under both a grant from the house of Ìomhar and a grant from the line of Eithne, as her marriage-portion had been sworn to satisfy both sides at once and had satisfied, in the drawing, no one's question of what should happen were she to die without an heir of her own body. Within the year, the house of Ìomhar claimed her lands as returning, on a childless death, to the kin that had granted them, and the line of Eithne claimed the same lands as passing, by the marriage, into the husband's holding and thence to his own kin at Cathair mhòr, and both claims were argued with equal heat and equal justice by men who had never troubled, while Muireall lived, to ask which grant would prevail should she die too soon, because no one had thought a woman not yet four-and-twenty would die too soon.

What began as an argument over a bride's portion did not stay an argument over a bride's portion. Within two years of Muireall's death, households on ground her marriage-portion had touched found themselves claimed by both houses at once, sworn, or made to swear, to Dùn dhearg on one hand and to Cathair mhòr on the other, and a holding sworn twice over was a holding neither side would leave standing for the other's use. The first of the double-sworn fields to burn belonged to a household that had held the same stretch of barley ground for four generations without either house troubling to ask it whose grant it lived

under, and the burning, when it came, came in a single night from men its own household could name by voice if not by face, the byre fired first and the standing barley after, so that by morning there was nothing left on that stretch worth either house's claiming. The household that had held it went, as the plunderers' households had once gone, down to whatever kin would have them, and the ground lay unsown the season after, claimed loudly by both houses and worked by neither, which those who saw it called a stranger sight than the fire had been: land that a house of Ìomhar's blood and a house of Eithne's blood both wanted badly enough to burn a neighbour for, and neither wanted enough to plant. The men who fired it were no strangers to the household that lost it, but its own near neighbours, men who had shared a boundary stone with the burned household the season before and would share nothing with it now but the smoke. Coinneach, growing old by then and troubled more by the burnings than by anything else two-and-sixty years of keeping had shown him, called it, the one time he was heard to name it plainly, the war neither house had declared and both houses were fighting, and said that a plain which had gone three centuries scarcely changing had found, in one woman's early death, a wound that changing might not close again in his own lifetime nor in the lifetime of whoever kept the flame after him.

I X

Of the Death of Coinneach Mòr

he died in his eighty-seventh year, in the month of the year's turning, in the small room off Talla na Lasrach¹ at Dùn ìseal where the Keepers slept, with the flame he had kept so steadily burning in its accustomed place not twenty paces from where he lay and the widow of the springs herself among those who sat the watch with him at the end. In his last days he asked after the walkers' list, whether it still said only who did not own each ruin and had not been made, in his absence, to say more, and was told that it stood as he had left it, and seemed satisfied with that answer beyond any other comfort offered him.

He asked, too, after the fields his own Keeping had failed to keep whole, and was told, because those who sat with him judged an old man's asking better answered than left to guess at, that three more holdings on the marriage lands had

1. the Hall of the Flame

burned that same season, the smoke of the nearest of them visible, on a still day, from the rise where the fence still stood about the stone at Cnoc bheag. A long silence answered that news, such as those who had known him through his whole keeping recognised as his particular way of receiving a thing he had no ruling left to give against, and he died before the season turned again, leaving the flame to whoever the four houses would choose after him and leaving the plain, in the words the rolls kept afterward of his going, exactly as reverent and exactly as centuries-still as he had found it, save for the smoke that stood, some mornings, on the horizon south of Dùn dhearg, where no smoke of that kind had stood in living memory before Muireall nic Ìomhair died too young to settle which of two houses her lands belonged to.

CHAPTER TWENTY

OF FEARGHAS OF THE TWO OATHS

FE 543 – 556

*The reapers of Achadh mhòr tell this at the end of harvest, when
the last sheaf is cut, and they cut it high.*

I

Of the House Sworn Twice

Achadh mhòr lay where the Red Share's stones ran out and Eithne's plain began, and no one now living could say which of the two had held it first, only that both had held it long enough to be sure of it. The fields ran flat and wide between the two boundary lines, the best grain ground on the island, and the house that farmed them had been sworn to both lords since before Fearghas's grandmother was a girl. It was Ciorstaidh who had made the double oath, not by any wish of her own: she had stood up at the Roinn among the seven hundred and twelve, had her knot cut through with the rest, and married after into a family already sworn to Dùn dhearg, so that her children answered to two halls at once and her grandson after them. Fearghas had heard the story of the cutting so many times as a boy, at so many hearths, that he could have told it himself in his grandmother's own words, down to the catch in her voice at the place where the knife went through.

By the year the reapers now reckon as the true beginning of his trouble, Fearghas was a hundred and seventy-one years old, which on the island of that century was old but not yet remarkable, and had held Achadh mhòr's granary fields alone

for longer than most men then living had been alive. He was called, and had been called since he was young enough to find it funny, Fearghas Dà-Mhionn, Fearghas of the Two Oaths, and for the better part of a hundred and fifty years the name had been a joke told at his own hearth as readily as at anyone else's. Twice a year, at the two greater cuttings, he sent a sheaf to Dùn dhearg and a sheaf to Cathair mhòr, each a little short of the full measure, measured on his own threshing-floor before both stewards' men so that neither steward could say he had been cheated more than the other. He used to say, when a stranger asked him how a man served two lords without being torn between them, that he had never yet met the lord who begrudged a short sheaf so long as his neighbour got no more, and that this was the whole of statecraft as he understood it. It got a laugh at Dùn dhearg and a laugh at Cathair mhòr both, which he counted, privately, as proof that he had struck the balance right.

He had a wife once, Beathag, who died young of a fever the healers at Muileann ruadh could not put a name to, and no children who lived past their first winter, so that by the year the reapers mean, the house at Achadh mhòr held only himself, his steward, and whatever hands the harvest needed hired in from the granaries round about. He kept a stone knife of his grandmother's on the lintel of the hall, the one she had carried after the Roinn and given him in his turn, since the knife that had cut her cord that day no one had kept, and he touched it going in and out of his own door the way another man might touch a charm, without troubling to say why.

The fields ran a good half-day's walk from stone to stone, east to west, longer than any granary holding on either side of the two shares, and a carrier coming up the east road with his basket could reckon he had reached Achadh mhòr a full morning before he reached the hall, so wide was the grain before any roof showed over it. Fearghas had walked every rod of it on foot at one time or another in a hundred and seventy years, first at his father's heel and then alone and then, in the last decades, with whichever steward the years had left him, and there was no boundary stone on either side, the Red Share's or Eithne's, that he could not have found blind by the shape of the ground underfoot. He knew, better than either hall that claimed him, exactly where his own oath ran out and the other's began, which was one reason, though not the only one, that neither Dùn dhearg nor Cathair mhòr had ever managed to catch him short on either sheaf.

Of the War Fought in Fits

The joke held for most of a hundred and fifty years because the two houses it named had no quarrel that Fearghas's short sheaves could not paper over.

It stopped holding the year a great-grandson of Eithne's, Torcall Donn, took to wife Muireall nic Ìomhair, of the line that held the Red Share, meaning the marriage to heal what the island still called, out of old habit, the strife of the heirs, though the Roinn that had begun it was by then five centuries gone and half forgotten outside the Hall's own rolls. Muireall died in her first winter at Cathair mhòr, of nothing anyone could point to, only the ordinary cruelty of a cold season on a woman not raised to it, and the lands she had brought to the marriage, three granges and a fishing-right on the Abhainn fhionn, were claimed at once by both houses: Cathair mhòr's, because the widower held them; the Red Share's, because Muireall had never sworn them away from her own line. Neither claim was new in its kind. What was new was that there were, by then, some hundreds of holdings across the island sworn to two lords the way Achadh mhòr was, households that had married and been given land and taken oaths without troubling, in quieter years, to notice that the oaths might one day pull in different directions, and every one of those hundreds of holdings now had to choose.

Fearghas watched it happen to his neighbours before it came near his own gate. The household two valleys east of Achadh mhòr, sworn the same double way, chose the Red Share within the first season, on no better reason than that the Red Share's steward asked first and asked more civilly, and Cathair mhòr's men burned it to the field-walls before the following harvest, taking the cattle and leaving the house standing empty and black-eaved as a warning to the next household asked to choose. A holding to the south, sworn the same way, tried the opposite course and chose neither, sending word to both halls that it would keep faith with whichever kept faith with it, and was burned within the year by both, first the Red Share's riders in a night raid that took the barn, and then, before the roof could be mended, a company out of Cathair mhòr that finished what the first had started, each host telling its own men it was only punishing what the other had already begun. Refugees from both kinds of burning came through Achadh mhòr on the road to wherever they still had kin, and Fearghas fed what he could of them from his own stores and asked no oath of any of them, since he judged,

and said so once to his steward, that a man burned out for choosing badly had paid enough already without being asked to choose again at another man's gate.

One family from the southern burning, a widow and three grown sons with nothing left to their name but a hand-barrow and a milking cow that had somehow been walked clear of the fire, stopped three nights at Achadh mhòr on their way to a sister's holding beyond Ceann leathan, and the widow, warming herself at Fearghas's own hearth on the second of those nights, asked him outright, with the bluntness of a woman who had already lost everything a lord could threaten to take, why a man sworn twice himself had never once been asked to choose the way her own household had. Fearghas told her, and it was the only time his steward ever heard him say it in so many words, that he supposed neither hall had yet reckoned Achadh mhòr's grain worth the burning, and that he had made his peace, long before she ever came to his door, with the year they finally did. The widow said nothing to that, only looked at him a while over the fire, and went on to Ceann leathan the next morning without asking him anything further.

Fearghas rode out himself, once, in the third year of the burnings, to the black-eaved holding two valleys east, not to claim it, for it was Cathair mhòr's men who had burned it and no lord of the Red Share's would have thanked him for standing on ground his own house had never held a right to, but only, as he told his steward before he went, to see with his own eyes what a double-sworn holding looked like once the choosing was done and paid for, since he judged a man ought to know the shape of the thing he might himself be asked to choose. He found the field-walls standing and the house gone to its foundations, the byre likewise, and an old dog still living about the ruin that would not be coaxed away from it though no one remained there to feed it, and he stood a long while at what had been the threshold, saying nothing to the steward who had ridden with him, before turning his horse back toward Achadh mhòr without once setting foot inside the walls themselves. It was after that ride, the steward said, that Fearghas stopped speaking of the war as something happening to other men's holdings, though it was three years more before anyone at either hall heard him speak of it as something that might happen to his own.

It went on that way in fits rather than as one war fought straight through, a burning in one valley followed by two quiet years and then a burning in another, because neither the Red Share nor Cathair mhòr had the strength any longer, five centuries and more after the Roinn had first cut the island into shares, to keep a host in the field for a whole season. The lines that had once stood up seven hun-

dred and twelve strong were down, by then, to a scattering of great-grandchildren holding what their forefathers had held whole and parting it further at every burial, and only the two strongest, the Red Share that Ìomhar's blood had never let be broken and Eithne's own plain, still had spears enough to call a muster worth the name. The island came to call it Cogadh an Dà Mhionn¹, the War of the Two Oaths, for Fearghas's own house before any other, since his was the oldest and best known of all the double-sworn houses, the one every teller reached for when the war wanted a name, though he himself had done nothing yet to earn it beyond going on sending his short sheaves and hoping, as he told no one but his steward, that the two hosts would exhaust each other on smaller holdings before either thought to reckon what a granary the size of Achadh mhòr's might be worth to whichever side finally took it whole.

III

Of Torcall Donn

Torcall Donn did not live to see how long the war he had made, without meaning to, would run. He was a hundred and eighteen years old, and had never in his life led men further than the boundary of his own fields, when the Red Share's riders caught his company on the road below Dùn thais in the fifth year of the burnings, going, by his own account afterward given to no one, only to see the granges his wife had brought him and judge for himself whether they were worth what both houses were spending to hold them. He was killed there, on the road and not in any hall, and his own steward, who survived it, said after that no one on either side had struck the first blow with any particular hatred, only that a company of the Red Share's riders had met a company of Cathair mhòr's on a narrow stretch of road neither would give way on, and that Torcall Donn had been in front when the pushing turned to something worse. Word of it reached Achadh mhòr within three days, carried by a granary carrier who had seen the bodies still on the road and would not eat at Fearghas's table until he had told it all, start to end, twice over.

Fearghas heard it out standing in his own doorway with his hand on his grandmother's knife, and said only, when the driver had finished, that a man dead on a

1. the War of the Two Oaths

road solved nothing that a man alive with a claim on land had not already made insoluble, since the lands Muireall had brought were no less claimed by both houses for her husband's death, and might now be claimed with less patience on either side, there being no one left living to argue that the marriage had ever been meant to end this way. He was right in it, as the years after bore out: the Red Share pressed its claim on the three granges harder once Torcall Donn was gone rather than less hard, judging, not wrongly, that Cathair mhòr's grip on lands it held only through a dead man's marriage was weaker than it had been while he lived, and Cathair mhòr held to its claim all the harder for the same reason, so that the war, which might have guttered out on Torcall Donn's death the way a fire sometimes dies with the man who lit it, instead burned on past it into holdings that had nothing to do with Muireall's dowry at all, Achadh mhòr's own among the number that both houses now began, for the first time in Fearghas's long life, to count aloud.

Torcall Donn's body was carried back to Cathair mhòr and buried there rather than sent to whatever Red Share ground his wife's people might have claimed for it, and it was said afterward, though Fearghas never repeated it as more than a saying he had heard, that Eithne's own hall kept his grave apart from the family ground for a season, as though even the dead of the marriage that had begun the war could not be let lie too near the living who still argued over what it had bought them. Fearghas sent no man to the burial, judging that a lord sworn to both houses had no honest place at a grave either side might read as taking sides merely by his standing near it, but he sent, by the same granary carrier who had first brought the news, a measure of Achadh mhòr's own barley to be burned at the graveside in Torcall Donn's name, the old rite for a man who had died before his harvest was in, and asked that no word go with it saying who had sent it. The carrier kept that silence rather less carefully than the mason later would keep his, so that within the season it too was known on both sides of the war, and read, as everything Fearghas did in those years came to be read, two different ways by two different hearths.

IV

Of Ciorstaidh's Stone

It was in the second year after Torcall Donn's death that Fearghas had his grandmother's stone cut and set into the wall of his own hall, a plain grey slab cut on its two faces with the signs of the two shares and, between them, the sign of the knot, the same sign the eleven had worn who had their cords cut through at the Roinn. He had put off doing it for a hundred years and more, telling his steward, when the man asked why, that a stone in a wall could not be unsaid the way a story at a hearth could, and that he had never been sure, until that year, what he wanted said permanently about a woman who had been sworn twice before he himself was ever sworn to anything. What decided him was neither grief nor age but the plain reckoning that the house he had inherited from her, along with her double oath, was now spoken of on both sides of a war as a prize rather than a farm, and that whichever host eventually took it, he wanted it known, cut in stone and not merely told, that the man who had held it last had held it from a woman who had cut her own cord at the Roinn and answered for it all her life without once choosing a side to betray the other.

The stone-cutter who came up from Muileann chiar to do the work said afterward, to whoever would listen, that he had cut a hundred memorial stones in his time and never one where the man who ordered it stood over his shoulder the whole day watching every stroke of the chisel, as though he feared the mason might carve some sign into the grain of it that was not true. Fearghas paid him double the going rate and asked him to say nothing of the day's work at Dùn dhearg or at Cathair mhòr, a request the mason kept for exactly as long as it took him to reach the next market, where the setting of Ciorstaidh's stone became, within a season, one more thing the tellers on both sides of the war repeated of Fearghas Dà-Mhionn, some saying it proved he still meant to hold for both houses to the end, and others saying, more shrewdly, that a man who set his grandmother's memory in stone before deciding anything else was a man already reckoning how he wished to be remembered, which was not the same thing as reckoning how he meant to act.

V

Of the Hosts Called Out

The word that both hosts were finally on the road for Achadh mhòr came to Fearghas in the heat of Lùnastal, six years after the stone was set, carried by

two riders arriving within an hour of each other, one from the east swearing that the Red Share's council had that week resolved to take the granary whole rather than go on arguing its worth in councils that settled nothing, one from the west swearing the same of Cathair mhòr, each rider plainly astonished to find, on arrival, that his own lord's host was not the first to move. Fearghas was a hundred and eighty-four years old that Lùnastal, and had outlived his wife, both his children, his grandmother, and every steward who had served him before the one now standing at his shoulder, and he heard the two riders out in the yard, one after the other, with no more visible feeling than he had shown at any of the burnings two valleys off, though his steward, who had served him eleven years by then and thought he knew the shape of the man's silences, said afterward that this one had a different weight to it.

The steward had asked, when the second rider's dust was still settling in the yard, whether word should go to the granaries round about so that the smaller households might carry off what stores they could before either host arrived, a question any steward of thirty years' less service might have asked out of plain decency, and Fearghas had answered only that word had best go instead to the reapers still working the western strips, to finish the cutting they were on before they thought about anything else, an answer the steward found so strange coming from a man who had fed every burned-out household on the road for six years that he did not know, telling it afterward, whether to set it down to age, to grief he had not shown, or to some reckoning the old man had already made and not yet spoken.

The barley that year stood ripe to the edge of the sky, the best crop Achadh mhòr had raised in a decade of uneven summers, heavy-headed and dry after a summer with almost no rain in it, the kind of harvest a granary saw perhaps once in a generation and long remembered for it, and Fearghas walked out into it that evening with his steward a pace behind him, the way he had walked his fields every harvest evening of his long life, and ran his hand along the heads of grain as he went the way another man might run a hand along a horse's neck, an old habit he had never broken himself of, though his eyes could see well enough on their own by then what his hand was telling him. He looked east first, to where a low haze of dust hung over the road that came down from the Red Share, too far off yet to show men or spears but unmistakable to anyone who had watched such roads for six years running, and then west, to where a second haze, thicker and nearer, showed that Cathair mhòr's host had the shorter way to come and meant

to use it. Neither haze had yet crossed a boundary stone, and by the steward's own reckoning there was the best part of a day left before either host could reach the fields at all, time enough, he thought, for the two of them to talk over what might yet be done, and he was already turning over in his mind which of the two halls a rider might be sent to first when Fearghas spoke.

"Whichever I feed, the other burns me," he said, not loudly, and not as a question, so that his steward, who had half expected to be asked which host stood the better chance, understood only afterward that the old man had not been asking anything at all. "I've sworn to both of them." He was quiet a moment, still looking west, where the dust was nearer than the east's. "Let them both have it."

The steward said afterward that he took the words at first for a bitter kind of surrender, a lord too old and too tired to fight either claim any longer allowing that whichever host arrived first might simply take what it liked, and he answered Fearghas in that understanding, saying that a rider sent now to Dùn dhearg, or failing that to Cathair mhòr, might yet buy the granary a season's grace while the two halls argued the matter between themselves as they had argued the three granges for forty years without once coming to blows over Achadh mhòr. Fearghas heard him out and shook his head, once, and said that forty years of argument over three granges had already cost more burned households than either hall would trouble to count, and that he did not mean to add Achadh mhòr's own people to that number waiting on a season's grace that would only be spent arguing the next season's instead. He asked, then, whether the last strip in the western field had been cut, and being told it had not, said that it should be, that evening, before dark, the same as any ordinary harvest evening the two of them had ever kept together.

VI

Of the Last Sheaf and the Smoke

The reapers had already begun the last cutting that week, working the western fields first as the custom of Achadh mhòr had always run, and it was among them, not in the hall, that Fearghas walked next, asking which sheaf stood ready to be cut last and highest, the honour every harvest gave to whichever binder's hands were steadiest at the end of a long day, and telling the reapers, when they showed him, to cut it as they always had and carry it in to the hall as

they always had, war or no war on the road. Some tellings since have made more of that evening than the steward himself ever claimed for it, saying Fearghas told the reapers plainly what he meant to do with their harvest before he did it, but the steward's own account, given many times over at hearths from Achadh mhòr to Muileann chiar, says only that the old man watched the last sheaf cut and bound, said nothing of fire to any reaper living, and walked back to the hall alone once the dark had properly come down, leaving the reapers to carry the last sheaf in behind him not knowing it would be the last thing carried into that hall whole.

He took the torch himself from the hearth inside, not sending steward or reaper to do it, and walked the bounds of his own fields lighting the standing barley from the eastern boundary stones, the Red Share's own markers, clear across to the western ones that marked Cathair mhòr's edge, so that by the time either host came over the rises that bordered the valley there was nothing left standing for a rider to see but smoke going up in one long sheet from stone to stone. He walked slowly, the steward said, not as a man in any haste to be done, stopping twice to catch his breath the way a man of a hundred and eighty-four years must, and laying the torch to each new stretch of standing grain with the same unhurried care he had once given to the reaping, as though a field fired badly might somehow be fired again more honestly. The barley took at once, dry as it was after a rainless summer, and ran ahead of him faster than an old man could walk, so that by the time he reached the western stones the eastern ones were already lost behind a wall of smoke he did not look back to see.

The fire took the field-walls and the drying-barns and, before any hand thought to stop it or any hand any longer wished to, the steadings themselves, running up from the fields to the hall on a wind that had stood fair for burning all that dry summer, so that the hall Ciorstaidh's stone stood in was already alight by the time the first riders of either host crested their rise and understood, each separately and each too late to matter, what the dust of the other host had been racing toward all along. The reapers who had cut the last sheaf that same evening carried it clear of the burning before the wind turned, and it was that sheaf, and not the granary it came from, that the households round about kept afterward and still keep, cutting a new one high at the end of every harvest since in the field-strips that grew back green the following spring, on ground that had been ash the autumn before.

Fearghas went back into the hall while it burned and shut the door behind him, and did not come out again, and no one who was there that night, reaper or

steward, ever gave an account of trying to stop him or of being asked to. His steward said only that he had followed the old man as far as the threshold and been told, in the same voice that had said *let them both have it*, to go and see the reapers safe on the road to Muileann chiar, and that he had gone, and that by the time he judged it safe to look back the hall's roof had already fallen in on itself, and no door remained for anyone to have opened even had they wished to.

The Red Share's host came over the eastern rise first that evening and found the barley already ash to the middle distance; Cathair mhòr's host, coming over the western rise not an hour behind them, found the same, and both hosts, meeting at last on ground that had cost neither of them a spear thrown, stood on the black stubble in the last of that evening's light with nothing between them any longer worth fighting for, looking down at Achadh mhòr's smoke going up straight in the windless dusk, and finding, when each looked for the granary they had marched to take, only more of it. Neither host stayed the night on that ground. The Red Share's riders turned east again before full dark, and Cathair mhòr's before the last light was gone from the sky, each company going home to a hall that had spent six years and more arguing over a prize that had put itself beyond either of their reaching in a single evening, and it was said after, on both sides, that no rider of either host ever cared to say aloud which of the two hosts had arrived the first.

The reapers came back the following spring to strips gone black and then, within two seasons, green again, since fire does a granary field less lasting harm than it does a hall or a house, and they cut their harvest there for generations on ground that had once been sworn twice and was sworn, after that Lùnastal, to no one living. Fearghas Dà-Mhionn had lived a hundred and eighty-four years, sworn for a hundred and fifty of them to two lords at once, and was remembered on both sides of the shares he had refused, in the end, to choose between, though never, on either side, with quite the same story of why. It is the reapers' own telling, not the Hall's roll nor either lord's tellers, that has lasted longest: that a man who could not feed two masters honestly chose to feed neither, and that the last sheaf of Achadh mhòr is still cut high at every harvest's end for the sake of the one that was carried clear of the fire the year the fields answered, at last, to no oath but the reaping.

Of the Peace of the Threshold

FE 556

Niall Òg told this at more hearths than any other tale of his long life, and he always ended it the same way: "I have carried a great many things up that path. That was the heaviest, and she weighed nothing at all."

I

Of the Hungry Winter

The smoke of Achadh mhòr had not gone out of the sky before the middle of the island understood what it had lost. The two hosts that came home from the burned fields that Lùnastal brought back no grain, for there had been none to bring, and every granary between Dùn dhearg and Cathair mhòr that had counted on Fearghas's short sheaves to see it through the dark months now counted its own stores twice and found them wanting both times. The Red Share's granaries were full enough from the east, but the east had spent forty years feeding a war and had little to spare beyond its own households, and Cathair mhòr's plain, which grew less grain than it ate even in a fat year, had leaned on Achadh mhòr's harvest longer than anyone at either hall had cared to say aloud.

By the turn of the year the households of the middle plain were boiling bark with their oats to make the sacks last, and the waypoint-keepers on the road between the two shares had begun to ask carriers for news of grain before they asked for news of anything else. Old men said it was the worst want since the rev-

erent centuries, when the same measure had been mined and burned generation after generation and nobody had thought to ask whether it was still enough for the mouths it fed. Younger men, who had grown up knowing nothing but the burnings, said only that a war fought over granary fields had done what neither side's spears could, and burned the granary itself.

The Hall's own rolls, kept on the knot-keepers' cords since Sine nan Snaidhm's day, counted that winter's dead among the dead of the war, not apart from them, for the cold took the old and the very young in numbers no one troubled to count separately from the numbers the burnings had already cost, and there was no one left with the heart to draw so fine a line between a death by the sword and a death by an empty sack. Those who lived through it gave it a plain name and kept to it afterward: the hungry winter, said the same way in every hearth between Dùn dhearg and Cathair mhòr, and no other name was ever offered for it.

At the waypoint house on the road below Muileann chiar, where carriers had once asked first for news of the war, the keeper that season began asking first for news of grain, and kept a slate by his door on which he chalked, and rubbed out, and chalked again, which granaries along the road still had anything to sell and at what the toll-house on either side would let it pass for. A household two days' walk from Achadh mhòr's black fields sent its youngest son round every kinsman it had, near and distant, sworn or unsworn to either share, asking only for seed corn and not for grain to eat, on the reckoning that a family that ate its seed that winter would have nothing to sow when the ground opened again; and it is remembered, in that country, that the boy came home with less seed than he asked for but more than he had feared, gathered a handful at a time from households no better off than his own. It was the kind of winter, the old at Cathair mhòr said afterward, in which a neighbour's door mattered more than either lord's, and in which a good many people who had spent forty years choosing between two halls learned, in a single cold season, how little either hall could do for them once the choosing was over.

II

Of the Call to the Threshold

It was Ruairidh Glas who sent the first word. He held the Red Share at Dùn dhearg by then, an old man himself, though nothing to the age of the woman he was sending to, and the word his runner carried to Cathair mhòr was short: that a war fought for a granary which no longer stood profited no one, that his own people were as hungry as hers, and that he would meet her to say so, if she would name a place neither hall need be ashamed to walk from.

Eithne sent back that she set foot in no hall of the Red Share's, as he set foot in none of hers, and that this had been true since before either of them held anything, and was not like to stop being true now. But she named a place all the same, by the same runner, who had to say it back to her twice before she would let him go. There was ground on the island that belonged to no share and never had, ground that every line of the old heirs had sworn to on the same day, before any of them had learned to hate the others: the threshold of Talla na Lasrach¹ at Dùn ìseal, where the stone cup stood, and where seven hundred and twelve of them, in another age, had agreed on nothing except that the vein under the hill should belong to none of them. If the lords of the shares could not go under one another's roofs, she sent, let them stand under no roof at all.

Ruairidh Glas agreed to it, and so, in the weeks after, did every lord and lady left holding a share worth calling one: the Red Share out of Dùn dhearg; Cathair mhòr's plain under Eithne; the lesser holdings that had come through the burnings still whole, whose lords had watched the war from the edges and had no wish to be caught in the next one; and the double-sworn, those hundreds of households that had chosen a side, or refused to, and been burned by one or both for it, whose headmen came to Dùn ìseal with nothing left to lose by standing on ground that owed allegiance to neither of the powers that had ruined them.

Not every lord who was asked came willingly. The steward of one of the lesser holdings north of Achadh mhòr sent back word that his lord saw no profit in standing bareheaded before an old woman and an older man to be told what he already knew, that a burned field feeds nobody; and Eithne, when the answer was brought to her, said only that the man could stand at home then, and explain to his own hungry households why the peace that fed everyone else's had passed his door by. He came, in the end, with the rest, a season later than the first runners, and swore the same words as any other, and no one at the threshold troubled to remind him aloud that he had once thought better of it.

1. the Hall of the Flame

The day set was Samhain, the dark of the year, when every hearth on the island burned its own small handful and remembered the night the seven hundred and twelve had first sworn the Binding. It was the Keeper who pressed for that day above any other, arguing to both halls, by runners whose words Eithne and Ruairidh Glas each repeated afterward in much the same form, that a peace sworn on the one night every household on the island already kept the same rite would need no explaining to the households themselves; they would understand it the way they understood their own hearths, without a herald's telling. No one troubled to say aloud that this was also the night the Binding itself had first been sworn, on that same hill, by heirs who had agreed on nothing but that the vein should belong to none of them. It did not need saying, and by the time the runners had gone the length of the island and back, everyone who mattered to the swearing had worked it out for themselves.

III

Of the Carrying of Eithne

She had ridden to Dùn ìseal once before, in the first year of the Roinn, on her own feet and at her own pace, quick and sharp and impatient of the ceremony that had kept seven hundred and twelve heirs sitting in a gathering-house through a whole winter and the summer after it. She did not ride there now. Her legs, which had carried her the length and breadth of the plain for the better part of two thousand years, had stopped carrying her some decades before, quietly, the way a well runs low before it runs dry, and she had accepted the chair the way she accepted most things by then, without complaint and without pretending it was anything other than what it was.

Two of her household carried the poles, one at the front and one at the behind, and the one at the front was Niall Òg. He had come to Cathair mhòr a season before, as he did most seasons by then, for he had outlived nearly everyone else who remembered the valley under Dùn ìseal in the days the tents stood there, and Eithne was one of the last who could still finish his own stories for him when his memory faltered on a name. He was some fourteen hundred and fifty years old that winter, a grandson of Ailean beside a daughter, and young enough beside her that she still called him the boy, as she had at the Roinn, though his own hair had long since gone the colour of hers.

"You could have sent a chair-man," she said to him, on the second day of the climb up from the plain, when the path had begun to steepen toward the hill. "You could have sent two chair-men and stayed by your own fire."

"I could have," Niall Òg said, and did not slow his pace, and did not answer the rest of it, because they both knew the rest of it, and neither of them had ever found much use in saying aloud what a silence already carried.

They went by the old carriers' road rather than the shorter track over the hill-shoulder, for a chair could keep the road where it could not keep the track, and the going was slow enough in any case that the second bearer, a grandson of one of Eithne's own household some three generations removed and young enough beside the other two that neither of them thought to ask his opinion of anything, had time to point out to her, at every mile, some boundary stone or byre or burned strip of ground he judged she might not have seen from a chair before. She had seen most of it a great many times, from a horse and from her own two feet, in centuries he had no memory of and no grandmother old enough to have told him of either, and she let him point it out to her all the same, because a young man's pleasure in showing an old woman his own country cost her nothing and seemed, on a road with so little else to recommend it, worth the having.

At the first night's stopping-place, a waypoint house on the old road where the keeper turned out half his own stores to feed a party he had not been told to expect, Niall Òg sat by her fire after the household had gone to their own beds and asked her, as he had not troubled to ask in some decades, whether she remembered the valley under Dùn ìseal the first time, when the tents had stood there and the cord had not yet been tied. She said that she remembered the smell of it before anything else, woodsmoke and wet canvas and something under both that she had never found a word for and had stopped trying to, and that she remembered Murchadh's voice before she remembered his face, a door on a cold hinge, he had, and had kept it to the end of his own long life. Niall Òg said that he remembered being called a boy for the first time in his life at that gathering, by men younger than his own father who had somehow contrived to be older than he was in years the island still counted, and that it had taken him the better part of nine hundred years to stop minding it and rather longer than that to be glad of it, since every one of the men who had called him it was dead now, and he was not.

"You are not a boy," Eithne said. "You are the last man on this island who remembers what I remember, and when I am gone you will be the only one, and there is nothing boyish left in that."

He said nothing to that for a while, and mended the fire instead, and when he spoke again it was only to ask whether she wanted another blanket against the cold, which she took as his own way of not saying aloud what her silence, in its turn, had already told him.

She watched the country go by from the chair, the burned black stretch where Achadh mhòr had stood still bare between the rebuilt eastern boundary and the rebuilt western, the boundary stones of a hundred small holdings along the road, cut with the marks of shares that were no longer as whole as they had been when the marks were first struck. Two thousand four hundred and fifty-five years she had lived by then, more than any soul then living on the island, and she had watched every one of those stones go up, and the wars that moved them, and she thought, watching the road unwind behind her, that she was tired in a way sleep did not answer, and that she meant this to be the last long road she asked her own legs, or anyone else's, to walk for her sake.

She said none of that to Niall Òg. She had never been a woman who told a man behind her what she was thinking before she had decided what to do about it, and she had not changed that habit for dying, any more than she meant to change it for living a while longer yet.

IV

Of the Swearing

They came up to the hill of Dùn ìseal on the evening before Samhain, and found the stones before Talla na Lasrach¹ already crowded, for word of the meeting had run ahead of every party that came to keep it, and no lord wished to be the last to arrive at a peace he had asked for himself. Ruairidh Glas was there before her, an old man in a plain cloak with no more men about him than courtesy required, and when her chair was set down he came across the stones himself, without waiting to be sent for, and gave her his arm to stand on, which she took, because her own legs by then needed it and there was no profit in pretending otherwise in front of the one man on the island old enough to remember why they had once been enemies.

"I have not stood this close to you since the ford," he said. He did not say which ford. There had been more than one in their two long lives, but she knew,

because she had asked him once, decades before this, whether he still thought of the boy he had killed at Dùn thais, and he had said that he thought of little else on a cold morning, and had never asked her not to mention it again, which she had taken, from a man of his kind, for as near to an invitation as he was able to give.

"Nor I you," she said. "It has taken a burned granary to do it."

"Less than that, in the end," he said. "A winter with nothing in the sacks did it. I have buried more of my own people to this last hunger than to forty years of war, and I expect you can say the same of yours."

She could, and told him so, and they said nothing further to each other that evening, for there was a Keeper to greet, and lesser lords waiting their turn to be seen greeting the two eldest, and the ordinary business of a great meeting that neither of them, after so many centuries of great meetings, had any taste left for hurrying.

The Keeper that year was neither of the two names the Hall's own roll remembers best from either side of her, an office between offices, holding the flame in the years after Coinneach Mòr and before the woman who would take it from her; but she held the stone cup at her feet all the same, as every Keeper before and since had held it, and when the lords of the shares gathered on the stones the next morning, in the grey light before Samhain's dark truly closed on the day, it was she who set it down on the worn sill of Talla na Lasrach's threshold and stood back from it, so that no one might say the Hall itself had asked for anything from either side.

She had shaped the terms herself, at both halls' asking, for neither Eithne nor Ruairidh Glas had trusted the other's stewards to shape them and neither trusted his own stewards not to shape them a little in his own favour; and it was the Keeper who said them aloud to the gathered stones before any lord was asked to swear to a word of them, so that the crowd standing back beyond the lords themselves, headmen and stewards and a good many households who had walked up from the plain on no better claim than curiosity and hunger for news, might hear the whole of it plainly and carry it home in their own words rather than whatever a lord's own steward chose to tell them afterward. She said them slowly, in the flat voice the office asked of her rather than any voice of her own, and the crowd was quiet enough, in the cold of that morning, that a man at the back of it said after-

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ward he had heard every word of it clear across the stones, though he stood further from the threshold than any lord standing to swear.

Eithne swore first. It had been agreed beforehand, by nobody's authority but the plain fact that she was the last living of the nine who had cut the cord at the Roinn, and no one at the gathering, not even Murchadh's own great-grandsons who still held the northern share in his name, thought to dispute it. She came forward on Niall Òg's arm rather than the chair, for she judged, and said so afterward to no one but him, that a peace sworn from a chair looked too much like an old woman being carried to her grave, and she meant this peace, if it held, to look like something a living woman had chosen. She laid her palm across the cup's mouth, as the custom asked, and said the words that had been agreed among the lords in the weeks before: that no share should be parted again at a lord's death, but pass whole to one heir named while the lord yet lived, or, failing a name, to whoever the Keeper judged nearest and fittest; that no household should hold an oath to two lords, and any that did should give up one of the two before the spring sowing; and that the boundary stones should stand where they stood that morning, on every share and every holding, and whoever moved one after should answer for it at Dùn ìseal.

Ruairidh Glas swore next, and where Eithne had said the words plainly and been done, he stood a moment longer with his hand still on the cup after the words were out, and said one thing more of his own, which no one had agreed beforehand and no one afterward thought to strike from the telling: "I shed the first blood of this at Dùn thais, over cattle on a wet slope, when I was young enough to think a stone worth a life. I am old enough now to know what I bought with it, and I would not buy it again for twice the grazing on the island." He took his hand from the cup, and no one answered him, for there was nothing owed in answer, and the lords who came after him to swear, one by one down the line of the shares, great and small, said only the words that had been agreed, until the sun that had barely cleared the eastern ridge when Eithne began was well up and warm on the stones by the time the last of the double-sworn headmen had sworn his own turn and stepped back.

So, on the day the island still calls Sìth an Stairsnich², the Peace of the Threshold, the lords of the shares ended Aimhreit nan Oighrean³, the strife of the heirs, some five hundred and fifty years after Ruairidh Glas's spear had gone into

2. the Peace of the Threshold

3. the Strife of the Heirs

Aonghas Bàn on the wet slope above Dùn thais. No one who stood on the stones that morning troubled to reckon the years aloud. It was Niall Òg, telling it afterward at his own hearth and at every other that would have him, who did the reckoning, and who first said the number to anyone who had not already worked it out for themselves.

V

Of the Double-Sworn

The clause that had already remade the shape of the island, holding a share whole from one lord's death to the next heir's swearing, cost the shares themselves the least grief that winter. The clause that cost the most was the plainer one, that no household should answer to two lords, and that whoever did must choose before the spring. There were still some hundreds of such households scattered along the old boundary lines, most of them families who had married across a share's edge two or three generations back and never thought the double oath worth troubling over until the burnings taught them otherwise, and every one of them now had a winter to decide which hall it would keep faith with and which it would let go.

Some chose the way Achadh mhòr's neighbours had chosen years before, for the same reasons: nearness, an old debt of kindness, a steward who asked civilly rather than one who threatened. Others chose against their own nearest interest, out of a grief that was still raw enough to want no further dealing with whichever hall's riders had done the burning in their own valley, whatever the cost of refusing it. A few, it is told, chose by no reckoning at all, but by a knucklebone thrown at the hearth on the night before the deadline, judging, as one such headman is remembered saying, that a knucklebone at least bore no grudge and asked for no bribe, which was more than either hall's steward could truthfully claim.

One such household, a holding on the old boundary a half-day's walk east of Achadh mhòr's black fields, had been sworn twice since a grandmother's grandmother's marriage, and its headman that winter sat by his own hearth three nights running, saying nothing to his wife or his grown sons beyond that he was thinking, until the eldest son, who had lost a brother to the burnings and had no patience left for his father's thinking, asked him outright which hall had ever once sent grain to their door in the whole of the hungry winter just past. The old man

said neither had, and the son said that this, then, was the whole of the answer, and by the son's own account, given many years after at his own hearth in his turn, that was the reckoning that decided it: the plain memory of which door nobody's carrier had knocked on when the sacks ran low. The household kept the oath that had cost it least, and let the other go before the first thaw, and was neither the first nor the last on the island to reckon its loyalty that way that winter.

What none of them did, that whole winter, was burn a neighbour's roof for choosing wrong. The Peace held that first test better than either the lords who had sworn it or the households bound by it had quite dared to expect, and by the time the spring sowing came the boundary lines that had shifted and blurred through forty years of burning had settled again into a shape that would hold, with only small mendings, for longer than any lord who swore that Samhain morning would live to see.

VI

Of the First Market

In the spring after the Peace, the Hall at Dùn iséal opened its ground under Talla na Lasrach¹ to a market on the four quarter days, Samhain, Là Fhèill Brìde, Bealltainn and Lùnastal, when the households of the eastern hills came up to pay their dues and found, waiting for them under the Hall's own shadow, traders from both the shares that had so lately burned each other's granaries, laying out hides and venison and charcoal and the silversmiths' new weights from Muileann chiar side by side on the same trampled grass. The first of those markets was a thin one, for the hungry winter had left little enough to trade, and more than one household came up the hill with nothing to sell and stood about the edges only to watch whether a trader of the Red Share and a trader of Cathair mhòr's plain could truly stand at the same stall without a steward from either hall coming to part them. None came. The Keepers allowed no coal to be sold on the Hall's own ground, then or ever after, and none was; but everything else the island grew or made or dug changed hands there on the fair weights, and by the third quarter day the households who had only watched the first were bringing their own baskets, and within a few years no one thought it worth remarking that

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a trader of one share should haggle over the same measure of hides with a trader of the other within a spear's throw of the cup that had lately parted their two hosts.

Eithne lived to be carried up the hill to a great many more of those markets than her household thought wise; Ruairidh Glas did not, whose own years, long as they were beside any ordinary man's, ran out within two generations of the swearing. But the stones they had sworn to leave standing stood, boundary after boundary, along every road a carrier walked between the shares, cut with the marks of lines that had once counted their honour in spears and now counted it, more quietly, in whether a stone had moved. In time the carriers who passed them going to and from the quarter-day market stopped troubling to read the signs cut on their faces at all, for the stones had stood so long, and the peace they marked had held so plainly, that a boundary no longer needed reading to be believed.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Of the Truce in the Galleries and the Walled Town

FE 557 – 634

I

Of the Rolls that Fill

In the years after the Peace of the Threshold the rolls at Dùn ìseal began to fill the way a field fills with barley once the birds have had their share of it and stopped coming: slowly, unevenly, season on season, until a shelf that had held a handful of notched sticks and a coil or two of knotted cord held more than any one knot-keeper could carry in both arms. The knot-keepers of Sìne's line were still the ones who kept it, cord and notch and nothing else, as their mothers and grandmothers had kept it since the Roinn; and the cords themselves had begun to multiply past what any hand could hold at once, one for every share, one for every boundary stone the Peace had fixed, one for every household that came up the mountain at the quarter days to swear an oath or settle a debt or ask the Keeper's word on a matter no lord below would touch. The island was at peace, and a peace, it turned out, made more work for a clerk than a war ever had, for a war at least had the grace to burn its own tally along with everything else it touched.

Seonaid Chiar was born into this fatter, quieter island in the year the reapers of the low country still reckoned by the last burning, though by the time she was old enough to reckon anything herself the burned fields of Achadh mhòr had long since greened over and the boundary stones the Peace had fixed stood as un-

remarkable as any others. She came of the house of Muireach, Sliochd Mhuirich¹, the one house among the four of custody that held no drop of the king's blood and had never claimed to, and she grew up on the mountain's own ground, among the nine hearths, with the smell of the galleries in her clothes before she had any clear notion of what lay under the mountain or why her grandmother's hands were always faintly grey at the knuckle no matter how often they were washed.

She was some six-and-twenty years old, by her own house's reckoning, when the nine hearths raised her to the flame; a young Keeper by any measure the office had known since Muireach Liath's own day, and younger than several of the cutters she would spend her first years learning to judge fairly. In those first years she held the cup the way a new-married woman holds a house not yet her own, carefully, and with an eye always on how the last Keeper before her would have done a thing, until enough seasons had passed under her own hand that she stopped asking herself the question and simply did what seemed right, which is, by most tellings, the mark of a Keeper who has finally grown into the office rather than merely into the name of it.

Her own grandmother, who had cut coal at Dùn ìseal all her working life and never once expected to see a grandchild raised above the galleries she had spent her back on, told her, the night the nine hearths' word came down, that a young Keeper's first year was worth two of any other, because a young Keeper is watched by every hearth in the Hall to see whether she will bend to the first steward who flatters her or the first lord who frowns, and that a Keeper who bends once in her first year is asked to bend again for the rest of her keeping. Seonaid took the warning to heart, and it is said of her, by cutters old enough to have served under her from the first season, that she never once in six decades gave a different answer to the same question asked twice, however many years apart the asking fell, which her own knot-keepers came in time to reckon the surest mark of her rule.

II

Of the Stag's People at Cnoc bhàn

1. the house of Muireach

It was in the third year of her keeping, some nine-and-twenty years old by the reckoning her own house kept for her, that the matter of the stag's people came to the door of Talla na Lasrach¹ and would not be turned away by silence, as it had been turned away by every Keeper before her since Gormshuil nic Mhuirich first shut the galleries against them.

The stag's people, newly housed at Cnoc bhàn north of the mountain, had grown in the generations of the shutting-out rather than withered, as the Hall had perhaps hoped it would. Its teachers still kept the question Sileas nic Coinnich had left them at the far-eastern grove, generations before, unanswered and unforgotten: why the coal answered its colours to one hand and not to another, and whether the vein knew the difference between a cutter born to the galleries and one merely trained to them. They had not found an answer the Hall would accept, nor, in truth, had they found one they were wholly satisfied with themselves; but they had gone on teaching all the same, and their own cutters, barred from Dùn ìseal, had found work at Cnoc bhàn's own small seams and at Muileann chiar's silver, and the school had not starved for it.

Seonaid received their asking through three old men who climbed the mountain road on foot, in autumn, with nothing in their hands but a single lamp, which they set down unlit on the stones before the Hall's door as a sign that they had come to ask a flame and not to bring one of their own to compare against it.

"We do not ask to be believed," the eldest of the three said, when she had come out to them herself rather than send a steward, which the Hall had not troubled to do for the school in living memory. "We ask only to be let back among the cutters who are already there. Let the question stay a question. We will not ask it of the vein aloud, if the Hall will only stop asking us, aloud, whether we have any right to stand near it at all."

She thought on it through that winter, and took counsel of no one but her own galleries, walking them at odd hours with a lamp of her own until she had satisfied herself that the objection she had inherited from every Keeper before her — that a cutter trained outside the nine hearths might work some harm on the vein that a cutter born to it would not — was an objection she had never once seen answered with anything better than the fact that it had always been made. On 26 an Gearran, FE 574, she let the school's cutters back into the galleries, sworn, every one of them, to ask nothing of the vein aloud in the Hall's own hear-

1. the Hall of the Flame

ing, whatever they went on asking of it among themselves at Cnoc bhàn. The Hall's own roll, in the dry words of whichever knot-keeper was set to keep it that season, calls the day a reconciling. The school, from that day to this, has never called it anything but a truce, and Seonaid, hearing both words used of the same morning in the same week, said only that she did not much mind which word a man chose, so long as the cutters kept the oath under either one.

The first of them to cross the gallery door again was an old man of the school whose teachers' teachers had been shut out by Gormshuil, and had spent the better part of his own long working life at Muileann chiar's silver seams believing he would die there without ever seeing the vein his own teachers had spent three generations arguing over. He stood a long while in the mouth of the gallery before he went in, by every account that survives of that morning, and said nothing to the cutters of the nine hearths who stood back to let him pass, and they said nothing to him, and it was, in its way, as full a truce as any words could have made it.

III

Of the Island Filling Out

The rolls that came up to Dùn ìseal in Seonaid's years told of an island growing steadier than it had been in the five centuries since the Roinn, though no single teller then living could have said, from any one report, quite how much the whole had changed.

Cathair mhòr, on the southern coast, raised a wall of fitted stone about its own headland in those years, the first wall of its kind the island had ever built, and would not say, then or afterward, what it had raised the wall against. The reapers of Achadh mhòr, when anyone asked them, said only that the town had not forgotten the smoke, and left it at that, for the burning of the great granary fields was still near enough in living memory that no one much doubted them, and far enough that no one troubled to ask Cathair mhòr's own people to confirm it. Ceann leathan, on the southern fishing grounds, grew fat on dried fish sent inland along the carriers' roads, and its harbour-master began keeping tallies on notched sticks, among the oldest counted things kept anywhere on the island; the man who cut the first of them, it is told, was no scholar and no clerk, only a fisherman's son who had grown tired of arguing with buyers over how many baskets a

boat had brought in, and had found that a stick with a notch for every basket argued better than he could.

At Inis thais, on the western coast, a shrine was raised to the ancestors the sea had taken and never given back, and its keepers burned their season's handful on the open shore rather than under any roof, so that the drowned, gone west over the water, might see the flame from wherever the sea had carried them. Cuan shean, further up that same coast, dug salt-pans on the flats below the town and boiled the sea over peat fires that burned day and night through the drying months, and sent its salt inland on the western road until it kept the fish of half the island through the long storm season; and where the road from Cuan shean crossed the heath above Baile fhiadhaich, a scatter of salt-carriers settled by a stream that ran the summer through, on ground too poor for the plough, and kept goats there ever after, by every account that has come down of them.

On the eastern road, where the carriers out of Cnoc leathan met the southern coast path, a waypoint house was built on ground already known for its warmth, and took the name the ground had always had, An Taigh-òsta Grianach¹, the sunny house; its own builders, asked afterward why they had chosen that stretch of road over a dozen others no less convenient, said only that a house ought to be built where the sun already liked to stand, and that this was reason enough. Cnoc leathan itself, at the road's eastern end, grew into the market town of the whole south-eastern hill country, and its carriers bound themselves into a guild that held, by the Hall's own grant, the sole right to carry for the Hall on the stretch of road down to the coast, a right its members guarded, in the years that followed, with rather more jealousy than the road itself was worth to anyone who had not grown up walking it.

Seonaid heard all this, in her years at Dùn ìseal, from the tallies and the tellings the waypoint-keepers and the harbour-masters sent up the mountain each quarter day, more of them each year than the year before, until she found herself saying to her own knot-keepers, more than once, that she had come to know the shape of towns she had never set foot in better than she knew the shape of her own galleries' further reaches, which she had likewise never had cause to walk to their very end. It was, she said once, at her own hearth and not for any roll to record, a strange thing to rule an island chiefly through the reports of men who had

1. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

never once seen her face; and stranger still, she added, that it seemed to trouble the island rather less than it troubled her.

The guild at Cnoc leathan brought its own quarrel to her door in the fourteenth year of her keeping, when two of its own carriers came up the mountain, each swearing the other had carried a load down to the coast road out of turn and taken the fee for it, and each demanding the Hall strip the other of his place in the guild altogether. Seonaid heard them both out on the stones before Talla na Lasrach², in the plain grey light the office asked of every hearing, and asked at the end of it only one question of either man: which of them had first offered to give the disputed load back rather than argue over who had carried it. Neither had. She told them then that the Hall's grant to the guild was a right to carry, not a right to quarrel, and that she would as soon strip the whole guild of its charter as decide between two men who had each thought a fee worth more than a friendship of twenty years' carrying together, and left them to settle it between themselves before she troubled to hear either man's case again. They came to an agreement on the road home, by their own later account, before they had gone a mile, which the Hall's knot-keeper that season kept as proof, if proof were wanted, that most quarrels brought up a mountain could have been settled at the bottom of it, had either party troubled to try.

IV

Of Ruairidh Glas and the Ford He Never Returned To

Of the old blood that had stood up at the Roinn, few enough were left by the time Seonaid held the cup, and fewer still who had themselves shed blood in the long strife the Peace had ended. Ruairidh Glas, holder of the Red Share at Dùn dhearg, had come to the holding some hundred and eighty-five years before Seonaid's own birth, at an age, six hundred and fifty-eight years, that had seemed unremarkable enough among his own kin and would have seemed past belief to any household of the low country; and he had held it, by the time the Peace was thirty years old, longer than any other lord then living had held anything.

He had sworn the Peace himself, on the stone cup, with his own hand still upon it when he spoke the one thing beyond the agreed words that no one after-

ward thought to strike from the telling: that he had shed the first blood of the whole long strife at Dùn thais, over cattle on a wet slope, when he was young enough to think a stone worth a life, and that he would not buy such a peace again for twice the grazing on the island. He had never gone back to Dùn thais after that morning at Aonghas Bàn's body, not once in all the centuries between, though the road there from Dùn dhearg was no longer than a hard day's ride and he had ridden further, on lesser business, a hundred times over. His steward, in the last years, used to say that his lord knew every stone on every road on the island except the one road he could have walked blind, and had chosen, deliberately and for reasons he never once gave aloud, not to.

In his nine hundred and ninth year he sent to Dùn iséal, unasked, for leave to come up and stand once more before the stone cup, which no lord of a share was required to do outside the quarter days and which none had troubled to ask for in Seonaid's own years of keeping. She granted it without asking his reason, and he came up the mountain road on foot rather than by any chair or litter, for his legs still carried him and he saw no cause to spare them for whatever years remained. He stood before the cup a long while, by the account of the knot-keeper who kept the door that day, and said nothing aloud that any living ear caught, and went back down the mountain the same evening to Dùn dhearg, and died there within the year, in his own bed, with his own household about him, having lived nine hundred and ten years and outlived every soul who had stood up in the gathering-house at the Roinn, save only Eithne nic Ailein.

His son took up the holding without any summons to the Hall, for the Peace by then required none where an heir was named and undisputed, and the rolls of that season, which had grown careful about naming every lord however small, are strangely thin about naming this one; a fault, Seonaid's own knot-keeper said drily, that lay with the household's own silence about him rather than with any failure of her cords. He held the Red Share after his father a very long time, by any ordinary reckoning, and a markedly shorter one than his father had, though neither he nor his own son after him would live to see the day when that shortening was spoken of, in the Hall's own rolls, as anything but the ordinary way of things.

V

Of the Fall in the High Gallery

It was in the three-and-fortieth year of Seonaid's keeping, when she herself was close on seventy years old and had begun, though she said so to no one but her own hands on a cold morning, to feel the mountain's damp in her joints the way the older cutters had always sworn a person eventually did, that the roof of the highest gallery at Dùn ìseal came down.

It fell in the dark hour before the second watch, when the gallery held fewer cutters than it would have by daylight but not so few that the fall went unwitnessed. The lamps went out with the dust before anyone standing further down the gallery understood what had happened, and it was the coughing, by every account that survives, that told the cutters below which way to run, since no one could see anything at all for the better part of a minute, and no one who was there afterward found much to say about that minute beyond the coughing and the dark. Four men died under it, cutters of the nine hearths every one; the eldest of them, a man named Aonghas Crom who had cut coal at Dùn ìseal since before Seonaid herself was born and had trained half the younger cutters now working the lower galleries, was found still gripping his pick, which the men who carried him up remarked on afterward more than they remarked on anything else about that morning. A fifth man was pulled out with a crushed hand that never again closed fully round a pick, and worked the lighter galleries for the rest of his years cutting one-handed, which the rolls note without further comment, as if a one-handed cutter working on regardless were no more remarkable, in that Hall, than a wall standing where a wall had always stood.

Seonaid went down into the gallery herself before the dust had finished settling, against every counsel her own stewards gave her, and stood in the broken rock with a lamp held high enough to see the shape of what the mountain had done, and said, to the men working to clear the fallen stone, only that she wished to see it with her own eyes before anyone told her what to think of it. What she saw, by every account, was rock enough to have killed twice the number it had, held back only by a seam of harder stone that had happened, by no planning of any cutter living, to catch the worst of the fall before it reached the floor where the other men stood.

The four dead were carried up and buried on the Hall's own ground, the one ground on the island no feud had ever been let to follow a man, and Seonaid her-

self set the last stone over the last of them, which no Keeper before her, so far as the rolls remember, had troubled to do with her own hands rather than a steward's. She gave the season over to argument after that, not about whether the dead should be mourned, which no one disputed, but about what should be done so that no gallery should ever again be held up by nothing more than the luck of a harder seam catching a fall before it found a man. On 23 an Lùnastal, FE 614, she ordered timber props of oak set in every gallery the Hall worked, the first timber the Hall had ever spent on the mountain rather than on a road or a bridge or a waypoint house below it, and the first oak for the purpose was felled and cut within the season, so that by the following year's cutting no gallery at Dùn ìseal stood without a prop of its own between the roof and the men beneath it.

The walled-up mouth of the highest gallery, where the four had died and where the fall itself had been judged too dangerous to work again, stood sealed from that year on, and stands sealed still, by every telling that has come down since; and it is that walled door, more than any prop or any roll, that the cutters of Dùn ìseal point to, when a stranger asks them why every gallery below it now stands propped in oak that no earlier generation of cutters had thought to spend.

VI

Of the Close of Seonaid's Keeping

Seonaid Chiar held the flame sixteen years more after the fall, and grew old in the office in a way none of the four houses of custody had troubled to record of any Keeper before her, for the simple reason that few Keepers had held the cup long enough for anyone to notice the greying of a hand that had once been young. She died in her own quarters above the galleries, eighty-five years old, having kept the flame the better part of six decades, and the nine hearths that had raised her young chose another after her without any dispute that the rolls thought worth setting down, which is, of every Keeper's ending, the kindest sort a Hall can give.

Word of her death went out along the same roads that had carried her own rolls up to her for sixty years, and came, among other places, to the school at Cnoc bhàn, whose teachers sent up the mountain no message of grief and no delegation to mourn her, only the single unlit lamp their own three old men had once set down before her door, carried back up now by cutters young enough to

have known no Keeper but her, and left again on the same stones, still unlit, as they had left it the first time: which the Hall's knot-keeper that season understood well enough not to ask the school to explain, and did not.

Cathair dhomhain, on the western coast, was founded in the same years as her dying, by carriers who had settled at the western road's end above its harbour and raised a town on the rise there that they meant, from the first, to be known for keeping every measure strictly, in coal as in everything else a scale could weigh. Its own shrine, from 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 634, held the Small-Burning Law to the very grain from its founding day onward, and the town grew, in the years that followed, a name for a kind of pride that no other town on the island quite shared: pride in how exactly it kept to what it was owed, whatever measure of its own it had to show for it. It stood, that year, still a place carriers passed through on their way to somewhere else, its harbour no more than a fishing quay and its wall not yet raised; but its shrine's own strictness outlasted every one of the carriers who founded it, and was spoken of, by lowland households who had never once set foot on its own rise above the sea, as a strange, stiff-necked kind of pride to hold a whole town by.

At Dùn ìseal the walled mouth of the high gallery stood as it had stood since the year of the fall, sealed in dry stone, with the oak props running down every working gallery below it into the dark the way a spine runs down a back; and the cutters who passed the sealed door on their way to their own lower galleries had, within a generation, stopped remarking on it at all, the way the carriers on the roads below had long since stopped reading the boundary stones the Peace had set. It had become, as the Hall's own oldest things so often did, no longer a thing anyone spoke of, but a thing that was simply there, propping up, in its own silent way, everything built above and around it since.

PART FOUR

The Gathering of the Shares

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

OF GORaidh mac Ìomhair

FE 635 – 753

I

Of the Red Share Whole

By the time the oak props at Dùn Ìseal had stopped smelling of the axe, the island had begun to fill out again, the way a field fills with barley once the birds have had their share and stopped coming. Cathair mhòr had its wall now, and would not say what it had built the wall against, though the reapers of Achadh mhòr still said, whenever anyone asked, that the town had not forgotten the smoke. Ceann leathan had a harbour-master keeping notched sticks that were already the oldest counted things on the island, and the Keeper Seonaid Chiar, before she died, had let the stag's cutters back into the galleries of the Hall on oath to ask nothing of the vein aloud, which the Hall called a reconciling and the school still called a truce. The Peace of the Threshold was eighty years old and had not been broken once, not at a death, not at a boundary stone, not even at Cathair dhomhain, whose people were proud of keeping every measure to the grain and were forever finding some new law to keep strictly. The shares no longer shrank at every burial. Here and there, slowly, without anyone marking the day it began, they had started instead to grow.

Of no line was this truer than the line of Ìomhar.

Goraidh mac Ìomhair was born in the Red Share in the spring of the Hall's fifth century, the year his grandmother's roof at Dùn dhearg was new-thatched, and he grew up under a roof that had never in his father's memory, or his father's

father's, been parted from a neighbour's spear. The Red Share had been won with a sword, not given at the Roinn, and it had never been cut since; whatever quarrels the rest of the island's heirs had over their boundary stones, the holders of Dùn dhearg had only to hold what they already had, and they had held it with a plainness that other lines, forever arguing a grazing-right through three generations of cousins, found almost insulting.

He came into it young, as his line reckoned youth. His father died at four hundred, a middling age by then for one of Ailean's blood and past belief for any other household, thrown from a horse on the low ground below Dùn dhearg in a spring so wet the ground never firmed under the beast's feet. Goraidh stood at the grave with his mother's people and his father's stewards, a hundred and twenty-six years old and taller than any man in either line, and he said nothing, because there was nothing that wanted saying. He took up the household the next morning. The granaries at Dùn dhearg were full that year, as they generally were; the Red Share paid its own way and had done since Ìomhar Dearg burned the halls within the double bank six centuries before, and Goraidh's first act as its head was no more than to walk the granaries with the steward and check the thatch.

In those years he thought of himself as no more than a holder of a hall. He married early, a woman of a small house on the coast whose name the Red Share's own reciters kept and no one else troubled to, and she gave him a daughter before the century was out, a quick, restless child who could not be got to sit still at a hearth and was forever down at the ford watching the carriers. Goraidh called her Mòrag, for his mother, and thought no more of the succession than any lord of a whole share needs to. The girl would have the hall when he was done with it, as her grandmother had had it before him, only smaller than most, because the Red Share had never been the kind of thing that grew.

Then, within the same ten years, both his mother's brother's sons died without children of their bodies.

They were cousins he had known well enough as a boy, before his own father's death and the long duties after it had cut down his visiting. Cailean had gone under a wall he was mending at his own hall on a night of high wind, and Donnchadh, the younger, had wasted two winters with a cough the hearth-women could not cut and died in the third with his hand in his sister's. Between them they had held two of the old counties east of Dùn dhearg, parted from the Roinn's great share of the north four centuries before and parted again at every death since, the way the north had gone on parting itself until, as the tellers of

Dùn ìseal like to say, it could not raise twenty spears from the whole of it. There was no one of either dead man's body to take up what was left. By the custom that had held since the Peace, a share with no heir named went to the Keeper to give as she saw fit, unless some other of the blood could show a claim before her.

Goraidh could show one, through his mother, and so could three other households, more distantly. He did not go to Dùn ìseal to argue it. He went instead, the winter after Donnchadh's burial, to the third of his mother's kin who was still living unmarried and held the third of the three old counties in her own right, a widow some four hundred years old named Muirne nic Dhonnchaidh, whose county marched with both the dead men's and who had buried two husbands of her own without a child of either surviving her.

He did not pretend to himself, nor to her, that it was a love match. She was old enough to remember the War of the Two Oaths from its first burning, and he was not far behind her. But she had held her county alone for eighty years with no one to leave it to, and had watched her cousins' lands sit empty of a lord while three strangers' stewards argued over them at Dùn ìseal, and when Goraidh rode over in the worst of the winter with six men and no threat in him at all, she heard him out at her own hearth and told him she had been waiting for someone to ask her a sensible question, and that he was the first.

"You have not asked me what I want kept in the marrying," she said to him, the second evening he sat at her hearth, before he had so much as named the thing he had ridden over to ask.

"Tell me, then," said Goraidh, "and I'll swear to it before I swear to the rest."

She told him. Her own reciter would keep his place and his fire, whatever the Red Share's own reciters thought of sharing a hearth with a stranger's teller; the debts her two husbands had left the county's smiths were his to carry, and not her name's to carry after her; and she would be buried, when it came to that, among her own dead and not among his. He agreed to all three before she had finished the third, and she looked at him a while, the way a woman looks at a tally that has come out even for once, and said that he was the first of his line she had ever heard of who did not need a thing explained to him twice.

They were married at Dùn dhearg in the spring, before the roads had properly dried, with the Red Share's own reciters standing witness because no others could get there in time. By the terms she brought to it, her county came into the marriage whole, as the Peace allowed; and by the same terms, made before the Keeper's own knot-keeper so that no line could later say the marriage was got up only

for the land, Goraidh took on himself the debts her two dead husbands had left the county's smiths, which were not small.

So it was that within a single winter's dealing, and by nothing more than two deaths he had not caused and one marriage he had gone looking for, Goraidh mac Ìomhair held in one hand the Red Share, whole as his fathers had kept it, and three of the old counties of the east besides, parted since the Roinn and gathered now, for the first time in four hundred years, into a single household's granaries.

II

Of the Third County and What It Cost

The stewards of the three counties came to Dùn dhearg that first summer to be sworn, and they were not, on the whole, glad men. Two of the counties had been managed for a generation by men who had grown used to answering to no one nearer than a dead cousin's memory, and the third had been Muirne's alone, run her own close way, with her own notches on her own sticks, and she had never once in eighty years asked any of them to account to a husband. Now there was a hall at Dùn dhearg that wanted their tallies each autumn, and a lord in it younger than some of their own grandchildren, of the Red Share's blood but not, until that winter, of theirs.

Goraidh did not go about it the way his father would have. He rode the boundary of all three counties himself in the first year, on foot half the time, with Muirne beside him telling him which stream had moved its bed and which family had held a grazing since before the Roinn and would go to war over it if a new steward tried to measure it out again. He ate at the hearths and not the halls, and asked before he ruled. It cost him a full summer and most of the autumn, and it cost Muirne, who was not young even by the reckoning of her own line, more than she let him see; she died in the ninth year of the marriage, in her sleep, with the county's own reciter in the room, and Goraidh buried her among her own dead, not his, because she had asked it of him plainly the week before, and he had learned by then not to argue with her.

He did not marry again. He had his daughter, growing tall and impatient at Dùn dhearg, and he had four counties where his father had held one, and he found, in the years after Muirne's death, that the four together took more of his

waking hours than the Red Share alone had ever asked of him, and that he did not mind it.

It was a hard decade for the low ground east of the mountain. Two summers running the rains came at the wrong end of the season and the barley stood in the field and rotted before the reapers could get to it, and in the second of those years three of the smaller households along the old boundary between Cailean's dead county and Donnchadh's went hungry enough that their children were sent to kin in the hills to be fed through the worst of the winter. Goraidh opened the granaries at Dùn dhearg that year, all four of them, the Red Share's own stores and the three counties' besides, and sold the grain at less than it had cost him to keep, and gave it outright to nine households that could not have paid even that.

It was not, by his own account of it, a generous act. He said so once to his daughter, late in his life, when she pressed him on it: that a lord who lets his own low ground starve has nothing left to be lord of, granary or no granary, and that he had done the arithmetic before he had done anything that could be mistaken for kindness. Mòrag did not believe him, and neither, in the end, did the households.

III

Of the Granary Door

It began, as such things do, with no one meaning it.

A household at the eastern edge of what had been Donnchadh's county came to the granary door at Dùn dhearg in the third bad autumn to beg seed corn against the next year's sowing, and the steward at the door, new to the post and unsure of the forms for a thing that had never before crossed three counties' worth of custom at once, asked whose authority he should set against the debt.

"The rìgh's," said the old woman who had come for the corn, before the steward could finish the question, and went on into the yard as if she had said nothing remarkable at all.

The word went through the queue at the door faster than the corn did. No one on the island had been called that since Ailean Mòr fell at the ford six hundred years before; at the Roinn the seven hundred and twelve heirs had sworn, each with some private reservation, that none of them would take it, and in the centuries since, only the reciters of the Mason's line had troubled to remember

that the gods had once given the word to Ailean in the grove, and even they had let it go mostly to dust. The heirs of Ailean's blood, all down every one of the nine great shares, had never once offered it to Goraidh, nor to any lord of the Red Share before him. It was the granaries that gave it to him, and the granaries did not ask anyone's leave.

Goraidh heard of it that same evening from the steward, half apologising, as though the man had let something get past him at the door that he should have stopped. Goraidh did not answer at once. He walked out to the granary himself, in the last of the light, and stood by the door a while looking at the grain-dust still hanging in the air of the yard, and when the steward asked him at last whether he wanted the word stopped at the door in future, Goraidh said only that he did not see how a man was to stop a word once nine households had already said it to each other on the road home.

It spread the way such words do among people who have use for them and none for the thing they properly name. By the fourth bad harvest it was not only the hungry who said it at the door; the smiths of the third county said it, and the carriers on the road to Cathair dhomhain said it of him without ever having stood in his hall, and within a generation the lowland households from the Abhainn dhomhain to the old bounds of Donnchadh's county called Dùn dhearg the rìgh's hall as plainly as they called Talla na Lasrach¹ the Hall.

Goraidh never once used the word of himself. He gave his name at the granary door as he always had, Goraidh mac Ìomhair of the Red Share, and when the reciters of neighbouring counties tried it on him to his face, the way a man tries a new coat on another man to see how he wears it, he let it pass without either taking it up or putting it down, which some of his own stewards thought a kind of cunning and others thought a kind of honesty, and were probably both right.

IV

Of the Climb

he was a hundred and ninety-nine years old, by the granaries' own count, though there were men half that age in the hill counties who looked older

1. the Hall of the Flame

than he did, when word came down from Dùn ìseal that the council wished to speak with the lord the lowlands had taken to calling their king.

It was not a summons in the way the Keepers had ever summoned anyone before. The council did not raise its voice; it had never needed to, in six centuries of holding the one thing every share on the island had sworn to hold in common, and it did not raise it now. But the word went east plainly enough for all its quiet, and Goraidh, who had by then held four counties for the better part of a century and been called a king by lowland households for the better part of two generations, understood well enough what was being asked of him, and rode west that spring with six men, as far as the last waypoint house on the mountain road.

There he stopped, and gave his spear to the man riding beside him, and told him to wait with the horses.

He had thought about it for three nights before he set out, lying awake in the hall his father and his father's father had held without a stranger's spear ever crossing its threshold in peace, turning the thing over the way his stewards turned a tally-stick to catch the light on a notch. A man who came to the Hall armed had already said, before he opened his mouth, what he wanted; and Goraidh, walking up the last mile of the mountain road on his own two feet with the wind coming down cold off the passes and his breath going short in a way it had not gone short in eighty years, hoped that the council would read the other thing in his empty hands, because he did not entirely trust himself to say it as plainly as he meant it.

The grey roof of Talla na Lasrach¹ came in sight over the shoulder of the hill while he was still catching that breath, and for a moment, an old man on a mountain road with his knees aching and his men and his spear left behind him at the last house, Goraidh mac Ìomhair looked very little like anyone's king at all.

The council sat outside on the stones before the door, for the day was fine, and the Keeper sat among them with the stone cup at her feet, the same cup that had stood on the threshold since Fionnlagh Dall's time, filled always to the two palms and no more. Goraidh stood before them in his travelling cloak with the wind in his beard, an old man by any low-ground reckoning and a young one by his own blood's, and he said the thing he had come up the mountain to say before any of them could ask it of him.

"I claim nothing under the mountain. Not a gallery, not a grain of coal. Let the Hall hear me say it."

1. the Hall of the Flame

The Hall heard him. Nobody answered at once; the wind took the words up over the roof and out along the ridge, and one of the council, an old woman of the Mason's line who had sat on that bench longer than Goraidh had been alive, looked at him a long while before she said anything at all, as if she were counting something on his face that he could not see himself.

"A man who holds four counties and is called a king by nine households in ten does not come up a mountain to tell us what he does not want," she said at last. "Tell us what you do."

So he told her, and the telling of it was most of the day. The roads he wanted plainly, because his granaries already fed the households that walked them, and it seemed to him a poor kind of ruling to feed a man and let some other hand toll him on the way home. The waypoint houses he wanted left to their own keepers, because he had learned enough from Muirne's eighty years of one county to know that a thing gathered by a stranger is gathered worse than a thing gathered by a neighbour with a share in it. Of the galleries, the flame and the cup he asked to have nothing said, in the swearing or out of it, because he had watched what four hundred years of the Roinn's quarrelling over the vein had done to every line that tried it, and he had no wish to be the fifth line remembered for trying again.

Then they bargained, and they bargained until the light went.

It was not a quarrel, though it had the shape of one at times, voices raised and let fall again, a councilman getting up to walk the length of the terrace and sit down somewhere else before he spoke his next piece. It was a dividing, done slowly and in the open air because neither side wanted it done any other way, each line of it turned over from every side before it was set down: what a righ might hold and what a Keeper must, what roads belonged to which of them and what happened at a boundary between a granary and a gallery, what was owed a household that answered, as so many did along the old bounds, to both halls at once. Goraidh gave up more than he had meant to when he set out, and got less, in the way of standing, than the lowland households already believed he had; the council gave him the roads and did not pretend, by the end of it, that the roads were a small thing to give.

They swore it the next morning, before the council had had time to sleep on second thoughts, on the stone cup itself: the Keeper to keep the flame and the galleries, the rìgh to keep the roads, the granaries and the peace of the lowlands; the rìgh never to set foot in a working gallery, the Keeper never to raise a spear. *Roinn a' Ghleidhidh*², the division of keeping, the council called it before the knots of the roll were tied, and by it, more than by any granary door or any word a hungry household chose to use of him, Goraidh mac Ìomhair became the first ruler since Ailean Mòr that the Hall itself would answer to as a ruler, on the one narrow ground the Hall had left him to be one.

He walked back down the mountain the way he had come, on his own feet, and took up his spear again at the last house without a word, and one of his own men said afterward that the old man had looked, coming down, twenty years younger than he had looked going up, though nobody could say for certain that it was the bargain and not simply the road being downhill.

V

Of the Timber Hall and the Fish in Twenty

He built the hall the council had, in effect if not in any clause of the swearing, told him he had a right to build. It went up on the same rise at Dùn dhearg where his father's turf-and-timber house had stood, a long hall of squared oak with a granary set at each of its four corners, so that a man riding in from any of the four counties saw first, before he saw the door, the thing the hall was actually for. The Red Share's own carpenters cut it, and the three gathered counties' carpenters raised it, working side by side in a way their stewards would not have thought possible ten years before, and when it was roofed Goraidh had the granaries filled from all four counties at once, in the same season, so that no household along any boundary could say its grain had gone first into a stranger's store.

Within the next handful of years, with the roads under his keeping and the Keeper's word behind the division that had put them there, he set the first toll the island had ever known on the carriers who used them: one fish in twenty, or its worth in whatever a carrier's basket held, to pay the guards who kept the road-

2. the division of keeping between rìgh and Keeper

peace and to mend the bridges the floods still took every few years wherever a crossing had been built too near the water. He did not set the toll himself, at every crossing, with his own hand; he had learned that much from Muirne's eighty years of running one county alone. He gave the gathering of it to the keepers of the waypoint houses along each road, the same households that had kept a bed and a fire for carriers since before his grandfather's day, and let each of them keep a share of what they took, on the plain reckoning that a keeper with something of his own in the toll would gather it more honestly than one gathering only for a stranger at Dùn dhearg. The rolls said so themselves, in their dry way: that the waypoint-keepers kept their share, and the rest went to the guards and the bridges, and the sums, allowing for the ordinary dishonesty of the world, came out close enough to be believed.

At one of the waypoint houses on the northern road, a woman who had kept its fire for thirty years and her mother before her tallied her first season's toll before Goraidh's own steward, sack by sack, and when the count came out a full tenth short of what the steward's own reckoning of the traffic said it ought to, she did not flinch from it. "The carriers who go by night pay nothing," she said, "because there is no one at the door to ask them, and I am not walking a night road at my age to catch a man carrying salt fish." The steward carried it word for word to Dùn dhearg, and Goraidh, hearing it, laughed for the first time in some weeks and said only that a rìgh who wanted every fish in every twenty counted true had better learn to walk a night road himself, and let the matter drop. It was the kind of ruling the lowland households came, in time, to expect of him, and the kind the hill counties, who had never had a rìgh to expect anything of, found faintly ridiculous.

The years after that went the way years go for a man who has already done the one or two things his life was going to be remembered for. He grew old past two hundred and stayed hale a long while past it, the long years of his blood fading in him the way they had been fading in every line since the Roinn, century by century, so that where Murchadh Mòr had lived near three thousand years and Ìomhar Dearg fifteen hundred, Goraidh mac Ìomhair, seven generations on from the Roinn, counted himself old at two hundred and fifty and was right to. His daughter Mòrag, who had grown from the restless child at the ford into a woman who could not sit still in a hall any better than she had ever been able to sit still at a hearth, took over the walking of the roads long before he was willing to call it a

handing-over, and he let her, because he had never much cared, himself, for the roads once they were built, only for the fact of their being kept.

He died in his own hall at Dùn dhearg in his two hundred and fifty-ninth year, in the granary month, with the smell of the new grain coming in through the door he had insisted be left open. Mòrag was with him, and two of the waypoint-keepers who had come in that week to render their tallies and stayed on when they saw how it was going, because a man does not like to walk out on a dying king over a fish in twenty. He said little at the end that the tellers thought worth the keeping; what they did keep was that he asked, the last evening, whether the toll-sticks for the western road had been notched that season, and was told that they had, and said that was well, and did not speak again.

Some days after, at the old waypoint house on the western road that had been Mòr nic Dhùghaill's in the Small-Burning Law's own time and was a waypoint-keeper's still, the keeper of that house sat at her door in the last of the light with a fresh-cut stick across her knees, and notched it once for a carrier's toll paid in fish and once for a toll paid in wool, exactly as she had notched it the week before, and would notch the next one the week after that, the granaries at Dùn dhearg being full or empty, a rìgh being alive in the timber hall or laid in the ground beside it, the road going on being a road either way.

OF MÒRAG OF THE ROADS

FE 754 – 879

I

Of the Hall Left Standing Open

Goraidh Mòr had ruled at Dùn dhearg four-score years, from the granary door where the lowland households had first called him rìgh to the timber hall he raised over it with a granary at each corner, and when he died in his sleep in the seven hundred and fifty-third year of the Hall the hall stood a night and a day with its doors open, as the custom of the household was, before anyone was let in to take his chair.

Mòrag nic Ghoraidh was a hundred and thirty-five years old that night, and she had never once sat in it. She had stood beside it at feasts and at judgements, and had leaned on its arm once as a girl until her father lifted her off by the collar, laughing, and told her a rìgh's chair was not a thing to lean on; and now she stood in the doorway in the grey of the morning with the household behind her, and looked at the empty seat, and did not go in.

It was Tormod, her father's steward, who broke the silence, because someone had to and no one else would. He said that the toll-sticks were a season behind in the counting, and that the eastern granary wanted its roof seen to before the rains, and that three waypoint-keepers had sent word asking whether the road-toll still stood now the old rìgh was gone, as if a toll were a thing that might have died with a man.

"Tell them it stands," said Mòrag, "and tell them I'll be asking after it myself before the year is out."

She went in and sat down. The chair was warm from nothing; it had stood empty a night and a day, as the custom asked, and the wood was cold under her, and she sat in it a while without speaking, getting the feel of a thing she had watched other people sit in her whole life. Then she stood up again and did not sit in it for the better part of a year, because she had said a thing in the doorway that she meant to keep, and there is no keeping a road-toll from a chair.

She sent for a staff first. Not a sceptre; her father's steward brought her one of those, cut and banded for the purpose, and she looked at it and sent it back to the woodworker with word that she wanted something a woman could lean her whole weight on across the length of the island, and that if it looked well in a hall that was no fault of hers. What came back was a plain thing of black-thorn, taller than she was, worn smooth where a hand would fall on it before ever her own hand had touched it, because the woodworker had walked with it himself a week to be sure of the balance. She kept that staff the rest of her life, and it is the one thing of hers that is remembered by its own shape and not only by its name.

The roads her father had left her were his father's roads before that: tracks widened where a toll-house wanted widening and left as they were everywhere else, fords that a wet spring made impassable for a week at a stretch, one stone bridge at the western crossing that had not been touched since the masons of an earlier age set the last course. The waypoint-keepers sent word to Dùn dhearg twice a year with their tallies and their complaints, and Goraidh Mòr had answered the tallies and let the complaints lie, being a builder of halls and not, in his heart, a mender of roads. His daughter had three years of those complaints said over to her in a week, sitting up past the lamp's good hours with Tormod's tally-sticks stacked at her knee, and in the spring she called for her staff and a horse and went out to see the roads for herself, and she did not come back to sit in the chair again until the autumn.

II

Of the Broken Stretch above the Ford

The first stretch she walked was the road up from the ford at Dùn dhearg, because it was the one nearest home and because a waypoint-keeper there had sent word three years running that the spring floods took the same twenty yards of it every year and that the carriers went round it through a farmer's

barley until the farmer complained, and then round it through his neighbour's until that one complained too.

She found it exactly as told. The road dropped to the ford between two low banks that the water undercut every spring, so that by autumn there was a raw scar of red earth on either side and a soft place in the middle that swallowed a laden ox to the hocks. She stood on the near bank in her travelling boots with the staff planted beside her and watched a laden ox-sledge go through it while she was there, watched the carrier swear and the ox strain and the whole load lean sideways before it came free, and she said nothing until the sledge was past and the carrier had seen who was watching him.

"How long has it done that?" she said.

"Since before my father's father, my lady," said the carrier, "and the toll-house has sent word every year, and every year they send word back that it'll be seen to."

"It'll be seen to," said Mòrag, "because I'm standing in it."

She had the waypoint-keeper of that stretch bring her every man and ox-team within a day's walk, and she paid them out of the toll itself, which no one had thought to do before, since the toll went to Dùn dhearg and the roads were left to whatever labour a household owed its lord besides. In eleven days they had cut back both banks, laid a bed of stone under the soft place, and raised the road a hand's breadth above the water on either side of the ford. She stood in the finished stretch herself when the first loaded sledge went through it dry-footed, and said nothing at all that time, only watched it go, and then walked on to the next bad stretch, which a complaint three years old had also told her of and which no one had touched.

Not every waypoint-keeper welcomed her. At a stretch two days east of the ford, where the toll-house had gone unanswered longest of all, the keeper met her at his own door with his arms folded and said that the road had been bad since his grandfather's time and would be bad after his own grandchildren, and that a rìgh who came once with a staff and a season's labourers would be forgotten before the next flood took the bank again, as every rìgh before her had been forgotten. Mòrag heard him out, and then had her road-guards break open his own toll-chest before him, in his own doorway, and counted the silver herself onto a cloth on the ground: enough, by her own reckoning, to have paid for the mending three times over in the years he had let it lie. She did not shame him further than the counting. She left half the silver where it lay, for the household's own use, and took the other half for the work, and told him that she would be back in four

years to see whether the bank had held, and that if it had not, the next counting would be done at Dùn dhearg and not at his door. It held. He sent word to her twice a year after that, of his own will, whether the road wanted mending or not, and his words are among the few from that stretch that the toll-rolls keep entire.

She walked the roads of the island that way for the better part of six years: every road a toll-house sat on, and every bad stretch the complaints named, though there was no time in one life for every mile of every road besides. She had them mended in the order the complaints had come in, oldest complaint first, a rule of her own devising that some of the older keepers called foolish, since a small hurt long borne got mended before a great one newly reported. It meant, all the same, that a waypoint-keeper who sent word and was ignored for ten years learned that sending word to Dùn dhearg was no longer wasted breath. Some of the mending was small: a culvert cleared, a gate hung where a farmer's beasts had been getting onto the road and fouling it. Some of it was not small. She had a whole stretch of the northern road moved a quarter-mile east, off a slope that slid every winter, and the farmers whose barley the new stretch crossed were paid out of the toll for the ground, which had likewise not been done before, and which some of the older waypoint-keepers said was no way to run a road and would beggar the toll inside a generation. It did not.

III

Of Niall Òg on the Cold Road

She met Niall Òg on the northern road in the seventh year of her reign, in a wet spring, on a stretch she had not yet reached and had no plan of reaching for another two years. He was sitting on a boundary stone with his cloak over his head against the rain, an old man by then past his sixteen hundredth year, small and bent and grey, with a stick of his own across his knees that he had never had cut for a purpose the way she had had hers cut, only picked up somewhere along some road forty years before and kept because it was a good length. She did not know him. He knew her at once, by the staff and by the four road-guards behind her, and by something in the way she stood looking at a rut in the road as if it had done her a personal injury.

"You'll be Goraidh's daughter," he said.

"I am," said Mòrag.

"You look at a bad road the way your grandfather's brother used to look at a bad debt," said Niall Òg, "and I knew him, so I say it kindly. Sit down out of the wet a while. There's room on the stone."

She sat, because a man of sixteen hundred years asking a rìgh of a hundred and forty to sit is not easily refused, and because her feet were glad of it. He told her, without being asked, who he was, and she had heard the name from her father, who had heard it from his father, the way everyone on the island had heard the name Niall Òg by then, though fewer and fewer of them had ever sat beside him.

"I tied a knot once," he said, "at a door below Dùn ìseal, when the whole of what Ailean Mòr left was cut on a cord and laid on a floor for seven hundred and twelve of us to walk the length of and count. I found my own knot that night and sat by it a good while, the way a man does, looking for what he was owed. And do you know what I saw, sitting there?"

"No," said Mòrag.

"I saw that everyone else in the house was doing the same. Every one of the seven hundred and twelve of us walked that cord looking for his own knot, and having found it, stood up and went looking at everyone else's. I thought that a fine thing to have watched, at the time. I've had a long while since to think it a sadder one. We were all tied on the one cord and not one of us, that whole night, looked at the cord. Only at the knots."

Mòrag said nothing to that for a time, watching the rain come down the road ahead of them in grey sheets.

"And is that why you tell it to a woman mending a road?" she said at last.

"It is," said Niall Òg. "You're the first of the line I've met in a long life who looks at the cord and not the knot. A road doesn't ask whose share it crosses. It only asks to be walked on, by whoever's walking. Keep at that, and you'll have done something the seven hundred and twelve of us never managed among ourselves, and never will, being who we are."

He got up before she did, stiffly, with his stick, and went on down the road ahead of her household on foot, an old man alone in the wet, refusing the offer of a horse with a wave of his hand and a remark she did not catch over the rain. She never saw him again, though she heard of him twice more before her own death, both times at the funerals of people younger than himself, standing at the graveside with his stick, the last of the seven hundred and twelve who still came to such things.

IV

Of the Golden House and the Sign Recut

She built the golden house in her ninth year, on the eastern road north of Seann Dunn, where the stage from the coast to the mountain had always been a hard day's carrying with no house to break it and a bad night's camping if the weather turned. It was not the first waypoint house on the island; there had been such houses since the carriers' roads themselves, built by whatever household held the ground and kept up out of what custom the ground's own people were owed. It was the first built at a rìgh's order and out of a rìgh's toll, and she meant it to be seen to be one, and had it built larger than the ground needed and roofed it with new-cut timber that stood pale and bright against the older grey houses about it, so that carriers coming up from the coast called it the golden house before the beams had so much as weathered, and the name held.

She opened it herself, on a night in the autumn, with every carrier who could be got word to in time asked to eat there free of the toll, and stood in the doorway of her own hall watching them come in wet and cold off the road and sit down to a fire and a full table that none of them had paid for, and she thought, watching it, that this was worth more of her father's granaries than anything he had built with them, and did not say so aloud, because he was three years dead and past hearing either the praise or the argument.

Five years after that she had the western crossing of the Abhainn dhomhain widened, where the old bridge below Cathair dhearg had stood narrow enough that two laden carriers could not pass on it, and where every spring saw a shouting match on the span between a string of carriers going up and a string coming down, neither willing to back off first. The new stone went up wide enough for two, and when the masons came to the keystone she had them find, among the older stones taken down, the hearth-sign that Ailean Clachair had cut there in an age before her grandfather's grandfather was born, worn nearly smooth by the years and the weather, and she had it cut fresh into the new stone, in the same hand as near as a mason four generations removed from Ailean Clachair could match it. It is there yet. From that year the small fishing town at the bridge-foot, that had shrunk to almost nothing after the old wars and grown slowly back since, began to grow in earnest, for a wide bridge draws trade the way a narrow one turns it aside, and within Mòrag's own lifetime it had outgrown three of the

towns around it, though no one troubled yet to give it any name grander than the ground it stood on had always borne.

V

Of Dòmhnall, Who Could Not Walk

her son was called lame all his life, though he had not been born so; he came into the world with two sound legs and used them like any child until his sixteenth year, when he fell under a laden ox-sledge on the road above the ford at Dùn dhearg, the stretch his mother would mend in her first summer as rìgh. He had been riding the load, as boys do against every warning, and the sledge had struck a stone standing proud of the track and rolled, and taken his leg under it. The leg was set, and set again when it did not knit true, and in the end he walked with a stick for the rest of his life and could not do it far, and never rode a horse again without another man's hand at the bridle.

Mòrag never once, in all the years she outlived that day, ordered the stone taken up, though her masons mended the stretch round it and pointed out to her more than once that it still sat there. She had it left, and told no one why, though her own household guessed, and some of the older road-guards said among themselves that she went out of her way to walk past it whenever her road took her near, and stood by it a while before going on, as if it owed her an answer it never gave.

Dòmhnall could not do what his mother had done. He knew it before she did, and said so to her plainly, sitting in the golden house one evening in his thirtieth year with his bad leg stretched out before the fire, and told her that whatever she left him he would rule from a chair, and that she had better begin now teaching him how a chair could be made to reach as far as a staff had. She did not argue with him. That autumn he was carried the length of three road-stretches, in a covered chair on two men's shoulders, so that he should at least have seen with his own eyes the roads he could otherwise know only from a waypoint-keeper's word, and before the year was out she named him at Dùn dhearg as her heir, an old woman by then and past her hundred and eightieth, with the long years thinning fast in her line the way they had thinned in her father's and would thin further in her son's, so that where Ailean Mòr's own children had lived three thousand years and more, his great-great-granddaughter counted herself fortunate to see two

hundred, and his great-great-grandson, sound of mind and short of leg, would not see even that.

VI

Of the Last Circuit

She made her last circuit of the roads in her two hundred and eleventh year, against the advice of her household and her son both, who said a woman of that age had no business on a horse in the spring mud, and she told them that a road she had not walked in four years was a road she no longer knew, and that she would rather die on one of her own roads than in the chair she had spent a lifetime staying out of. She went the whole western circuit, from the wide crossing below Cathair dhearg round by the golden house and back, five weeks on the road with her staff worn now to a paler colour at the grip than anywhere else on its length, and she found, to her own satisfaction and to the surprise of the waypoint-keepers who had grown used to sending their complaints into a silence, that there was less to mend that year than in any year of her reign, and she said so at every waypoint house she stopped in, which the keepers took as high praise from a hard woman and repeated to their children after.

Four years later she died at Dùn dhearg, in the winter, of nothing anyone could name beyond her age, with her son beside her and the black-thorn staff standing in the corner of the room where she had had it set every night of her life since the woodworker gave it to her. She was two hundred and fifteen years old. There were people living on the island by then, of her own kin among the waypoint-keepers' houses, who had never known a righ but her, and who found it hard to picture the roads with anyone else's name attached to their mending.

They laid her out in the hall her father had built, and the household came in as it had for him, and stood a night and a day before the doors were shut. Word went out on the roads themselves, carried by the same waypoint system she had built up out of a ten-year-old complaint and a rutted ford, and it reached the far waypoint houses before the funeral could be held, so that carriers came in from three days' distance to stand outside the hall at Dùn dhearg, men and women who had eaten free at her opening feast or been paid out of her toll to cut back a riverbank, more of them than the household had thought to feed, and Dòmhnall, new in his chair and lame on his stick, had the golden house's own stores brought up to Dùn

dhearg to feed them, which his mother would have counted, had she lived to see it, the rightest thing he ever did.

Niall Òg came, the last time anyone at Dùn dhearg saw him, older now than any living memory could measure him against, and stood at the grave a long while on his own stick, and when someone asked him, since he had known her, to say a word over her, he said only that he had told her once about a cord and seven hundred knots, and that she was the one heir of that whole gathering who had spent her life looking at the cord, and that the roads she had mended were the nearest thing the island had, after her, to that same cord laid honestly on the ground for anyone to walk. Then he went away down the road on foot, as he had come, and refused a horse again, and no one at Dùn dhearg saw him after that day, though word came, years later and from a great distance, that he was still living.

The black-thorn staff was laid across her feet on the bier, whole and unbroken after forty years of every road on the island, worn smooth from end to end by a single hand; and that is the last thing the tellers give of Mòrag nan Rathad, before they go on, as the roads themselves went on, into the reign of her son.

VII

Of the Keepers of Ceann mhin and the Grain That Came First

Dòmhnall Crùbach ruled four-score years from the same hall, carried where his mother had walked, and where she had gone herself to every bad stretch of road, he sent the keepers of the waypoint houses in his stead, and trusted them to bring him an honest tally. Round the harbour town of Ceann mhin, where the road-toll came in heaviest off the eastern shipping, the keepers took to gathering it into their own hands within thirty years of his rule beginning and paying the hall what they judged a fair remainder, and their judgement, the rolls note without further comment, was generous to themselves in every year the rolls survive. Dòmhnall knew it, by report if not by his own eyes, and let it stand, for he could not walk to Ceann mhin to argue it and had no wish to send road-guards against men who kept the roads his mother had built running. It was a bargain no one swore as a bargain, and it held, more or less, for longer than his own reign.

In the west that same generation, settlers out from Cathair dhomhain took up the wet heath by the coast, where the ground was thin and the reed-beds thick with a small yellow scorpion the older shires thought a plague and the new settlers, within a few years of living among them, had come to think a kind of luck. A woman of that settlement, stung on the hand at a trade of cattle for salt fish, held her swelling fingers up before the other party rather than draw back from the bargain, and finished the trade with her hand still burning, saying that a hurt taken in the open was worth more than a promise given behind a closed door. Others took up the way of it after her, keeping a scorpion's sting, dried in a box, at every trading and swearing an oath on the pain of it rather than on a name or a god, and the settlement that grew up there took the name Baile àrsaidh, and its neighbours, who swore on hearth-fire or on the flame itself as everyone else on the island did, thought the whole custom a strange and a hard one, and said so, and traded there anyway, because a woman who would finish a bargain stung was a woman whose word could be trusted after.

Sileas Dhonn, Dòmhnall's sister's daughter, was a girl of fourteen at Dùn dhearg when her uncle first began asking her to sit in on the reckoning of the way-point-keepers' tallies, because her eye for a tally that did not add was sharper than any tally-keeper's he kept, and she found, going back through ten years of the Ceann mhin rolls at his bidding, three separate years in which the keepers' own count of what they had gathered did not match the count of what had passed through their gates, though never by enough, in any single year, to be called outright theft before a council that had no proof to set against a keeper's word. She said nothing of it publicly while her uncle lived, being young and his niece and the ruler of nothing at all, and kept her own tally-sticks of the count, notched in her own hand and locked in the same chest as her mother's marriage-cloth, and told no one why she kept them, only that a tally that did not add was a thing worth keeping until someone asked to see it.

In the forty-fifth year of Dòmhnall's reign a storm out of the west drove the sea over the harbour at Seann Chwen and took the boats at their moorings and a third of the houses with them, and left the survivors on the high ground above the water with nothing but what they stood in. Word of it reached Dùn ìseal and Dùn dhearg within the same day, carried on the road Mòrag nan Rathad had raised above the flood, the same road that had once swallowed a laden ox to the hocks and now ran dry through worse rain than that storm brought; and it was the Keeper's grain, carried down from the Hall's own stores, that reached the

ruined harbour first, a full day ahead of Dòmhnall's, though he had sent his the same hour the word came to him and grudged no bushel of it. The people of Seann Chwen ate from both that winter and were glad of both, and never afterward forgot, in all the tellings that followed, which grain had come up the road first; and it is told that the road itself, when the tale is given whole, is remembered as being no less part of the saving than the grain that was carried on it, being the very stretch above the ford that a righ's daughter had raised out of the mud in the first summer of her reign, a hundred and twenty-five years before the storm that proved it.

Of the Stag-Letters

FE 880 – 914

I

Of the Boy Who Counted Wrong

Rònat was ten years old the summer he was sent up from his father's holding to the stag's school in the holy wood east of Muileann chiar, and he arrived with a bundle of clothes, a knife his mother had cut too sharp for a boy his age, and a talent, already noticed by every adult who had ever set him to watch a flock, for losing count of anything past thirty. The teachers of the stag kept their reckonings on notched sticks, one stroke to a beast, a bundle, a day, and it was the first task of every new pupil to cut such a stick clean and true and bring it to the old cutter for judgement, and Rònat's first stick, judged by Aonghas Cam, came back to him with a groove scored clean through the middle of it and the single word: again.

Aonghas Cam had taught at the wood longer than any pupil then living could remember him not teaching, and he had a leg that had set crooked after a fall from the oak he still climbed every autumn to mark the mast, and a patience with a wrong stick that did not extend to a boy who argued with him about it. He set Rònat cutting sticks for two years before he let him near a beast to be counted at all, and told him, more than once and always in the same words, that a stick that lied was worse than no stick, because a man believed a stick the way he did not always believe another man, and a wrong count believed was a debt paid twice or a debt never paid at all.

It was slow work, the counting, and Rònat was not, by his own later account, ever quick at it; what he was, once he had it, was exact, and Aonghas Cam came in

time to trust his sticks over the sticks of pupils twice as fast with the knife, and to say so where the boy could hear it, which from Aonghas Cam was a kind of praise that other teachers spent whole speeches failing to match. By the time Rònát was one and twenty he cut the wood's own tally of the mast harvest and the new lambs and the toll owed the road-guards for the year, and it was put about, by pupils younger than himself, that Aonghas Cam trusted Rònát's stick before he trusted his own eyes, which Aonghas Cam neither confirmed nor troubled to deny.

The teaching itself, beyond the counting, was carried the old way, by a mouth and an ear and a memory trained to hold what it was given: the names of the beasts of the wood and which were the stag's and which were common; the turns of the year and which rite belonged to which turn; the descent of the teachers themselves, one from another, back further than any pupil could hold without losing the thread somewhere in the middle. Aonghas Cam held that whole thread, and said it over at every year's turning to whichever pupils could sit still long enough to hear the whole of it, and Rònát, sitting through it a dozen times by his twentieth year, found that he could hold perhaps two-thirds of it after, and lost the rest within a season, the same as every pupil before him had lost some part and no pupil after him would keep whole.

He said as much to Aonghas Cam once, in his twenty-fourth year, more out of a wish to be told he was wrong than any real complaint, and the old cutter looked at him a long while before he answered, in the flat way he had of answering a thing he had thought about longer than the boy asking it.

"You will lose more of it than I did," he said, "because I lost less of what was said to me than you will lose of what is said to you, there being more of it said now than there was said to me. And whoever comes after you will lose more again. It has always gone that way and there is no stick cut yet that holds a word instead of a count, so there is no help for it."

Rònát did not forget that answer, though he could not, at four and twenty, have said why it stayed with him longer than most of what Aonghas Cam said that same year.

The school itself was no more than three low houses and a byre set among the oaks of the holy wood, a morning's walk east of Muileann chiar along a path the mast-gatherers kept clear with their own feet more than any road-guard troubled to clear it, and it had stood in that clearing, teacher after teacher, longer than the wood's own oldest trees, or so the pupils were told and had no cause to doubt,

there being no mark on any tree to say otherwise and no stick cut yet that held such a mark if there had been. The pupils slept two and three to a pallet in the low house nearest the byre, rose before the light to feed what beasts the school kept for its own table, and spent the day between the counting and the beast-lore and, on the turning of the year, the rites that belonged to the stag's people alone, which Aonghas Cam taught with more patience than he ever showed a wrong stick, and which Rònát, of all that he was made to hold in memory those years, found came back to him whole and unbidden even in his old age, long after the thread of names had thinned past keeping.

II

Of the Sign Made for a Sound

Aonghas Cam's leg, crooked since his fall, took a fever in the wet autumn of Rònát's thirty-first year that no poultice the wood's healers laid on it would draw out, and he did not climb the oak that year to mark the mast, sending Rònát up in his place for the first time, and spent the winter in the low house by the fire, teaching what he could sitting down and losing his breath over what he could not. Rònát sat with him most evenings of that winter, less as a pupil now than as the man who fetched wood and water for an old teacher too proud to ask a younger one for either, and it was in those evenings, watching Aonghas Cam search for a name or a line of the old thread and not always find it before his breath gave out, that the shape of the thing came to Rònát, slowly and in pieces, the way a knot comes undone by first one strand and then another and not all at once.

He had been cutting a tally-stick that same week, one groove to a fish counted at the smoke-house, and it struck him, watching Aonghas Cam grope after a name he had said clean a hundred times before, that a groove held a count exactly and forgot nothing of it, and a mouth held a name or a line of teaching only as well as the mouth's own memory served it on the day, which was not always well. If a groove could be made to stand for a count, he thought, there was no reason in wood or knife that it could not be made to stand for a sound instead, and a row of sounds was a name, and a row of names in their right order was the very thread Aonghas Cam was losing by the fire, held now on something that did not have a bad night or a failing breath.

He did not say any of this to Aonghas Cam that winter, fearing to be told it was foolishness, and fearing worse, though he owned to this only later, to be told it had been tried before and failed for a reason he had not thought of. So he worked at it alone, in the hours before the school woke, cutting the same length of straight-grained ash over and over, one edge to lay the strokes against, as a stick already carried for a plain count. The trick of it, when it came, lay in giving each sound of speech its own small mark against that edge: some short and to one side, some short and to the other, some crossing the edge clean through, some slanting, so that a hand running down it in the dark could tell one sound from the next by touch alone before the eye had even looked. The vowels he set apart from the rest, five short cuts standing clear of the long consonant-marks, for a school-child learning them first would want the vowels easiest to the hand, and he had been such a child himself not so many years before, and remembered which sounds had come hardest.

By the spring he had cut his own name on a stick, and could read it back cold, without the stick in front of him, three days after cutting it; and then Aonghas Cam's name, and read that back too; and then, on an evening when the old man's breath was better than it had been in a month, he set the stick in Aonghas Cam's own hand and told him what the marks were, and asked him to run his thumb down the edge and say what he found.

Aonghas Cam was a long time silent over it, turning the stick, running his thumb back along the strokes a second time and a third. "This is my name," he said at last, "cut on a stick as if it were a count of fish."

"It is a count," said Rònath. "A count of sounds, in their order, same as a count of fish is a count of fish in their order taken."

The old man laughed at that, a short laugh that cost him more breath than he had to spend, and said that a boy who had once cut a stick so wrong it had to be scored through the middle had come, in the end, to cutting a stick no one on the island had thought to cut before him, and that he did not know whether that was a joke on him or a joke on the wood's whole way of teaching, and thought, on the whole, it was likely both.

Word of the sound-marks went round the school before the summer was out, and round the other schools of the stag within two years more, carried by pupils moving between them the way any new trick of the knife was carried, and by the time Rònát was five and thirty he had taught the whole scheme, strokes and vowels and the order of cutting them, to every pupil under him and to two teachers of the western school who came east on purpose to see it and stayed a season learning it from a man twenty years their junior without any evident shame in the asking. Aonghas Cam did not live to see the western teachers come; he died in Rònát's thirty-third year, in his sleep, in the same low house by the fire where he had first read his own name off a stick, and it was Rònát who cut, at the old man's own asking made some months before, the tally of his years on a length of the same ash, one stroke for each, rather than the sounds of his name, because Aonghas Cam had said, hearing what the new marks could do, that he wanted his years counted the old way at the last, having spent his whole life trusting a count over a name.

It was Sileas nic Ruairidh, eldest of the western teachers who had come to learn the scheme, who first asked the question that sent Rònát and two others west to Cnoc bheag in Rònát's four-and-fortieth year, in the season the mast was gathered. She had been told, as every pupil of the stag was told somewhere in the long thread of teaching, that there stood at Cnoc bheag an old grey stone cut with marks no living teacher could read, set up by hands no living teacher could name, and it came to her, turning the new sound-marks over in her mind as she fell asleep one night, to wonder whether the old marks on that stone might be sounds too, cut by some maker whose speech the marks would give back if only someone knew now how to look.

They walked the road west together, the three of them, five days on foot with a tally-stick from the wood's own steward to see them fed at the waypoint houses along the way, and slept the fourth night at a turf longhouse with a hearth at either end, where the keeper, an old woman who had never heard of the sound-marks nor asked to, fed them barley and dried fish and told them, unprompted, that the road that far west ran along ground her own grandmother's grandmother had walked before there was any toll on it at all, which Rònát wrote down nowhere, having as yet nothing to write it in beyond his own memory, and thought afterward that this too was a kind of thread that would thin and be lost the way every unwritten thread was lost, whether or not anyone standing by the fire that night troubled to mourn it. They came to the stone on a grey morning,

the rain still holding off, and stood before it a long while before any of the three so much as touched it. The marks on the old stone ran in lines and crossings not unlike Rònát's own scheme, cut deep enough that centuries of weather had not worn them smooth, and for a morning and half an afternoon the three of them set every stroke of the old marks beside every stroke of the new, turning the stone, comparing angle to angle and count to count, hoping, none of them said aloud what they hoped, that some line of it would answer to some line of theirs and give back, after all that silence, a single sound they could name.

Nothing answered. The strokes on the stone kept no order that matched the order Rònát had given his own, no vowel stood apart the way his stood apart, no five-and-five grouping of the marks gave up anything a mouth could shape. By evening Sìleas nic Ruairidh sat down on the wet grass at the stone's foot and said, plainly, that whoever had cut it had not taught them, and had not been taught by anyone who had taught them either, and that the two schemes, hers and the stone's, shared nothing but the accident of being marks cut in rows on a hard surface, which was no kinship at all, being the only way marks can be cut on a hard surface whether the makers ever knew of one another or not.

Rònát cut that finding onto a fresh stick before they took the road home, the first time, so far as any of the three knew, that a whole thought and not a single name or a single count had been set down in the new marks: that the makers of the stone at Cnoc bheag had not taught the makers of the stag's marks, and were not known to them, and left nothing behind that answered anything the three of them had brought to ask it. It was a small thing to have crossed five days of road to learn, and a smaller thing still to have carved, a handful of strokes on a length of ash beside a stone that had stood mute for longer than any of them could reckon; but it was the first thing the Dia-thìrich ever set down of the makers of that stone, and what it said was only what they were not.

IV

Of the Ancient Man Who Laughed

Níall Òg came through the far east twice in those years, once before Aonghas Cam's death and once after, walking as he always walked, on his own two feet with a stick worn pale at the grip and no household about him beyond whatever family happened, that season, to be minding the wood he

passed through. He was old past any counting the school itself could put a number to with confidence, well past his eighteen hundredth year by the reckoning the teachers kept among themselves from the tales told of Ailean's own fall, and he had outlived, by that reckoning, every one of the seven hundred and twelve heirs who had stood beside him at the cord's cutting save Eithne nic Ailein alone, and most of the children of those heirs besides, and he walked the roads still as a man walks a road he means to keep walking, without any particular hurry to be somewhere he had not yet been.

He came to the school in Rònat's forty-third year, the second of his two passings, an old man greeting an old man's school with the easy familiarity of someone who had watched it built in his own lifetime and expected, without saying so, to watch a good deal more of it before he was done, and he sat by the fire in the low house two evenings running, telling the pupils tales of the night of the handful that not one of them had heard told by a man who had stood there, and asking, when the tales ran out, after the trick he had been told of on the road, the marks that were said to hold a name the way a stick held a count.

Rònat cut his name for him that second evening, Niall's own name in the strokes, and set it in his hand, and told him to run his thumb along it the way Aonghas Cam once had, and said what each stroke gave. Niall Òg was quicker at it than Aonghas Cam had been, or perhaps only less proud to be seen slow, and read his own name back within the hour, haltingly at first and then clean, and sat with the stick in his two hands a while after, turning it, before he began to laugh.

It was not a short laugh. It took him by the chest and would not let go for the better part of a minute, an old man's laugh that ended, as old men's laughs will, in a fit of coughing that brought two of the younger pupils half out of their seats before he waved them back down with the hand that was not holding the stick, and when he had his breath again he said that he had been called by his name more times than there were fish in the western sea, by mothers and by kings and by every heir of the seven hundred and twelve who had ever wanted a thing off him, and that not one of those tellings had ever held still on a piece of wood after the telling was done, waiting for him to come back and hear it again whenever he chose.

"A name that stays," he said, "when the mouth that gave it is gone home to its supper. I have wanted that trick my whole long life and never once thought to ask for it, because I did not know there was a trick to ask for." He gave the stick back to Rònat, though Rònat pressed it on him to keep, and said that a man who had

outlived every stick anyone had ever cut of him so far had no need to start keeping the ones that came after; better it stayed at the school, where a pupil could learn from it that even a name as old as his own could be held on so small a thing.

He went on east the next morning, refusing, as he always refused, the offer of a horse, and word of him came to the school twice more in the years after, from travellers who had passed him on some other road entirely, walking still.

V

Of the Keepers Who Would Not Write

Dòmhnall Crùbach died at Dùn dhearg in his hundred and eightieth year, the same season Rònath turned four and forty, and the household stood the customary night and day with his chair empty before Sileas Dhonn, his sister's daughter, went in and sat down in it and did not get up again for the better part of a year. She had kept, through all the years of her uncle's reign, her own fair copy of the waypoint-keepers' tallies locked in a chest with her mother's marriage-cloth, three years of Ceann mhin's figures that did not match the count of what had passed through Ceann mhin's own gates, and she had told no one why she kept them beyond that a column that did not add was worth keeping until someone asked to see it. In the first winter of her own reign she had that chest brought up and opened before the whole household, and sent word to every waypoint house on the island that the keeper of it should come to Dùn dhearg within the year and render account of the tolls taken in his own hand or another's, in whatever manner he judged fit to render it, so long as it could be checked against what the road-guards themselves had counted passing the same gate.

Word of the sound-marks had reached Dùn dhearg by then, carried the length of the island the way any new trick travelled, on the tongues of carriers and the word of stewards, though no keeper of a waypoint house had yet troubled to learn the scheme himself, it being, as far as most of them were concerned, a schoolboy's trick of the stag's people and no business of a toll-house. It was the keeper of Muileann shean, an old man named Beathan mac Dhonnchaidh who had held that house since before Dòmhnall Crùbach's own accession, who came to Dùn dhearg in the second year of Sileas Dhonn's reign with his tally recited from memory in the old way, name for name and count for count, the way every keeper before him had ever rendered an account to any ruler; and Sileas Dhonn

heard him through to the end without once interrupting, and then asked him, plainly, how she was to know that what he had just recited was the same tally he had recited to the road-guard who rode through his gate that same season, there being no way to set one telling against the other once both were three seasons gone and held only in two separate memories that might, without either man meaning to lie, have drifted from each other in the telling.

Beathan mac Dhonnchaidh had no answer to that beyond his own long honesty, which Sileas Dhonn did not doubt and said so, and let him go home without penalty; but she sent, within the month, to the far-eastern school, asking whether a teacher of the stag might be spared to come to Dùn dhearg and teach her own clerks the sound-marks, so that a keeper's tally, cut once at the gate in the road-guard's presence, might be carried whole to the hall instead of trusted a second time to a memory that had crossed the whole island since.

It was Rònath himself who went, in his forty-sixth year, the last long road he walked before age began to slow him, and he taught Sileas Dhonn's clerks the strokes and the vowels over a winter at Dùn dhearg much as he had once taught them to pupils half his own age in the holy wood, finding the ruler's clerks quicker with the knife than any pupil he had taught before, being grown men and women already trained to a column of figures and wanting only the new marks to set beside the old ones they already knew. Ailig mac Ruairidh, keeper of the toll at Ceann mhin, whose house had been named in Sileas Dhonn's own three years of mismatched figures, was the first keeper summoned to render account after the clerks were taught, and the first ordered to bring his tally cut in the new marks rather than carried in his head, checked against a second cutting made by the road-guard at his own gate the same season; and when the two tallies were set side by side at Dùn dhearg before the whole hall, in the second winter of Sileas Dhonn's reign, they did not match, by a sum neither honest forgetting nor an honest drift of memory could account for, and Ailig mac Ruairidh, who had judged, like every keeper of Ceann mhin before him, that his own word carried further than any road-guard's, found for the first time that a stick cut at his own gate had carried further than his word.

He was not the last keeper found out that way, nor even, in that first year, the worst of them; but he was the first, and word of it ran the length of the carriers' road faster than any letter could have carried it, so that keepers who had never troubled to learn the new marks sent, within the season, to ask whether a teacher might be spared them too, having heard it said, by carriers who had stood in the

hall at Dùn dhearg and seen the two sticks set side by side, that a keeper caught out by his own gate's stick had no more room left to argue than a man caught with the stolen thing still in his hand. The clerks who set Ailig mac Ruairidh's two tallies side by side and read out the difference between them, plainly, before the hall, did it in the new marks, off two sticks that neither man's memory could soften afterward however either of them told the story elsewhere. Sileas Dhonn took no more from him than the sum itself, made whole, and let him keep his house, saying that a keeper caught once and shamed before the whole hall commonly kept an honest tally after than a keeper hanged for it would have taught any other keeper to be, there being no other keeper left alive to learn the lesson from a hanging.

It was in the same winter, cutting the record of Ailig mac Ruairidh's shortfall for the hall's own keeping, that Rònath set down, for the clerks to copy and learn by, the first whole sentence any hand at the hall had yet cut in the new marks: that the toll of Ceann mhin, counted at the gate and counted again at the hall, had come short by a sum the gate's own count made plain, and that the keeper had answered for it before Sileas Dhonn and her household. It was a plain thing to say and a plainer thing to have needed saying at all, after so many years of tallies rendered on trust and kept only as long as one old man's breath held out to repeat them; but it stood after, cut whole on its length of ash in the hall's own keeping, saying the same thing every time any clerk's thumb ran down it, in a season when the man who had spoken it first was already three days gone home on the eastern road, and would not himself have known, walking it, that his own words had outlasted the telling.

He walked that road a slower man than he had walked the road to Cnoc bheag two years before with Sileas nic Ruairidh beside him and a question about an old stone still open between them, and he thought, somewhere on the third of those days, of Aonghas Cam by the fire in the last winter of his life, groping after a name he had said clean a hundred times before and not always finding it, and of the answer the old man had given a boy of four and twenty who had complained, once, of losing the thread of a teaching within a season of hearing it. There was no help for it, Aonghas Cam had said, there being no stick cut yet that held a word instead of a count. Rònath came home to the holy wood in the last light of the fifth day, an old man himself now by the school's own reckoning, and found the pupils waiting on him for the evening's counting the way pupils had always waited on a teacher, and cut that evening's tally as he had cut ten thousand tallies

before it, one stroke to a beast, before he sat down by his own fire and, for the first time in all the years since he had first set his own name on a stick, cut nothing further that night at all, being content, for once, to let the day go unrecorded and trust it, as every day before the sound-marks had ever been trusted, to memory alone.

Of the Basket of Fish-Bones

FE 915 – 1,009

I

Of Sileas Dhonn's Reckoning

I ain, son of Sileas Dhonn, was born at Dùn dhearg in the fifteenth year of his mother's long watch over the waypoint-keepers' tallies, and he grew up under a roof where a column of figures was looked at with the same care other households gave a wound. His mother had found, going back through the Ceann mhin rolls in her girlhood, three years in which the keepers' own count did not match what had passed through their gates, and she had never afterward let a tally lie unchecked a season. By the time Iain could walk the length of the hall without a hand to steady him, she was ruler in all but the chair itself, her uncle Dòmhnall Crùbach old and content to let her carry what his leg would not, and the boy grew up at her knee hearing her read out a keeper's account the way other boys heard the old tales.

He was not a quick child with the reckoning itself. What he had, his mother said, laughing at him more than once across the ledgers, was a memory for a face that had lied to her once, and he never forgot one. She set him, from the age of ten, to sit beside her when the keepers came in from the road to give their tallies in person, watching the men who gave them rather than the columns they gave, and more than once it was Iain who said afterward, low, that the keeper of Muileann shean had not looked at her when he named his season's toll, and more than once

his mother found, on going back through the man's figures with a harder eye, that he had been right.

He was not gentle with what he found. He had his father's build, broad through the shoulder before he was fifteen, and a laugh that carried the length of a hall and did not always come at the moment a laugh was looked for; the household called him Iain Garbh, Iain the Rough, half in fondness and half in caution, and the name stayed on him the rest of his life. His mother did not check the name. "A rough hand keeps a straight column as well as a soft one," she said, "and better, in a season when a keeper thinks a soft hand can be talked round."

Dòmhnall Crùbach died in the nine hundred and fourteenth year of the Hall, and the household stood the customary night and day with the chair empty before Sileas Dhonn went in and sat in it, and did not get up again for the better part of a year. She was five-and-seventy and would rule four-score years more, and in all that reign, which the keepers came to call, among themselves and not to her face, the long counting, she broke not one column that she found honest and forgave not one that she found false. She widened the toll on nothing and lightened it on nothing; she only made certain that what was owed came in whole, and that what came in whole was written down where a later hand could not soften it. Under her the granaries at Dùn dhearg filled steadier than they had filled under any ruler since Goraiddh Mòr first raised the timber hall over the granary door, and the roads Mòrag nan Rathad had cut through the mud two centuries before were kept, by Sileas Dhonn's order and at her cost, in better repair than the old woman herself might have troubled to keep them once the far stretches stopped catching her eye.

She sent Iain out on the roads himself from his twentieth year, first with an older keeper to mind him and then alone, and he came back from those years with a sunburn that never wholly left his face and a habit, which stayed with him the rest of his days, of counting a granary's sacks with his own hands before he would take any steward's word for the number. He learned the shares that paid their tolls whole without being asked and the ones that paid only when a rider from Dùn dhearg stood at the gate to watch them do it, and among the second kind, in the years his mother still ruled, none was worse than the harbour town in the south-west called Caol leathan.

Caol leathan sat where the western fishing came in thickest and where the carriers' road that ran the length of the island met the sea, and it had grown fat on both, fatter than any town of its size on the coast, under the leading family of the

place, whose head in Iain's young manhood was a broad, quiet man named Lachlann Ciar. The town's toll on the road's southern end had been Dùn dhearg's by right since the road-peace was first sworn, but it reached Dùn dhearg thinner every season Iain rode down to collect it, and thinner still the seasons he did not, and Lachlann Ciar's answers, when pressed, were always the same: a poor season on the boats, a poor season on the road, the toll-house roof wanting mending before the toll itself could be counted properly. Iain rode home from his third visit at twenty-six years old and told his mother, plainly, that the man was lying to her face and smiling while he did it, and that he had counted the boats in the harbour himself and there had been no poor season in it that any eye but a liar's could see.

"Then you know him," said Sileas Dhonn, "and knowing a liar is worth more than catching him once. Wait. He is not the one who will answer for it; his account is not run out yet, and mine has years left in it either way."

Her account had near sixty more years in it, and Iain waited them out at her side, counting granaries and watching a man in the far south-west grow fatter on a toll that was not his, and he did not forget the man's face, nor the smiling poverty of his excuses, nor the boats that had not once, in all Iain's visits, been fewer than the harbour could hold.

There was one keeper, in those waiting years, whom Iain never forgot either, though for a gentler reason. The man kept the toll-house at Cnoc dhubh on the eastern stretch of the road, an old fellow with a stammer that grew worse the longer Iain sat across the table from him, and on Iain's second visit the tally came out a full third short of the traffic Iain had himself counted passing the gate that week. He said nothing while the man stammered through his reckoning, and said nothing after, only asked, mildly, whether the keeper's daughter was still down with the fever that had kept the household from the last two fairs. The keeper, startled into honesty by the question, said she was, and that the physician at Muileann shean wanted paying, and that he had thought, the gods forgive him, to make up the difference out of the toll and put it back before the reckoning was due. Iain rode home and told his mother the whole of it, expecting, he said afterward, to see the man's name struck from the rolls before the month was out. Sileas Dhonn sent instead silver for the physician and word that named no theft at all, only a debt owed and now discharged, and told her son that a rough hand did well enough on a column that lied for greed, but wanted a softer one for a column that lied for love, and that he had best learn to tell the two apart before he sat in the chair himself. Iain kept that lesson beside the other; it was, he said in his own

old age, the harder of the two to hold onto, and the one he was proudest of holding.

II

Of the Basket of Fish-Bones

Sileas Dhonn died in her hundred and fifty-fifth year, in the nine hundred and ninety-fourth year of the Hall, sitting upright in the chair with a keeper's tally still open on her knee, and the household found her there in the grey of the morning with the ink not yet dry on the line she had been reading. She had asked, near the end, that the chair stand its customary night and day and no longer, and that whoever came after her not waste a season getting the feel of it, having had, she said, sixty years to get the feel of it already at her side.

Iain Garbh was eighty-five years old the night the chair stood open, and he did not stand long in the doorway looking at it the way, it was told, his grandmother's grandmother once had. He went in at first light, sat down, and sent for the year's tallies before the household had finished the mourning-meal.

Caol leathan's account that year showed the same figure it had shown for a decade: a toll paid thin, and an excuse to cover the thinness. Iain read it once, set it down, and sent a rider south with a plain demand, in his own hand and no steward's: the toll owed in full, counted before Dùn dhearg's own man at the harbour, or an answer for why it should not be paid at all.

The rider was gone the better part of a month, longer than the road alone accounted for, and came back at last white about the mouth and would not meet Iain's eye when he set what he carried on the floor of the hall. It was a basket, covered, of a size a fisherman's wife might carry to market, and it had been carried the length of the island roped shut, and the household backed a step from it before Iain had so much as touched the lid.

He lifted it himself. The smell came up first, old and gone dry, and under the smell, packed in rows the way a careful hand packs herring for the keeping, was a basket entirely full of fish-bones, picked clean, not one scrap of flesh left on any of them, and no letter, no word, no answer at all beyond the basket itself and the silence of the man who had sent it.

Iain looked at it a long while. Then he laughed, once, short and hard, a sound that frightened the household a good deal more than shouting would have done,

because they had heard him shout before and knew the shape of it, and had never heard this. He called for the road-guards to be summoned from every waypoint within three days' ride, and for the lowland households to be told their levy stood, and he did not raise his voice again the whole of that week, which those who had known him longest found harder to bear than any roaring would have been.

"He has sent me an answer," Iain said, to the steward who asked what the basket meant. "There is nothing left in Caol leathan worth the honesty of a letter, and I believe him."

III

Of the Flame That Would Not Come

he marched west before the month was out, with the road-guards of the southern waypoints and the lowland levies behind him, and he took the toll-house at Muileann òg that Lachlann Ciar's people had seized from Dùn dhearg's own keeper two winters before, and burned it, standing with his arms folded to watch the thatch go up, in a silence the household about him found harder to read than any order he might have given. It was the first war fought by Dia-thìreach against Dia-thìreach since the Peace of the Threshold had been sworn, and the first, of all the wars the reciters could name before it, fought over a road and not a share; every quarrel before this one had been a quarrel over land, and this was a quarrel over the right to carry a thing across land that both sides agreed belonged to neither of them.

Before he marched further Iain sent to Dùn ìseal for the Hall's blessing on the warband's hearths, as every rìgh before him had done at the raising of a levy, asking no more than the customary handful to light the first night's fires on the road. The messengers came back on the third day with their hands empty and a message they had been made, by the Keeper himself, to repeat word for word before they were let go.

Cha bhlàthaich an lasair fir a tha a' dol a mharbhadh. The flame will not warm men who are going to kill.

Uisdean mac Ruairidh had held the flame at Dùn ìseal eleven years by then, a spare, grey-eyed man who had never once, in all that time, refused a rìgh's messenger anything the Hall was able to give, and Iain heard the answer read out twice before he was certain he had heard it whole. He did not send a second messenger

to argue it. He stood a while with the strip of hide the first had carried, on which the Keeper's words had been set down in the stag-letters by a clerk at Dùn Ìseal so there could be no mistaking them later, and then he folded it once and put it inside his coat, and it is told that he carried that same strip, worn soft at the folds, the rest of his life, and would show it, in his old age, to anyone fool enough to ask him why he never once, in forty years, set foot inside the Hall's own ground.

"Then we'll burn peat," he said, and the warband wintered on peat that year at Muileann òg, coughing through the cold months on smoke that lay low and sour over the camp and would not draw clean the way the Hall's flame drew, and men who had marched south whole came home in the spring with a cough that some of them carried the rest of their days, so that the older road-guards, decades on, could be told from the younger by the sound of a hard winter's night. Iain coughed with the rest of them and never once said, that whole winter or after, that he wished he had swallowed his pride and sent a gentler messenger; and it was in that camp, watching the sour smoke lie over his own men, that the division of keeping was first spoken aloud and understood for what it was: that the rìgh held the spears and the Keeper held the flame, and that neither, whatever the provocation, could any longer lay a hand on the other's.

The camp at Muileann òg was a poor thing to winter in, a scatter of turf shelters thrown up around the burned toll-house with the black timbers still standing over them like a warning nobody had asked for, and Iain walked it every evening of that season with a road-guard named Dùghall at his shoulder, a young man from the eastern waypoints who had never before been further from home than a day's ride and said so, more than once, in the flat voice of a man too cold to be ashamed of complaining. "The Hall would have kept us dry," Dùghall said one such evening, not quite meaning it as a challenge, and Iain, who had not expected to be answered for the choice by anyone under his own command, found he had no readier answer than the one he had already given the steward. "The Hall keeps whoever it likes dry," he said, "and it does not like us this season. Wrap the coat tighter and mind the peat doesn't smother; a smothered fire coughs worse than a good one." Dùghall did as he was told, and lived to be an old man himself, and told the story of that winter, in his own age, to grandchildren who found it hard to credit that a rìgh had once stood over a peat fire at midnight showing a common guardsman how to keep it drawing.

IV

Of the Ford of the Forty

In the spring the men of Caol leathan met the levies of Iain Garbh at the ford of Àth fhiadhaich, where the road crossed the last river before the harbour town, and held the water against them a full day before they gave way. They had chosen the ground with more care than Iain expected of them, forming along the far bank where the current ran hardest and a man had to fight the water before he could fight anything else, and he heard, before ever he saw the far rank clearly, Lachlann Ciar's own voice carrying across the noise, hoarse already, telling his people to hold the deep water and let the river do half the work for them. It did. The first men across went down as much to the current as to any blade, and Iain, standing in reserve on the near bank with the second rank around him, watched the water take three before a single spear had crossed it, and understood, watching, why his mother had always said a fool fights the ground before he fights the man on it.

Iain went in with the second rank himself, when the first had thinned enough to want him, and he remembered it afterward, in the few tellings he ever gave of that day, less as a battle than as a string of particular things: the cold that took the legs at the first step into the current, worse than any cold he had felt on the winter roads; the noise of it, which was not the noise he had expected, less shouting than a kind of grunting labour, men working at killing the way other men worked at a stubborn stump; and one man of Caol leathan in particular, standing waist-deep with a shield split clean through and still holding it up before him with no sense left in the holding, until a spear thrown from somewhere behind Iain's own shoulder found him and he went down into the water and did not come up where Iain could see.

By evening the men of Caol leathan had given the ford, falling back toward the harbour in good order, and the carriers who came that way named it the ford of the forty, for the number of dead the two sides left in the shallows and on the near bank, and said, in the tellings that grew up around it in the waypoint houses, that the Murrigan's own crows were down on the ford before the last light left the water, walking among the dead as if the field were theirs before either side had finished claiming it.

Iain crossed the water that night with the rest of the levy and did not look for the man with the split shield among the drowned, though it is told he asked, once, months later, whether any name had been kept for him, and was told none had.

V

Of Baile ghlais and Baile chial

Falling back on Caol leathan, Lachlann Ciar's men burned the granaries and the standing grain at Baile ghlais, a lowland town that had sent Iain neither men nor grudge in the whole of the war, so that the levies coming after would find nothing there to feed themselves on. Iain rode through the warm ash the next morning, the roofs still smoking, and found no one left in the place to ask where its people had gone; they had walked north to Cathair dhomhain in the night, most of them, and a good number of those, weakened on the road or taken by the cold that followed, never came home again to see what little was left standing.

South of the bridge-foot, the town of Baile chial shut its gate against both hosts that same season and would let neither the levies of Dùn dhearg nor the men of Caol leathan inside its walls, and instead opened its own granaries to the burned-out people of Baile ghlais and fed them through the whole of that hard winter on grain the town had meant for its own year. Iain rode up to that gate himself, meaning to ask lodging for a night for no more than himself and a dozen men, and was met on the wall by the town's own reeve, a broad woman named Beathag who called down that the gate opened for the hungry and for no one carrying a spear, right or otherwise, and that if he wanted a roof he could leave the spear on the road below and come up with empty hands like any other man asking shelter of a stranger. Iain looked at the wall a while, and at the smoke of Baile ghlais still faint behind him on the wind, and left the spear where she had told him to leave it, and slept that night on a floor among refugees from a town he had ridden through the ashes of two days before, and never afterward spoke a hard word of Baile chial in any household where the tale might carry back to it. Neither side forgave the shut gate, each reading it as favour shown to the other, and neither, for all that, ever brought a spear against it; and in the years after, when the carriers spoke of the towns that had kept faith in the War of the Roads, they set Baile

chiar's name beside no other town's, because it had kept faith with neither army and with every hungry mouth that came to its gate.

Iain closed Caol leathan by land before that winter was out, ringing the town on every road with his levies, but he could not close what the town's own boats still brought it from the sea. From the camp on the hill above the harbour he watched, night after night, the low dark shapes slip in past his lines at dusk, heavy in the water with fish, and there was nothing a road-guard on a hillside could do about a harbour that opened onto open sea. His levies, drawn from households that had their own harvest waiting, began going home first by ones and then by whole villages as the season turned, and the siege that could not close a harbour ended without an assault, dissolved by an army that simply was no longer there to press it.

VI

Of the Peace at Mòr nic Dhùghaill's House

The war ended, as every long quarrel on the island's roads had come, in the end, to end, under the roof of a waypoint house bound by the road-peace, where no man might draw a blade on another whatever stood between them outside its door. Iain Garbh and Lachlann Ciar met that autumn at the house that had once been Mòr nic Dhùghaill's, on the western road where the road-peace had first been sworn generations before, and sat down at one board because the roof over them allowed nothing else.

Iain had thought, riding to it, that he would find the fat, smiling liar of his younger years, the man who had sent boats out full while he swore the season poor. He found instead an old man with a cough of his own, thinner than the harbour's wealth should have left him, who ate the jugged buffalo the house was known for without much appetite and did not, for a long while, say anything at all. It was Lachlann Ciar who broke the silence first, saying only that the fish-bones had been his son's notion and not his own, and that he had let it go out under his own name because a father does not send a son's foolishness back to be answered for by the son; and Iain, hearing it, found he no longer much wanted the argument he had ridden south to have.

They talked the rest of that evening as two old men talk who have spent thirty years disliking each other from a distance and find, sitting across one board, that

the distance had done most of the disliking's work. Caol leathan kept half its road-toll after that and sent half to Dùn dhearg, and Lachlann Ciar swore to the Small-Burning Law before the witness of a keeper sent down from the Hall for the purpose, the first oath the Hall's own witness had taken from him in twenty years, though Uisdean mac Ruairidh did not come himself, and neither man asked him to.

It left three things behind it, that war fought over a road and ended in a house built to feed the carriers of one. Iain rode south the following spring, at Lachlann Ciar's own asking, to stand at the town gate of Caol leathan while the men who had fought the siege that could not close a harbour swore their new watch upon it: a white stone cut, by a mason of the town, in the rough shape of a wolf standing over what might have been a fish or might have been a lamb, no two tellers agreeing which, and set into the gatepost where every traveller on the road would pass under its eye. The men knelt to it one by one, a hand laid flat on the stone's cold flank, and swore to count a toll true and carry a warning fast and never again send a covered basket in place of an honest word, and called themselves, from that swearing on, the wolf-sworn; and Iain, watching from horseback with Lachlann Ciar's son at his stirrup, said to no one in particular that he would have given a fair sum, in his younger years, to see the day a road-guard of Caol leathan swore anything at all before an honest witness. No waypoint-keeper on the southern road ever again found reason to doubt a toll that a wolf-sworn guard had counted. The harbour town of Caol fhiadhaich, whose boats had fed the besieged town through the whole hard winter Iain could not starve it out, was given by Lachlann Ciar a share of the western tolls in payment, and built with it, in the years after, a harbour wall of its own. And Iain Garbh, riding home past Dùn ìseal for the last time in his life, did not turn in at the Hall's gate, nor ever would again; the folded strip of hide stayed inside his coat, and the flame that would not warm him stayed, by his own choosing, a flame he never again asked to be warmed by.

Lachlann Ciar died eleven years after the peace at Mòr nic Dhùghaill's house, in his ninetieth year, the cough that had sat with him at that last board having worn him down by slow degrees the way it had worn down half the men who wintered on peat smoke at Muileann òg; and word came to Dùn dhearg that his household had buried him within sight of the harbour he had grown fat and then thin defending, with his son standing where he had stood at the peace-board, ready, if the toll ever thinned again, to send an honest answer south than a basket of bones. Iain read the word of it at his own hearth, said nothing for a while,

and then went out into a cold rain that had been falling since morning and walked the length of the road above the ford without his staff or his steward, in no hurry at all to come back in.

OF the Last of the Nine

FE 1,010 – 1,122

Dh'fhairtlich air an fhèath fhèin fuireach. Even the calm could not
stay calm.

— said of Eithne nic Ailein by the reciters of Cathair mhòr, after her

I

Of the Hall at Cathair mhòr

Eithne nic Ailein kept her hall at Cathair mhòr in the hundredth generation of her own house, though she called none of them her house, since a woman who has buried her own great-great-grandchildren counts her kin by some longer measure than generations. She was the youngest of the nine who had cut the cord at the Roinn, and by the tenth century of the Hall she was also the last of them living, though she felt it first in the way a hall feels emptier before anyone tells you who has died, and knew it for a fact only later.

She was old past two thousand nine hundred years and did not look it, or rather looked it in a way that had stopped changing: the long years did that, her father's blood held its shape once it had settled into age, the way a stone settles into the bank of a river and is not moved again by any flood after the first hundred. Her hands were thin and quick still. Her hair had been white so long that no one living remembered it any other colour, not even her own stewards, whose grandfathers had died in service to her. She sat in the lowland hall she had sat in since before the Peace of the Threshold, and she heard the island's news the way a person hears weather come in from a long way off: felt before it was named.

Her household kept her days simple, by her own long-standing order: bread and fish and the wool of her own sheds, a fire lit whatever the season, and no one troubled to bring her the disputes of Cathair mhòr's own share, which she had handed to a council of stewards a hundred years before and had not once taken back. She had, in her time, cut a knot at a gathering-house, sworn an oath on a threshold beside a carried chair, and buried more kin than most halls on the island had ever held living at one time; and by the tenth century of the Hall she had settled, without meaning to settle anywhere, into the office of an old woman who is asked nothing and told everything, which she had come to think, on her better days, the most restful office a person of her blood could hold.

In the tenth century of the Hall the news that came to her hall was mostly of the west, where a rìgh she had never met, a son of Sileas Dhonn called Iain Garbh, was fighting a war over a road-toll with a household at Caol leathan that would not send its share to Dùn dhearg. Eithne heard the first of it from a wool-merchant come up from the coast with a load for her own weaving-sheds, a man who told the tale the way traders tell any tale, for what it was worth in the telling.

"They say the Keeper sent his messengers home with nothing," the merchant said, "and the rìgh burned a toll-house for it, and the whole west is up in arms over a basket of fish-bones."

"A basket of fish-bones," said Eithne, who had heard stranger reasons for a war and started one or two herself, long before this merchant's grandmother was born. "Tell it me again from the beginning."

She heard it three times more before the war ended, each telling a little different, as tellings are, and she did not go to it and did not send to it. Cathair mhòr's own share had kept its tolls and its peace both, and she had long since given up riding to wars that were another share's business to end. The last of the nine, whoever she was, stayed by her own fire.

II

Of the Harbour Wall at Caol fhiadhaich

It was told to her afterward, by the same wool-merchant on his next journey, how the town of Caol fhiadhaich on the south-western shore had sent its own boats out in the worst of the siege to feed the besieged town of Caol leathan by night, running fish past the rìgh's watch-fires on the hill, because the

two towns had markets in each other's children and would not see either starve for a quarrel neither had made.

"Iain Garbh gave them a share of the tolls for it, after," the merchant said, "the western tolls, a good share, and they've put up a wall round the harbour with the silver of it, the first stone wall that coast has had."

Eithne had never seen Caol fhiadhaich and never would; it lay the width of the island from her own hall by the roads she no longer travelled, and she pictured it the way an old woman pictures a place from a stranger's words, as something both smaller and grander than it was, a wall of pale stone standing up out of grey water with boats drawn under it. She thought, hearing it, that it was a fair thing to do with a war's spoils, better than most she had heard of in her father's day, when spoils had meant the taking of a share and the burning of a hall. She said so to her steward, an old man himself by then, and the steward, who had heard her say such things before, only nodded and let her say it, the way a household lets an old woman have her thoughts undisturbed.

It was not her wall to build, and she sent nothing west. But she asked, in the years after, whenever a trader came up from that coast, whether the wall still stood, and was told each time that it did, a little higher each telling, as walls grow in the telling the way wars shrink.

III

Of the Death of Iain Garbh

Iain Garbh lived long after the war he had made, and died at last an old man in his own hall at Dùn dhearg, in the thousand and forty-fourth year of the Hall, a hundred and thirty-five years old. He had ruled forty years past the war's end, and had never once, in all that time, gone up the mountain road to Dùn ìseal to stand before the cup, though every rìgh before him and every rìgh after would go at least once in a reign.

Eithne had this from a Keeper's messenger, one of the young men the Hall sent out now with the season's news, a young man of perhaps twenty who had never known a world without the Small-Burning Law and thought it as old as the vein itself.

"He would not have the flame at his own burying," the messenger told her, standing in her hall with the cold of the road still on him. "His daughter had him

laid in the floor of the hall at Dùn dhearg, under the hearthstone where his own father used to sit, and not on the slope at Dùn ìseal where the kings before him lie. The Hall did not ask for him, and I do not think it would have been given him if it had asked."

"He never forgave the flame for the war," Eithne said. It was not a question, though the messenger answered it as one.

"They say he never forgave it for saying no to him," the young man said. "Not for the war itself. He'd have forgiven a war. He didn't forgive being refused."

Eithne sat with that a while after the young man had gone on his way, because she had known men like Iain Garbh, more of them than this messenger could guess from a name in a chronicle: men who would take any hurt from a fight but not from a flame that would not fight beside them. She had watched Ìomhar Dearg wash his hands at a ford in the very first year of the Hall and known even then that a man who takes a thing by the sword remembers the taking longer than he remembers the thing. Iain Garbh had wanted the flame's blessing on a war the flame would not bless, and had gone without it, and had died still wanting it, buried under his own hearthstone rather than under the mountain, because a man's grave is the last word he gets to have.

"He had a daughter," Eithne said to her steward, when the household had gone in to their supper and she sat on alone by her own low fire, which she kept lit even in summer now, more for the company of it than the warmth. "Wise, they tell me. Let us hear of her instead."

IV

Of Catrìona Ghlic and the Breach Mended

Catrìona Ghlic ruled at Dùn dhearg from her father's death, and the name the island gave her within ten years of her crowning was Catrìona the Wise, which is not a name given lightly to a ruler by the people who pay her tolls, and Eithne, hearing it, thought it the kind of name a daughter earns by undoing what her father did rather than by doing anything grand of her own.

What Catrìona undid, first of all, was the coldness between the hall and the Hall. She sent her own son, a boy not yet come to his full growth, to sit a season with the flame at Dùn ìseal, to carry the baskets and learn the galleries the way any hearth's child might, and this had not been done by the royal house since the divi-

sion of keeping in Goraidh Mòr's day, when the rìgh had taken the spears and the Keeper had kept the flame and the two had gone their separate ways for the better part of four centuries.

Eithne heard of it from a knot-keeper's granddaughter, one of the last of that dwindling trade, who still came to Cathair mhòr twice a year with the tallies the old way, on a cord, though the letters had come west out of the stag's schools by then, a thing Eithne had heard of and never troubled to see.

"They say the Keeper wept to see him come up the path," the woman said, "a boy of the royal blood carrying a basket like any hearth's son, and asking no more of the Hall than any other boy would ask. And when his season was out he did not want to go home."

"Did they let him stay?"

"They sent him home. A rìgh's son belongs at the rìgh's hall, whatever he wants for himself. But he goes back every year since, at the turn of the season, and they say the Keeper keeps a place for him at the long table without being asked."

Eithne thought of the flame kept once in a keepers' hut of turf and stone, before the Hall was built at all, and of the long quarrel of spears and flame that had run under every reign since Ìomhar Dearg first won a share with the sword before any was given him. It seemed to her, sitting in her own hall so long a time on, that the quarrel had never once been about the flame itself, which asked nothing of anyone, but about which of the island's two powers would be seen to bow first, and that a boy carrying a basket without being asked to had done what four hundred years of rulers and Keepers, careful of each other's pride, had not managed between them.

"Tell them at Cathair mhòr," she said to her own steward, "that when the boy is a man and rules at Dùn dhearg, this hall will send its own tithe to the Hall's handful without waiting to be asked, the way it has not done since the Roinn."

It was done, and it held, a small thing set beside a war and a wall and a king's grave, but Eithne, who had seen a great many large things come to nothing, had learned by then to trust the small ones that held. She thought, sending the order, of Aodh Crom standing on the hill in the first year of the Hall and asking that the vein be in no share. He had meant the flame for every hand equally, and it had taken the island's two powers four hundred years to learn the meaning of it, a rìgh's pride and a Keeper's pride each finding it harder to swallow than any war.

V

Of the Two Houses and the Wool of Inis mhòr

Catrìona built two houses on the northern road in the years after, and Eithne heard of both from carriers before she heard of them from anyone at court, which was the way of it now: the carriers' roads carried news faster than any messenger the halls could send, because a carrier told his tale at every waypoint house between one end of the island and the other, and a messenger told his only at the end of his riding.

The first house stood above the river port in the north where the wool trade gathered, on ground that had held nothing before but a burned foundation and a bad name; Catrìona had it built fresh and gave it to the carriers of the northern baskets, who took the Hall's grain up to the wool country and brought wool back for it. The second stood further on, out on the open moor between the port and the northern coast, a plain stone house built for no other purpose than to be there when the snow came down early and caught a string of carriers between one hearth and the next with nowhere to shelter. The Hall paid its keepers in grain and the crown paid them in cloth, and the keepers, being carriers' people themselves and used to complaint as a form of thanks, grumbled at both payments and stayed at their post through every winter all the same.

"The wool town has grown past every other town in the north," a carrier told Eithne, an old man himself, near the end of his last run before his knees gave out the trade for good. "They've asked the crown for a road-guard of their own, the way the wolf-sworn keep the west, and the crown has given them one. There's more silver moves through that port in a season now than moves through Dùn dhearg in a year, they say, though I'd not swear to the saying, only the telling of it."

Eithne had seen the wool herself once, in bales brought south along the very road the carrier spoke of, soft grey fleece from the northern flocks that her own weavers turned into cloth finer than anything the lowland sheep gave. She held a handful of it in her hand, that last winter she was strong enough to walk her own sheds, and turned it over between her fingers the way her own weavers did when they were judging a fleece's worth, though she had no craft in the judging and only liked the feel of it, soft and slightly greasy with the lanolin still in it, smelling of a country she would never see. She thought that she had outlived the four rules and the nine shares and the double oaths and a war fought over fish-bones, and

here at the end of it all was a town she had never seen growing rich on wool, asking the crown for a guard the way a child asks a parent for a coat, and being given it without argument, as if the asking and the giving were the most ordinary thing in the world.

It seemed to her a good sign of the age, though she said so to no one, having learned that an old woman's good signs are mostly taken for an old woman's fancies. She thought, too, though she kept this thought closer still, that a town could grow that rich and that fast only in an age when no lord's household needed to fear another's spears across its own boundary stone, which had not always been true of the island and had been true for less than half the years of her own life; and she set the fleece down and went back into her hall a little comforted by a thing she could not have explained to her own steward without sounding, to her own ear, like an old woman talking to herself.

VI

Of Niall Òg on the Last Road

Niall Òg came to Cathair mhòr in the hundred and ninth year of that century of the Hall, unannounced, on foot, with a single household man behind him carrying nothing but a blanket and a skin of water, and Eithne's steward came to her chamber before the sun was well up to say that an old man was asking at the gate who gave his name as Niall, grandson of Ailean, and would not be turned away though he looked in no state to be let stand in the yard.

She had not seen him in over four hundred years. She went down to the gate herself rather than have him brought up, because some meetings are owed the courtesy of going to them, and found him leaning on a stick worn smooth by a use far longer than the making of it, a small bent man with a face gone the colour and texture of old bark, and eyes that had not dimmed at all, which was, she thought, the cruellest part of what the long years did to a person: the eyes went on seeing everything clearly long after the rest had begun to fail.

"You've taken your time," she said, "coming to see me."

"I've been coming for four hundred years," said Niall Òg. "I kept getting distracted by roads. There was always one more stretch of it I hadn't walked, and a man doesn't like to die owing the island a road he never saw."

"And have you seen them all now?"

"Most," he said. "Enough. I met a rìgh's daughter on one of them once, mending a broken stretch with her own staff, and told her a thing about a knotted cord that I don't think she's forgotten, and I've been glad of that meeting ever since, more than of most things I did with a spear in my hand in the early days, which were more than I'd care to count now."

She had him brought in and fed and given the best chair by her own low fire, and he sat in it the whole of that day and would not be moved to a bed until the light was long gone, because, he said, he had slept in enough beds in four centuries and would rather sit up a night talking to the only other person alive who remembered the smoke in the gathering-house on the night of the handful.

They talked of it. Eithne had not spoken of that night to anyone in a hundred years or more, because everyone she might have spoken to about it was long dead, and a memory kept alone in one head begins to feel less like a memory and more like a thing one dreamed; and it was, she found, a relief beyond anything she had felt in a long while to say to another living person, "I knelt by Ciorstaidh's knot a long while before I cut it," and have that other person say, "I remember. You were the only one who knelt. The rest of us just cut and walked on."

"I've thought since," Eithne said, "that kneeling changed nothing. She still lost her share to mine that night."

"It changed you," said Niall Òg. "I watched it. You were never quite so quick to cut anything again, all the years after, not a knot and not much else. I don't think anyone else in that house noticed. I noticed, because I was watching you instead of my own knot, which is a poor way to conduct yourself at a gathering of seven hundred and twelve heirs, but I was young and you were the one worth watching."

He told her the night of the handful once more before he slept, the whole of it, every hearth burning its measure at once and the smoke lying in the rafters and the nine knives going round the cord, and she saw that he told it now the way a teller tells a tale rather than the way a man remembers a thing that happened to him, smoothed by four hundred years of telling into its final shape, every pause in the right place; and she understood, hearing it told that way for what she guessed rightly would be the last time, that this had become his life's whole use in his last years, the carrying of that one night down through every year since, so that when the last of the nine who had lived it was gone, someone would still be able to say how it had truly been, in the smoke, with the lamps.

He died in her own hall three days later, in the chair by her fire, in his sleep, without pain that anyone could see on his face after. The evening before, he had told her that he had walked the road to her gate on purpose, the last road he meant to walk, because he did not want to die on some empty stretch between waypoint houses with no one by to hear the story out, and would rather it were told once more, to her, than carried into the ground with him half-spoken.

She sat with him the night after he died, alone, because she found she did not want her household in the room, and thought that of the seven hundred and twelve who had walked that cord with their lamps, she was now the only one who could say she had been there, in body and in memory both, and that a night no longer walked by a living foot begins, from the moment of the last such walker's death, to belong entirely to the tellers, who had not been there, and would tell it their own way from then on, well or badly, as tellers do.

She had him carried up the mountain road herself, at her own cost, though he was no kin of her own share and she owed his line no such honour by any rule the Roinn had made; she had him laid near the old graves at the slope below Dùn ìseal, among the first heirs, because she judged, and no one troubled to argue her judgement, that a man who had spent four hundred years walking every road on the island back to that one house had earned the right to lie near it at the last.

VII

Of the Last of the Nine

Eithne outlived him thirteen years, and in those years she felt, for the first time since her father's death at Àth na Fala¹, entirely alone in a way that was not loneliness so much as a kind of clear sight, the sight of a woman standing at the top of a stair and looking down and finding no one else on any step of it. She had outlived Murchadh, who had cut first at the Roinn; she had outlived Ìomhar, whose blood had thinned in his own line faster than any of the others'; she had outlived Fionnghal and Artair and Cormac and the four whose shares the tellers named in different orders; and now, with Niall Òg gone, she had outlived every one of the seven hundred and twelve who had walked that cord

1. the Ford of Blood, below Dùn dhearg

with a lamp on the night of the handful, and every child of Ailean Mòr who had stood weeping in the valley when word came of his falling.

Loud grief, she had learned long before, was mostly for the living to hear, and there was no one left of her own generation to hear hers, so she grieved the way she had grieved for the others: quietly, at her own low fire, in the evenings, when the household had gone to its supper and left her the room. Her hall went on as it always had. She heard the island's news as it came to her, of a market that had begun at the fords of Baile Mòr dhomhain, where the lords of the deep river gathered cattle and sheep and horses and hides and the white stone of the hills for sale on the day after each new moon, and took one fleece in forty from every seller for the privilege of the ground; a small thing, a market like a hundred others the island had grown since the Peace, but it pleased her to hear of it, a new thing built on old ground by people who had never heard her name and would not have known it if they had.

Her steward, in those last months, thought her mind had begun to wander, because she asked him more than once what the day was, and made him say the year over twice to be sure he had it right. It had not wandered at all. She wanted, at the end, to know exactly how long the count had run: three thousand years and then some, a number that had stopped meaning anything to her decades before and had become, in her last year, a thing she wanted fixed precisely, the way a weaver wants to know the exact length of a cloth before she cuts it. When he told her the tale of it, one last winter evening, he found himself weeping before he had finished the sum, though she herself only nodded, as if he had confirmed a measurement she had already taken by her own hand and only wanted checked against another's.

She died in her hall at Cathair mhòr on a quiet morning with no illness anyone could name, simply not waking when her women came to her at the hour she always rose, and the reciters who kept the rolls of that hall wrote of her afterward in the old formula they gave to the children of the first king, so that the tale should be told the same way it had always been told of Ailean's line: and all the days of Eithne were three thousand and twenty-one years, and she died.

After her, none of the nine who had cut the cord at the Roinn was living, and the great shares that had once been carried in seven hundred and twelve living memories became names cut into boundary stones, read by carriers who did not know whose hand had first claimed the ground they walked, or why. The long years went on thinning in the king's kin after her, generation by generation, the

way a river thins as it runs from the mountain to the sea, until there would come a day, though no one then could have named it, when no one on the island could be told from anyone else by the length of the life allotted him.

At the fords of Baile Mòr dhomhain that same season, on the day after the new moon, the market ran as it always ran: cattle lowing, a fleece in forty going into the lords' baskets, a boy haggling over a length of the white hill-stone with a trader who would not come down on his price, none of them sparing a thought for an old woman who had died a few days' walk off in a hall most of them would never see, whose knife, eleven hundred years before any of them were born, had cut the last knot on a cord that no longer existed, in a house that no longer stood, for a kingdom that had long since forgotten it had ever been undivided.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

Of the Eleven Names and Tormod the Writer

FE 1,123 – 1,320

Chan eil dà chuimhne aig dithis air aon oidhche. No two people keep
one night the same way in memory.

— said of the reciters of Dùn dhearg, after Tormod Scriobhaiche

I

Of the Mill on the Northern Road

A mill was raised at Muileann shean in the year after Eithne died, on the northern road where the carriers' baskets came down off the pass heavy with grain and went back up light. It was built for no grander purpose than to save every household along that stretch of road the day's walk to the next stone, and it did that well enough that a town grew round it inside two generations, the way a town will grow round anything that saves a day's walk often enough. The miller paid the Hall in grain for his stone and his water-right, and paid the riagh's toll in flour, and between the two payments he was left, most years, enough to feed his own house and complain that he was left nothing at all, which the carriers who stopped there took as a sign of a well-run mill rather than a poor one, since a miller who is not complaining is a miller counting a loss he has not yet found.

It was an unremarkable town in an unremarkable stretch of years, and the years themselves, for once, had little in them worth a teller's breath. Catrìona Gh-

lic, who had buried Iain Garbh in his own hall floor and mended what she could of the breach his war had opened, died at Dùn dhearg an old woman by the ordinary count and a young one by the count her blood had once kept, a hundred and twenty-two years old, which would have seemed to Ìomhar Dearg, had he lived to hear it, no age at all for a ruler of his line. Her son took the hall at ninety-two and held it eighteen years and died at a hundred and ten, and after him came another, and after that one another, and the king-list, when at last someone thought to make one, gave eleven names for the hall at Dùn dhearg between Catriona Ghlic and the queen who came after them, and nothing more than the names and the order they sat in.

It is not that nothing happened in those years. Roads were kept, tolls were gathered, a harbour wall went up somewhere and a granary went up somewhere else, and every one of the eleven, no doubt, believed his own reign the equal in incident of any that the tellers still told whole. But the reciters who carried the hall's memory from one generation to the next carried it the way a river carries silt, taking up what a flood brings down and letting the rest settle unseen, and by the time anyone asked them for those years entire they had already settled into eleven names and a rough count of the winters each ruler held, and no reciter living could give back what had never been asked of them in time.

The Hall on the mountain kept its own roll for the same years, spoken, not written, and it gave five Keepers where the hall at Dùn dhearg gave eleven rulers, which any teller of the Hall's years will tell you is no more than the ordinary difference between a mountain's years, which are long, and a lowland's, which are not.

Somewhere in the middle of those eleven reigns, in a year no reciter troubled to fix more closely than "before Ealasaid Chiar and some while after Catriona Ghlic," the last ruler of the house of Ìomhar and Goraidh who carried any of the long years in his blood died at a hundred years old, which had once, in his grandmother's grandmother's day, been a boy's age and was now, without anyone marking the day it happened, an old man's. The long years had been going out of that line since the ford at Àth na Fala¹, thinning a little in every child the way a dye thins with every washing of the cloth, and by the time the thinning reached its end there was no one left who remembered the blood as it had been, and so no one to mourn it going. The rulers after him lived and died at the pace of any household

1. the Ford of Blood, below Dùn dhearg

on the island, and the numbering of their years, wherever it is set down, reads no differently from the roll of any carrier's family kept beside it.

Of the eleven themselves, the roll, once it was made, gave little beyond their names and the years they sat, and this telling, which owes the roll its facts, follows it in that restraint. No one, in their own day, thought a written hand would ever be asked to remember them, and by the time a written hand was, the deeds were gone and only the names were left standing, the way boundary stones stand long after the fence between them has rotted into the ground.

II

Of Tormod mac Iain

Tormod was born at Dùn dhearg in the reign of the tenth of the eleven, a younger son of the house of Tormod, which had held no great office in the hall for three generations and was not expected, by anyone in it, to hold one again soon. His father Iain kept a modest stretch of the granaries on the crown's account, an honest post and a dull one, and Tormod grew up among grain-tallies and the smell of dust and mice, learning to count sacks by the age of six and to hate counting them by the age of eight, a hatred that would have surprised, later in his life, everyone who came to know him only as a man bent over a roll with a stylus in his hand.

He was fifteen, by his own later reckoning, when a stag-teacher passed through Dùn dhearg on his way east and stayed the night in his father's granary-loft, out of the rain, and told the household over supper of the letters kept at Muileann chiar, marks that could hold a teaching in a line cut on hide or bark without a teacher standing over it to keep the teaching straight. Tormod had never in his life heard of a thing that could remember without a person to do the remembering, and it struck him, he said afterward more than once, the way lightning is said to strike a man who has spent his whole life indoors and steps out at the wrong hour: a thing that happened to him and left him changed, whether he had chosen it or not.

His father thought little of it, a boy's fancy caught by a traveller's tale, and would likely have let it pass had the boy not gone on asking after it, at meals and in the fields and once, to his father's lasting embarrassment, in front of the granary-reeve who had come to check the tallies. In the end simple arithmetic sent

Tormod east: a younger son of a house with no office to give him was a mouth the granary could feed more cheaply at Muileann chiar, learning a trade no one else in Dùn dhearg troubled to learn, than kept idle at home waiting for a post that would never come. His father called it practical sense and told the neighbours so. Tormod, walking the northern road with a carrier's basket-string for company and his own feet blistering inside a fortnight, called it, privately, the first stroke of luck his life had given him, and never after changed his mind on the matter.

III

Of the Stag-Letters at Muileann chiar

The teachers at Muileann chiar took him in without much ceremony, as they took in most who came asking, on the reckoning that a mind willing to sit through the tedium of the marks was worth more to them than a mind merely quick, and tedium there was: weeks of nothing but the shapes themselves, the strokes for breath and the strokes for stop, drilled on a slate until the hand knew them without the eye's help, before any teacher would let a pupil near a real telling. Tormod was neither the quickest of that season's intake nor the slowest, but he was, by his teachers' own account, the one who complained least at the drilling, which they took for the better sign, and rightly.

He wrote his first whole leaf in the second summer, a tally of a household's grain-debt over three seasons, copied from a spoken account an old woman gave him twice over to be sure he had it right, and it survived, folded small and much handled, among the leaves of his own house long after his death, the oldest thing in his own hand that the world still has. He kept it, his teachers said, tucked inside his shirt for a full year after the writing of it, the way a young cutter is said to keep the first coal his own hand brings up out of the vein, for the plain fact of having made a thing that had not existed the day before.

The better part of four years he stayed at Muileann chiar, longer than most who came only to learn the marks and go home to some clerk's post that wanted them and nothing more, and read what the teachers there kept, which was mostly grain-tallies and toll-counts and the odd letter between one waypoint house and another, and he found, reading it, that he wanted more than tallies: he wanted, though he could not have said so plainly even to himself at nineteen, to write down a thing that would still be readable when every mouth that had ever spoken

it was dead, the way the mountain's own coal, once cut and burned, gives its light to hands that never touched the vein it came from. It was a want with no post attached to it and no household waiting to pay for its satisfying, and he carried it home to Dùn dhearg unspoken, because a young man who says aloud that he means to outlast every reciter in the hall is a young man inviting every reciter in the hall to make sure he does not.

IV

Of Ealasaid Chiar

he served forty years at Dùn dhearg as a clerk of the granaries, his father's trade after all, before the chance came that his four years at Muileann chiar had been, without his knowing it, preparing him for the whole while. Ealasaid Chiar took the hall in the year Tormod turned fifty-nine, the granddaughter of the ninth of the eleven, a woman who had grown up hearing the reciters give the roll of her own house in a different order at every telling and had come, by the time she was crowned, thoroughly out of patience with it.

She had heard, from her own granary-reeve, that there was a clerk in her stores who could set a thing down in marks and have it read back the same way twice, which struck her, she said afterward, as either the most useful thing she had ever heard of a clerk or the strangest, and she sent for him to find out which. Tormod came before her in his working clothes with flour still in the seams of them, an old man by then in everything but the eye, and she asked him, without preamble, whether he could write down the names of every ruler who had held the hall before her, in the right order, so that her own grandchildren need not learn it eleven different ways from eleven different mouths.

He told her, honestly, that he did not know, since no one had ever asked such a thing of the marks before; the marks had been made, at Muileann chiar, for grain and debts and the odd letter, not for the memory of a house. But he said he would try, and Ealasaid Chiar, who had learned by then to value a clerk who said "I will try" over one who promised more than he could give, told him to begin that week and gave him a room off her own hall to work in, with a standing order that no reeve was to call him back to the granaries while the roll was unfinished, which his father, had he lived to see it, would have found the strangest turn of all:

that his son's idleness, once the family's shame, should end as the crown's own business.

V

Of the Reciters

Tormod began, sensibly enough, with the reciters, the old men and women whose whole office in the hall was to carry the ruler's line in their heads and give it out at feasts and namings, generation folded into generation the way a story-teller folds a long tale for a short evening. He sat with each of them in turn through the autumn and winter, asking the same questions of each and writing down what each one gave him, and it was in this work, more than in any drilling at Muileann Chiar, that he learned the true use of the marks: to hold still, on a leaf, exactly what one mouth had said on one day, so that it could afterward be set beside what another mouth had said and the difference between them looked at plainly instead of argued over in the air.

The differences, when he set them beside one another, troubled him more than he let Ealasaid Chiar see at first. Two reciters gave the ninth ruler's mother a different name. One gave the seventh reign nine years and another gave it eleven, and neither would yield the point, each citing a teacher long dead who had told it so and could not now be asked. A reciter from the southern households, brought up before Ealasaid Chiar on some other matter and questioned by Tormod almost as an afterthought, gave an order for three of the eleven that put none of them where the hall's own reciters put them, and defended it with as much certainty as any of the others had defended theirs.

"They cannot all be remembering the same thing," Tormod said to Ealasaid Chiar, the first time he brought her his doubts rather than his progress, "and yet each of them is certain."

"Then which is right?" she asked him.

"I do not know," he said, "and I have come to think that not knowing may be the truest thing I can write down."

She was silent a moment at that, turning it over the way a woman turns over a ring she is not sure is good silver. "Write down the doubt, then," she said at last, "where you have it, and the sure thing where you have that, and let the two stand together on the leaf. A roll that hides its own uncertainty is a roll that will be be-

lieved too well by people who have no way of knowing better, and I would rather my grandchildren doubted rightly than believed wrongly."

It was not, in the end, an order many clerks after him chose to follow, since a roll with gaps in it looks, to most eyes, less finished than one without; but Tormod took her at her word, and in three places where his reciters' account disagreed with what he later learned the Hall's own roll gave, he set both readings down side by side and chose neither, a habit that earned him, among the few scholars who ever came to read his leaves entire, more honour than any of the names he did manage to fix beyond doubt.

VI

Of the Roll's Making

The writing of the first roll took the better part of a year, since Tormod would not set a name down until he had heard it from more than one mouth, or marked plainly that he had not; and because Ealasaid Chiar, once the habit of asking had been started in her hall, found she wanted more than the eleven names that had first sent her to him. She had him go back further, into the reigns the earlier reciters still just remembered whole, Goraidh Mòr and the war of the roads and the peace under Mòr nic Dhùghaill's roof, setting down in the same careful hand what until then had lived only in the telling.

He worked at a low table by the window of the room she had given him, a room that had been a store for undyed wool before it was a clerk's room and still smelled faintly of lanolin on a damp day, and he kept, through that year and the years of going back that followed it, the two-summer boy's habit of the first leaf he had ever written: he read each finished page over to whoever had given it to him, reciter or steward or Ealasaid Chiar herself, before he counted it done, so that no name went into the roll that its own source had not heard back and owned. It was slow work, and it made him few friends among the reciters, who did not care to be read back to like children learning a lesson. It made the roll, when it was finished, a thing no one at Dùn dhearg could afterward call a single clerk's fancy, since every name in it had been sworn to twice, once in the giving and once in the hearing.

The finished roll ran from Goraidh Mòr to Ealasaid Chiar herself, the eleven names set at last in an order Tormod judged, after weighing every reciter's ac-

count, the least contradicted rather than the most certain, with the three doubtful places marked as doubtful and left so. He brought it to Ealasaid Chiar on a winter evening with the wool-smell of the room still on his sleeves, an old man of sixty with a stylus-callus on his first finger that would not soften now for the rest of his life, and set it in her two hands the way a steward sets a harvest tally before a lord, though what he had brought her weighed nothing at all and had cost him a year of his life.

She read it through by her own fire without speaking, and when she had finished she said only, "Now no one at Dùn dhearg need learn it eleven different ways again," which was, from a queen not given to open praise, as much praise as Tormod Scriobhaiche ever had for his life's whole work, and by every account he asked for none.

He died ten years after, at seventy, in the same room off the hall where he had written the roll, with the finished leaves stacked beside his bed and a half-begun copy of the disputed reign still under his hand. Ealasaid Chiar had the room's wool-smell scrubbed out of it afterward and gave it a proper clerk's floor, and named it, in the hall's own speech, no more than "Tormod's room."

VII

Of the Shamed Hall

Word of the written roll reached the Hall on the mountain the following spring, carried up by a carrier who had heard it told at a waypoint house and thought it worth the telling twice, and it reached the Keeper of that year, Fionnlagh Dall's line by four generations though the years had by then taken his sight as they had taken his forebear's, in words that stung more than the carrier had meant them to: that the rìgh's clerk had set down in marks a memory the Hall had only ever kept in the mouth.

The Keeper heard it out and said nothing for three days, which those who knew him took for a bad sign, since a blind man's silence has nowhere to look and so settles, when it settles at all, on whatever is nearest. On the fourth day he called the reciters of the Hall before him, the old men and women who kept the Keepers' line the way Dùn dhearg's reciters had once kept the rulers', and told them, in words the reciters afterward repeated more often than any other he ever spoke, that a Hall shamed by a rìgh's clerk into writing down what it should have written

down of its own accord a century before had no one to blame for the shame but itself, and that he would not sit blind at the head of a Hall that let a lowland granary-clerk out-remember it.

The writing of the Hall's own roll fell, in the end, less to any one hand than to a company of hands, since no clerk among the Hall's own people had Tormod's years of practice at the marks; a young cutter who had spent a season at Muileann chiar himself was set to the actual writing, while the reciters gave their account and the Keeper, sightless, listened to every leaf read back to him twice before he let it stand, a slower and stranger method than Tormod's but one that suited a blind man's hall as well as sight had suited Tormod's own working. It began, as the Hall's spoken roll had always begun, with Beathag Bhàn, and it ran longer than Tormod's roll by several centuries, since the Hall's own line reached back past the eleven rulers and past Goraidh Mòr both, into years the righ's own reciters had never troubled to keep at all.

VIII

Of the Cord Untied

It was in the last summer of that writing, some thirteen hundred years since the cord of the heirs had been cut at the Roinn, that Cairistìona nan Snaidhm came down from her own house to the Hall with the cord carried before her on a cushion of undyed wool, the last of Sìne nan Snaidhm's line still living who could read a knot the old way, without letters, by the shape and the tightness and the place of it along the length.

She was an old woman herself by then, the knot-keeping long since fallen from any real use in the Hall's business, since the Hall had kept its accounts by tally-stick and now by the marks for longer than she had been alive; but the old cord itself, the whole cord Sìne nan Snaidhm had tied a second time in the year after the Roinn so that the Hall should keep entire what the nine had carried away in pieces, had never been untied, seven hundred and twelve knots still holding the shape she had given them, and no one at the Hall could read what they held save Cairistìona, and after Cairistìona no one at all.

She sat with the young scribe two full days, the cord across both their laps, and untied it knot by knot from the first end, naming aloud, for each knot, the heir it had been tied for and the share that heir had taken, while the scribe set each name

down in the new marks as she gave it. It was slow work, slower even than Tormod's had been, since a knot untied cannot be tied again to check the reading, and Cairistiona would not have a knot loosed until she had named it twice to her own satisfaction, turning it under her fingers the way her mother had taught her mother's mother to turn them, feeling for the small differences of tightness that thirteen hundred years of handling had not quite smoothed away.

"My mother could read this cord blind," she told the scribe, on the second day, when her own eyes had begun to tire of the light in the low room, "and her mother before her, and neither of them ever wrote a single name of it down, because the cord did the remembering and a Snaidhm's fingers did the reading, and between the two of them nothing was ever lost in thirteen hundred years. I am the last who can do both. After me the cord will still exist, coiled in whatever chest you set it in, but it will not be able to speak, because there will be no hand left that knows its language, only these marks of yours, which speak a different way and cannot be unmade back into a knot if anyone should ever doubt them."

The scribe, a young man with no reply ready for so plain a grief, said only that the marks would keep what she gave them for longer than any hand could keep a cord, hers or her daughter's or any daughter after.

"That may be true," Cairistiona said, "and it is no comfort at all," and went back to the untying.

When the last knot came free, the seven hundred and twelfth, tied for a claimant so far down the great division that no reciter of either roll had carried the name whole into living memory, she held the loose cord a while in both hands before she gave it over, feeling its slackness the way a person feels the absence of a weight they have carried so long they no longer notice carrying it. Then she coiled it herself, in the old way, the way her mother had taught her to coil it for storage between one Roinn business and the next, and laid it in the chest the Hall had made for it, and did not ask to see it again.

In the three places where the righ's roll and the Hall's roll disagreed, as Tormod had marked they would, no one at either hall in that season thought it worth another six years of arguing to settle which was right, and both readings were let stand side by side, the one habit of Tormod's that the Hall's own scribes had, without quite meaning to, taken up as their own.

In the year the last knot came free it was only a cord, coiled small, going into a chest built for it by a hall that had learned, in the space of two clerks' careful lifetimes, to trust marks on a leaf over the memory of any single mouth or any single

pair of hands, however faithful either had been. The chest was set in the Hall's own gallery, and the lid was closed on it, and no one that season thought to open it again.

I X

Of the Names That Are Left

Eleven names stand now on Tormod's roll where before there had been eleven shapes in a reciter's memory, some clearer than others, none of them fixed. Five names stand on the Hall's roll for the same span of years, and neither roll, for all the care its makers gave it, can now be checked against the mouths that first carried the memory, since every one of those mouths is generations in its grave. What is left is marks on a leaf and a coiled cord that no living hand can read, and a room off a hall that still smells, faintly, on a damp day, of the wool it once stored, though no one now remembers why a clerk's room should smell of wool at all.

It is a small thing, set beside a war fought over fish-bones or a bier made of a host's own spears, eleven names written where eleven shapes had stood before; but it is the thing this telling has to set down of those years, since the years themselves, for all the width of them, chiefly held themselves and did not choose, in their own day, to be remembered further than that. The next hand that comes to the roll, wherever it comes from, will read Tormod's doubt in the three disputed places exactly as he left it, neither resolved nor hidden, and will know, from that alone, more of how the roll was made than either roll's makers thought, at the time, they were troubling to tell it.

PART FIVE

The Written Roll and the Red Hall

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

Of the Wood- Watchers

FE 1,321 – 1,595

Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann. We did not come; we were here.
— said by both companies of the dark wood, each of its own wood,
and neither meaning the other

I

Of the Years the List Does Not Count

Ealasaid Chiar died in the thirtieth year of her writing, having lived sixty years and reigned thirty-one of them, and was carried to the graves of the house of Ìomhar at Dùn dhearg. It is told that the clerk Tormod had trained stood at the grave with the roll his master had made her, the first written king-list on Dia-thìr, and read her own name out of it last, in its right place, because she had once asked Tormod whether a written name could feel it was written, and Tormod had not been able to answer her and had thought of the question every day he had left.

After Ealasaid Chiar the list falters. For a space the reciters cannot close, the roll Tormod began gives no ruler at all, only a silence where a name should stand, because in those years no household strong enough to hold the hall at Dùn dhearg troubled to have its claim written down, or because the writing lapsed with the clerk who alone knew how to keep it, or for some third reason no one living now can give. The Keepers' roll at Dùn ìseal keeps its own count through the same years. It was begun later than Tormod's and kept by a different hand,

and where the king-list is silent the Keepers' roll goes on naming its own Keepers one after another, each dying and each replaced, so that a person wishing to know how many years passed in the gap must count them there instead, by the flame's own succession rather than by the hall's.

It was in this gap, some fifty years into it by the Keepers' count, that the Hall at Dùn ìseal first set its own hand to teaching. Until then the stag-letters had been the stag's people's alone, taught in their own schools to their own novices, and any at Dùn ìseal who wished to read sent a son or a daughter east to learn it as a guest. In the fiftieth year of the gap the Keeper of that day judged that a Hall which could not read its own roll without borrowing another order's letters was a Hall too dependent on goodwill it had not earned, and set two of his own clerks to learn the stag-letters at Dùn ìseal, taught by a stag-teacher paid in coal for the winter of his teaching. It is remembered now as a small thing, though it did not feel small to the clerks who first sat down to a stranger's alphabet at their own Keeper's order. From that year the Hall kept its roll in its own hand, and the roll it kept, once begun, did not stop, through every year of the silence that followed in the king-list, so that when at last a ruler's name returns to the record it is the Keepers' roll, not the king-list, that can say with any certainty how many years had passed.

Seventy years further into the gap a Keeper was named of whom the roll gives only the years of her reign, twenty-two, and the year of her death. It is the fate of a quiet age that most of what happens in it happens to no one the tellers thought worth naming, and a hundred small keepings, harvests neither good nor bad, coal cut and burned and cut again, children born and old people buried in the ordinary way, pass without a single teller troubling to set them down, because a teller tells what changes, and in those years, on the whole, nothing changed. The households burned their handful at dawn as their grandparents had burned it. The carriers walked the roads their grandparents had walked. The Hall's clerks, in their new letters, wrote the Keepers' names into the roll as each died and each was chosen, and nothing in the writing asked to be read twice.

It is not that the island slept through those years, only that it did what an island does when no one is fighting for it and no god has spoken and no famine has come: it went on, quietly, at the pace of a life rather than the pace of a telling, and the tellers, who love a fire or a war or a birth of note, left it mostly alone.

II

Of the Black Horned Beast

Near the far end of that quiet a woman of the households of the north-west gave birth to a son she named Conall, and called him Dubh for the black hair he came into the world with and kept all his life, thick and unfading even in his last years, when every other hair he had gone grey turned white instead of thinning. He was the fourth of five children in a household that kept sheep on the high ground above Cnoc bheag, in sight of the wood the island had never cleared, a stand of old oak and thorn that ran back from the moor's edge further than any household's memory, and that no one, in all the generations since Aodh Crom had first divided the vein from the shares, had ever put an axe to.

Conall grew up half afraid of that wood and half in love with it, the way a child is of any dark place close enough to walk to and far enough that its parents forbid the walking. He heard from his grandmother, who had heard it from hers, that something walked in the uncleared wood that was not a stag and was not a wolf and was not any beast a hunter's dog would follow, a thing horned and black that let only those it chose come upon it, and that the wood was left uncleared on its account rather than on any rule of the Hall's, because the first households to try clearing it had lost cattle in it and never gone back to try again. His grandmother told it as an old woman tells a thing she half believes and wholly enjoys telling, with a shiver in the voice at the right places, and Conall, who was a serious child even at six years old, asked her each time whether she herself had seen it, and each time she said no, but that her own grandmother had, once, at dusk, at the wood's edge, and had never afterward walked past it without making the old sign against ill luck, faith or no faith.

He was twenty years old, in the household's own reckoning, when he saw it himself.

He had gone up to the high pasture before first light to bring down two ewes that had strayed the night before, and came along the wood's edge in the grey hour when the birds have not yet begun and the light is more a lessening of dark than a beginning of day, and there, at the treeline, not thirty paces off and standing quite still, was a beast the size of a large hind but built heavier through the shoulder, black from nose to hoof but for two pale horns that caught what little light there was and held it, so that Conall, who told the tale only twice in his life and both times to people he trusted absolutely, said afterward that the horns

seemed lit from within rather than by the sky. It looked at him. He did not move, and it did not move, for what he judged afterward to have been the space of ten or twelve breaths, though it might have been less, fear being a poor clock. Then it turned, without hurry, and walked back into the trees, and was gone before he had drawn a full breath to call out, though he had no one near enough to call to and would not, in any case, have known what to call.

He told his mother that night. She did not laugh at him, which surprised him more than the beast had. She said only that her own grandmother's grandmother, by the family's count, had seen the same thing in the same place, or something enough like it that the tellings could not be told apart, and that a household that farmed this close to the wood had best let it keep its own council and not go looking for it a second time.

Conall did not let it keep its own council. He went back.

III

Of the Watch

he went back first alone, then, within a year, with his younger sister, who did not believe him until she saw the beast herself from the same spot at the same grey hour, and after her with two cousins, and within five years there were nine of them, none older than thirty, who kept a watch at the wood's edge by turns, not to hunt the beast and not, at first, for any reason any of them could have set down in words beyond a wish to be there when it came again, which it did, not often, perhaps once in a season, always at the grey hour, always at a little distance, always turning back into the trees before anyone had gathered courage or wit enough to follow.

The people of Cathair dhearg, hearing of it from carriers who stopped at the household on the northern road, called them the wood-watchers, a name none of the nine had chosen for themselves and all of them, in time, came to answer to. Conall, being the first and the steadiest, and having by then given up shepherding to his brothers so that he might keep the watch through every season rather than the seasons his flock could spare him, became without any choosing on anyone's part the one the others looked to. He did not call himself a teacher of anything. He said, when the carriers asked him what the watchers believed, that they believed a beast walked in the wood and that a wood a beast walks in ought to have

someone by it who is paying attention, which was not, he knew, an answer that satisfied a person looking for a faith with rules and a name, but it was the only answer he had, and he gave the same one for the rest of his life whenever the question was put to him.

By his thirtieth year, when Conall was already greying a little at the temples though his hair kept its black, the watchers numbered near thirty and had built themselves a low turf hut at the wood's edge where two or three of them slept in every season, keeping the watch through the night as well as the grey hour, because the beast, once, had been seen at full dark by a watcher out later than she meant to be. It was in that year that Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹, the uncleared wood, was first called sacred by anyone outside the watchers' own company, when a Hall clerk travelling the northern road to count the season's coal wrote the word down in his own report, more from habit than from any judgement of his own, having heard the watchers speak of the wood in that way and having no better word to hand.

IV

Of the Tree in the Stag's Grove

It was Conall's own doing, and he never afterward denied it or claimed it was other than his own doing, that brought the wood-watchers into their first quarrel with any other company on the island.

In the dark of a winter some seven years after the clerk's report, the beast came right up to the watch-fire, closer than it had ever come before, and stood at the very edge of the firelight while five watchers sat frozen and silent around the flame, and then walked a slow circle about the fire, and stopped, and looked long at one particular tree at the wood's edge, a black-barked oak no different to the eye from a hundred others near it, before it turned and was gone into the dark. Conall lay asleep in the turf hut that night, and heard it told before the fire had burned down, by watchers too shaken to sleep, and he went out himself before first light and stood a long while before the tree the beast had looked at, and decided, in the way a man decides a thing he has been circling toward for years without knowing it, that the beast had shown it to him.

1. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

He cut the limb himself, with his own axe, the only cutting the wood-watchers had made in all their years of keeping their watch without cutting anything, and he did not cut it from Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹ at all. The beast, when it turned from the fire, had turned east, and gone east into the dark; and Conall, who had once as a young man driven sheep the length of the island and seen, at the western edge of the stag's grove at Muileann chiar, a stand of black-barked oaks like the one the beast had stood beside, took it into his head that the beast had been showing him the way. He walked east six days with the axe at his belt and one watcher for company, and at dawn on the seventh he cut a limb from the first black-barked oak at the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar², believing, once the thought had taken him, that a sign shown to the watchers belonged to the watchers wherever it stood. He carried the limb home to the turf hut and set it above the door, and the watchers kept a small fire under it that spring, calling it the beast's own wood, given by the beast's own choosing.

The teachers of the grove found the wound in the tree that same morning. The teachers at Coille Naomh Muileann chiar, who kept their own long watch over their own wood far to the east and had heard of the wood-watchers only as a strange household custom on the far side of the island, not as any rival order, sent two of their eldest west with the word that a tree had been cut from the stag's own ground, a theft of a teaching-place rather than merely of wood, for the black-barked oaks at the grove's western edge had for longer than any of the wood-watchers' memory been used by the stag's teachers for lessons, and the tree Conall had cut was one three generations of teachers had taught beneath.

Conall met the two elders at the wood's edge himself. He did not deny the cutting; he never in his life denied a thing he had done. He told them what the beast had done, circling the fire and looking long at the one tree, and said that he had read it as a sign meant for the watchers, and the elder who spoke for the pair, a woman old enough to have taught three generations of her own order's novices, heard him out in full and then said, not unkindly, that a sign was a hard thing to read from outside another order's own understanding, and that the stag's people had their own long history of signs read wrongly by those who wanted them read a certain way, and that a man who read a sign as leave to walk six days into another order's wood with an axe had read it, at the least, very much to his own advantage.

1. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

2. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

V

Of the Teachers in the Dark Wood

The stag's people did not let the matter rest with words at the wood's edge. Within the season they sent teachers of their own west, straight into Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹, the wood-watchers' own uncleared wood, and set up a teaching-circle at its western edge, saying that the first stag any teller could name had come from that wood before it came to any grove in the east, and that the stag's people therefore held as good a claim to the uncleared wood as the wood-watchers held to any border tree.

Conall would not have it that the teachers had come to steal his own ground in answer, though several of the younger watchers said so plainly and said it to the teachers' faces. He thought, and said so to any watcher who would listen, that the stag's people had done exactly what he himself had done at the border tree: taken a grievance and answered it the only way either order knew how, by claiming ground. He did not think it made either side wrong, only that it made both sides the same kind of wrong, which he found, when he had turned it over long enough in his own mind, oddly steadying, since a quarrel between two sides equally wrong is at least a quarrel that can be settled without either side needing to be told it alone was at fault.

For the better part of two years the two companies kept to their two ends of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag, each claiming both woods, and it is told, and Conall himself told it so in the one full account he ever gave of those years, that the watchers and the teachers met often enough in the wood between their two camps, gathering the same fallen wood for the same small fires, drawing water from the same spring, and that in all that time neither side spoke a word to the other beyond what courtesy required to pass on a narrow path, each nodding to the other and going on, as if an old agreement neither had ever made held them apart more surely than any boundary stone could have. It is the first quarrel remembered on Dia-thìr between two holy claims, and it was fought, if fought is the word for it, in silence, by two companies that shared a wood, a spring, and firewood, and would not share a sentence.

Word of it went to Dùn dhearg and to Dùn ìseal both, carried by the same carriers who had first named the wood-watchers, and both halls, hearing that neither

1. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

company had raised a hand against the other and that the quarrel, such as it was, threatened no household's grain and no road's peace, judged it a matter for the two orders to settle between themselves, and sent no one to settle it for them. It was, in the end, a death that moved the matter, though not a death either side caused. In the second winter of the silence one of the teaching elders, the same woman who had spoken for the two who first came west, died of an ordinary winter cough in the teaching-circle's own camp, an old woman whose years had simply run their course, and Conall, hearing of it from a watcher who had heard it from a teacher too grieved to keep the old silence, walked alone to the teachers' camp and stood at its edge until he was noticed, and said, when he was asked what he wanted, only that he had come to say he was sorry for their loss, and that he thought, whatever else stood between the two companies, an old woman's death was not a thing either side should keep silent over.

VI

Of Fearchar Òg, a Boy of Seven

The two companies kept the wood between them in their changed silence for fifteen years more, meeting at the spring, gathering the same fallen wood, nodding and passing on, and it is told that in all that span not one further word was cut in anger nor one further branch taken without leave, so that the quarrel, such as it remained, had by then worn itself down to a habit of politeness neither side troubled to explain to the other.

It was in the fifteenth of those years, though the wood-watchers did not hear of it for some months, that a boy of seven years old was brought to the Keepers' hall at Dùn ìseal by his own mother's hand, a great-grandson, by a line the reciters had kept with more care than most, of the house that had once held Dùn dhearg before the gap swallowed its record. He was named Fearchar, and called Òg, the young, from the day he first stood before the Keeper to be looked over, because there had been, within living memory of the hall, no ruler young enough to need the naming.

The Keeper of that year judged the boy's claim as carefully as the gap-worn records allowed, weighing the line the reciters gave him against what little the Keepers' own roll could confirm of it, and found nothing in it she could set aside. She did not crown him that day, a boy of seven being no ruler by any measure the is-

land kept, but she had his name entered in the roll as heir acknowledged, and sent word to Dùn dhearg that a claim had at last been found worth the hall's confidence, the first such word in longer than the Keepers' own count could say with certainty.

Fearchar Òg was raised after that within sight of the hall, in a household the Keeper trusted, and grew, as boys of seven do, slowly and without any teller's notice, learning the roads and the halls and, in time, the names of the two companies quarrelling in silence in the wood his own great-grandmother's line had once held authority over, a quarrel that by the time he was old enough to be told of it at all had already run near twenty years without a blow struck on either side and showed no sign, to anyone watching from Dùn ìseal, of ever settling.

VII

Of the Shared Keeping

It was Calum Liath, made Keeper in the boy's ninth year, a man of forty-five summers when he took the flame and known already for a patience the roll credits him with more than once, who judged at once that the wood-watchers and the stag's people would go on sharing a wood and a spring and a silence forever unless someone with authority over neither order set a boundary between them that both could keep without either being told it had lost. He did not summon the two companies to Dùn ìseal, judging rightly that neither would come at the summons of a hall it did not answer to. He went to the wood himself, that same spring, and brought the boy-king with him, a boy still by any measure but for the office now laid on him, not yet crowned in any full sense the roll would call a reign.

They walked the wood's whole length together, Keeper and heir, from the western turf hut to the eastern teaching-circle, and spoke first with Conall, who was by then a man past fifty with more grey than black left in his hair though it had not, even then, whitened through, and then with the eldest of the teachers, a man who had come west in the first year of the quarrel and stayed every year since. Calum Liath asked each company the same question: what would you keep, if you kept only your own claim and gave up any claim to the other's ground. Conall answered that the watchers wanted only the western wood, where the beast had first shown itself and had gone on showing itself in all the years since, and

would give up any claim to the eastern grove if the eastern grove gave up its claim to the western wood. The teacher answered much the same of the eastern grove, and it was Calum Liath, hearing both answers land so near the same ground, who proposed what neither company had thought to ask for on its own: that the black-barked stand be left to the stag's people who had taught beneath it, with the watchers free to keep a watch there at their pleasure so long as they cut no branch of it again, and that each wood, western and eastern both, stay in the keeping of the company that had first claimed it, with each free to walk the other's wood unarmed and without cutting, as a guest walks a neighbour's ground.

Fearchar Òg, standing by, said little through the whole of it, being young and new to matters he had been raised to understand only in outline, but it is told that when Calum Liath had finished setting out the terms, the young king asked the two elders whether either side had, in near twenty years of silence, ever once wished the other gone from the wood entirely, and that both Conall and the teacher, after a long pause, said no, each in their own words, and that Calum Liath took the two no's as the surest sign yet that the terms would hold.

They held. Stones were cut that same season, at the boy-king's own order and the Keeper's, and set at the edges of both woods, with the terms cut into them in stag-letters, so that any who could read might know, walking that ground, what was kept and by whom. No side was named the victor of the quarrel, because the roll that recorded it, kept in the Hall's own hand as it had been since the Keeper who first set his clerks to their letters two centuries before, judged there had been no victory to name, only a boundary two companies had at last agreed to keep.

VIII

Of Conall in the Eastern Wood

Conall walked into the eastern grove for the first time in his life the day after the last stone was set, alone, without the axe he had carried at his belt for thirty years out of habit rather than any need of it, and without any of the younger watchers who would have gone with him gladly had he asked. He wanted, he told the one watcher he did tell, to walk it once as the stones now allowed, a guest in another order's wood, before he grew too old to walk it at all.

The teachers let him pass without a word raised against him, as the stones now bound them to, and he walked the length of Coille Naomh Muileann ch¹ in the slow hour before dusk, under oaks no different to look at from the oaks of his own wood, and came at last to the black-barked stand at its western edge, where the stump of the limb he had cut had long since healed over, and stood there a while in the failing light, an old man by then in all but the roll's reckoning, thinking, as he told it afterward, of nothing in particular, only that the wood was quiet, and that it had taken him thirty years and a stranger's death and a boy-king's question to learn that a company could keep a watch without needing the whole wood for its own.

1. the holy wood of Muileann ch¹, Flidais's wood

CHAPTER THIRTY

OF the KNOTTED CORDS IN the Galleries

FE 1,596 – 1,641

I

Of the Keeper's Cutters

Calum Liath had kept the flame no more than a season when the last stone was set between the two woods, and in the years after, the reciters of Dùn Ìseal say, he asked for nothing that a Keeper had not already asked for before him. He fed the flame, he weighed the coloured coal against no man's claim, he judged the small quarrels the Small-Burning Law was made to settle, and beyond that he wanted little, a want so plain that people remarked on it, for the Keepers before him had mostly wanted a great deal in one direction or another. What he wanted, when he came at last to want something for himself, was to know how much coal the mountain held.

He put the question first to old Aonghas nan Uaimh, a cutter grown grey in the lower galleries who had followed the vein by touch since before Calum Liath was born, and Aonghas laughed at him, not unkindly, and said that a man might as well ask how deep the sea ran under a boat. The vein went where it went. It thickened under one gallery and pinched to a thread under the next, and no cutter living had ever cut to the end of it, because no cutter had ever needed to. You cut your measure, you filled your basket, you went home. Calum Liath heard him out and said that he had not asked whether the thing could be known, only whether anyone had tried to know it, and when Aonghas allowed that nobody had, the Keeper said that was answer enough for him.

He sent for cutters from every gallery at Dùn ìseal in the turn of that year, 9 an Giblean, FE 1,602, and gave each of them a cord knotted at the length of a man's forearm and a lamp that burned longer than the Law allowed a household's, being the Hall's own oil and not a hearth's handful, and told them to walk every gallery the mountain had, counting the knots as they went, and to mark on a slate where the coal ran thick under their feet and where it ran thin, and where it ran out altogether into blind rock. He did not tell them why, beyond what he had told Aonghas, and most of them did not ask, because a Keeper's asking passed for an answer in the Hall, and had done since Beathag Bhàn's silence was first counted a virtue.

It was slower work than any of them had reckoned. A cutter's hand knows a rich vein from a poor one at a touch and does not trouble to measure the poor one; Calum Liath's cutters had to measure both alike, poor and rich, dead rock and running coal, cord-length by cord-length, in galleries that had never been walked from end to end by anyone living, because no one had ever had reason to walk them so. Aonghas, who took the lowest galleries for his own share of the work, being too old by his own reckoning to be sent to the high cold ones, came up some evenings with his hands shaking from more than the cold, and said to anyone who would listen that a man's whole life passed differently when he was counting instead of cutting; that a cutter felt the mountain giving to him, handful by handful, the way a household feels a harvest coming in, but a counter only felt how much of the mountain he had not yet counted, which was, every evening, nearly all of it.

II

Of the Three Lean Seasons

The counting cost what counting costs. A cutter set to measuring the vein was a cutter not filling a basket, and the baskets of Dùn ìseal's own galleries, which fed the nine hearths and, through them, more households than any other seam on the island, ran short through three seasons running while the cords were walked. The Small-Burning Law did not bend for it. The measure stayed the measure, a household's handful was still a household's handful, but there were fewer hands filling the store the handfuls were drawn from, and by the second of the three lean seasons the waypoint-keepers who kept the Hall's own

tallies were sending less than the Law's full measure to households a full day's carry from the mountain, with a mark against each short delivery so that it might be made good later, though nobody could say when later would come.

At the household of Beitris nic Ruairidh, three days' carry north on the road to Baile Mòr mhòr, the winter of the second lean season was cold enough that her husband's father, an old man who had outlived two Keepers and three of his own sons, sat by a fire built half of driftwood and half of the coal they had, and said, more than once and to anyone in the house who would sit still for it, that he did not remember the mountain ever asking a household to wait on it before. Beitris, who had six mouths at her own hearth besides his, told him each time that the mountain was not asking anything, the Hall was asking, and the Hall had told them plainly enough why, if he cared to have the reason read to him again from the waypoint-keeper's mark. He did not care to. He had lived, he said, under the Binding his whole life and under no other law, and the Binding had never before told him to burn driftwood in his own hearth while the mountain kept its coal for counting.

It is told, and the reciters of Dùn ìseal tell it against themselves as often as for themselves, that in that second lean season three households of the northern road sent a steward to Dùn ìseal to ask the Keeper directly whether the counting would end before the grain in their own stores did, and that Calum Liath received the steward himself, at the door of the Hall and not within it, and answered only that he could not yet say, because he did not yet know the answer himself, which was true and satisfied nobody. The steward, a stooped man called Uisdean who had walked three days to ask a question and would walk three days home with the same one unanswered, said before he turned to go that a household could live on a true answer no better than on a false one if neither filled a basket, and Calum Liath, the reciters say, had no reply to that either, and let him go with only the one truth to carry. The households of the northern road burned what driftwood and dried dung they could find that winter, and kept their grudge, as households do, longer than the Keeper who had given them cause for it.

Even at the mountain's own foot the short seasons were felt, though less sharply, for the nine hearths ate first from what the galleries gave and felt the pinch last. The waypoint-keepers, whose own tally sticks recorded every short delivery against the day it might be made good, found that the marks piled faster than any later plenty could clear them, and more than one keeper of a northern house, going over her sticks by firelight, wondered aloud whether a debt owed by

the mountain to a household was a debt at all, or only a Keeper's word that a household must take on trust, the way it had always been made to take the weather on trust, and the vein's own moods, and everything else that no household had ever been asked to agree to and every household had always had to live inside.

III

Of the Cords in the Dark

Through all three seasons the cutters went on knotting their way through the mountain's galleries, and by the second summer even Aonghas, who had begun the work half in scorn of it, had come round to a kind of pride in the doing, though he would not have called it that himself. He had walked, by his own count, further under the mountain than any cutter before him, further than any hunter had walked above it, and he had begun, without meaning to, to know the mountain's shape as a blind man knows a familiar room, by the cords and the echo of his own lamp and the way the air moved or did not move in a gallery that ran true or one that had been abandoned for a reason nobody living remembered.

The young cutters set to the high galleries fared worse. Two of them were lost a full day in a working that had been cut and abandoned in Fionnlagh Dall's time and forgotten since, and came out half starved and swearing they had heard something moving in the dark beyond their lamp's reach that was not the mountain settling, though neither of them would say more of it afterward, and the tellers of Dùn Ìseal, who love a mystery no better than they love a plain answer, leave it exactly as the two cutters left it: unfinished.

Calum Liath walked the counted galleries himself when the cords came back to him. He had no skill to check a cutter's work and did not pretend to it; he went because he had said, from the first, that he would not ask a cutter to walk ground he had not walked, and he kept to it even in the last winter of the counting, when his own knees had begun to trouble him on the steep pitches and Aonghas, twenty years his elder, went ahead of him with a hand held back to steady him over the worst of the rubble, an old cutter steadying a Keeper, which the reciters say pleased Aonghas more than anything else that happened in those three years.

IV

Of the Slab and the Silence

When the last cord came back and the last slate was read against the others, it fell to a clerk of the Hall, a woman named Mòr nic Aonghais who had learned her letters from a wanderer of the stag's school and kept the Hall's small store of writing ever since, to set the sum down where any who could read the stag-letters might see it. At Calum Liath's own word she cut it on a slab of the grey stone the Hall's masons kept for its own building, a slate being too easily lost or broken for what it would carry, and set the slab upright inside the Hall's door, where the light from the doorway fell on it in the morning.

The sum said that the mountain, giving out no more than the Small-Burning Law already allowed and no less, could give every household on the island its handful for more generations of households than there were grains of barley in the granaries of Dùn dhearg at full harvest, a comparison Mòr nic Aonghais had chosen herself, having counted grain for the Hall before she counted anything else and knowing no larger number that a household could hold in its own hand and believe.

It was read out at the council that autumn, 26 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,607, with the great shares' stewards and the waypoint-keepers and as many of the nine hearths as could be spared from the flame all crowded into the Hall to hear it, and Calum Liath read it himself, plainly, without adding to it, and when he had finished there was a silence in the Hall long enough that the reciters who were there, and told it after to their own daughters, remembered the silence better than they remembered the sum. Nobody stood to speak against it, and nobody stood to praise it either. The stewards of the northern road, who had burned driftwood three winters running to pay for the counting, said nothing at all, and it was that silence above every other in the Hall that the Keeper, and the Hall after him, chose to take for assent, though Mòr nic Aonghais herself said once, late in her life, to a niece who pressed her on it, that a silence could mean a great many things besides yes, and that she had never been sure, cutting the sum into that slab, whether she was cutting the Hall's proof or the Hall's excuse.

V

Of the Lower Gallery

The lean seasons ended with the counting, and the galleries filled again, and it might have been no more than a hard three years remembered afterward the way households remember any hard three years, if it had not been for what came in the fourteenth year after the slab was set, when two youths of the nine hearths, neither of them a full season in the galleries, were sent down into the lower working at Dùn ìseal, the same working the two cutters had once lost a day in, to bring up a basket the evening's cutters had left behind.

Their names were Griogair mac Dhonnchaidh and a girl called Sìne Bheag, cousins of the same hearth, sent together because the lower gallery frightened Griogair on his own and Sìne Bheag had gone down it twice before and told him there was nothing in it worse than the dark. They went without a Keeper's cutter to walk ahead of them, because none was to spare that evening and the errand seemed a small one, a basket and back, and in the dark beyond the last lamp-mark they broke, by whatever mischance the tellers can no longer reconstruct, a face of rock that Aonghas's own cords had marked as unsound years before, a mark that had gone into the Hall's slates but never, it was found after, into any warning a cutter carried down with him in his own head. The rock came down across them both. It was Aonghas himself, roused from his own hearth near midnight when the two did not come up, who went down with three others and dug them free, and found Griogair already gone and Sìne Bheag alive but not for long past the digging.

The Hall keened them as it keened its own, which it had never before had cause to do for two so young, and buried them on the slope above the vein where the Keepers' own dead were laid. Aonghas, who had marked the unsound face himself years before and lived to dig the two of them out of what it had done, kept his own silence about that winter for the rest of his life, and spoke of it only once, in his own old age, to Oighrig Bhàn, telling her that he had gone down into the lower gallery that night thinking of nothing but the digging, and had only understood, climbing back up into the grey of the morning with Sìne Bheag's weight failing in his arms before he reached the air, that his own mark on his own slate had done this as surely as the rock had, a mark he had cut and trusted a slate to carry when it should have been carried, he said, in the head of every cutter who went down after him.

It might have ended there, in grief alone, as such things mostly did, but Griogair's mother, a woman named Ealasaid Rìoghach of no particular note before that winter, stood up at the council that followed and asked the Hall, before every steward and hearth-holder gathered there, what it owed her son.

VI

Of What the Hall Owed

It was not a question the council had an answer ready for, and the reciters of Dùn ìseal, who are fond of Calum Liath and slow to fault him, admit plainly that he had none either, not that day. The Small-Burning Law set the measure a household might burn and the peace of the Hall's own ground; it had never set down what a household was owed for a child sent into the dark on the Hall's own errand and lost there. Ealasaid Rìoghach did not ask for silver, having none to spend and no custom to spend it in; she asked only, and asked it twice more before the council found an answer, why a boy of one season in the galleries had been sent down a working two cutters had already lost a day in and a slate had already marked unsound, and why no one had told him so before he went.

The council sat three days on it, which was longer than it had sat on anything since the Small-Burning Law itself, and the first day was spent, by the reciters' account, on little more than stewards of the nine great shares each saying, in their own words, that the fault lay elsewhere: with the errand's giver, who had not thought a basket worth a Keeper's cutter; with the slates, which had kept a warning no one had thought to carry down in memory; with the two youths themselves, who ought, said one steward and was shouted down for it, to have known a lower gallery's dangers without being told. Ealasaid Rìoghach sat through all of it on the floor by the door, and it was only on the second day, when she stood a second time and asked again, in fewer words than before, what the Hall owed her son, that the council turned from fault to custom, which the reciters count the true turning of those three days, more than anything said in them.

The Hall had no payment to offer that would not have looked like a coal-price set on a life, and offered none. What came out of the three days was a custom instead: that no young Dia-thirich would go into any gallery of the vein's custody again, on any errand however small, until they had spent seven years bound to a cutter of proven years, learning the mountain's marks and its unsound faces and

its moods before they were trusted alone in its dark. It was not called a payment, and Ealasaid Rìoghach, when it was told to her, said only that it came seven years too late for her own son, which was true and which nobody in the council disputed.

Calum Liath himself did not live to see the custom much beyond its first winter. He had failed through the last of the counting years, a failing the reciters put down more to age than to any single grief, though they note, as reciters will, that he was never quite the same Keeper after Griogair and Sìne Bheag as he had been before, readier to sit long over a small dispute than he had once been, as if he had learned, late, that a Keeper's silence could cost more than his own dignity. He died in the eighteenth year after the slab was set, in the Hall itself, by the door he had had the slab set beside, and was carried up to lie among the Keepers' own dead near the two he had buried before him, a resting he had asked for himself and been given without argument.

VII

Of Oighrig Bhàn

The nine hearths chose Oighrig Bhàn to follow him, a woman of six and thirty years who had come to the Hall as a girl of the northern road, one of the very households that had burned driftwood through the lean seasons, though she never once, in all her years at the flame, spoke of that against the Keeper who had caused it. She had sat with Calum Liath in his last winter more than any other of the nine hearths, and she had no wish to be chosen after him; she had a gift the reciters call patience and a plainer name calls stubbornness, and she had stayed at his side through the failing when younger hands found reasons to be elsewhere.

She took the flame in a season thin on ceremony, the Hall still close in its grief for the old Keeper, and one of her first acts, before she had worn the office a full year, was to send for the custom the council had made after Griogair and Sìne Bheag and ask why, three years on, it still stood only as a thing agreed and not a thing done. Nobody in the Hall could give her a good reason, beyond the plain one that grief cools and custom is easier sworn than kept, and Oighrig Bhàn, who had buried nobody of her own in the galleries but had grown up on short seasons all the same, said that a custom not kept was worse than none, because it let a

household believe itself answered when it was not. She had it declared a custom of every gallery in the vein's custody within three years of her choosing, on 24 am Faoilleach, FE 1,628, though six years more passed before she found twelve youths and twelve masters she judged fit to begin it.

VIII

Of the Twelve on the Stone Cup

She bound the first twelve herself, at Dùn ìseal, in the Hall's own doorway where the light fell on the reckoning-slab still, each of the twelve sworn by name to a master cutter of her own choosing, most of them the very cutters who had walked Calum Liath's cords through the lean seasons and knew the mountain's unsound faces better than any slate could tell it. Aonghas nan Uaimh, old now past any gallery-work of his own, took the youngest of the twelve, a boy called Tormod Beag who had been born the same winter Griogair and Sìne Bheag died, and taught him, in his first season, more of where not to cut than of where to cut, which Aonghas said, to anyone who asked, was the whole of the teaching that mattered.

The twelve swore on the stone cup, each in turn, to serve seven years at a master's side before the coal was theirs to touch alone, 21 an Giblean, FE 1,634, and Oighrig Bhàn stood by the cup for every one of the twelve oaths and did not sit down until the last was sworn, a small stubbornness the reciters note because it cost her a long morning on her feet in a doorway open to the winter air, and because it was, in its way, the same stubbornness that had first brought her to Calum Liath's bedside and kept her there. Four of the twelve, grown old in their own turn, came in time to hold the flame themselves, which the reciters of Dùn ìseal count the best proof the custom ever had, better than any words the council could have found for Ealasaid Rìoghach, though none of it, they are careful to say, ever answered her question in full, for no custom made after a death answers the death that made it, only the deaths that might have followed and did not.

IX

Of Cnoc bhàn and the First Entry

Word of the binding travelled north in the years of the twelve's service, carried by the same carriers who carried most things between the mountain and the far side of the island, and came at last to the stag's house at Cnoc bhàn, where the teachers who kept their own long watch over their own grove heard it and judged, after the manner of that school, that a custom worth a Keeper's keeping was worth their own testing. They took up the seven years for their own cutters, binding each apprentice to a master of the school as the Hall bound its own, and added to it a rule the Hall itself had never thought to make: that every apprentice keep, in their own hand once the stag-letters were learned, a written account of every stroke made in a season's cutting, so that a master might read back, at the season's turn, exactly what the apprentice's hand had done and where it had gone wrong.

It was a small rule when it was made, meant, by the teacher who first set it down, only to give a master something firmer than memory to correct an apprentice by, but the accounts grew, season on season, into a store the school kept and consulted the way the Hall kept its slates, and in time the teachers of Cnoc bhàn came to call them by a plainer name than any the stag-letters gave them: the strike-books, for the strokes they recorded, one stroke and one line at a time.

The first of them was begun by a girl called Rìoghnach, no kin that any reciter can trace to Ealasaid Rìoghach of the northern road though the two names are near enough that more than one teller has made the mistake, a novice of that first bound company at Cnoc bhàn, in the winter after her binding, at her master's own bidding. She wrote her first line by lamp-light in a hand still stiff from the letters' learning, three words and no more, set down as plainly as a stag-letter allows: *chuir mi buille*, I struck a stroke, and under it the day, and under the day nothing else, because there was, in that first season, nothing else yet to say. It was the least of anything written on the island in that age, and it is kept still among the strike-books of Cnoc bhàn, the school's own reciters say, because a beginning ought to be kept exactly as small as it was.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

OF FEARCHAR ÒG AND THE SILVER RINGS

FE 1,642 – 1,685

*Cha b'e an aois a rinn an rìgh; ach dh'fhàg i sinn ga chuimh-
neachadh.* It was not his age that made the king; but it left us remem-
bering him by it.
— a saying of the road-guards of Dùn dhearg, said of no other rìgh
before or since

I

Of the King Who Went On

In the year the first strike-book entry was set down at Cnoc bhàn, three words scratched by a novice's stiff new hand, Fearchar Òg had sat at Dùn dhearg for nine-and-forty years, and was still called Òg by everyone who had known him as the boy of seven the Keeper had entered on her roll. He had stopped correcting them some twenty years before. A name given at seven, he told his own steward once, is a debt a man pays the rest of his life whether he likes the price or not, and Fearchar Òg, six-and-fifty years old that year, greying at the temples but not yet stooped, had long since made his peace with it.

He was not a builder of walls, as Cathair mhòr's rìghrean before him had been, nor a maker of laws remembered by their sentences, as Fionnlagh Dall was remembered for the stone cup and the Small-Burning Law two centuries before him. What he built, in the main, he built out of the plain fact that he did not die. Ealasaid Chiar's own line had run thin in the years before him, a ruler here and a long gap there that the reciters could not close, and every household on the roads

between Dùn dhearg and Dùn ìseal had grown used to hearing, every few years, that the hall was empty again and the succession in question. Fearchar Òg ended that simply by staying. He crowned no wars, quelled no strife the Peace of the Threshold had not already quelled a hundred years before him, and is remembered by the roll, in the end, for very little beyond the plain number of his years and a handful of small things his clerks did in his name that outlasted every one of them.

The first of these small things began twelve years after, in the sixty-first year of his reign. His steward, an old man named Griogal who had served Fearchar's mother's house before him, came to the hall one evening with a complaint he had carried three days from the southern road: that the road-guards of the southern ford, who kept the crossings and the waypoint houses against thieves and floods both, had gone two seasons without their due from the hall, because the granary-clerks who paid them in grain and cloth could not always find carriers spare to send south when the grain was wanted nearer home.

"Pay them in coal, then," said Fearchar Òg, who had heard the same complaint in different words every winter of his reign and had grown tired of answering it the same way each time.

"The hall has no coal to spare either, lord. The mountain gives what the mountain gives, and the guards do not sit near enough the Hall's galleries to be paid from them even if it had."

Fearchar Òg sat a long while with that, turning a ring on his own hand, a plain band of silver his mother had worn before him and her mother before her, the kind every household of any standing kept a few of against a daughter's marrying or a debt too proud to pay in grain. It is told that he looked at it longer than a man looks at a thing he has worn every day of his life without once considering it, and that when he spoke again it was to ask Griogal how much silver the hall's own smiths could spare from a season's ordinary work without troubling any household for more.

Griogal did not understand him at first, and said so plainly, being an old man too tired of the road to pretend to a cleverness he did not feel. Fearchar Òg explained it slowly, as a man explains a thing he is still working out himself as he speaks it: that a guard paid in grain must carry his own pay home on his own back, and a guard paid in cloth must find a buyer for what he does not need. A small stamped ring of silver, known at a glance to every smith on the island from the Muileann chiar trade, could be carried in a fist, spent at any market that knew

silver at all, and would travel, once spent, far past wherever the guard himself ever walked.

"It is not grain," said Griogal, who did not think much of the idea and said so.

"No," said Fearchar Òg. "It will keep longer."

II

Of the First Rings and Aonghas Ruadh

The first rings were struck that winter, small and plain, no thicker than a woman's finger and stamped on one face with the hearth-sign of Dùn dhearg, and there were not many of them: forty, by the steward's own count, enough for one season's pay to the road-guards of the southern crossings and no more. Among the men who took one that winter was Aonghas Ruadh of Cnoc mhòr, a guard of the ford below Ceann leathan these eleven years, a broad, quiet man who had buried one wife of the coughing sickness and married a second, Sìne, the year before the rings were struck, and who had, that same year, a daughter he and Sìne named Mòrag, for no one in either house could afterward agree whose grandmother it was for.

Aonghas Ruadh did not think much of the ring when it was first put into his hand at the ford, a small cold weight he turned over twice before he understood it was meant to be his whole winter's due and not some token toward it. He had carried grain home from the hall's granary every winter of his service and had grown used to the weight of a full sack on his shoulder as the shape his labour took. A ring the size of a barleycorn's shadow felt, at first handling, like being paid in nothing at all.

He carried it home anyway, because a guard does not argue with the hand that pays him, and it was Sìne who saw the good of it before he did. She walked it to the market at Ceann leathan the next week, where a cloth-seller from the eastern road, who had never in his life had reason to travel as far west as Dùn dhearg and would not have known a grain-measure of that hall's stamp from any other, weighed the ring on his own scale, found it good silver of the Muileann chiar weight he already dealt in, and gave her cloth for it without a question asked beyond the weighing. Sìne came home with more cloth for the ring than Aonghas could have carried home in grain in the same day's walk, and told him so at the hearth that night while Mòrag slept in the basket by the fire, not yet a year old and

already, though neither of them could have said it then, growing up in a household that had begun, without quite meaning to, to think in silver.

Word of the southern crossings' new pay went east before the spring was out, carried the way all such things were carried, by carriers who had nothing better to talk of on a long road and travellers who liked a curious thing to tell at the next hearth. By the time Fearchar Òg's clerks struck a second batch of rings, the following winter, waypoint-keepers from three roads he had never troubled to pay in silver before sent word asking whether the hall meant to go on with it, and whether their own guards might be included. Fearchar Òg, who had meant the rings as no more than a fix for one season's short grain, found within five years that every road-guard on the roads out of Dùn dhearg was paid, in whole or in part, in the small stamped silver, and that the rings themselves had begun to turn up in markets the guards had never walked to, carried on by hands the hall's clerks would never trouble to count.

"They travel further than the men do," Griogal said to him once, some years into it, in the tone of a man admitting he had been wrong without quite saying so.

"That was the whole of the thought," said Fearchar Òg, and did not say more, because there was not much more to say of a thing that had, by then, said itself.

III

Of the Toll-House at Àth ghlais

The southern road crossed the river at Àth ghlais on its way toward Ceann leathan, a shallow ford between two low banks where a laden beast sank to the hock in a wet spring and a child could wade it dry-shod in a dry summer, and it was there, within five years of the first rings, that the hall built its first toll-house.

There had been a toll at Àth ghlais long before the house was built, kept as most such tolls were kept, by whichever household of the ford's own bank had the standing and the patience to sit by the crossing and collect it, a portion going to the household and a portion carried up to Dùn dhearg twice a year with the rest of the road's due. It had worked well enough for longer than anyone at the ford could say, and the household that kept it, a family called the Griogaraich after some ancestor no one living remembered, had grown used to thinking of the

toll as theirs by a kind of standing that felt, to the family, near enough a right to be worth defending.

Fearchar Òg's clerks judged, reasonably enough by the hall's own reckoning, that a toll paid in the new silver wanted a keeper who could be trusted to weigh a ring honestly and not merely to eye a purse and guess, and sent a man of their own from Dùn dhearg to keep the new toll-house: a clerk named Dòmhnall Beag, careful with a scale and careless, by his own later admission, of the ford's own feelings, who arrived at Àth ghlas in the spring with the hall's own commission in his hand and no kin at the ford at all.

The Griogaraich took it hard. It is told, and told still at Cnoc mhòr, where Aonghas Ruadh's own household heard it from the ford folk themselves, that the family's eldest stood in the toll-house door the morning Dòmhnall Beag arrived and asked him, plainly enough that the whole crossing heard it, what right a man with no kin at the ford had to weigh a ford-family's own toll. Dòmhnall Beag, who had been told to expect trouble and had, in his own quiet way, prepared an answer for it, said only that the commission in his hand was the rìgh's, and that he had not asked to come, and would go again the day the rìgh sent for him and not a day before, and that in the meantime he meant to weigh every ring honestly, the Griogaraich's tolls along with everyone else's, and would be glad of their help if they cared to give it and would manage without it if they did not.

They did not help him, not for the better part of a year. But a toll-house wants firewood in winter and a hand at the gate when the spring floods run high, and Dòmhnall Beag, being alone at it and no fool, hired what help he needed from whoever at the ford would take his silver, most of the Griogaraich in time, one at a time and never all admitting it to one another. By the year the rings had been struck for a decade, the toll-house at Àth ghlas stood as the first on any road of Dia-thìr whose keeper had been sent from a hall and not chosen by the ford, and the Griogaraich had made their peace with the fact of it, because the toll ran honest under Dòmhnall Beag's scale than under any of their own.

Aonghas Ruadh crossed that ford twice a season for the rest of his working years, and it was there, waiting his turn at Dòmhnall Beag's scale with his daughter riding his shoulders one summer when she was too small yet to walk the whole way, that Mòrag Dhubh first saw the games.

IV

Of Mòrag Dhubh

She was called Dhubh from the day she could stand, for hair black enough that her mother's own people, fair to a woman for three generations, took to saying she must have got it from the ford's own water. She grew up at Cnoc mhòr in a household that kept sheep on the low ground and sent its men, when the roads wanted guarding, down to the crossings her father had walked all his life, and she grew up, too, in the particular way a road-guard's daughter grows, hearing more of tolls and thieves and the weight of a season's silver at her own hearth than most children of Cnoc mhòr heard of anything.

Her father taught her the staff before he taught her much else. It was no wish of his to make a fighter of her; a road-guard's household simply kept staves the way a fisher's kept nets, hung by the door and taken down as often for mending a gap in a fence as for anything else, and a girl underfoot at a hearth full of staves will sooner or later be given one to stop her taking someone else's. Aonghas Ruadh, whose own father had taught him the ford-guards' old bout-play with a stick no thicker than a thumb, more a way of keeping a man's balance and his temper both than any true fighting art, taught it to Mòrag the same way, in the yard behind the house, first for the game of it and then, as she grew and would not be turned from it, because she asked him to and would not be put off.

She was quick rather than strong, small for her years until she was not, and it is told of her, by those who trained beside her, that she never once in all her years at it struck the first blow of a bout, preferring to let an opponent spend himself against her guard before she answered, a patience her father said came from her mother's side and Sìne always swore came from his. By the time she was fifteen she had outgrown every staff her father owned and cut one of her own from a young ash at the wood's edge, straight-grained and a hand's breadth taller than she was, and carried it everywhere a girl of that country could carry a staff without remark, which in a road-guard's household was nearly everywhere.

It was at Àth ghlas, riding her father's shoulders as a small child and, later, walking beside him as a girl grown tall enough to carry her own bundle, that she first heard the talk that would shape the rest of her young life: that the guards of the southern crossings, paid now in silver they had somewhere to spend and nowhere in particular to spend it on any given day, had begun meeting once a year at Ceann leathan, where the ford-market already drew traders from three roads, to

fight bout after bout with blunted staves for the newest and best-struck ring the hall's smiths had sent south that season.

V

Of the Meeting at Ceann leathan

The meeting had begun small, as such things do, a handful of guards from the nearest crossings settling an old argument over whose bout-play was the surer with a match fought in the market square on the day of the autumn trading, the loser buying the winner a cup and the whole thing forgotten by the next year's trading, except that it was not forgotten. The next year there were more of them, guards from crossings two days' walk distant who had heard the tale and wanted a bout of their own, and the year after that the market began setting aside a corner of the square for it, because a crowd that gathers to watch two men trade blows with staves is a crowd that buys cloth and cups and cooked meat while it waits its turn to watch, and Ceann leathan's traders were not slow to see the good of that.

By the time Mòrag Dhubh was old enough to be let compete, some ten years after the meeting first began, it had grown into a full day's contest, guards from every southern crossing entering by turns through the morning and the afternoon both, the losers of each bout dropping away and the winners meeting again until, by evening, two stood who had beaten every man put in front of them, and fought the last bout by torchlight for the season's finest ring, struck that year and never worn by anyone until it was won.

Her father did not want her to enter, the first year she was old enough by the meeting's own loose custom, which asked only that a fighter be grown and be a guard or a guard's kin trained to it, and said so plainly at the hearth the week before the autumn trading. It was not, he told her, that he doubted her staff-work, which he had watched grow past his own teaching some years before and had stopped correcting, out of a kind of pride he did not often show her, when she was seventeen. No woman had ever entered the meeting in all its years, and he did not want his daughter's first bout to be one fought, as he put it, against the whole square's opinion before ever a staff was raised.

"Then I'll fight the square's opinion first," said Mòrag Dhubh, "and my bouts after, and see which tires me more."

She lost that first year, in the second round, to a guard of the eastern ford twice her age and near twice her size, who beat her guard down by main strength rather than by any skill she could not have answered in a longer bout, and who told her afterward, not unkindly, that she had the surest staff of anyone he had fought that day and the worst luck of drawing him for it. The second year took her further and still ended in a loss, to a younger man whose reach she had not yet learned to read. The third year and the fourth she did not lose, and by the fifth, the year she turned twenty-five, she had beaten every man put in front of her through a long grey morning and a longer afternoon, standing at dusk across the torchlit ground from the last guard left to beat, a broad-shouldered man of Muileann chrom named Ruairidh Fada who had won the meeting twice before and meant, by every sign he gave before the bout began, to win it a third time without much trouble from a woman half his size.

VI

Of the Last Bout

It is told at Cnoc mhòr, in the telling the household kept for three generations after her and no doubt shaped a little in the keeping, that Mòrag Dhubh said nothing at all before that bout, where every other fighter of the day had traded some word or some grin with his opponent across the torchlight, and that Ruairidh Fada, finding no word offered him to answer, said his own anyway, loud enough for the square to hear, that he would go easy on her for her father's sake, who he knew by the crossing where they had both served a season together some years before.

She did not answer that either. She let him come first, as she let every man come first, and took the weight of his opening strike on a guard raised so quietly that half the square, watching for a woman's nerve to fail her, missed the moment it did not. He was strong and he was quick for a man his size, and for the better part of the bout he pressed her back a pace at a time across the torchlit ground, striking hard and often, spending, as her father had taught her every man eventually spends, more strength than the bout wanted from him because he had not yet learned, three strikes in, that she meant to let him.

She turned him on the ninth strike, catching his staff high and driving it wide with a twist of her own that owed more, by her own telling, to a morning spent

freeing a gate-post from a stuck hinge than to any bout-play her father had ever named for her, and in the gap that twist opened she struck once, low and short, across the back of his knee, and he went down in the dust of the square with the crowd's noise breaking over both of them at once, a noise, it is told, louder than the square had made for any bout in the meeting's history, because no one there, Ruairidh Fada least of all, had thought to see a woman standing at the end of it.

The ring given her that night was the finest struck that season, heavier than most, cut with the hearth-sign of Dùn dhearg on one face and, new that year, a small mark of Ceann leathan's own on the other, the market having asked the hall's smiths, now that the meeting had grown into something the whole square profited by, for a ring that carried the ford's name along with the crown's. Mòrag Dhubh is the first winner of that meeting whose name the reciters of the southern crossings kept, and it is not lost on any who tell it that the first name kept was a woman's, in a contest no woman had fought before her.

Her father wept at it, which he had not done at either of her losses nor, so far as the household ever knew, at very much else in his life, and told her afterward, walking home in the dark with the new ring cold in her own fist for the first time, that he had been wrong to try to keep her from the square, and that he would not try again.

VII

Of Muileann òg and the Lùnastal Fair

The ring Mòrag Dhubh won that autumn stayed in her own keeping the rest of her life and passed, after her, into her household's, worn on high days and shown to travellers who asked after the mark on it and told the tale, in shorter and shorter tellings as the generations went, of the woman of Cnoc mhòr who had beaten every man in the meeting the year the ring was cut. But the silver itself, the rings struck each winter in their dozens and scores now, went on doing what Fearchar Òg had first hoped a small hard thing might do, travelling further than any guard who ever carried one, into markets and hands the hall's own clerks would never trouble to trace.

Nowhere did that travelling show plainer than at Muileann òg, a market town on the ford where the old Stone Kings and the holders of the Red Hill had once agreed salt for wool, burned in the War of the Roads six centuries before and left,

since, little more than a scattering of rebuilt hearths around the old ford-stones. In the same years the meeting at Ceann leathan was growing from a handful of guards to a whole day's contest, traders drifting west along the southern road with silver rings in their purses had begun stopping at Muileann òg's ford rather than pressing on, finding there, in the ruin of a town too poor to charge them anything for the privilege, goods and prices neither Ceann leathan's crowded market nor Dùn dhearg's own could match.

It was traders' own custom, at first, and not the hall's doing, that fixed the meeting at Muileann òg to the feast of Lùnastal, when the first of the harvest came in and the roads were driest and best for travelling; but within a few years of the custom taking hold, the households resettling the town, seeing what a season's fair might bring them, asked Fearchar Òg's clerks for a charter of their own, and were given it gladly, the hall by then having long since learned that a market well fed brought more silver home in tolls than a market starved of custom ever would. The fair of Muileann òg, held that first chartered year and every year after at the turn from summer into harvest, grew within Mòrag Dhubh's own lifetime into the largest gathering of goods and craft on the southern half of the island, its ford lined three days running with stalls that sold, by the end of her years, near everything the roads of Dia-thìr could carry to it.

She went there herself, once, some years after her own win. Muileann òg kept no meeting of staves; she went there only to trade a season's wool for cloth her own household could not weave as fine, and it is told, though the household's own telling grows uncertain on this point with every generation that passes it on, that a trader of the eastern road, seeing the mark on the ring she still wore, asked her outright whether the tale of the woman of Ceann leathan was true, and that she answered only that it was, and let him tell the rest of it to whoever asked him after, because a tale told by a stranger travels further, she said, than one told by the person it happened to, and she had already seen how far a small hard thing could travel once it left a person's own hand.

VIII

Of Cidhe Beag and the River-Men

Not every road the silver opened ran so smoothly. Some twenty miles north-east of Muileann òg, where the Abhainn uaine ran broad and slow

enough for a laden boat to sit steady in it, an old landing had stood since Ailean's own age, a place called Cidhe Beag, the little quay, where a fisherman or a ferryman had put a boat into the river time out of mind without ever troubling to make more of it than a scramble of flat stones at the water's edge.

The carriers of the eastern road, who had walked grain and salt fish overland from the lowland granaries to the market towns for longer than any of them could count generations, had never had reason to think much of Cidhe Beag at all, until the year Fearchar Òg's clerks, weighing the cost of paying carriers' wages against the cost of building a proper landing there, judged that a river running near empty of traffic beside a road worn to ruts under sack after sack of the same grain was a waste neither the hall's granaries nor its silver could afford to go on making. They built the landing that same year, timbered piers driven into the old scramble of stones and a shed raised above it for the goods waiting passage, and put out word to every boatbuilder on the lower river that the hall would pay well for flat-bottomed craft of hide over withy frame, built to sit shallow enough for the Abhainn uaine's own shifting bars.

The carriers of the eastern road sent word to Dùn dhearg within the month, three of their eldest walking the whole distance to say to Fearchar Òg's own face what they had already said to every clerk who would listen, that the granaries' grain had gone on their backs for generations and ought to go on going there, and that a river-boat, once it took up the trade, would leave half their households without the wages that had fed them since before the hall was built.

Fearchar Òg heard them out fully, in the same unhurried way he had heard every complaint of his reign, and answered them, in the end, much as he had answered Griogal over the rings some years before: that a sack of grain carried on a man's back for two days' walk cost the hall, in wages and in spoiled grain both, more than the same sack floated down in an afternoon cost it in the wear of a boat and the pay of two boatmen, and that he could not, weighing the granaries' own good against the carriers' own comfort, choose the dearer road when a cheaper one lay open beside it.

"Then what becomes of us?" asked the eldest of the three, a woman named Ciorstaidh who had carried grain on that road herself for sixty years before her knees gave out and left her to the walking rather than the carrying.

"The road does not close," said Fearchar Òg. "Only the river opens beside it. There is grain enough on this island, and will be more each year the granaries fill, for a road and a river both to carry, and neither to starve of work while the other

eats." It was not, by the carriers' own reckoning, an answer that mended what they had walked so far to mend, and they went home saying so plainly to anyone who would hear it; but it proved, in the years that followed, truer than they had believed it could be, for the river carried the heaviest and least urgent of the grain, the loads that could wait a boat's slow pace, while the roads kept the carrying trade in everything that could not wait, cloth and tools and the small urgent parcels no boatman would trouble himself over, and both trades, in time, grew rather than starved.

IX

Of Muileann chrom and the Paddle-Oath

The boats themselves, once the landing was built and the first of them launched, drew their builders and their crews from Muileann chrom, a small town up the valley from Cidhe Beag whose men had fished the river's slower reaches for longer than anyone at the landing could say, and whose skill with hide over withy, learned first for coracles no bigger than a single man could carry, proved, once it was set to the larger work, exactly what the hall's clerks had hoped to find.

The first crews to take up the trade were young men of Muileann chrom with more nerve than standing, sons of fishing households too many to divide a single boat's catch among, and it was among themselves, not at any hall's asking, that they settled the custom that came, in time, to mark every boatman of that river after them: that no man might call himself one of their fellowship, nor be trusted at another boatman's back on a laden crossing, until he had sworn on his own paddle, held flat across both palms before the others of his crew, to answer any fellow boatman's need on the water before his own household's, a river being no place, as the eldest of them put it, for a man who would let another drown to save his own cargo.

The swearing was a small thing, no priest's rite and no hall's law, a custom made among working men who wanted a way to know, before they trusted a stranger's hand on a crossing, that the stranger had sworn the same oath they had. But it held, year on year, more surely than many a law the hall itself had made with far greater ceremony, and by the time Mòrag Dhubh was grown old enough to have grandchildren of her own at Cnoc mhòr, the boatmen's fellowship of

Muileann chrom was building flat river-boats not only for the Abhainn uaine but for every river of the island wide enough to float one, each boat leaving the yards with a paddle laid across its bow until the crew that took it had sworn their own oath upon it.

Her own younger brother, Dòmhnall, who had never taken to the staff the way she had and had spent his boyhood down at Cidhe Beag watching the first boats loaded rather than at Àth ghlais watching the toll weighed, was among the second crews to take up the river trade, and swore his paddle-oath the same year Mòrag Dhubh's own daughter was born, so that the household at Cnoc mhòr came, within one generation, to hold both a silver ring won on land and a paddle sworn on water, and told both tales at the same hearth without ever quite agreeing which of the two mattered more.

X

Of the King Who Died Old

Fearchar Òg lived to see all of it: the rings spreading past every road his clerks had first meant them for, the meeting at Ceann leathan grown from a handful of guards to a whole day's contest, Muileann òg's fair drawing traders from three roads at once, the river opened beside the roads and neither one starved by it. He did not live to see much beyond it. His reign, remembered by the roll for very little else, is remembered above all for its length, and in his last years, when he had sat at Dùn dhearg longer than any ruler the reciters could name before him, it became a kind of custom among the households of the southern roads to reckon their own years by his, a child born in the year of the toll-house at Àth ghlais, a marriage made in the year the fair was chartered, a death in the year the river-boats first sailed, so that Fearchar Òg's long sitting became, without his ever asking for it, the measure other lives were told against.

He died in the winter of his ninety-fourth year, at Dùn dhearg, in the same hall his clerks had struck the first rings in more than fifty years before, and it is told that Griogal's own grandson, steward by then in his grandfather's place, found him in his chair by the hearth one morning, gone as quietly as a man goes who has simply, after so very long, stopped going on. He was buried among the house of Ìomhar with the state a reign of eighty-seven years was owed, and the roll that recorded him, which had made much of other rulers for their wars or their

laws or their buildings, could find little to say of him beyond the plain fact the whole island had already learned to measure by: that he had come to the hall a boy of seven and left it, eighty-seven years later, an old man who had simply gone on, season after season, longer than anyone then living had thought to expect of him.

Word of it reached Cnoc mhòr the way all such word travelled, carried down the southern road by guards who had themselves been paid, most of their working lives, in the dead king's silver, and it found Mòrag Dhubh in the winter after her own win, sitting by her own hearth with the ring still bright from the smith, kept where her household could see it on high days. She is said to have turned it once in her fingers when she heard the news, the same slow turning her father had given it the winter he first carried it home, and to have said only that the king had done one thing right in a long reign of small quiet things, which was to make a thing worth keeping that did not need his own hand on it to go on travelling after he was gone.

She lived on herself many years more at Cnoc mhòr, and the ring lived longer than she did, passed down through a household that never afterward forgot, whatever else it forgot with the passing of the generations that first won it, whose hand had held it first and why.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

OF the Red Hall and the Census of Hands

FE 1,685 – 1,735

I

Of the Twenty-Year-Old Queen

Beathag Mhòr took the hall at Dùn dhearg five years after Fearchar Òg died at ninety-four, and she took it at twenty, which the reeve Lachlann Dubh, who had kept the granary accounts under three rulers of her line and meant to keep them under a fourth, thought a poor age for anyone to begin anything. He said so to no one but his wife, and even to her only once, for Beathag Mhòr's great-grandfather had died old and easy and his own father before him the same, and a house that buried its rulers gently was not a house a careful man complained of.

She was brought up through the granary yard on the morning of her crowning, past the sacks that had fed the Red Share since Ìomhar Dearg burned the old halls within the double bank, and Lachlann Dubh walked at her stirrup with the tallies under his arm because it was his office to walk there, whoever rode above him. He had expected a girl's questions, the kind Fearchar Òg's own heir had once asked him, about the weight of a full sack and how many the granary held. Beathag Mhòr asked him instead how many of the sacks were owed elsewhere before the winter was out, and when he told her, she asked him to whom, by name, and wrote nothing down, because she had not yet learned her letters past her own name and the count to a hundred, but she remembered every name he gave her,

and asked after three of them again a year later, by which time he had stopped thinking her age a fault in her.

It was the list-keepers at Dùn ìseal, and not Beathag Mhòr herself, who first wrote her down as *ban-rìgh*, queen, rather than *rìgh* with a woman's name set after it as the rolls had always done for Eithne and Catriona and the rest. Nobody asked her leave for the change, and she gave none, for it seemed to her, when Lachlann Dubh told her of it, a small matter beside the sacks, though she noticed, in the years after, that the word travelled ahead of her wherever she rode, spoken first by strangers who had never called any ruler anything but *rìgh* in their lives and found the new word came easier to them than she would have guessed.

Her crowning was held at Dùn dhearg in the last cold week of am Faoilleach, 6 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,685, with snow lying thin on the double bank and the wind coming down off the granary roofs in a way that made the household's fires gutter every time a door was opened. Fearchar Òg's own line filled the hall three deep, cousins she had met perhaps twice in her life come to stand for a great-grandfather most of them remembered only as an old man too tired at the end to be much afraid of, and Lachlann Dubh, watching from his usual place by the grain-stores' door, thought the girl looked smaller under the household's old crown than any ruler he could remember crowning, and said as much to his wife, who told him that every crown looked too large on whoever first wore it and grew no smaller for the wearing.

There was a moment, before the crown was set, when the eldest of the cousins, a woman near six hundred years old who had outlived two rulers of her own generation and buried a granddaughter besides, stood up unasked and said to the hall at large that a twenty-year-old girl who had never sat a council nor ridden a boundary was no fit head for a line that had held its ground unbroken since the ford. Beathag Mhòr had no leave yet to speak from the chair, and held her tongue; she looked at the woman long enough that the hall grew quiet waiting to see what would come of the look, and what came of it, in the end, was nothing at all: the crown was set, the woman sat down, and no one in that hall ever heard Beathag Mhòr mention the challenge again, though Lachlann Dubh's own accounts show that the woman's household received, every winter after, its full measure of grain and never a sack more.

II

Of the Fleece at Baile Mòr fhionn

In her third year she rode west to the fair at Baile Mòr fhionn, where the lords of the plain held their market each autumn and had lately taken to pricing everything in fleeces, a grown ewe's fleece the measure against which grain and wine and the plain's own horses were weighed. Beathag Mhòr had never seen a market run on wool before and stood a long while at the edge of it watching a horse-trader and a grain-factor argue a bargain down to the quarter-fleece, each of them naming a different ewe in his head and neither troubling to say so.

The silver rings of Muileann chiar were sold there too, though the plain's traders would not call a price in rings outright and reckoned every ring against its fleece-worth first, as if the silver were a foreign thing that needed a native measure to stand beside it before an honest man would touch it. Beathag Mhòr bought nothing at Baile Mòr fhionn that year but a length of the plain's own wool cloth, dyed the red the western dye-houses were known for, and had it made into a cloak she wore at her own crowning-feast the following spring, so that the two colours of her reign, the red of the Share she was born to and the wool-red of the plain she had gone to see, were the same colour before anyone thought to remark on it.

She rode home by the northern road rather than the way she had come, three days longer, because Lachlann Dubh's own accounts had shown her that the northern waypoint houses saw less of the queen's custom than the western ones did, and she wished, she told her household, to know what a keeper's face looked like when a queen's own party filled his hearth for the first time in a generation. It looked, at the house called An Taigh-seinnse Mòr¹, like a man who had killed his last fowl for a stranger's supper and was already wondering how to feed his own children through the week that followed, and Beathag Mhòr, seeing it, sent a carrier's load of grain back to him from Dùn dhearg before the month was out, though she never told him it was hers.

The keeper of that house was a thin, quick-spoken man called Fearchar Iar, no kin to the line of kings that shared his first name, and he served the queen's party the same steamed carp and heather ale his house had served the carriers every winter since the road was first cut, apologising for it twice over supper as though a queen's own stomach might want better than a carrier's. Beathag Mhòr told him,

1. the second waypoint house, a turf longhouse with a hearth at either end

the second time he apologised, that she had eaten worse at her own hearth as a girl and would eat worse again before she died. It was a small enough lie, and her own household knew it for one, yet Fearchar Iar took it for kindness rather than flattery and repeated it to every traveller who lodged under his roof for years afterward, so that the saying outlived the visit that made it by a good deal longer than the visit deserved.

She asked him, before she rode on, how many households the house served in a hard winter and how many turned away for want of room, and he answered her plainly, having nothing to hide and no reason yet to think a queen's questions worth measuring his answers against. It was that plain answering, more than anything seen at Baile Mòr fhionn, that stayed with her longest of everything from that journey, and she said once, years later, to Dùghall mac Raghnaill, that she had learned more of her own island from one night at a road-house's hearth than from every steward's letter that had ever reached her at Dùn dhearg.

III

Of the Bridge-Foot

The hall at Dùn dhearg had stood on its hill since before the shares were cut, and Beathag Mhòr's own line had held it whole and unquestioned longer than any other line on the island had held anything. It was Lachlann Dubh, oddly, who first said aloud what she had already begun to think: that a hall at the island's eastern end, days' ride from the western harbours, could rule a boundary quarrel in the west only at second hand, through a steward's letter that was a season old by the time it was answered, and that a queen who wished to see her own island rather than hear it reported to her would do better to sit where the roads and the river and the western harbours all came together.

He meant it, he said afterward, as an old man's grumble and nothing more, having no wish himself to leave the granary he had counted for forty years, but Beathag Mhòr rode down to the bridge-foot town the winter after he said it and stood on the rise above the harbour a long while in a wind that had her household's cloaks snapping about them, and said only that the ground was good building ground, and asked no one's leave before she began.

Dùn dhearg's people took the news as they took most things touching their own pride, at first with a flat refusal to believe it, and then, when the masons' ox-

sledges began to pass through on the western road, with a silence Lachlann Dubh recognised from the winter of the counting slab four generations before, the silence a household keeps when it has decided a thing cannot be argued and will not therefore be forgiven either. He himself said nothing against the move in the queen's hearing, but he kept, from that year on, a second set of accounts beside the Hall's own, a private tally of every sack that left Dùn dhearg's granaries for the new hall at the bridge-foot, and showed it to no one, not even his son, who found it among his tally-sticks after he died and could not say what his father had meant to do with a count kept for no eye but his own.

The new hall was built of the red stone the town was already named for, on foundations laid deep enough that no age after would need to dig them again, and the masons cut the hearth-sign into its lintel as if the whole building were no more than a threshold, which in a sense, Beathag Mhòr said once to the master mason, it was. The building took four years, through two wet winters that flooded the harbour road and a third summer so dry the masons carried water up from the river in relays of carriers to keep their mortar workable, and Beathag Mhòr rode down from Dùn dhearg to stand on the scaffolding herself more often than her own household thought fitting for a ruler, saying, when Lachlann Dubh's own steward asked her why, that a hall built without its ruler watching was a hall built for someone else's reign, not hers.

The master mason, a broad-shouldered woman of Cathair dhomhain named Sileas nan Clach, had never before been asked to raise a building meant to outlast every hall on the island, and she told the queen plainly, at the laying of the last course, that she could promise the stone would hold and nothing else, for a hall's worth was made by whoever sat in it after the masons had gone home, and that was no mason's business to answer for. Beathag Mhòr took the answer for the honest one it was and paid Sileas nan Clach in full before the hearth-sign was even cut, against the custom of paying a mason only on the building's finishing, which Sileas nan Clach remembered, she told her own apprentices in her old age, as the first time in her working life anyone had trusted her hand before they had seen the whole of what it made.

From that year the hall at the bridge-foot was where a ruler of Dia-thìr kept court, whatever else about the reign might change, though Dùn dhearg kept its granaries and its graves and went on calling itself, in every reeve's own letters home, the rìgh's hill, long after the rìgh had stopped living on it.

IV

Of the Harbour's Grudge

Cathair dhomhain lay near enough to the new hall to smell the masons' dust, and its people, who had built their own harbour into the largest on that coast while Dùn dhearg's rulers were still five days' ride away and easily flattered by a gift of fish, did not care for a queen's toll-gatherers appearing at their own quays as though the harbour had been waiting all along for someone to come and own it.

The harbour-master, a broad woman named Iseabail nic Fhearchair who had run the quays longer than Beathag Mhòr had been alive, brought the matter to the new hall herself rather than send a steward, and stood in front of the queen's own chair with her arms folded and said that Cathair dhomhain had weighed its own fish, mended its own nets and buried its own drowned for longer than the Red Share had held a single stone of Dùn dhearg, and had no memory of asking the Red Share's leave to do any of it. Beathag Mhòr heard her out to the end, which Iseabail nic Fhearchair said afterward she had not expected, having come ready to be interrupted, and answered that she asked no toll of a harbour older than her own hall's foundations, and that Cathair dhomhain might keep its own tolls under its own charter if it kept its own peace with the new town beside it.

The charter was written that same season, in the clerks' own hand and not the knot-keepers', for Beathag Mhòr had by then set two of the Hall's young stag-scholars to write down what had once only been recited, and Iseabail nic Fhearchair carried it home rolled inside her own cloak rather than trust it to any steward's saddlebag. It settled nothing between the two towns beyond the letter of the tolls themselves. Cathair dhomhain's harbour-masters went on for the rest of the age finding some new law of their own to keep more strictly than the new town beside them kept it, a rivalry that cost neither town anything worse than pride, and pride, as Iseabail nic Fhearchair told her own successor before she died, is a cheap enough thing for two towns a few miles apart to spend on each other instead of spears.

The rivalry came out first, and most plainly, in the matter of the winter storm the third year after the charter, when a grain-ship out of the western islands broke its mast off Cathair dhomhain's own harbour mouth and drifted, helpless, toward the shoals below the new hall's rise. Cathair dhomhain's boats reached it first, being the nearer and the more practised at a lee shore in weather, and towed it in to

their own quays rather than the new town's, and though the grain itself went, in the end, to whichever granary the queen's own clerks directed it, Cathair dhomhain's harbour-master let it be known, in every telling of the rescue after, that the ship had been saved by an older skill than any charter could grant a younger town, and the new town's own boatmen, stung, spent the better part of that winter refitting two hulls of their own against the day a ship might drift the other way instead.

None ever did, in Beathag Mhòr's reign or after it, but the two towns kept their boats the sharper for the waiting, and a visitor to either quay had only to ask after the weather to hear some version of the same story, told from whichever side he happened to be standing on.

V

Of the Quarrels over the Handful

At Dùn ìseal, in those same years, the council that judged the small disputes the Small-Burning Law had always settled found itself judging fewer boundary quarrels and more of a kind it had barely troubled with before: households whose right to the handful was disputed outright, a new hearth claiming descent from one of the nine without proof, two households sworn to the same waypoint-keeper each saying the other had no standing at all.

The Keeper who held the flame in those years, an old man who had come to it late from a hearth in the far north and left it again after a short season none of the reciters of Dùn ìseal cared to dwell on, had let the disputes pile against each other without settling more than the loudest, and it fell to his successor, a man named Dùghall mac Raghnaill, chosen by the nine hearths in his twenty-ninth year, to find the council's floor at his own first sitting so crowded with claimants that he could not walk from the door to the cup without a hand catching at his sleeve.

Dùghall mac Raghnaill was of Sliochd Raghnaill¹, one of the Four Houses sworn at Dùn ìseal, though he had left his own house's hall as a boy to learn the vein's reckoning and had not gone back to it since, and he judged, in that first crowded season, with a plainness his own house was not much known for, ruling three claims for and eleven against inside a single afternoon, until an old woman

1. the house of Raghnaill

of the eastern road stood up before him and asked, not unkindly, how a Keeper meant to judge eleven claims a season for the rest of his life without ever once knowing, for certain, which of the eleven he had judged rightly.

He had no answer ready for her, and he told her so, which the reciters of Dùn ìseal count the beginning of what came after, for a lesser Keeper, they say, would have found some answer rather than admit he lacked one, and Dùghall mac Raghnaill rode to Cathair dhearg within the month to ask the queen for a count.

The old woman who had asked him the question, a widow of the eastern road named Beitris nic Ailein, lived long enough, a very old woman by then, to see the first counters ride out from Dùn ìseal six-and-thirty years later, and she told her own grandchildren, more than once before she died, that she had put the question to the Keeper meaning only to shame him a little for the crowded council floor, and had never once expected an island's worth of households to be walked and written down because of it. Dùghall mac Raghnaill himself, when the reciters asked him in his own old age whether he remembered her question word for word, said only that he remembered her face better than her words, and that a Keeper who forgot the faces that had unsettled him was no Keeper worth the flame he kept.

VI

Of the Count Agreed

Beathag Mhòr received him in the new hall's smaller chamber, the one that still smelled of fresh-cut stone, and heard him through without once interrupting, a habit Lachlann Dubh, watching from the doorway, recognised from the granary yard fourteen years before and thought, not for the first time, that a queen who listened whole before she answered was rarer than her own age's reeves ever gave her credit for.

What Dùghall mac Raghnaill asked was simple to say and hard to do: that every household on the island claiming the old right to the handful be counted once, in its own place, its right proved or refused before a clerk who wrote it down, so that no council afterward need judge the same claim twice from memory alone. Beathag Mhòr agreed to it before he had finished asking; it was six-and-thirty years before she found clerks enough and grain enough to begin it, in the last year of her reign, and when the two of them came at last to the doing

she asked only where the counting should be done, since neither the Hall's own clerks nor the queen's own stewards could reach every household on the island inside a single lifetime without some fixed ground to work from.

It was Dùghall mac Raghnaill who thought of the waypoint houses, for every household on Dia-thìr lay within a day's walk of one, and the queen agreed to feed the counters at her own cost out of each house's own stores, which the waypoint-keepers, more used to feeding travellers who never paid enough to cover a night's fire, remembered afterward as the best year their own hearths had ever had. At the house called An Taigh-seinnse Mòr¹, the same house Beathag Mhòr had ridden three days out of her way to see filled once, a counter named Sorcha nic Ruairidh sat six months with a household's own grandmother going back four generations by name and by story until the old woman's claim, thin as it had looked on the council's own doubtful roll, stood proved beyond any argument the council could have raised against it, and Sorcha nic Ruairidh wrote the four names down in a hand the old woman could not read and would not have trusted if she could, and told her, when she asked what was to become of the leaf, that it would outlast them both, which was the plain truth and no more comfort to the old woman than the plain truth generally is.

VII

Of the Refused Roll

The count ran the length of the island and took the better part of that year, and when the last waypoint house had sent its tally in to the clerks at Cath-air dhearg, the rolls gave eleven thousand four hundred households holding the right by clear descent and near two thousand whose claims the counters had been unable to prove by any account, old or new, that the council would accept.

The refused were written on a roll of their own, kept separate from the rest, and it was that separate roll, more than the larger one, that the island remembered afterward, for a family with a clear right had nothing to think about it and a family without one had a roll to search for the rest of its life. Most of the refused lay along the north-eastern coast about Seann Tarr, fisher-families who had never

1. the second waypoint house, a turf longhouse with a hearth at either end

burned coal at all in living memory and now found, when the counters came to their doors expecting to write down a right already held, that no such right had ever been theirs to begin with. A fisherman there named Ruairidh Cam told the counter plainly, when she asked whether his house meant to appeal the ruling, that his house had burned peat before the Small-Burning Law was thought of and would go on burning it after, and that peat, in his own experience of both, was the warmer fire besides, a saying the counters carried back to Cathair dhearg and that spread, in the years after, further along that coast than the census roll itself ever did.

Sliochd Raghnaill¹, Dùghall mac Raghnaill's own house, took up the fisher-families' cause at the council the following spring, arguing that a right so long unclaimed ought to be granted rather than refused, since a household that had never burned coal could hardly be said to have forfeited a habit it had never had. The council heard the argument through and ruled against it, on the plain ground that the Small-Burning Law had never promised a right to a household that had not held it, only protected the right of a household that had, and Dùghall mac Raghnaill, sitting the ruling out from the Keeper's own place beside the cup, did not speak for his own house's argument nor against it, a silence the reciters of Dùn ìseal note without troubling to explain, since a Keeper's silence in his own house's cause was, by then, the kind of thing the Hall had learned to take for something, though never for the same thing twice.

Three of the old sea-lights, fallen to ash and unkept along stretches of coast the census had newly walked from end to end, were rebuilt in those same years, at Baile ìseal on the eastern cape, at Muileann bheag on the northern point, and at Àth dhearg on the north-eastern headland that marked the passage in toward Seann Tarr, each kept afterward with driftwood and seal fat as the Law required, by households who had counted their own coasts, in the walking of the census, for the first time in longer than any of them could say.

Ruairidh Cam himself never troubled the council again after the ruling, and lived to see his own grandson keep the driftwood fire at Baile ìseal's rebuilt light two winters running, a duty owed to no coal-right at all but to the plain fact that his family had always lived nearest the point and knew its rocks in the dark better than any counter's roll could teach a stranger. He was asked once, by a traveller who had heard the saying about peat repeated as far south as Cathair dhearg,

1. the house of Raghnaill

whether he still held to it, and he answered that he did, and that a fire a man had tended with his own hands since boyhood was always the warmer one, whatever its ash was made of, which the traveller wrote down as a fisherman's stubbornness and the fisher-families of that coast kept, afterward, as something nearer the truth.

VIII

Of the Long Road Home

Beathag Mhòr's son Ruairidh was born at the new hall in its first year, grey-headed almost from his cradle, which his own household took for an ill sign and his mother, when she was told of it, took for nothing at all, having by then buried enough of her own line's short-lived cousins to know that a child's colouring foretold no more than a child's colouring ever does.

She lived only months past the count's finishing, long enough to see the refused roll consulted for the first time by a family proving an old claim through a cousin's cousin, and to see Dùghall mac Raghnaill, grey now in his own turn at the cup, still Keeper, still hearing the same handful of claims that the census had not quite managed to end.

In her last years she sat less at the harbour rise and more at the small chamber's own window, which looked east, back the way the bridge-foot road ran toward Dùn dhearg, and her household came to know that a queen sitting at that window in the last hour of daylight was a queen who wished to be left with her own thoughts rather than her own council. Her son Ruairidh, grown into a tall, grey-headed man who had long since stopped minding the colour that had once been called an ill sign, sat with her there more often than his own stewards thought fitting for an heir with a hall's business waiting on him, and it was to him alone, in the last winter, that she gave the command about her carrying, speaking it plainly and only once, as though a thing worth doing at all was not worth the saying twice.

She died at Cathair dhearg in her seventieth year, in the same small chamber where she had first heard Dùghall mac Raghnaill ask her for a count, and by her own command, given years before to her son and never once changed, she was carried back to Dùn dhearg to lie among the house of Ìomhar, the granaries she

had grown up counting and the hill her own great-grandfather had died old and easy upon.

No royal journey before it had been so long. The road ran east the whole width of the island, five days at a walking bier's pace, and it was carried by relays of bearers drawn from every waypoint house along the way, twelve to a stage, so that the same road that had once counted the island's households now carried its queen home along the ground her own counters had walked. Ruairidh rode at the bier's head the whole distance and would let no one take his place, though his own stewards offered more than once to spell him on the harder stretches, and at each waypoint house where the bearers changed he stood by while the new twelve took up the poles and said nothing, having, his own household remembered, very little left to say by the second day.

Dùghall mac Raghnaill rode with it the last stretch from Dùn ìseal, an old man himself by then, remembering, as the bier passed the waypoint house at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr¹ where a counter had once sat six months over one grandmother's claim, that the queen he was burying had asked him, the very first time he stood before her, only where the counting should be done, and had never once, in all the years after, asked him whether it had been worth the doing. He thought, riding behind her bier into the granary yard at Dùn dhearg where Lachlann Dubh's grandson stood waiting with the household's own tallies under his arm, that he might have told her, had she asked: that the roll of the refused, thin and worn as it already was, would go on being searched long after that, when every hand that had written it was dust, and that this, of everything a reign could leave behind it, was no small thing to have made.

They laid her among the house of Ìomhar on the slope above the double bank, within sight of the granaries Lachlann Dubh had walked her through as a girl of twenty who had asked a steward the name of every household a sack was owed to, and no sack's weight besides. The roll of the refused was carried up from Cathair dhearg in its own worn chest the following season, kept for the living rather than laid with the dead, and read aloud once at Dùn dhearg before the household of Ìomhar, so that the hill that had given up its own hall might hear, at least once, what the giving had bought.

1. the second waypoint house, a turf longhouse with a hearth at either end

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

Of the Silver Feud

FE 1,736 – 1,781

Cha do bbris an t-airgead a dbath riamh; carson a bhristeadh e a chumbachd? Silver never broke its colour; why should it break its word?

— said still at the smiths' hearth of Muileann chiar, of no ruler in particular

I

Of the Grey Rìgh

Ruairidh Liath took the red hall at Cathair dhearg in his thirty-sixth year, five days after they had carried his mother the length of the island to lie among the house of Ìomhar, and the reeves who set the crown on him did it quietly, for a household still in its year of mourning is not a household that wants a feast made of a crowning. He had been grey since his cradle, as his mother's own household had first taken for an ill sign and then, watching him grow tall and steady and no sicklier than any other child, for nothing more than the colour a man is born with, and the byname stuck to him the way a byname sticks to a family that has run out of new ones: Ruairidh Liath, Ruairidh the Grey, the one jest the king-list ever allowed among its years of names.

He kept his mother's clerks, her stewards, her reeve at Dùn dhearg, and for the first years of his reign changed little that she had set in order, being, his own household said of him, a man who mistrusted a thing done only because it was new. The old reeve who had walked at Beathag Mhòr's stirrup was long dead by then, but his grandson kept the same tallies in much the same hand, and it was to

him, in his first winter, that Ruairidh Liath said the one thing of his own that the granary household remembered afterward: that he had watched his mother spend her reign finding out what the island held, and meant to spend his own reign finding out only what it needed, which he judged the smaller and the harder task of the two.

What he did change, in his fourth year, was the guard he kept on the eastern road, doubling it against the toll-cheats who had grown bold in the years the census had kept every clerk in the island walking from house to house rather than watching the roads, and it was the guard's own pay, more than anything else in his reign, that brought him at last to the silver.

The silver of the island came from one place only, the workings at Muileann chiar, a small town of a few hundred souls a short ride north of Dùn ìseal, where the seam ran shallow enough to be worked with pick and fire-setting and had done, by Ruairidh Liath's day, for longer than any family there could count in generations rather than reigns. It was Muireach Liath himself, second Keeper of the flame, who had ruled in the age's first years that silver showed no colour when it broke and so was not the mountain's, and Muileann chiar had dug as deep as it liked ever since on the strength of those words, paying no toll to the Hall and none, until Ruairidh Liath's reign, to the crown either.

II

Of Sliochd Fhearchair

The house that held the workings by that time, and had held them for sixty generations without any other house troubling to dispute it, was Sliochd Fhearchair, the line of Fearchar Airgeadach, the basket-carrier who had first hammered the ore into rings in the Hall's first century, and it was an old woman of that house, Màiri nic Fhearchair, who spoke for it in the years that followed, having outlived two husbands, three of her own children, and every other smith of her own generation who might have spoken instead.

She had been born in the first years of Beathag Mhòr's reign, and had lived to see her own grandmother's claim to the handful proved before the counters when the census came at last to Muileann chiar, so that Màiri nic Fhearchair knew, before she knew much else, what it cost a house to have its right questioned and what it was worth to have it settled beyond argument afterward. She came to

speak for Sliochd Fhearchair the ordinary way a smith's house chooses its voice, by being the one whose word the others trusted furthest, and she held the place for twenty years before Ruairidh Liath ever asked anything of her that was hard to give.

Neither large nor loud, she was known to the traders who came up from Dùn ìseal to buy rings by the basket only for weighing a ring twice before she named its price and never once, in all the years they dealt with her, weighed it wrong. Her own hands, by the time Ruairidh Liath's reign was ten years old, had thickened at the knuckle from forty years at the fire, and she wore, summer and winter both, a single ring of her own house's silver on a cord at her throat rather than on her finger, saying, when anyone asked her why, that a ring worn where it could be seen was a ring a smith remembered making rather than a ring she had forgotten she owned.

Her own house kept, in those years, some thirty smiths and apprentices at the workings and the forge-yard beside them, a small enough number beside the shepherds and cutters of the greater shares but the only hands on the island that drew silver at all, and Muileann chiar had grown up around them a town of a few hundred souls who owed their bread, one way or another, to the ore beneath their own feet. Màiri knew every one of the thirty by name and by trade, the fire-setters who cracked the rock with heat and water before the pick ever touched it, the smelters who read a flame's colour the way a reciter read a knotted cord, the smiths proper who drew the wire and struck the rings, and she judged each of their disputes herself rather than let them go before the town's own reeve, saying that a smith's quarrel was a family matter until the day it was not, and she meant, by that, to keep it a family matter as long as she was able.

III

Of the Ring in Five

The demand came in Ruairidh Liath's ninth year, carried up from Dùn dhearg by a steward who had ridden three days to deliver it and plainly wished, from the look of him, that someone else had been sent instead: that Sliochd Fhearchair should render one ring in every five it drew from the ore, the silver going to pay the guard whose doubling had emptied the crown's own purse faster than the eastern tolls could fill it again.

Màiri nic Fhearchair heard the steward out in the yard before her own forge, with the fire banked low behind her and her apprentices standing well back, and the steward, who had expected an old smith to hear a righ's asking with some show of trouble at least, said afterward that she heard it the way a woman hears news of weather she has already dressed against. She asked him only one question before she answered him at all: whether he had been told to wait for her answer or only to carry it away with him whatever it was, and when he said he had been told to wait, she told him he need not, for the answer would take her no longer to give than it had taken him to ask.

She answered him, then, with words she had not troubled to soften: that the tokens which paid a queen's guards were the queen's own business, but the silver that made them had never once, in sixty generations, been anybody's business but the hands that dug it and the fire that shaped it, and that Muireach Liath himself, second Keeper of the flame, had said as much before any road-guard on the island carried a spear. The steward asked her, before he left, whether she wished him to soften the words on the road back to Cathair dhearg, and she told him no, that a message softened in the carrying was a message that lied twice over, once to the one who sent it and once to the one who received it, and she would rather Ruairidh Liath heard her exact meaning and be angry at it than a kinder one and be satisfied with less than the truth.

She sent the steward home with no other answer, and within the month, before the crown's own clerks had finished drawing up the toll roll they meant to collect it by, the workings at Muileann chiar stood shut, the fires out, the ore left in the ground.

It was not a thing any house on the island had done before, to close a working rather than pay what its ruler asked, and Sliochd Fhearchair did not do it lightly: the shutting cost the house its own trade as surely as it cost the crown its silver, and more than one of Màiri's own kin asked her, in the first weeks, whether a ring in five paid quietly would not have been the cheaper course in the end. Tormod himself, then a young man newly come into his own place at the forge, put the question to her most plainly of any of them, standing in the cooling yard with the last of the fire's light on his face, and asked whether a house that had never once been troubled for a toll in sixty generations might not simply pay the one toll and go back to being untroubled the generation after.

She told him that a house which paid the first asking without argument would be asked again within the year, and a third time within two, until it had nothing

left to argue with, for a right unused, she said, was no different in the end from a right given away, only slower in the losing of it; and she told him besides that she had not shut the fires to save the house a single ring, since the house could well have spared the silver, but to make certain that whatever it paid afterward, it paid because a Keeper had judged it owed and not because a righ had asked for it once and found no one troubled to say him no. Her own certainty in the matter, Tor-mod said years afterward, was the only certain thing in Muileann chiar that whole first season, for even her own household went to their beds most nights that winter no surer than the righ himself how long a smith's house could go without its fires before it stopped being a smith's house at all.

IV

Of the Three Seasons

The shutting held three seasons entire, the longest quiet the workings at Muileann chiar had known since they were first opened, and the island felt it before the year was out. The fair at Muileann òg, which had traded half its custom in silver rings for as long as the smiths of Sliochd Fhearchair had carried them there, went back to weighing its bargains in grain and cloth as it had done before the workings were dug at all, and the traders who had grown rich carrying rings down the eastern road found their own baskets empty and their own trade gone to whoever still had grain to sell.

V

Of the Toll-House at Àth ghlas

The road-guards themselves, whose pay had begun the whole quarrel, went unpaid through the second season and the third, and it was at the toll-house of Àth ghlas, the first keeper the righ's hall had ever sent to stand a road, that the wanting was felt worst. Two of the four guards posted there left their spears against the toll-house wall in the same week of the second winter and walked home to their own villages rather than stand a further watch for wages that were themselves standing, unpaid, on a silver toll no one had yet agreed to

gather, and the keeper who held the house, a woman named Oighrig nic Ailein who had kept it eleven years without missing a season's watch before that winter, sent no word of the desertion to Cathair dhearg at all, judging, she told the two who stayed, that a rìgh already short of silver had no need of a letter telling him he was short of guards as well.

She stood the toll-house herself through the worst of that season with the two guards who remained, turning back no traveller and collecting no toll from any of them either, for a toll-house with half its watch was no toll-house at all in her own reckoning, only a roof with a fire under it, and she told travellers who asked after the toll that the crown's business with the silversmiths was the crown's own to settle and none of theirs, an answer more than one carrier carried onward down the road and repeated at hearths from Àth ghlas to the western harbours until it had travelled, by the third season, further than the quarrel itself had yet been heard of in some quarters. The tolls of the eastern road went ungathered the whole three seasons through, for want of anyone willing to stand the road and collect them, and it was the emptiest the crown's own purse had stood since Beathag Mhòr's own reign, before the census had ever begun to fill it.

Ruairidh Liath, for his own part, did not send soldiers to the workings, though more than one of his own reeves urged it on him; his mother's household remembered him saying once, in those years, that a mine could be broken open by force but a smith's hand could not, and a crown that had only broken hands to show for its silver had made a poor bargain of it. He sent, instead, a second steward to Àth ghlas with grain enough to feed the toll-house through what remained of the winter, unasked and unannounced, much as his own mother had once sent grain to a hungry waypoint house without naming herself the sender, and Oighrig nic Ailein, who guessed well enough whose grain it was, never once told a traveller the story of it, though she kept, for the rest of her life, a fuller hearth at Àth ghlas than the crown's own wages alone would have bought her.

VI

Of the Third Winter

he held to the toll, and waited, through the whole of that hungry season, and it was Màiri nic Fhearchair, in the end, who moved first, not because her own house's will had bent but because of what she saw, in the third

winter, in her own forge-yard: two of her youngest apprentices, a brother and sister taken on the year the shutting began, going thinner at the wrist than any apprentice she had trained in forty years at the fire, their own family having nothing to send them from Muileann chiar's own thin fields, and no wage from the silver to buy what the fields could not give. She fed them from her own table rather than send them home, and told no one of it beyond her own household, but she judged, watching the boy's hands shake over a task that should not have troubled hands half so young, that a right worth keeping was not worth keeping at the cost of the hands that would keep it after her.

She said as much to her own kin, plainly, the same week she sent word to Dùn ìseal: that Sliochd Fhearchair had shut its fires to keep a principle and very nearly starved two children doing it, and a principle that cost a smith's own apprentices their strength before it cost the crown a single ring was a principle she had begun to hold for her own pride's sake rather than the house's, which was, she told them, the one thing she had sworn, on taking up her place at the forge twenty years before, that she would never let herself do.

VII

Of the Journey to Dùn ìseal

She made the ride to Dùn ìseal herself, in the last month of the third season, in a rain that had not let up in four days and turned the road below Muileann chiar to a soup the horses balked at twice before she got them through it, taking with her only her grandnephew Tormod and a single strongbox holding every ring Sliochd Fhearchair had struck in the reign of Fearchar Òg, that the Keeper might see, she said, exactly what silver looked like before anyone had thought to argue over who owned it.

She had never before asked the Hall for anything, her own house having stood, since Muireach Liath's ruling, entirely outside the Hall's reckoning of what belonged to the mountain and what did not, and it cost her something, Tormod said years afterward, to ride up to the Keeper's own door and ask a judgment of a man whose office existed to weigh coal, not silver. Dùghall mac Raghnaill received her all the same, being by then an old man of seventy-nine who had judged every manner of claim the island could bring him and had long since stopped thinking any of them beneath his hearing, and he sent word to Cathair dhearg the same

week asking that Ruairidh Liath meet her there, at Dùn ìseal, on ground that belonged to neither of them outright.

VIII

Of the Rain-Shut Hearing

The hearing was held in the Hall at Dùn ìseal on a day the rain shut every door in the town and kept the roof-gutters running loud enough that Dùghall mac Raghnaill twice had to ask both sides to speak again, and it was there, before the cup and the Keeper and Ruairidh Liath, grey and forty-nine and no longer young enough to think a quarrel would settle on its own, that Màiri nic Fhearchair said Muireach Liath's sentence for the first time: that silver showed no colour when it broke, and so was not the mountain's.

She said it standing, her strongbox open on the floor before the cup so that any who wished might look into it and see the rings themselves, struck before the crown had ever thought to ask anything of them, and she added to Muireach Liath's own words only a handful of her own: that she had not come to Dùn ìseal to ask whether the crown might be poor, for every house on the island had known a poor season and none begrudged its ruler one, but to ask whether a right sixty generations old could be undone by a single asking from a man who had held the hall thirteen years, and if it could, she wished to be told so plainly, that Sliochd Fhearchair might know from that day what its rights were worth.

Ruairidh Liath answered that he did not dispute the mountain's claim or lack of one; he disputed only whether a crown might ask a toll of a trade that used its roads, wore its peace and sold its wares under laws his own house had written, silver or no silver, mountain's or no mountain's. He said, further, that he had not shut her workings; she had shut them herself rather than argue the matter with him first, and a house that answered an asking with a closed door had made the quarrel larger than the asking ever was, a charge Màiri nic Fhearchair did not trouble to deny, saying only that a door closed in argument was easier to open again than a right given away was to take back.

Dùghall mac Raghnaill let them argue it the better part of a day, the rain never once slackening, and when he judged at last he had Màiri nic Fhearchair say the sentence a second time, word for word as she had said it the first, before he gave his own ruling on it.

He ruled that the words of Muireach Liath stood as they had always stood: silver was not the mountain's, and no Keeper after him would say otherwise. But he ruled, in the same breath, that the crown kept the roads the silver travelled whether the silver itself was the crown's or not, and that a house which used those roads owed something toward their keeping, though nothing toward the ore beneath its own feet. Each of them was right, he said, and each of them had asked the wrong question first, Ruairidh Liath for reaching past the silver to the roads without saying so and Màiri nic Fhearchair for reaching past the roads to the silver in her own defence of it, and a ring in five had never been the toll he would have set had either of them asked him the plainer question at the start.

He set it, in the end, at one ring in ten, owed not on the ore drawn from the ground but on every ring that left Muileann chiar by the roads the crown kept, and both sides, Tormod said afterward, rode home from Dùn ìseal calling it a victory, though neither, in truth, had won anything but the certainty of knowing what it would cost them from that year on.

I X

Of the Weight Made Law

The workings opened again within the month, the fires lit and the ore drawn as it had been for sixty generations, but the settlement left one thing behind it that outlasted the quarrel's own memory: for the toll to be reckoned fairly, ring against ring, the weights of Muileann chiar, kept by Sliochd Fhearchair's own hand since the Peace of the Threshold and trusted nowhere beyond the workings themselves, were declared by the Keeper's own judgment the only lawful weights on the roads of the island, and copies in bronze were ordered sent to every waypoint house between Dùn ìseal and the western harbours, that a ring weighed at one hearth might be trusted at the next without argument.

Màiri nic Fhearchair was paid, by the crown's own clerks, for every copy cast from her house's own weights, the first silver Sliochd Fhearchair had ever taken from Cathair dhearg rather than given it, and she remarked once to Tormod, counting the payment into the strongbox that had ridden to Dùn ìseal and back, that she had gone to the Hall meaning to keep the crown's hand off her house's silver and had come home, instead, with the crown's own silver in her own strong-

box, a different victory than the one she had set out to win, and, she judged, no poor one to settle for.

X

Of the Bronze-Casters

The copies themselves were cast at Muileann dhearg, a market town roughly midway along the road between Cathair dhearg and Dùn ìseal, by a family of casters named Sliochd Aonghais who had learned the trade from the smiths of Muileann chlar two generations before and had never yet found a market for it beyond a few pins and buckles a season. The weight-copies gave them, for the first time, a craft the whole island wanted, and they went on, in the years after, to cast bells for the waypoint houses and lamp-bowls for the Hall's own use, each lamp-bowl holding, by the founder's own boast, exactly the measure the Small-Burning Law required and not a hair's breadth more or less.

The founder of that trade, a broad woman named Beitris nic Aonghais, kept for the rest of her life the first weight-copy she had ever cast, a poor one, cracked along its rim from cooling too fast, and showed it to every apprentice she took on afterward before she let them near the good bronze, telling them that a caster who forgot her own worst work was a caster likely to repeat it.

She sent word to Màiri nic Fhearchair, the season the good copies first went out along the road, asking leave to cast the smiths' own hearth-sign into each weight's underside, that any waypoint keeper who turned one over might know at a glance whose measure it stood for, and Màiri gave the leave gladly, saying it cost Sliochd Fhearchair nothing and might, in some quarrel neither of them could yet foresee, save a keeper an argument over whether the weight in his own hand was the true one. It was a small mark, cut no bigger than a thumbnail, and the two houses that had never traded more than a few pins between them before the settlement went on trading weights and bells and lamp-bowls for years after both women who had first agreed to it were dead, every weight cast at Muileann dhearg still carrying, to the close of Ruairidh Liath's reign and past it, the same small sign struck at Muileann chlar and cast at Muileann dhearg together.

X I

Of Màiri's Last Years

Màiri nic Fhearchair lived eleven years past the settlement, long enough to see the bronze weights reach every waypoint house from Dùn ìseal to the western harbours and long enough to see her own grandnephew Tormod take up her place at the forge-yard, speaking for Sliochd Fhearchair in his turn with a plainness she had taught him without ever once calling it teaching. She wore the same ring on its cord at her throat to the end of her days, and when she died, in the eightieth year of her life, the household of Sliochd Fhearchair buried her, at her own long-standing word, with the strongbox itself rather than the ring on the cord, empty by then of everything but the single weight-copy she had carried to Dùn ìseal in the rain, saying she had carried enough silver in her life without needing to carry any of it into the ground.

Dùghall mac Raghnaill died the same year, in his ninetieth, an old man who had held the flame near as long as Coinneach Mòr before him and had judged, by his own late count, more disputes over the handful and over the silver both than he could any longer put a number to; the reciters of Dùn ìseal remembered him afterward less for the census that had made his name than for the rain-shut hearing at which he had told two sides they were each right and each wrong, a saying more than one Keeper after him borrowed without troubling to say whose it had first been.

X I I

Of Seonag Chrom and the List Kept Yearly

Ruairidh Liath reigned one-and-thirty years more, growing no greyer than he had been at his crowning, for a man born grey has little further to grow into, and died in the red hall at Cathair dhearg in his eightieth year, in the same small chamber where his mother had died before him, mourned by a household that remembered him, in the reeve's own words to his successor, as a right who had waited where waiting served and moved where nothing else would.

His granddaughter Seonag Chrom took the hall the year after, in her twenty-first year, the crown set on her without argument from any of the houses that might once have disputed a young ruler's age, for the island had by then buried

enough young rulers grown old in office to have stopped counting a crowned head's years against her. She had grown up, her own household said, on stories of her grandfather's silver quarrel told at the granary fire by clerks who still kept, among the hall's own rolls, the roll of weights sent out that year to every waypoint house, and she asked, in the first month of her reign, to see that roll for herself before she asked to see any other roll in the hall's keeping.

What she found, turning it over by lamplight with the reeve who had kept it since his own father's day, was a record set down on whatever scrap of hide or bark had come to hand at the time, one clerk's tally crossed through and corrected in another clerk's hand, a third page missing its corner where damp had eaten it, and she judged, closing it at last, that a crown which meant to keep such a roll at all owed the keeping of it more care than a corner of the granary stores had ever given it. She gave the Hall's clerks, in her first season, a room of their own within the red hall, the first they had ever had that was not a corner of the granary stores or a table borrowed from the kitchens, and a wage in silver besides, the same silver the settlement at Dùn ìseal had first taught the crown to reckon by the ring rather than by the sack.

It was from her reign, the clerks of Cathair dhearg said afterward, that the king-list ceased to be kept reign by reign, as it had been kept since Tormod first set it down, and began instead to be kept year by year, so that no year of the island's telling, however quiet, would ever again go unwritten for want of a reign large enough to hold it.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

OF PEIGI'S HAND AND THE DAWN-HAWK

FE 1,782 – 2,217

Chan eil fuil aig an fhirinn; tha i mar a chithear i. Truth has no
blood in it; it is as it is seen.

— a saying of the clerks' room at Cathair dhearg

I

Of Fish that Do Not Need Reading

At Inis bheag, where the Abhainn bheag comes down brown with peat-water into the sea and the fisher-houses stand along the one street with their backs to the wind, a teacher of the stag's people took a boat north a century after the Silver Feud was settled and stayed. He had been a cutter's son himself before he was a teacher, and had come to letters the way the stag's people came to most of what they taught, sideways, from a lesson meant for something else; but he found at Inis bheag a village of children who would never in their lives cut a handful of coal, whose fathers measured their year by the herring and not by the Hall's roll, and he taught them the marks anyway, on slate and on the smoothed bark of driftwood, because it seemed to him a poor thing that a mark should belong only to the vein.

The Hall's roll took note of it, as the Hall's roll took note of most things done anywhere on the island that year, and set down beside the notice, in the dry hand of whichever clerk kept the roll that season, a line to the effect that fish had no need of reading. Most who copied the line took it, in the years after, for nothing

crueller than a clerk's small joke, the kind a tired hand makes at the foot of a long entry, and for two generations at Inis bheag it was told against the reading fisher-children themselves, at the boat-mending in winter, a jest the letters had as yet done nothing to earn: they had lightened no net and stilled no wave. The children the teacher taught grew old and taught their own in turn, and the marks he had begun on driftwood were still, by the time his grandchildren's grandchildren were grown, marks for counting a catch and naming a boat, no stranger in the eyes of the rest of the island than a knot on a cord, only harder on the eye to read at a distance.

The teacher himself did not live to see the marks travel further than his own street. He died an old man at Inis bheag, having taught three generations of the same dozen families and never once been asked by the Hall what use the teaching served, and his own grave-marker, cut by a pupil's hand, carries his name in the fisher-marks rather than in the Hall's own hand, the first stone on the island so cut, though no teller thought, at the time it was raised, to set the day down.

What the fisher-houses did not know, because no one troubled to tell them and they had no way of finding it out on their own, was that a boy of their own street, sent inland in his youth to serve at Cathair dhearg because his mother's cousin kept horses in the red hall's own stables, carried the marks with him into the red hall's own household, where no one before him had thought to teach them to anyone who was not already a clerk. He taught them badly and by accident, scratching a fisher's tally on a granary door for his own amusement while he waited on a groom who was slow to his work, and a clerk's daughter watching him at it asked what the marks meant and would not be put off with an answer that they were nothing, being a child who had already, by nine years old, formed the habit of believing that a thing written down meant something, or it would not have been written at all.

II

Of Peigi's Hand

The clerk's daughter was Peigi nic Tormoid, of the line of Tormod Scriobhaiche, who had first set a ruler's name on a leaf of oiled hide more than six hundred years before her, and by the time she came to the clerks' room herself, grown, the room Seonag Chrom had given the clerks five generations before

had four benches in it instead of one, and a chest for the rolls that would not shut for the fullness of it. She learned the fisher-marks from the stable-boy before she learned the Hall's own hand from her mother, and kept both all her life, though she used the second far oftener. Clerks two generations after her own said that a document in Peigi nic Tormoid's hand could be told from any other in the chest without a name beside it at all: the letters were set close and upright, and never once trailed off at the foot of a page the way a tired hand trails, whoever holds the pen.

She was given the clerk's stool in her twenty-sixth year for a plainer reason than her own family cared to admit afterward: the elder cousin who had held it before her had died of a fever the winter past, and no one else in the room wanted the work. Peigi herself, told the plain truth of it years later by the reeve who had made the choice, thought it a better reason to be given anything than most reasons rulers give. She kept the roll of the red hall for four-and-forty years from that day, through a reign and the half of another, and left behind her, when she died in her own bed at seventy, entries enough that the clerks who came after her learned to date a leaf by nothing more than whether her hand lay on it. More than one of them called it a truer clock than the reign it was written under.

Her days ran, for most of those four-and-forty years, on a pattern so unbroken that later clerks who read her own account of an ordinary week found it stranger, in its way, than any single ruling she made. She rose before the household woke, kept her own small fire until the granary bell rang, and walked the length of the clerks' room twice before touching a single leaf, to see, she told a young clerk once who asked her the use of it, whether anything had been moved in the night that oughtn't have been. Nothing ever had been, in all the years she kept the habit, but she never gave it up, on the reasoning that a habit which cost nothing and caught nothing was still worth keeping against the one year it might catch something.

She never gave a reason where a fact would serve, and it was this above her hand that the clerks who followed her remembered longest. A lord of the plain came to her once, in her middle years, to have a boundary dispute set down in his own favour, and pressed her at length for her opinion of the case's justice before she would write a word of it. Peigi told him she kept no opinions in the roll, only what was said and by whom, and that if he wanted an opinion set down he should say his own aloud and she would write that too, word for word, with his name beside it. He did not ask her again. What she wrote instead, plainly and at his own asking once he saw there was no other way to have it set down at all, was

the boundary as both sides had described it, the disagreement between the two descriptions, and the day the two sides had last agreed on anything, which turned out, when a Keeper's clerk went looking for it two centuries later in a dispute grown far larger than the first, to be the one fact in the whole roll that settled the matter.

III

Of the Grey Hawk of the Northern Skell

While Peigi kept her roll at Cathair dhearg, far to the north at Seann Skell on the cold coast the fowler families had begun a custom the Hall's roll would not hear of for years yet, being a custom kept entirely among themselves, on a shore few clerks ever troubled to visit. Every household there kept a hawk, as fowlers along that coast had always kept hawks, for the wild geese and the duck that came down onto the flats in their season; but somewhere in the years after the letters reached Inis bheag, without any teacher coming north to bring them, the fowler households of Seann Skell took to feeding the hawk before the household ate, on the reasoning, as one of them put it to a trader who asked, that a hunger fed first was a hunger that did not turn on the house that kept it waiting.

Raghnaid nic Chaluim was born into one of those households in the same generation that Peigi's roll, far south, was already growing thick with her successor's hand, and her own household came to say of her, in the tellings that followed, that she was the first of her line to carry the custom the whole distance it would go. Her hawk was a grey bird her father had flown before her and called Mòd, as the old households of that coast called their hawks Mòd, after the grey hawk of time that had lived down every age as a salmon and an eagle and a hawk by turns and remembered, between its shapes, more than any single creature could remember alone. At every dawn of the season when the handful was due she stood at her own threshold, unhooded the bird herself rather than leave it to a servant, and burned her household's measure with Mòd on her wrist, so that its eye was on the flame the whole time it burned, the smoke going up past its head into a sky still more grey than light.

A clerk sent up from Cathair dhearg to write the custom down for the Hall's own roll found her at that threshold one such dawn, in the last winter of her

middle years, and asked her plainly, once the burning was done, why the bird had to watch it rather than wait fed in its mews until the handful was ash. She did not answer him at once. She looked at the hawk a while, working a loose feather straight with two fingers, and then said only that the flame was a hunger too, as the hawk on her wrist was a hunger, and ought to be fed the way a hunger is fed, in the sight of the thing that hungers; a household that burned its handful with the bird shut away would be doing the whole business by halves, the way a man does a kindness by halves when he does it where no eye can find him out. The clerk wrote the answer down as she gave it, without a word of his own beside it, for the Hall's roll had learned, at some cost, what came of setting a joke beside a keeping it did not yet understand, and meant, this time, to make no such mistake twice.

IV

Of "No Concern of Ours"

The custom spread from Seann Skell up the Abhainn ìseal within Raghnaid's own lifetime, carried by traders who had seen it kept and thought it a fair thing to keep, until households at Inis ìseal and at Cnoc bheag were feeding a hawk before themselves and burning their dawn handful on the wrist as the Skell fowlers did, though none of them fowled for a living and more than one household, in the first years, kept a bird they had bought at no small cost from a Skell trader and fed better than they fed their own children, which their neighbours who kept no hawk at all were not slow to remark on.

Word of it reached Dùn ìseal in its own season, as word of every rite kept anywhere on the island reached Dùn ìseal sooner or later, and the Keeper who held the cup that year, whose name the Hall's roll set down plainly enough but whose face no teller troubled afterward to remember, was pressed by a household of the lowland plain to say whether the Hall meant to rule on the hawk-rite as Fionnlagh Dall had once ruled on a household's burning of its own measure. The household was uneasy less at the burning itself than at a keeping it did not understand spreading past its own coast into ground it thought its own to watch. The Keeper sent a clerk north to Cnoc bheag to see the dawn kept before answering rather than trust a report carried three times over by mouths that had not seen it, and the clerk came back and said plainly that the hawk-households burned no

more of their handful than any other household on the island, to the grain, no later in the day and no earlier, only in the sight of a bird where other hearths kept no such sight at all.

On the strength of that report the Keeper wrote to the lowland household, and to every household after it that raised the same question in the years that followed, four words that were copied afterward into more than one household's own chest as a ruling in their own right: the rite kept the measure, and was no concern of the Hall's. It was, as it turned out, the last time in the whole age that the Hall answered any rite so simply. No one at Dùn ìseal that season, occupied wholly with the hawk-households and nothing beyond them, reckoned how many other keepings the island held that a household might one day put the same question to, nor how much harder each answer after the first would grow, once the first had been given away so freely and for so little in return.

V

Of the Sting and the Western Harbours

Own the western coast, at Ros bheag where the harbour court had kept its own customs of trade since before any hawk was fed on that shore, a different swearing had begun to travel up from Baile àrsaidh among the yellow scorpions of the dry hill country, where a sting shut living in a box had been sworn on for longer than any teller could say why. A merchant of Ros bheag named Coll Ruadh, trading salt fish for the dry country's dyed wool, came home from his first journey south with the box and the custom both, and swore his next bargain on the sting before the harbour court had ever seen such a thing done, more from habit picked up on the road, he said afterward, than from any belief that a sting in a box bound a man tighter than his own word.

It bound the western harbours tighter than anything else had, within a few short years, for reasons Coll Ruadh himself was the first to admit he had not foreseen. A trader of the plain came to Ros bheag the following season, meaning to buy a season's fish on credit against a debt he swore would be paid by midwinter, and would not swear it on the sting when the harbour court, having by then grown fond of the custom, asked him to; he gave his reasons plainly enough, that a box of scorpions was no fit thing to swear a grown man's debt on and he would swear it on his own name or not at all. The harbour court let him swear on his

own name, as he asked, and sold him no fish, on the reasoning, given him by the court's own eldest without much softening, that a man who would not swear on the sting when every other trader on that coast did was a man telling the court something about his debt that his own name alone did not say.

He came back within the season, paid double what the fish would have cost him at midwinter, and swore on the sting the second time without being asked, and it was remembered afterward at Ros bheag, by those who told the tale against traders of the plain generally, that he had learned in one dear lesson what the harbour had known for a generation: a custom trusted by everyone costs a stranger far more to refuse than to keep. He was not the last to learn it the hard way. A wool-factor of Cathair mhòr, a few years later, made the same refusal on the same grounds and got the same answer, and left Ros bheag that season, the harbour's own tellers say, with a string of pack-beasts still laden with the fleeces he had meant to sell against fish he never bought.

By the time Coll Ruadh himself died, an old man still keeping his own scorpion in its box behind the harbour-master's door, no merchant travelled the western coast without learning the swearing before he learned the prices, and the harbour courts from Ros bheag to Baile àrsaidh had come to hold, without any of them writing it down as a law, that a bargain sworn any other way was a bargain a careful man watched closely. His own box, kept after him by his daughter and her daughter after her, outlived three generations of the family that first brought it north, the scorpion within it renewed from the dry hill country each time the old one died, so that the box itself, the harbour-master's clerks noted once in an idle entry, had by then held more scorpions than any single trader who swore upon it would live to count.

VI

Of the Second Wolf-Stone

Inland and to the south, where the roads Ailean Clachair's masons had first bridged now carried more carriers than ever, the wolf-sworn road-guards of Caol leathan kept a watch the island's peace had come, by slow degrees, to lean on more than it once needed to, feuds being rarer on the roads with every generation that forgot what the stones at Dùn thais had once marked. The guards swore their own oath on a white stone at their founding, and it had stood alone

for so long that most travellers who passed it took it for no more than a boundary marker of the guild's own ground, until the shrine-keepers of Inis thais, hearing of the guard's stone and its keeping, asked whether a second might be set at their own shrine, where the drowned were already prayed to and a guard's oath, they thought, would sit well beside an older prayer.

The guards agreed, being flattered more than they let on to be asked, and set about the dragging of it themselves rather than trust the work to any mason who had not sworn their own oath. The stone they chose was white quartz from high on the mountain, heavier by half than the guard's own first stone, and it cost them, by the account their captain Calum Mòr gave afterward to a teller who asked him plainly what a shrine-stone was worth, more oxen than the guild could easily spare and the better part of a season's toll besides, the sledge breaking twice on the lower slopes and one ox dying under the strain of the second breaking before it ever reached the road proper.

Calum Mòr stood at Inis thais himself when the stone was finally raised beside the shrine, and it was noted by more than one of the shrine-keepers present, and set down afterward in their own thin roll, that the road-guard's captain, asked by the eldest keeper whether he wished to pray before the stone himself now that it stood, answered only that he had sworn on it once at his own founding and saw no cause to swear on it twice in one lifetime, but that his guards were welcome to pray there as often as the drowned welcomed a stranger's prayer, which was a longer answer, the keeper thought, than the question had strictly asked for, and she let it stand in the roll unaltered, since a captain's own words, once given, were no clerk's business to shorten.

The eldest keeper herself, who had asked leave to set the second stone in the first place, lived to see it stand thirty years and more, long enough to watch travellers who had never known the shrine without it take the second stone for as old as the first, and older pilgrims correct them without much patience. She said once, to a younger keeper who asked her why the guard's white quartz sat so close beside the shrine's own darker stone rather than at a more respectful distance, that a shrine which could not stand a guard's oath at its elbow had no business calling itself a shrine to the drowned, who had never in any teller's memory asked to be prayed to alone.

VII

Of the Roll Filed Without Comment

None of these keepings, taken alone, seemed to the red hall at Cathair dhearg a thing worth troubling a ruler's own attention with, and for a long while none of them troubled it much. The clerks who kept Peigi nic Tormoid's roll after her, and their own successors after them, entered each report as it came up from the coasts and the western harbours and the road-guards' ground, in the same dry hand the roll had always been kept in, without a word beside any of them to say which, if any, mattered more than the rest. A trader passing through Cathair dhearg in those years, asked by a clerk what he had seen kept on his travels that season, might name the hawk fed before its household at Seann Skell, the sting sworn on at Ros bheag, the wolf-stone prayed to at Inis thais, and the fisher-marks still taught at Inis bheag though no fisher's child who learned them any longer remembered the joke once made about them, all in the one breath, as though they were pieces of the same custom rather than four keepings that had grown up a hundred miles apart from one another without ever once being planned together.

The red hall's own roll, by the year the last of these reports was entered, ran to more chests than the room Seonag Chrom had first given the clerks could hold, and a later generation of them had long since given up trying to read every leaf of it at once. They worked instead from summaries their own predecessors had made of it, summaries of summaries by then in places, the original hands beneath them known to the clerks who copied them only by name and reputation, never by sight. What no clerk at Cathair dhearg thought to write, because it was not the kind of thing the roll had ever been kept to say, was that the Hall which had once answered a hawk-household's rite with four words and no more had found, in all the years since, no occasion to answer any other rite so simply again. Each of the coasts and the harbours and the road-guards' ground had, by slow and separate degrees, grown a keeping too much its own to be dismissed any longer in a clerk's single line, the way the first of them had once been dismissed and never troubled again.

The report on the second wolf-stone, the last of that season's news to reach Cathair dhearg, was filed in its turn behind the sting-oath and the hawk-rite and the fisher-marks, in a hand none of the four keepings would have known from any other. No ruler of the red hall that year, and no clerk who filed the report,

thought to ask what it might mean that the island now held so many ways of keeping faith with what it could not fully explain, each sworn and fed and prayed to in its own corner, none of them counted among the rest, nor asked to be.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

Of the Strike-Books

FE 2,218 – 2,391

Cha do dh'iarr an fhèith oirnn breith a thoirt. The vein never asked
us to give judgement.

— the Keeper Raonaid Dhubh, at Dùn ìseal

I

Of the Strike-Books Compared

At Cnoc bhàn, in the stag's house among the pines north of the mountain, the strike-books that a novice called Rìoghnach had begun with three words and a day, near six hundred years before, had grown by then into a store no single shelf could hold: chests of oiled hide leaves in the long room behind the grove, each leaf a season's account of one apprentice's hand, kept by masters who had themselves once been the apprentices of masters long dead, so that the room smelled, winter and summer both, of oil and old smoke and the particular dryness of hide that has been read too many times by too many lamps. No one at Cnoc bhàn any longer thought the keeping strange. It had become, in those six centuries, simply what the school did, the way a smith banks a fire or a fisher mends a net, a habit so worn into the place that a child born there took the sight of the chests for granted before it could read what was written in them.

Donnchadh mac Iain was born into that house in the Hall's twenty-third century, the second son of a cutter's widow who had brought him to the teachers herself rather than send him down to the vein at ten years old as his elder brother had gone, on the reasoning, given plainly enough to the master who took him in, that one son owed to the coal was as much as her house could spare and the other

might as well learn what use could be made of the marks. He grew up among the chests before he grew up among the seams, and by his twelfth year could find, faster than any master then living, the leaf of any apprentice whose name he was given, a skill that earned him no particular honour at Cnoc bhàn, where finding a leaf was reckoned a small thing beside cutting a fair day's coal, but that stayed with him after the honour of cutting had long ceased to interest him.

He came to his own reading of the chests in his thirtieth year, in the dead of a winter when the vein ran thin and the school's own cutting fell behind its measure, so that the masters set him, for want of better work to give an idle hand, to going through the older leaves and striking out any apprentice long since dead whose account no longer served any purpose but to take up room. It was a task given him as a punishment more than a trust, Donnchadh said himself, once he was old, to more than one of his own pupils, and he did it at first the way a man does a punishment, without much thought beyond finishing it; but somewhere in the second month of that winter, with the strike-books stacked higher than his own head on the table before him and the lamp burned low at his elbow more nights than he afterward cared to count, he began setting a private tally of his own beside the school's: a count, leaf by leaf, of when in a cutter's years the coal had come brightest from the vein.

The answer, when he had it, was plainer than he had looked for. It made no difference whose house a cutter had been born to, the son of a master's line or a cutter with no line worth naming; every hand, without exception among the hundred and more he had gone through, cut its brightest and truest coal well on in its own years at the seam, seldom or never in its first, the vein answering, leaf after leaf, to years spent at it however little blood had been carried to it. Some nights the tally would not come out even, a leaf or two running against the grain of all the rest, and he set those aside in their own small stack rather than force them, on the reasoning, which he kept to all his life afterward, that a count a man has to bend to make it agree with him is no count at all. He brought the whole of it before the elders of the house on the night nearest midwinter, the whole school gathered as it gathered every year for the turning, and read it out plainly, leaf and year and hand, until the room had gone quiet enough that the lamp's own guttering was the loudest thing in it, and a cutter near the door, a young woman with no schooling in the chests at all, said afterward that she had understood, for the first time in her life, why the teachers made so much of a thing so small as a mark on hide.

The elders did not deny his count. They answered him instead, through the eldest of them, a teacher named Aonghas Cam who had held the chests longer than Donnchadh had been alive, that the vein answered what a cutter was born with, and that the years only showed what had been there from the first, the way a seed shows, in its ripening, no more than what it was planted as. "A seed planted poor does not ripen rich," Aonghas Cam said, "whatever the season does for it." It was an old answer, older than Cnoc bhàn's own strike-books, and Donnchadh had heard it given to lesser questions than his own more times than he could count; but he asked, that night, the one thing no apprentice before him had thought, or dared, to ask back: if the coal answered only to blood and the years showed nothing new, why did every hand in the chests, without one single exception among a hundred and more, show more with every year that passed than it had shown the year before. Aonghas Cam was quiet a while at that, turning it over, and said at last that a seed might ripen slowly and still be no richer a seed for the slowness, which struck more than one in the room as an answer to a question Donnchadh had not asked; and the school let the matter close there for that winter, as the school had let harder matters close before it on nights when no one present had the heart to press further.

II

Of the Twenty-Two Hearers

Donnchadh did not let it close in his own mind, and for ten years he kept his count, adding to it every leaf that came into the chests in that decade and reading his tally aloud at every midwinter gathering, until the masters of Cnoc bhàn came to expect it of him the way they expected the turning of the year, some listening each time with more patience than the last and some with less. He gathered, over those years, a following among the younger teachers and the older apprentices that the house never troubled to give a name to until the followers had a name of their own choosing: those who heard Donnchadh out to the end of his tally before they answered him, as against those who answered before he had finished, and by the eighth year of it the two groups sat, at the midwinter gathering, on opposite sides of the same long room without any master having told them to.

What broke the house at last was smaller than the tally. In the tenth winter of his counting Donnchadh brought before the whole school not his count alone, which by then most of the house had heard often enough to recite along with him, but a plain question set beside it: if the vein answered practice and not blood, as his own hundred leaves and more showed it did, why did the house still write a cutter's parentage at the head of every leaf, before a single stroke of the cutter's own hand was set down. Aonghas Cam, older now and greyer, gave the same answer he had given ten years before, that the vein answered what a cutter was born with and the years only showed it; and Donnchadh, who had by then heard the answer so many times he could have spoken it himself in the old teacher's own voice, said only that a school which wrote a cutter's blood before it wrote a single stroke of the cutter's work had already answered its own question before the question was asked, and that he, for his own part, would keep no more books that way.

He did not leave that night, nor that winter. It took him the better part of a year to gather what he meant to take, twenty-two of the house's own hearers, apprentices and younger teachers both, who had sat on his side of the long room long enough that the choice, when it came, cost most of them less than it might have cost a stranger to the quarrel. Not all who had once sat on his side came with him in the end; three stayed at Cnoc bhàn on the plain grounds, given to Donnchadh himself without much softening, that a house was still a house whatever it wrote at the head of a leaf, and that they had no wish to spend the rest of their own years proving a point at the cost of the roof they had grown up under. Donnchadh took the refusal, by his own later word, harder than he let any of the twenty-two see at the time. They left Cnoc bhàn on 30 am Faoilleach, FE 2,300, ten years to the season after Donnchadh's own question had first split the room, carrying between them copies of the strike-books they judged their own, made in their own hands over that last year from the chests that still stood, as they always had, in the long room behind the grove. The elders who watched them go called it theft, and said so plainly to the twenty-two as they loaded what they carried onto two ox-sledges borrowed from a carrier of the river for the day; Donnchadh, standing at the second sledge with the last of the leaves in his own arms, answered only that a copy taken from a book left whole behind it was no theft that any court on the island would know how to try, whatever a grieved house chose to call it, and that the leaves themselves, every one, still stood where they had always stood, for any hand at Cnoc bhàn that cared to read them.

They walked the half-day south and east to Muileann chaol, a mill-town on the same river the school at Cnoc bhàn stood beside, further down where the water ran slower and the banks stood wide enough for a settlement to spread without crowding the mill it was named for. Donnchadh had chosen the place himself, in the year of the gathering, for no reason he ever gave the twenty-two beyond that it lay far enough from Cnoc bhàn that the two houses would not trip over each other's grounds within a single season, and near enough that a letter could still cross between them inside a day. He was forty years old the day the sledges came into Muileann chaol's own square, grey already at the temple though no greyer than his father had been at the same age, and it was there, in a mill-wright's storehouse the town's own reeve let them at a rent none of the twenty-two could then have paid in silver and did pay, that first winter, in mended roofs and re-hung doors for half the town, that the second school of the stag began.

The storehouse itself had stood empty three years before Donnchadh's people came to it, a long low building of river stone the miller's own grandfather had raised for grain and never filled past its first floor, and the twenty-two spent that first autumn clearing out the old sacking and the damp before a single leaf of the strike-books was so much as unwrapped from the oiled hide it had travelled south in. One of the younger among them, a girl not yet twenty who had left a mother and two brothers still at Cnoc bhàn and never went back to see them, said afterward that she remembered the storehouse's own smell before she remembered anything Donnchadh ever taught her in it, mildew and river damp giving way, over that first winter's work, to the oil and old smoke the chests themselves would come, in their turn, to fill the place with. The town took to calling them, in that first season and for some years after, the river-house teachers, a name none of the twenty-two much minded, having no other name yet of their own choosing to set against it.

III

Of the School Without Parentage

The rule Donnchadh set for the new school's own strike-books, once the storehouse had a proper chest to hold them and a proper roof to keep the damp from the leaves, was the one his ten years of asking had led him to and Cnoc bhàn had never once been willing to grant him: that a cutter's parent-

age should not be written in the book at all, not the father's name nor the mother's, not the house nor the line, only the cutter's own name, the day, and the stroke. An apprentice's leaf at Muileann chaol carried, from its very first line, nothing that a stranger reading it could use to say whose child had cut it, and more than one of the twenty-two, in those first years, found the omission harder to keep to than they had expected, a hand's habit of thirty years being slower to unlearn than a rule was to set down. One of the elder teachers among them, who had kept the Cnoc bhàn chests longer than any of the other twenty-two, was caught out at it three winters running, writing a father's name from long habit and scraping it out again before the ink had dried; she said of herself, to any apprentice who asked, that she had unlearned worse habits in her time and expected the fourth winter to serve where the first three had not, which it did. Donnchadh himself kept to the rule without exception, in his own leaves and in every leaf he checked over another's shoulder, and by the fourth or fifth year of the school's own keeping the omission had stopped feeling, even to the oldest of the twenty-two, like an omission at all.

Word of the new house reached Cnoc bhàn within the season, as word of anything done on that river reached the other bank soon enough, and for some years the two schools kept apart entirely, each teaching its own apprentices from its own chests and answering questions about the other, when a trader or a carrier asked, with no more than a dry word and a shrug. It was the school at Muileann chaol that broke the silence first, in FE 2,330, when Donnchadh, seventy years old by then and less able to travel even that short road himself than he once had been, sent a letter north by a carrier bound that way regardless, addressed to no one master of Cnoc bhàn by name but to the house at large, asking only whether the elder school's own count, kept now for near seven centuries, showed the same rise in a cutter's years that his own hundred leaves had shown thirty years before, or whether the years at Cnoc bhàn told some other tale entirely.

The answer came back within the month, in the hand of a teacher none at Muileann chaol had heard of before that winter, and said, in fewer words than Donnchadh's own letter had asked its question in, that the count was the same at Cnoc bhàn as he said it was at Muileann chaol, and had been the same for as long as any leaf in either house's chests could show it, and that this changed nothing whatever in what the elder school believed the coal answered to. Donnchadh read the letter twice at his own table, by his own account given to a pupil who asked him of it years later, and laughed once, without much humour in it, at a house

that could grant him every fact he had spent forty years gathering and refuse him, in the same breath, the single conclusion he had built the facts to carry. He wrote back once more, a shorter letter than his first, saying only that the two houses, having agreed at last on what the vein showed, need not agree on what it meant to go on writing to each other about it; and it was that second letter, the reeve of Muileann chaol's own clerk noted years afterward in a private hand at the foot of a copy he kept for himself, that began the correspondence the two schools would keep for the rest of the age, neither house ever again letting a full season pass without some word crossing the river between them, whether the word carried agreement or its plain refusal.

Donnchadh mac Iain did not live to see the correspondence outlast its own quarrel. He died at Muileann chaol in his eightieth year, in the same storehouse-turned-schoolhouse the twenty-two had first taken shelter in forty years before, having taught, by the school's own later reckoning, some six generations of apprentices whose leaves, true to his own rule to the last, carried no name of father or mother anywhere upon them. He was buried, at his own asking given some years before his death to the pupils who would carry it out, not under any stone cut with his own house's mark, which by then none at Muileann chaol troubled to keep any longer, but under a plain leaf of oiled hide set in the ground above him and left to weather away in its own time, a grave-marker that told, within a season of rain, nothing of who lay beneath it but the one word he had asked cut upon it before it went into the ground: *scriòbhaiche*, one who writes.

IV

Of the Vein That Asked No Judgement

In the same year that Donnchadh mac Iain died at Muileann chaol, a girl was born at Dùn ìseal, in the household of a clerk of the Hall's own roll, and given the name Raonaid Dhubh for the black hair she kept, unusually, from her first day, when most children of that household had been born fair. She grew up nearer the mountain's own vein than either school on the river had ever stood, in the long galleries the strike-books of the elder generation had first been born to keep account of, and came to the Hall's own service in her twentieth year as a clerk of the Keeper's own chest, the roll the Hall had kept in its own hand since

the Keepers first wrote it down, which had passed, in the generations since, through more hands than any single leaf of it now bore a name for.

Her rise in that service came on a plainer reason than her own house cared to admit, an elder cousin's death leaving the Keeper's own stool empty at a season when no one else in the room wanted the sitting of it, much as the red hall's own clerk's stool had once been given to Peigi nic Tormoid for the same reason four centuries before her; and when the Keeper she served died, the nine hearths and the Four Houses gave the flame into Raonaid Dhubh's own hands, at six-and-twenty years old, the youngest to hold it in three generations. Word of the giving reached the granary households before the ink of the roll's own entry had dried, one reeve remarking to another, as the story was told afterward, that a Keeper young enough to be his own daughter would want watching the first year or two, a remark the reeve himself was said to have taken back within the season.

Raonaid Dhubh had known of the two schools' quarrel long before she came to the cup, as any clerk at Dùn ìseal knew of it, the letters between Cnoc bhàn and Muileann chaol having by then grown into a small archive of their own that more than one idle clerk had read through for want of livelier business on a slow afternoon. It came, by her own later account, as no great surprise to her when both houses, within her first year in office, sent word asking the same thing of the new Keeper that they had once asked, without much hope of an answer, of every Keeper before her: that the Hall say, once and plainly, which school's reading of the vein was the truer one, so that a matter forty years unsettled might at last be settled by a voice neither house could answer back to.

She heard them both at Dùn ìseal, in the same hall her own predecessors had heard lesser disputes in for longer than the mountain's own chests could number, a delegation from each school standing on either side of the same floor as the two halves of Cnoc bhàn's old long room had once sat on either side of a single table. The elder school's own delegation spoke first, an old teacher naming leaf after leaf of near seven hundred years to show how long the house's own reading had stood unshaken; the younger school answered with Donnchadh's own tally, carried north in a hand not his own, since none of the twenty-two who had first walked it south still lived to carry it themselves. Raonaid Dhubh let each speak its full case before she answered either, asking no question of her own beyond a plain point of date now and again, which one of the clerks with her noted afterward she had asked chiefly, he thought, to be certain both delegations knew she had listened to every word.

What she said, when both had finished, was fewer words than either delegation had spent making its case, and the Hall's own roll set it down that same evening in the plain hand of the clerk who had once been, before her own rise, no more than one voice among many reading old letters for want of livelier business: that the vein had never asked the Hall to give judgement on what a cutter was born with, and she saw no cause to give one now that it had not asked for, either school being free to keep its books as it judged best so long as neither book claimed for itself an authority the mountain had never granted to any book at all.

It was, the roll's own later summary noted, the plainest refusal any Keeper of that century had given, and for that reason, more than any ruling could have been, the one most often cited afterward by clerks weary of a dispute they had no wish to settle themselves: a Keeper's own words, once given, standing thereafter as a kind of ruling in everything but the name, though Raonaid Dhubh, asked years later by a younger clerk whether she had meant her answer to stand as one, said only that she had meant it as what it said and nothing further, and that a clerk who read more into four sentences than the four sentences carried was doing the roll no favour by it.

V

Of Cnoc ghorm's Stone and the Diggers' Road

The two schools kept their letters after that hearing as they had kept them before it, neither claiming the Keeper's refusal for its own side though each, in its own private correspondence with its own house, read the silence somewhat to its own advantage; and it was scholars of the stag from Muileann chaol, ten years on from the hearing, who made the journey west to Cnoc ghorm in the autumn of FE 2,376 to look at a standing stone the town had kept at its own centre longer than any teller there could say, cut in a hand no school on the river, elder or younger, could make out a single letter of. The scholars stood before it the better part of a day, turning its worn face to the low autumn light from every angle a careful reading asks, tracing a finger along grooves that might have been letters once and might, as one of the younger scholars said, be nothing more than what any stone standing that long in that weather comes to wear on its own account. They left it, by evening, no nearer an answer than they had come with.

It was the people of Cnoc ghorm themselves, who read no more of the stone's own cutting than the scholars had, who gave the visitors what the stone would not give up on its own: that the stone said, as it had always been told in that town from mother to child longer than any single house there could trace its own line back, *cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann*, we did not come; we were here. The scholars wrote the saying down exactly as the town gave it to them, together with the plain fact that neither they nor any hand before them had read the stone itself to confirm it, and left the matter there, in a hand as careful of what it did not know as of what it did; and no scholar of either school, nor any teller after them, ever explained the stone or the saying further, the one being, as the elder among the visiting party put it to the younger on the road home, no poorer a thing for having no explanation than a great many older things on the island that had gone unexplained a good deal longer.

Ten years after that again, in the summer of FE 2,386, a company of men from Baile ghorm to the south, hearing a tale grown old in their own district that the fallen walls of Làrach an Dùin¹ held riches enough to buy a poor man's house twice over, went up under cover of a single night and broke into the ruin's lower ground with picks and torches. The oldest of them, a mason's son named for no history now troubles to keep, had heard the tale from his own grandfather, who had heard it in turn from a grandfather of his own, so that none of the company digging that night could have said with any certainty how old the promise of riches was, only that it had never once, in all the tellings, been said to be false. They found, when the dawn came up on their digging, nothing beneath the fallen stone but ash, cold and undisturbed, that no fire any of them could name had left there.

The Keeper, word of the digging having reached Dùn ìseal within the fortnight, had the diggers brought before her and sentenced them as though they had broken the Law, though no law then written covered a ruin no living hand had built or owned; and it was that sentence, given for a wrong the roll admitted no statute named, that stood from that summer on as the rule for every old place the island held, that a thing standing from before any house now living could claim it was a thing no living hand had leave to break into, riches or no riches beneath it.

The families of the diggers did their penance, as the Keeper set it, by keeping in repair, at their own house's cost and their own house's labour, the road that ran

1. the fortress ruin

from Baile ghorm south to the tomb-ground at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach², a stretch of track that had gone to mud and broken stone in more winters than any reeve had troubled to count before that summer; and they kept it, the families and their children after them, long past the years any sentence could properly have bound them to, until the road, within a generation, had gone by no other name in all the southern hills but the one the penance had given it, the diggers' road, a name that told, to anyone who asked why an ordinary stretch of track between an ordinary town and an ordinary tomb-ground should carry so plain a title, the whole of the story in the two words alone.

By that same year the letters between Cnoc bhàn and Muileann chaol had crossed the river between them for near sixty years without a season's gap, two chests of correspondence standing now in each house beside the chests of strike-books that had begun the whole quarrel, neither school any nearer agreeing with the other on what the vein truly answered to than Donnchadh mac Iain and Aonghas Cam had been on the night the question was first asked aloud, and neither house, for all that, willing to let a single season pass without writing to say so.

2. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

Of the Shared Meal

FE 2,392 – 2,474

Chan eil aran aig aon taigh a dh' easbhaidh aig taigh eile. No house
lacks bread while another has it.

— still said at Àth dhìreach, of the extra bowl set out at the turn of
the year

I

Of the Carriers' Road

The coal road out of Muileann chiar ran high before it ran anywhere else, up out of the galleries by a track no cart could keep to, so that everything the mountain sent down to the lowlands and everything the lowlands sent up in trade went on a back or a pony's load, carried by families who had carried for their fathers and would carry for their sons, and who owned, most of them, nothing else worth the naming. Calum Ruadh of Àth dhìreach was such a man, broad through the shoulder from thirty years of it, and in a hard year in the middle of Lachlann Bàn's reign, before any granary law was thought of, he carried down more coal than his own household ate grain in trade for, a plain enough arithmetic that needed no clerk to read it. He was not the only one. Àth dhìreach that year, and Muileann gheal beside it, and the smaller houses of Doire uaine strung along the same track, all carried more than they were given back, because the lowland households they traded with had, in a poor season of their own, less to spare than the mountain had coal to sell, and no custom on the island yet bound one district to feed another when the trade between them ran short.

The small halting-house below the pass, where every carrier of that road broke his journey whether the day was fair or foul, kept in those years a rough tally of loads carried and grain owed, scratched on a board by the fire, and it was there, as Calum Ruadh was fond of saying, that a man first saw the whole shape of the trouble rather than only his own household's corner of it: mark after mark for coal going down and next to nothing coming up, in every hand that had cut a line on it that winter. The keeper of the house, an old woman named Mòr who asked no man his business before she fed him, told the carriers who stopped there that she had seen three such winters in her own life and buried a husband in the second of them, of a chest that a thinly fed winter had never let mend; she said it plainly, over the fire, to men too tired to answer her, and let the silence after do the rest of the telling.

Nothing came of that year worse than short commons and a hard winter got through on less than anyone would have chosen, and no teller troubled to set it down at the time, there being nothing in an ordinary hungry season that the island's rolls thought worth a line. But Calum Ruadh remembered it all his life, and told it after to his son, when the boy was old enough to understand why his father counted a full granary the way another man might count silver: that a mountain which lived by carrying could carry its own households into want as easily as any other house, and that no strength of back had ever yet fed a family through a winter when there was nothing at the bottom of the road to carry home.

It was in the years before, at Cathair dhearg on the plain below, that the red hall had passed by a road only the king-list itself troubles to keep whole, from Seonag Chrom's line to a house that traced its own line back to Goraidh Mòr, the rìgh who had first climbed to Dùn Ìseal on foot with his spear left at the last house. Of the years between, the island's own rolls say little, and this telling has no better to add to them; but the line held, as lines on Dia-thìr mostly did, quietly, one reeve's book handed to the next, until a young man of six-and-twenty took the crown in his own right and gave his name, before his reign was very old, to a law that outlasted every other thing he did.

Lachlann Bàn came to the red hall in his twenty-sixth year, and the household that raised him said of him afterward, when he was long past caring what was said, that he had been from a boy the kind who counted a room before he sat down in it: how many benches, how many at each bench, how much bread would need to be cut before the meal was called. It was not a gift that made him quick company, and it made him none at all with the reeves who had grown used to a looser hand at the granary door, but it served him, once he held the hall himself, in the one matter he is chiefly remembered for.

He found, in his first years, a hall whose granaries filled and emptied by no rule but the harvest and the whim of whichever steward kept the key that season, so that one province seat might sit on grain enough for three winters while another, a hard week's carry away, went short in the same year for no reason but that its own harvest had failed and nobody's business but its own to mend it. Lachlann Bàn thought this a poor way to keep a household, whether the household was his own kitchen or the whole island, and he set about building a granary in every province seat that would agree to keep one, of stone where stone could be had and of timber banked with turf where it could not, each one built to the same plan so that a steward moved from one to another would know, on the first morning, where the grain lay and how it was kept.

Cnoc mhòr, close under Cathair mhòr on the plain, built the first of them before any other seat on the island, and sent word of it to Cathair dhearg within the same season the roof went on, its reeve plainly hoping to be first noticed as well as first built. Lachlann Bàn sent back a silver ring for the reeve's own hand, a small enough thing beside the cost of the granary, but it did what he meant it to do, for within two years every province seat on the plain had a granary of its own or was building one, none of them wishing to be named last where Cnoc mhòr had been named first.

III

Of the Law of the Common Granary

A granary built and never filled is a shed, and Lachlann Bàn knew it, so that the building was only the half of what he meant to do. He went himself to Dùn ìseal, in the fourth year of his reign, to put the other half to the Keeper who then held the cup, Raonaid Dhubh, a woman of the north country who

had come to the flame at six-and-twenty herself and held it, by the time Lachlann Bàn climbed the last path to her door, for the better part of forty years.

What he asked her for was not new. Every household on the island already kept, as an unwritten custom older than any king-list, the habit of giving a neighbour grain in a hard year on the understanding that the neighbour would do the same when the turn came round; it was a kindness owed and repaid the way a fire was banked and relit, without anyone troubling to write down the terms of it. Lachlann Bàn wanted only to set that same custom under the granaries he had built, so that it ran district to district, at the pace of a full granary and an empty one, rather than house to house at the slower pace of one neighbour's memory: a household with grain above its winter's need would give the surplus to its district's common granary before the storm season closed the roads, and the granary would feed, in turn, any household of the district that ran short, without asking first whether the shortfall was the household's own fault or the year's.

Raonaid Dhubh heard him out at her own hearth, and it is told that she asked him only one question in return, whether he meant the law for his own reign or for every reign after his: and when he answered that a law worth the writing was worth writing for longer than one life, she set the cup down between them and said the custom was old enough already, and needed only a king willing to be bound by it as much as any carrier, before she would put her own hand to it. She asked him further, being a woman who had heard kings promise things before, whether he meant his own hall's own granary bound by the same terms as any household's, or held apart as a king's granary is so often held apart; and when he answered that the red hall's surplus would go in on the same terms and be drawn on the same terms, no household's need weighed heavier for being poorer than the crown's, she told him that was the answer she had been waiting to hear rather than the one she had asked for, and put her hand to the writing.

Lachlann Bàn swore, before her and before the flame, that his own hall's surplus would go into the granary at Cathair dhearg on the same terms as any household's, and the successors of Peigi nic Tormoid wrote the law into the rolls in full that same year, the first ever made by rìgh and Keeper together rather than by the hall alone.

Under the new law the granaries went up faster than before, and none faster than in the mountain districts round Muileann chiar, where the households lived wholly by cutting and carrying and grew almost nothing of their own, so that a common granary there was less a convenience than the difference, in a bad year,

between a hard winter and a starved one. The lowland districts that were asked to fill those granaries grumbled at it more than once, being asked, as they saw it, to feed households that grew no grain of their own to put in return, and more than one reeve of the plain wrote to Cathair dhearg to say so plainly. Lachlann Bàn's own answer to one such letter is kept in the rolls yet: that a household which carried the plain's coal down every winter of its life had already paid, in the coin of its own back, for whatever grain the plain sent up in return, and he would hear no more of the matter unless the letter's writer wished to carry a season's coal himself before he judged what it was worth.

At Cathair mhòr, whose fishing towns grew no grain either, a granary was raised within the old town wall, the first anywhere to stand behind one, and the southern strands that fed it sent dried fish rather than barley for their own share, packed in baskets the same way the toll fish had once been packed for the Hall at Dùn ìseal, so that in a hard winter a mountain household might find itself, without knowing it, eating the same salt herring a fisher's wife had gutted a season before on a strand two days' walk from the nearest coal seam.

IV

Of the Eastern Raiders and the Childless Queen

Not every trouble of those years bent to a granary's cure. Out beyond the eastern strands, where the fishing boats of Seann Tarr worked the shallows, outlaws in low black boats had begun raiding from the offshore islets, taking nets and dried fish from any strand too small to keep a watch, and running before any boat large enough to give chase could be launched after them. Sliochd Raghnaill¹, whose own house had held the boats of that coast since the reign of Eilidh nic Ìomhair, armed three of its own craft at Seann Tarr in answer, and caught the raiders at their own anchorage one grey morning with the tide against them, burning two of the low boats where they lay and losing, in the burning, more of the raiders' plunder than they recovered whole. The rest of the raiders' boats slipped the harbour mouth before the fire had well caught, and were not seen again on that stretch of coast for the length of the telling, though the strands kept a closer watch after, and Seann Tarr's own boys grew up knowing the

1. the house of Raghnaill

shapes of the low black hulls the way other boys knew the shapes of gulls. The captain who led that morning's chase, a grandson of the house's own line named Ruairidh mac Nèill, was asked afterward by a trader why he had not pressed on and taken the rest of the raiders while the tide still ran against them; he answered only that a boat burned at its own anchorage was a lesson the strand's own watch would remember longer than a raider hanged at Seann Tarr, and that he had come out that morning to end a season's raiding, not to fill a gallows he had no order to fill.

Lachlann Bàn's own household, meanwhile, grew by one child only, a daughter, Oighrig nic Lachlainn, born in the four-and-thirtieth year of his reign and raised, from what the rolls of her own household say of her upbringing, with more of her father's habit of counting a room than any softness to balance it. She married, in her turn, a lord of no great house who died young of a fever some years before her father, and she bore him no children before his death nor after it, a plain fact that the hall's own clerks noted without comment at the time and that the island's greater houses, who noted everything touching a childless heir, did not let pass so quietly.

In the fourteenth year of Lachlann Bàn's reign, Raonaid Dhubh, who had kept the flame at Dùn ìseal since before he was crowned, died at last in her own eightieth year, having seen the law she had sworn to stand unbroken through its first years. The Keeper who followed her is named in the Hall's own rolls, but nowhere in the mountain's telling of what came after, the mountain households having troubled themselves, in the years that mattered most to them, far less with who held the cup at Dùn ìseal than with who kept the granary key at Muileann gheal.

Lachlann Bàn held the red hall five-and-fifty years from his crowning, longer than most of the reigns before or after his, and died in his own bed at one-and-eighty, mourned, the rolls say, chiefly by the reeves whose granaries he had built and by the carriers of the mountain roads, who had never once, in all his reign, gone the whole distance of a winter without knowing where the next grain was coming from. Oighrig nic Lachlainn took the hall in her own one-and-twentieth year, the same year her father was laid among the house of Ìomhar at Dùn dhearg, and it was remarked at the time, by more than one house with an eye already on the succession after hers, that a queen with no child of her own body was a queen whose reign would be watched more closely at its end than at its beginning. The houses did not press the matter while she was young and the hall still full of her

father's own men, but they began, before her reign was very old, the slow business of counting what each of them might claim should she die without an heir, a counting that went on quietly under the ordinary business of the hall for the whole of her reign and longer. Sliochd Ìomhair² counted its claim by blood, being of the same house that had held Dùn dhearg since Ìomhar Dearg's own day; Sliochd Thormoid³ counted its claim by the clerks who had kept the hall's own rolls since Tormod Scriobhaiche first set a ruler's name on oiled hide; Sliochd Raghnaill counted its claim by the boats it had armed at Seann Tarr and every strand its own captains had kept safe since; and Sliochd Mhuirich⁴, which held the Keeper's own office and had held it since the Binding, counted nothing at all, being of the one house on the island that had never once, in all the age, put its hand to the cup for itself.

None of the four houses spoke its counting aloud in Oighrig's own hearing, and she gave no sign, in all the years of her reign, that she had heard of it; but a clerk of that room, copying a routine grant of land some years into her reign, noted in the margin of his own copy, in a hand meant for no eye but his own successor's, that the hall's business went on as it always had, and that a hall which goes on as it always has is a hall whose ruler has begun to be watched for the day it will not.

V

Of the Late Snow

The trouble that came was weather, and it came the way weather on Dia-thìr had always come to the mountain, without asking leave of any reign. The watchers who kept the cairns above Cnoc ghlas, whose whole office was watching the high passes for the sign that told the Hall when the galleries might safely open, looked up one spring in Oighrig's eleventh year and saw snow lying white on the passes long past the day it should have gone, and looked again a month later, and saw it lying still. The Hall, on their word, kept the galleries shut a full season longer than the custom of the mountain expected, for a cutter caught by a late fall on those slopes was a cutter not coming home, and no reeve at

2. the house of Ìomhar

3. the house of Tormod

4. the house of Muireach

Dùn ìseal was minded to weigh a season's coal against a company of cutters buried under it.

When the galleries did at last open, they opened late and closed early at the first sign of the passes closing again, and the coal that came down that whole season was not a third of what a common year gave. For the mountain households, who had nothing of their own to fall back on but the coal they carried and the grain they carried it for, the shortfall was not a hardship to be borne so much as a debt with no way to pay it: Muileann gheal, Doire uaine and Àth dhìreach alike found themselves, by the season's end, with nothing left to trade for grain at all, their own granaries already thin from the two poor years before, and by the following autumn the households of all three were eating, one careful handful at a time, the very seed they would need in spring if the next planting was to be anything at all.

Calum Ruadh, old now and past the heaviest carrying himself, sat that autumn at his own hearth with his son Iain Caol, a boy of some fifteen years grown already near his father's own height, and told him plainly, the way he had never troubled to soften a hard fact for the boy before, that this was the very want he had carried through as a young man, come round again in his own old age, and that neither of them would live to see it not come round a third time unless something below the mountain had changed since the last. Iain Caol asked him, being at the age when a boy first begins to ask his father questions the father cannot easily answer, whether the new law the old king had made would hold any better than the old custom had. Calum Ruadh told him he did not know, never having seen a law tried by a true want before, only by grumbling reeves with grain enough to spare in the end whatever they wrote to Cathair dhearg about it.

VI

Of the Granaries Opened

The law was tried, and it held. Word went down from Cnoc ghlas to Cathair dhearg of the mountain's want before the worst of the winter, and Oighrig nic Lachlainn, whose own household had never once gone hungry in her life, gave the order the same week the word reached her: the common granaries of the mountain were to be opened at Muileann gheal, the largest of the three seats, and every household of the three settlements was to draw on it as its own need

asked, without a steward standing over the door to weigh whether the need was proved.

The granary at Muileann gheal ran low again within the month, the three settlements together holding more mouths than one granary had ever been built to feed through a whole winter, and it was here that the law was tried a second time, in a matter the writing had never troubled to say in so many words. The reeves of Dùn dhearg, who had for generations kept their own granaries close and their own accounts closer, apart even from the rest of the plain, opened the old stores of the house of Ìomhar to the mountain the same week word of the shortfall reached them, and sent the grain up the carriers' roads before any order came down from Cathair dhearg telling them to. Oighrig nic Lachlainn wrote afterward, in a letter the Hall's own clerks kept, that she would have given the order herself had Dùn dhearg only waited for it; the clerk who copied her words into the roll added beneath them, in the same dry hand every clerk of that room seemed to inherit from the one before, that Dùn dhearg had not waited.

Calum Ruadh was among the carriers who went down for that grain, too old by his own reckoning for the full weight of a load but unwilling, he told his son, to sit at his own hearth while younger men carried what his own life's work had once carried in a leaner year with no granary at the bottom of the road to catch it. Iain Caol went with him, not yet old enough by the town's own reckoning to carry a man's load but old enough to carry half of one, and it was the boy, walking the last mile into Àth dhìreach behind his father with the light going and the first sacks of Dùn dhearg's grain on both their backs, who first heard what the town meant to do for the men who had brought it.

The carriers took no fee for that winter's carrying, no household on the mountain having anything to pay them with, and in the town's own account of what came after, it was this refusal, more than the grain, that Àth dhìreach chose to answer. The reeve of the settlement called the whole town together before the spring thaw, in the same hall the households used for weighing tolls and settling boundary disputes, and asked the carriers who had walked the road that winter to stand forward where all could see them; Calum Ruadh, being the eldest of them and the one whose own hunger the town remembered longest, was asked to stand first, and stood with his son beside him though the boy had carried, by his own honest word to the reeve, no more than half a man's share of it.

The reeve granted, before the whole gathering, that every carrier who had stood forward that day should have the right to rest, for the whole of his life after,

in any house of Àth dhìreach without payment asked or expected, and asked the town's own households, one by one round the hall, whether each would keep the grant as its own word rather than as any order out of Cathair dhearg. Every household answered that it would, Mòr of the halting-house loudest of any of them, being the one among the town's own who had fed the coldest of that winter's carriers longest before the grain ever came. It was kept, from that day, as a right the town's own households owed rather than any the Hall recorded, on the reasoning, as one of the elders present put it, that a kindness owed to a neighbour was the neighbour's business to keep, not the Hall's to write down. Not one soul of the three settlements is known to have died of hunger that whole winter, a fact the mountain's own tellers set beside the granting of the right whenever the tale is told, as though the one could not be properly understood without the other.

VII

Of the First Load and the Bowl Still Set

Iain Caol grew to a man's full height and strength in the years after, and it was known of him, by those who remembered his father's own carrying, that he walked the coal road with much of Calum Ruadh's own steadiness, though the two men rarely put their loads down at the same waypoint house any longer, Calum Ruadh's back having given out at last, past sixty, to more years of the road than most carriers' backs were asked to bear. Iain Caol took up his own first load as a carrier proper in his three-and-twentieth year, in the autumn of Oighrig nic Lachlainn's nineteenth year in the hall, walking the same track his father had walked before him with a company of four other young men of Àth dhìreach, none of whom had carried a working load before that season.

He was not one of the carriers the town had named in the granting after the famine winter, being too young then by the settlement's own reckoning to have carried a full share, and it was a plain fact he never once, in all his life, tried to claim otherwise. But the men the town had named grew old through the years of his own carrying, one by one, and as each of them died the town found itself, without ever quite deciding to, extending the same rest to whichever carrier of that road was oldest living at the time, on the reasoning that a custom kept for the men who had walked the famine's road was a custom that belonged, in the end, to the road and not only to the particular feet that had first walked it hungry. Iain

Caol, by the time he was old himself, had carried that road the better part of fifty years, through easy seasons and two lean ones after, and had buried, along the way, every man who had carried grain up to Muileann gheal in the year he was a boy of fifteen at his father's hearth.

In his own last years, when his legs would carry him no further than the halt-ing-house and back, Iain Caol took to telling the whole of it himself, at the turn of every year, to whatever children of the town would sit still long enough to hear an old man out: his father's own hungry youth, the late snow above Cnoc ghlas, the granaries opening at Muileann gheal, and the night the reeve had called the whole town together and asked every household, one by one, whether it would keep the grant as its own word. He never once, in the telling, put himself among the carriers the town had named that day, being as careful an old man about the plain truth of it as he had been a young one; but he set out, every year he told it, a bowl at his own hearth all the same, for whichever carrier might be on the road that night, and let the children carry that habit home with them the way he had once carried grain, without troubling to explain to them why a boy too young to have earned a right should be the one keeping it.

He died at Àth dhìreach an old man, in the ninetieth year of his own life, the last then living of any who could say he had carried on that road in the years the famine and the right to rest were both still new, and the right the town had kept for its carriers died with him, there being none left of that particular reckoning to extend it to. It is told, and the town does not trouble to soften the telling, that no carrier's back has since been asked to bear a winter's want the way that mountain once bore it, the coal roads having grown wider and the granaries fuller with every reign since Lachlann Bàn's; and so the right was never renewed for want of the hunger that had first earned it, though what remains of it is kept all the same, at the turn of every year, in the one bowl still set out at Àth dhìreach's own hearths for whatever carrier is on the road that night, whether he has any claim to it by the old reckoning or none at all.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

OF the Shut Hall and the Choosinſ of Gilleasbuig

FE 2,475 – 2,558

Cha do rugadh rìgh; chaidh e a shuidhe air an stòl a bh' ann. No king
was born; he came and sat on the stool that was there.

— a saying of the clerks of Seann Dunn, kept in no other house

I

Of the Boy at the Rolls

At Seann Dunn the hall and the shrine stood on the near bank of the Abhainn chaol, and the mountain stood across the water, and between them the ford ran shallow enough in summer that a boy of five could wade it holding his father's hand. Gilleasbuig's father was Tormod Beag, a copying clerk of Sliochd Thormoid¹, and his trade was the same trade Peigi nic Tormoid's line had kept since her own hand was first proved worth telling from another's: he sat at a bench under the shrine's north window with a knife and a scraped hide and put down, in the small square hand the house had taught for six generations, whatever the red hall sent him to copy. Gilleasbuig grew up under that bench before he grew up beside it. He knew the smell of the scraping-knife's grease before he knew the sound of his own name in any mouth but his mother's, and by the time he was old enough to be sent for water he could tell, without be-

1. the house of Tormod

ing told, which of his father's rolls was the king-list and which was only a province's tithe.

He asked once, small enough still to be answered rather than sent off, why the king-list needed six copies where the tithe needed one. His father said the tithe would be true for a year and then thrown out, and a king-list had to be true for longer than any man who wrote it, so it went into six hands at once, that if fire took one house or flood another, the rest would still agree. Gilleasbuig turned that over for the length of a whole winter and came back to it in the spring with a second question, whether a king-list could be wrong if all six copies agreed and were wrong the same way. His father put down the knife at that one and looked at him a while before he answered, and what he answered the boy did not think worth remembering until he was an old man himself and had cause to remember it very well.

The temple across the river was Sliochd Thormoid's own, raised in Eilidh nic Ìomhair's day when the Four Houses were first bound, and its lamp burned the Small-Burning Law's measure like every other lamp on the island, or was supposed to; the other three houses said, in the flat voice houses use for an old grievance they no longer trouble to prove, that Seann Dunn's lamp burned fuller than its neighbours'. Gilleasbuig heard that said at his own hearth more than once before he was ten, always by a stranger and always denied at once by whoever in his own house was nearest, and he learned early that a thing repeated and denied in the same breath, in every house on the island, was probably not worth losing sleep over either way.

He learned his letters at that bench, and then the shapes of the Roinn's old shares, and then, because his father's hand was wanted at Cathair dhearg two summers out of three, the road between Seann Dunn and the red hall, first riding behind Tormod Beag and later, at fourteen, riding alone with the rolls in a satchel across his back and a hearth-sign token that let him sleep free at any waypoint house on the way. The road ran a day and a half in fair weather, down through the mountain districts and onto the lowland plain, and he came to know every waypoint keeper on it by name before he knew half the great families whose shares those waypoints stood in, which his father said was the proper order for a clerk to know a road in, whatever order a lord might prefer.

He was set once, at eleven, to copy out a short roll of a province's tithe under his father's eye, and made in it a single error, a stroke too many in a number that turned a modest year into a plentiful one, and did not himself catch it. His father

caught it before it left the bench, scraped the hide clean to the one line, and made him write the whole roll again from the beginning rather than mend the single stroke, though the mending would have taken a tenth of the time. Gilleasbuig asked, aggrieved as a boy of eleven is entitled to be, why the whole roll needed doing over for one wrong stroke. His father told him that a roll with one mended stroke in it taught a boy that a mistake could be quietly put right, and a roll done over from the beginning taught him it could not, and that of the two lessons only one was worth having in a clerk who might one day be trusted with a roll no one stood over to check. Gilleasbuig did the roll over, and never again, by his own later account, let a wrong stroke stand unscraped in anything that left his own bench.

He was, by every account that troubles to say anything of him at all before his fortieth year, an unremarkable clerk's son doing an unremarkable clerk's work, and there is no sign that he thought of himself as anything else, or that anyone else thought of him as anything else, until the year the line of Goraidh Mòr ran out.

II

Of the Failing of a Line

The failing had been long in coming and was no secret to anyone who read the rolls Gilleasbuig's own house kept. Lachlann Bàn had built his granaries and set his shared-meal law with the Keeper Raonaid Dhubh, and had a daughter, Oighrig nic Lachlainn, who took the red hall at one-and-twenty and held it the better part of fifty years without ever bearing a child of her own body. The houses had begun their counting early, before her reign was even half spent; Gilleasbuig heard it done at his own father's bench, in the careful unhurried voices men use when they are reckoning something they hope not to need. Sliochd Ìomhair¹ reckoned its blood, which ran thin by then but ran; Sliochd Thormoid² reckoned the clerks who had kept every roll the red hall owned since Tormod Scriobhaiche's own day; Sliochd Raghnaill³ reckoned its boats and its silver and the seat at Seann Tarr the Small-Burning Law had first named. Only

1. the house of Ìomhar

2. the house of Tormod

3. the house of Raghnaill

Sliochd Mhuirich⁴, which held the Keeper's own office and answered to no share at all, took no part in the reckoning, and said, when asked, that the vein had not asked it to give judgement on the matter.

Oighrig herself, whom Gilleasbuig saw only once in his life, on a summer he came to Cathair dhearg at sixteen with his father's rolls, was by then a spare grey woman who signed what was put before her and asked few questions of it; the famine that was never allowed to become a famine had happened under her reign and under her name, though it was Lachlann Bàn's law and the reeves of Dùn dhearg's own quick hands that had turned it back, and she is remembered, where she is remembered at all, for having been present at a good thing rather than for having done it. She asked him, that one summer, whose son he was, and when he told her, said only that his father's hand was known to her and left it there; it was the whole of the speech any ruler of the island ever made to him before he came to sit where she had sat, and he remembered it, he said later, chiefly for how little either of them had thought to make of it at the time.

She died at Cathair dhearg in her one-and-seventieth year, without an heir of her body and with the line of Goraidh Mòr ending in the same breath as her own life did, and the red hall was shut behind her, its doors barred and its clerks — Gilleasbuig's own house among them — set to keep it, there being no other hand to give it to.

Gilleasbuig was one-and-forty that year, a clerk of thirty years' standing and no more remarkable than he had ever been. He was at Seann Dunn when the word came up the river road, and what he remembered of the day, when he was old and told it, was the small practical scramble that followed it at his own hearth: which rolls to send down to Cathair dhearg and which to keep, and whether the shrine's own lamp should be let burn on as before or banked against a season nobody yet knew the shape of. He said the news of it, oddly, went out of his head almost at once, crowded out by the tally of rolls he had to sort before nightfall.

III

Of the Shut Hall

4. the house of Muireach

The clerks kept the shut hall the better part of two years before the Four Houses so much as agreed to sit in the same room together, and Gilleasbuig's own hand was among the hands that kept it: he rode down to Cath-air dhearg the winter after Oighrig's death and stayed the better part of a season, sealing rolls and answering, as best a clerk could answer for a hall with no one in it, the reeves who came asking whom they were to render their accounts to now. He told them, truthfully, that he did not know, and that the tallies were to be kept all the same, on the plain reasoning that whoever came to the red hall next would want them true and would not thank a clerk for having let a good year go unrecorded for want of a name to put at its head.

The queen's own chambers were shut with the rest of the hall, the fires in them let go cold, and Gilleasbuig slept that whole season in the rolls-chamber among the boxes of hide, with the other clerks of the house of Tormod turning the lock in the great door themselves each night, since no steward remained whose office it was to do it for them. He wrote to his father once that winter that a red hall with no one in it was, for all that anyone outside it could tell, exactly the same red hall it had always been, the rolls being kept, the rents being reckoned, the granaries opening and shutting to the same seasons; only the men who kept it knew how strange it felt to hand a reeve his own tally and have no name to put after the word *sworn to*. His father's answer, kept among the house's own letters, said that a clerk who found that stranger than he found the years before it, when the tallies were kept for a queen he never once saw sign her own name to them, had not yet understood what a clerk's work had always been.

The Four Houses met at last at Dùn Ìseal, in the second year of the shut hall, because no custom on the island covered a red hall with no one to fill it and the Hall's own ground was the one place none of the four could be told they had no right to stand. Sliochd Ìomhair¹ claimed by blood, thin as that blood now ran; Sliochd Thormoid² claimed through the clerks who alone among the four houses had never once let the rolls fall silent in fifty years of an ageing queen; Sliochd Raghnaill³ claimed through its boats and its silver, which by then paid for more of the island's carrying than any two of the other shares together. Sliochd Mhuirich⁴, whose own house held the Keeper's office and so stood outside every reckoning of

1. the house of Ìomhar

2. the house of Tormod

3. the house of Raghnaill

4. the house of Muireach

blood or trade, made no claim at all, and said again what it had said at Oighrig's death, that the vein had not asked it to give judgement on the matter of a stool it had never sat in and had no wish to.

How long the three houses argued, and whether they argued in good faith or only long enough to be seen to have argued, is not a thing the rolls of any of them agree on; Sliochd Ìomhair's own account, kept at Dùn dhearg, makes more of the sitting than Sliochd Raghnaill's does, and Sliochd Thormoid's account, kept by the same clerks' bench Gilleasbuig had grown up under, says least of all, which a man might read either as modesty or as the plain fact that the clerks had the least to gain from making the quarrel sound weighty. What is agreed by all three is that no blow was struck and no word was said that could not be unsaid over the same table the next morning, and that the sitting dragged three years past the meeting itself before any name was put forward that all four houses could be brought to sit still for.

Gilleasbuig himself sat through most of that sitting at the edge of the room rather than in it, called down from Cathair dhearg twice a year to lay the hall's own rolls before whichever house asked to see them, and so he heard more of the three years' arguing, from the doorway and the side bench, than any of the four houses' own principals ever troubled to say to his face. He heard Sliochd Ìomhair's eldest ask, more than once, what blood was worth if it were passed over for a boat or a bench; he heard Sliochd Raghnaill answer that the island's silver did not care whose grandfather had held a hill, only whose hand could be trusted to reckon it truly; and he heard, oftenest of all, the long patient silences of Sliochd Mhuirich's own man, who came to every sitting, said the same few words at the start of it and the end of it, and otherwise let the other three talk themselves hoarse over a stool his own house had no wish to sit in. Of himself, in all that time, nobody asked anything at all, beyond whether the year's tallies balanced, and he answered that question, each time it was put, exactly as truly as he had ever answered it for Oighrig.

IV

Of the Cup Set in His Hands

T

he name that was put forward, in the end, was Gilleasbuig's own, and by every account it was Sliochd Raghnaill¹ that first said it aloud, on the reasoning that a clerk who had kept the shut hall's rolls straight for three years without once putting his own house's claim ahead of the work had shown, whether he meant to or not, exactly the kind of hand a red hall wanted at its head. Sliochd Ìomhair², whose blood claim would have cost the other three houses more to refuse outright than any of them wished to pay, consented on one condition only, which it had been readying since the first year of the shut hall and did not trouble to soften in the asking: that whoever took the red hall, the graves at Dùn dhearg would remain the kings' own burying-place, as they had been since Ìomhar Dearg first washed his hands at the ford. Gilleasbuig, when the condition was put to him, is said to have answered that he had never in his life expected to be buried anywhere else, which was true in a plainer sense than the house that heard it understood, and the condition was sworn to on the spot.

He was summoned to Dùn ìseal in the sixth year of the shut hall, in his six-and-fortieth year, and told nothing of why beyond that his own presence was wanted before the council; he rode down from Cathair dhearg expecting, by his own account, to be asked some further question about the tallies, and packed no better cloak than he wore for any ordinary sitting. He stood before the council of the Four Houses in that same plain cloak while Sliochd Raghnaill's own elder named him, and Sliochd Ìomhair, having already had its condition of the graves sworn to beforehand, consented without argument, and Sliochd Mhuirich³'s man said the same few words he had said at every sitting for three years, which this time were enough.

The Keeper set the stone cup in his hands, filled to the fill of two palms as it had been filled for every household's dues since Fionnlagh Dall's own day, and for the first time in the whole of the age a ruler was made under the mountain rather than crowned or chosen anywhere else on the island. Gilleasbuig held the cup a long moment before he drank from it, and what struck him then, by his own later telling, was the plain foolishness of a clerk's son from Seann Dunn holding in his two hands the very measure his own father had spent a lifetime copying onto hide for other men to swear by. He asked the Keeper, before he drank, whether a clerk's hands were the right shape for it; the Keeper answered that the cup had no

1. the house of Raghnaill

2. the house of Ìomhar

3. the house of Muireach

opinion of the hands that held it, only of whether they spilled it, and Gilleasbuig did not spill it. It looked, more than one chronicler has since said dryly, very much as though the Hall had made the king, there being no blood in the choosing and no boat and no old grievance settled, only a hand the Hall had come to trust with its own rolls.

He rode to Cathair dhearg that same season to take the red hall, by the low-land road his father had ridden twice a year for thirty years, and slept his first night in it, by his own account, in the small room off the rolls-chamber where the clerks kept their own beds, because the queen's own chambers had stood empty five years and nobody had thought yet to air them.

V

Of the Line Drawn and the Temple Enlarged

his first act of any weight, the year after the cup was set in his hands, was to have the king-list copied again from its beginning, in his own house's careful square hand, with a single line drawn beneath the name of Oighrig nic Lachlainn. He drew it, or had it drawn, not to mark her death, which every copy of the list already marked well enough in its own way, but to mark the ending of a whole line of names running back to Goraidh Mòr, so that no clerk after him would waste an afternoon hunting a kinship that no longer existed. The line is in every copy of the king-list made since, and it is the first mark in the whole record that a clerk's own hand put there for a reason the clerk himself troubled to explain in the margin, which some later readers have taken as the surest sign of all that a clerk, and not a warrior or a boat-captain, had at last come to sit in the red hall.

He kept the clerks' office in his own house's hands for the whole of his reign, which cost him nothing, since no other house had ever much wanted the work of it, and he sent for his son Tormod, a boy of sixteen already taught the bench at Seann Dunn as Gilleasbuig himself had been taught it, to sit beside him at Cathair dhearg and learn the red hall's own rolls before he was taught anything else of ruling, on the same reasoning his own father had given him and never troubled to improve upon. He enlarged his house's shrine at Seann Dunn into a full temple in the one-and-twentieth year of his reign, with a court where pilgrims from as far as Cnoc bhàn and Muileann chiar could stand under a roof while they waited their

turn at the lamp, and the other three houses said, as they had always said, that its measure burned fuller than the Law allowed; a Keeper's cutter was sent every season after to try it by the same weights used everywhere else on the island, and every season the cutter found the measure kept, which satisfied nobody who had not already believed it and changed the mind of nobody who had not already doubted it, and so the saying outlived the doubt by a good many years, as sayings will.

By the plain evidence of the rolls his own house kept of him, he was neither a great king nor a poor one. He raised no new law that outlasted him and lost no old right that had not already been half lost before he came to the cup; the granaries Lachlann Bàn had built stood full or empty by the same seasons as before him, and the roads his mason predecessors had cut were mended by the same waypoint-keepers as before him. The island under his hand was, by every account, neither better nor worse governed than it had been under Oighrig's, only governed by a man who had grown up knowing exactly how the rolls that governed it were kept, which is not nothing, though it is not much to set beside the deeds of the men the earlier tellings of this age remember.

He heard, in his eighth year, the one dispute of his reign the rolls trouble to set down whole: a household of Muileann àrsaidh and a household of Ceann àrsaidh both claiming a single water-meadow their grandfathers had shared without a stone between them, each holding a notched stick that named the whole meadow theirs and neither stick agreeing with the other. Gilleasbuig sent a clerk of his own house, rather than a steward, to copy both sticks stroke for stroke before he judged anything, and found that the two tallies agreed exactly up to a season forty years back and disagreed only after it; this told him less about the meadow than about the year a notch had been cut wrong by someone long dead on one side or the other. He gave the meadow to neither household outright and to both together, with a boundary stone cut down its centre for the first time in living memory, on the plain reasoning that a stick a man could not check against another man's stick was worth exactly as much as the two men trusted each other, which by then was not much. The households of Muileann àrsaidh and Ceann àrsaidh have shared the meadow by that stone ever since, and grumbled at it about equally, which a clerk of Seann Dunn once told his own son was the surest sign a judgement had been fair.

VI

Of His Death and the Son Who Followed

He died at Cathair dhearg in his one-and-seventieth year, in the small room off the rolls-chamber he had never troubled to leave for the queen's own empty chambers, having kept, to the end, the habit of rising before his own household to check the night's tally against the day's before either was sent on to a steward. He was carried to Dùn dhearg to be buried among the house of Ìomhar, as had been sworn at his choosing, over five days on the lowland road his own father had ridden twice a year for thirty years, the bier stopping each night at a waypoint house whose keeper had known him first as a boy with a satchel of rolls and last as the man whose seal was on every tally in the house. Sliochd Ìomhair¹ kept its own oath to the letter: the grave was dug beside Ìomhar Dearg's own kin, and no voice was raised against a clerk's son lying there, the condition having been the graves' and not the blood's.

His son Tormod succeeded him at Cathair dhearg in his one-and-fortieth year without any meeting of the Four Houses at all, and none of the four asked for one; whatever quarrel over the red hall the island had once thought worth three years of sitting at Dùn ìseal for, it had by then settled itself so thoroughly into a single house's keeping that a son following a father seemed to every house the plainer course, and the plainer course, once taken, was never afterward questioned. Between that quiet handing-on and the coming of a queen from the same house long years later, the king-list at Cathair dhearg gives nine rulers their names and their years and very little else, the clerks of Gilleasbuig's own line having proved, in the reigns that followed his son's, as diligent in the keeping of the rolls as they were brief in the writing of anything beyond a harvest, a toll and the mending of a bridge. It is a sign, the tellers of Seann Dunn still say, of an island doing tolerably well; a shut hall had been filled without a blow struck over it, and a clerk's own careful hand had proved, in the end, as sound a measure of a king as blood or a boat or an old grievance nursed three centuries long.

1. the house of Ìomhar

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

Of the Bridges

the Riders and the North-West

FE 2,559 – 2,791

Chan eil clach gun neach a chuir ann i. No stone stands without a
hand that set it there.

— the fourth hearth's own saying, said over every keystone since Ros
fhionn

I

Of the Carts on the Lowland Roads

The list at Dùn ìseal keeps no ruler's name between Tormod Òg, who died in the seventieth year of his own life without ever walking the whole circuit his father had been chosen to walk, and Anna Ruadh, who came to the red hall two hundred and thirty-six years after him and walked it twice. Of the reigns that filled those years the rolls say only that the red hall passed from hand to hand at Cathair dhearg as it had passed since Gilleasbuig, without war and without a name any teller troubled to keep past its own generation; and where the red hall has so little to say, this telling turns, as it has turned before, to the roads, the bridges and the shore, whose keeping fell to no single house and so was never once let lapse for the want of one.

The lowland roads in those years carried more than they had ever carried before, for the cart had come onto them at last in numbers, where for the whole of the age before it a back or a pony's load had done most of a household's carrying between one waypoint house and the next. A cart asked more of a road than a back ever had: it asked a level bed where a foot could climb a rut without com-

plaint, and it asked, above all, a bridge wide enough to take it, where the narrow footbridges of the earlier reigns had answered a walking man and nothing wider. The bridge at Cathair dhearg, first thrown by Ailean Clachair's own fellowship in the reign before Mòrag nan Rathad and widened once already in her own time, was widened a third time in these years, its old piers kept and a new span laid across them broad enough for two carts to pass abreast without either driver giving way to the other. The hearth-sign was cut again into the new keystone, the same small mark the fourth hearth had cut into every crossing since Ros fhionn, and the masons who cut it left, beside it, the old stone that had carried the sign before, set into the parapet where any hand might touch it, rather than break it for rubble as an easier fellowship might have done.

It was in this same stretch of years that the road-guards of Dùn dhearg first took to riding the lowland roads rather than walking them, mounted on the small tough horses of the southern grass country, bred for a light rider and a long day rather than for weight or war. A guard on foot had answered a quarrel at a waypoint house only after it had cooled into a grievance nursed over a night's telling and retelling; a guard on a horse could be at the same house before the first blow had properly landed, and it changed, within a few years, the whole temper of the road-guard's own trade, from a company that judged what had happened to one that could, on a fast enough horse, sometimes stop it happening at all. The riders of that first company are the earliest whose names the road-guard's own roll troubles to keep, and for a long while after they were the only ones so kept, every rider before them having ridden nothing faster than his own two feet and so left no mark on a roll built to record a particular kind of speed.

II

Of the Mending at Ros fhionn

The flood that took the eastern approach of Ailean Clachair's own span above Ros fhionn came in a wet spring some way into this stretch of years, a season of rain on rain that swelled every river of the western shares past any bank built to hold it, and it carried off, along with a good stretch of the road on the eastern bank, three households built too near the water on the strength of a hundred quiet years. The masons of the fellowship, called down from Cathair dhearg within the same season, found the span standing where Ailean had left it,

its piers untouched by a flood that had taken lesser work on every side of it, and set about mending only the washed-out approach, laying a new causeway on stone footings deep enough, this time, that no flood within living memory of the mending was ever expected to trouble it again.

It was in clearing the old approach for the new footings that the masons came, at last, to the keystone Ailean had cut with his own hand in the hundred and sixtieth year of the age, the small mark of the fourth hearth that said, to any mason's eye that knew to look for it, that living hands and not chance had raised the stone above it. The sign was as sharp as the day it was cut, the grey stone of that quarry having proved, as Ailean himself had judged it would when he chose the face near Ros fhionn over an easier one closer to hand, harder wearing than most that went into a bridge on Dia-thìr; and the masons who found it, none of them born when Ailean cut it, left it exactly as they found it, cutting their own new work a full course below rather than disturb a sign that had already outlasted the man who set it and looked fit to outlast a good many masons after. It became, from that mending onward, a small custom among the fellowship, never written into any rule of theirs but kept all the same, that a mason sent to mend an older crossing left the old signs standing wherever the stone beneath them still stood, and cut his own work apart from them rather than over them, so that a bridge mended twice might carry, in its own stones, the mark of every hand that had answered for it.

III

Of Dùn chrom and Ceann àrsaidh

Two crossings went up in those same years that the fellowship built new rather than mended, and neither answered quite the same want as Ros fhionn's had.

The first spanned the river below Dùn chrom, joining the southern road to the western by a route that saved a full day's cart-journey over the long way round through Cathair dhearg, and the fellowship set its toll, by a custom of its own that no rule of the red hall had ever told it to keep, at half of what the road-toll asked at the capital's own crossing, the mason who led that building holding it no fair thing to charge a full toll for half the road. Cathair dhearg's own reeves complained of it loudly and at length, in letters the rolls still keep, arguing that a toll set anywhere on the island by anyone but the crown's own reckoning was a toll

that would, in time, be set anywhere by anyone, and calling the fellowship's half-measure at Dùn chrom the year the red hall's own word on tolls first went unanswered. The fellowship answered, through the mason who had set the toll, that a bridge built by its own hands on its own stone might be priced by its own reckoning until the red hall chose to build one of its own beside it, and offered, should Cathair dhearg wish it otherwise, to hand the whole crossing over to the crown's own keeping, tolls and upkeep together. No reeve of Cathair dhearg ever took up that offer, the upkeep of a bridge proving, as it generally does, a less welcome inheritance than the toll alone, and the half-toll at Dùn chrom stood unaltered for as long as the fellowship stood.

The second crossing, at the river town of Ceann àrsaidh, was the fourth stone bridge raised across the lowlands, and it was built, from the first stone laid to the last, by forty of the fisher-kin of Sliochd Raghnaill¹ rather than by cutters bred to the trade, men and women who had learned the mason's craft in a season when their own boats lay idle after the burning at Seann Tarr had thinned the raiders from that coast and left, for a while, more hands on the strand than there was fish to occupy them. The fellowship's own roll at Cathair dhearg names all forty, a courtesy it did not always trouble to extend to a crew of borrowed hands, and the reason given in the same roll is plain enough in its own way: that forty people who had learned a new trade rather than sit idle through a season deserved, whatever their birth, to be named among the masons who had spent a life at it. The bridge at Ceann àrsaidh stood a little rougher in its coursing than Ros fhionn or Dùn chrom, the fisher-kin's hands being surer, that first winter, with a net than with a chisel, but it stood, and it carried, within the year, more cart-traffic between the river towns of the eastern lowlands than any crossing before it had carried in three.

IV

Of Beathag Clachair

Among the households that settled, in these same generations, along the fellowship's own roads rather than at any single hearth, was a family of Doire mhin on the southern road, cutters of ordinary boundary-stones and

1. the house of Raghnaill

byre-lintels for three generations before a daughter of that house was born, one whose fellowship remembers her still for a single small mark on a bridge no grander than a dozen others of its own age, though every boundary-stone her grandfather ever cut has weathered past reading.

Beathag Clachair came to her family's own trade the way most of that trade's daughters and sons came to it, at an age too young to remember choosing it, her first task no harder than sweeping chips from beneath her father's chisel and her first lesson no deeper than which face of a stone would split true and which would shatter if a hand did not first read the grain of it. She was quicker at the reading than most of her father's own apprentices, a fact her father noticed early and said aloud often, in the plain way of that house; and by the time she had seen twenty summers she was cutting boundary-stones of her own, sound work that stood where it was set and troubled no household with a crooked line, though nothing in it yet asked more of her than the trade had asked of her grandfather.

The bridge that made her name was a small one, built to carry the southern road over a stream at Doire mhin that flooded each spring past any ford a cart could safely trust, no grander in its span than the footbridges of an earlier age and no harder, by the fellowship's own reckoning, than a dozen others its masons had thrown in those same years without any one of them being remembered for it after. Beathag was three-and-thirty when the fellowship set her to lead the cutting, the first time a woman of that house had been given a crossing of her own to answer for rather than a stretch of some other mason's work to finish, and she led it, by every account the fellowship kept, exactly as her father and his father before him would have led it: a sound bed, a true arch, the fourth hearth's own sign cut into the keystone where every crossing since Ros fhionn had carried it.

What she added, beside the hearth's own sign and beneath it, was her own name, cut in her own hand in letters no larger than the sign: *Beathag Clachair a chuir seo*, Beathag the mason set this. No mason of the fellowship, in all the generations since Ailean Clachair first cut the fourth hearth's mark at Ros fhionn, had ever cut a name of his own beside it, the hearth-sign having been understood, from the very first crossing, to speak for every hand that had answered to it rather than for any one hand alone; and when the fellowship's elder masons came down from Cathair dhearg, as they did each season, to look over the year's work, more than one of them stood a long while at the small bridge at Doire mhin before they said anything of it at all.

It is told that the eldest among them, a woman near seventy who had cut stone since before Beathag's own father was born, asked her plainly why she had done it, whether she held her own hand a better one than the hearth's, or thought her own work owed more remembering than the forty who had died, over the generations, cutting crossings no less sound than hers and left no name behind them. Beathag answered, by the fellowship's own telling of it, that she held her hand no better than any hearth-mark ever cut, and had cut her own name to stand beside the hearth's sign rather than above it, so that whoever stood at that stream a hundred years on and asked who had set the stone might, for once, be given an answer rather than only a sign that said hands had done it, without saying whose. The eldest mason gave no answer of her own that day; within two seasons masons of every hearth on the island had begun cutting their own names beside the fourth hearth's sign wherever a fellowship crew finished a crossing, a custom that held for as long as the fellowship held, and the island's own masons still call it, to this day, by no other name than Beathag's mark.

Beathag Clachair lived to see her own mark cut on four further crossings before her hands grew too stiff for the finer work of a keystone, and died at Doire mhin in the seventieth year of her own life, an ordinary age for a mason's death by then, no age on Dia-thir since Fearchar Òg's own generation having asked a life to run much longer; she was buried, at her own asking, at the foot of the bridge she had cut her name into rather than among the household's own dead, and the fellowship's own masons passing that road are told to have kept, for a long while after, the habit of laying a chip of good grey stone on the grave whenever their own work carried them by it.

V

Of the Far-Off House and the Fire-Water

The waypoint house on the site the carriers called, half in earnest and half in the plain joke of the road, the far-off house, having stood so long from any town that a traveller was never nearer to reaching it than halfway, was rebuilt in stone in these same years, the old timber and turf of its earlier building having at last given out under one too many storms off the western sea. It kept, in its rebuilding, the same name the carriers had always known it by, the fellowship's own masons holding that a name earned by a hundred years of true telling was

not a thing to improve upon, whatever a stone building might otherwise have suggested to a prouder hand.

Further north, at a waypoint house on the northern road, a keeper new to that house began, in the same generation, to serve a spirit distilled from barley rather than the small beer every waypoint house on the northern road had always kept, a stronger drink than any the carriers had trade with before, that warmed a man through on a cold night in a way small beer never troubled to and left him, more than once, warmer still the next morning than the night's own cold could account for. The carriers took to calling it fire-water, for the way of it going down and the way of it sitting after, and the name held faster than any other the drink was ever given. Word of it reached Dùn ìseal before two winters were out, more than one household of that road having found its own hearth's peace disturbed by a carrier who had taken more fire-water than sense the night before, and the Keeper of that generation was asked, by more than one reeve troubled at the change in her own district's roads, to rule whether the drink fell under the Small-Burning Law that governed every other burning on the island.

The ruling, when it came, was as plain as most of that Hall's rulings had always been: that a fire kept in a man's own belly, however hot it burned there, was no burning the Law had ever been written to answer for, the Small-Burning Law having concerned itself, since Fionnlagh's own day, with what a hearth or a forge sent up into the air rather than with what any household chose to swallow of its own free will, and that the Hall would rule on drink the day it began ruling on food, and not a day before. The keeper of that house took the ruling for the leave it plainly was, and the house's trade doubled within the season, carriers of the whole northern road coming to hear of a house where a cold night's journey might be answered with more than small beer and a hard bench. What quarrels the fire-water caused after, the rolls of that road are content to let the waypoint houses settle, as they had always settled a carrier's own excesses without troubling Dùn ìseal for a ruling on every one of them.

VI

Of Caol mhòr, Ceann mhòr and the Edge of Things

Of the north-west in these years the island's own rolls have little to say, and what little they keep is mostly complaint, the north-west having always

sat at the far edge of whatever reach the red hall's own writ carried, and further still from whatever reach its own attention troubled to follow. The fisher-families of Caol mhòr, on that coast, had by these generations gathered themselves under a headman of their own choosing rather than any reeve sent out from Cathair dhearg, and sent their tolls to the red hall only in the years a road-guard actually came so far to collect them, which by the fisher-families' own telling was not every year, nor even most of them. A reeve of Ros dhomhain, whose own district lay nearest the north-west of any that troubled to keep a written roll, wrote to the red hall more than once in these years to say that Caol mhòr paid what it pleased and answered to whom it pleased, and that a coast so far from the capital's own eye might as well keep its own law for all the crown's writ reached it; the red hall's own answer, where the rolls keep one at all, is generally no answer, the north-west's tolls having never yet amounted to a sum the red hall thought worth a road-guard's whole season to collect.

Ceann mhòr, further up that same coast, found in these years a trade that the rest of the island came, in time, to depend on more than it ever troubled to thank Ceann mhòr for: seal-oil, rendered from the seals of the northern rocks and carried down the western coast to Ros bheag in exchange for silver rings, burned in the beacons of every western harbour from Ros bheag to Cuan shean. The seal-oil lamps of the western harbours have burned, since, the brightest light on the whole of Dia-thir, a fact every sailor of that coast came to know before he knew much else of the trade that fed him, and Ceann mhòr grew, on the strength of a trade in nothing grander than rendered fat, into a town of some standing on a coast where standing of any kind was otherwise hard come by.

In the high country above Muileann leathan, further north again, herding families took to the summer pastures for the wool of the mountain sheep that grazed there, sheep whose fleece the weavers of Inis mhòr had long prized above any other on the island; the herders held no right to the handful that the census of hands had reckoned two generations before, having never held one, their pastures lying too high and too far from any waypoint house for a road-guard to trouble counting them, and they were not written into that census nor into any that followed it, a people the island's own rolls knew existed without ever quite troubling to know how many of them there were.

Inis mhin, a small fishing harbour on the northern shore further east again, came into the rolls for the first and, in this stretch of years, the only time, when its own headman walked the whole distance to the wool-fair at Inis mhòr to lay a

complaint against the road-guard's toll before whichever reeve would hear it. The complaint is kept in full in the rolls of that fair, a longer telling by far than the harbour otherwise earned in the whole of this age, and it is the plain truth of that coast, as one clerk of Inis mhòr noted in the margin of his own copy without troubling to soften it, that a small harbour's whole history on the written page might amount to nothing more than the one grievance it once walked far enough to voice.

VII

Of the Raid, the Second Sighting and the Round of the Islands

The western strands, in these same generations, suffered a season of raiding out of the north-western waters, low boats coming in at first light to take a night's catch of dried fish from any strand too small to keep its own watch and running before any boat large enough to give chase could be launched after them, much as an earlier generation of raiders had once troubled the eastern islets in Lachlann Bàn's own day. The sting-sworn merchants of Ros bheag, whose own trade in seal-oil and silver rings ran along that whole coast, paid from their own purses for two boats armed and crewed to watch the strands through the worst of that season, a cost none of them welcomed but every one of them judged cheaper, in the end, than a season's fish lost to raiders with no watch to answer them. The raiders moved north before the two boats ever caught one at open sea, the western strands having grown, within a season, too well watched to be worth the risk, and the coast north of Ros bheag kept, for a good while after, a wariness it had not troubled to keep before.

It was off that same coast, in the north-western water, that two boats of Baile chrom told of something vast moving beneath them one grey morning, neither crew able to say more of it than that the sea had seemed, for the length of a held breath, to breathe under their own keels, and that whatever it was had passed beneath them without touching either hull and was gone before either crew could properly say they had seen anything at all. It was the second such telling the coast remembered, an earlier crew of the same harbour having told a like tale some generations before in Ruairidh Liath's own reign, and the second telling was believed

more readily for the first having gone before it, the way one strange thing believed makes the next easier to credit. One of the two boats that morning did not come home, its own crew never found nor any wreck of it either, and Baile chrom, which had kept a wake for the earlier loss out of the first telling, kept the same wake after for both losses together, the harbour holding, as its own elders put it, that a sea capable of taking two boats a generation apart owed no household an explanation before it was owed a proper mourning.

Boats of Sliochd Raghnaill¹, in a calmer season of these same years, sailed out from Seann Tarr round the whole ring of the offshore islands, Eilean ruadh, Eilean dhearg and Eilean fhada among them, and came home again within the one season, the first crew of the age known to have made the whole round rather than only visiting one island at a time as the fishing or the grazing asked. No crew of that whole stretch of years is known to have gone further from the coast than those islands, nor is any told to have wished to, the open water beyond them holding, for every sailor of that generation, the same plain want of anything worth the sailing to that it had held for every generation before. Families of that same coast took, in these years, to carrying sheep over to Eilean ruadh each summer for its grazing, building turf shelters there against the worst of the weather and bringing the flocks home again before the autumn storms closed the crossing, a custom the coast's herders keep up still, using the same shelters the first families built, patched season by season rather than rebuilt, so that a herder of any later summer shelters, without knowing it, under turf his own great-grandmother first cut and laid.

VIII

Of the Mark That Held

Of the two hundred and thirty-six years between Tormod Òg and Anna Ruadh, this telling has told what the roads and the shore troubled to keep, and left, as the red hall's own rolls left, whatever passed at Cathair dhearg in those same years to a silence no teller has since thought worth disturbing. It is not a silence this telling judges a loss. A road bridged, a coast watched, a mark cut once and copied after by every hearth on the island: these are not lesser things for having no king's name fixed beside them, and the fellowship of masons

1. the house of Raghnaill

that carried the fourth hearth's sign from Ros fhionn to Doire mhin and on to every crossing after asked no ruler's leave to keep its own trade, nor any ruler's remembering to make the keeping worth the labour.

The bridge at Doire mhin stands yet, by every account kept of it, its stream no less given to spring flooding than it ever was and its span no grander than the day Beathag Clachair set the last stone of it; and it is told that a mason passing that way, whatever hearth he answers to and whatever crossing he is bound for next, still stops, before he passes on, to read the small cut letters beneath the fourth hearth's own sign, and to set, if his own errand allows him the moment, a fresh chip of grey stone at the bridge's foot before he takes the road again.

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

OF ANNA RUADH'S TWO CIRCUITS AND THE PARTING OF THE RITES

FE 2,792 – 2,863

Aon lasair, iomadh ainm. One flame, many names.

— said of the companies at Dùn ìseal, after Seumas Bàn had done his
counting

I

Of Anna Ruadh's First Circuit

Between Tormod Òg and Anna Ruadh's own father the house of Tormod had sat the red hall nine reigns running, and the rolls of those years hold little beyond harvests, tolls and the mending of bridges, which the tellers of Cathair dhearg took, not unreasonably, for a sign that the island had been doing well. Anna Ruadh's father was the ninth and quietest of them, a man remembered for having asked, in thirty years, no question of the provinces that a reeve could not answer sitting down.

Anna Ruadh took the red hall at Cathair dhearg in her six-and-twentieth year, 24 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,806, and the clerks who had known her father's quiet reign found her a restless kind of ruler from the first council she sat. She asked the reeves who came up from the provinces how the roads stood between one seat and the next, and when none of them could tell her past the borders of his own district, she said she would go and see for herself, as Mòrag nan Rathad had gone before any road-guard rode it and before any bridge stood at Cathair dhearg to be

widened. No ruler had walked the whole circuit since. Cathair dhomhain's own reeve, who kept the Law by the letter and had little patience for a queen's whims, told her plainly that a hall was better kept from a hall. Anna Ruadh answered that a hall built by a woman who had walked every mile of it might be worth the keeping, and left the following spring with a dozen of her household and no more baggage than a carrier takes. She took no litter and no guard beyond what any well-off traveller kept on the road, and told the household she left behind that a queen who could not be spared from her own hall for a season was no queen worth the keeping either, a saying more than one later ruler of her house repeated without ever once acting on it.

She came, on the mountain road, 23 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,809, to the house that carriers still called Am Buabhall Fortanach¹, the Auspicious Buffalo, where the War of the Roads had been ended so long before that its own keepers no longer troubled to say in which reign. The house had passed by then through five generations of a line that still called itself Mòr nic Dhùghaill's own, though none living had known her, and its hearth had not gone cold since. The keeper of the house, a broad, unhurried woman who had heard a queen was coming and set nothing extra on the table for it, gave Anna Ruadh the same jugged buffalo she gave any carrier who stopped there, in the same wooden bowl, with the same crust of bread beside it. Anna Ruadh ate it at the long table among the household's own carriers, asked for a second helping, and got it without ceremony. It is the keepers of that house who tell the tale still, not the rolls, and they tell it exactly so: that the queen ate what was put in front of her and did not ask for better.

Further east, on the road that climbed toward Cnoc leathan, she came to the turf longhouse the carriers called the sunny house for the way its south wall caught the morning, 21 an Lùnastal, FE 2,813. Its keepers had mended the worst of that road themselves for three generations, out of their own stores and their own backs, because no province seat claimed the stretch as its own to mend. Anna Ruadh heard the whole of it from the youngest of them, a woman missing two fingers from a rockfall on that same road, and before she left she granted the house a toll of its own for the road's keeping, Slighe Cnoc leathan, the first and only charter any waypoint house on the island holds. She is said to have told the woman, when she thanked her, that a road mended by a stranger's charity for three generations had earned the right to be mended by its own money instead, and

1. the first waypoint house, kept by Mòr nic Dhùghaill above Doire shean

that this was no great gift but only a debt the hall had been slow to notice. The woman, whose name the rolls never troubled to keep though the toll they keep to this day, asked only that the charter be cut in stone rather than skin, since skin could be lost in a house fire and a road could not; Anna Ruadh had it cut in stone before she left the district.

At Ceann mhin on the south-eastern coast, 12 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,816, she found a quarrel old enough that neither side troubled any longer to be civil about it: the fishers of the strand and the carriers of the mountain road, both claiming the right to carry the dried fish up-country, each accusing the other of spoiling a trade that had fed them both for generations. Anna Ruadh heard the fishers first, in the low stone shed where they dried their catch, and then the carriers, at the halting-house above the strand, and gave her ruling under the open sky between the two, where both households could hear it together: that either might carry, and the trade would go to whichever kept the fish drier and the road shorter, and no household of either kind was to be turned back at the other's door. The fish going inland doubled within two years, and its price at Dùn ìseal fell by half, and both households, it is told, claimed the doubling as proof they had been in the right all along. An old fisher of the strand, asked years after whether the queen had favoured his own side in the end, is remembered to have said only that she had favoured the fish, which was more than either side had thought to do.

II

Of the Contest Field and the Wood-Watcher

At Ceann leathan the road-guards had kept a staves-contest on an open green since before living memory, the kind of match where a young man made his name and an old one kept it a season longer, and Mòrag Dhubh of Cnoc mhòr was still spoken of there for a win two centuries gone; her ring, or one so old it was taken for hers, still hung by the green's own well, and every fighter who came to try the green touched it before he took up a staff, whether he had heard her name told rightly or garbled past all knowing. Anna Ruadh watched a match fought in the mud of a wet spring and thought it a poor return for the skill on show. She gave the green a wall of dressed stone and a drained floor, 11 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,819, and set a silver ring from the red hall's own store as the prize, and ruled besides that whoever lost a match at her contest should eat at the

crown's cost before going home, win or lose being no reason, she said, for a man to go home hungry. Fighters came after that from every province of the south to try the stone field, and the year Fearchar Ruadh of Doire mhin took the ring, he was carried on the shoulders of men who had lost to him not an hour before. He had come to the green as a mason's apprentice with nothing to his name but a borrowed staff, and he ate, by Anna Ruadh's own new law, the same crown's meal as every man he had beaten, at the same board, before the ring was ever put in his hand; it is remembered of him that he never afterward sat down to eat without asking who else was at the table.

It was on the same circuit that Anna Ruadh took into her household a wood-watcher out of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹, a spare, sun-browned man who read the fall of a dropped stick or the turn of a bird's flight the way a clerk read a slate, and asked him to read the omens of the hall at Cathair dhearg as he had read them under the trees. It was the first time the rite of the wood-watchers, which held Macha for its goddess, sovereignty and horses both, had come so far east, 23 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,822. Anna Ruadh's own household saw him first read the hall on a morning when three geese crossed the yard from the north before the queen had broken her fast, and the wood-watcher told her, without being asked, that a message she had given up waiting for would come before the week was out; a rider from the southern coast rode in on the sixth day with an answer to a letter she had sent a full year before and thought lost on the road, and after that no one in the household troubled him with questions he had not been asked first. The Keeper at Dùn ìseal sent a protest up by the same road Anna Ruadh had walked, asking by what right a hall built on the Binding kept an omen-reader who answered to no measure of the vein at all. The rolls give no answer to it, and none is remembered as having been sent.

Cathair dhomhain took the matter harder than Dùn ìseal had. Its own shrine had kept the Law strictly since the town's founding, its Keeper's cutter tried every season without complaint, and its people said openly, where Anna Ruadh's messengers could hear it, that the capital had handed its omens to folk who sat in trees, 24 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,826. Cathair dhomhain and the capital had quarrelled before over tolls and over precedence at the council bench; from that year the quarrel carried a weight of faith as well; and it never again lost it. A generation later a Cathair dhomhain reeve, asked why his town still would take no wood-

1. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

watcher of its own, is said to have answered only that a bird did not judge a king, and left it at that. Cathair dhomhain's own shrine, in the same season, doubled its cutter's visits to the Keeper's measure without being asked, as though the strictness alone might answer an insult that no letter to Cathair dhearg had ever troubled to make plain, and for a hundred years after, a Cathair dhomhain man swearing an oath was known on the roads by how exactly he kept to the letter of it.

Anna Ruadh walked the circuit a second time some years on, in her middle years, slower than the first, stopping longer at each house and asking after names she remembered from the first walking; more than one keeper who had fed her as a young queen fed her again white-haired, and told their own children afterward which meal it had been. At Am Buabhall Fortanach² the same broad-handed keeper who had served her the juggled buffalo unceremoniously the first time set the bowl down before her a second, with grey in her own hair by then, and this time asked, since the queen had come so far twice over, whether she would not sit a while longer than the meal took. Anna Ruadh stayed the night, the only night of either circuit she is known to have slept two together under one roof that was not her own.

She came home from that second circuit already tiring, though she said nothing of it to her household, and she held the red hall four years more before she died of no sickness anyone could name, in the way that a candle goes out at the end of its wick rather than by any wind, 26 an Cèitean, FE 2,829, in her nine-and-fortieth year. In her last winter she had the household read her the toll rolls of the sunny house and of Slighe Cnoc leathan aloud at her own bedside, twice, as though to be sure the charter still stood as she had cut it, and asked after no other matter of state before she died. She was carried to Dùn dhearg and laid among the house of Ìomhar and the kings of her own house together, as her line had been promised at its choosing.

The council kept the hall three years in her son's name, and Coinneach Bàn took it in his own, 27 an Giblean, FE 2,832, seven-and-twenty years old and already known to the reeves for asking the same close questions of a slate that his mother had asked of a road. He did not walk the circuit as she had. He said, when a councillor asked him whether he meant to, that his mother had already walked it twice and left him little to see that she had not seen first, and that he would

2. the first waypoint house, kept by Mòr nic Dhùghaill above Doire shean

rather have every province seat send him a true copy of its own rolls than walk out to read them himself. It was the beginning of the work that filled the better part of his reign: seat after seat sent its clerk down to Cathair dhearg over the following years with the district's laws copied fresh, and Coinneach Bàn read every copy through himself before it was shelved, so that within a decade a province seat's own clerks, wanting to settle a point of law, more often sent to the capital for a copy of their own rolls than trusted the skins in their own keeping, which the damp of a mountain winter had usually got to first.

III

Of Seumas Bàn and the Roll

Sliochd Mhuirich had held the Keeper's office, without ever once claiming the red hall in its own name, since long before Oighrig nic Lachlainn's death, and through the shut hall that followed it, when the house had stood back from the choosing at Dùn ìseal while three other houses quarrelled over the red hall; and it was said of Sliochd Mhuirich¹, half in respect and half in the way a rival house says such things, that it had learned early to want the keeping of a thing rather than the owning of it. Seumas Bàn was the youngest son of that house's youngest branch, raised at Dùn ìseal within sound of the flame, and no one who had known him as a boy running the Hall's own passages was greatly surprised when the flame came to his keeping in his turn.

Seumas Bàn came to the flame at five-and-thirty, 16 an t-Samhain, FE 2,835, and did what every new Keeper before him had done, and sat down with the Keepers' roll to learn the names of those who had kept the flame before him. He read it by the light of Bride's own flame, in the stone room below Talla na Lasrach² where the roll was kept, with a jug of small beer going flat at his elbow and no company but the clerk who had shown him where the oldest skins were stored. The names ran down the page in the old stag-letters, a hundred years and more to a skin, some hands cramped and some sprawling, a few so faded with age that he had to tilt the whole page to the firelight to read them at all. He had meant, when he sat down, only an evening's reading, the way a man learns the names of his

1. the house of Muireach

2. the Hall of the Flame

own grandfather's brothers before a feast; the roll ran to nine skins by the time it reached him, and he was still at the fourth when the clerk came in to tell him the fire in the outer room had gone out and been relit twice without his noticing either time.

He read for the better part of two nights before he noticed the pattern, and a third before he stopped reading and began instead to count, going back to the beginning and setting a mark on a scrap of hide for every name of his own house, and counting the whole roll through twice to be sure of himself. When he had finished he sat a long while looking at the two rows of marks, which agreed with each other exactly. More than half the Keepers of the age, from Beathag Bhàn down to himself, had been of Sliochd Mhuirich. He went further, though the roll gave him no cause to and no one afterward thanked him for it, and reckoned how many of the rest had married into the house or fostered a child of it, and found the true number nearer to two in every three.

He told no one at once, sending the clerk to his bed and sitting alone with the roll until the fire burned low, and it is the clerk's own account, given in his old age and kept unstruck in a hand not his master's, that Seumas Bàn said only one thing aloud that night, to no one: that a Hall built so that no heir might hold the flame had, without anybody meaning it so, let one house hold the watching of it instead. In the morning he sent for the same clerk and a knife, and had the count struck from the roll's preface where he had written it the night before in a heat that had not survived till daylight, 16 an t-Samhain, FE 2,835. The clerk did as he was bid and said nothing of the copy he had already made for his own hand before the knife came near the page, and it is that copy, not the scraped one, that answers for the fact today.

That winter, done with counting his own house, Seumas Bàn turned to counting everyone else's. He had the clerks of the Hall set down every rite on the island that burned a handful at dawn or laid any claim at all to the vein, so that the council should know, he said, what it was that it kept, 18 an Dàmhair, FE 2,838. The list, when it was finished, ran longer than he had expected: the Hall's own rite of the flame and the stone; the old keeping of the ancestors, which asked nothing of the vein and troubled no one; the dawn-hawk of the northern coast; the wood-watchers of the western wood; the wolf-sworn of the road-guards; the sting-oath of the harbour courts; and both schools of the stag, the elders' and Donnchadh mac Iain's, still trading their letters after three generations of disagreement. The clerk who wrote the list added, at its foot, that a thousand years

before no such list would have been needed, since there had been, in the memory the roll kept, only the one flame and the one measure. Seumas Bàn read the note and let it stand.

IV

Of the Rites Counted

In the spring he sent a cutter named Ruairidh Òg north to Seann Skell, to try the hawk-keepers' dawn-burning against the Hall's own measure, as every rite on the list was tried in its turn. He came back within the month, 19 an t-Sultain, FE 2,840, wind-burned about the face and short in his answers, with a strip of tanned hide folded inside his coat. He had put the Hall's question to the household of Ealasaid Bhàn, eldest of the fowlers, who fed her hawk before her own table was laid, as the rite required, and who heard him out at her own door without asking him in. She had told him, he said, standing in her own doorway with the hawk hooded on her wrist and the dawn fire already lit behind her, that the measure he had come to try was the hawk's own, not the Keeper's, that her people burned exactly what the Law required and had done so every dawn of her life, and that they had put it in writing so that no cutter after him could mistake the matter again. When Ruairidh Òg asked whether he might at least see the handful weighed, she answered that he might watch from the yard as any neighbour was welcome to, but that watching was not trying, and the two were not the same thing however he chose to name them to the Keeper. The strip of hide he carried was that writing. It was the first time any rite on the list had turned the Hall's own trial away outright, and Seumas Bàn read it twice by the fire before he put it in the chest with the roll rather than answering it.

From Caol leathan came word, a few years on, that the wolf-sworn had raised a hall of their own about the white stone at the town gate, the second such stone the order had ever set, and that the oaths sworn there now were no longer the plain guards' oaths of the road but something graver, 21 an Lùnastal, FE 2,843. The stone, its keepers said, watched the whole island as any guard watched his own stretch of road, and would cry out under a rightful king as under no other; men had begun to call it Lia Fàil¹, the Stone, and the wolf-sworn who kept it An

1. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

Fhianna, though the road-guards among them still rode the same roads they had always ridden. A young guard swore the new oath that same season with his hand flat on the stone in a hall still smelling of its own fresh mortar, and told his own household after that the stone had felt warm under his palm on a cold morning, though the mason who had set it swore he had cut and laid nothing but plain grey rock out of the same quarry that built half the town's walls. Seumas Bàn had known most of those men by their given names before they were anything of the kind, and it troubled him more, he told the clerk, that a name could change a man's oath than that the oath itself had changed.

At the western Seann Skell the harbour court's old sting-oath, sworn on a scorpion carved for the purpose since before anyone living could say why, had by then become a settled creed, ³ an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,846. Its keepers held that one power alone stung the liar wherever he stood, naming him Manannan mac Lir, lord of the sea, and that the scorpion was no more than his sign; and it was the first teaching on the island to claim, in so many words, that it alone was true, where every other rite on the list had been content to be its own. From that court's founding the oath was sworn thereafter over a cup marked with the scorpion, called Manannan's Cup of Truth, which was said to break in three at three lies spoken over it and to be made whole again by three truths, though no clerk of the Hall ever saw it broken, and a merchant of the harbour town who was once heard to wonder aloud what would happen if it were tested found no one willing to lend him a boat that season. Seann Vell, below Cuan shean on the same coast, took up the oath from its neighbour within the year and carved its own scorpion in yellow stone, ⁴ an t-Samhain, FE 2,849, the first image of the creature cut for worship rather than for swearing on, so that a child of that town grew up knowing the scorpion's shape before it ever heard the oath explained. The stonecutter who carved it, a woman better known for gravestones than for shrines, is said to have complained that no one had ever shown her a living scorpion to work from, and to have carved it in the end from a fisherman's telling of one washed up dead on the strand, so that the image every child of Seann Vell learned to fear owed at least as much to a fisherman's memory as to the god it was meant to serve.

The wood-watchers went furthest of all. They stopped sending their quarrels to the Hall for judgement and began to settle them instead under the trees of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag², where no clerk of Dùn ìseal had ever sat in council,

2. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

13 am Faoilleach, FE 2,852. They held that the black beast of the wood had two natures, one that kept and one that devoured, and that the vein under the mountain had the very same two, though it showed only one face to any cutter who had never gone hungry a winter for want of it. Some among them told it further, in a telling the order took up afterward as its own, of two horses harnessed to a single chariot, the black Dubh Sainglenn and the grey Liath Macha, pulling one load between them and neither able to run without the other. A cutter of Cnoc bhàn and a fowler of the Abhainn iséal brought a boundary quarrel to the wood-watchers that same year rather than to Dùn iséal, over a stretch of scrub neither the Hall nor any province seat had ever troubled to survey, and came away with a judgement neither had asked for and both, it is told, accepted: that the ground belonged to whoever kept it fed through a hard winter, and to no one in a good one. Seumas Bàn heard the tale from the same wood-watcher who still read the omens of Anna Ruadh's old household, now grown old himself in Coinneach Bàn's service, and said only that he had heard stranger doctrines argue less sense.

V

Of the Parting

By the time the last of these reports had reached Dùn iséal, the one practice the island had kept since the Binding had plainly come apart into as many pieces as it had reasons to, 11 an Gearran, FE 2,855. Men had begun to call the whole scattering of rites An Creideamh Sean¹, the Old Faith, and set beside it, standing a little apart as it always had, the older reverence of the hearths, which asked nothing of the vein and was known by its own name, Na Seann Spioradan², the Old Spirits; and it was no longer possible, Seumas Bàn told the council plainly, to speak of the belief of the Dia-thìrich as though it were one thing, whatever the roll of the Hall had once assumed.

The council gave up the pretence a few years on, in its own turn. It had sat, since the days of the Roinn, by hearth and by house, a man beside whoever his neighbour happened to be; that year it began instead to sit in companies by rite, each on benches of its own, 16 an t-Samhain, FE 2,858, and the seating held for

1. the Old Faith

2. the Old Spirits

the rest of the age without anyone troubling to reverse it. The carpenters who built the new benches were given no instruction beyond a count of heads for each company, and it is remembered that they set the hawk-keepers' bench nearest the door, for no reason any clerk ever wrote down, so that latecomers to every council after sat longest among strangers before they reached their own.

Seumas Bàn stood at the door on the first morning they sat so and watched the benches fill, knot by knot, none of them so much as glancing at the bench beside it, and said to the clerk at his shoulder, loud enough, by his own wish, to be set down: that he kept the one flame now for eight peoples, and each of the eight was certain it was the only one that kept it truly.

Two things alone stayed outside the companies, and Seumas Bàn is said to have taken more comfort from them than from anything else that year. Pilgrims of every rite still walked to Allt an Àigh³ at the proper turn of the moon, as they always had, and asked no one's company or leave to do it; the Hall's own list, drawn up to set every rite in its place, had found no place to set that one and left it out of the reckoning entirely, ¹⁵ an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,860. That same season pilgrims of four rites, meeting on the path from Caol shean by no arrangement anyone could afterward account for, fell to mending its worn stones together, hawk-keeper beside wolf-sworn beside a stag scholar of the elders' school, and finished the work before any of them thought to ask whether the others belonged there.

And at Muileann ruadh, where the warm springs still ran from under the mountain as they had before the Binding was ever sworn, the keeper of the bathhouse, a broad, plain-spoken woman named Beathag Fhionn, ruled that year that the sick of every rite should be carried up and bathed at dawn without being asked first which company they kept, ¹⁹ an t-Sultain, FE 2,863. Her ruling was copied that same season into the rolls of every province seat that had a copy of anything at all, and it is remembered as the last ruling of the whole age that every company of the council accepted without a single voice raised against it, coming as it did from the one office in the Hall's whole keeping that had never had anything to do with the coal.

Seumas Bàn kept the flame five-and-forty years in all after that winter of the roll and the roll's scraping. What is chiefly told of him is one morning, standing again at the door of the council as he had the first day the benches were parted, and looking down the length of the Hall at knot after knot of his own eight

3. the stream of the healing water

peoples, none looking at any other, when he said nothing further to the clerk beside him. He had come to the flame meaning only to learn the names of the dead who had held it before him, and had found instead, by the same reading, the shape of the thing he now kept: no longer the one measure the Binding had set over every hearth alike, but eight measures each certain it alone answered to the vein, sitting as far from one another as the carpenters' benches would allow and closer, in the end, than either the hawk-keepers or the wolf-sworn much cared to be told. None of the eight companies, from that day to the last day the rolls of the age were kept, ever sat together again by hearth and house as one; and the flame on the threshold at Dùn ìseal burned on regardless, keeping, as it had always kept, the one measure no company of the eight had yet found cause to dispute.

CHAPTER FORTY

OF the Last Quiet Years

FE 2,864 – 5 AM FAOILLEACH FE 2,960

Chan eil bliadhna aig aon nach eil aig càch. No one has years that
the rest do not.

— said at Dùn ìseal, of the roll's last count

I

Of the Provincial Rolls

The clerks of the red hall kept, in these last generations of the Holy Age, a roll of the provinces that no single teller has ever set down whole, for the plain reason that no single year of it held anything a teller would trouble to carry from house to house; and yet it is out of that same roll, dry province by dry province, that the shape of these last quiet years is best read, since the red hall has, for most of that stretch, next to nothing else to say.

At Cnoc dhìreach in the east, on the carriers' road south of the springs, the weavers turned out in these years a heavy undyed cloth that the carriers came to wear on the high passes and nowhere else, a cloth coarse enough to turn a wind that finer weaving let through, 18 an Dàmhair, FE 2,866. It is not, the roll is careful to say, the same Cnoc dhìreach that keeps the old tombs and the grave-keepers' silence; the two towns share a name and nothing further, and the roll tells them apart, where a stranger could not, by that one cloth. The dyers of Muileann bhàn, in the eastern hills not far off, learned in the same years to fix a pale blue out of a hill plant that grew nowhere lower, and the mountain country's cloth was dyed

there ever after, 23 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,869; the Keepers alone, of everyone who wore the cloth, kept theirs undyed, and said so to any who asked, holding, as they had always held, that a flame kept for no one's blood needed no colour to mark whose it was.

A water-mill was raised in those same years at Muileann dhomhain, further into the hills, to grind the grain of the common granaries that the mountain districts had kept since Lachlann Bàn's own day, 21 an Lùnastal, FE 2,872. The miller took one measure in sixteen for his own trade and no more, and the roll calls it fair, a word the roll uses of few enough millers in the whole of it. It was at Àth Chiar, not two valleys off, that the same rains which had watered Muileann bhàn's blue plant and Cnoc dhìreach's cloth-wool that generation came down instead as a flood, carrying the river clean over its ford and taking with it the carriers' shelter and six of the town's own people, 26 an Cèitean, FE 2,875. The common granary of that district stood on a rise the flood never reached, and it fed the town through the winter that followed on nothing but its own stores, so that the roll, having told the drowning plainly, tells the granary's answer just as plainly and leaves the two to stand together without further comment, as the roll's own custom was.

On the south-eastern coast the people of Seann Bhrál began, in this same stretch, to lay oyster-beds in the shallows below their own town, a craft they held had come with their town's own name, though the clerks who keep the provincial roll set the claim down and mark it doubtful, 24 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,878, the roll's own custom being to doubt a claim it had not itself walked out and seen made good. Further down that coast Seann Vell grew, on the strength of its own fishing and the silver of Muileann Chiar carried down the eastern road, into a town large enough to raise the first stone quay any harbour on the island had ever built, 20 an Gearran, FE 2,880, its timber jetties having rotted out from under one too many seasons of the tide. On the southern cape the old beacon at Tobar dhearg was built up in stone in the same years, a tower now rather than a heap of driftwood, with its fire kept burning above the ground for the first time on any coast of Dia-thìr, 22 an Faoilleach, FE 2,883; it burned seal-oil carried the whole length of the island from the northern rocks, the same trade that had made Ceann mhòr's name a generation before, and every sailor of that southern water learned to look for its light before he learned much else his trade required of him.

At Muileann naomh, on the same southern coast, a mill and a shrine came in these years to share one roof, the miller keeping the shrine's own handful of grain

beside his millstones as faithfully as he kept his sixteenth measure, 19 an Giblean, FE 2,886; the Keeper's cutter who came out to try it, as the Hall's cutters tried every rite's measure in its turn, found the handful kept and the flour good, and wrote as much in the roll and no more. Dùn thais, in the eastern hills, was walled in the same generation, and within its new wall the stag's people raised the first temple of their own ever built in stone rather than kept in a grove, 21 am Màrt, FE 2,889, the elder school at Cnoc bhàn sending teachers down to see it properly served. Inis mhòr, on the northern coast, held by now a wool-fair at every shearing that drew buyers from the whole of that coast and some from Cathair dhearg itself, its silver weighed on the same weights Muileann chiar had sent to the northern road two generations before, 16 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,892; and further along that same coast, west of Seann Toll, the fishing town of Baile Mòr mhòr grew great enough to send its own member to the council at Dùn iséal, a seat the Four Houses mislike to this day and gave, when they could no longer refuse it outright, at the foot of the hall rather than beside their own benches, 18 an Cèitean, FE 2,895. Seann Toll had by then become the home of the whole northern fishing fleet, its boatbuilders shaping the longest craft the island knew, built for a single day's run along the coast and never meant for anything further out, 13 an Lùnastal, FE 2,898.

In the east a dry summer burned the pastures round Achadh shean and left the district's common granary empty by the following spring, 15 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,900; grain came up from Baile chaol and from Cuan ruadh under the shared-meal law that Lachlann Bàn and Raonaid Dhubh had made together three generations before, and the district repaid it, harvest by harvest, over the years after, the rolls of Baile chaol setting the repayment down measure by measure to the very last, with a clerk's own note added that no such debt in the whole of that roll had ever before been repaid in full, 10 an Dàmhair, FE 2,903. The panthers crossed the southern road late that same autumn, and fewer of them than the carriers remembered crossing in any year before; the weather-watchers read it for a hard winter and were not wrong, 11 an t-Sultain, FE 2,906, and the Keepers of that generation, whose own reckonings answered to the vein and not to the beasts of the south road, noted the crossing in their own roll without troubling to remark on it further. On the north-eastern coast a timber watch-tower went up at Baile ruadh against raiders out of the islands, manned by turns by the fisher-kin of Sliochd Raghnaill¹, the only tower built for war in the whole of this age, 13 an Lùnastal,

FE 2,909; and further south, at Cuan ruadh, the fishers gave boats and men to that same watch and were given, in return, a place on the council beside Sliochd Raghnaill's own seat, 11 an t-Sultain, FE 2,912, a bargain both sides of it were still keeping at the close of the age.

At Inis chrom, on the western coast, the families of the drowned took up the custom of holding a feast on the shore each year with an empty place set for each of the lost, a custom that spread northward in these same years as far as Seann Warr², 10 an Dàmhair, FE 2,915. Potters at Baile ghorm, on the south-western coast, learned to fire a hard red ware of their own clay in the same stretch, and their jars carried oil and grain the length of the western road, sherds of them lying, by a reeve's own count, on every waypoint-house site a rider had troubled to walk, 8 an t-Samhain, FE 2,918; the same potters set up new kilns before long at Cnoc àrsaidh, where the clay ran better and the wood nearer, and the red ware of the western road was made there for the rest of the age, 19 an Giblean, FE 2,920. On the southern coast, families crowded out of the harbours about Cathair dhearg settled at Cathair fhada and raised its long street along the ridge above the water, bringing with them a wood-watcher of their own rite and a copy of the laws, and the town grew, 18 an Cèitean, FE 2,923. At Cnoc naomh the people kept, in the old folk way, a shrine to the ancestors and to the sìth of their own hill, with no hawk in it, no wolf, no sting, no stag, 16 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,926; and the Hall's own list of rites, drawn up not long before in Seumas Bà'n's day, named them among the keepers of the old reverence, a company by now as settled and as separate as any of the eight.

It is out of this same weave of small and settled things, and out of very little else, that the last generations of the Holy Age must be read, for the red hall in these years kept, for the most part, only the red hall passing from hand to hand as it had passed since Gilleasbuig Mòr's day, and troubled the roll with little more than that.

II

Of Coinneach Bà'n's Last Years

1. the house of Raghnaill

2. a harbour beside Seann Mhorn on Loch chrom, resettled with its old name kept

Coinneach Bàn, son of Anna Ruadh, who had copied the laws for every province in his own strong years and had them read at every waypoint house from the northern road to the southern cape, held the hall a long while after that work was done, growing old at Cathair dhearg the way a man grows old who has already done the one thing his own name will be kept for and finds himself, past it, with nothing further asked of him but to keep on living. He died in the ninety-first year of his own life, in his own bed at the red hall and not on any road, and the roll gives him no more than that, holding, as the roll had held of every rìgh since the long years went out of the line, that a death in a man's own bed at ninety-one years was a death like any other and owed no further telling than the fact of it.

His son, Coinneach Donn, took up the red hall in the way sons of that house had always taken it up, without any meeting of the Four Houses troubling to be called, the hall by then passing so quietly from father to son at Cathair dhearg that a reeve of some outlying district might learn of one rìgh's death and the next rìgh's holding both from the same single line of a single roll, sent up months after the fact and answered with no more surprise than any other item of provincial business. Coinneach Donn held it thirty years and more, long enough that the carriers' road-guards of his own generation knew no other name to give the red hall, and long enough, too, that when he died in his turn, in the eighty-seventh year of his own life, it seemed to more than one reeve that the hall's passing that year ought to be as quiet as every passing before it had been.

It was not so quiet, this once, for Coinneach Donn left, besides his own daughter Mòr, a younger brother, Tormod Donn, who had held no hall of his own and wanted, now that his elder brother's line stood at a girl not yet twenty-three years old, to hold this one.

III

Of Mòr's Claim Against Her Uncle

Mòr nic Coinnich had grown up, by her own later telling, expecting nothing of the red hall beyond the ordinary daughter's portion of a house that already held the red hall, her father having never once, in the whole of her girlhood, spoken of the succession as a thing that might be contested rather than simply continued; and it was a hard schooling to her, in the first

winter after his death, to learn from her own household's own steward that her father's brother had gone to the Four Houses at Dùn ìseal with a claim of his own, arguing before them that a girl of not yet twenty-three had no more right to a hall her own line had held three generations than any other daughter of any other house on the island, and that a man grown, of the same blood and twice her years, stood the plainer heir.

The Four Houses heard Tormod Donn's claim in the same hall where they had heard Gilleasbuig Mòr's claim and old Oighrig's line's claims before him, four centuries and more back, and found themselves, as their own predecessors had found themselves then, arguing a question the roll had never troubled to settle in words because no one had ever before troubled to ask it in words: whether the hall passed by blood alone, or by blood and by the house's own custom together, and whether a woman's blood ran thinner in the reckoning than a man's when both stood equally close to the line. Sliochd Mhuirich's own bench, silent as it had been silent at every such reckoning since the shut hall of Oighrig's own day, gave no voice either way; the bench that had once sat for the clerks' line spoke for Mòr, holding that a house's custom, once kept three generations running without challenge, was a kind of blood in its own right; and the two remaining benches split evenly between them, so that the matter stood, at the winter's end, exactly where it had stood at the winter's beginning, decided by no vote the Four Houses could agree to call a decision.

It was Catriona nic Mhuirich, Keeper of the flame in those years and the last of her office the Holy Age was to know, who ended it, though the ending was none of the Hall's own business by the Small-Burning Law's own letter, and Catriona said as much to the Four Houses before she said anything else. She had known Coinneach Donn her own self, she told them, in the years before either of them held the office each now held, and she had known his daughter as a child brought once a year to see the flame kept, wide-eyed at a burning no larger than a man's two hands cupped together; and she had watched Tormod Donn, in the same years, come to the Hall himself not once, holding, by his own account to anyone who asked him, that a younger son's business lay in his own house's lands and not in a flame he would never be called on to answer for. A red hall, she told the Four Houses, was no business of the Hall's to give. She had watched, all the same, enough hands over enough years to have formed her own opinion of which

1. the house of Muireach

hands a house's custom had shaped for the holding and which had not; and she said, plainly, that she would set the stone cup in Mòr's hands, as it had been set once before in Gilleasbuig Mòr's, should the Four Houses ask her to, and in no one else's.

Tormod Donn yielded within the season, quietly, in his own house at Cuan ruadh rather than before the Four Houses, sending word by his own steward that he withdrew a claim he had never, in his own telling afterward, much wanted to press so far as it had gone, and had pressed it chiefly, he said, because no one else of his own house had troubled to ask him whether a girl not yet twenty-three could hold a hall her own father had held without any man standing behind her to hold it for her. It was, by the roll's own later reckoning, the last such claim the house of Tormod was ever to see contested, and the reason given for that, by more than one clerk who wrote of it after, was Mòr nic Coinnich's own long and plain holding of the hall, which left no younger brother of her own generation any reason to think a girl's hand unfit for it.

Catrìona nic Mhuirich set the stone cup in Mòr's hands at Dùn ìseal in the spring of her own twenty-fourth year, as a Keeper had set it in Gilleasbuig Mòr's hands four centuries before and in no rìgh's hands since, 15 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,929, and it is told that Mòr, taking the cup, asked Catrìona only one question of her own, low enough that the Four Houses standing by did not hear it: whether her uncle's claim had been, in Catrìona's own honest judgement, a wicked thing or only a foolish one. Catrìona is said to have answered that she had known few enough claims in her own long keeping of the flame that were purely one or the other, and that Mòr would do better, holding the hall twenty years or more as Catrìona judged she might, to spend her own reckoning on the hall's proper keeping than on her uncle's proper punishing; and Mòr took the answer, by every account that has come down of that day, for the whole of the counsel it plainly was, and never once, in the years after, brought any charge against her uncle beyond the one the Four Houses had already let lapse of their own accord.

IV

Of Mòr's Reign



òr nic Coinnich wed, within two years of taking the cup, a man of Sliochd Ragh-naill¹ named Dòmhnall Dubh, whose own kin had kept the watch-tower at Baile ruadh and given boats to the coast's own defence in her father's time, and whose own reckoning of the sea, she is said to have told her household, sat easier beside her own reckoning of the hall than any lowland house's reckoning of grain and silver would have sat. Dòmhnall Dubh held no office at the red hall and asked none, keeping, through the whole of Mòr's reign, to the same trade his own house had always kept, boats and the watch of the north-eastern coast, and coming to Cathair dhearg only as a husband comes to his wife's own hall rather than as any rìgh's consort claiming a hand in her own business; and it is remembered of him, by the one or two tellers who troubled to remember him at all, chiefly that he never once, in twenty years at Cathair dhearg, learned to sit easy through a full council sitting of the eight companies by rite, finding the benches' own silence toward one another harder to bear, he is said to have said, than any storm his own boats had ever ridden out.

The reign these two years opened ran, for the better part of thirty years, very much as Coinneach Bà'n's and Coinneach Donn's reigns before it had run: the red hall at Cathair dhearg, the provinces sending their rolls up each year with little in them a teller would trouble to keep, the eight companies of the council sitting their own benches without disorder and without, so far as the rolls show, any of them troubling to speak across the gap between one bench and the next. Mòr herself is remembered as a rìgh who read every roll that came up to her rather than leaving the reading to a clerk, a habit her own steward is said to have found tiresome when she was young to the office and to have come, as his own service under her lengthened, to value above any other habit a rìgh had ever kept; and it was Mòr, reading the Hall's own roll one winter evening not many years before her death, who first had the count made that the roll's later keepers were afterward to set at its foot: one hundred and forty names of Keepers from Beathag Bhàn to Ca-trìona nic Mhuirich, and better than ninety names of rìghrean from Goraidh Mòr to her own, 2 an Giblean, FE 2,939, a reckoning she is said to have sat with a long while by her own lamp before she troubled anyone else with it.

It was in that same reckoning, brought to her by a clerk who had made it chiefly to answer her own asking, that Mòr found the fact these tellings have made most of already, though she herself, by her steward's own account, made rather

1. the house of Raghnaill

less of it at the time: that no family on the whole of the island, her own included, now lived any longer than any other, the long years that had once carried Ìomhar Dearg to fifteen hundred summers and Eithne past three thousand having gone, generation by generation, clean out of every line that had ever carried them, so that a rìgh of Cathair dhearg in that year could expect, by the plain arithmetic the roll now showed, very much the same span of years as a potter of Baile ghorm or a weaver of Cnoc dhìreach. Mòr is said to have remarked to her steward only that it seemed to her a fitting enough thing, a cup meant from its first swearing for no one's blood having taken, in the end, the better part of three thousand years to make every blood on the island answer to the same measure; and the steward, setting the remark down afterward at Ruairidh Clèireach's own asking, added nothing of his own beside it, judging it needed none.

Dòmhnall Dubh died in the fiftieth year of his own life, at Baile ruadh among his own kin rather than at Cathair dhearg, and Mòr, who had kept the hall by then the better part of twenty years, is told to have gone north herself to see him buried beside the watch-tower his own house had kept three generations, a journey no rìgh of Cathair dhearg had troubled to make in living memory for a husband's burying rather than a province's own business. She held the hall three years more after that, alone in her own hall in a way she had not been alone in it since her uncle's claim was first brought against her, and it is of those three years that the least is told of the whole of her reign, the roll of that stretch holding nothing beyond the provinces' own small business and a single note, written in Ruairidh Clèireach's own hand, that the rìgh kept her own counsel more than she had kept it in any year before.

V

Of Mòr's Death and Beathag's Crowning

Mòr nic Coinnich died on the one-and-twentieth day of an t-Iuchar, in the eight-and-fortieth year of her own life, at Cathair dhearg, in the same hall her father and her father's father had died in before her. She left two daughters, Beathag, not yet sixteen, and Mòrag, younger still, and no brother, no uncle, no cousin near enough in blood to raise the question her own reign had opened with; and it is told, by more than one hand that wrote of that year afterward, that the Four Houses, summoned in haste to Dùn ìseal within

days of the rìgh's death, found themselves for the first time in living memory with a succession that raised no claim at all, Tormod Donn's own line having died with him some thirteen years before and left no son of an age or a temper to trouble a girl of sixteen for a hall her own mother and grandfather and great-grandfather had all three held before her.

Beathag was crowned at Cathair dhearg within the month, by her own house's word and the Four Houses' own assent, rather than by any journey to Dùn ìseal to have the stone cup set in her hands as her mother had had it set in hers; and it is this, of all the small departures the last years of the Holy Age made from the years before them, that the chroniclers who came after troubled most to remark on, some holding it a plain matter of a girl of sixteen being crowned in haste at her own hall rather than made to journey the fifty-five miles east to Dùn ìseal in the heat of the harvest, and others holding it the first sign of a distance opening between the red hall's own crowning and the Hall's own flame that no teller of that year, watching it happen, yet had words to name. Catriona nic Mhuirich, by then past threescore years, sent word to Cathair dhearg that she stood ready to travel to Dùn ìseal and receive the young rìgh there whenever the roads and the season allowed it, as the Hall's own custom asked; and it is recorded, without further comment from the roll, that the journey was never made in Mòr's own daughter's first year, nor troubled over again in the years the roll of this age had left to keep.

It fell to Ruairidh Clèireach, clerk of the red hall these twenty years and more, to find, in the same weeks, that the skin on which the king-list and the Keepers' roll together had been kept since Coinneach Bàn's own day was filled to its last line with Mòr's own name and the count her own reading had asked for, and no room left on it for any name after hers. He began a new skin that same winter, ruling its first lines himself by lamplight at his own table rather than waiting on any clerk under him, and set at its head, in the same plain hand he had kept the old roll in for twenty years, the name of Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill, crowned rìgh at Cathair dhearg in the year of her mother's death; so that the old roll, closed that winter and laid away in the same chest that held every roll of the Hall before it, carries to this hour no name later than Mòr's, and it is Mòr's name, not her daughter's, that stands last of all the names the Holy Age was to write down.

VI

Of the Winter Morning

The fifth day of Faoilleach, by the almanac the red hall kept, in the year the roll had by then run to two thousand nine hundred and threescore, found the young rìgh Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill down at the harbour below her own hall at Cathair dhearg, her younger sister Mòrag beside her, both of them come down in the dark and the cold ahead of any steward's asking to see the last of the season's boats brought in before the weather the watchers had promised broke over the coast in earnest.

The boats came in by ones and twos through the last of the dark, the crews calling to each other across the water in the plain short words men keep for a cold morning's work, and were made fast along the same stone quay Seann Vell's own masons had raised the pattern for the better part of a hundred years before and every southern harbour since had copied; and Beathag stood at the harbour's edge in a cloak too thin for the hour, by her sister's own later telling, and counted the boats in against some tally of her own that she never troubled to share with anyone standing near her, whether it was the whole season's fleet she was counting or only the boats she had watched go out the evening before.

Mòrag, younger by four years and not yet crowned with any business of her own beyond a girl's ordinary place at her sister's side, asked her, standing there in the cold with the last boat still some way off the quay, whether she was afraid of the storm the watchers had promised; and Beathag answered, after a while long enough that Mòrag is said to have thought she would not answer at all, that she was not afraid of a storm that every fisherman on that coast had ridden out a hundred times before her, but that she found herself thinking, more mornings than not since her own crowning, of the stone cup sitting on its threshold at Dùn ìseal, waiting on a journey neither she nor the old Keeper who had asked for it had yet troubled to make, and wondering whether a rìgh who had never held that cup in her own two hands could rightly call herself the last name of an age that had begun with heirs quarrelling over who might hold a flame no hand was ever meant to keep.

The last boat came in as the light began, thin and grey, over the water east of the harbour, and the crews went up to their own hearths with the night's catch, and the two sisters stood a while longer at the quay's edge with nothing further asked of either of them that morning beyond the ordinary business of a cold sea-

son's turning. The sea beyond the harbour mouth lay open and empty to the edge of what the morning's grey light let them see, as it had lain empty of any wished-for shore through every one of the two thousand nine hundred and threescore years the roll behind them had troubled to keep; and it is on that sea, and on that morning, and on the stone cup standing yet on its own threshold a day's hard ride to the east, that the last roll of the Holy Age closes, with no name written after Mòr's, and no shore in sight from any coast the island's own boats had ever thought worth the sailing to.

PART SIX

The Annals of the Age

THE YEARS FE 1 – 200

- 2 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1** — *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*¹ (Dùn dhearg). The host of Dùn dhearg and the eastern households who never bowed come against the king at the ford below Dùn dhearg. Ailean Mòr holds the ford alone three days and three nights, and the dead of the host dam the river. On the third night he falls, worn down by the whole host; no one man overcame him, and age had not touched him. His kin, quarrelling already over the shares of the kingdom, did not come. He was four thousand six hundred and twenty-six years old, and had been king since the grove. The ford is called Àth na Fala after.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1** — *The Binding of the First Flame*. Custody is declared over the vein, and the first flame is bound at Dùn ìseal: the undying flame of Bride, kept over the stone of Crom Cruaich. The heirs of Ailean Mòr, gathered to part his kingdom, cannot part the vein, and swear it to no one of the blood. Its keepers, Òrd Bhride², are the first order on Dia-thìr to govern both rite and people, and they are older by centuries than any rìgh after Ailean.
- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1** — *Runners to every coast* (Dùn ìseal). The kin in the valley send runners in pairs from fires that do not trust each other to every coast of the island, to call in the king's blood who had not come.
- 5 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1** — *Aodh Crom asks for a cord of the heirs* (Dùn ìseal). The eldest keeper of the slab, Aodh Crom, comes to the house of the knot-keeper Sine nan Snaidhm by night and asks her for a new cord, to count the heirs, since none of them will believe another's count.³
- 8 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1** — *The knotting of the heirs begins* (Dùn ìseal). Sine nan Snaidhm sits down at the door of the gathering-house below Dùn ìseal with a new cord of flax and wool of many colours, one colour for each child of the king with living heirs. No heir is to be heard on the shares who has not first been knotted at the door.
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1** — *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). The kin of Ailean Mòr, come too late to the ford, stay on at Dùn ìseal after the Binding to part his kingdom. The knot-keeper Sine nan Snaidhm ties a knot on a cord for every heir who stands up to claim: seven hundred and twelve. The eldest of them, Murchadh Mòr, is near two thousand nine hundred years old; the youngest who claims is a child in arms.⁴
- 19 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1** — *Ìomhar Dearg comes to the ford* (Dùn dhearg). Ìomhar Dearg, a son of Ailean Mòr, who had stayed three days in the valley under Dùn ìseal arguing for river-grazing, comes down out of the heather to Àth na Fala⁵ on the morning after the king fell, and finds the river dammed by the dead and his father on the west bank.⁶

1. the Ford of Blood, below Dùn dhearg

2. the order of Bride's flame

3. ← Follows from *Runners to every coast*, 27 an t-Sultain, FE 1.

4. → Caused by *Runners to every coast*, 27 an t-Sultain, FE 1; → Caused by *Aodh Crom asks for a cord of the heirs*, 5 an Dàmhair, FE 1; → Caused by *The knotting of the heirs begins*, 8 an Dàmhair, FE 1.

5. the Ford of Blood, below Dùn dhearg

- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1** — *The spent host broken at the ford* (Dùn dhearg). Ìomhar Dearg's household crosses the ford and falls on the host of the east where it lies spent in the heather. Many are killed, many run, and some sit down and cover their heads. By evening Ìomhar holds the ford.⁷
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1** — *The greybeard found in the ford* (Dùn dhearg). The greybeard of the eastern households who gave the counsel of the third day is found at dawn face down in the shallows below the king's stone. Whether he fell or went in of his own will, nobody on the east bank will say.⁸
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1** — *Dùn dhearg taken and its halls burned* (Dùn dhearg). Ìomhar Dearg walks in through both gates of Dùn dhearg, where the households of the east had sworn they owed nothing to Dùn ìseal. No one will own the blow that felled the king. He has the halls within the double bank burned, and takes the people under his own hand.⁹
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1** — *The bier of spears* (Dùn ìseal). On the fifth day after the ford the king's body is laid on a bier lashed from the host's spears and carried up the valley road by twelve men of Dùn dhearg who had been in the river. Two grey sons of the king meet it at the lip of the valley and walk behind it. Ìomhar Dearg does not go with it.¹⁰
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1** — *The dead of the ford buried on the meadow* (Dùn dhearg). Ìomhar Dearg has the dead of the host drawn out of the river and buried in long trenches on the meadow, all together, since none can be told apart. The king's stone at the head of the ford is left standing, and he forbids anyone to move it.¹¹
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1** — *The twelve bearers given cattle* (Dùn dhearg). The twelve bearers come back to Dùn dhearg with the poles of the bier. Ìomhar Dearg gives each a cow and a place within the bank, and sets the poles up at the inner gate.¹²
- I AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *The grey stone at the ford left standing* (Dùn dhearg). In his nine days at Dùn dhearg Ìomhar Dearg has the bank of the ford cleared but the grey stone left where it stands, and forbids anyone to move it.¹³
- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *The eastern households called down from the hills* (Dùn dhearg). Ìomhar sends riders round the eastern hills to the households who fled with their cattle: if they come down to him and to nobody else they keep their cattle and their lives. Most come. Those who do not are hunted.¹⁴

6. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1.

7. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *Ìomhar Dearg comes to the ford*, 19 an Dàmhair, FE 1.

8. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1.

9. → Leads to *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1.

10. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *Dùn dhearg taken and its halls burned*, 25 an Dàmhair, FE 1.

11. ○ Same place *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *The bier of spears*, 26 an Dàmhair, FE 1.

12. ← Follows from *The dead of the ford buried on the meadow*, 27 an Dàmhair, FE 1.

13. ‡ Legacy *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *The twelve bearers given cattle*, 31 an Dàmhair, FE 1.

- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *The tidings at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Donnan, a herd-boy of the eastern hills who watched the ford from the ridge, comes over the tops to the spring below Dùn ìseal on the fourth evening after the battle. The first word said in the camps of the kin is a question: who holds the hill now?¹⁵
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *The keening in the valley* (Dùn ìseal). Mairsile, an aged daughter of the king, begins to keen alone at her fire in the upper valley, and the whole valley of the kin takes it up fire by fire.¹⁶
- 9 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *The bier at the gathering-house* (Dùn ìseal). The bier of spears comes up the valley road with two grey sons of the king behind it. Sìne nan Snaidhm gives the twelve bearers water at the spring. The keepers of the slab take the king from them at the door of the gathering-house.¹⁷
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *The king laid in the earth* (Dùn ìseal). After three nights in the gathering-house Ailean Mòr is carried out before dawn and laid in the earth under a mound. The tellers of Dùn ìseal show a mound on the slope facing the vein; the reciters of the Mason's line, following Seathan Crom of Clann na Ceiste¹⁸, show another. The two have never been reconciled.¹⁹
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *Ìomhar Dearg comes up as lord of Dùn dhearg* (Dùn ìseal). Ìomhar Dearg rides up the valley road with his household in the cloaks of the east and stands in the door of the gathering-house as lord of Dùn dhearg. Aodh Crom bids him sit.²⁰
- 13 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *Two mounds shown for the king's grave* (Dùn ìseal). The knot-keepers of Dùn ìseal show a long low mound on the slope facing the vein as Ailean Mòr's grave; the reciters of the Mason's line tell of another, and of the lame reciter Seathan Crom who spoke to the grey sons on the third night. Sìne did not follow the bier and will not say.²¹
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *The keepers bring down their fire* (Tobar dhìreach). The nine keepers of the slab come down from Tobar dhìreach to Dùn ìseal with the fire of their hut in a covered pot. The reciters of the Mason's line hold that it came down from the mason's fire; the keepers say only that it is old and must not go out.²²

14. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *The grey stone at the ford left standing*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 1.

15. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *Aodh Crom asks for a cord of the beirs*, 5 an Dàmhair, FE 1.

16. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1.

17. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1.

18. the Children of the Question

19. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *The bier at the gathering-house*, 9 an t-Samhain, FE 1.

20. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1.

21. ¶ Legacy *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1.

22. → Leads to *The Binding of the First Flame*, 23 an t-Sultain, FE 1.

- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *The heirs' first quarrel over the hill* (Dùn ìseal). The kin of Ailean Mòr meet in the gathering-house below Dùn ìseal and quarrel three days over the hill, which stands over the vein: by the eldest, by the living, by the dead, and by a gallery to each line. Eithne nic Ailein and Murchadh Mòr nearly come to blood on the first day.²³
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *Aodh Crom's asking* (Dùn ìseal). Aodh Crom, eldest of the keepers of the slab, asks the heirs to declare the keepers' charge, as the keepers had asked of Ca-trìona Mhòr, and to put the vein and the hill over it into no share, held by no one of the king's blood. Each line would sooner nobody had it than a cousin.²⁴
- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *Gille-Bride carries a coal of the First Flame home* (Dùn ìseal). Gille-Bride of the line of Somhairle comes down from the high valleys, swears the Binding last of the king's blood, and asks for a coal of the flame. He carries it home in a clay pot and asks for nothing more, and no knot is tied for him.²⁵
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *The flame kept in the keepers' hut* (Dùn ìseal). After the Binding the First Flame is kept in the keepers' hut on the slope above the gathering-house at Dùn ìseal, fed with a little of the coloured coal each night.²⁶
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *Murchadh Mòr comes alone to the keepers' hut* (Dùn ìseal). On the night before the swearing Murchadh Mòr climbs alone to the keepers' hut and sits across the fire from Aodh Crom like a carrier, knees up, to tell him the hill will go to the fire and not to the man who feeds it, and to ask what the keepers want.²⁷
- 28 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1** — *The youngest keeper asks who will hold the flame* (Dùn ìseal). On the night after the Binding, while the heirs drink in the valley, the youngest of the nine keepers sits down across the flame from Aodh Crom and asks who will hold it when he and the rest of them are gone.²⁸
- I AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *Murchadh Mòr knotted first* (Dùn ìseal). Murchadh Mòr, eldest living son of the king, gives his line in two words, 'Ailean's son', and stands over the knot-keeper while she ties it. The knotting of his line takes the whole first day.²⁹

23. → Leads to *The Binding of the First Flame*, 23 an t-Sultain, FE 1.

24. → Leads to *The Binding of the First Flame*, 23 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ♦ Fulfils *The keepers ask to be named* → An Aois Ailein, GE 4,376; ← Follows from *The heirs' first quarrel over the hill*, 16 an t-Samhain, FE 1.

25. ← Follows from *The Binding of the First Flame*, 23 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *Aodh Crom's asking*, 18 an t-Samhain, FE 1.

26. ← Follows from *The Binding of the First Flame*, 23 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *Gille-Bride carries a coal of the First Flame home*, 19 an t-Samhain, FE 1.

27. → Leads to *The Binding of the First Flame*, 23 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *The flame kept in the keepers' hut*, 22 an t-Samhain, FE 1.

28. ← Follows from *The Binding of the First Flame*, 23 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *Murchadh Mòr comes alone to the keepers' hut*, 25 an t-Samhain, FE 1.

29. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *The knotting of the heirs begins*, 8 an Dàmhair, FE 1.

- 2 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *Fionn Beag sent home* (Dùn ìseal). Eithne nic Ailein sets her own knot-keeper, Fionn Beag of the lowlands, on the step to count after Sine nan Snaidhm. After four days he tells her that the knot-keeper of Dùn ìseal has made no mistake, and Eithne sends him home.³⁰
- 6 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *Niall Òg's knot tied once* (Dùn ìseal). Niall Òg, a grandson of the king, gives his line through his mother and again through his father and says that he is owed twice. Sine nan Snaidhm ties his knot once.³¹
- 7 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *The knot-keeper refuses a cow* (Dùn ìseal). A steward of one of the lines of the dead brings Sine nan Snaidhm a cow in milk to have doubtful cousins tied close to his lord's line. She sends him away, and two more after him, and the stewards begin to watch one another's lines at the door.³²
- 8 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *The knots of the dead* (Dùn ìseal). For the lines of the king's children who died before him, Sine nan Snaidhm ties a hollow knot of black wool round nothing, and ties their heirs after it. By the end there are more hollow knots in the cord than knots for the king's living children.³³
- 12 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *Four lines protest Ìomhar's knot* (Dùn ìseal). When Ìomhar Dearg is knotted as a son of the king, four lines send their stewards to Aodh Crom to say they will not agree to Dùn dhearg being counted as one share when the shares are cut.³⁴
- 13 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *The youngest heir knotted* (Dùn ìseal). A great-great-grandchild of the king of the salt-shore line, a child in arms, is held up at the door and knotted, the youngest of all the heirs.³⁵
- 14 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *The cord laid on the floor* (Dùn ìseal). On the eleventh evening the cord of the heirs, Sreang nan Oighrean³⁶, is laid along the floor of the gathering-house from the hearth to the door and back, with lamps set beside it, and the heirs walk it looking at their own knots and counting their neighbours'.³⁷
- 15 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *The four rules put before the valley* (Dùn ìseal). As the sitting settles in for the winter, the heirs' quarrel sorts itself into four rival rules for the parting of the kingdom: the eldest to hold and feed the rest, the living to hold by nearness of blood, the dead's children to stand in their fathers' places, and the shares to be thrown for by lot.³⁸

30. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *Murchadh Mòr knotted first*, 1 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

31. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *Fionn Beag sent home*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

32. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *Niall Òg's knot tied once*, 6 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

33. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *The knot-keeper refuses a cow*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

34. ← Follows from *The knots of the dead*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

35. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1.

36. the knotted cord of the 712 claimants, cut at the Roinn

37. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *The youngest heir knotted*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *Murchadh Mòr argues the eldest's rule* (Dùn ìseal). Murchadh Mòr holds, before the assembled heirs, that the eldest of the king's children should take the whole kingdom and feed the rest of the blood from his own hand, as a household divides no differently at a father's death.³⁹
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *Eithne argues the rule of the living* (Dùn ìseal). Eithne nic Ailein argues that the living should hold in the order of their nearness to the king's blood and no further back, so that the youngest living child stands level with the eldest.⁴⁰
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *The dead's children ask a place in the reckoning* (Dùn ìseal). The lines of the king's dead children, gathered behind an old man who had felt the hollow knot at the door, argue that a line does not end because its head died before the king, and ask a rule that does not forget them.⁴¹
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *The youngest heirs ask the lot* (Dùn ìseal). Among the youngest and least-landed of the heirs a fourth rule is heard, that the shares be thrown for by lot and left to the ancestors to judge, since none of the other three rules gives them much to hope for.⁴²
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *Niall Òg carries words between the two fires* (Dùn ìseal). Niall Òg, owed twice over and feared by nobody's steward, begins carrying words straight between Murchadh Mòr's fire and Eithne nic Ailein's, each of them trusting him, of all the valley, to repeat the meaning and not soften it.⁴³
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1** — *The grass of the valley fails to come back* (Dùn ìseal). The river-side grass, grazed to the earth by two winters of the sitting's horses and households, does not come green again with the spring, and does not for three years after.⁴⁴
- 21 AN GEARRAN, FE 2** — *Mairsile nic Ailein dies in the cold* (Dùn ìseal). Mairsile nic Ailein, the white-haired daughter who began the keening at the ford, dies in the valley in the second month of the year, when the short winter ration leaves her brazier low overnight; she is laid by the river as she had asked before her death.⁴⁵

38. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1.

39. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *The four rules put before the valley*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

40. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *Murchadh Mòr argues the eldest's rule*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

41. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *Eithne argues the rule of the living*, 20 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

42. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *The dead's children ask a place in the reckoning*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

43. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *The youngest heirs ask the lot*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1; ← Leads to *The grass of the valley fails to come back*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

44. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *Niall Òg carries words between the two fires*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

- 15 AM MÀRT, FE 2** — *Four lines protest the Red Share* (Dùn dhearg). Four lines with no claim on Dùn dhearg argue that Ìomhar Dearg's hold on it, won by the sword and not by any of the four rules, ought to be parted into whatever settlement the rest of the kingdom comes into; Eithne answers that no rule written after the fact can take back what is already held.⁴⁶
- 6 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2** — *The clause against the name of rìgh* (Dùn ìseal). Through the summer the strongest lines come, fire by fire, to swear that none of the nine shall be called rìgh or take the word for a share, since the kingdom ended with Ailean Mòr; Murchadh Mòr swears it hardest, having watched what the word cost his father.⁴⁷
- 12 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2** — *Aodh Crom proposes the four rules together* (Dùn ìseal). Aodh Crom, asked his mind though he holds no share, tells the heads of the strongest lines that no one of the four rules can be sworn alone, and sets out a settlement that gives each rule something: nine great shares for the eldest living lines, a portion out of all nine for the dead, and the lot within each share where an equal claim cannot be told apart.⁴⁸
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2** — *The nine eldest lines agree to the settlement* (Dùn ìseal). The nine strongest lines of the king's blood, among them Murchadh Mòr, Eithne nic Ailein, Fionnghal nic Ailein of the western shore, Artair mac Ailein of the salt shore and Cormac mac Ailein of the east, agree to hold the nine great shares, with the portion of the dead set out of all nine and the Red Share of Ìomhar Dearg let stand.⁴⁹
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2** — *The agreement to cut the cord at the handful* (Dùn ìseal). The nine lines agree that the cord of the heirs shall be laid on the gathering-house floor again and cut into nine lengths at the night of the handful, with the clause against the name of rìgh and the peace of the Hall's ground sworn once before the whole valley as it is cut.⁵⁰
- 16 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2** — *The cord of the heirs laid twice round the gathering-house floor* (Dùn ìseal). On Oidhche an Dòrlaich⁵¹ the keepers bring the cord of the heirs down from its chest and lay it from the hearth to the door and back, with lamps set along its length. Nine plain, unmarked knives are laid out for the nine lines that will cut it.

45. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *The grass of the valley fails to come back*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1.

46. ← Follows from *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *Mairsile nic Ailein dies in the cold*, 21 an Gearran, FE 2.

47. ← Follows from *Four lines protest the Red Share*, 15 am Màrt, FE 2.

48. ← Follows from *The clause against the name of rìgh*, 6 an Giblean, FE 2.

49. ← Follows from *Aodh Crom proposes the four rules together*, 12 an t-Iuchar, FE 2.

50. ← Follows from *The nine eldest lines agree to the settlement*, 3 an Lùnastal, FE 2.

51. the dark of the year when every hearth burns its measure; the Roinn was sworn on it

- 1 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2** — *Roinn na Rìoghachd*⁵² (Dùn ìseal). On the night of the handful the heirs swear the parting of the kingdom, Roinn na Rìoghachd. The island below the mountain is cut into nine great shares, earrannan mòra, for the nine eldest lines of the king's blood, and the lines of his dead children are given the portion of the dead, cuid nam marbh, out of all nine. No heir is to be called rìgh. The ground of the Hall is in no share. Dùn dhearg, which Ìomhar Dearg had taken with the sword after the ford, is let stand as his share, over the protest of four lines.⁵³
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2** — *Murchadh Mòr cuts the cord first* (Dùn ìseal). Murchadh Mòr, eldest living son of the king and near two thousand nine hundred years old, cuts the cord in one stroke exactly where he had long meant to, and takes up the great share of the north, from Baile Mòr mhòr to the high passes.⁵⁴
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2** — *Eithne nic Ailein's knife cuts through a knot* (Dùn ìseal). Eithne nic Ailein, youngest of the nine eldest lines, kneels long over her place on the cord and cuts through a knot rather than between two, leaving one heir's line divided between her share and the next.⁵⁵
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *Ciorstaidh cut through and claimed by two shares* (Dùn ìseal). Ciorstaidh of the salt shore, whose knot is cut through by Eithne's knife, answers the two lords quarrelling over her with "I'll take both." It is let stand: the first of the double oaths sworn that night.⁵⁶
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *Eleven knots cut through in one night* (Dùn ìseal). Where the nine knives cross the cord's thickest stretches, eleven knots in all are cut through rather than between. Eleven households find themselves sworn to two lords at once; most pay both oaths rather than contest them.⁵⁷
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *The western share sworn to Fionnghal nic Ailein* (Dùn ìseal). Fionnghal nic Ailein cuts her length of the cord clean and takes the western share, with its seat on the harbour at Ros dhomhain.⁵⁸

52. the Division; lit. 'the parting of the kingdom'

53. → Caused by *The knots of the dead*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1; → Caused by *Four lines protest Ìomhar's knot*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1; → Caused by *The four rules put before the valley*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1; → Caused by *Mairsile nic Ailein dies in the cold*, 21 an Gearran, FE 2; → Caused by *Four lines protest the Red Share*, 15 am Màrt, FE 2; → Caused by *The clause against the name of rìgh*, 6 an Giblean, FE 2; → Caused by *Aodh Crom proposes the four rules together*, 12 an t-Iuchar, FE 2; → Caused by *The nine eldest lines agree to the settlement*, 3 an Lùnastal, FE 2; → Caused by *The agreement to cut the cord at the handful*, 25 an Lùnastal, FE 2; → Caused by *The cord of the heirs laid twice round the gathering-house floor*, 16 an t-Sultain, FE 2.

54. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rìoghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *The cord of the heirs laid twice round the gathering-house floor*, 16 an t-Sultain, FE 2.

55. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rìoghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *Murchadh Mòr cuts the cord first*, 15 an t-Samhain, FE 2.

56. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rìoghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *Eithne nic Ailein's knife cuts through a knot*, 16 an t-Samhain, FE 2.

57. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rìoghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *Ciorstaidh cut through and claimed by two shares*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2.

- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *The salt shore sworn to Artair mac Ailein* (Dùn ìseal). Artair mac Ailein, who had argued least of the nine that summer, takes the share of the salt shore, seated at the western Baile ghoram.⁵⁹
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *The eastern share sworn to Cormac mac Ailein* (Dùn ìseal). Cormac mac Ailein takes the eastern share, seated at Caol shean, in which the silver of Muileann chiar will one day be found.⁶⁰
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *The four lesser shares sworn to Ùna, Coll, Gormlaith and Tadhg* (Dùn ìseal). The last four of the nine cut their lengths in quick succession: Ùna nic Ailein takes the north-west at Muileann àrsaidh, Coll mac Ailein the hills of the Abhainn fhionn at Ceann àrsaidh, Gormlaith nic Ailein the south-east at Tobar dhearg, and Tadhg mac Ailein the Abhainn ìseal and the Hawk bay at Cnoc bheag.⁶¹
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *The cord of the beirs lies in nine pieces* (Dùn ìseal). With the ninth cut made, the cord no longer runs the floor of the gathering-house whole. It lies in nine lengths, one over each lord's arm, with the loose ends of the eleven double knots hanging free between them.⁶²
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *The Red Hill declares itself sworn to nobody* (Dùn ìseal). The holder of the Red Hill, whose line had sworn to Ailean Mòr alone and to no lord of a share, stands up on the night of the handful and says his oath died with the king, and that the Red Hill is that night sworn to nobody at all.⁶³
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *Three great shares claim the Red Hill* (Dùn ìseal). Murchadh Mòr and two other lords of the nine cross the floor at once to claim the ownerless Red Hill. None yields, and none of the three can make the claim stand, that night or in the years that follow.⁶⁴
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *The Hall's ground confirmed in no share* (Dùn ìseal). Aodh Crom reminds the nine, on the night of the handful, that the hill of the slab and the gathering-house and the valley about it, as walked by the keepers, lie in no share, as sworn at the Binding, and are not to be argued afresh.⁶⁵

58. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rìoghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *Eleven knots cut through in one night*, 16 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2.

59. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rìoghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *The western share sworn to Fionnghal nic Ailein*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2.

60. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rìoghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *The salt shore sworn to Artair mac Ailein*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2.

61. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rìoghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *The eastern share sworn to Cormac mac Ailein*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2.

62. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rìoghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *The four lesser shares sworn to Ùna, Coll, Gormlaith and Tadhg*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2.

63. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rìoghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *The cord of the beirs lies in nine pieces*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2.

64. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rìoghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *The Red Hill declares itself sworn to nobody*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2.

65. ¶ Legacy *The Binding of the First Flame*, 23 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *Three great shares claim the Red Hill*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2.

- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *The lengths of cord carried out of the gathering-house* (Dùn iséal). At dawn the nine lords go out through the door of the gathering-house one after another, each with his length of the cord folded or coiled over his arm, and their households follow, so that the valley empties along nine roads at once.⁶⁶
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *The boundary stones cut and set along the Roinn*. Through the winter after the handful the stewards of the nine lines ride the boundaries with the reciters, agreeing what they can, and masons cut and set the clachan-criche, each stone bearing the sign of the share it faces. Some are moved in the night and set again by morning.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2** — *A stone set on each bank at Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). No steward of the north or of the Red Share will yield Dùn thais to the other, so the masons of both lines set a stone on the north bank of the burn below the old fort, cut with Murchadh's sign, and another on the south bank, cut with the sign of the Red Share, and leave the hill itself between the two.⁶⁷
- 24 AN GEARRAN, FE 3** — *Ìomhar Dearg claims the grazing above Dùn thais* (Dùn dhearg). At his own supper-table Ìomhar Dearg tells his grandson Ruairidh Glas that the grazing on the northern slope above Dùn thais belongs to the Red Share, stone or no stone, and that it is time the cattle grazing there under the northern share's sign were driven off it.⁶⁸
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, FE 3** — *First blood among the heirs* (Dùn thais). At Dùn thais, on the line between the great share of the north and the Red Share, the men of Aonghas Bàn mac Mhurchaidh and of Ruairidh Glas of the line of Ìomhar come to blows over which share the fort lies in. Aonghas Bàn is killed. With his death begins Aimhreit nan Oighrean⁶⁹, the strife of the heirs, between the line of Murchadh and the line of Ìomhar and then between many lines.⁷⁰
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, FE 3** — *Aonghas Bàn carried home to his brother's hall* (Dùn thais). Ruairidh Glas's men carry Aonghas Bàn mac Mhurchaidh down off the hill of Dùn thais in a cloak between two spear-shafts, in the rain, and word runs ahead of them to his own household, where his brother Eachann Ruadh is already waiting at the gate.⁷¹
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, FE 3** — *Eachann Ruadh's oath over his brother's body*. Eachann Ruadh mac Mhurchaidh kneels by his brother's body in the yard of their own hall and swears that the blood spilt at Dùn thais will be answered, blood for blood, by his own hand or his sons' after him, without naming the man he means, which by the old custom of the households leaves the quarrel open to a settling short of a second death.⁷²

66. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rìoghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *The Hall's ground confirmed in no share*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2.

67. ← Follows from *The boundary stones cut and set along the Roinn*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2.

68. ← Follows from *A stone set on each bank at Dùn thais*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2.

69. the Strife of the Heirs

70. → Caused by *A stone set on each bank at Dùn thais*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2; → Caused by *Ìomhar Dearg claims the grazing above Dùn thais*, 24 an Gearran, FE 3.

71. ← Follows from *First blood among the heirs*, 17 an Giblean, FE 3; ← Follows from *Ìomhar Dearg claims the grazing above Dùn thais*, 24 an Gearran, FE 3.

- 23 AN CÈITEAN, FE 3** — *Ìomhar Dearg refuses to answer for the killing* (Dùn dhearg). Ìomhar Dearg tells his grandson Ruairidh Glas that he did no more than a man does when his own are threatened, and that he is not to trouble himself with an oath sworn by a boy over his brother's body. The line of Ìomhar makes no answer to Eachann Ruadh's oath.⁷³
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 3** — *The shares parted into countries and provinces*. Under each of the nine great shares the households sworn to it are parted again into countries, and the countries into provinces, as the lines of the king's dead children are fitted in among the living heirs' claims.⁷⁴
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 3** — *Provinces parted again into counties and holdings*. Below the provinces the land is cut finer still, into counties and, under the counties, holdings no larger than a single steading, sworn by whichever household holds them to whatever county's steward stands nearest and troubles to ride out and take the oath.⁷⁵
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 3** — *Holdings sworn to two counties and to three*. A stream that shifts its bed in a wet winter leaves more than one holding claimed by two counties at once, and some households, rather than fight for the difference, swear to both and pay both, and the two counties are slow to compare their rolls.⁷⁶
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 3** — *The three lords of the mill on the Abhainn dhombhain*. Three counties meeting at a bend of the Abhainn dhomhain each claim the eel-catch of an old mill's pond, and the miller, who built the wheel before the Roinn was thought of, takes to paying each lord a third of the autumn catch unasked, and the quarrel goes no further.
- 25 AM MÀRT, FE 4** — *Shares of shares*. The great shares are parted again among their holders' children and grandchildren, into countries, provinces, counties and holdings, until the lesser blood of the portion of the dead is fitted in. Many holdings owe oaths to two lords, and some to three. The boundary stones of the Roinn are set up, and moved, and set up again.⁷⁷
- 21 AN CÈITEAN, FE 4** — *Aodh Crom's charge to the new Keeper* (Dùn ìeal). At the choosing on the slope below the slab, Aodh Crom, eldest of the keepers, holds out a lit rush to Beathag Bhàn and charges her to hold it for Bride and answer to Crom for what is taken from the vein. She says nothing, and the keepers count her silence in her favour.

72. ← Follows from *First blood among the heirs*, 17 an Giblean, FE 3; ← Follows from *Aonghas Bàn carried home to his brother's hall*, 21 an Giblean, FE 3.

73. ← Follows from *First blood among the heirs*, 17 an Giblean, FE 3; ← Follows from *Eachann Ruadh's oath over his brother's body*, 7 an Cèitean, FE 3.

74. ← Follows from *Ìomhar Dearg refuses to answer for the killing*, 23 an Cèitean, FE 3.

75. ← Follows from *The shares parted into countries and provinces*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, FE 3.

76. ← Follows from *Provinces parted again into counties and holdings*, 20 an Lùnastal, FE 3.

77. → Caused by *The boundary stones cut and set along the Roinn*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2; → Caused by *The shares parted into countries and provinces*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, FE 3; ← Leads to *Provinces parted again into counties and holdings*, 20 an Lùnastal, FE 3; ← Leads to *Holdings sworn to two counties and to three*, 5 an t-Sultain, FE 3; ← Leads to *The three lords of the mill on the Abhainn dhombhain*, 21 an t-Sultain, FE 3.

- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 4** — *Beathag Bhàn keeps the first flame* (Dùn ìseal). At Dùn ìseal under the central mountains the keepers of the slab and the households sworn to the Binding choose Beathag Bhàn to hold the first flame for Bride and to answer to Crom for what is taken from the vein. She is of no heir's blood and holds no share, and the heirs let her be chosen for that. The spoken roll of the Keepers begins with her name. Of her life before it nothing is remembered.⁷⁸
- 4 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 4** — *The knot-keepers count forty-four countries* (Dùn ìseal). Riding the boundaries themselves with cords of their own, the knot-keepers of Dùn ìseal come to a count of forty-four countries under the nine great shares, a count that holds for a season before two countries are found to have quietly divided themselves into three apiece.⁷⁹
- 20 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 4** — *The count of a hundred and thirty-one provinces*. The knot-keepers count a hundred and thirty-one provinces under the countries, and hold the number the better part of a year, though even as it is counted two provinces of the eastern share split into three over a fishing-weir.⁸⁰
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 4** — *The knot-keepers give up the count at the counties* (Dùn ìseal). Cairistiona, Sine's eldest daughter, tells Aodh Crom that the counties change their own boundaries faster than any cord can be tied to hold them, and that a knot-keeper who tries to count them all will chase a number that is never the same twice. The count of counties is given up unfinished.⁸¹
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 4** — *A boundary quarrel brought to the Hall's ground* (Dùn ìseal). Stewards of the Red Share and the great share of the north, come to lay a raid and a cattle-theft before the keepers, nearly bring their quarrel armed onto the ground under the mountain. Aodh Crom stands between them and says again that no spear may come onto that ground in anger.⁸²
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 4** — *The heirs go home from the valley* (Dùn ìseal). In the second summer after the stones went up at Dùn thais, the heirs and their households go home from the valley below Dùn ìseal, most of them for the first time in nearly two years without a boundary still openly disputed.⁸³
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 4** — *The flame kept in a turf hut* (Dùn ìseal). With no hall yet raised, the households build Beathag Bhàn a one-room hut of turf at the mountain's foot, and she carries the newly given flame into it and sits up with it through the first night, having found no words to answer the keepers with.⁸⁴

78. → Caused by *Aodh Crom's charge to the new Keeper*, 21 an Cèitean, FE 4.

79. ← Follows from *Shares of shares*, 25 am Màrt, FE 4.

80. ← Follows from *Shares of shares*, 25 am Màrt, FE 4; ← Follows from *The knot-keepers count forty-four countries*, 4 an Lùnastal, FE 4.

81. ← Follows from *Shares of shares*, 25 am Màrt, FE 4; ← Follows from *The count of a hundred and thirty-one provinces*, 20 an t-Sultain, FE 4.

82. ← Follows from *First blood among the heirs*, 17 an Giblean, FE 3; ← Follows from *The knot-keepers give up the count at the counties*, 4 an Dàmhair, FE 4.

83. ← Follows from *Shares of shares*, 25 am Màrt, FE 4; ← Follows from *A boundary quarrel brought to the Hall's ground*, 4 an t-Samhain, FE 4.

- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 5** — *Beathag Bhàn learns the galleries* (Dùn ìseal). Aodh Crom leads Beathag Bhàn down into the low galleries under Dùn ìseal and names them for her one by one, though he will not let her cut the coal herself, telling her that the hand which holds the flame does not also cut the vein.⁸⁵
- 7 AN GEARRAN, FE 6** — *The watch set on the cairns above Cnoc ghlais* (Cnoc ghlais). Beitris, an old keeper of the slab, teaches Beathag Bhàn to read the cloud on the high passes from the cairns above Cnoc ghlais, the sign by which the Hall judges when a gallery may safely be opened for the season.⁸⁶
- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 9** — *The nine districts argue the turn of the hearths* (Dùn ìseal). Before the first season is set, two of the nine districts about the mountain's foot claim the tending of the flame for themselves alone, on the ground that their people sat nearest the old slab the longest, and are outvoted by the other seven.⁸⁷
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 10** — *The nine hearths* (Dùn ìseal). Nine households about the mountain's foot, one for each district of the old keepers of the slab, take the tending of the flame in turn, each sending a son or daughter to sit with it through a season. The later houses of custody all claim descent from one or another of the nine. Not all the claims can be true.⁸⁸
- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 10** — *Cailean of the northern hearth sits the first season* (Dùn ìseal). Cailean, a boy of the northern district, is the first of the nine hearths sent up to sit a season with Beathag Bhàn and the flame, arriving expecting a shrine and finding a cold hut with one keeper barely older than himself.⁸⁹
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 10** — *The first cairns raised above Cnoc ghlais*. Before fixed cairns marked the ridge, watchers of the weather climbed wherever their own eye judged best each morning. An eastern woman, Sorcha, first piles stone at the three places she finds she reads the sky truest, so that watchers after her need not guess afresh each dawn where to stand.
- 10 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 12** — *Niall Òg offers Beathag Bhàn a silver cup* (Dùn ìseal). Niall Òg climbs to the Hall's ground alone and offers Beathag Bhàn a cup of worked silver beaten with running deer, so that she might have one thing of her own.⁹⁰

84. ← Follows from *Beathag Bhàn keeps the first flame*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, FE 4; ← Follows from *Aodh Crom's charge to the new Keeper*, 21 an Cèitean, FE 4.

85. ← Follows from *Beathag Bhàn keeps the first flame*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, FE 4; ← Follows from *The flame kept in a turf hut*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, FE 4.

86. ← Follows from *Beathag Bhàn keeps the first flame*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, FE 4; ← Follows from *Beathag Bhàn learns the galleries*, 12 an t-Samhain, FE 5.

87. ← Follows from *The watch set on the cairns above Cnoc ghlais*, 7 an Gearran, FE 6.

88. → Caused by *The nine districts argue the turn of the hearths*, 9 am Faoilleach, FE 9.

89. ← Follows from *The nine hearths*, 27 an t-Iuchar, FE 10; ← Follows from *The nine districts argue the turn of the hearths*, 9 am Faoilleach, FE 9.

90. ← Follows from *Cailean of the northern hearth sits the first season*, 22 an t-Sultain, FE 10.

- 8 **AN GEARRAN, FE 12** — *Beathag Bhàn refuses the gift* (Dùn ìseal). Beathag Bhàn gives the silver cup back to Niall Òg, saying that whatever she holds she holds for every hand in the valley, and that taking a gift from one heir would oblige her to answer for refusing every other.⁹¹
- 9 **AM MÀRT, FE 13** — *Mòrag nan Càrn named watcher of the ridge*. A child of the fifth hearth who could tell one grey sky from another better than watchers grown old at the work is named, at not yet twenty, to keep the cairns above Cnoc ghlais in her own right, the youngest the mountain has yet trusted with the reading of its weather.⁹²
- 7 **AN GIBLEAN, FE 14** — *The door of Talla na Lasrach*⁹³ *set toward the vein* (Dùn ìseal). Aodh Crom walks the ground of the new hall with Beathag Bhàn before the first stone is laid and marks where its one door must stand, facing the vein and turned from the sea, giving no reason he will afterward repeat the same way twice.⁹⁴
- 19 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 15** — *Talla na Lasrach*⁹⁵ *raised* (Dùn ìseal). A long hall of dry stone and turf is raised over the flame at Dùn ìseal, with one door toward the vein and none toward the sea. It is rebuilt many times on the same footings, and the footings are all of it that anyone can now swear to.⁹⁶
- 25 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 15** — *The nine hearths raise the hall's walls* (Dùn ìseal). Sons and daughters of the nine households build Talla na Lasrach⁹⁷'s walls of dry stone and turf under Beathag Bhàn's eye, each household's work known afterward by the set of its stones, straight where the ninth hearth laid it and less so where the second did.⁹⁸
- 26 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 15** — *Ruairidh Glas and Eachann Ruadh stand at one fire* (Dùn ìseal). At Samhain on the Hall's ground, Ruairidh Glas, who killed Aonghas Bàn at Dùn thais, and Eachann Ruadh, the dead man's brother, stand at opposite sides of the same fire the whole night and speak no word to one another, but neither draws.⁹⁹
- 27 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 15** — *Sine nan Snaidhm ties a knot for good news* (Dùn ìseal). Sine nan Snaidhm comes up to Dùn ìseal for the carrying of the flame into the finished hall and ties a plain unmarked length into her long cord-record, the first knot she has ever tied for good news alone rather than for a claim or a grief.¹⁰⁰

91. ← Follows from *Niall Òg offers Beathag Bhàn a silver cup*, 10 am Faoilleach, FE 12.

92. ← Follows from *The first cairns raised above Cnoc ghlais*, 21 an Dàmhair, FE 10.

93. the Hall of the Flame

94. ← Follows from *Beathag Bhàn refuses the gift*, 8 an Gearran, FE 12.

95. the Hall of the Flame

96. → Caused by *The flame kept in the keepers' but*, 22 an t-Samhain, FE 1; → Caused by *The door of Talla na Lasrach set toward the vein*, 7 an Giblean, FE 14.

97. the Hall of the Flame

98. ← Follows from *Talla na Lasrach raised*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 15; ← Follows from *The door of Talla na Lasrach set toward the vein*, 7 an Giblean, FE 14.

99. ↓ Legacy *First blood among the heirs*, 17 an Giblean, FE 3; ← Follows from *The nine hearths raise the hall's walls*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, FE 15.

100. ← Follows from *Talla na Lasrach raised*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 15; ← Follows from *Ruairidh Glas and Eachann Ruadh stand at one fire*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, FE 15.

- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 15** — *The flame carried into Talla na Lasrach*¹⁰¹ (Dùn iséal). On the shortest day of the year Beathag Bhàn lifts the flame from the hearth-stone of the turf hut that had held it eleven years and carries it into the finished hall, where it burns that evening for the first time under a roof built to hold it.¹⁰²
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 18** — *The reverence about the mountain given a name*. Asked by a walker of the eastern share what the households call the milk left on the sill and the silence kept on the ridge, old Beitris of the Hall answers for them: Seann Spioradan nan Dia-thìreach¹⁰³, the ancestors, the sìth, the vein and the weather held together, owed remembering and courtesy and watching, and needing no priest to speak for any of them.
- 17 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 21** — *Seann Spioradan nan Dia-thìreach*¹⁰⁴ established. At the hearths the eldest of the island's folk-ways takes shape: reverence for the ancestors, for the vein, for the weather that rules the mining season, and for the sìth of the hills and mounds. It keeps no priests, and it has never ceased.¹⁰⁵
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 27** — *The weather-cairns of Cnoc ghlàs* (Cnoc ghlàs). Watchers build cairns on the ridge above Cnoc ghlàs and read the cloud on the high passes from them, to tell the Hall when the galleries may be opened for the season. A wrong reading costs the whole mountain its season, and the watchers are chosen with more care than the Keeper.¹⁰⁶
- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 29** — *Fearchar Glas reads the cloud wrong*. A watcher of six years' standing judges a low grey sky wind only and sends the galleries open; the rain that follows floods the low gallery past saving and costs the households the whole autumn's cutting. Fearchar comes down off the ridge unbidden to tell the keepers of the slab what he did.¹⁰⁷
- 3 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 30** — *The cairns given a stricter choosing*. After the season lost to a wrong reading, the keepers of the slab rule that no one may watch the cairns alone who has not first stood a full season under an elder watcher's eye and been judged fit by more than one. Mòrag nan Càrn sits among those who judge the youths who come after.¹⁰⁸
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 33** — *A boy of Doire uaine chooses the cold over the flint*. In the hardest winter the slopes have seen, a boy sent to bring in a ewe is caught by the wind and found two days later, alive, having refused to strike a fire within sight of the forbidden hills though he carried flint enough. His mother carries him down to the Hall herself rather than risk the road past the standing stones.

101. the Hall of the Flame

102. ← Follows from *Talla na Lasrach raised*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 15; ← Follows from *Sine nan Snaidhm ties a knot for good news*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, FE 15.

103. the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich (the full name)

104. the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich (the full name)

105. → Caused by *The reverence about the mountain given a name*, 30 an Lùnastal, FE 18.

106. → Caused by *The first cairns raised above Cnoc ghlàs*, 21 an Dàmhair, FE 10; → Caused by *Mòrag nan Càrn named watcher of the ridge*, 9 am Màrt, FE 13.

107. → Leads to *The weather-cairns of Cnoc ghlàs*, 22 an Dàmhair, FE 27.

108. ← Follows from *The weather-cairns of Cnoc ghlàs*, 22 an Dàmhair, FE 27; ← Follows from *Fearchar Glas reads the cloud wrong*, 28 an t-Sultain, FE 29.

- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 33** — *The ban on fires in sight of Doire uaine* (Marbh-bhed¹⁰⁹ Doire uaine). In obedience to the old inscriptions the Keepers forbid any fire, of wood or of coal, to be lit in sight of the Doire uaine hills. Herders who winter on those slopes eat cold for the season. The ban is never lifted, and none is known to have owned to breaking it.¹¹⁰
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 33** — *The Hall's hearth opened to the Doire uaine households*. Beathag Bhàn sends word that any household of the forbidden slopes may bring a sick child or a frost-bitten hand to the Keeper's own hearth at Dùn ìseal, the ban forbidding only a fire lit within sight of those hills. Few households make the long journey, but the offer is remembered longer than it is used.¹¹¹
- 1 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 34** — *Beathag Bhàn walks alone to the temple ruin*. Telling no one where she goes, Beathag Bhàn crosses broken ground to Làrach an Teampaill¹¹² and finds its altar-slab, worn by hands no one living can name, turned toward her own mountain. She returns and tells the keepers of the slab plainly that she cannot say whose place it is, only that it is neither Brìde's nor Crom's.¹¹³
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 34** — *Làrach an Teampaill¹¹⁴ left unentered* (Làrach an Teampaill). Beathag Bhàn walks to Làrach an Teampaill, finds its altar already turned toward the mountain, and declares the place not the Hall's to keep. The Keepers set no foot in it for the rest of the age. Whose it was they did not say, and it seems they did not know.¹¹⁵
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 34** — *The keepers swear never to enter the ruin*. After argument over whether the temple ruin should be cleared and watched like the cairns or left untouched, Beathag Bhàn ends it: no keeper of the slab, and no Keeper of the flame after her, will set foot inside it again, a reverence built on courtesy to what it cannot read being no reverence at all if it tramples the ground.¹¹⁶
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 44** — *Death of Beathag Bhàn*. After a winter's slow failing, Beathag Bhàn dies at Dùn ìseal without ever having risen ill from her bed. She is laid on the slope facing the vein with her back to the sea, at Beitris's word, since she never once turned from the mountain living and none will have her do it the one day she cannot choose.¹¹⁷
- 3 AN GEARRAN, FE 44** — *Death of Beathag Bhàn* (Dùn ìseal). Beathag Bhàn dies at Dùn ìseal and is laid on the slope facing the vein, with her back to the sea. The nine hearths choose Muireach Liath, her sister's son, to keep the flame after her.¹¹⁸

109. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

110. → Caused by *A boy of Doire uaine chooses the cold over the flint*, 17 an t-Sultain, FE 33.

111. ← Follows from *The ban on fires in sight of Doire uaine*, 20 an t-Samhain, FE 33; ← Follows from *A boy of Doire uaine chooses the cold over the flint*, 17 an t-Sultain, FE 33.

112. the temple ruin

113. ← Follows from *The Hall's hearth opened to the Doire uaine households*, 20 an Dùbhlachd, FE 33.

114. the temple ruin

115. → Caused by *Beathag Bhàn walks alone to the temple ruin*, 1 am Faoilleach, FE 34.

116. ← Follows from *Làrach an Teampaill left unentered*, 5 am Faoilleach, FE 34; ← Follows from *Beathag Bhàn walks alone to the temple ruin*, 1 am Faoilleach, FE 34.

117. ← Follows from *The keepers swear never to enter the ruin*, 23 an Lùnastal, FE 34.

118. → Caused by *Death of Beathag Bhàn*, 3 am Faoilleach, FE 44.

- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 44** — *Muireach Liath chosen to hold the flame.* The nine hearths gather within the week and name Muireach Liath, Beathag Bhàn's sister's son, faster than any choosing the mountain has seen. Old Beitris puts the rush into his hands with words close to Aodh Crom's own, and he carries the flame into the Hall that same evening.¹¹⁹
- 1 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 45** — *The basket argued to one size.* Muireach Liath asks the nine hearths for a common measure, a lidded basket of plaited heather, one to a household, filled once a season. The households argue the size of it until they have argued themselves into agreeing on one.
- 20 AN GEARRAN, FE 46** — *The weavers of the third hearth take the basket's making.* The plaiting that holds the measured basket's shape under a full load proves particular enough that the weavers of the third hearth keep the craft for their own. Baskets of that weave outlast a season's use before any other household's do.¹²⁰
- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 47** — *A second and third sinking answered* (Caol shean). Two more households of Caol shean come forward with tales like the first woman's, of boats kept whole after a drink of the stream in what each judges the right quarter of the moon. The laughing that met her first telling thins.
- 15 AN GEARRAN, FE 48** — *Coal by the basket* (Dùn ìseal). Muireach Liath fixes the first common measure for coal carried down from the galleries: a lidded basket of plaited heather, one to a household, filled once a season. Baskets of that weave are made at Dùn ìseal still, for no purpose but the making.¹²¹
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 49** — *Muireach walks up to Muileann ruadh* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹²²). In his fourth year Muireach Liath goes up to the warm springs himself rather than let the households' carrying run past him unquestioned, and finds an old woman keeping her granddaughter's ill-set arm a season longer in the water before anyone speaks of breaking it again.
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 52** — *A hearth-elder puts the stream to Muireach* (Allt an Àigh¹²³). One of the hearth-elders who kept the ancestors' watch before Beathag Bhàn's own choosing asks Muireach Liath directly whether a stream running off the vein's own mountain belongs to the Hall's reckoning. His answer, given plainly in a few sentences, is repeated by every Keeper who follows him.¹²⁴

119. ← Follows from *Death of Beathag Bhàn*, 3 an Gearran, FE 44; ← Follows from *Death of Beathag Bhàn*, 3 am Faoilleach, FE 44.

120. ← Follows from *The basket argued to one size*, 1 an Lùnastal, FE 45.

121. → Caused by *The basket argued to one size*, 1 an Lùnastal, FE 45; ← Leads to *The weavers of the third hearth take the basket's making*, 20 an Gearran, FE 46.

122. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

123. the stream of the healing water

124. ← Follows from *Muireach walks up to Muileann ruadh*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, FE 49.

- 17 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 53** — *Allt an Àigh*¹²⁵ *named* (Allt an Àigh). A stream is held to bring good fortune to any who drink of it in a certain quarter of the moon. Pilgrims come to it, and have never wholly ceased to come.¹²⁶
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, FE 53** — *Gille-Bride dies in the high valleys*. Gille-Bride of Somhairle's line, who carried a coal of the First Flame home from the Binding and asked for nothing since, dies among his own people at two hundred and twenty-four, in an early winter hard on the hill-folk of Coille naomh.¹²⁷
- 30 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 53** — *Ceallach keeps the coal*. Ceallach mac Ghille-Bhrìde takes up his father's hearth and the coal of the First Flame kept on it, changing nothing the hill-folk who sit by that fire can name, since he had been feeding it quietly on his father's behalf for years before.¹²⁸
- 4 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 53** — *Niall Òg sits an evening at Ceallach's hearth*. Niall Òg goes up alone to the high valleys on hearing of Gille-Bride's death, and finds, for the first time in sixty years of burying his father's kin, a death that leaves him nothing to feel bitter about.¹²⁹
- 14 AN GIBLEAN, FE 57** — *The pilgrims' path from Caol shean* (Caol shean). A path is worn from the river landing at Caol shean up the valley to Allt an Àigh¹³⁰. It is walked by night, so that pilgrims reach the water in the right quarter of the moon. Fishermen who walk it are said to lose fewer boats; no count was kept either way.
- 16 AM MÀRT, FE 59** — *The Hall declines the stream* (Allt an Àigh¹³¹). Muireach Liath rules that Allt an Àigh belongs to the ancestors and the weather and not to the vein, and that the Hall will not keep it. Here the Keepers' rite and the older folk reverence first plainly part, and each side afterwards cites the ruling as proof that it was right.¹³²
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, FE 64** — *Murchadh Mòr dies at Baile Mòr mhòr*. Murchadh Mòr, eldest of Ailean's living sons and the first knotted on Sine's cord, dies at his own seat close on three thousand years old, having outlived every one of his generation but Eithne and a scattering of the youngest.¹³³
- 26 AN GEARRAN, FE 65** — *Eleven knives for the north*. Murchadh Mòr's eleven sons, none by the same mother, divide the great share of the north among themselves with a knife to each of the north's chief holdings, over eleven nights of arguing which hall goes with which knife.¹³⁴

125. the stream of the healing water

126. → Caused by *A second and third sinking answered*, 22 am Faoilleach, FE 47.

127. ⇌ At the same time *Coal by the basket*, 15 an Gearran, FE 48.

128. ← Follows from *Coal by the basket*, 15 an Gearran, FE 48; ← Follows from *Gille-Bride dies in the high valleys*, 2 an Giblean, FE 53.

129. ← Follows from *Coal by the basket*, 15 an Gearran, FE 48; ← Follows from *Ceallach keeps the coal*, 30 an t-Ògmhios, FE 53.

130. the stream of the healing water

131. the stream of the healing water

132. → Caused by *A hearth-elder puts the stream to Muireach*, 28 am Faoilleach, FE 52.

133. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1; ← Follows from *Niall Òg sits an evening at Ceallach's hearth*, 4 an Dùbhlachd, FE 53.

- 27 AM MÀRT, FE 65** — *Lachlann Mòr takes Baile Mòr mhòr*. The eldest of Murchadh Mòr's eleven sons is given his father's own seat and its name with less argument than the rest of the division, none of his brothers wanting the weight of a hall so long held.¹³⁵
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 65** — *Donnchadh Iar disputes the western glens*. The fourth of Murchadh Mòr's sons wins the western glens only after the longest argument of the whole division, and goes on calling the settlement unjust for years after.¹³⁶
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 65** — *The north's counties too small for twenty spears*. What comes out of Baile Mòr mhòr's last division is a floor of small halls, none able to raise so much as twenty spears alone, a smallness the tellers already read as proof the long-lived blood was fading fastest from that line.¹³⁷
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 66** — *The sick carried to Muileann ruadh* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹³⁸). The sick are carried up in litters to the warm springs below Muileann ruadh and bathed at dawn. The Keepers allow it, for the heat of the water comes from the mountain and no one breaks the stone for it.¹³⁹
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, FE 67** — *Eachann Ruadh raids the Red Share's cattle*. Eachann Ruadh rides a dozen men across the boundary stones into the Red Share's northern grazing and drives off near forty head before the alarm is fully raised, the old feud from Dùn thais finding a fresh grievance to spend itself on.¹⁴⁰
- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 67** — *Muireach refuses the Hall's ground to the cattle*. Asked to shelter the Red Share's recovered cattle on the Hall's own ground, Muireach Liath refuses, ruling that the ground was sworn to keep a man safe from a knife and never to make holy ground of every quarrel brought to his door.¹⁴¹
- 26 AN GEARRAN, FE 69** — *A grey stone found apart from the vein* (Muileann chiar). A shepherd of the ninth hearth, hunting a ewe caught in bracken a few miles north of Dùn iséal, finds a grey stone with a bright wound where her stick scraped the moss away and carries it down out of curiosity. It sits on a sill at Dùn iséal a season, turned over by whoever passes, before anyone thinks to put fire to it.

134. ⇌ At the same time *Roinn na Rioghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *Murchadh Mòr dies at Baile Mòr mhòr*, 24 an Cèitean, FE 64.

135. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rioghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *Eleven knives for the north*, 26 an Gearran, FE 65.

136. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rioghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *Lachlann Mòr takes Baile Mòr mhòr*, 27 am Màrt, FE 65.

137. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rioghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2.

138. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

139. → Caused by *Muireach walks up to Muileann ruadh*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, FE 49.

140. ⇌ At the same time *Shares of shares*, 25 am Màrt, FE 4.

141. ⇌ At the same time *First blood among the heirs*, 17 an Giblean, FE 3.

- 21 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 69** — *Fearchar Airgeadach smelts the first bead* (Muileann chiar). Fearchar, a basket-carrier of the ninth hearth who has spent three winters tending the vein's fires, builds his own fire apart from the Hall on the spur where the stone was found and feeds it through a day and half a night. Old Tormod, dozing beside him, wakes to find a bead of soft bright metal in Fearchar's hand that answers to no fire the Hall has ever kept.¹⁴²
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 69** — *Muileann chiar named* (Muileann chiar). Within a month Fearchar has raised a proper furnace of clay and dry stone on the spur and is hammering beads into rings. The households of the ninth hearth call the place Muileann chiar, the dark mill, after the smoke that hangs over it of a still morning, unmindful of the older place of that name far to the east.¹⁴³
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 70** — *Muireach Liath rules the silver shows no blood* (Muileann chiar). Asked whether the new metal falls under the flame, Muireach Liath presses a ring's softest edge with his thumbnail, finds no colour beneath the break as a coal always shows, and rules that the Hall has no claim on a thing that shows no colour when it breaks. Fearchar is left free to dig on, and to keep or give what he digs.¹⁴⁴
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 71** — *Muileann chiar founded* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). A seam of silver is found near the great vein but apart from it. It is the first wealth of the island other than the coal.¹⁴⁵
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 71** — *The first ring set out for Goibhniu* (Muileann chiar). Fearchar takes up the custom of setting the first ring off every new furnace whole on a flat stone at the mouth of the workings, an offering to Goibhniu, before a second ring is begun. No furnace of his ever fails in its first season, which the smiths of Muileann chiar take as proof the god has taken the offerings kindly.¹⁴⁶
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 74** — *Fearchar Airgeadach works the silver* (Muileann chiar). Fearchar Airgeadach, a basket-carrier of the nine hearths, is the first known to smelt the silver of Muileann chiar and hammer it into rings. His furnace burns wood and peat. It is the first fire on the island that answers to no one in the Hall.¹⁴⁷
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 74** — *Silver is not holy* (Muileann chiar). Asked whether the new seam falls under the flame, Muireach Liath answers that silver shows no colour when it breaks and so is not the mountain's. Muileann chiar is left free to dig as deep as it likes, and it digs. Every later quarrel over the silver begins from these words.¹⁴⁸

142. ← Follows from *A grey stone found apart from the vein*, 26 an Gearran, FE 69.

143. ← Follows from *Fearchar Airgeadach smelts the first bead*, 21 an t-Iuchar, FE 69.

144. ← Follows from *Muileann chiar named*, 19 an Lùnastal, FE 69.

145. → Caused by *A grey stone found apart from the vein*, 26 an Gearran, FE 69.

146. ← Follows from *Muireach Liath rules the silver shows no blood*, 28 am Faoilleach, FE 70.

147. → Caused by *Fearchar Airgeadach smelts the first bead*, 21 an t-Iuchar, FE 69; ← Leads to *Muileann chiar named*, 19 an Lùnastal, FE 69; ← Leads to *The first ring set out for Goibhniu*, 6 an Dùbhlachd, FE 71.

148. → Caused by *Muireach Liath rules the silver shows no blood*, 28 am Faoilleach, FE 70.

- 27 AM MÀRT, FE 75** — *Two cousins of the eastern share claim the silver ground* (Muileann chiar). Grandsons of one grandfather through different daughters, whose households have shared an unremarkable boundary along a dry burn since their grandfather's day, each send word to Dùn ìseal within days of the other, swearing the spur of Fearchar's furnaces lies on his own side of the burn. The keepers of the slab find the seam outside their reach to judge and send the cousins back to settle it themselves.¹⁴⁹
- 9 AN GEARRAN, FE 76** — *Fearchar pays a ring to each cousin* (Muileann chiar). Weary of digging under a dispute he did not start, Fearchar offers a ring from the season's working to each of the two cousins, on condition that both let the digging go on undisturbed while their elders argue the boundary. Both take the ring, neither gladly, and the quarrel is settled within the year by a boundary stone the two households cut and raise together at the driest point of the burn.¹⁵⁰
- 11 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 77** — *The first ring traded at Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). A carrier of the ninth hearth strikes the first known trade of a ring against a whole boatload of salted fish and sealskin at the river quays of Ros fhionn. The measure holds for every later bargain on the quay, so that a boatman naming a price says simply "a ring's worth" and is understood without further reckoning.
- 7 AN GEARRAN, FE 79** — *Death of Ceallach mac Ghille-Bhrìde*. Ceallach, who has kept the coal of the First Flame in the high valleys since his father Gille-Bhrìde's death, dies in his sleep at the age of a hundred and forty, the last of Somhairle's line in whom the long years still showed. His household carries the coal down to the Hall's own flame; his children leave the high valleys within the year and settle among the lower hearths.¹⁵¹
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 84** — *Silver for salt at Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). Carriers take rings of Muileann chiar down to the river quays at Ros fhionn and trade them for salt fish and sealskin, one ring for a boatload. It is the first trade in anything but food, and the first whose price is remembered.¹⁵²
- 16 AM MÀRT, FE 89** — *Three candidates passed over for the flame* (Dùn ìseal). On Muireach Liath's death the nine hearths weigh three households' candidates at length: a steady grandson of the sixth hearth, a daughter of the third hearth whose grandmother helped choose Beathag Bhàn, and Muireach's own nephew of the ninth hearth. All three are passed over in favour of Muireach's daughter Gormshuil, chosen on the work alone.¹⁵³
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, FE 89** — *Death of Muireach Liath* (Dùn ìseal). Muireach Liath dies at Dùn ìseal, keeping the flame. The nine hearths pass over three of other lines and choose his daughter Gormshuil nic Mhuirich. After her the Keeper's office stays in the house of Muireach for many generations.¹⁵⁴

149. ← Follows from *Silver is not holy*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 74.

150. ← Follows from *Silver is not holy*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 74; ← Follows from *Two cousins of the eastern share claim the silver ground*, 27 an Màrt, FE 75.

151. ⇌ At the same time *Muileann chiar founded*, 23 an t-Sultain, FE 71.

152. → Caused by *The first ring traded at Ros fhionn*, 11 an Faoilleach, FE 77.

153. ← Follows from *Death of Ceallach mac Ghille-Bhrìde*, 7 an Gearran, FE 79.

- 21 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 89** — *Muireach's nephew goes to the furnaces* (Muileann chiar). Passed over for the flame on the strength of blood alone, Muireach Liath's nephew of the ninth hearth goes north within the year to take up work at one of Fearchar's furnaces at Muileann chiar, where he is said to prosper a good deal more than he might have as a Keeper chosen by kinship rather than by the households' own will.¹⁵⁵
- II AN T-SULTAIN, FE 96** — *Sliochd Mhuirich*¹⁵⁶ *named* (Dùn iséal). The kin of Gormshuil nic Mhuirich at Dùn iséal begin to be called Sliochd Mhuirich, the house of Muireach, the first house of custody known by a name and not by a hearth. No account that survives tells of the other eight hearths objecting.
- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 97** — *Sileas counts the coal's colours* (Muileann chiar). At the far-eastern Muileann chiar, Sileas nic Coinnich begins counting which strokes of her own pick break the vein bright with colour and which break it plain dull coal, and notices the bright breaks come to no cutter's hand alone, not even her own, on every shift.
- 14 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 98** — *Sileas's mother warns against the asking* (Muileann chiar). Sileas's mother, who cut the same wall before her, tells her that a question put to the vein is better left unput, and that the mountain has fed the house four generations without being asked why. Sileas holds her tongue, but not her counting.¹⁵⁷
- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 100** — *Sileas moved from wall to wall* (Muileann chiar). The overseer of Muileann chiar's galleries, wearying of a cutter who tries the coal's answer against fasting, singing and the hour of the day, moves Sileas nic Coinnich from wall to wall until no face is left that has not already been asked her questions.¹⁵⁸
- II AN LÙNASTAL, FE 101** — *Sileas withdraws to the holy wood* (Muileann chiar). Sileas nic Coinnich goes up into Coille Naomh Muileann chiar¹⁵⁹ meaning only to sit and think, and finds three cutters of her own galleries have followed her there unasked, each carrying the same unspoken question from the face.¹⁶⁰
- IO AN DÀMHAIR, FE 103** — *The first school of the druids founded*. The first of the Scoiltean nan Draoidhean¹⁶¹, the druid schools, gathers about one question: why the vein answers some hands and not others. For the first time within the Old Faith the coal is reasoned about, and not only revered.

154. → Caused by *Three candidates passed over for the flame*, 16 am Màrt, FE 89.

155. ← Follows from *Death of Muireach Liath*, 30 an Cèitean, FE 89; ← Follows from *Three candidates passed over for the flame*, 16 am Màrt, FE 89.

156. the house of Muireach

157. ← Follows from *Sileas counts the coal's colours*, 13 an t-Iuchar, FE 97.

158. ← Follows from *Sileas's mother warns against the asking*, 14 an t-Ògmhios, FE 98.

159. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

160. ← Follows from *Sileas moved from wall to wall*, 9 an t-Sultain, FE 100.

161. the druid schools

- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 103** — *Forty gather in the clearing* (Muileann chiar). Two springs after the first evening in the wood, near forty cutters, basket-carriers and children of the overseer's own house sit in the clearing above Muileann chiar to hear Sileas nic Coinnich set out her counting, more than the old fallen trunk she taught from can seat.¹⁶²
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 110** — *Sileas nic Coinnich in the wood* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar¹⁶³). Sileas nic Coinnich, a cutter from Muileann chiar in the far east, begins to teach in Coille Naomh Muileann chiar. At the galleries she had seen the coal break bright with its colours under some cutters' picks and dull under others, and she will not let the question be.¹⁶⁴
- 8 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 112** — *A bearer walks a fortnight to the wood* (Muileann chiar). A woman of the northern shore, having heard a story of a stag grown taller with every telling between her home and the wood, walks a fortnight to sit in Sileas's clearing, and is told plainly that the counting, not the stag, is the whole of what is taught there.¹⁶⁵
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 118** — *The stag in the grove* (Muileann chiar). The hearers of Sileas nic Coinnich at Muileann chiar name themselves the stag's people, for a stag said to have stood in the grove through a whole lesson. The school's later name, the stag's name Camaran, and the telling that it was the white stag of Flidais, lady of the deer, are found first in writings far younger than these days.¹⁶⁶
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 121** — *Ìomhar Dearg killed at the ford*. Riding to see a moved boundary stone on the Red Share's northern march, Ìomhar Dearg is speared through the throat at the ford of the Abhainn dhomhain by Eachann Ruadh mac Mhurchaidh, in payment for Aonghas Bàn's death at Dùn thais sixty years before. His riders bring him from the water dead.¹⁶⁷
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 121** — *The Red Share held whole under Dughall Dearg* (Dùn dhearg). Dughall Dearg mac Ìomhair takes up the Red Share entire the week his father is buried, and tells the four lines who come to Dùn dhearg with old claims that the share was won with a sword and will be kept with one. None presses a claim against his household.¹⁶⁸

162. ← Follows from *Sileas withdraws to the holy wood*, 11 an Lùnastal, FE 101.

163. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

164. → Caused by *Sileas counts the coal's colours*, 13 an t-Iuchar, FE 97; ← Leads to *Sileas's mother warns against the asking*, 14 an t-Ògmhios, FE 98; ← Leads to *Sileas moved from wall to wall*, 9 an t-Sultain, FE 100; ← Leads to *Sileas withdraws to the holy wood*, 11 an Lùnastal, FE 101.

165. ← Follows from *Forty gather in the clearing*, 19 an t-Samhain, FE 103.

166. → Caused by *Forty gather in the clearing*, 19 an t-Samhain, FE 103; ← Leads to *A bearer walks a fortnight to the wood*, 8 an Dàmhair, FE 112.

167. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rioghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2.

168. ← Follows from *Roinn na Rioghachd*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2; ← Follows from *Ìomhar Dearg killed at the ford*, 3 am Faoilleach, FE 121.

- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 122 — *Eachann Ruadh flees to the Hall's ground* (Dùn ìseal). Eachann Ruadh mac Mhurchaidh rides through the night from the ford to the ground before the Hall of the Flame, throws down his second spear, and sits within sight of Bride's fire until the Keeper's cutters come out to him, asking the ground and nothing of the flame itself.¹⁶⁹
- 8 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 122 — *Gormshuil rules the Hall's ground holds even a killer* (Dùn ìseal). Gormshuil nic Mhuirich rules that no spear may follow Eachann Ruadh mac Mhurchaidh past the Hall's boundary stone, though what waits for him beyond it is not hers to answer for, and lets him raise a hut at the ground's edge to cut turf for the Hall's own fires.¹⁷⁰
- 12 AN GIBLEAN, FE 123 — *A loaned cutter's report reaches Gormshuil* (Dùn ìseal). A cutter of Dùn ìseal's own galleries, home from a season's loan to Muileann chiar, tells the Hall in passing that the eastern cutters count their strokes and ask why the coal answers one hand and not another. Gormshuil sends her own cutter east to see the wood for herself.¹⁷¹
- 11 AN CÈITEAN, FE 124 — *Sileas summoned to Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Gormshuil nic Mhuirich summons Sileas nic Coinnich to Dùn ìseal, and the two speak alone in the keepers' hut by the flame Beathag Bhàn once held. Neither afterwards gives a full account of what passed between them; only the ruling that follows is known.¹⁷²
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, FE 125 — *The Hall shuts the galleries to the stag's people* (Dùn ìseal). Gormshuil nic Mhuirich forbids the hearers of Sileas to cut in the galleries of Dùn ìseal, holding that a question asked of the vein is a demand made of it. The stag's people keep their school in the east and send no cutters to the mountain for a long while after.¹⁷³
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 125 — *The eastern cutters walk further into the hills* (Muileann chiar). After the galleries of Dùn ìseal are shut to them, a dozen of Sileas nic Coinnich's oldest hearers walk east out of Muileann chiar to raise a house of their own further from the mountain's shadow, following the wood where it thickens and the seam where it runs deeper.¹⁷⁴
- 14 AM MÀRT, FE 127 — *Gormshuil nic Mhuirich dies at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Gormshuil, Keeper after Muireach Liath for thirty-eight years, dies in the small room off the Hall at the age of eighty-seven, her cutter's daughter and Fionnlagh Dall at her bedside. Her last words are a complaint about the cold of the room rather than any ruling, and the household keeps the telling of it fondly afterward.¹⁷⁵

169. ⇔ At the same time *Sileas nic Coinnich in the wood*, 8 an t-Samhain, FE 110; ← Follows from *The Red Share held whole under Dúghall Dearg*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, FE 121.

170. ← Follows from *Sileas nic Coinnich in the wood*, 8 an t-Samhain, FE 110; ← Follows from *Eachann Ruadh flees to the Hall's ground*, 9 an t-Ògmhios, FE 122.

171. → Leads to *The stag in the grove*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, FE 118; ← Follows from *Gormshuil rules the Hall's ground holds even a killer*, 8 an t-Iuchar, FE 122.

172. ← Follows from *A loaned cutter's report reaches Gormshuil*, 12 an Giblean, FE 123.

173. → Caused by *Sileas summoned to Dùn ìseal*, 11 an Cèitean, FE 124.

174. ← Follows from *The Hall shuts the galleries to the stag's people*, 18 an Cèitean, FE 125; ← Follows from *Sileas summoned to Dùn ìseal*, 11 an Cèitean, FE 124.

175. ← Follows from *The Hall shuts the galleries to the stag's people*, 18 an Cèitean, FE 125.

- 15 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 128** — *Fionnlagh Dall chosen Keeper* (Dùn ìseal). The nine hearths choose Fionnlagh, blind since a childhood fever and a sitter with the flame for thirty years, over a cutter of the fourth hearth and Gormshuil's own niece, on the argument of the niece's household that his hands judge a measure more truly than a sighted man's. He is thirty-eight years old, the first blind Keeper the island has known.¹⁷⁶
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 128** — *Calum Beag begins leading the blind Keeper* (Dùn ìseal). A boy of ten who has followed Fionnlagh about the Hall since he could walk is brought to him by his own mother and asked to guide him through the galleries, on the one condition that he keep a Keeper's silence about what he sees there. He agrees at once, and the two go about Dùn ìseal together from that day.¹⁷⁷
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 131** — *A household at Cnoc dhubh burns by the basketful* (Cnoc dhubh). In a bitter winter a household of the high ground above Cnoc dhubh, its measured handful not enough to warm three children and an old woman through the worst nights, burns the coal by the basketful instead, a measure no household has burned before. The smoke lies down in the still valley air and will not lift.¹⁷⁸
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 132** — *The smoke at Cnoc dhubh* (Cnoc dhubh). In a hard winter a household at Cnoc dhubh burns its coal by the basketful and not by the handful. The smoke settles in the valley, and three of the household and two neighbours die of it. The Keepers are sent for, and the case is argued at Dùn ìseal for the rest of the season.¹⁷⁹
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 132** — *Five die of the smoke at Cnoc dhubh* (Cnoc dhubh). Three of the burning household, a grandmother of the house beside it, and a neighbour's infant carried past the settling smoke are dead within three nights. Calum Beag carries the word to Fionnlagh, who goes up to the valley himself before any council is called.¹⁸⁰
- 30 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 132** — *The season of argument at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). The dead household's kin argue that a law which lets a house freeze rather than burn what the mountain holds in plenty is no law worth keeping; the other eight hearths, frightened by what one family's basketful did to two houses that burned nothing at all, argue the measure must hold unargued or hold not at all. Fionnlagh gives no ruling for the better part of two months.¹⁸¹

176. ← Follows from *The Hall shuts the galleries to the stag's people*, 18 an Cèitean, FE 125; ← Follows from *Gormshuil nic Mbuirich dies at Dùn ìseal*, 14 am Màrt, FE 127.

177. ← Follows from *Fionnlagh Dall chosen Keeper*, 15 am Faoilleach, FE 128.

178. ← Follows from *Calum Beag begins leading the blind Keeper*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, FE 128.

179. ← Leads to *A household at Cnoc dhubh burns by the basketful*, 20 an Dàmhair, FE 131.

180. ← Follows from *The smoke at Cnoc dhubh*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, FE 132; ← Follows from *A household at Cnoc dhubh burns by the basketful*, 20 an Dàmhair, FE 131.

181. ← Follows from *The smoke at Cnoc dhubh*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, FE 132; ← Follows from *Five die of the smoke at Cnoc dhubh*, 28 an Dàmhair, FE 132.

- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 138** — *Calum Beag finds the grey stone* (Dùn ìseal). Sent into the hills above Dùn ìseal to find stone hard, fine-grained and free of any crack, Calum Beag returns three days later with a cutter of the fourth hearth and a slab slung between two poles. Fionnlagh spends the better part of a month testing it by hand before he lets the chisel near it.¹⁸²
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 138** — *The stone cup cut to two palms* (Dùn ìseal). Fionnlagh has the new cup cut hollow to the exact measure of his own two hands cupped together, palm to palm, trusting his own hands to be the one instrument that never changes. He tests the fill again and again by touch alone until he can judge a hair's difference against the stone's cold lip.¹⁸³
- 15 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 139** — *Fionnlagh Dall and the stone cup* (Dùn ìseal). Fionnlagh Dall, Keeper after Gormshuil, has the old keepers' stone cup cut anew in grey stone to hold just what a cupped pair of hands will hold, and sets it for the measure on the threshold of Talla na Lasrach¹⁸⁴ at Dùn ìseal. He is blind, and fills it by touch before the council, and none can say afterwards that he favoured anyone's hands.¹⁸⁵
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 139** — *The cup set on the threshold* (Dùn ìseal). Rather than keep the new cup within the Hall where a favoured keeper's hand might reach it first, Fionnlagh sets it on the worn threshold stone of Talla na Lasrach¹⁸⁶, in the open, where any household or its neighbour can see the measure given. He finds the threshold's true centre by walking it barefoot.¹⁸⁷
- 15 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 139** — *An old woman of the fourth hearth trusts the measure* (Dùn ìseal). The first household to bring its claim to the new cup is a poor one, its elder's hands shaking with palsy. Fionnlagh fills the cup by touch, says "Enough" when the measure is met, and closes his hand over its lip. She weeps at a fairness she says she has not trusted from a sighted keeper in three years.¹⁸⁸
- 19 AN CÈITEAN, FE 142** — *The lords swear the Small-Burning Law* (Dùn ìseal). At the Samhain gathering the lords of every share, grumbling but pressed by the memory of Cnoc dhubbh and the weeping woman of the fourth hearth, swear the measured handful into a law binding on every share alike, each laying a hand on the stone cup itself. It is the first law the island has ever kept the same in every share.¹⁸⁹

182. ← Follows from *The season of argument at Dùn ìseal*, 30 an Dàmhair, FE 132.

183. ← Follows from *Calum Beag finds the grey stone*, 19 an Lùnastal, FE 138.

184. the Hall of the Flame

185. → Caused by *Fionnlagh Dall chosen Keeper*, 15 am Faoilleach, FE 128; → Caused by *Calum Beag begins leading the blind Keeper*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, FE 128; → Caused by *The season of argument at Dùn ìseal*, 30 an Dàmhair, FE 132; → Caused by *Calum Beag finds the grey stone*, 19 an Lùnastal, FE 138; ← Leads to *The stone cup cut to two palms*, 17 an t-Sultain, FE 138.

186. the Hall of the Flame

187. ← Follows from *Fionnlagh Dall and the stone cup*, 15 an t-Iuchar, FE 139; ← Follows from *The stone cup cut to two palms*, 17 an t-Sultain, FE 138.

188. ← Follows from *Fionnlagh Dall and the stone cup*, 15 an t-Iuchar, FE 139; ← Follows from *The cup set on the threshold*, 9 an Dàmhair, FE 139.

189. ← Follows from *An old woman of the fourth hearth trusts the measure*, 15 an Dàmhair, FE 139.

- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 142** — *The Small-Burning Law*. The custom of the handful is made law: no household may burn more than a measured handful of the coal in a season. It becomes the holy law of the Keepers of Bride's flame and Crom's stone, and it holds for centuries.¹⁹⁰
- 1 AN CÈITEAN, FE 145** — *The first sentence under the Law* (Seann Tarr). A household of Seann Tarr burns twice its measure in a season and loses its right to the coal for the season after, the first sentence given under the Small-Burning Law. Its name is set on the roll with the offence beside it, and for many centuries its descendants petition to have the offence struck out.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 145** — *Seann Tarr sentenced under the new law* (Seann Tarr). A fishing household of Seann Tarr, its catch ruined by wet weather, burns twice its measure to save its dried fish and is the first sentenced under the Small-Burning Law: it loses its right to the coal for the season following, its name and offence set on the roll. Fionnlagh gives the ruling with real reluctance.¹⁹¹
- 1 AN GIBLEAN, FE 148** — *The question of the beacon at Tobar dhearg* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg¹⁹²). A fisherman of the southern coast asks the council whether a beacon lit to warn strangers off the rocks, and no household's own hearth, should be counted against a household's handful at all. Fionnlagh takes the better part of a day alone with the stone cup before he answers.¹⁹³
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, FE 148** — *No coal on the beacons* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg¹⁹⁴). The Keepers rule that no coal may feed a beacon, since a beacon burns for strangers. The fire on the headland at Tobar dhearg is kept with driftwood and seal fat, and so are all the sea-lights of the island after it.¹⁹⁵
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 148** — *Driftwood and seal fat light the sea-lights* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg¹⁹⁶). Fionnlagh rules that no coal may feed a beacon meant for strangers, since the vein answers to the island's own and to no boat that might never touch its shore. The beacon at Tobar dhearg is kept after with driftwood and rendered seal fat, and every sea-light raised on the island after it is kept the same way.¹⁹⁷

190. → Caused by *The lords swear the Small-Burning Law*, 19 an Cèitean, FE 142.

191. ← Follows from *The first sentence under the Law*, 1 an Cèitean, FE 145; ← Follows from *The lords swear the Small-Burning Law*, 19 an Cèitean, FE 142.

192. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

193. ← Follows from *Seann Tarr sentenced under the new law*, 21 an Lùnastal, FE 145.

194. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

195. → Caused by *The question of the beacon at Tobar dhearg*, 1 an Giblean, FE 148.

196. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

197. ← Follows from *No coal on the beacons*, 30 an Cèitean, FE 148; ← Follows from *The question of the beacon at Tobar dhearg*, 1 an Giblean, FE 148.

- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 149** — *Ailean Clachair takes on the steps to Ceann chaol* (Ceann chaol). The council at Dùn ìseal asks the nine hearths' cutters whether any will cut a proper path down the steep mile above the harbour of Ceann chaol, where carriers going down sideways on bare rock have turned more ankles than the Hall has troubled to count. Ailean Clachair, a cutter of the fourth hearth four and twenty years old, steps forward first.
- 4 AM MÀRT, FE 151** — *The carriers' path to Ceann chaol* (Ceann chaol). A carriers' path is cut from the mountain down to the harbour of Ceann chaol, with steps hewn at the steep places. The Hall's baskets go down it to the southern households, and the dried fish of the south comes up.¹⁹⁸
- 23 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 151** — *The steps to Ceann chaol are finished* (Ceann chaol). After two years of work by Ailean Clachair and six others of the fourth hearth, the stepped path down to the harbour of Ceann chaol is finished, cut stone where the rock allows a step and fitted stone where it does not. A carrier with a full basket can go down to the harbour on a wet morning without setting a hand to the rock.¹⁹⁹
- 7 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 154** — *Eleven carriers drown at the ford of the Abhainn dhombhain*. A party of eleven carriers bound south with the Hall's baskets crosses the ford of the Abhainn dhomhain on a night of hard rain, led by Beathag nan Cliabh on her own word that the rising water looks no worse than a flood she remembers from her youth. The river rises over a tall man's head before the last of them is across; only the one carrier who turned back at the water's edge survives to carry word of it.
- 3 AN GEARRAN, FE 154** — *The carriers drowned on the Abhainn dhombhain* (Abhainn dhomhain). The Abhainn dhomhain rises in the night and takes eleven carriers and their baskets at a ford. The Hall mourns the coal with the carriers, and Fionnlagh Dall asks the council for a way across that the river cannot take.²⁰⁰
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, FE 154** — *The Hall sets the names of the drowned upon its roll* (Dùn ìseal). Fionnlagh Dall has the eleven names read to him twice before he will let the roll be closed, among them Beathag nan Cliabh, Griogair mac Ailig, Sineag nighean Dhonnchaidh, and a boy the roll gives only as young Tormod of the salt shore, who went on the crossing in place of an uncle whose knee had gone bad in the wet.²⁰¹
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 154** — *The carriers' joke of the mourned coal*. The carriers who come after the drowning make a joke of their own grief, saying the Hall mourns its coal along with its dead, since eleven baskets went into the river with the eleven who carried them. Fionnlagh, hearing it repeated to him, does not rebuke it, and says a mountain that measures its coal so carefully may be allowed to grieve a basketful lost the same way its people grieve a life.²⁰²

198. → Caused by *Ailean Clachair takes on the steps to Ceann chaol*, 28 am Faoilleach, FE 149.

199. ← Follows from *The carriers' path to Ceann chaol*, 4 am Màrt, FE 151; ← Follows from *Ailean Clachair takes on the steps to Ceann chaol*, 28 am Faoilleach, FE 149.

200. → Caused by *Eleven carriers drown at the ford of the Abhainn dhombhain*, 7 am Faoilleach, FE 154.

201. ← Follows from *The carriers drowned on the Abhainn dhombhain*, 3 an Gearran, FE 154.

- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 154** — *Fionnlagh asks the council for a crossing the river cannot take* (Dùn iséal). Fionnlagh brings the drowning before the council within the fortnight and asks for a crossing the Abhainn dhomhain cannot take in any weather. An elder of the southern hearths argues the river's risk is no worse than any ordinary misfortune; Fionnlagh answers that he asked only whether the risk could be made smaller, and asks who can name him a mason proved against water and weight.²⁰³
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 155** — *Ailean Clachair is charged with the crossing at Ros fhionn* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). The council calls Ailean Clachair, whose steps above Ceann chaol a wet winter has not yet broken, and charges him with a single stone span above Ros fhionn, where the river runs narrower and its banks stand higher and firmer than anywhere else along its reach. Ailean answers that he does not know whether such a span can be built at all, but will try rather than tell a Keeper who has just buried eleven carriers that it cannot.²⁰⁴
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 156** — *Ailean gathers the forty of the nine hearths* (Ros fhionn). Over a winter Ailean draws forty cutters and masons from the nine hearths, none of whom has ever cut anything meant to hold a river's weight rather than a roof's. They quarry grey stone near Ros fhionn and spend a season learning how stone cut to a wedge's shape leans upon its neighbours and holds itself up by leaning.²⁰⁵
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 157** — *The first bridges* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg²⁰⁶). Stone crossings begin to join the mining paths of the interior to the coast. From them in time come Drochaid Cathair dhearg and Drochaid Ros fhionn.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 158** — *Aonghas Beag falls on the centring* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). In the sixth week of the building, a mason of the ninth hearth named Aonghas Beag puts a foot wrong on wet timber and is caught at the edge of the fall by two others. Ailean keeps him off the scaffold for two days, saying a mason frightened in his own body cuts stone worse than one who has never learned fear.²⁰⁷
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 160** — *Ailean Clachair's crossing at Ros fhionn* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). Ailean Clachair and forty masons of the nine hearths bridge the river above Ros fhionn with a single span of fitted stone, from which Drochaid Ros fhionn descends. Ailean sets a hearth-sign in the keystone. Every bridge the masons build after bears one, and a bridge without it is not trusted.²⁰⁸

202. ← Follows from *The carriers drowned on the Abhainn dhomhain*, 3 an Gearran, FE 154; ← Follows from *The Hall sets the names of the drowned upon its roll*, 27 an Giblean, FE 154.

203. ← Follows from *The carriers drowned on the Abhainn dhomhain*, 3 an Gearran, FE 154; ← Follows from *The carriers' joke of the mourned coal*, 14 an Lùnastal, FE 154.

204. ← Follows from *Fionnlagh asks the council for a crossing the river cannot take*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, FE 154.

205. ← Follows from *Ailean Clachair is charged with the crossing at Ros fhionn*, 17 an t-Sultain, FE 155.

206. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

207. ← Follows from *Ailean gathers the forty of the nine hearths*, 16 an Dàmhair, FE 156.

208. → Caused by *Fionnlagh asks the council for a crossing the river cannot take*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, FE 154; → Caused by *Ailean Clachair is charged with the crossing at Ros fhionn*, 17 an t-Sultain, FE 155; → Caused by *Ailean gathers the forty of the nine hearths*, 16 an Dàmhair, FE 156; → Caused by *Aonghas Beag falls on the centring*, 14 an t-Samhain, FE 158.

- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 160** — *The single span above Ros fhionn is closed* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). The keystone is raised on ropes and levers and set into the arch above Ros fhionn, Ailean himself guiding it the last hand's-width into place while the forty stand silent on both banks. The scaffold comes down within the week and the span stands alone over the water on its own weight and shape.²⁰⁹
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 160** — *Ailean cuts the first hearth-sign in a keystone* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). Before the scaffold comes down, Ailean cuts the fourth hearth's own mark into the keystone's face, unasked, so that any eye that looks for it may know the stone was raised by hands that answer for their own work. The mark spreads to every span the forty raise after, and within a handful of years a crossing without it is said, not always fairly, to be a crossing built by hands that had not troubled to answer for themselves.²¹⁰
- 5 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 161** — *The masons swear the oath of the stone cup* (Dùn ìseal). Gathered at Dùn ìseal to be paid for the season's labour, the forty ask Fionnlagh whether they may swear a fellowship of their own. Each lays a hand on the stone cup at the threshold of Talla na Lasrach²¹¹ and swears that no span will ever be closed to a traveller in the dark, and none ever paid for in coal.²¹²
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 163** — *The masons' custom* (Ros dhomhain). The bridge-masons form a fellowship bound by an oath sworn on the stone cup at Dùn ìseal: no span to be closed in the dark, and none to be paid for in coal. Their lodge is kept near the western crossing, in the country of Ros dhomhain.²¹³
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 163** — *The masons' lodge is raised at the western crossing* (Ros dhomhain). Having kept together under Ailean's leading and raised three crossings more, the forty build a plain stone lodge beside the widest of the three, above a badly-used ford in the country of Ros dhomhain, where a mason called from any share may find a roof, a fire, and a fellow of the trade.²¹⁴
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 163** — *A carrier refuses an unsigned bridge* (Ros dhomhain). A cart-builder of Ros dhomhain throws an unmarked crossing of his own upriver of the western span. A carrier of the Hall's baskets, reaching it after dark, will not cross it, saying he knows whose oath a bridge without the fourth hearth's sign was not built under, and sleeps cold on the near bank rather than trust it.²¹⁵

209. ← Follows from *Ailean Clachair's crossing at Ros fhionn*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, FE 160; ← Follows from *Aonghas Beag falls on the centring*, 14 an t-Samhain, FE 158.

210. ← Follows from *Ailean Clachair's crossing at Ros fhionn*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, FE 160; ← Follows from *The single span above Ros fhionn is closed*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, FE 160.

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212. ← Follows from *Ailean cuts the first hearth-sign in a keystone*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 160.

213. → Caused by *Ailean cuts the first hearth-sign in a keystone*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 160; ← Leads to *The masons swear the oath of the stone cup*, 5 an Dàmhair, FE 161.

214. ← Follows from *The masons' custom*, 8 an t-Samhain, FE 163; ← Follows from *The masons swear the oath of the stone cup*, 5 an Dàmhair, FE 161.

215. ← Follows from *The masons' custom*, 8 an t-Samhain, FE 163; ← Follows from *The masons' lodge is raised at the western crossing*, 25 an t-Samhain, FE 163.

- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 164** — *Mòr nic Dhùghaill feeds three carriers in the rain* (Doire shean²¹⁶). A widow of Doire shean with more buffalo than grass boils a haunch for three carriers caught by a mud-slicked path, and asks no coin for it. Word of the free bowl travels the mountain road faster than any basket on it, and within a year she has built a second room to feed the men it sends her.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 166** — *The tavern roads begin* (Am Buabhall Fortanach²¹⁷). The first waypoint houses are raised along the mining roads. From them come in time Am Buabhall Fortanach, An Taigh-òsta Grianach²¹⁸ and the others of the circuit.²¹⁹
- 11 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 168** — *The turf longhouse raised at the crossing*. Three families of the fourth hearth build a long turf house where the mountain road meets the road to the western harbours, a hearth burning at either end for carriers going up and carriers coming down. Its long central table becomes the place where news of the whole road first gathers as one telling.²²⁰
- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 169** — *Mòr nic Dhùghaill's house* (Am Buabhall Fortanach²²¹). Mòr nic Dhùghaill, a widow of Doire shean²²², keeps the first waypoint house on the site of Am Buabhall Fortanach. She serves the carriers juggled buffalo from her own herd, and the house has served it ever since.²²³
- 13 AN CÈITEAN, FE 170** — *Seann Mborn²²⁴ resettled and its name kept* (Seann Mhorn). Fishers of the nine hearths find old house-footings above a good landing on the western shore of Loch chrom, and a name already fixed to the place that is not of their own tongue. They keep the name rather than giving it a new one, judging that a name found standing has more right to stay than one a stranger could invent.
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 172** — *The house at the middle of the road* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr²²⁵). A second waypoint house is built where the carriers' road from the mountain meets the road to the western harbours, on the site of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr. It is a turf longhouse with a hearth at either end, one for carriers going up and one for carriers coming down.²²⁶

216. the mountainside croft and village where Mòr nic Dhùghaill was born and kept her house

217. the first waypoint house, kept by Mòr nic Dhùghaill above Doire shean

218. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

219. → Caused by *Mòr nic Dhùghaill feeds three carriers in the rain*, 3 an t-Samhain, FE 164.

220. ← Follows from *Mòr nic Dhùghaill feeds three carriers in the rain*, 3 an t-Samhain, FE 164.

221. the first waypoint house, kept by Mòr nic Dhùghaill above Doire shean

222. the mountainside croft and village where Mòr nic Dhùghaill was born and kept her house

223. ← Leads to *Mòr nic Dhùghaill feeds three carriers in the rain*, 3 an t-Samhain, FE 164.

224. a harbour on the western shore of Loch chrom, resettled with its old name kept

225. the second waypoint house, a turf longhouse with a hearth at either end

226. ← Leads to *The turf longhouse raised at the crossing*, 11 an t-Ògmhios, FE 168.

- 11 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 172** — *Seann Warr*²²⁷ resettled beside it (Seann Warr). Families walking the same road find a second harbour a short way along the shore, house-footings there as well, and build on them without asking whose. Seann Warr and Seann Mhorn²²⁸ grow together within the century, sharing a landing, a market day and a single waypoint house where the mountain road meets the sea.
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, FE 175** — *A chase stopped at Mòr's door* (Doire shean²²⁹). A man fleeing his cousin's kin over an old knife-wound takes shelter at Mòr nic Dhùghaill's table, and his three pursuers, knives at their belts, find her standing between them and the fire. She swears there will be no blade drawn under her roof for any grievance, old or new, and feeds all four from the one pot until the debt walks back out onto the open road unsettled between them.
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 175** — *The road-peace* (An Sligeanach Fad' às²³⁰). The keepers of the waypoint houses agree that no feud may be pursued under an inn roof or within a spear's throw of its door. The custom is first set down at the house on the site of An Sligeanach Fad' às. It is the oldest law on the island that neither Keeper nor lord made.²³¹
- 15 AN GEARRAN, FE 176** — *The road-peace kept as custom*. Word of the chase stopped at Mòr's door runs the mountain road faster than any basket that season, and other waypoint houses along the circuit take up the same custom unasked: no feud pursued and no blade drawn under a road-house roof or within a spear's throw of its door.²³²
- 17 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 177** — *Niall Òg sits at Mòr's table* (Doire shean²³³). The old heir Niall Òg walks the mountain road to see for himself the house where a widow's word held two feuding kin to one table, and is given the same bowl and the same seat as any other traveller. He leaves a ring behind that Mòr will not keep, saying a man who has outlived his own quarrels can afford, once in a while, to pay for a peace he did not make.²³⁴
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 178** — *Seann Mhorn*²³⁵ resettled (Seann Mhorn). Fishers of the nine hearths settle the harbour at Seann Mhorn and keep the name they find there, which is not of their own tongue; the old name came with the stones, they say. It is the first such name known to be taken over and not replaced.²³⁶

227. a harbour beside Seann Mhorn on Loch chrom, resettled with its old name kept

228. a harbour on the western shore of Loch chrom, resettled with its old name kept

229. the mountainside croft and village where Mòr nic Dhùghaill was born and kept her house

230. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

231. → Caused by *A chase stopped at Mòr's door*, 7 an Cèitean, FE 175.

232. ← Follows from *The road-peace*, 22 an Dàmhair, FE 175; ← Follows from *A chase stopped at Mòr's door*, 7 an Cèitean, FE 175.

233. the mountainside croft and village where Mòr nic Dhùghaill was born and kept her house

234. ← Follows from *The road-peace*, 22 an Dàmhair, FE 175; ← Follows from *The road-peace kept as custom*, 15 an Gearran, FE 176.

235. a harbour on the western shore of Loch chrom, resettled with its old name kept

236. ← Leads to *Seann Mhorn resettled and its name kept*, 13 an Cèitean, FE 170.

- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 181** — *Seann Warr*²³⁷ resettled (Seann Warr). Families walking the new road from the mountain settle the harbour of Seann Warr on the western shore of Loch chrom in like manner. They find house-footings there already, and build on them, as the carriers' song has it, without asking whose.²³⁸
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 184** — *Death of Fionnlagh Dall* (Dùn iséal). Fionnlagh Dall dies at Dùn iséal. At his own asking he is not laid on the slope with the Keepers before him, but carried south to the old graves near Cnoc dhìreach, which no living people had yet claimed.
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 184** — *Fionnlagh Dall carried to the old graves* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach²³⁹). The bearers are eleven days on the road with the body of Fionnlagh Dall, and lay it at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach among graves older than any name. The Keepers after him cannot agree why he asked it; two answers are given, and neither is chosen.
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 184** — *Fionnlagh Dall asks to be carried south* (Dùn iséal). Dying at four-and-ninety after fifty-six years keeping the flame, Fionnlagh Dall tells Calum Beag he wishes to be laid not on the Keepers' own slope but in the unclaimed old graves near Cnoc dhìreach, ground no household's cord has ever divided. He dies within the month, his last words a question about whether the flame had been fed.²⁴⁰
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 184** — *The eleven days' bearing* (Doire shean²⁴¹). Bearers carry Fionnlagh Dall's body the twenty miles to Cnoc dhìreach in eleven days rather than three, as every hearth on the road asks to carry him some part of the way. Calum Beag walks the whole distance at the litter's head, the only bearer who never once hands off his own share of the weight.²⁴²
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 184** — *Tuam Cnoc dhìreach*²⁴³ hallowed (Cnoc dhìreach). Fionnlagh Dall is laid in the ancient, unclaimed burying-ground near Cnoc dhìreach, the first burial there any living hand has set down by name. The Keepers hallow the ground that same season, and it passes from belonging to no one to belonging, by the Hall's own reckoning, to everyone.²⁴⁴
- 16 AM MÀRT, FE 185** — *The grave-keepers of Cnoc dhìreach paid in coal* (Cnoc dhìreach). A handful of families settle by Tuam Cnoc dhìreach²⁴⁵ to tend the grave, and the Hall pays them one measured handful of coal each a season, the only service the Small-Burning Law is ever known to reward in coal rather than coin or kind.²⁴⁶

237. a harbour beside Seann Mhorn on Loch chrom, resettled with its old name kept

238. ← Leads to *Seann Warr resettled beside it*, 11 an t-Samhain, FE 172.

239. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

240. → Leads to *Death of Fionnlagh Dall*, 23 an Lùnastal, FE 184.

241. the mountainside croft and village where Mòr nic Dhùghaill was born and kept her house

242. ← Follows from *Fionnlagh Dall carried to the old graves*, 18 an t-Samhain, FE 184; ← Follows from *Fionnlagh Dall asks to be carried south*, 23 an t-Samhain, FE 184.

243. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

244. ← Follows from *The eleven days' bearing*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, FE 184.

245. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

246. ← Follows from *Tuam Cnoc dhìreach hallowed*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, FE 184.

- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 186** — *Mòr nic Dhùghaill dies at her own hearth* (Doire shean²⁴⁷). Found sitting upright in her fireside chair one morning by her own daughter, Mòr nic Dhùghaill dies at sixty-two, two years after Fionnlagh Dall. Her daughter and a niece take up the pot the same week, and the house does not miss a single night's fire.²⁴⁸
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 189** — *The mausoleum consecrated*. Tuam Cnoc dhìreach²⁴⁹, already ancient, is hallowed by the Keepers over the grave of Fionnlagh Dall, the first burial there that is set down by name. The burial-ground that no one claimed is claimed.²⁵⁰
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 189** — *Calum Beag sets a marker at the grave* (Cnoc dhìreach). Calum Beag, now an old man, carries a plain stone the whole way to Cnoc dhìreach on his own back and sets it at Fionnlagh Dall's grave-head with his own hands, cut with nothing but the shape of the stone cup and no name, judging the shape said enough on its own.²⁵¹
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 194** — *The grave-keepers of Cnoc dhìreach* (Cnoc dhìreach). A few families settle at Cnoc dhìreach to tend Tuam Cnoc dhìreach²⁵² after the Keeper's burial. The Hall pays them in coal, a handful each a season, the only payment in coal the Law ever allows.²⁵³

247. the mountainside croft and village where Mòr nic Dhùghaill was born and kept her house

248. ← Follows from *Mòr nic Dhùghaill's house*, 11 an t-Sultain, FE 169.

249. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

250. ← Leads to *Tuam Cnoc dhìreach hallowed*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, FE 184.

251. ← Follows from *The mausoleum consecrated*, 21 an t-Sultain, FE 189.

252. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

253. ← Leads to *The grave-keepers of Cnoc dhìreach paid in coal*, 16 am Màrt, FE 185.

THE YEARS FE 201 – 400

- 11 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 214** — *The wedding insult at Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). At a mason's wedding on the western share, Griogair mac Lachlainn of Sliochd Fhionnghail¹ strikes Tormod mac Ruairidh of Sliochd Artair² across the face with a drinking-horn after a slight against Fionnghal nic Ailein's memory. Both men are dragged from the hall still nursing the insult, and the two lines that had traded fish for grain for three generations begin refusing each other's carriers at their waypoint houses.
- 10 AN T-IÚCHAR, FE 216** — *The first raid of the wedding quarrel* (Ros dhomhain). A dozen head of cattle are lifted from a salt-shore pasture by men who call it payment owed for the insult at Ros dhomhain. A barn burns on the western share's ground within the season in answer, and within five years neither line can say with certainty who struck first.³
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 236** — *Eimhir nic Mhuirich chosen to keep the flame* (Dùn ìseal). The nine hearths choose Eimhir nic Mhuirich, of the hearth-line and past sixty already, to keep the flame at Dùn ìseal. She holds the Hall to its measure through the widening quarrel of the king's blood, judging no man's raids and taking no side between Sliochd Fhionnghail⁴ and Sliochd Artair⁵.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 245** — *Tormod mac Ruairidh asks the Hall's blessing on a raid* (Dùn ìseal). Tormod mac Ruairidh comes to Dùn ìseal asking Eimhir nic Mhuirich to bless a raid he calls justice rather than vengeance. She hears him out and refuses, telling him the Hall keeps coal and not grudges, and that the flame she keeps was lit before his own great-grandfather was born.⁶
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 262** — *Fionnghal nic Ailein dies* (Ros dhomhain). Fionnghal nic Ailein, daughter of Ailean Mòr and holder of the western share since the age's early years, dies at Ros dhomhain some two thousand eight hundred and forty-four years old. Her funeral is the last occasion on which Sliochd Fhionnghail⁷ and Sliochd Artair⁸ stand under one roof without a blow struck.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 290** — *Eimhir nic Mhuirich dies* (Dùn ìseal). Eimhir nic Mhuirich dies at Dùn ìseal some eighty years old, having kept the flame through fifty-four years of the widening strife of the heirs more steadily than the quarrel's own principals kept their tempers. The nine hearths choose a younger Keeper who holds much the same course.

1. the descendants of Fionnghal nic Ailein, holding the western share at Ros dhomhain
 2. the descendants of Artair mac Ailein, holding the share of the salt shore at Baile ghorm
 3. ← Follows from *The wedding insult at Ros dhomhain*, 11 an t-Ògmhios, FE 214.
 4. the descendants of Fionnghal nic Ailein, holding the western share at Ros dhomhain
 5. the descendants of Artair mac Ailein, holding the share of the salt shore at Baile ghorm
 6. ← Follows from *Eimhir nic Mhuirich chosen to keep the flame*, 25 an Lùnastal, FE 236.
 7. the descendants of Fionnghal nic Ailein, holding the western share at Ros dhomhain
 8. the descendants of Artair mac Ailein, holding the share of the salt shore at Baile ghorm

- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 298** — *Artair mac Ailein dies* (Baile ghorm). Artair mac Ailein, son of Ailean Mòr and holder of the salt shore at Baile ghorm, dies at his own hall some two thousand six hundred years old, the widening feud between his own descendants and Fionnghal's a weight he carried into his last years and could not set down.
- 27 AN T-ÌUCHAR, FE 331** — *Cormac mac Ailein dies* (Caol shean). Cormac mac Ailein, son of Ailean Mòr and holder of the eastern share at Caol shean, dies some two thousand four hundred and fifty-three years old, the last of Ailean's own children still living at the strife's true middle. His last wish, that his household keep clear of the western quarrel, is honoured for less than a generation.⁹
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 352** — *Niall Òg calls a peace at the crossing of Ros fhionn* (Cathair dhearg). Niall Òg sets a long table on neutral ground at the crossing of Ros fhionn and brings the heads of Sliochd Fhionnghail¹⁰ and Sliochd Artair¹¹ to it unarmed, hoping to loosen a quarrel now two generations old. Each recites a longer account of wrongs than he came with, neither offers an apology, and both walk home by the same road they came by.¹²
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, FE 353** — *The raids resume after the failed peace*. Within the season of Niall Òg's failed peace at Ros fhionn, raids between Sliochd Fhionnghail¹³ and Sliochd Artair¹⁴ begin again, if indeed they had ever truly stopped for the meeting.¹⁵
- I AN CÈITEAN, FE 360** — *The tally-stick of Cnoc leathan* (Baile chiar). A household of the fourth hearth at Cnoc leathan, sworn to neither quarrelling line, keeps a tally-stick notched for whichever share's steward calls first each season. By the century's turn it carries better than a hundred and fifty notches on each face, a plainer record than either quarrelling line keeps of its own raids.
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, FE 377** — *Eachann Ruadh mac Mhurchaidh dies in his bed* (Dùn ìseal). Eachann Ruadh mac Mhurchaidh, who killed Ìomhar Dearg at a ford four generations before in vengeance for his brother, dies quietly in his bed at seven hundred and twenty-nine years old, the last of his generation of the king's kin. His own line, long at peace with the Red Share, takes no fresh quarrel from his death.
- 8 AN GIBLEAN, FE 381** — *The hearth-elders sound out Eilidh nic Ìomhair* (Dùn dhearg). Two elders of the nine hearths walk from Dùn ìseal to Dùn dhearg to ask Eilidh nic Ìomhair, a granddaughter's granddaughter of Ìomhar Dearg who keeps the Red Share's granary rolls, whether she would be persuaded to sit a season with the coal. She names the difficulty herself before they can raise it: her own blood.

9. ← Follows from *Artair mac Ailein dies*, 25 an Lùnastal, FE 298.

10. the descendants of Fionnghal nic Ailein, holding the western share at Ros dhomhain

11. the descendants of Artair mac Ailein, holding the share of the salt shore at Baile ghorm

12. ← Follows from *Cormac mac Ailein dies*, 27 an t-Iuchar, FE 331.

13. the descendants of Fionnghal nic Ailein, holding the western share at Ros dhomhain

14. the descendants of Artair mac Ailein, holding the share of the salt shore at Baile ghorm

15. ← Follows from *Niall Òg calls a peace at the crossing of Ros fhionn*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, FE 352.

17 AN GIBLEAN, FE 381 — *Eilidh tells the elders to choose another* (Dùn dhearg). Eilidh nic Ìomhair tells the two hearth-elders plainly to choose one of the other names put forward, having no wish to force the question of her own blood against the Binding's old rule.¹⁶

25 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 381 — *Eilidh nic Ìomhair keeps the flame* (Dùn ìseal). The nine hearths choose a Keeper from outside the house of Muireach for the first time: Eilidh nic Ìomhair, of Dùn dhearg, of the line of Ìomhar Dearg and so of the king's blood. Sliochd Mhuirich¹⁷, holding to the Binding, refuses for a season, then yields at Dùn ìseal, on the condition that the stone cup never leaves Talla na Lasrach^{18, 19}.

11 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 381 — *The Keeper before Eilidh dies at the cup* (Dùn ìseal). The Keeper who held the flame after Eimhir nic Mhuirich dies sitting on the low stool beside the stone cup at Talla na Lasrach²⁰, her hands folded in her lap. The small lamp beside her burns out unfed in the night, the first time in living memory that any lamp in the Hall has been let go dark.²¹

15 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 382 — *The cup left unfilled a season* (Dùn ìseal). For the better part of a year after the nine hearths choose Eilidh, Sliochd Mhuirich²² refuses to yield the flame, and the stone cup at Talla na Lasrach²³ sits under the care of the hearth-line's own eldest, unfilled by any new hand, while every market and threshing floor on the mountain airs an opinion on the matter.²⁴

13 AN GEARRAN, FE 382 — *The argument of the diluted blood* (Dùn dhearg). Eilidh's own kin argue to her, and to anyone who will listen, that half the households in the hills carry some thread of the king's blood by now, so that the Binding's old rule has become a rule against nearly everybody or nobody. Eilidh answers that the argument settles nothing Sliochd Mhuirich²⁵ has actually asked.²⁶

8 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 382 — *The hearth-line eldest offers the cup's condition* (Dùn ìseal). The eldest of Sliochd Mhuirich²⁷ comes to the Hall's threshold and offers a single condition for yielding the flame to Eilidh nic Ìomhair: that the stone cup Fionnlagh Dall cut to the measure of two palms shall never, for any cause, be carried out through the door of Talla na Lasrach^{28, 29}.

16. ← Follows from *The hearth-elders sound out Eilidh nic Ìomhair*, 8 an Giblean, FE 381.

17. the house of Muireach

18. the Hall of the Flame

19. → Caused by *The hearth-elders sound out Eilidh nic Ìomhair*, 8 an Giblean, FE 381; → Caused by *Eilidh tells the elders to choose another*, 17 an Giblean, FE 381.

20. the Hall of the Flame

21. ← Follows from *Eilidh tells the elders to choose another*, 17 an Giblean, FE 381.

22. the house of Muireach

23. the Hall of the Flame

24. → Leads to *Eilidh nic Ìomhair keeps the flame*, 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 381; ← Follows from *The Keeper before Eilidh dies at the cup*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, FE 381.

25. the house of Muireach

26. → Leads to *Eilidh nic Ìomhair keeps the flame*, 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 381; ← Follows from *The cup left unfilled a season*, 15 am Faoilleach, FE 382.

27. the house of Muireach

- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 382** — *Eilidh swears to the cup's condition* (Dùn ìseal). Eilidh nic Ìomhair swears before the nine hearths that the stone cup will never leave Talla na Lasrach³⁰, her hand flat on its rim, and takes the coal that same afternoon, the measure poured level to her palm exactly as for every Keeper before her.³¹
- 1 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 385** — *Sliochd Thormoid*³² *names Tormod Liath* (Dùn ìseal). At a gathering of the nine hearths, the eldest of Sliochd Thormoid names for the first time an ancestor called Tormod Liath, said to have held the hill itself under the old king, as the ground of the house's claim to a voice in the Keeper's office.
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 385** — *Sliochd Raghnaill*³³ *names Raghnaill Ceannfhionn* (Seann Tarr). Sliochd Raghnaill answers Sliochd Thormoid³⁴'s claim with its own, naming an ancestor Raghnaill Ceannfhionn, though the house rests its true weight less on any hill than on the plain fact that its boats carry more coal down the coast in a bad season than any other house's carts carry inland.³⁵
- 28 AM MÀRT, FE 385** — *Eilidh binds the office to four houses* (Dùn ìseal). Eilidh nic Ìomhair puts to the nine hearths that the Keeper's office be bound from that season to four houses of custody alone, Sliochd Mhuirich³⁶, Sliochd Ìomhair³⁷, Sliochd Thormoid³⁸ and Sliochd Raghnaill³⁹, and that the other hearths keep their council seats but surrender any further claim on the flame.⁴⁰
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, FE 385** — *The Four Houses sworn* (Dùn ìseal). Under Eilidh nic Ìomhair the office of Keeper is bound to four houses of custody: Sliochd Mhuirich⁴¹ of Dùn ìseal, Sliochd Ìomhair⁴² of Dùn dhearg, Sliochd Thormoid⁴³ of Seann Dunn and Sliochd Raghnaill⁴⁴ of Seann Tarr. The other hearths keep their seats on the council, but lose their claim to the flame. Most of the later nobility of the island descends from one of the four, or says it does.⁴⁵

28. the Hall of the Flame

29. → Leads to *Eilidh nic Ìomhair keeps the flame*, 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 381; ← Follows from *The argument of the diluted blood*, 13 an Gearran, FE 382.

30. the Hall of the Flame

31. ← Follows from *The hearth-line eldest offers the cup's condition*, 8 an t-Iuchar, FE 382.

32. the house of Tormod

33. the house of Raghnaill

34. the house of Tormod

35. ← Follows from *Sliochd Thormoid names Tormod Liath*, 1 am Faoilleach, FE 385.

36. the house of Muireach

37. the house of Ìomhar

38. the house of Tormod

39. the house of Raghnaill

40. ← Follows from *Sliochd Raghnaill names Raghnaill Ceannfhionn*, 26 am Faoilleach, FE 385.

41. the house of Muireach

42. the house of Ìomhar

43. the house of Tormod

20 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 386 — *The grumble over Seann Dunn's fullest lamp* (Seann Dunn).

The other three houses grumble that Sliochd Thormoid⁴⁶'s coal-lamp at Seann Dunn always burns fuller than the Law's measure allows, though no cutter sent to check it ever finds a grain over the handful. Eilidh judges the grievance one best left to wear out on its own.⁴⁷

28 AN CÈITEAN, FE 389 — *The house of Tormod at Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). Sliochd

Thormoid⁴⁸ raises a hall and a shrine at Seann Dunn, facing the mountain across the river. A lamp of coal burns in the shrine at the Law's measure. The other houses complain that the measure of Seann Dunn is always the fullest.⁴⁹

1 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 390 — *Sliochd Raghnaill⁵⁰ grows rich on the fishing* (Seann Tarr). The

house that took its seat at Seann Tarr, the very town first sentenced under the Small-Burning Law, keeps no galleries and cuts no coal, choosing boats instead, and grows rich enough within two generations that its neighbours stop mentioning the old offence.

2 AM MÀRT, FE 393 — *The house of Raghnaill at Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). Sliochd Ragh-

naill⁵¹ takes for its seat Seann Tarr on the north-eastern coast, the town whose household was first sentenced under the Law. The house keeps boats and not galleries, and grows rich on the fishing.⁵²

3 AN GEARRAN, FE 397 — *The wager at Seann Tarr's quay* (Seann Tarr). Tormod Ruadh, a

steersman of Sliochd Raghnaill⁵³, insists through a winter of evenings at Seann Tarr's quay that a boat could as easily be sailed round the black island Eilean dhubh as fished within sight of it, and finds himself, come spring, with a crew of four and a wager too large to back out of.

31 AM MÀRT, FE 397 — *Round Eilean dhubh* (Eilean dhubh). Boats of Sliochd Raghnaill⁵⁴

sail round Eilean dhubh and come home, the first voyage made to see a coast and not to fish it. The house's songs name the steersman Tormod Ruadh. He brings back word of rock and birds, and of having gone, and of nothing else.⁵⁵

45. → Caused by *Eilidh swears to the cup's condition*, 6 an Lùnastal, FE 382; → Caused by *Sliochd Thormoid names Tormod Liath*, 1 am Faoilleach, FE 385; → Caused by *Sliochd Raghnaill names Raghnaill Ceannfhiann*, 26 am Faoilleach, FE 385; → Caused by *Eilidh binds the office to four houses*, 28 am Màrt, FE 385.

44. the house of Raghnaill

46. the house of Tormod

47. ← Follows from *Eilidh binds the office to four houses*, 28 am Màrt, FE 385.

48. the house of Tormod

49. ← Leads to *The grumble over Seann Dunn's fullest lamp*, 20 an Dàmhair, FE 386.

50. the house of Raghnaill

51. the house of Raghnaill

52. ← Leads to *Sliochd Raghnaill grows rich on the fishing*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 390.

53. the house of Raghnaill

54. the house of Raghnaill

55. → Caused by *The wager at Seann Tarr's quay*, 3 an Gearran, FE 397.

II AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 397 — *The strand mistakes Tormod Ruadh's boat for a stranger's.* A strand that has never before had reason to look for a boat of Seann Tarr's from that quarter of the sea sights Tormod Ruadh's boat rounding Eilean dhubh's far side and takes alarm at it, word of the strange sighting reaching Dùn ìseal well ahead of the boat's own return.⁵⁶

6 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 398 — *Murchadh Ruadh's household loses its right* (Baile chrom). The household of Murchadh Ruadh of Baile chrom is stripped of its right under the Law for a third offence, and goes down to the strand with what it can carry rather than beg cold porridge from kin. No hearth on the coast will give it coal after, or discuss why.

56. ← Follows from *Round Eilean dhubh*, 31 am Màrt, FE 397; ← Follows from *The wager at Seann Tarr's quay*, 3 an Gearran, FE 397.

THE YEARS FE 401 – 600

26 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 401 — *The outlaws of the north-west waters* (Spùinneadairean-mara).

Households stripped of their right under the Law for a third offence take to boats, live off the north-western waters, and raid the fishing strands. They are called spùinneadairean, plunderers, and the name stays with those waters after them.¹

8 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 403 — *A strand south of Baile chrom burned in the dark*. Boats out of no household raid a fishing strand half a day south of Baile chrom in the small hours of a moonless night, burning two houses to their footings and stripping the drying-racks bare. A woman of the strand says she knew two of the raiders by their voices, and will not name them.²

28 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 405 — *The boat lost off the north-west* (Uilebheist na Mara³). A fishing boat out of Baile chrom is lost in calm water off the north-western coast. The two men who swim home say that something rose under it. Each year thereafter the boat's village keeps a wake for it. Of the thing they saw no more is told.

9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 406 — *The wake first kept for the five* (Baile chrom). A year to the day after Cailean Buidhe's boat is lost in the calm off Baile chrom, the strand sets out a bowl for the five who went out on her and speaks the boat's name once over it. Anndra Cìobair, one of the two who swam home, pours the first cup, and goes on pouring it every year after.⁴

23 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 409 — *The fire at Baile chrom relit* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom⁵). After the loss the fishers of Baile chrom light the old beacon on the point again, fed with driftwood as the Law requires. From it comes Taigh-solais Baile chrom.

II AN CÈITEAN, FE 410 — *The keeping of the beacon falls to the households in turn* (Baile chrom). Once the old beacon on the Baile chrom headland is relit, the carrying of driftwood to feed it becomes a charge the coast's households take up one season at a time, the way other coasts keep a granary door or a toll-stick.⁶

25 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 413 — *Seann Bhrenn resettled* (Seann Bhrenn). Fishers from the north side of the mountain settle the harbour of Seann Bhrenn on the northern coast and keep its old name, as the western settlers kept Seann Warr⁷s. They find a stone quay under the silt and use it.

1. → Caused by *Murchadh Ruadh's household loses its right*, 6 an Lùnastal, FE 398.

2. ← Follows from *The outlaws of the north-west waters*, 26 an t-Sultain, FE 401; ← Follows from *Murchadh Ruadh's household loses its right*, 6 an Lùnastal, FE 398.

3. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

4. ← Follows from *The boat lost off the north-west*, 28 an Lùnastal, FE 405; ← Follows from *A strand south of Baile chrom burned in the dark*, 8 an t-Iuchar, FE 403.

5. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

6. ← Follows from *The fire at Baile chrom relit*, 23 an t-Samhain, FE 409.

7. a harbour beside Seann Mhorn on Loch chrom, resettled with its old name kept

- 12 AN GIBLEAN, FE 414** — *Word of the stone quay travels the coast* (Baile chrom). News of the worked stone quay found under the silt at Seann Bhrenn reaches Baile chrom by trader's boat, grown in the telling to a buried town in one mouth and shrunk to a single stone in another, neither telling closer to the truth than the other.⁸
- 20 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 417** — *The ancestor-cairn at Cathair naomh* (Cathair naomh). The people of Cathair naomh in the north raise a cairn for their dead on the hill above the town, and bring it a stone at every burial. It is the greatest ancestor-cairn in the north, and it grows still.
- 14 AM MÀRT, FE 418** — *Word of the cairn at Cathair naomh travels the coast* (Baile chrom). Word reaches Baile chrom of the growing ancestor-cairn on the hill above Cathair naomh, carried a stone at a time at every burial, and travellers who see it years apart swear the hill itself looks changed.⁹
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 421** — *The panthers let pass* (Imrich nam Pantar¹⁰). The crossing of the great cats is found to run straight over the carriers' southern road. Eilidh nic Ìomhair rules that no panther may be killed on the road in its season, and the carriers wait in the waypoint houses until the crossing is done. The rule is kept, for it costs the carriers only time.
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 421** — *The carriers of the southern road grumble at the panthers' ruling*. Told as far as Baile chrom, the tale of Eilidh nic Ìomhair's ruling on the great cats' crossing carries with it the carriers' first grumbling at the delay, and her answer that a Law which measures every handful can measure a few days' patience too.¹¹
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 430** — *The granaries of Dùn dhearg opened to households not its own* (Dùn dhearg). Sliochd Ìomhair¹² opens the new granaries at Dùn dhearg to any household of the lowland plain caught short by the storm season, not only its own. Coinneach Mòr, still a young man of Seann Dunn, watches the queue at the gate and hears his father call it a debt of bread that few who take it yet feel as a debt.
- 19 AM MÀRT, FE 434** — *The granaries of Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Sliochd Ìomhair¹³ builds stone granaries at Dùn dhearg and fills them from the lowland fields of its share, holding grain against the storm season as the old custom of sharing asks. So the house gains what the Hall never had: people who owe it their bread.¹⁴
- 7 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 440** — *Anndra Ciobair dies at Baile chrom* (Baile chrom). Anndra Ciobair, who swam home from Cailean Buidhe's boat and kept the wake's first cup for near forty years, dies in his own bed above the strand he never left, and is buried within sight of the headland he tended.¹⁵

8. ← Follows from *Seann Bhrenn resettled*, 25 an Dàmhair, FE 413.

9. ← Follows from *The ancestor-cairn at Cathair naomh*, 20 am Faoilleach, FE 417.

10. the panthers' crossing

11. ← Follows from *The panthers let pass*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, FE 421.

12. the house of Ìomhar

13. the house of Ìomhar

14. → Caused by *The granaries of Dùn dhearg opened to households not its own*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, FE 430.

- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 445** — *The resting-place at the foot of the pass becomes Baile Mòr dhomhain* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). The carriers' resting-place at the last flat ground before the high pass grows byres, a smithy and an inn that is never empty in the season the pass is open, and takes the name Baile Mòr dhomhain, though it stands on no deep water and lives by the pass and little else.
- 18 AN GEARRAN, FE 448** — *Baile Mòr dhomhain at the foot of the pass* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Carriers who take the Hall's baskets north over the high pass settle at its southern foot, where Baile Mòr dhomhain now stands, to rest their beasts before the climb. The town lives by the pass, and by little else.¹⁶
- 16 AN CÈITEAN, FE 461** — *The reverent centuries*. Generation after generation mines the same small measure and burns the same small measure, and the people neither grow nor dwindle, whichever lord's share they live in. The rolls call them the reverent centuries.
- 20 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 475** — *Coinneach Mòr chosen Keeper of Sliochd Thormoid*¹⁷ (Seann Dunn). In the month of Giblean, the four houses choose Coinneach Mòr mac Tormoid, five-and-twenty, first Keeper of his house, for his patience rather than any gift of speech, judging a Keeper who keeps a flame steadily worth more than one who keeps it brilliantly for a short while.
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, FE 475** — *Coinneach Mòr mac Tormoid keeps the flame* (Seann Dunn). Coinneach Mòr mac Tormoid of Seann Dunn becomes the first Keeper of Sliochd Thormoid¹⁸. He keeps the flame longer than any Keeper before him, and changes nothing while he keeps it.¹⁹
- 4 AN GIBLEAN, FE 476** — *Griogair Ruadh asks a seat for Achadh chaol and is refused* (Achadh chaol). The headman of the shepherds at Achadh chaol asks the council at Dùn ìseal for a seat among the houses that govern the plain, and is refused for want of hearth-right cut in stone at the Roinn. He sits one courtesy season and goes home with the dues still owed and no seat won.²⁰
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 488** — *The shepherds of Achadh chaol* (Achadh chaol). Shepherds settle the upland fields at Achadh chaol in the north-east and send their wool down to the harbours. Their headman sits one season on the council at Dùn ìseal, is found to hold no hearth-right, and goes home.²¹
- 3 AN CÈITEAN, FE 490** — *Coinneach's walkers set out to list the ruins*. Coinneach Mòr sends six walkers the length of the plain to list every ruin standing on ground the four houses claim, ruling before they leave that the list shall say only who does not own each place, and never guess who built it.²²

15. † Legacy *The boat lost off the north-west*, 28 an Lùnastal, FE 405.

16. → Caused by *The resting-place at the foot of the pass becomes Baile Mòr dhomhain*, 12 an Dàmhair, FE 445.

17. the house of Tormod

18. the house of Tormod

19. → Caused by *Coinneach Mòr chosen Keeper of Sliochd Thormoid*, 20 am Faoilleach, FE 475.

20. ← Follows from *Coinneach Mòr chosen Keeper of Sliochd Thormoid*, 20 am Faoilleach, FE 475.

21. → Caused by *Griogair Ruadh asks a seat for Achadh chaol and is refused*, 4 an Giblean, FE 476.

- 5 **AN GEARRAN, FE 492** — *The walkers return with the list of the old people's ruins* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire²³). The walkers come home after two years with Làrach an Dùin-fhaire, Làrach an Dùin²⁴, Làrach an Teampaill²⁵ and the plain's scattered standing stones set down on one list, each entry naming who does not hold the ground and none guessing at the builders, who are called after only the old people.²⁶
- 6 **AM MÀRT, FE 498** — *The first ring of stakes raised round Carragh Cnoc bheag*²⁷ (Carragh Cnoc bheag). Once the walkers' list names the standing stone above Cnoc bheag, the household nearest it fences the rise to keep cattle from rubbing the cut letters smooth. Each generation after renews the stakes, and the stone itself is never moved.
- 4 **AN DÀMHAIR, FE 502** — *The Keepers' count of the old places* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire²⁸). Coinneach Mòr sends walkers to list the ruins of the old people. They bring back Làrach an Dùin-fhaire, Làrach an Dùin²⁹, Làrach an Teampaill³⁰ and the standing stones. The list says who does not own each place, and not who built it; the Keepers rule that it shall not guess.³¹
- 29 **AN T-IUCHAR, FE 505** — *The bath-house roofed over the springs of Muileann ruadh* (Muileann ruadh). After a cousin of his own house is carried to the warm springs half dead of a wasting cough and comes home breathing, Coinneach Mòr orders a bath-house raised over the largest pool, with sleeping-places for the sick and benches for those who wait out the cure beside them.
- 27 **AN LÙNASTAL, FE 505** — *A keeper of the springs named in Dian Cècht's name* (Muileann ruadh). Coinneach Mòr names a widow who nursed her own husband through a wasting fever as keeper of the springs at Muileann ruadh, the office set in the healer Dian Cècht's name and answering to no measure of coal, the first such office the flame at Seann Dunn has made.³²
- 1 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 508** — *The silversmiths of Muileann chiar cast their weights* (Muileann chiar). Weary of disputes at their own market, the silversmiths of Muileann chiar cast a set of weights from a barley-corn to a newborn lamb, checked one against another and set out for any trader to use. Within years a thing weighed there is called, the length of the carriers' roads, weighed fairly.

22. ← Follows from *Griogair Ruadh asks a seat for Achadh chaol and is refused*, 4 an Giblean, FE 476.

23. the watch-fort ruin

24. the fortress ruin

25. the temple ruin

26. ← Follows from *Coinneach's walkers set out to list the ruins*, 3 an Cèitean, FE 490.

27. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

28. the watch-fort ruin

29. the fortress ruin

30. the temple ruin

31. → Caused by *Coinneach's walkers set out to list the ruins*, 3 an Cèitean, FE 490; ← Leads to *The walkers return with the list of the old people's ruins*, 5 an Gearran, FE 492.

32. ← Follows from *The bath-house roofed over the springs of Muileann ruadh*, 29 an t-Iuchar, FE 505.

- 3 AN CÈITEAN, FE 513** — *Torcall Donn weds Muireall nic Ìomhair* (Dùn dhearg). Torcall Donn, great-grandson of Eithne nic Ailein and five-and-eighty, weds Muireall nic Ìomhair, not yet four-and-twenty, at Dùn dhearg, a match both houses call costless and both houses are pleased with, her marriage-portion drawn to satisfy both grants at once.
- 29 AN T-IÚCHAR, FE 514** — *Muireall nic Ìomhair dies in her first winter*. Muireall nic Ìomhair dies of a nine-day fever in her first winter as a wife, leaving no child and no settled answer to which grant, the house of Ìomhar's or the line of Eithne's, should hold her lands should she die too soon, since no one had thought she would.³³
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 515** — *The fence round Carragh Cnoc bheag*³⁴ (Carragh Cnoc bheag). The people of Cnoc bheag set a ring of stakes round the old standing stone above their town, that the cattle may not rub against it. Every generation after renews the ring. The stone is never moved.³⁵
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 515** — *Both houses claim Muireall's lands*. The house of Ìomhar claims Muireall's marriage-lands as returning to the kin that granted them; the line of Eithne claims the same ground as passing to the husband's holding. Both claims are argued with equal heat by men who never asked, while she lived, which grant should prevail.³⁶
- 5 AN GEARRAN, FE 517** — *The first double-sworn field burned*. A holding sworn to both Dùn dhearg and Cathair mhòr since Muireall's marriage-portion touched it is burned in a single night by its own near neighbours, byre first and standing barley after. The household goes to kin elsewhere, and the ground lies unsown, claimed loudly and worked by neither house.³⁷
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 529** — *The bath-house at Muileann ruadh* (Muileann ruadh). A roofed bath-house is built over the warm springs below Muileann ruadh, with sleeping-places for the sick and their bearers. The Hall appoints a keeper of the springs, who tends them in the name of Dian Cècht, the healer. It is the first office the Hall makes that has nothing to do with the coal.³⁸
- 7 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 537** — *Coinneach Mòr dies at Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). Coinneach Mòr mac Tormoid dies at Seann Dunn in his eighty-seventh year, two-and-sixty years into his keeping, asking after the walkers' list and the burned marriage-lands in his last days, and leaving the flame to a nephew chosen in his stead with the smoke of the burnings still on the southern horizon.³⁹

33. ← Follows from *Torcall Donn weds Muireall nic Ìomhair*, 3 an Cèitean, FE 513.

34. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

35. → Caused by *The first ring of stakes raised round Carragh Cnoc bheag*, 6 am Màrt, FE 498.

36. ← Follows from *Muireall nic Ìomhair dies in her first winter*, 29 an t-Iuchar, FE 514.

37. ← Follows from *Both houses claim Muireall's lands*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, FE 515.

38. → Caused by *The bath-house roofed over the springs of Muileann ruadh*, 29 an t-Iuchar, FE 505; ← Leads to *A keeper of the springs named in Dian Cècht's name*, 27 an Lùnastal, FE 505.

39. ← Follows from *Coinneach Mòr mac Tormoid keeps the flame*, 17 an Giblean, FE 475.

- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 542** — *The silver weights of Muileann chiar* (Muileann chiar). The silversmiths of Muileann chiar cast a set of weights, the least the weight of a barley-corn and the greatest that of a newborn lamb. Every trader on the carriers' roads comes to use them, and for the rest of the age a thing weighed at Muileann chiar is said to be weighed fairly.⁴⁰
- 4 AN GIBLEAN, FE 543** — *Fearghas sends the last untroubled tithe* (Achadh mhòr). Fearghas Dà-Mhionn weighs out his sheaves for Dùn dhearg and for Cathair mhòr at Muileann chiar as he has every harvest of his long life, a little short to each, not yet knowing it is the last year either hall will let the joke stand.
- 6 AM MÀRT, FE 544** — *The black-eaved holding east of Achadh mhòr*. A double-sworn household two valleys east chooses the Red Share and is burned to its field-walls by Cathair mhòr's men before the next harvest, its cattle driven off and its house left standing empty as a warning to the next household asked to choose.
- 19 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 545** — *A holding that chose neither is burned by both*. A double-sworn holding south of Achadh mhòr refuses to choose between its lords and is burned within the year by both hosts in turn, the Red Share's riders taking the barn first and a company of Cathair mhòr's finishing it, each telling its own men it punished only what the other began.
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 546** — *Fearghas rides to see a burned holding*. Fearghas rides to the black-eaved holding east of his own fields to see with his own eyes what a double-sworn household looks like once burned, and finds only standing walls, fallen roofs and a dog that will not leave the ruin, and speaks of the war differently after.
- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 547** — *A burned widow's household shelters at Achadh mhòr* (Achadh mhòr). A widow and her three sons, burned out in the southern raids, shelter three nights at Fearghas's hall on their way to kin beyond Ceann leathan, and Fearghas feeds them without asking any oath of them, telling his steward a household already burned has paid enough.⁴¹
- 18 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 548** — *Torcall Donn killed on the road below Dùn thais*. Torcall Donn, great-grandson of Eithne and husband of the dead Muireall nic Ìomhair, is killed at a hundred and eighteen years old when his company meets a company of the Red Share's riders on a narrow road and the pushing between them turns to blows.
- 16 AN GEARRAN, FE 548** — *Fearghas sends barley to be burned at Torcall Donn's grave* (Cathair mhòr). Fearghas sends a measure of his own barley to be burned at Torcall Donn's graveside at Cathair mhòr, the old rite for a man dead before his harvest is in, asking that no word go with it saying who sent it; the giver is known within the season regardless.⁴²

40. → Caused by *The silversmiths of Muileann chiar cast their weights*, 1 an t-Ògmhios, FE 508.

41. ← Follows from *Fearghas rides to see a burned holding*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, FE 546.

42. ← Follows from *Torcall Donn killed on the road below Dùn thais*, 18 am Faoilleach, FE 548.

- 17 AM MÀRT, FE 549** — *The Red Share presses its claim after the widower's death* (Dùn dhearg). With Torcall Donn dead, the Red Share presses its claim on Muireall's three granges harder rather than less, judging Cathair mhòr's grip on lands held only through a dead man's marriage weaker than before, and the war burns on past the quarrel that began it.
- 15 AN GIBLEAN, FE 550** — *Ciorstaidh's stone set in Fearghas's hall* (Achadh mhòr). Fearghas has a stone cut for his grandmother Ciorstaidh and set into his own hall wall, her name and the sign of the cut knot beside it, wanting it known in stone that the house he holds was held first by one of the eleven who answered for their double oath all their lives.
- 14 AN CÈITEAN, FE 550** — *The mason of Muileann chiar carries the tale*. The stone-cutter who set Ciorstaidh's memorial breaks his promise of silence at the first market he reaches, and the setting of the stone becomes, within a season, one more thing told of Fearghas Dà-Mhionn on both sides of the war, read two different ways by two different hearths.
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 556** — *The burning of Achadh mhòr* (Achadh mhòr). Cogadh an Dà Mhionn⁴³, the War of the Two Oaths, ends where it began. Fearghas Dà-Mhionn, lord of the granary fields of Achadh mhòr, sworn both to the line of Ìomhar and to the lords of Cathair mhòr, is called to arms by each against the other, and both come to take his fields. The fields are burned to the stubble, and Fearghas dies in his hall.⁴⁴
- I AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 556** — *Sìth an Stairsnich*⁴⁵ (Dùn ìseal). The lords of the shares swear the Peace of the Threshold, Sìth an Stairsnich, on the threshold of Talla na Lasrach⁴⁶, beside the stone cup, with the Keeper as witness. No share may be parted again at a death: a holding passes whole to one heir. No man may swear to two lords. The boundary stones are set where they stand that day. So ends Aimhreit nan Oighrean⁴⁷.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 556** — *The market under the Hall* (Dùn ìseal). A market is held under the walls of the Hall at Dùn ìseal on the four quarter days, Samhain, Là Fhèill Brìde, Bealltainn and Lùnastal, when the households of the eastern hills come up with their dues. Hides, venison, charcoal, honey and the silver of Muileann chiar change hands there on the new weights. The Keepers allow no coal to be sold on their ground, and none is.

43. the War of the Two Oaths

44. → Caused by *Torcall Donn weds Muireall nic Ìomhair*, 3 an Cèitean, FE 513; → Caused by *Muireall nic Ìomhair dies in her first winter*, 29 an t-Iuchar, FE 514; → Caused by *Both houses claim Muireall's lands*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, FE 515; → Caused by *The first double-sworn field burned*, 5 an Gearran, FE 517; → Caused by *Fearghas sends the last untroubled tithe*, 4 an Giblean, FE 543; → Caused by *The black-eaved holding east of Achadh mhòr*, 6 am Màrt, FE 544; → Caused by *A holding that chose neither is burned by both*, 19 am Faoilleach, FE 545; → Caused by *Fearghas rides to see a burned holding*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, FE 546; → Caused by *A burned widow's household shelters at Achadh mhòr*, 20 an Dùbhlachd, FE 547; → Caused by *Torcall Donn killed on the road below Dùn thais*, 18 am Faoilleach, FE 548; ← Leads to *Fearghas sends barley to be burned at Torcall Donn's grave*, 16 an Gearran, FE 548; ← Leads to *The Red Share presses its claim after the widower's death*, 17 am Màrt, FE 549; → Caused by *Ciorstaidh's stone set in Fearghas's hall*, 15 an Giblean, FE 550; ← Leads to *The mason of Muileann chiar carries the tale*, 14 an Cèitean, FE 550.

45. the Peace of the Threshold

46. the Hall of the Flame

47. the Strife of the Heirs

- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 556** — *Both hosts called out for Achadh mhòr* (Achadh mhòr). In the heat of Lùnastal the Red Share's council and Cathair mhòr's both resolve within the same week to take Achadh mhòr's granary whole, and two riders reach Fearghas within an hour of each other, each astonished that his own lord's host was not first to move.⁴⁸
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 556** — *The last sheaf of Achadh mhòr carried clear of the fire* (Achadh mhòr). The reapers finish the western cutting and carry the last sheaf, bound and cut high as the custom asks, clear of the burning fields before the wind turns, and it is this sheaf, not the granary, that the households round about keep afterward at every harvest's end.⁴⁹
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 556** — *The waypoint house at Muileann chiar begins tallying grain* (Muileann chiar). In the season after Achadh mhòr's burning, the keeper of the waypoint house on the road below Muileann chiar chinks a slate with every granary along the carriers' road still holding grain, and rubs it out and chinks it again as the hungry winter empties one store after another. Carriers come to ask him for news of bread before they ask for news of the war.⁵⁰
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 556** — *A household of the middle plain sends its youngest son begging seed corn.* A family two days' walk from Achadh mhòr's blackened fields sends its youngest son round every kinsman it has, sworn or unsworn to either share, asking only for seed corn against the spring sowing and not for grain to eat that winter. He comes home with less than he asked for, gathered a handful at a time from households as pinched as his own.⁵¹
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 556** — *Ruairidh Glas writes to Eithne nic Ailein* (Dùn dhearg). Ruairidh Glas, holder of the Red Share at Dùn dhearg, sends word to Eithne nic Ailein of Cathair mhòr's plain that a war fought over a granary which no longer stands profits neither of their hungry households, and asks her to name ground where neither hall need be ashamed to meet.⁵²
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 556** — *Eithne nic Ailein names the threshold of Talla na Lasrach*⁵³ (Dùn iséal). Eithne nic Ailein answers Ruairidh Glas that she will set foot in no hall of the Red Share's, as he will set foot in none of hers, and names instead the threshold of Talla na Lasrach at Dùn iséal, where the stone cup stands on ground that belongs to no share and never has.⁵⁴

48. → Leads to *The burning of Achadh mhòr*, 24 an Lùnastal, FE 556.

49. ⇄ At the same time *The burning of Achadh mhòr*, 24 an Lùnastal, FE 556.

50. ← Follows from *The burning of Achadh mhòr*, 24 an Lùnastal, FE 556.

51. ← Follows from *The burning of Achadh mhòr*, 24 an Lùnastal, FE 556.

52. → Leads to *Sith an Stairnich*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 556.

53. the Hall of the Flame

54. → Leads to *Sith an Stairnich*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 556; ← Follows from *Ruairidh Glas writes to Eithne nic Ailein*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, FE 556.

- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 556** — *A reluctant lord is shamed into the swearing.* The steward of a lesser holding north of Achadh mhòr answers Eithne's summons that his lord sees no profit in standing bareheaded before an old woman to be told what he knows already. Eithne sends back that he may explain to his own hungry households why the peace that feeds everyone else's has passed his door by, and he comes a season late to swear it.⁵⁵
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 556** — *Eithne nic Ailein is carried up to Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Eithne nic Ailein, whose legs have long since stopped carrying her, is borne up the old carriers' road to Dùn ìseal in a chair, one pole carried by Niall Òg, who has outlived nearly every other soul that remembers the valley of the Roinn, and who tells her, on the road, that she is the last one left who remembers what he remembers.⁵⁶
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 556** — *The Keeper drafts and reads the terms of the Threshold* (Dùn ìseal). At the asking of both halls, neither of which trusts the other's clerks to write the terms fairly, the Keeper of the flame drafts the peace herself and reads it aloud to the gathered stones before any lord is asked to swear, so that the households standing beyond the lords may carry the whole of it home in their own words.⁵⁷
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 556** — *Ruairidh Glas speaks of the first blood at Dùn thais* (Dùn ìseal). Swearing the Peace of the Threshold with his hand still on the stone cup, Ruairidh Glas says before the gathered lords that he shed the first blood of the strife at Dùn thais over cattle on a wet slope, when he was young enough to think a stone worth a life, and that he would not buy it again for twice the grazing on the island.⁵⁸
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 557** — *A double-sworn household on the old boundary gives up one oath* (Achadh mhòr). A household sworn to two lords since a marriage two generations back keeps the oath that has cost it least and lets the other lapse before the spring sowing, its eldest son reasoning aloud that neither hall's carrier had once knocked on their door in the whole of the hungry winter past.⁵⁹
- II AN T-IUCHAR, FE 557** — *The first Threshold market stands thin and unparted* (Dùn ìseal). The first quarter-day market held below Talla na Lasrach⁶⁰ after the Peace draws little to sell, the hungry winter having left small surplus, and many households come only to watch whether a trader of the Red Share can stand at a stall beside one of Cathair mhòr's plain without a steward of either hall coming to part them. None comes.⁶¹

55. → Leads to *Sìth an Stairsnich*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 556; ← Follows from *Eithne nic Ailein names the threshold of Talla na Lasrach*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, FE 556.

56. → Leads to *Sìth an Stairsnich*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 556; ← Follows from *A reluctant lord is shamed into the swearing*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, FE 556.

57. → Leads to *Sìth an Stairsnich*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 556.

58. ¶ Legacy *First blood among the heirs*, 17 an Giblean, FE 3.

59. ← Follows from *Sìth an Stairsnich*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 556.

60. the Hall of the Flame

61. ← Follows from *The market under the Hall*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, FE 556.

- 9 **AN LÙNASTAL, FE 557** — *The boundary lines of the middle plain settle by the sowing.* By the time of the spring sowing after the Peace, the boundary lines that had shifted and blurred through forty years of burning have settled again into a shape that will hold for longer than any lord who swore to it that Samhain will live to see, with only small mendings asked at Dùn ìseal in the years after.⁶²
- 28 **AM FAOILLEACH, FE 565** — *The stag's people at Cnoc bhàn (Cnoc bhàn).* A house of the stag's people is founded at Cnoc bhàn, north of the mountain, and after the long exclusion takes cutters again. Its teachers keep the question of Sileas nic Coinnich as she left it: why does the coal show its colours for one hand and not another?
- 2 **AN T-SULTAIN, FE 571** — *The nine hearths raise Seonaid Chiar to the flame (Dùn ìseal).* The nine hearths of Dùn ìseal raise Seonaid Chiar of the house of Muireach to the flame at six-and-twenty years old, the youngest Keeper chosen since Muireach Liath's own day. Her grandmother, a cutter of the galleries all her working life, warns her that a young Keeper who bends once in her first year is asked to bend again for the rest of her keeping.
- 4 **AN LÙNASTAL, FE 573** — *Three teachers of Cnoc bhàn set an unlit lamp before the Hall's door (Dùn ìseal).* Three old teachers of the stag's school at Cnoc bhàn climb the mountain road on foot and set an unlit lamp on the stones before Talla na Lasrach⁶³, asking only to be let back among the cutters already working the galleries, and swearing to ask nothing of the vein aloud if the Hall will stop asking whether they have any right to stand near it.⁶⁴
- 26 **AN GEARRAN, FE 574** — *Seonaid Chiar reopens the galleries to the stag's people (Dùn ìseal).* Seonaid Chiar, Keeper of the house of Muireach, lets cutters trained by the stag's people back into the galleries at Dùn ìseal, sworn to ask nothing of the vein aloud. The Hall's roll calls it a reconciling. The school remembers it as a truce.⁶⁵
- 27 **AM MÀRT, FE 579** — *Cathair mhòr walled (Cathair mhòr).* The people of Cathair mhòr on the southern coast build a wall of fitted stone about their headland town, the first town wall on the island. What they feared no one has told.
- 16 **AM FAOILLEACH, FE 584** — *Ceann leathan's fish-market (Ceann leathan).* Ceann leathan becomes the market of the southern fishing and sends dried fish inland along the carriers' paths. Its harbour-master keeps tallies on notched sticks. Several are kept at Muileann chaol, the oldest counted things in its keeping.

62. ← Follows from *Sith an Stairnich*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 556.

63. the Hall of the Flame

64. ← Follows from *The nine hearths raise Seonaid Chiar to the flame*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 571.

65. → Caused by *The nine hearths raise Seonaid Chiar to the flame*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 571; → Caused by *Three teachers of Cnoc bhàn set an unlit lamp before the Hall's door*, 4 an Lùnastal, FE 573.

- 6 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 585** — *Seonaid Chiar's guild judgment at Cnoc leathan* (Dùn ìseal). Hearing two carriers of Cnoc leathan's guild each accuse the other of taking a fee out of turn, Seonaid Chiar asks only which of them had first offered to give the disputed load back, and, hearing neither had, tells them the Hall's grant is a right to carry and not a right to quarrel. The two settle the matter themselves before they have gone a mile down the mountain road.⁶⁶
- 14 AN GEARRAN, FE 589** — *The shrine at Inis thais* (Inis thais). A shrine to the ancestors lost at sea is raised at Inis thais on the western coast. Its keepers burn their season's handful on the shore and not indoors, so that the drowned, gone west over the sea, may see it.
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, FE 594** — *Cuan shean's salt-pans* (Cuan shean). The people of Cuan shean on the western coast dig salt-pans on the flats below the town and boil sea-water over peat. Their salt goes inland along the western road and keeps the fish of half the island.
- 31 AM MÀRT, FE 599** — *Salt-carriers on the heath above Baile fhiadhaich* (Baile fhiadhaich). Salt-carriers from Cuan shean settle on the western heath above Baile fhiadhaich, by a stream that runs all summer. The heath about it is not worth the plough, and its people keep goats.

66. ← Follows from *Three teachers of Cnoc bhàn set an unlit lamp before the Hall's door*, 4 an Lùnastal, FE 573.

THE YEARS FE 601 – 800

- 2 AM MÀRT, FE 604** — *The sunny house* (An Taigh-òsta Grianach¹). A waypoint house is built on the eastern road where the carriers from Cnoc leathan meet the southern coast path, on the site of An Taigh-òsta Grianach. It faces south, and from the first is known for its warmth, which is all its name has ever meant.
- 1 AN GEARRAN, FE 609** — *Cnoc leathan's market* (Cnoc leathan). Cnoc leathan, at the eastern end of the road past the sunny house, becomes the market town of the south-eastern hills. Its carriers' guild holds the right to carry for the Hall on the stretch down to the coast.²
- 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 611** — *Ruairidh Glas stands once more before the stone cup* (Dùn ìseal). In his nine hundred and ninth year, Ruairidh Glas, holder of the Red Share, asks unasked leave to climb Dùn ìseal on foot and stand again before the stone cup, though no lord of a share is required to outside the quarter days. He says nothing aloud that any living ear catches, and goes back down the same evening to Dùn dhearg.³
- 10 AN GIBLEAN, FE 612** — *Ruairidh Glas dies at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Ruairidh Glas dies in his own bed at Dùn dhearg, having lived nine hundred and ten years and never once returned to Dùn thais since the morning he shed the first blood of the strife of the heirs there. He outlives every soul who stood beside him at the ford where his grandfather's line first took the Red Hill.⁴
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, FE 612** — *The Red Share passes without a summons to the Hall* (Dùn dhearg). Ruairidh Glas's son takes up the Red Share at Dùn dhearg without any summons to the Hall, as the Peace of the Threshold requires none where an heir is named and undisputed. The season's rolls, careful to name every lesser lord, stay strangely thin about naming this one, a silence the Hall's clerk lays to the household's own quiet rather than to any failure of the pen.⁵
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 614** — *The fall in the high gallery* (Dùn ìseal). A roof falls in the highest gallery at Dùn ìseal and kills four cutters. The gallery is walled up and left. Seonaid Chiar orders props of oak set in every gallery after, and for the first time the Hall spends timber on the mountain.

1. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

2. ← Leads to *Seonaid Chiar's guild judgment at Cnoc leathan*, 6 an t-Iuchar, FE 585.

3. ¶ Legacy *Sith an Stairsnich*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 556; ← Follows from *Seonaid Chiar's guild judgment at Cnoc leathan*, 6 an t-Iuchar, FE 585.

4. ¶ Legacy *First blood among the heirs*, 17 an Giblean, FE 3; ← Follows from *Ruairidh Glas stands once more before the stone cup*, 7 an t-Ògmhios, FE 611.

5. ← Follows from *Sith an Stairsnich*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 556; ← Follows from *Ruairidh Glas dies at Dùn dhearg*, 10 an Giblean, FE 612.

- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 614** — *The four dead of the high gallery are buried on the Hall's own ground* (Dùn ìseal). The four cutters killed when the roof of the highest gallery falls at Dùn ìseal are carried up and buried on the Hall's own ground, the one ground on the island no feud has ever been let to follow a man. Seonaid Chiar sets the last stone over the last of them with her own hands, which no Keeper before her is remembered to have done.⁶
- 21 AN CÈITEAN, FE 615** — *The first oak props are cut for the galleries* (Dùn ìseal). After a season's argument over how a gallery roof should ever be held against another such fall, Seonaid Chiar orders timber props of oak set in every gallery the Hall works, the first timber the Hall has ever spent on the mountain itself. The first oak is felled and cut within the season, so that no gallery stands unpropped by the following year's cutting.⁷
- 10 AN GIBLEAN, FE 630** — *Seonaid Chiar dies above the galleries she kept* (Dùn ìseal). Seonaid Chiar dies in her own quarters above the galleries at Dùn ìseal, eighty-five years old, having held the flame the better part of six decades. The nine hearths that raised her young choose another after her without any dispute the rolls think worth setting down.⁸
- 22 AN GIBLEAN, FE 630** — *The school at Cnoc bhàn returns its unlit lamp* (Dùn ìseal). On word of Seonaid Chiar's death, the school at Cnoc bhàn sends no delegation and no message of grief, only the same unlit lamp its three old teachers once set before her door, carried back up by cutters young enough to have known no other Keeper, and left again on the same stones, still unlit.⁹
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 634** — *Cathair dhombhain founded* (Cathair dhomhain). Carriers settled at the mouth of the western road raise a town on the rise above the harbour and name it Cathair dhomhain. Its shrine keeps the Law's measure strictly, and its people are proud of it.
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, FE 635** — *Cathair dhomhain's shrine holds the Law to the grain* (Cathair dhomhain). The new shrine at Cathair dhomhain keeps the Small-Burning Law to the very grain from its founding day, a strictness the town becomes known for beyond any other pride it holds. Lowland households speak of it for a lifetime, though the town itself remains a place carriers pass through on the way to somewhere else.¹⁰
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 654** — *A fishing town at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). The old settlement of the Red Hill, shrunk to a small fishing town, grows again at the western bridge-foot on the Abhainn dhomhain, a little above its meeting with the Abhainn gheal below Loch chrom. The ground is afterwards called Cathair dhearg, for its red stone. As yet it is a place carriers pass through on the way to somewhere else.

6. ← Follows from *The fall in the high gallery*, 23 an Lùnastal, FE 614.

7. ← Follows from *The fall in the high gallery*, 23 an Lùnastal, FE 614; ← Follows from *The four dead of the high gallery are buried on the Hall's own ground*, 3 an t-Sultain, FE 614.

8. ← Follows from *Seonaid Chiar reopens the galleries to the stag's people*, 26 an Gearran, FE 574; ← Follows from *The first oak props are cut for the galleries*, 21 an Cèitean, FE 615.

9. ¶ Legacy *Seonaid Chiar reopens the galleries to the stag's people*, 26 an Gearran, FE 574; ← Follows from *Seonaid Chiar dies above the galleries she kept*, 10 an Giblean, FE 630.

10. ← Follows from *Cathair dhombhain founded*, 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 634.

- 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 660** — *The death of Cailean* (Dùn dhearg). Cailean, a cousin of Goraidh mac Ìomhair through their grandmothers, dies under a wall he is mending at his own hall in a night of high wind. He leaves no child of his body, and his county of the east goes unclaimed.
- 6 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 662** — *The death of Donnchadh* (Dùn dhearg). Donnchadh, Cailean's younger brother, dies of a cough the hearth-women cannot cut, with his sister's hand in his. He too leaves no child, and the second of the three old counties east of Dùn dhearg is left without an heir named.¹¹
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 668** — *Goraidh's marriage to Muirne nic Dhonnchaidh* (Dùn dhearg). Goraidh mac Ìomhair rides to Muirne nic Dhonnchaidh, a widowed kinswoman of four hundred years who holds the third of the old eastern counties alone, and marries her in the spring. Her county comes whole into the marriage, as the Peace of the Threshold allows, and Goraidh takes on her dead husbands' debts to the county's smiths.¹²
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 669** — *Goraidh rides the three counties* (Dùn dhearg). Through the first year of the marriage Goraidh mac Ìomhair walks the boundaries of all three gathered counties with Muirne beside him, eating at the hearths and not the halls, learning which streams have moved and which grazings are old enough to fight over.¹³
- 11 AN GEARRAN, FE 672** — *The hungry harvests* (Dùn dhearg). Two summers running the rains come at the wrong end of the season and the barley rots standing in the low ground east of Dùn dhearg. Goraidh mac Ìomhair opens all four of his granaries and gives grain outright to nine households that cannot pay even the lowered price.¹⁴
- 3 AN GIBLEAN, FE 674** — *Goraidh gathers the shares of the east* (Dùn dhearg). By two cousins dead without heirs and a marriage to a third, Goraidh mac Ìomhair holds in one hand three of the old counties of the east round Dùn dhearg, parted since the Roinn. He is the first of the kin to gather again what the Roinn had divided, and the Peace of the Threshold lets him keep it whole.¹⁵
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, FE 674** — *Goraidh mac Ìomhair called rìgh* (Dùn dhearg). At Dùn dhearg the lowland households who eat from the granaries of Sliochd Ìomhair¹⁶ begin to call its head, Goraidh mac Ìomhair, their rìgh, their king. No one had been so called since Ailean Mòr, for at the Roinn the heirs swore that none of them would take the word. Goraidh claims nothing over the vein, and is careful to tell the Hall so.¹⁷

11. ← Follows from *The death of Cailean*, 7 an t-Ògmhios, FE 660.

12. ← Follows from *The death of Donnchadh*, 6 an t-Iuchar, FE 662.

13. ← Follows from *Goraidh's marriage to Muirne nic Dhonnchaidh*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, FE 668.

14. ← Follows from *Goraidh rides the three counties*, 13 am Faoilleach, FE 669.

15. → Caused by *The death of Cailean*, 7 an t-Ògmhios, FE 660; → Caused by *The death of Donnchadh*, 6 an t-Iuchar, FE 662; ← Leads to *Goraidh's marriage to Muirne nic Dhonnchaidh*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, FE 668; ← Leads to *Goraidh rides the three counties*, 13 am Faoilleach, FE 669.

16. the house of Ìomhar

- 12 AM MÀRT, FE 677** — *Death of Muirne nic Dhonnchaidh* (Dùn dhearg). Muirne nic Dhonnchaidh dies in her sleep in the ninth year of her marriage to Goraidh mac Ìomhair, with her own county's reciter in the room. He buries her among her own dead, as she asked him.¹⁸
- 28 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 688** — *The timber hall of Dùn dhearg raised with a granary at each corner* (Dùn dhearg). Goraidh mac Ìomhair raises a long hall of squared oak on his father's rise at Dùn dhearg, with a granary at each of its four corners. The carpenters of the Red Share and of the three gathered counties raise it side by side, and the granaries are filled from all four counties in one season.¹⁹
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 693** — *Goraidh leaves his spear at the last house* (Dùn ìseal). Come to answer the council's word, Goraidh mac Ìomhair leaves his spear with his men at the last waypoint house on the mountain road and climbs to Dùn ìseal on foot and unarmed.²⁰
- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 694** — *The division of keeping* (Dùn ìseal). The council at Dùn ìseal and Goraidh mac Ìomhair agree on a division. The Keeper keeps the flame and the galleries; the rìgh keeps the roads, the granaries and the peace of the lowlands. The rìgh may not enter the galleries, and the Keeper may not raise spears. On this division the island is governed for the rest of the age.²¹
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 694** — *The waypoint-keepers gather the road toll for a share* (Dùn dhearg). Goraidh does not gather the toll of one fish in twenty himself. He gives it to the keepers of the waypoint houses along each road, who have kept a bed and a fire for carriers since before his grandfather's day, and lets each keep a share of what they take.²²
- 16 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 703** — *A waypoint-keeper's short tally forgiven*. At a waypoint house on the northern road a keeper's first season's toll comes in a tenth short, for want of anyone at the door by night. Goraidh mac Ìomhair laughs at the reckoning and lets the shortfall stand.²³
- 11 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 714** — *Goraidh Mòr's hall* (Dùn dhearg). Goraidh mac Ìomhair, called Goraidh Mòr, builds a timber hall on the hill at Dùn dhearg, with a granary at each corner. Its post-holes could still be seen when the surveyors of the Library walked the hill, and they measured and drew them.

17. → Caused by *The hungry harvests*, 11 an Gearran, FE 672.

18. ↓ Legacy *Goraidh gathers the shares of the east*, 3 an Giblean, FE 674; ← Follows from *The hungry harvests*, 11 an Gearran, FE 672.

19. ← Follows from *Death of Muirne nic Dhonnchaidh*, 12 am Màrt, FE 677.

20. ← Follows from *The timber hall of Dùn dhearg raised with a granary at each corner*, 28 an t-Samhain, FE 688.

21. → Caused by *Goraidh leaves his spear at the last house*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, FE 693.

22. ← Follows from *Goraidh leaves his spear at the last house*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, FE 693.

23. ← Follows from *The waypoint-keepers gather the road toll for a share*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, FE 694.

- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 719** — *The first road-toll* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr²⁴). Goraidh Mòr sets a toll on the carriers' roads, one fish in twenty or its worth, to pay the road-guards and keep up the bridges. The keepers of the waypoint houses gather it, and keep a share of it, and the rolls say so.²⁵
- 11 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 725** — *Mòrag takes up the walking of the roads* (Dùn dhearg). Goraidh's daughter Mòrag, who could never sit still in a hall, takes over the walking of the island's roads from her ageing father long before he will call it a handing-over. He lets her.²⁶
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 736** — *Dòmhnall's fall from the cart* (Dùn dhearg). Dòmhnall, riding the back board of a laden cart above the ford, is thrown under its wheel where it strikes a stone left standing proud of the road-bed. His leg is set and set again and never knits true; he walks with a stick the rest of his life.
- 22 AN GIBLEAN, FE 753** — *Death of Goraidh Mòr* (Dùn dhearg). Goraidh mac Ìomhair dies in his own hall at Dùn dhearg in his two hundred and thirteenth year, in the granary month, asking after the notching of the western road's toll-sticks. His daughter Mòrag and two waypoint-keepers rendering their tallies are with him.²⁷
- 21 AN CÈITEAN, FE 753** — *The toll-stick notched at Mòr nic Dhùghaill's old house* (Am Bùabhall Fortanach²⁸). Days after Goraidh Mòr's death, the keeper of the old waypoint house that was Mòr nic Dhùghaill's notches a fresh toll-stick for a carrier's fish and a carrier's wool, as she has every week before and will every week after, whoever holds the hall at Dùn dhearg.²⁹
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 754** — *Mòrag of the Roads* (Dùn dhearg). Mòrag nic Ghoraidh takes the hall at Dùn dhearg after her father Goraidh Mòr. She is called Mòrag nan Rathad, Mòrag of the Roads, for in her first years she walks every carriers' road on the island and orders the bad stretches made anew.³⁰
- 18 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 756** — *The toll-chest counted at a keeper's own door* (Dùn dhearg). Mòrag nan Rathad finds the toll-house two days east of the ford unanswered longest of all its keepers' letters. She has her road-guards open the keeper's own chest and counts the silver on a cloth before him, takes half for the mending, and leaves half for his household.³¹
- 25 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 760** — *Mòrag meets Niall Òg on the northern road* (Dùn dhearg). On a wet stretch of the northern road, Mòrag nan Rathad shelters from rain beside an old man on a milestone: Niall Òg, grandson of Ailean Mòr, now past his sixteen hundredth year. He tells her his name and sits with her a while before going on afoot.³²

24. the second waypoint house, a turf longhouse with a hearth at either end

25. ← Leads to *A waypoint-keeper's short tally forgiven*, 16 an Lùnastal, FE 703.

26. ← Follows from *A waypoint-keeper's short tally forgiven*, 16 an Lùnastal, FE 703.

27. ← Follows from *Mòrag takes up the walking of the roads*, 11 an t-Samhain, FE 725.

28. the first waypoint house, kept by Mòr nic Dhùghaill above Doire shean

29. ‡ Legacy *The first road-toll*, 22 an t-Sultain, FE 719.

- 19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 760** — *Niall Òg tells Mòrag of the cord* (Dùn dhearg). Niall Òg tells Mòrag nan Rathad of the cord of seven hundred and twelve knots laid on the floor at Dùn ìseal, and says she is the first of the line he has met who looks at the cord itself and not at her own knot in it.³³
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 763** — *The golden house opened free of toll* (Seann Dunn). Mòrag nan Rathad opens the new waypoint house on the eastern road north of Seann Dunn with a night's feast for every carrier who can be reached in time, none of them charged the toll. Carriers call the new timber the golden house before it has weathered, and the name holds.³⁴
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 781** — *The golden house* (An Taigh-seinnse Òir³⁵). Mòrag nan Rathad has a waypoint house built on the road north of Seann Dunn, on the site of An Taigh-seinnse Òir, to shorten the carriers' stage from the coast to the mountain. It is the first waypoint house raised by a ruler and not by a family.³⁶
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 794** — *The bridge-foot rebuilt* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg³⁷). At the bidding of Mòrag nan Rathad the western crossing of the Abhainn dhomhain is rebuilt in wider stone, so that two laden carriers can pass on it. The hearth-sign of Ailean Clachair is cut again in its keystone. From this time the town at the bridge-foot begins to grow.
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 794** — *The bridge-foot town begins to grow* (Cathair dhearg). After the western crossing of the Abhainn dhomhain is widened for two laden carts abreast, the small fishing town at the bridge-foot below Dùn ìseal begins to grow in earnest, outgrowing three neighbouring towns within Mòrag nan Rathad's own lifetime.³⁸
- 22 AN GIBLEAN, FE 800** — *Mòrag names Dòmhnall her heir* (Dùn dhearg). Mòrag nan Rathad has her lame son Dòmhnall carried the length of three road-stretches in a covered chair, then names him before the household at Dùn dhearg as her heir, past her hundred and sixtieth year herself.

32. ← Follows from *Mòrag of the Roads*, 21 an Dàmhair, FE 754; ← Follows from *The toll-chest counted at a keeper's own door*, 18 an t-Iuchar, FE 756.

30. → Caused by *Death of Goraidh Mòr*, 22 an Giblean, FE 753.

31. ← Follows from *Mòrag of the Roads*, 21 an Dàmhair, FE 754.

33. ↓ Legacy *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 1; ← Follows from *Mòrag meets Niall Òg on the northern road*, 25 am Faoilleach, FE 760.

34. ← Follows from *Niall Òg tells Mòrag of the cord*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, FE 760.

35. the golden house, a waypoint inn

36. ← Leads to *The golden house opened free of toll*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, FE 763.

37. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

38. ← Follows from *The bridge-foot rebuilt*, 24 an Lùnastal, FE 794; ← Follows from *The golden house opened free of toll*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, FE 763.

THE YEARS FE 801 – 1,000

- 25 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 830** — *Mòrag's last circuit of the roads* (Dùn dhearg). Against the advice of her household, Mòrag nan Rathad rides the whole western circuit in her hundred and eighty-ninth year, finding less to mend than in any year of her reign, and tells the waypoint-keepers so at every house she stops in.¹
- 14 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 834** — *Mòrag nan Rathad dies at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Mòrag nan Rathad dies at Dùn dhearg in the winter, a hundred and ninety-four years old, with her son beside her. Carriers from three days' distance come to stand outside the hall, and Dòmhnall feeds them from the golden house's own stores.²
- 16 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 834** — *Dòmhnall Crùbach* (Dùn dhearg). Dòmhnall Crùbach, Dòmhnall the Lamé, follows his mother Mòrag at Dùn dhearg. He cannot walk the roads as she did, and rules through the keepers of the waypoint houses, who grow mighty in his reign.³
- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 834** — *Niall Òg speaks over Mòrag's grave* (Dùn dhearg). At Mòrag nan Rathad's grave, Niall Òg says that of the seven hundred and twelve heirs he once watched knotted on the cord, she alone spent her life looking at the cord itself, and that her roads are the nearest thing since to that cord laid honestly on the ground.⁴
- 16 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 860** — *Sileas Dhonn finds the Ceann mhin rolls do not add* (Ceann mhin). Dòmhnall Crùbach's young niece Sileas Dhonn, asked to check the waypoint-keepers' tallies, finds three years in which the Ceann mhin keepers' own count does not match what passed through their gates, though never provably by theft. She keeps her own copy of the figures and says nothing of it while her uncle lives.
- 21 AN CÈITEAN, FE 862** — *The scorpion's sting sworn on at a trade* (Baile àrsaidh). At Baile àrsaidh a woman stung on the hand during a trade of cattle for salt fish finishes the bargain with her fingers still swelling, saying a hurt taken in the open is worth more than a promise given behind a closed door. Others take up her way of it, keeping a dried sting in a box to swear by.
- 14 AN GEARRAN, FE 863** — *The waypoint-keepers of Ceann mhin* (Ceann mhin). In the reign of Dòmhnall Crùbach the keepers of the waypoint houses about the harbour town of Ceann mhin take the gathering of the road-toll into their own hands and pay the right what they judge fair. Their judgement is generous to themselves, and the rolls keep the sums.⁵

1. ← Follows from *Mòrag of the Roads*, 21 an Dàmhair, FE 754; ← Follows from *Mòrag names Dòmhnall her heir*, 22 an Giblean, FE 800.

2. ← Follows from *Mòrag of the Roads*, 21 an Dàmhair, FE 754; ← Follows from *Mòrag's last circuit of the roads*, 25 am Faoilleach, FE 830.

3. → Caused by *Dòmhnall's fall from the cart*, 13 an Dàmhair, FE 736; → Caused by *Mòrag names Dòmhnall her heir*, 22 an Giblean, FE 800; → Caused by *Mòrag nan Rathad dies at Dùn dhearg*, 14 am Faoilleach, FE 834.

4. ¶ Legacy *Mòrag of the Roads*, 21 an Dàmhair, FE 754; ← Follows from *Mòrag nan Rathad dies at Dùn dhearg*, 14 am Faoilleach, FE 834.

- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 879** — *Baile àrsaidh on the western heath* (Baile àrsaidh). Settlers from Cathair dhomhain take the wet heath of the west coast and found Baile àrsaidh, where the soil is thin and the yellow scorpions thick. They swear their oaths on a scorpion's sting kept in a box, and their neighbours think it a strange custom.⁶
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 879** — *The storm at Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). A storm drives the sea over the harbour at Seann Chwen and takes the boats and a third of the houses. The Keeper sends the Hall's grain from Dùn ìseal, and Dòmhnall Crùbach sends his from Dùn dhearg. The survivors remember that the Hall's came first.
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 879** — *The Hall's grain-carts reach Seann Chwen first* (Dùn ìseal). After the storm at Seann Chwen, the Keeper's grain-carts reach the ruined harbour a full day ahead of Dòmhnall Crùbach's, running the whole way on the road above the ford that Mòrag nan Rathad raised out of the mud in the first summer of her reign.⁷
- 4 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 880** — *The sting first sworn on at a wider trade* (Baile àrsaidh). The scorpion's-sting oath of Baile àrsaidh is sworn for the first time at a trade with an outside harbour town, at Ros bheag, carrying the custom beyond the settlement that began it.⁸
- 2 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 880** — *Rònat sent to the stag's school* (Muileann chiar). A boy of ten with a talent for losing count past thirty is sent from his father's holding to the stag's school in the holy wood east of Muileann chiar. Aonghas Cam, the old cutter, scores his first tally-stick through the middle and sets him cutting sticks two years before he is trusted near a beast to be counted.
- 20 AM MÀRT, FE 901** — *Aonghas Cam's failing thread* (Muileann chiar). A fever settles in the old cutter's crooked leg and will not draw out. Through that winter Rònat watches him grope after names and lines of the long teaching-thread and not always find them, and it is by that fireside, and not by any beast to be counted, that the shape of the sound-marks first comes to him.⁹
- 19 AN GEARRAN, FE 902** — *The first name cut in strokes* (Muileann chiar). Rònat cuts his own name onto a length of ash by a scheme of small strokes, one to a sound, and reads it back cold three days after. He sets the same trick to Aonghas Cam's own name and lays the stick in the old man's hand, who reads his name off it and calls it a count of sounds where he had always cut a count of fish.¹⁰
- 21 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 903** — *The death of Aonghas Cam* (Muileann chiar). The old cutter of Muileann chiar's stag school dies in his sleep, having asked that his own years be counted the old way at the last, one stroke to a year, having spent his life trusting a count over a name. Rònat cuts the tally himself.¹¹

5. → Caused by *Sileas Dhonn finds the Ceann mbin rolls do not add*, 16 an Lùnastal, FE 860.

6. → Caused by *The scorpion's sting sworn on at a trade*, 21 an Cèitean, FE 862.

7. ¶ Legacy *The storm at Seann Chwen*, 18 an Dùbhlachd, FE 879; ¶ Legacy *Mòrag of the Roads*, 21 an Dàmhair, FE 754.

8. ← Follows from *Baile àrsaidh on the western heath*, 19 an t-Samhain, FE 879.

9. ← Follows from *Rònat sent to the stag's school*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 880.

10. ← Follows from *Aonghas Cam's failing thread*, 20 am Màrt, FE 901.

- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 905** — *The western teachers come east* (Muileann chiar). Two teachers of the western druid school travel to the far-eastern Muileann chiar to learn Rònát's sound-marks, and stay a season under a man twenty years their junior. Among them is Sileas nic Ruairidh, eldest of the two, who carries the scheme home and turns it over in her own mind.¹²
- 15 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 908** — *The letters set against the obelisk* (Carragh Cnoc bheag¹³). Rònát and two others walk five days east to the grey stone at Cnoc bheag and set the sound-marks stroke for stroke against the old marks cut there. Nothing answers: no vowel, no grouping, no order in the stone's marks matches theirs.¹⁴
- 14 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 908** — *The first thing written of the old marks* (Carragh Cnoc bheag¹⁵). Before the road home, Rònát cuts onto ash the finding at Cnoc bheag: that the makers of the old stone did not teach the makers of the stag's marks and are not known to them. It is the first thought, rather than a name or a count, that the new marks are made to carry.¹⁶
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, FE 912** — *Niall Òg at the stag's school* (Muileann chiar). The ancient heir passes through the far east on foot and sits two evenings by the school's fire, telling pupils tales of the night of the handful. He asks, at the second evening's end, after the trick of marks he has heard tell of on the road.¹⁷
- 17 AN CÈITEAN, FE 912** — *Niall Òg reads his own name* (Muileann chiar). Rònát cuts Niall Òg's name in the sound-marks and sets the stick in his hand. The old heir, who has been called by his name more times than there are fish in the western sea, reads it back within the hour and laughs until he coughs, saying he has found, at last, a name that stays after the mouth that gave it has gone home.¹⁸
- 15 AM MÀRT, FE 914** — *The stag-letters* (Muileann chiar). At Muileann chiar in the far east the teachers of the stag's people make the cutters' tally-notches into signs for sounds, so that a teaching may be kept without a teacher. These are the first letters the Dia-thirich use: the ogham, which the druids call the gift of Oghma.¹⁹

11. ← Follows from *The first name cut in strokes*, 19 an Gearran, FE 902.

12. ← Follows from *The death of Aonghas Cam*, 21 am Faoilleach, FE 903.

13. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

14. ← Follows from *The western teachers come east*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, FE 905.

15. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

16. ← Follows from *The letters set against the obelisk*, 15 an t-Ògmhios, FE 908.

17. ← Follows from *The first thing written of the old marks*, 14 an t-Iuchar, FE 908.

18. ← Follows from *Niall Òg at the stag's school*, 18 an Giblean, FE 912.

19. → Caused by *Rònát sent to the stag's school*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 880; → Caused by *Aonghas Cam's failing thread*, 20 am Màrt, FE 901; → Caused by *The first name cut in strokes*, 19 an Gearran, FE 902; ← Leads to *The death of Aonghas Cam*, 21 am Faoilleach, FE 903; ← Leads to *The western teachers come east*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, FE 905.

- 12 AN CÈITEAN, FE 914** — *The letters set against the obelisk* (Carragh Cnoc bheag²⁰). Scholars of the stag carry their new letters to Carragh Cnoc bheag and set them beside the marks on the obelisk. They match nothing. The scholars write that the stone's makers were not their teachers, and that is the first thing the Dia-thìrich ever write of the old people.²¹
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, FE 914** — *The chest of mismatched tallies opened* (Dùn dhearg). Sileas Dhonn, new in the chair at Dùn dhearg after Dòmhnall Crùbach's death, has brought out and opened before the household the chest she has kept locked for years: her own fair copy of three seasons' Ceann mhin tallies that never matched the toll counted at the gate.
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 914** — *Sileas Dhonn* (Dùn dhearg). Sileas Dhonn, niece of Dòmhnall Crùbach, holds Dùn dhearg after him. In her reign the keepers of the waypoint houses are bidden to render account of the tolls at her hall once a year, and several of them do.²²
- 4 AN GIBLEAN, FE 915** — *Beathan mac Dhonnchaidh's memory found wanting* (Muileann shean). The old keeper of Muileann shean recites his tally to Sileas Dhonn from memory, the old way, name for name; she asks him plainly how she is to know it is the same tally he gave the road-guard three seasons past. He has no answer beyond his own honesty, and she sends east for a teacher of the sound-marks.²³
- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 915** — *Rònat teaches Sileas Dhonn's clerks* (Dùn dhearg). Rònat walks the last long road of his active years to Dùn dhearg and teaches the ruler's clerks the sound-marks over a winter, finding grown clerks trained to a column of figures quicker with the knife than any pupil he taught in the holy wood.²⁴
- 3 AN CÈITEAN, FE 916** — *Ailig mac Ruairidh caught by his own gate* (Ceann mhin). The keeper of Ceann mhin's toll, first summoned to render account cut in the new marks and checked against the road-guard's own cutting at his gate, is found short by a sum no honest forgetting explains. It is the first time a keeper's own tally, and not his word, answers for him before the hall.²⁵
- 1 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 916** — *The first whole sentence* (Dùn dhearg). Cutting the record of Ailig mac Ruairidh's shortfall for the hall's keeping, Rònat sets down the first whole sentence any hand has yet cut in the sound-marks: that the toll of Ceann mhin was counted short and the keeper answered for it. It stands after him in the hall, saying the same thing to every thumb that reads it.²⁶

20. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

21. → Caused by *The letters set against the obelisk*, 15 an t-Ògmhios, FE 908; ← Leads to *The first thing written of the old marks*, 14 an t-Iuchar, FE 908.

22. → Caused by *Sileas Dhonn finds the Ceann mhin rolls do not add*, 16 an Lùnastal, FE 860; → Caused by *The chest of mismatched tallies opened*, 26 an Cèitean, FE 914.

23. ← Follows from *Sileas Dhonn*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, FE 914; ← Follows from *The chest of mismatched tallies opened*, 26 an Cèitean, FE 914.

24. ← Follows from *Sileas Dhonn*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, FE 914; ← Follows from *Beathan mac Dhonnchaidh's memory found wanting*, 4 an Giblean, FE 915.

25. ← Follows from *Sileas Dhonn*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, FE 914; ← Follows from *Rònat teaches Sileas Dhonn's clerks*, 2 an t-Iuchar, FE 915.

- 14 AN GEARRAN, FE 991** — *The lords of Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). The harbour town of Caol leathan in the south-west grows rich on the western fishing and the southern end of the carriers' road. Its leading family, under Lachlann Ciar, takes the road-toll for itself and sends none of it to Dùn dhearg.
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, FE 994** — *Sileas Dhonn dies at her ledger* (Dùn dhearg). Sileas Dhonn dies in the chair at Dùn dhearg with a keeper's tally open on her knee, in her hundred and ninety-fourth year. She has asked that the chair stand its customary night and day and no longer, having had forty years at her uncle's side to learn the feel of it.
- 12 AN CÈITEAN, FE 994** — *Iain Garbh* (Dùn dhearg). Iain Garbh, Iain the Rough, son of Sileas Dhonn, takes the hall at Dùn dhearg and demands the western tolls of Caol leathan. Lachlann Ciar sends back a basket of fish-bones.²⁷
- 28 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 994** — *Iain Garbh's demand sent south* (Dùn dhearg). On his first morning in the chair Iain Garbh reads Caol leathan's thin account and sends a rider south with a plain demand in his own hand: the toll owed in full, counted before Dùn dhearg's own man at the harbour, or an answer for why it should not be paid.²⁸
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 994** — *The basket set on the hall floor* (Dùn dhearg). Iain Garbh's rider returns from Caol leathan white about the mouth, carrying a covered basket he will not open himself. Iain lifts the lid to find it packed in rows with fish-bones, picked clean, and no letter with it.²⁹
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 994** — *Iain Garbh calls the levy* (Dùn dhearg). Iain Garbh laughs once over the basket of fish-bones, then calls the road-guards from every waypoint within three days' ride and tells the lowland households their levy stands, raising his voice at no one the whole of that week.³⁰
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, FE 999** — *The War of the Roads begins at Muileann òg* (Muileann òg). Iain Garbh marches west with the road-guards and the lowland levies, and burns the toll-house at Muileann òg that the men of Lachlann Ciar had taken. It is the first war of Dia-thìreach against Dia-thìreach since the Peace of the Threshold, and the first fought over a road; every war before it was fought over a share. The Hall will bless neither side.³¹
- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,000** — *Uisdean mac Ruairidh's refusal* (Dùn ìseal). The Keeper Uisdean mac Ruairidh refuses the messengers of Iain Garbh at Dùn ìseal the Hall's handful for the warband's hearths, saying that the flame does not warm men who go out to kill. The warband winters on peat. Iain Garbh never forgives the Hall, and never enters it.

26. ← Follows from *Sileas Dhonn*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, FE 914; ← Follows from *Ailig mac Ruairidh caught by his own gate*, 3 an Cèitean, FE 916.

27. → Caused by *Sileas Dhonn dies at her ledger*, 17 an Giblean, FE 994.

28. ← Follows from *Iain Garbh*, 12 an Cèitean, FE 994; ← Follows from *Sileas Dhonn dies at her ledger*, 17 an Giblean, FE 994.

29. ← Follows from *Iain Garbh*, 12 an Cèitean, FE 994; ← Follows from *Iain Garbh's demand sent south*, 28 an t-Samhain, FE 994.

30. ← Follows from *The basket set on the hall floor*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, FE 994.

31. → Caused by *Iain Garbh calls the levy*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, FE 994.

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,000 — *Iain Garbh folds the Keeper's answer* (Dùn ìseal). Iain Garbh's messengers return from Dùn ìseal empty-handed, made to repeat Uisdean mac Ruairidh's refusal word for word. Iain folds the written answer once and puts it inside his coat, and never again sets foot on the Hall's ground.³²

32. ← Follows from *Uisdean mac Ruairidh's refusal*, 19 an t-Samhain, FE 1,000; ← Follows from *Iain Garbh calls the levy*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, FE 994.

THE YEARS FE 1,001 – 1,200

- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,001** — *The fight at Àth fhiadhaich* (Àth fhiadhaich). The men of Caol leathan meet the levies of Iain Garbh at the ford of Àth fhiadhaich and hold it for a day before they give way. Forty lie dead of both sides. Long afterwards the carriers call it the ford of the forty.
- 28 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,001** — *The coughing winter at Muileann òg* (Muileann òg). The warband winters on peat smoke at the burned toll-house of Muileann òg. Men who marched south whole come home in spring with a cough some of them carry the rest of their days, so that the older road-guards are known ever after by the sound of a hard winter's night.¹
- 16 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,002** — *Baile ghlais burned* (Baile ghlais). The men of Lachlann Ciar, falling back on Caol leathan, burn Baile ghlais, that the levies of Iain Garbh may find no grain. Its people walk to Cathair dhomhain, and many never return.
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,002** — *The unnamed man of the ford* (Àth fhiadhaich). At the ford of Àth fhiadhaich a man of Caol leathan holds a split shield upright well past any sense left in the holding, until a spear from behind Iain Garbh's own rank finds him. No name is ever kept for him.²
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,003** — *Baile chiald holds* (Baile chiald). Baile chiald, south of the western bridge-foot, shuts its gate on both hosts in the War of the Roads and feeds the burned-out folk of Baile ghlais through the winter. Neither side forgives it, and neither attacks it.
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,003** — *Beathag of Baile chiald turns back a spear* (Baile chiald). Riding to Baile chiald for a night's lodging, Iain Garbh is met on the wall by the town's reeve, Beathag, who will open the gate to the hungry and to no one carrying a spear. He leaves the spear on the road and sleeps that night among the burned-out of Baile ghlais.³
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,005** — *The siege of Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). Iain Garbh shuts Caol leathan in from the land for a season, but its boats bring in fish from the sea, and the harbour he cannot close. His levies begin to go home for the harvest, and the siege ends without an assault.

1. ← Follows from *Uisdean mac Ruairidh's refusal*, 19 an t-Samhain, FE 1,000; ← Follows from *Iain Garbh folds the Keeper's answer*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,000.

2. ← Follows from *The fight at Àth fhiadhaich*, 21 an Dàmhair, FE 1,001; ← Follows from *The coughing winter at Muileann òg*, 28 an t-Samhain, FE 1,001.

3. ← Follows from *Baile chiald holds*, 18 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,003; ← Follows from *The unnamed man of the ford*, 28 an Lùnastal, FE 1,002.

- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,006** — *The peace at Mòr nic Dhùghaill's house* (Am Buabhall Fortanach⁴). Iain Garbh and Lachlann Ciar meet under the roof of the waypoint house that is afterwards Am Buabhall Fortanach, where by the road-peace neither may draw. Caol leathan keeps half its tolls and sends half to Dùn dhearg, and Lachlann Ciar swears to the Law before the Keeper's witness. So the War of the Roads ends in a house built to feed carriers.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,008** — *Lachlann Ciar's confession at the peace-board* (Am Buabhall Fortanach⁵). At the waypoint house on the road-peace, Lachlann Ciar tells Iain Garbh that the basket of fish-bones was his son's notion, sent out under his own name because a father does not answer for a son's foolishness by naming him. The two talk the evening out.⁶
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,009** — *The wolf-sworn of Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). Men who fought for Caol leathan become its road-guards and swear their watch on a white stone carved as a wolf, kept at the town gate. They call themselves the wolf-sworn.
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,009** — *Iain Garbh witnesses the wolf-sworn* (Caol leathan). At Lachlann Ciar's own asking, Iain Garbh rides south to stand at the gate of Caol leathan while the men of its siege swear their new watch on a white stone cut as a wolf, and are called from that day the wolf-sworn.⁷
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,010** — *News of the fish-bone war reaches Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). A wool-merchant brings Eithne nic Ailein, last living of the nine who cut the cord at the Roinn, the tale of Iain Garbh's war on Caol leathan. She does not ride to it and does not send to it, judging it another share's quarrel to end.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,011** — *Word of the harbour wall at Caol fhiadhaich* (Caol fhiadhaich). The wool-merchant's next journey brings word to Cathair mhòr of how Caol fhiadhaich fed besieged Caol leathan by night and was given a share of the western tolls, with which it raised the first stone wall that coast has had. Eithne asks after the wall every year after.⁸
- 24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,020** — *Lachlann Ciar dies within sight of the harbour* (Caol leathan). Lachlann Ciar dies in his ninetieth year, worn down by slow degrees by the cough he carried from the coughing winter. His household buries him within sight of the harbour he grew fat and then thin defending, his son standing at the peace-board in his place.⁹
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,036** — *Caol fhiadhaich rebuilt* (Caol fhiadhaich). Caol fhiadhaich on the south-western shore had sent its boats to feed Caol leathan through the siege. In thanks Lachlann Ciar gives it a share of the western tolls, and with it the town builds a harbour wall.¹⁰

4. the first waypoint house, kept by Mòr nic Dhùghaill above Doire shean

5. the first waypoint house, kept by Mòr nic Dhùghaill above Doire shean

6. ← Follows from *The peace at Mòr nic Dhùghaill's house*, 4 an Dàmhair, FE 1,006; ← Follows from *Beathag of Baile chiar turns back a spear*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,003.

7. ← Follows from *The wolf-sworn of Caol leathan*, 12 am Faoilleach, FE 1,009; ← Follows from *Lachlann Ciar's confession at the peace-board*, 28 an Gearran, FE 1,008.

8. ← Follows from *News of the fish-bone war reaches Cathair mhòr*, 21 an Lùnastal, FE 1,010.

9. ← Follows from *The peace at Mòr nic Dhùghaill's house*, 4 an Dàmhair, FE 1,006; ← Follows from *Iain Garbh witnesses the wolf-sworn*, 29 an Cèitean, FE 1,009.

- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,044** — *Iain Garbh never climbs to the cup* (Dùn dhearg). Iain Garbh rules forty years past the end of the War of the Roads and never once goes up the mountain road to stand before the cup, unlike every rìgh before or after him. He dies unreconciled to the flame that had refused his warband its blessing.
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,044** — *Death of Iain Garbh* (Dùn dhearg). Iain Garbh dies at Dùn dhearg. His daughter Catriona buries him in the floor of the hall and not on the slope at Dùn iséal, and the Hall does not ask for him.¹¹
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,044** — *Catriona Ghlic crowned at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Catriona, daughter of Iain Garbh, is crowned at Dùn dhearg on her father's death and takes within ten years the name Catriona Ghlic, Catriona the Wise, for undoing the coldness he had left between the rìgh's hall and the Hall of the Flame.¹²
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,046** — *Catriona Ghlic* (Dùn dhearg). Catriona Ghlic, Catriona the Wise, rules from Dùn dhearg. She sends her own son to sit a season with the flame, the first child of the royal house to do so since the division of keeping. By the end of her reign the Hall and the hall are on speaking terms again.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,051** — *The rìgh's tithe sent again to the Hall* (Cathair mhòr). Eithne nic Ailein, hearing that Catriona Ghlic's son has sat a season with the flame unasked, orders that Cathair mhòr's own hall send its tithe to the Hall's handful again, unwaited-for, as it had not done since her own father's day.¹³
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,058** — *The Keeper keeps a place for the rìgh's son* (Dùn iséal). After his first season carrying the baskets at Dùn iséal, Catriona Ghlic's son returns each year at the turn of the season, and the Keeper comes to keep a place for him at the long table without being asked, a small thing the island reads as the breach mended.¹⁴
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,075** — *Inis mhòr asks the crown for its own guard* (Inis mhòr). The wool port of Inis mhòr, grown past every other town in the north on the trade the two new waypoint houses carry, asks Catriona Ghlic's crown for a road-guard of its own, and is given one without argument.¹⁵
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,081** — *The house on the northern road* (An Leòmhann Buidhe¹⁶). Catriona Ghlic has a waypoint house built on the northern road above Inis mhòr, on the site of An Leòmhann Buidhe. It serves the carriers who take the Hall's baskets to the northern households and bring back wool.

10. ○ Same place *News of the fish-bone war reaches Cathair mhòr*, 21 an Lùnastal, FE 1,010; ← Leads to *Word of the harbour wall at Caol fhiadhaich*, 26 an Cèitean, FE 1,011.

11. → Caused by *Iain Garbh never climbs to the cup*, 4 an t-Sultain, FE 1,044.

12. ← Follows from *Death of Iain Garbh*, 15 an t-Samhain, FE 1,044.

13. ⇌ At the same time *Catriona Ghlic*, 17 an Dàmhair, FE 1,046; ← Follows from *Catriona Ghlic crowned at Dùn dhearg*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,044.

14. ← Follows from *Catriona Ghlic*, 17 an Dàmhair, FE 1,046; ← Follows from *The rìgh's tithe sent again to the Hall*, 19 an t-Sultain, FE 1,051.

15. ← Follows from *The Keeper keeps a place for the rìgh's son*, 21 an Lùnastal, FE 1,058.

16. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

- 9 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,085** — *The house on the cold road* (An Taigh-seinnse Reòta). A stone house is built on the open moor, on the road between Baile Mòr dhomhain and the northern coast, on the site of An Taigh-seinnse Reòta, for carriers caught by snow. The Hall pays its keepers in grain and the crown in cloth, and they complain of both.
- 11 AM MÀRT, FE 1,089** — *Inis mhòr grows* (Inis mhòr). The river port of Inis mhòr in the north becomes the gathering-place of the northern wool trade and outgrows every other northern town. Its people ask Catriona Ghlic for a road-guard of their own, and are given one.¹⁷
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,109** — *Niall Òg walks his last road* (Cathair mhòr). Niall Òg comes on foot and unannounced to Eithne nic Ailein's hall at Cathair mhòr, the last road he means to walk, so that the night of the handful should be told once more, to the only other living witness of it, before he dies.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,109** — *Death of Niall Òg* (Cathair mhòr). Niall Òg dies in his sleep by Eithne nic Ailein's own fire at Cathair mhòr, some two thousand years old, three days after telling her the night of the handful for what proves the last time. She sends his body up the mountain at her own cost.¹⁸
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,109** — *Niall Òg laid near the first heirs* (Dùn ìseal). Eithne has Niall Òg laid near the old graves on the slope below Dùn ìseal, among the first heirs of the Roinn, though he was of no kin to her own share, judging that a man who spent four hundred years walking every road on the island had earned the ground.¹⁹
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,121** — *Eithne asks the count of her own years* (Cathair mhòr). In her last year Eithne nic Ailein asks her steward more than once to reckon the exact tale of her days, wanting the number fixed precisely at the end, though her mind has not begun to fail her.²⁰
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,122** — *Death of Eithne nic Ailein, last of the nine* (Cathair mhòr). Eithne nic Ailein, daughter of Ailean Mòr and youngest of the nine who took the great shares at the Roinn, dies in her hall at Cathair mhòr. And all the days of Eithne were three thousand and twenty-one years, and she died. After her none of the nine is living, and the great shares are names on the boundary stones.²¹
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,122** — *The market at the fords of Baile Mòr dhomhain* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). The lords of the deep river set a market at Baile Mòr dhomhain, where the carriers' road from the south meets the paths down from the hill pastures. Cattle, sheep, horses, hides and the white stone of the hills are sold at the fords on the day after each new moon, and the lords take one fleece in forty from the sellers.

17. → Caused by *Inis mhòr asks the crown for its own guard*, 16 an t-Samhain, FE 1,075.

18. ← Follows from *Niall Òg walks his last road*, 27 an Giblean, FE 1,109.

19. ← Follows from *Death of Niall Òg*, 26 an Cèitean, FE 1,109.

20. ← Follows from *Niall Òg laid near the first heirs*, 18 an Dàmhair, FE 1,109.

- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,122** — *Eithne's hall at Cathair mhòr falls silent* (Cathair mhòr). With Eithne nic Ailein's death her hall at Cathair mhòr is left to her stewards and her reciters, who keep the rolls but crown no one there, the lowland share having long since ceased to answer to any single hand of her line.²²
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,123** — *The mill at Muileann shean* (Muileann shean). A mill is raised on the northern road at Muileann shean to grind grain for the carriers crossing the pass; the miller pays the Hall in grain and the rìgh's toll in flour, and a town grows round the mill within two generations.
- 10 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,124** — *Catriona Gblic dies at a hundred and twenty-two* (Dùn dhearg). Catriona Gblic, who mended the breach her father Iain Garbh's war had opened, dies at Dùn dhearg. Her son takes the hall at ninety-two, the first of eleven rulers the later king-list will give only by name and order.²³
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,130** — *The Hall's own roll for the same years* (Dùn ìseal). For the span the king-list gives eleven rulers, the Hall's spoken roll gives only five Keepers, a mountain's years running longer than a lowland's, as every teller of the Fire already knows.
- 10 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,166** — *Muileann shean on the northern road* (Muileann shean). A mill is built at Muileann shean on the northern road, to grind the grain the carriers bring over the pass, and a town grows round it. The Hall pays the miller in grain, and he pays the rìgh's toll in flour.²⁴
- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,190** — *The last of the long years in the ruling line* (Dùn dhearg). The last ruler of the house of Ìomhar and Goraidh to carry any of the long years in his blood dies at a hundred years old, an age that was a boy's age in his grandmother's grandmother's day. After him the line ages and dies at the pace of any household on the island.²⁵

21. → Caused by *Eithne asks the count of her own years*, 23 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,121.

22. ← Follows from *Death of Eithne nic Ailein, last of the nine*, 28 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,122; ← Follows from *Eithne asks the count of her own years*, 23 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,121.

23. ← Follows from *Catriona Gblic*, 17 an Dàmhair, FE 1,046.

24. → Caused by *The mill at Muileann shean*, 9 an Cèitean, FE 1,123.

25. ‡ Legacy *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*, 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1.

THE YEARS FE 1,201 – 1,400

- 1 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,211** — *The unremembered rulers* (Dùn dhearg). Eleven rulers hold Dùn dhearg between Catrìona Ghlic and Ealasaid Chiar. The later king-list gives their names and their order, and nothing more. For the same years the Keepers' roll gives five Keepers, and of them too only the names.¹
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,240** — *Tormod mac Iain born to the house of Tormod* (Dùn dhearg). Tormod is born at Dùn dhearg, a younger son of a house that has held no great office in the hall for three generations. His father Iain keeps a stretch of the crown granaries, and the boy grows up among grain-tallies.
- 14 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,255** — *Tormod sent east to Muileann chiar* (Muileann chiar). A passing stag-teacher's tale of letters that can hold a teaching without a teacher fixes itself in the fifteen-year-old Tormod's mind. His father, a younger son's post being cheaper found elsewhere than at home, sends him east to Muileann chiar to learn the stag-letters.²
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,255** — *Tormod Scriobhaiche learns the letters* (Muileann chiar). Tormod mac Iain, a younger son of the house of Tormod, is sent east to Muileann chiar to learn the stag-letters. He is the first of the royal kin to read, and for the rest of his life he is called Tormod Scriobhaiche, Tormod the Writer.³
- 5 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,256** — *Tormod's first written leaf* (Muileann chiar). In his second summer at Muileann chiar, Tormod writes his first whole leaf, a grain-debt tally copied twice over from an old woman's spoken account. He keeps it inside his shirt a full year, the oldest surviving thing in his own hand.⁴
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,259** — *Tormod returns to the granaries* (Dùn dhearg). After four years at Muileann chiar, Tormod comes home to Dùn dhearg and his father's trade of the granaries, carrying unspoken a want to write down a thing that would outlast every mouth that had ever spoken it.⁵
- 22 AN T-IÚCHAR, FE 1,299** — *Ealasaid Chiar* (Dùn dhearg). Ealasaid Chiar takes the hall at Dùn dhearg and brings Tormod Scriobhaiche there as her clerk. She bids him set down in order the name of every ruler of the hall that the reciters can give him.
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,299** — *The first written king-list*. Rulers are first set down by name, and no longer only remembered in tales. The rolls of succession in every later age are kept after this pattern.

1. ⇌ At the same time *The Hall's own roll for the same years*, 29 an Lùnastal, FE 1,130.

2. ← Follows from *Tormod mac Iain born to the house of Tormod*, 26 an Dàmhair, FE 1,240.

3. → Caused by *Tormod mac Iain born to the house of Tormod*, 26 an Dàmhair, FE 1,240; → Caused by *Tormod sent east to Muileann chiar*, 14 an Cèitean, FE 1,255.

4. ← Follows from *Tormod Scriobhaiche learns the letters*, 3 an Lùnastal, FE 1,255; ← Follows from *Tormod sent east to Muileann chiar*, 14 an Cèitean, FE 1,255.

5. ← Follows from *Tormod Scriobhaiche learns the letters*, 3 an Lùnastal, FE 1,255; ← Follows from *Tormod's first written leaf*, 5 an Cèitean, FE 1,256.

- 4 **AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,299** — *Ealasaid Chiar takes the hall* (Dùn dhearg). Ealasaid Chiar, granddaughter of the ninth of the eleven, takes the hall at Dùn dhearg at twenty-nine, out of patience with hearing her own house's roll given a different order at every telling.⁶
- 8 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,299** — *Ealasaid Chiar sets Tormod to the writing* (Dùn dhearg). Ealasaid Chiar hears of a granary clerk who can set a thing down in marks and have it read back the same way twice, and sets Tormod Scriobhaiche, now fifty-nine, to write down every ruler the reciters can name, in order, freed of all other duty.⁷
- 18 **AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,300** — *The contents of Tormod's roll* (Dùn dhearg). Tormod Scriobhaiche's roll, kept in the hall at Dùn dhearg, runs from Goraidh Mòr to Ealasaid Chiar. The earlier names he has from the reciters and the later from living memory, and he marks which are which. In three places it differs from the Keepers' spoken roll; Tormod writes down both readings and does not choose.
- 9 **AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,301** — *The reciters disagree* (Dùn dhearg). Questioning the hall's reciters in turn, Tormod finds them certain and contradictory: a mother's name given two ways, a reign given nine years by one mouth and eleven by another, three rulers set in different orders by a southern reciter than by the hall's own.⁸
- 7 **AN GEARRAN, FE 1,301** — *Ealasaid Chiar bids the doubt be written too* (Dùn dhearg). Told of the disagreements, Ealasaid Chiar orders Tormod to set down the sure thing where he has it and the doubt where he has that, rather than hide the roll's own uncertainty from those who could not otherwise judge it.⁹
- 19 **AN GEARRAN, FE 1,305** — *Tormod's roll finished* (Dùn dhearg). After six years' careful writing, reading each page back to whoever gave it before counting it done, Tormod brings Ealasaid Chiar the finished roll from Goraidh Mòr to herself, with three disputed places marked and left unresolved.¹⁰
- 21 **AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,310** — *Death of Tormod Scriobhaiche* (Dùn dhearg). Tormod Scriobhaiche dies at seventy in the clerk's room off the hall at Dùn dhearg, a half-begun copy of the disputed reign still under his hand. Ealasaid Chiar names the room, ever after, Tormod's room.¹¹

6. → Leads to *Ealasaid Chiar*, 22 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,299.

7. → Leads to *Ealasaid Chiar*, 22 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,299; ← Follows from *Ealasaid Chiar takes the hall*, 4 an Dàmhair, FE 1,299.

8. → Leads to *The contents of Tormod's roll*, 18 an t-Sultain, FE 1,300; ← Follows from *Ealasaid Chiar sets Tormod to the writing*, 8 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,299.

9. → Leads to *The contents of Tormod's roll*, 18 an t-Sultain, FE 1,300; ← Follows from *The reciters disagree*, 9 am Faoilleach, FE 1,301.

10. ♦ Fulfils *The first written king-list*, 20 an Lùnastal, FE 1,299; ♦ Fulfils *The contents of Tormod's roll*, 18 an t-Sultain, FE 1,300; ← Follows from *Ealasaid Chiar bids the doubt be written too*, 7 an Gearran, FE 1,301.

11. ← Follows from *Tormod Scriobhaiche learns the letters*, 3 an Lùnastal, FE 1,255; ← Follows from *Tormod's roll finished*, 19 an Gearran, FE 1,305.

- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,311** — *The Hall shamed into writing its own roll* (Dùn ìseal). Word of the written king-list reaches the blind Keeper on the mountain, who sits three days in silence and then tells the Hall's own reciters that a Hall out-remembered by a rìgh's clerk has no one to blame but itself.¹²
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,320** — *The Keepers' roll written down* (Dùn ìseal). Shamed, in the Hall's own words, by the rìgh's clerk, the Keepers have their spoken roll written in stag-letters at Dùn ìseal. It begins with Beathag Bhàn, and it is longer than Tormod's by several centuries.¹³
- 30 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,320** — *Cairistiona reads the cord for the scribes* (Dùn ìseal). Cairistiona nan Snaidhm, last of Sine's line who can read a knot without letters, comes to the Hall and unties the cord of the heirs knot by knot over two days, naming each heir aloud so a young scribe can set the roll down in the new marks.¹⁴
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,320** — *The cord coiled in its chest* (Dùn ìseal). The last of the cord's seven hundred and twelve knots comes free, and Cairistiona coils it in the old way and lays it in the chest the Hall has made for it, telling the scribe that after her no hand living will be able to make it speak.¹⁵
- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,330** — *The death of Ealasaid Chiar* (Dùn dhearg). Ealasaid Chiar dies at sixty, having reigned thirty-one years and had the first king-list written, and is carried up the mountain road to lie among the house of Ìomhar. Her son takes the hall after her.¹⁶
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,341** — *The roll falls silent* (Dùn ìseal). After Ealasaid Chiar's son and granddaughter, the king-list Tormod began keeps no ruler's name for a span the reciters cannot close. The Keepers' roll at Dùn ìseal keeps its own count through the same years, naming its Keepers where the hall names none.¹⁷
- 31 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,380** — *The Hall's clerks learn the stag-letters* (Dùn ìseal). Shamed that it cannot read its own roll without borrowing another order's letters, the Hall at Dùn ìseal sets two of its own clerks to learn the stag-letters, taught by a stag-teacher paid in coal for the winter. From that year the Hall keeps its roll in its own hand.¹⁸

12. ← Follows from *Death of Tormod Scriobhaiche*, 21 am Faoilleach, FE 1,310.

13. → Caused by *The Hall shamed into writing its own roll*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,311.

14. ← Follows from *The Keepers' roll written down*, 17 an Dàmhair, FE 1,320; ← Follows from *The Hall shamed into writing its own roll*, 23 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,311.

15. ¶ Legacy *The Keepers' roll written down*, 17 an Dàmhair, FE 1,320; ← Follows from *Cairistiona reads the cord for the scribes*, 30 an Dàmhair, FE 1,320.

16. ¶ Legacy *Ealasaid Chiar*, 22 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,299.

17. ← Follows from *The Keepers' roll written down*, 17 an Dàmhair, FE 1,320; ← Follows from *The death of Ealasaid Chiar*, 27 an t-Sultain, FE 1,330.

18. → Leads to *The Keepers' roll written down*, 17 an Dàmhair, FE 1,320; ← Follows from *The roll falls silent*, 29 an Lùnastal, FE 1,341.

THE YEARS FE 1,401 – 1,600

- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,440** — *A Keeper named in the silent years* (Dùn iséal). A Keeper is named at Dùn iséal of whom the roll keeps only the years of her reign, twenty-two, and the year of her death; of the rest of it nothing is told, the households burning their handful and the carriers walking their roads as their grandparents had.¹
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,540** — *The birth of Conall Dubh* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag²). A household above Cnoc bheag, keeping sheep in sight of the wood the island has never cleared, has its fourth child, a son they name Conall and call Dubh for the black hair he is born with.
- 23 AM MÀRT, FE 1,560** — *Conall Dubh sees the black horned beast* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag³). At twenty years old, going up before first light to bring down strayed ewes, Conall Dubh meets a black horned beast at the edge of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag, standing and watching him before it turns back into the trees. His mother believes him.⁴
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,565** — *The watch grows to nine* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag⁵). Conall Dubh's sister and two cousins join his watch at the wood's edge, and within five years of his own first sighting nine keep it by turns, waiting on a beast none of them can explain to a stranger's satisfaction.⁶
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,569** — *The watchers of the dark wood* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag⁷). A small company settles at the edge of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag, the wood never cleared, and keeps watch for a black horned beast that they say walks in it. The people of Cathair dhearg call them the wood-watchers. None of their own accounts is older than Òrd Mhacha⁸, the order of Macha, which afterwards claims them and takes the beast for a sign of Dubh Sainglenn, the black horse.⁹
- 4 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,569** — *The wood called sacred* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁰). The watchers, near thirty now and housed in a turf hut at the wood's edge, are named the wood-watchers by the people of Cathair dhearg, and a Hall clerk counting the season's coal is the first outsider to write Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag sacred in his own report.¹¹

1. ¶ Legacy *The Keepers' roll written down*, 17 an Dàmhair, FE 1,320; ← Follows from *The Hall's clerks learn the stag-letters*, 31 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,380.

2. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

3. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

4. ← Follows from *The birth of Conall Dubh*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,540.

5. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

6. ← Follows from *Conall Dubh sees the black horned beast*, 23 am Màrt, FE 1,560.

7. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

8. the order of Macha

9. → Caused by *The birth of Conall Dubh*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,540; → Caused by *Conall Dubh sees the black horned beast*, 23 am Màrt, FE 1,560; ← Leads to *The watch grows to nine*, 21 an Giblean, FE 1,565.

10. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

11. ← Follows from *The watchers of the dark wood*, 15 an t-Samhain, FE 1,569; ← Follows from *The watch grows to nine*, 21 an Giblean, FE 1,565.

- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,576** — *The wood-watchers in the stag's grove* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar¹²). Wood-watchers come east and cut a black-barked tree in Coille Naomh Muileann chiar, saying that the beast had shown it to them. The stag's people call it theft from a place of teaching. Both sides send to Dùn dhearg and to Dùn ìseal.
- 22 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,578** — *The death of a teaching elder* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar¹³). In the second winter of the two orders' silence over the cut tree, the teacher who first spoke for the stag's people dies of an ordinary winter cough. Conall Dubh crosses to the teaching-circle unbidden to say he is sorry for their loss, the first word either side has spoken to the other.¹⁴
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,581** — *The stag's people claim the dark wood* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁵). In answer the stag's people send teachers west to hold their lessons in Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag, saying that the first stag came from there. Now each side claims both woods, and in either wood the two companies meet and do not speak.¹⁶
- 10 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,589** — *The holy-wood dispute*. Rival rites contend for Coille Naomh Muileann chiar¹⁷ and Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁸, the first such strife that is remembered. It is settled by dividing the keeping of the woods, and no side is judged the victor.
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,593** — *Fearchar Òg brought to the hall* (Dùn ìseal). A boy of seven, a great-grandson of the house that once held Dùn dhearg, is brought to Dùn ìseal by his mother's hand and acknowledged heir by the Keeper of that year, the first claim in longer than the roll can say with certainty found worth the Hall's confidence.
- 18 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,595** — *Calum Liath takes the flame* (Dùn ìseal). Calum Liath is made Keeper at forty-five, in Fearchar Òg's ninth year, and judges at once that the wood-watchers and the stag's people will share their silence forever unless someone outside both orders sets a boundary between them.¹⁹
- II AM MÀRT, FE 1,595** — *The boundary stones of the woods* (Dùn dhearg). The woods are divided at Dùn dhearg before Fearchar Òg, a righ of Ealasaid Chiar's line who had come to the hall as a boy, and the Keeper Calum Liath. The stag's people keep the eastern wood and the wood-watchers the western, and each may walk in the other's wood unarmed and without cutting. Boundary stones are set at the edges of both woods with the terms cut on them in stag-letters. Two of the eastern stones remain.²⁰

12. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

13. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

14. ← Follows from *The wood called sacred*, 4 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,569.

15. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

16. ← Leads to *The death of a teaching elder*, 22 an Gearran, FE 1,578.

17. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

18. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

19. ← Follows from *Fearchar Òg brought to the hall*, 27 an t-Samhain, FE 1,593.

8 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,595 — *Conall Dubh walks the eastern wood* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar²¹). The day after the last boundary stone is set, Conall Dubh walks unarmed into Coille Naomh Muileann chiar for the first time in his life, a guest under the terms he helped make, and stands a while at the border stand before turning home.²²

20. → Caused by *Fearchar Òg brought to the hall*, 27 an t-Samhain, FE 1,593; → Caused by *Calum Liath takes the flame*, 18 an Gearran, FE 1,595.

21. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

22. ← Follows from *The boundary stones of the woods*, 11 am Màrt, FE 1,595.

THE YEARS FE 1,601 – 1,800

- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,601** — *The households of the northern road go short* (Baile Mòr mhòr). With cutters set to counting rather than cutting, the waypoint-keepers send less than the Law's full measure to households a day's carry and more from the mountain, marking each short delivery against a day it might be made good.
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,602** — *Calum Liath's surveyors* (Dùn ìseal). The Keeper Calum Liath sends cutters with knotted cords and lamps into every gallery at Dùn ìseal, to follow the vein as far as it can be followed and mark where it thickens and thins. The work keeps the cutters from the coal for three seasons, and the households go short to pay for it.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,602** — *Calum Liath sends cutters to measure the vein* (Dùn ìseal). The Keeper Calum Liath gives every cutter of Dùn ìseal a knotted cord and a lamp of the Hall's own oil, and sends them into the galleries to walk the vein from end to end and mark on slates where it runs thick and where it runs to blind rock.¹
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,602** — *A steward of the northern road questions the Keeper* (Dùn ìseal). Three households short of their measure send the steward Uisdean to Dùn ìseal to ask whether the counting will end before their own stores do. Calum Liath answers only that he cannot yet say, and the steward walks home with the truth and nothing else.²
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,602** — *Two cutters lost a day in an old working* (Dùn ìseal). Sent to measure a gallery cut and abandoned in Fionnlagh Dall's time, two young cutters lose a full day in the dark and come out half starved, saying only that they heard something moving beyond their lamp's reach.³
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,607** — *The measuring of the vein*. For the first time men try to reckon how much coal the mountain holds. Their reckoning proves far too hopeful.
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,607** — *The clerk Mòr nic Aonghais cuts the reckoning* (Dùn ìseal). A clerk of the Hall who learned her letters from a wanderer of the stag's school sets the sum of the cords into a slab of grey stone, reckoning the mountain's coal against the grains in the granaries of Dùn dhearg, the largest measure a household could hold in its own hand and believe.⁴
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,607** — *The reckoning of the cords* (Dùn ìseal). The reckoning of Calum Liath is cut on a slab in the Hall at Dùn ìseal: the mountain can give every household its handful for more generations than there are grains in the granaries of Dùn dhearg. It is read out at the council and heard in silence, and the Hall takes the silence for assent.⁵

1. ← Follows from *Calum Liath's surveyors*, 9 an Giblean, FE 1,602; ← Follows from *The households of the northern road go short*, 29 an Dàmhair, FE 1,601.

2. ← Follows from *Calum Liath sends cutters to measure the vein*, 23 an Giblean, FE 1,602.

3. ← Follows from *A steward of the northern road questions the Keeper*, 27 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,602.

4. ← Follows from *The measuring of the vein*, 27 an t-Samhain, FE 1,607; ← Follows from *Two cutters lost a day in an old working*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,602.

5. ← Leads to *The clerk Mòr nic Aonghais cuts the reckoning*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,607.

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,607** — *The reckoning read and met with silence* (Dùn ìseal). Calum Liath reads the slab's sum to the assembled stewards and hearths at Dùn ìseal. No one speaks against it and no one praises it; the northern stewards, who paid for the counting in short seasons, say nothing at all, and the Hall takes the silence for assent.⁶
- 6 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,620** — *Ealasaid Rìoghach asks the council what is owed* (Dùn ìseal). Griogair's mother stands before the council at Dùn ìseal and asks what the Hall owes her son, sent into a gallery already marked dangerous by a slate no cutter had carried down in memory. The council has no answer ready.⁷
- 22 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,621** — *The deaths in the lower gallery* (Dùn ìseal). Two youths of the nine hearths, sent into the lower gallery at Dùn ìseal without a Keeper's cutter to guide them, break the wrong face and are crushed. They had been less than a season in the galleries. Their families ask the council what the Hall owes them, and the council has no answer.⁸
- 19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,621** — *Griogair mac Dhonnchaidh and Sine Bheag crushed in the lower gallery* (Dùn ìseal). Sent without a Keeper's cutter to bring up a left basket, two youths of one season in the galleries break a face already marked unsound on Aonghas's own slates two years before. Griogair dies at once; Sine Bheag does not outlive the digging.⁹
- 8 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,621** — *The council sits three days and turns from fault to custom* (Dùn ìseal). The stewards of the great shares spend a first day laying blame before Ealasaid Rìoghach's second asking turns the council from fault to remedy: a binding of seven years before any young Dia-thìrich may touch the vein alone.¹⁰
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,621** — *The apprentice-binding custom is agreed* (Dùn ìseal). The council of Dùn ìseal sets down that no young Dia-thìrich will go into any gallery of the vein's custody until bound seven years to a master cutter of proven years, to learn the mountain's marks and unsound faces before working it alone.¹¹
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,628** — *The apprentice-binding custom*. Young Dia-thìrich are first bound for seven years to a master of the vein's custody before they may go near the coal themselves. Every later guild of the mines is shaped on this binding.¹²

6. ← Follows from *The reckoning of the cords*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,607; ← Follows from *The clerk Mòr nic Aonghais cuts the reckoning*, 22 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,607.

7. ← Follows from *The reckoning read and met with silence*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,607.

8. ← Leads to *Ealasaid Rìoghach asks the council what is owed*, 6 an Giblean, FE 1,620.

9. ← Follows from *The deaths in the lower gallery*, 22 an Gearran, FE 1,621; ← Follows from *Ealasaid Rìoghach asks the council what is owed*, 6 an Giblean, FE 1,620.

10. ← Follows from *Griogair mac Dhonnchaidh and Sine Bheag crushed in the lower gallery*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,621.

11. ← Follows from *The council sits three days and turns from fault to custom*, 8 an t-Sultain, FE 1,621.

12. ← Leads to *The council sits three days and turns from fault to custom*, 8 an t-Sultain, FE 1,621; ← Leads to *The apprentice-binding custom is agreed*, 28 an Dàmhair, FE 1,621.

- 21 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,628** — *Calum Liath dies at the Hall's door* (Dùn ìseal). The Keeper Calum Liath dies by the doorway where he had the reckoning-slab set, in the ninth year after it was cut, and is carried up to lie among the Keepers' own dead near the two youths he had buried before him.
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,628** — *Oighrig Bhàn chosen Keeper* (Dùn ìseal). The nine hearths choose Oighrig Bhàn, a woman of the northern road who had sat with Calum Liath through his last winter, to hold the flame after him.¹³
- 7 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,628** — *Oighrig Bhàn asks why the binding stands unkept* (Dùn ìseal). Within her first year Oighrig Bhàn asks why the apprentice-binding, agreed by the council after Griogair and Sine Bheag's deaths, still stands only as a thing sworn and not a thing done, and finds no better answer than that grief cools faster than custom is kept.¹⁴
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,634** — *Oighrig Bhàn's first bound* (Dùn ìseal). Oighrig Bhàn, Keeper after Calum Liath, binds the first twelve apprentices under the new custom at Dùn ìseal, each to a master cutter by name. They swear on the stone cup to serve seven years before they touch the vein. Four of the twelve are afterwards Keepers, which is the best that can be said for the custom.
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,634** — *Oighrig Bhàn binds the first twelve apprentices* (Dùn ìseal). In the Hall's own doorway Oighrig Bhàn binds twelve apprentices by name to twelve master cutters, each swearing on the stone cup to serve seven years before touching the vein alone. She stands through every oath and does not sit until the last is sworn.¹⁵
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,634** — *Four of the twelve later hold the flame* (Dùn ìseal). Of the twelve first bound under Oighrig Bhàn, four in later years are themselves chosen Keeper, which the reciters of Dùn ìseal count the custom's best proof, though none of it answers in full the question Ealasaid Rìoghach asked.¹⁶
- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,640** — *Rìoghnach writes the first strike-book entry* (Cnoc bhàn). A novice of the first bound company at Cnoc bhàn, Rìoghnach, sets down the school's first written account by lamp-light in a hand still stiff from her letters: three words, I struck a stroke, and the day beneath them.
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,640** — *The birth of Mòrag Dhubh* (Cnoc mhòr). Aonghas Ruadh and Sine of Cnoc mhòr have a daughter, black-haired against the fairness of both their houses, and name her Mòrag. She is raised at a hearth already full of staves and toll-talk, in the first winters of the hall's new silver.

13. ← Follows from *Calum Liath dies at the Hall's door*, 21 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,628.

14. ← Follows from *The apprentice-binding custom*, 24 am Faoilleach, FE 1,628.

15. ← Follows from *Oighrig Bhàn's first bound*, 21 an Giblean, FE 1,634; ← Follows from *Oighrig Bhàn asks why the binding stands unkept*, 7 an t-Sultain, FE 1,628.

16. ← Follows from *Oighrig Bhàn binds the first twelve apprentices*, 22 an Cèitean, FE 1,634.

- 23 AM MÀRT, FE 1,641** — *The stag's people take apprentices* (Cnoc bhàn). The house of the stag's people at Cnoc bhàn takes the seven years for its own cutters and adds a rule: an apprentice keeps a written account of every stroke, and the account is read. These strike-books are the school's chief record for the rest of the age.¹⁷
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,641** — *Cnoc bhàn takes up the seven-year binding* (Cnoc bhàn). Hearing of the binding at Dùn ìseal, the stag's teachers of Cnoc bhàn take up the seven years for their own cutters, binding each apprentice to a master of the school as the Hall bound its own.¹⁸
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,641** — *Cnoc bhàn adds the written account of every stroke* (Cnoc bhàn). The teachers of Cnoc bhàn set a rule the Hall never made: that every bound apprentice keep, once the stag-letters are learned, a written account of every stroke cut in a season, so a master may read back exactly where the hand went wrong.¹⁹
- 25 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,642** — *Aonghas Ruadh is paid in the first silver rings* (Ceann leathan). Among the guards of the southern ford paid that winter in Fearchar Òg's new stamped rings is Aonghas Ruadh of Cnoc mhòr, who carries his home turning it over in his hand, unsure at first that so small a weight can be a whole season's wage. His wife Sine trades it for cloth within the week and proves him wrong.²⁰
- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,647** — *The long reign of Fearchar Òg* (Dùn dhearg). Fearchar Òg, who divided the woods, rules long at Dùn dhearg and is remembered chiefly for dying old. He was named Òg, the young, for coming to the hall as a boy, and the name stuck.
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,647** — *Dòmhnall Beag sent to keep the toll at Àth ghlais* (Àth ghlais). Fearchar Òg's clerks send a hall-trained man, Dòmhnall Beag, to weigh the new silver toll at the ford of Àth ghlais, where the Griogaraich have kept the crossing's toll by their own standing for longer than anyone can say. It is the first toll-house on any road kept by a man not chosen at the place.²¹
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,648** — *The Griogaraich come round to Dòmhnall Beag's scale* (Àth ghlais). A year into his keeping of the toll-house, Dòmhnall Beag is still unhelped by the ford's own family, until the winter's firewood and the spring floods force first one and then most of the Griogaraich to take his silver for their labour, never all admitting it to one another.²²

17. ← Leads to *Riognach writes the first strike-book entry*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,640.

18. ← Follows from *The stag's people take apprentices*, 23 am Màrt, FE 1,641; ← Follows from *Riognach writes the first strike-book entry*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,640.

19. ← Follows from *The stag's people take apprentices*, 23 am Màrt, FE 1,641; ← Follows from *Cnoc bhàn takes up the seven-year binding*, 17 an Giblean, FE 1,641.

20. ← Follows from *The birth of Mòrag Dhubh*, 5 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,640.

21. ← Follows from *Aonghas Ruadh is paid in the first silver rings*, 25 an Cèitean, FE 1,642.

22. ← Follows from *Dòmhnall Beag sent to keep the toll at Àth ghlais*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,647.

- 20 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,654** — *The silver tokens* (Muileann chiar). The clerks of Fearchar Òg begin to pay the road-guards in small silver rings of the Muileann chiar weight, stamped with the hall's mark. It is the first payment in metal by any ruler on Dia-thìr. The rings travel further than the guards do.²³
- 27 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,655** — *Mòrag Dhubh cuts her own staff* (Cnoc mhòr). Having outgrown every staff her father owns, Mòrag Dhubh cuts one of her own from a young ash at the wood's edge, straight-grained and a hand's breadth taller than she is, and carries it everywhere a girl of the southern road may carry a staff without remark.²⁴
- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,660** — *Mòrag Dhubh's first bout at Ceann leathan* (Ceann leathan). Against her father's own doubts, Mòrag Dhubh enters the guards' yearly meeting at Ceann leathan, the first woman to do so, and loses in the second round to a guard twice her age and size, who tells her afterward she had the surest staff of anyone he fought that day.²⁵
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,661** — *The toll-house at Àth ghlais* (Àth ghlais). A toll-house is built on the ford at Àth ghlais, where the southern road crosses the river toward Ceann leathan, and the road-guards are paid there in the new silver rings. Its keeper is the first sent from the rìgh's hall, and not chosen in the place.²⁶
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,665** — *The road-guards' games at Ceann leathan* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan²⁷). The road-guards of the south begin to meet each year at Ceann leathan and fight with blunted staves for a silver ring. The meeting outlives its purpose, and on its field Còmhrag Ceann leathan is afterwards fought. The first winner whose name is kept is a woman, Mòrag Dhubh of Cnoc mhòr.²⁸
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,665** — *The fair at Muileann òg* (Fèill Muileann òg²⁹). Muileann òg, burned in the War of the Roads, is rebuilt as a market town. A fair is held there each harvest at Lùnastal for the trade of the western and southern roads, and from it Fèill Muileann òg descends.
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,665** — *The landing on the Abhainn uaine* (Cidhe Beag). A landing for river-boats is built on the Abhainn uaine at the place since called Cidhe Beag, so that the grain of the lowlands may go upriver by boat and not on carriers' backs. The carriers of the eastern road protest to Fearchar Òg, and lose.

23. ← Leads to *Aonghas Ruadh is paid in the first silver rings*, 25 an Cèitean, FE 1,642.

24. ← Follows from *The Griogaraich come round to Dòmhnall Beag's scale*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,648.

25. ← Follows from *Mòrag Dhubh cuts her own staff*, 27 an Gearran, FE 1,655.

26. ← Leads to *Dòmhnall Beag sent to keep the toll at Àth ghlais*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,647; ← Leads to *The Griogaraich come round to Dòmhnall Beag's scale*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,648.

27. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

28. → Caused by *The birth of Mòrag Dhubh*, 5 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,640; → Caused by *Mòrag Dhubh cuts her own staff*, 27 an Gearran, FE 1,655; ← Leads to *Mòrag Dhubh's first bout at Ceann leathan*, 29 am Faoilleach, FE 1,660.

29. the fair at Muileann òg

- 5 **AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,665** — *Mòrag Dhubh wins the meeting at Ceann leathan* (Ceann leathan). In her fifth year entering, Mòrag Dhubh of Cnoc mhòr beats Ruairidh Fada of Muileann chrom, twice the meeting's winner before her, in the last bout by torchlight, and is given the finest ring struck that season. She is the first winner of the meeting whose name the reciters keep.³⁰
- 8 **AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,666** — *Ceann leathan's own mark is asked of the hall's smiths* (Ceann leathan). With the guards' meeting grown into a day the whole market profits by, Ceann leathan's traders ask Fearchar Òg's smiths for a ring carrying the ford's own mark beside the hall's hearth-sign, so that the finest ring struck each season may be known at a glance as the meeting's own.³¹
- 3 **AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,668** — *Muileann òg's households ask a charter for the harvest meeting* (Muileann òg). Seeing what silver a season's traders leave behind them, the households resettled at Muileann òg's ford ask Fearchar Òg's clerks for a charter of the trading already grown up there at Lùnastal, and are granted it, the hall having learned a fed market pays more toll than a starved one.³²
- 6 **AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,670** — *The landing built at Cidhe Beag* (Cidhe Beag). The hall's clerks raise timbered piers at the old scramble of stones called Cidhe Beag on the Abhainn uaine, judging a river running near empty beside a road worn to ruts a waste the granaries can no longer afford, and put out word for boats to be built to work it.³³
- 2 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,670** — *Ciorstaidh leads the carriers' protest to Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Ciorstaidh, who has carried grain on the eastern road sixty years, walks with two other elders the whole distance to Dùn dhearg to tell Fearchar Òg that a river-boat will starve half their households of the wages that have fed them since before the hall was built. He does not turn the landing back.³⁴
- 5 **AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,672** — *Mòrag Dhubh trades wool at the Lùnastal fair* (Muileann òg). Some years after her win, Mòrag Dhubh walks a season's wool to Muileann òg's fair to trade for cloth her own household cannot weave as fine, and is asked there by an eastern trader whether the tale of the ring she wears is true.³⁵

30. ← Follows from *The road-guards' games at Ceann leathan*, 9 an Giblean, FE 1,665; ← Follows from *Mòrag Dhubh's first bout at Ceann leathan*, 29 am Faoilleach, FE 1,660.

31. ¶ Legacy *The road-guards' games at Ceann leathan*, 9 an Giblean, FE 1,665; ← Follows from *Mòrag Dhubh wins the meeting at Ceann leathan*, 5 an t-Samhain, FE 1,665.

32. ← Follows from *The fair at Muileann òg*, 5 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,665; ← Follows from *Ceann leathan's own mark is asked of the hall's smiths*, 8 an Lùnastal, FE 1,666.

33. ← Follows from *The landing on the Abhainn uaine*, 3 an Lùnastal, FE 1,665; ← Follows from *Muileann òg's households ask a charter for the harvest meeting*, 3 an t-Samhain, FE 1,668.

34. ← Follows from *The landing on the Abhainn uaine*, 3 an Lùnastal, FE 1,665; ← Follows from *The landing built at Cidhe Beag*, 6 an t-Sultain, FE 1,670.

35. ← Follows from *The fair at Muileann òg*, 5 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,665; ← Follows from *Ciorstaidh leads the carriers' protest to Dùn dhearg*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,670.

- 27 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,673** — *The boatmen of Muileann chrom swear the paddle-oath* (Muileann chrom). The young crews of Muileann chrom who take up the new river trade settle among themselves, without any hall's asking, that no man may call himself one of their fellowship until he has sworn on his own paddle to answer another boatman's need on the water before his own household's.³⁶
- 28 AM MÀRT, FE 1,675** — *Dòmhnall of Cnoc mhòr swears his paddle* (Muileann chrom). Mòrag Dhubh's younger brother Dòmhnall, who never took to the staff as she did, swears his paddle-oath among the second crews of Muileann chrom the same year her own daughter is born, so that one household comes to hold a ring won on land and an oath sworn on water.³⁷
- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,680** — *Fearchar Òg dies at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Fearchar Òg dies at ninety-four in the hall his clerks first struck the silver rings in, found gone in his own chair by his steward's grandson. He is buried among the house of Ìomhar after a reign of eighty-seven years, the longest the roll can name, remembered chiefly for its length.³⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,680** — *Word of the king's death reaches Cnoc mhòr* (Cnoc mhòr). Carried down the southern road by guards paid most of their working lives in Fearchar Òg's silver, word of his death reaches Cnoc mhòr and an aging Mòrag Dhubh, who turns her own worn ring in her fingers at the hearth and says the king made one thing that did not need his hand to keep travelling.³⁹
- II AM MÀRT, FE 1,685** — *The river-boats* (Abhainn uaine). Flat river-boats of hide over withy begin to carry grain and salt fish up the Abhainn uaine from the landing at Cidhe Beag. The boatmen form a fellowship of their own, sworn on a paddle, and vie with the carriers for the Hall's baskets.
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,685** — *The boatmen of Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). Muileann chrom, up the valley from the landing at Cidhe Beag, becomes the home of the river-boatmen and their fellowship. Its yards build the flat hide boats for every river of the island.⁴⁰
- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,685** — *Beathag Mhòr* (Dùn dhearg). Beathag Mhòr, great-granddaughter of Fearchar Òg, takes the hall at Dùn dhearg. The list calls her ban-rìgh, queen, the first so called, and not rìgh with a woman's name after it; the change of word is the list's own.

36. ← Follows from *Mòrag Dhubh trades wool at the Lùnastal fair*, 5 an Dàmhair, FE 1,672.

37. ← Follows from *The boatmen of Muileann chrom swear the paddle-oath*, 27 an Gearran, FE 1,673.

38. ¶ Legacy *The long reign of Fearchar Òg*, 18 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,647; ← Follows from *Dòmhnall of Cnoc mhòr swears his paddle*, 28 am Màrt, FE 1,675.

39. ← Follows from *The long reign of Fearchar Òg*, 18 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,647; ← Follows from *Fearchar Òg dies at Dùn dhearg*, 29 am Faoilleach, FE 1,680.

40. ← Leads to *The boatmen of Muileann chrom swear the paddle-oath*, 27 an Gearran, FE 1,673; ◇ Same person *Dòmhnall of Cnoc mhòr swears his paddle*, 28 am Màrt, FE 1,675.

- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,685** — *Beathag Mhòr crowned at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Beathag Mhòr, great-granddaughter of Fearchar Òg, is crowned at twenty in the granary hall at Dùn dhearg. An elder of her own line stands unasked and names her too young to hold ground her house has kept unbroken since the ford. Beathag Mhòr answers with silence and a long look, and the crown is set.⁴¹
- 14 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,688** — *Beathag Mhòr rides the northern road* (Baile Mòr fhionn). Returning from the fleece-market at Baile Mòr fhionn, the young queen rides home by the northern road to see a waypoint-keeper's hearth she has never troubled with her custom. She finds the house at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr⁴² thin-fed and sends it grain from Dùn dhearg unmarked, telling its keeper nothing of the gift's source.⁴³
- 13 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,691** — *Sileas nan Clach paid before the hall's finishing* (Cathair dhearg). The mason Sileas nan Clach of Cathair dhomhain raises the red hall at the bridge-foot through two wet winters and a dry summer. Beathag Mhòr pays her in full before the last course is laid, against the custom of paying only on a building's finishing, and Sileas cuts the hearth-sign into the lintel last of all.⁴⁴
- 14 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,692** — *Iseabail nic Fhearchair answers for Cathair dhombhain* (Cathair dhomhain). The harbour-master Iseabail nic Fhearchair comes to the new hall herself rather than send a steward, and tells the queen to her face that Cathair dhomhain has weighed its own fish and buried its own drowned since before the Red Share held a single stone. Beathag Mhòr hears her through and grants the harbour its own charter of tolls.⁴⁵
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,695** — *The grain-ship saved off Cathair dhombhain* (Cathair dhomhain). A grain-ship out of the western islands loses its mast off Cathair dhomhain's harbour mouth in a winter storm, and the harbour's own boats reach it first and tow it in ahead of the new town's crews. The rescue is told afterward on both quays, and both towns refit boats against the day the sea might drift the other way.⁴⁶
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,699** — *The fleece-measure of Baile Mòr fhionn* (Baile Mòr fhionn). The lords of the western plain hold a market at Baile Mòr fhionn and make the fleece of a grown ewe its measure. Grain, wine, cattle and the horses of the plain are all priced in fleeces. The silver rings of Muileann chiar are taken there too, but reckoned in wool.⁴⁷

41. ← Follows from *Beathag Mhòr*, 6 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,685.

42. the second waypoint house, a turf longhouse with a hearth at either end

43. ← Follows from *Beathag Mhòr crowned at Dùn dhearg*, 6 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,685.

44. ← Follows from *Beathag Mhòr rides the northern road*, 14 an Giblean, FE 1,688.

45. ← Follows from *Sileas nan Clach paid before the hall's finishing*, 13 an Cèitean, FE 1,691.

46. ← Follows from *Iseabail nic Fhearchair answers for Cathair dhombhain*, 14 an Giblean, FE 1,692.

47. ← Leads to *Beathag Mhòr rides the northern road*, 14 an Giblean, FE 1,688.

10 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,699 — *The ball moves to Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Mhòr moves her hall from Dùn dhearg to the town at the western bridge-foot, Cathair dhearg, to sit where the roads, the river and the western harbours meet. Dùn dhearg keeps the old granaries and the graves of the house of Ìomhar. From this reign Cathair dhearg is the seat of rule on Dia-thìr, whatever else changes.⁴⁸

22 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,699 — *Dùn dhearg after the move* (Dùn dhearg). Dùn dhearg, left behind, keeps its granaries and its pride. Its people go on calling it the rìgh's hill, and for many generations its reeves will send their accounts to Cathair dhearg in no hand but their own.

23 AM MÀRT, FE 1,699 — *The red ball* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Mhòr's hall at Cathair dhearg is built on the rise above the harbour, of the red stone that names the town. Its foundations lie under the later citadel. The masons cut the hearth-sign in its lintel as though it were a bridge.⁴⁹

9 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,699 — *Cathair dhombhain against Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhomhain). The harbour of Cathair dhomhain, older and larger, grudges the new seat on its doorstep and refuses the queen's toll on its boats. Beathag Mhòr grants it a charter of its own tolls. The two towns, a few miles apart, are rivals for the rest of the age.⁵⁰

22 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,699 — *Disputed hands* (Dùn ìseal). The council at Dùn ìseal is asked to judge more quarrels over the right to the handful than over anything else: new households, divided households, households that claim descent from one of the nine hearths without proof. Dùghall mac Raghnaill, Keeper after Oighrig Bhàn, asks the queen for a counting.

7 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,699 — *Dùghall mac Raghnaill takes the flame* (Dùn ìseal). The nine hearths choose Dùghall mac Raghnaill of Sliochd Raghnaill⁵¹ to hold the flame, a man of twenty-nine who left his own house's hall as a boy to learn the vein's reckoning. His first sitting at the cup finds the council floor so crowded with disputed claims to the handful that he cannot cross it unhindered.⁵²

19 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,699 — *Beitris nic Ailein shames the Keeper into asking* (Dùn ìseal). An old widow of the eastern road, Beitris nic Ailein, asks Dùghall mac Raghnaill at the crowded council how he means to judge claims to the handful for the rest of his life without ever knowing which he has judged rightly. He has no answer, and rides to Cathair dhearg within the month to ask the queen for a count.⁵³

48. ← Leads to *Sileas nan Clach paid before the ball's finishing*, 13 an Cèitean, FE 1,691.

49. ← Leads to *Sileas nan Clach paid before the ball's finishing*, 13 an Cèitean, FE 1,691.

50. ← Leads to *Iseabail nic Fhearchair answers for Cathair dhombhain*, 14 an Giblean, FE 1,692; ← Leads to *The grain-ship saved off Cathair dhombhain*, 22 an t-Samhain, FE 1,695.

51. the house of Raghnaill

52. ← Follows from *Disputed hands*, 22 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,699.

- 29 AN T-IÚCHAR, FE 1,700** — *The queen and the Keeper agree the count* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Mhòr agrees to Dùghall mac Raghnaill's asking before he has finished it, and the two settle on the waypoint houses as the counting's ground, since every household on the island lies within a day of one. The queen pledges to feed the counters at her own cost out of each house's own stores.⁵⁴
- 27 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,700** — *Ruairidh born to the queen* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Mhòr's son Ruairidh is born at the new hall, grey-headed almost from his cradle. Her household takes the colour for an ill sign; the queen, who has buried enough of her own line's short-lived cousins to know better, takes it for nothing more than a child's colouring.⁵⁵
- 30 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,705** — *Sorcha nic Ruairidh proves a grandmother's claim* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr⁵⁶). At the waypoint house An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, the counter Sorcha nic Ruairidh sits six months over one old woman's claim to the handful, hearing it back four generations by name and by story until it stands proved beyond the council's doubt. She writes the four names down in a hand the old woman cannot read.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,708** — *Ruairidh Cam of Seann Tarr refused* (Seann Tarr). The counters find no coal-right in living memory at the fisher-household of Ruairidh Cam of Seann Tarr, and refuse his claim. Asked whether his house means to appeal, he answers that they burned peat before the Small-Burning Law was thought of and will burn it after, and that peat, besides, is the warmer fire.⁵⁷
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,709** — *Sliochd Raghnaill's plea for Seann Tarr* (Dùn ìseal). Dùghall mac Raghnaill's own house takes up the refused fisher-families' cause at the council, arguing that a right so long unclaimed ought to be granted rather than denied. The council rules against it: the Small-Burning Law protects a right already held, not one never claimed. The Keeper speaks neither for the argument nor against it.⁵⁹
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,712** — *Ruairidh Cam's grandson keeps the light* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal⁶⁰). The rebuilt sea-light on the eastern cape is kept by Ruairidh Cam's own grandson, a duty owed to no coal-right but to his family's long knowledge of the cape's rocks in the dark. Asked whether he still holds to his grandfather's saying about peat, he answers that he does, and the saying travels further than the census roll ever did.

53. ← Follows from *Disputed hands*, 22 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,699; ← Follows from *Dùghall mac Raghnaill takes the flame*, 7 an Dàmhair, FE 1,699.

54. ← Follows from *Beitris nic Ailein shames the Keeper into asking*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,699.

55. ← Follows from *The queen and the Keeper agree the count*, 29 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,700.

56. the second waypoint house, a turf longhouse with a hearth at either end

57. ← Follows from *Sorcha nic Ruairidh proves a grandmother's claim*, 30 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,705.

58. the house of Raghnaill

59. ← Follows from *Ruairidh Cam of Seann Tarr refused*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,708.

60. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,720 — *The refused roll kept in its own chest* (Cathair dhearg). The roll of the households refused the handful is consulted so often by families proving an old claim through a cousin's cousin that the clerks at Cathair dhearg give it a chest of its own. It is worn soft at the corners within a generation of its writing, more read than the larger roll beside it.

II AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,735 — *Beathag Mhòr orders the count* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Mhòr and Dùghall mac Raghnaill agree that every household on the island claiming the handful shall be counted, its right proved or refused, and its name written. The clerks at Cathair dhearg are to write, and the Keepers to judge.⁶¹

9 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,735 — *The waypoint houses as counting-houses* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr⁶²). The counters make their stations at the waypoint houses, for every household on the island lies within a day of one. The keepers of the houses feed the counters at the queen's cost, and in the houses the count is afterwards remembered as a good year.⁶³

22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,735 — *The census of hands*. The households that hold the old right to burn the coal are counted across the whole island for the first time. So it is shown that the burning of the coal was already rationed by rule.⁶⁴

21 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,735 — *The count of hands* (Cathair dhearg). The rolls of the count, kept at Cathair dhearg, give eleven thousand four hundred households holding the right, and some two thousand whose claims were refused. The refused are written on a roll of their own, and from then on it is that roll families search when they would prove an ancestor's standing.⁶⁵

19 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,735 — *The refused of Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). Most of the refused households of the north-eastern coast are fisher-families about Seann Tarr who had never burned coal at all, and now find they have no right to begin. Sliochd Raghnaill⁶⁶ takes up their cause at the council and loses. The fisher-families burn peat and say it is warmer.⁶⁷

17 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,735 — *The light at Baile ìseal* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal⁶⁸). The old beacon on the eastern point at Baile ìseal is rebuilt, kept with driftwood and seal fat as the Law requires, to bring the fishing boats of the eastern coast home in the dark. From it comes Taigh-solais Baile ìseal.⁶⁹

61. ← Leads to *The queen and the Keeper agree the count*, 29 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,700; ← Leads to *Ruairidh born to the queen*, 27 an Lùnastal, FE 1,700.

62. the second waypoint house, a turf longhouse with a hearth at either end

63. ← Leads to *The queen and the Keeper agree the count*, 29 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,700; ← Leads to *Sorcha nic Ruairidh proves a grandmother's claim*, 30 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,705.

64. ← Leads to *Sorcha nic Ruairidh proves a grandmother's claim*, 30 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,705.

65. ← Leads to *The refused roll kept in its own chest*, 26 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,720.

66. the house of Raghnaill

67. ← Leads to *Ruairidh Cam of Seann Tarr refused*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,708; ← Leads to *Sliochd Raghnaill's plea for Seann Tarr*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,709.

- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,735** — *The light at Muileann bheag* (Taigh-solais Muileann bheag⁷⁰). The old beacon on the northern headland at Muileann bheag is rebuilt; from it comes Taigh-solais Muileann bheag. Its keepers are fisher-families of the north-west, who pay no toll to Cathair dhearg in return for keeping it.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,735** — *The light at Àth dhearg* (Taigh-solais Àth dhearg⁷¹). Sliochd Raghnaill⁷² rebuilds the old beacon on the north-eastern cape at Àth dhearg, to mark the way in toward Seann Tarr. From it comes Taigh-solais Àth dhearg.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,735** — *Death of Beathag Mhòr* (Dùn dhearg). Beathag Mhòr dies at Cathair dhearg and by her own command is carried back to Dùn dhearg to lie among the house of Ìomhar. No royal journey before it was so long.
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,735** — *The refused roll read at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). After Beathag Mhòr is carried the length of the island to lie among the house of Ìomhar, the roll of the refused is brought up from Cathair dhearg in its worn chest and read aloud once before the household of Dùn dhearg, so that the hill that gave up its hall might hear what the giving had bought.⁷³
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,736** — *Ruairidh Liath* (Cathair dhearg). Ruairidh Liath, son of Beathag Mhòr, rules from Cathair dhearg. He is grey already when he takes the hall, and his byname is the list's one jest.
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,736** — *Ruairidh Liath crowned at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Ruairidh Liath, grey since his cradle, takes the red hall in his thirty-sixth year, five days after his mother Beathag Mhòr is carried to Dùn dhearg. The crowning is held quietly, in the household's year of mourning, and he keeps her clerks, stewards and reeve in their places.⁷⁴
- 1 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,740** — *The eastern guard doubled* (Cathair dhearg). Ruairidh Liath doubles the guard on the eastern road against toll-cheats grown bold in the census years, when every clerk on the island was walking house to house rather than watching the roads. The guard's pay, more than anything else in his reign, brings him at last to ask something of the silver.⁷⁵

68. the lighthouse at Baile iséal

69. ← Leads to *Ruairidh Cam's grandson keeps the light*, 28 an Cèitean, FE 1,712.

70. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

71. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

72. the house of Raghnaill

73. ← Follows from *Death of Beathag Mhòr*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,735; ← Follows from *The refused roll kept in its own chest*, 26 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,720.

74. ← Follows from *Ruairidh Liath*, 24 an Cèitean, FE 1,736.

75. ← Follows from *Ruairidh Liath crowned at Cathair dhearg*, 24 an t-Samhain, FE 1,736.

- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,745** — *The Silver Feud begins* (Muileann chiar). Ruairidh Liath demands one ring in five of the silver taken at Muileann chiar, saying the tokens that pay his guards should cost him nothing. Sliochd Fhearchair, the silversmiths' house, answers with Muireach Liath's ruling: silver is not holy, and so not the crown's either. They close the workings sooner than pay.
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,745** — *Màiri nic Fhearchair refuses the steward* (Muileann chiar). A steward rides three days from Dùn dhearg to demand one ring in five of Sliochd Fhearchair's silver. Màiri nic Fhearchair, who speaks for the house, answers with Muireach Liath's own ruling that silver is not the mountain's, and sends him home with no other word.⁷⁶
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,745** — *The guards leave Àth ghlas* (Àth ghlas). Two of the four road-guards at the toll-house of Àth ghlas leave their posts unpaid, the wages standing on a silver toll no one has yet agreed to gather. The keeper Oighrig nic Ailein stands the house through the winter with the two who remain, turning back no traveller and collecting no toll.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,746** — *The closing of the silver* (Muileann chiar). For three seasons no silver leaves Muileann chiar. The road-guards go unpaid, the fair at Muileann òg trades in grain again, and the tolls of the eastern road go ungathered. It is called the Silver Feud, though no one is killed in it.⁷⁷
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,746** — *Grain sent unnamed to Àth ghlas* (Àth ghlas). Ruairidh Liath sends grain to the toll-house at Àth ghlas without naming himself the sender, as his mother once sent grain to a hungry waypoint house. Oighrig nic Ailein guesses whose it is and never tells a traveller the story of it.⁷⁸
- 15 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,748** — *Two apprentices go hungry at Muileann chiar* (Muileann chiar). In the third winter of the shutting, two of Màiri nic Fhearchair's youngest apprentices go thinner than any she has trained in forty years at the fire. She feeds them from her own table and judges that a right is not worth keeping at the cost of the hands that would keep it after her.⁷⁹
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,749** — *The Keeper's judgment on the silver* (Dùn ìseal). At the asking of both sides the Keeper Dùghall mac Raghnaill rules at Dùn ìseal that the words of Muireach Liath stand, and silver is not the mountain's; but also that the crown keeps the roads the silver travels. Ruairidh Liath takes one ring in ten, Sliochd Fhearchair opens the workings again, and each calls it a victory.

76. ← Follows from *The Silver Feud begins*, 19 an Lùnastal, FE 1,745.

77. ← Leads to *The guards leave Àth ghlas*, 10 an t-Samhain, FE 1,745.

78. ← Follows from *The closing of the silver*, 17 an t-Sultain, FE 1,746; ← Follows from *The guards leave Àth ghlas*, 10 an t-Samhain, FE 1,745.

79. ← Follows from *The closing of the silver*, 17 an t-Sultain, FE 1,746.

- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,749** — *Màiri nic Fhearchair's journey to Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Màiri nic Fhearchair rides to Dùn ìseal in four days' unbroken rain with her grandnephew Tormod and a strongbox of rings struck in Fearchar Òg's reign, to ask the Keeper's judgment on a right her house has never before brought before the Hall.⁸⁰
- 17 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,749** — *The rain-shut hearing at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Dùghall mac Raghnaill hears Ruairidh Liath and Màiri nic Fhearchair argue the silver a full day in a hall the rain has shut. He has Màiri say Muireach Liath's sentence twice, then rules each of them right and each mistaken, setting the toll at one ring in ten on the roads, not the ore.⁸¹
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,750** — *The Muileann chiar weight made law* (Muileann chiar). In the settlement the silver weights of Muileann chiar are declared the only lawful weights on the roads of the island. Copies in bronze are sent to every waypoint house, and the house of Fearchar is paid for each.
- 17 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,750** — *Sliochd Fhearchair paid for its own weights* (Cathair dhearg). The crown's clerks pay Màiri nic Fhearchair for every bronze copy cast from Sliochd Fhearchair's own weights, the first silver the house has ever taken from Cathair dhearg rather than given it. She calls it no poor victory to settle for.⁸²
- 1 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,751** — *Beitris nic Aonghais casts the first weight* (Muileann dhearg). At Muileann dhearg, Beitris nic Aonghais casts the first bronze copy of the Muileann chiar weight, cracked along its rim from cooling too fast. She keeps the poor casting the rest of her life, showing it to every apprentice before letting them near the good bronze.
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,752** — *The hearth-sign struck on every weight* (Muileann dhearg). Beitris nic Aonghais asks leave to cut Sliochd Fhearchair's hearth-sign into the underside of every weight-copy, that a keeper might know the true measure at a glance. Màiri nic Fhearchair grants it gladly, and the two houses trade weights, bells and lamp-bowls for years after.⁸³
- 2 AM MÀRT, FE 1,760** — *Màiri nic Fhearchair dies* (Muileann chiar). Màiri nic Fhearchair dies in her eightieth year, eleven years after the settlement at Dùn ìseal. At her own long-standing word she is buried with the strongbox that carried her rings to the hearing, rather than the ring she wore at her throat.⁸⁴
- 31 AM MÀRT, FE 1,760** — *Dùghall mac Raghnaill dies* (Dùn ìseal). Dùghall mac Raghnaill dies in his ninetieth year, having held the flame longer than any Keeper before him. The reciters of Dùn ìseal remember him less for the census than for the rain-shut hearing where he told two sides they were each right and each wrong.

80. ← Follows from *The Keeper's judgment on the silver*, 16 an Dàmhair, FE 1,749; ← Follows from *Two apprentices go hungry at Muileann chiar*, 15 am Faoilleach, FE 1,748.

81. ← Follows from *The Keeper's judgment on the silver*, 16 an Dàmhair, FE 1,749; ← Follows from *Màiri nic Fhearchair's journey to Dùn ìseal*, 20 an Dàmhair, FE 1,749.

82. ← Follows from *The Muileann chiar weight made law*, 14 an t-Samhain, FE 1,750; ← Follows from *The rain-shut hearing at Dùn ìseal*, 17 an t-Samhain, FE 1,749.

83. ← Follows from *Beitris nic Aonghais casts the first weight*, 1 an Gearran, FE 1,751.

84. ← Follows from *The hearth-sign struck on every weight*, 3 am Faoilleach, FE 1,752.

- 28 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,780** — *Ruairidh Liath dies* (Cathair dhearg). Ruairidh Liath dies in the red hall at Cathair dhearg in his eightieth year, in the chamber where his mother died before him. His household remembers him as a rìgh who waited where waiting served and moved where nothing else would.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,781** — *The bronze-casters of Muileann dhearg* (Muileann dhearg). The bronze copies of the Muileann chiar weights are cast at Muileann dhearg, where a family of casters learned the craft from the silversmiths. They go on to cast bells, pins and lamp-bowls, and their lamp-bowls hold the Law's measure exactly.⁸⁵
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,781** — *Seonag Chrom* (Cathair dhearg). Seonag Chrom, granddaughter of Ruairidh Liath, rules at Cathair dhearg. She gives the clerks a room of their own in the red hall and a wage in silver, and from her reign the king-list is kept year by year and not reign by reign.⁸⁶
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,781** — *Seonag Chrom crowned and the clerks given a room* (Cathair dhearg). Seonag Chrom, granddaughter of Ruairidh Liath, takes the hall at Cathair dhearg in her twenty-first year. Having read the worn, damp-eaten roll of her grandfather's silver settlement, she gives the Hall's clerks their own room and a wage in silver, and the king-list begins to be kept year by year.⁸⁷
- 25 AN T-IÚCHAR, FE 1,786** — *A teacher of the stag's people comes to Inis bheag* (Inis bheag). A teacher of the stag's people, once a cutter's son, settles at Inis bheag on the northern coast and begins teaching the fisher-marks to children who will never cut coal. The Hall's roll notes the teaching and calls it, in passing, no great matter, since fish have no need of reading.

85. ← Leads to *Beitris nic Aonghais casts the first weight*, 1 an Gearran, FE 1,751; ← Leads to *The hearth-sign struck on every weight*, 3 am Faoilleach, FE 1,752.

86. ← Leads to *Ruairidh Liath dies*, 28 an Cèitean, FE 1,780.

87. ← Follows from *Seonag Chrom*, 24 an Cèitean, FE 1,781.

THE YEARS FE 1,801 – 2,000

- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,854** — *Inis bheag's school of letters* (Inis bheag). At Inis bheag on the Abhainn bheag in the north a teacher of the stag's people begins to teach letters to fishers' children who will never cut coal. It is the first teaching of letters for their own sake. The Hall's roll notes it, and adds that fish do not need reading.¹
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,871** — *The teacher of Inis bheag is buried in his own marks* (Inis bheag). The teacher who first brought letters to Inis bheag dies an old man, having taught three generations of the same dozen families. A pupil cuts his grave-marker in the fisher-marks rather than in the Hall's own hand, the first stone on the island so cut.²
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,908** — *A stable-boy's tally teaches a clerk's daughter her letters* (Cathair dhearg). At Cathair dhearg a boy of Inis bheag, sent inland to serve in the red hall's stables, scratches a fisher's tally on a granary door. A clerk's daughter, Peigi nic Tormoid, asks what the marks mean and will not be told they are nothing, and so learns the fisher-marks before she learns the Hall's own hand.
- 21 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,926** — *Peigi nic Tormoid, clerk of the hall* (Cathair dhearg). Peigi nic Tormoid, of the line of Tormod Scriobhaiche, is clerk of the hall at Cathair dhearg, the first whose own hand can be told from the others in the copies that survive. Her entries are short, and she never gives a reason where a fact will serve. Much of what is known of the middle of the age is in her hand, or copied from it.³
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,926** — *Peigi nic Tormoid takes the clerk's stool* (Cathair dhearg). Peigi nic Tormoid is given the clerk's stool at Cathair dhearg in her twenty-sixth year, after the death of an elder cousin from fever and for want of anyone else willing to take the work. She keeps the roll of the red hall for four-and-forty years after.⁴
- 1 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,948** — *Peigi's ruling on the boundary of two descriptions* (Cathair dhearg). A lord of the plain presses Peigi nic Tormoid to set a boundary dispute down in his own favour. She refuses to keep opinions in the roll and writes instead both sides' own words and the last day they had agreed on anything, a plain record a Keeper's clerk consults to settle a far larger dispute two centuries later.⁵
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,970** — *Death of Peigi nic Tormoid* (Cathair dhearg). Peigi nic Tormoid dies in her own bed at seventy, having kept the roll of the red hall through a reign and the half of another. The clerks who follow her learn to date a leaf by whether her hand lies on it, a truer clock, some say, than the reign it was written under.⁶

1. ← Leads to *A teacher of the stag's people comes to Inis bheag*, 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,786.

2. ← Follows from *Inis bheag's school of letters*, 22 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,854.

3. ← Leads to *A stable-boy's tally teaches a clerk's daughter her letters*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,908.

4. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Tormoid, clerk of the hall*, 21 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,926; ← Follows from *A stable-boy's tally teaches a clerk's daughter her letters*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,908.

4 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,975 — *The fowler households of Seann Skell feed the hawk first* (Seann Skell). At Seann Skell on the northern coast the fowler families begin feeding their hawks before the household eats, on the reasoning that a hunger fed first turns less readily on the house that keeps it waiting. The custom spreads from household to household along the one street.

30 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,999 — *The hawk-keepers of Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). At Seann Skell on the northern coast the fowler families keep a hawk in every household and feed it before the household eats. They burn their season's handful at dawn with the hawk on the wrist, for the flame, they say, is a hunger and should be fed as a hunger is fed. They call the hawk Mòd, the Hawk of Acaill, the grey hawk of time, as old as Fionntan mac Bòchra, eldest of men, who lived down the ages as a salmon, an eagle and a hawk; between them the two remember all things. From them Òrd an t-Seabhaig⁷ counts its beginning.⁸

3 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,000 — *Raghnaid nic Chaluim burns her handful with the hawk unhooded* (Seann Skell). Raghnaid nic Chaluim of Seann Skell burns her household's dawn handful with her hawk Mòd unhooded on her wrist, its eye on the flame the whole time it burns. Her own household says of her afterward that she carried the custom the whole distance it would go.⁹

6. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Tormoid, clerk of the hall*, 21 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,926; ← Follows from *Peigi's ruling on the boundary of two descriptions*, 1 an t-Samhain, FE 1,948.

5. ← Follows from *Peigi nic Tormoid, clerk of the hall*, 21 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,926; ← Follows from *Peigi nic Tormoid takes the clerk's stool*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,926.

7. the Hawk order

8. ← Leads to *The fowler households of Seann Skell feed the hawk first*, 4 an t-Sultain, FE 1,975.

9. ← Follows from *The hawk-keepers of Seann Skell*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,999; ← Follows from *The fowler households of Seann Skell feed the hawk first*, 4 an t-Sultain, FE 1,975.

THE YEARS FE 2,001 – 2,200

- 8 **AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,019** — *A clerk questions Raghnaid on the hawk's watching* (Seann Skell). A clerk sent from Cathair dhearg to set the dawn-hawk custom in the Hall's roll asks Raghnaid nic Chaluim why the bird must watch the burning. She answers that the flame is a hunger too and should be fed in the sight of the thing that hungers, and the clerk writes her words down unaltered.¹
- 6 **AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,035** — *The dawn-hawk kept at Cnoc bheag* (Cnoc bheag). Households at Cnoc bheag, none of them fowlers by trade, buy hawks at cost from Skell traders and take up the dawn burning with the bird on the wrist. Their neighbours, keeping no hawk, remark that the birds are fed better than the households' own children.²
- 11 **AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,041** — *The Keeper sends a clerk to see the dawn kept* (Cnoc bheag). Pressed by an uneasy household of the lowland plain, the Keeper of that season sends a clerk north to Cnoc bheag to see the dawn-hawk rite kept before ruling on it. The clerk reports the hawk-households burn no more of their measure than any other hearth, only in a bird's sight rather than none.³
- 9 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,042** — *The Hall answers that the rite is no concern of its own* (Inis ìseal). The Keeper writes to the lowland household, and to every household after it that raises the question, that the dawn-hawk rite keeps the measure exactly and is no concern of the Hall's. It is the last time in the age the Hall answers any rite so simply.⁴
- 28 **AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,072** — *The hawk-rite spreads up the Abhainn ìseal* (Inis ìseal). The dawn burning with the hawk spreads from Seann Skell on the northern shore up the Abhainn ìseal to Inis ìseal and Cnoc bheag. The Keeper at Dùn ìseal writes that the rite keeps the measure exactly and is therefore no concern of the Hall. Never again does the Hall say so of any rite.⁵
- 7 **AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,098** — *Aonghas Ruadh brings the sting-oath north to Ros bheag* (Ros bheag). Aonghas Ruadh, a merchant of Ros bheag trading salt fish for the dry country's dyed wool, returns from Baile àrsaigh with a boxed scorpion and swears his next bargain on its sting before the harbour court has seen the custom done. The court takes to the swearing within the year.

1. ← Follows from *The hawk-keepers of Seann Skell*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,999; ← Follows from *Raghnaid nic Chaluim burns her handful with the hawk unhooded*, 3 an Dàmhair, FE 2,000.

2. ← Follows from *A clerk questions Raghnaid on the hawk's watching*, 8 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,019.

3. ← Follows from *The dawn-hawk kept at Cnoc bheag*, 6 an Lùnastal, FE 2,035.

4. ← Follows from *The Keeper sends a clerk to see the dawn kept*, 11 an Cèitean, FE 2,041.

5. ← Leads to *The dawn-hawk kept at Cnoc bheag*, 6 an Lùnastal, FE 2,035; ← Leads to *The Keeper sends a clerk to see the dawn kept*, 11 an Cèitean, FE 2,041; ← Leads to *The Hall answers that the rite is no concern of its own*, 9 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,042.

8 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,099 — *A trader of the plain is refused for want of the sting-oath* (Ros bheag). A trader of the plain who will not swear his debt on Ros bheag's sting, calling a boxed scorpion no fit thing to bind a man, is sold no fish by the harbour court, which holds that a man unwilling to swear as every other trader swears is telling the court something his own name does not.⁶

1 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,145 — *The sting-oath at Ros bheag* (Ros bheag). The swearing on a scorpion's sting spreads from Baile àrsaidh up the western coast to Ros bheag, and the harbour court there takes it for every oath of trade. For the rest of the age a merchant who will not swear on the sting is not trusted in the western harbours.⁷

12 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,146 — *Death of Aonghas Ruadh* (Ros bheag). Aonghas Ruadh dies an old man at Ros bheag, still keeper of his own scorpion in its box behind the harbour-master's door. By then no merchant travels the western coast without learning the sting-oath before the prices, from Ros bheag to Baile àrsaidh alike.⁸

10 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,180 — *The shrine-keepers of Inis thais ask for a second stone* (Inis thais). The shrine-keepers of Inis thais, hearing of the wolf-sworn road-guards' oath-stone at Caol leathan, ask the guild whether a second might stand at their own shrine beside the drowned, where a guard's oath, they judge, would sit well beside an older prayer. The guards, flattered more than they admit, agree to drag one themselves rather than trust any mason unsworn to their own oath.

8 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,181 — *The dragging of the second wolf-stone* (Inis thais). The road-guards of Caol leathan drag a block of white quartz from the mountain to Inis thais at the cost of more oxen than the guild can easily spare, the sledge breaking twice on the lower slopes and one ox dying under the second breaking.

7 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,181 — *Calum Mòr declines to swear twice at Inis thais* (Inis thais). Asked by the eldest shrine-keeper whether he wishes to pray before the new stone, the road-guards' captain Calum Mòr answers that he swore on it once at his founding and sees no cause to swear twice, though his guards may pray there as the drowned welcome any stranger's prayer.⁹

6. ← Follows from *Aonghas Ruadh brings the sting-oath north to Ros bheag*, 7 an Cèitean, FE 2,098.

7. ← Leads to *Aonghas Ruadh brings the sting-oath north to Ros bheag*, 7 an Cèitean, FE 2,098; ← Leads to *A trader of the plain is refused for want of the sting-oath*, 8 an Giblean, FE 2,099.

8. ← Follows from *The sting-oath at Ros bheag*, 1 am Faoilleach, FE 2,145; ← Follows from *A trader of the plain is refused for want of the sting-oath*, 8 an Giblean, FE 2,099.

9. ← Follows from *The dragging of the second wolf-stone*, 8 an t-Sultain, FE 2,181.

THE YEARS FE 2,201 – 2,400

- 5 **AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,205** — *The Hall's roll outgrows the clerks' room* (Cathair dhearg). The roll kept at Cathair dhearg since Seonag Chrom first gave the clerks a room runs by now to more chests than the room can hold. A later generation of clerks works from summaries of summaries, the original hands known to them by name and reputation and not by sight.¹
- 3 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,217** — *The wolf-stone at Inis thais* (Inis thais). The wolf-sworn road-guards of Caol leathan set a second wolf-stone at the shrine of Inis thais, and the keepers of the shrine begin to pray before it as well as to the drowned. The stone is white quartz, dragged from the mountain on a sledge at a cost greater than the shrine's.²
- 10 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,217** — *Four keepings named in one breath at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). A trader passing through Cathair dhearg names the hawk fed at Seann Skell, the sting sworn at Ros bheag, the wolf-stone prayed to at Inis thais and the fisher-marks taught at Inis bheag all together, as though of one custom, though none were ever planned as such.³
- 2 **AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,260** — *Donnchadh mac Iain is born at Cnoc bhàn* (Cnoc bhàn). A cutter's widow of Cnoc bhàn brings her second son to the stag's teachers rather than send him to the vein at ten years old, judging one son owed to the coal enough for her house. He grows up among the school's chests of strike-books before he grows up among the seams.
- 28 **AN GEARRAN, FE 2,290** — *The strike-books compared* (Cnoc bhàn). Donnchadh mac Iain, a teacher of the stag's people at Cnoc bhàn, reads through the strike-books of many generations of apprentices. He finds that the coal breaks brighter in its colours for cutters in their later years than in their first, whatever their house, and argues that the vein answers practice. The elders answer that it answers what a cutter was born with, and that practice only shows it.⁴
- 4 **AN T-ÒGMHÌOS, FE 2,290** — *Donnchadh mac Iain is set to the old leaves* (Cnoc bhàn). In a thin winter Cnoc bhàn's masters set the young teacher Donnchadh mac Iain to clearing dead apprentices' leaves from the school's chests, a task given him more as punishment than trust. He begins, instead, a private tally of when in a cutter's years the coal comes brightest.⁵

1. ← Follows from *Peigí nic Tormoid, clerk of the hall*, 21 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,926.

2. ← Leads to *The shrine-keepers of Inis thais ask for a second stone*, 10 an Lùnastal, FE 2,180; ← Leads to *The dragging of the second wolf-stone*, 8 an t-Sultain, FE 2,181; ← Leads to *Calum Mòr declines to swear twice at Inis thais*, 7 an Dàmhair, FE 2,181.

3. ← Follows from *The wolf-stone at Inis thais*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,217.

4. ← Leads to *Donnchadh mac Iain is born at Cnoc bhàn*, 2 am Faoilleach, FE 2,260.

5. ← Follows from *The strike-books compared*, 28 an Gearran, FE 2,290; ← Follows from *Donnchadh mac Iain is born at Cnoc bhàn*, 2 am Faoilleach, FE 2,260.

- 29 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,290** — *Aonghas Cam answers the tally* (Cnoc bhàn). The eldest teacher of Cnoc bhàn, Aonghas Cam, hears Donnchadh mac Iain's tally at the midwinter gathering and answers, as the house had always answered, that the vein knows a cutter's blood and the years only show what was already there. The two teachings begin to divide the room.⁶
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,296** — *The house at Cnoc bhàn sits in two halves* (Cnoc bhàn). By the eighth year of Donnchadh mac Iain's yearly tally, those who hear him to the end of it and those who answer him before he finishes have come, without any master's ordering, to sit on opposite sides of the long room at every midwinter gathering.⁷
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,300** — *Donnchadh mac Iain leaves Cnoc bhàn* (Muileann chaol). Donnchadh mac Iain and twenty-two of his hearers leave the house at Cnoc bhàn and settle at Muileann chaol, taking copies of the strike-books with them. The elders of Cnoc bhàn call it theft of the books. Donnchadh calls it copying, which it is.
- 31 AM MÀRT, FE 2,300** — *The twenty-two leave Cnoc bhàn* (Cnoc bhàn). Donnchadh mac Iain and twenty-two hearers load copies of the strike-books they judge their own onto two borrowed carts and walk south to Muileann chaol. The elders of Cnoc bhàn call it theft; Donnchadh calls it copying, since every leaf they made a copy of stands where it always stood.⁸
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,300** — *Muileann chaol's reeve houses the school* (Muileann chaol). The reeve of Muileann chaol lets Donnchadh mac Iain's twenty-two hearers a millwright's storehouse for a rent none of them can pay in coin, taken instead that first winter in mended roofs and re-hung doors for half the town.⁹
- 3 AM MÀRT, FE 2,301** — *Muileann chaol's books are ruled to keep no parentage* (Muileann chaol). Donnchadh mac Iain sets the rule for the new school's strike-books: no cutter's father, mother or house is written on a leaf, only the name, the day and the stroke. More than one of the twenty-two finds the old habit slower to unlearn than the rule was to set down.¹⁰
- 7 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,317** — *The founding of the rival druid school*. A school of druids breaks away, holding that the vein answers labour and not birth.
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,330** — *The school at Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). The school of Donnchadh mac Iain at Muileann chaol keeps strike-books of its own under a rule the elder school never had: a cutter's parentage is not written in the book at all. The two schools of the stag dispute by letter for the rest of the age, and both keep the letters.¹¹

6. ← Follows from *The strike-books compared*, 28 an Gearran, FE 2,290; ← Follows from *Donnchadh mac Iain is set to the old leaves*, 4 an t-Ogmhios, FE 2,290.

7. ← Follows from *The strike-books compared*, 28 an Gearran, FE 2,290; ← Follows from *Aonghas Cam answers the tally*, 29 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,290.

8. ← Follows from *Donnchadh mac Iain leaves Cnoc bhàn*, 30 am Faoilleach, FE 2,300; ← Follows from *The house at Cnoc bhàn sits in two halves*, 29 an Cèitean, FE 2,296.

9. ← Follows from *Donnchadh mac Iain leaves Cnoc bhàn*, 30 am Faoilleach, FE 2,300; ← Follows from *The twenty-two leave Cnoc bhàn*, 31 am Màrt, FE 2,300.

10. ← Follows from *Muileann chaol's reeve houses the school*, 3 an Dàmhair, FE 2,300.

- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,330** — *Donnchadh mac Iain writes north* (Muileann chaol). Seventy years old and less able to travel, Donnchadh mac Iain sends the first letter to Cnoc bhàn, addressed to the house rather than to any one master, asking whether its own century-and-a-half of leaves shows the same rise with a cutter's years that his own count once showed.¹²
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,340** — *Donnchadh mac Iain dies at Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). Donnchadh mac Iain dies at eighty in the storehouse-schoolhouse his twenty-two hearers first took shelter in forty years before, having taught six generations whose leaves carry no father's or mother's name. He is buried under a leaf of oiled hide cut with one word: one who writes.¹³
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,340** — *Raonaid Dhubh is born at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). A clerk's daughter is born at Dùn ìseal in the same year Donnchadh mac Iain dies, given the name Raonaid Dhubh for the black hair she keeps unusually from her first day.
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,360** — *Raonaid Dhubh takes the Keeper's stool* (Dùn ìseal). Raonaid Dhubh comes to the Keeper's own chest of clerks at twenty, an elder cousin's death leaving the stool empty at a season when no one else in the room wants the sitting of it, and reads there, among other papers, the growing archive of letters between Cnoc bhàn and Muileann chaol.¹⁴
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,366** — *The Hall bears the two schools* (Dùn ìseal). The Keeper Raonaid Dhubh hears both schools of the stag at Dùn ìseal and gives no ruling, saying that the vein has not asked the Hall to decide. The Hall's roll sets down the hearing and the refusal. No refusal of the Hall is more often cited.¹⁵
- 28 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,366** — *Both schools ask the new Keeper for a ruling* (Dùn ìseal). Within her first year holding the cup, Raonaid Dhubh receives word from both Cnoc bhàn and Muileann chaol asking her to say, once and plainly, which school's reading of the vein is the truer, as every Keeper before her has been asked and never once has answered.¹⁶
- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,376** — *What the people of Cnoc ghorm say of their stone* (Calbh Cnoc ghorm¹⁷). Scholars of the stag from Muileann chaol come to Calbh Cnoc ghorm and cannot read it. The people of Cnoc ghorm tell them the stone says: we did not come; we were here. The scholars write that the people say so. No later hand explains either the stone or the saying.

11. ← Leads to *Muileann chaol's books are ruled to keep no parentage*, 3 am Màrt, FE 2,301.

12. ← Follows from *The school at Muileann chaol*, 9 an Lùnastal, FE 2,330; ← Follows from *Muileann chaol's books are ruled to keep no parentage*, 3 am Màrt, FE 2,301.

13. ← Follows from *The school at Muileann chaol*, 9 an Lùnastal, FE 2,330; ← Follows from *Donnchadh mac Iain writes north*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,330.

14. ← Follows from *Raonaid Dhubh is born at Dùn ìseal*, 24 an Lùnastal, FE 2,340.

15. ← Leads to *Raonaid Dhubh takes the Keeper's stool*, 27 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,360.

16. ← Follows from *The Hall bears the two schools*, 4 an t-Samhain, FE 2,366; ← Follows from *Raonaid Dhubh takes the Keeper's stool*, 27 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,360.

17. the column at Cnoc ghorm

- 20 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,376** — *The scholars of Muileann chaol cannot read Cnoc ghorm's stone* (Calbh Cnoc ghorm¹⁸). Scholars of the second school travel east to Cnoc ghorm to read the standing stone at the town's centre, and spend the better part of a day turning its worn face to the light without making out a single letter of its cutting.¹⁹
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,386** — *The digging at Làrach an Dùin*²⁰ (Làrach an Dùin). Men of Baile ghorm dig under the fallen walls of Làrach an Dùin for the riches the ruin was said to hold, and find ash and nothing else. The Keeper has them sentenced as if they had broken the Law, though no law covered it, and the sentence stands as the rule for all the old places after.
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,386** — *Baile ghorm's diggers find only ash* (Làrach an Dùin²¹). A company from Baile ghorm breaks into the fallen walls of Làrach an Dùin by night on the strength of an old tale of riches, and finds at dawn nothing beneath the stone but cold, undisturbed ash that no fire any of them can name had left.²²
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,391** — *Baile ghorm's penance* (Baile ghorm). The families of the diggers at Baile ghorm do penance by keeping in repair the road from their town to Tuam Cnoc dhìreach²³. In the southern hills it is called the diggers' road still.
- 8 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,391** — *The diggers' road earns its name* (Baile ghorm). The road the families of Baile ghorm keep in repair as their penance, from their own town south to Tuam Cnoc dhìreach²⁴, is by this year known in the southern hills by no other name than the diggers' road, kept long past any term the Keeper's sentence set.²⁵
- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,400** — *The hungry season at the halting-house below the pass* (Àth dhìreach). Calum Ruadh of Àth dhìreach and the other carriers of the mountain road read, on the tally board of a small halting-house, the shape of a poor year no custom yet mends: coal going down the road and next to no grain coming up. The house's keeper, an old woman named Mòr, tells them she has buried a husband to just such a winter before.

18. the column at Cnoc ghorm

19. ← Follows from *What the people of Cnoc ghorm say of their stone*, 6 an Dàmhair, FE 2,376.

20. the fortress ruin

21. the fortress ruin

22. ← Follows from *The digging at Làrach an Dùin*, 21 an Lùnastal, FE 2,386.

23. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

24. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

25. ← Follows from *Baile ghorm's penance*, 23 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,391.

THE YEARS FE 2,401 – 2,600

- 16 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,406** — *Lachlann Bàn* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann Bàn takes the red hall at Cathair dhearg. He builds granaries in every province seat that will have one, and makes a law about them, and for these he is remembered.¹
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,406** — *Lachlann Bàn's vow at his crowning* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann Bàn, come to the red hall in his twenty-sixth year, finds granaries that fill and empty by no rule but a steward's whim, and resolves to build a common granary in every province seat that will keep one, to the same plan, so that no district need go hungry beside another's plenty.²
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,408** — *The reeve of Cnoc mhòr's silver ring* (Cnoc mhòr). Cnoc mhòr raises its common granary before any other province seat and sends word of it to Cathair dhearg the same season. Lachlann Bàn sends the reeve a silver ring for his own hand, and within two years no province seat on the plain is willing to be named last where Cnoc mhòr was named first.³
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,410** — *Lachlann Bàn's journey to Dùn ìseal* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann Bàn climbs to Dùn ìseal to ask the Keeper Raonaid Dhubh to set the island's old neighbour-custom of shared grain under his new granaries as law. She asks whether he means his own hall's granary bound by the same terms as any household's; he swears it will be, and she puts her hand to the writing.⁴
- 14 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,411** — *The shared-meal law written* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann Bàn and the Keeper Raonaid Dhubh make the old unwritten custom law at Cathair dhearg: a household with grain above its winter's need gives the surplus to the common granary of its district before the storm season, and the granary feeds any household of the district that runs short. The successors of Peigi nic Tormoid write it into the rolls in full. It is the first law made by rìgh and Keeper together.⁵
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,412** — *Lachlann Bàn and Raonaid Dhubh swear the shared-meal law* (Cathair dhearg). The rìgh at Cathair dhearg and the Keeper at Dùn ìseal set their names together to the law of the common granary: that no district's store be kept from a neighbour's hunger, and that what is lent in a hard year be repaid harvest by harvest.⁶

1. ← Leads to *The hungry season at the halting-house below the pass*, 22 an t-Sultain, FE 2,400.

2. ← Follows from *Lachlann Bàn*, 16 am Faoilleach, FE 2,406.

3. ← Follows from *Lachlann Bàn's vow at his crowning*, 29 an Dàmhair, FE 2,406.

4. ← Follows from *The reeve of Cnoc mhòr's silver ring*, 26 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,408.

5. ← Leads to *Lachlann Bàn's journey to Dùn ìseal*, 24 an Lùnastal, FE 2,410.

6. ← Follows from *The shared-meal law written*, 14 an Gearran, FE 2,411; ← Follows from *Lachlann Bàn's journey to Dùn ìseal*, 24 an Lùnastal, FE 2,410.

- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,415** — *A reeve of the plain protests the mountain's granaries* (Cathair dhearg). A reeve of the lowland plain writes to Cathair dhearg that his district is asked to fill granaries for mountain households that grow no grain of their own. Lachlann Bàn answers that a household which carries the plain's coal all winter has already paid, in the coin of its own back, for whatever grain comes up in return.⁷
- I AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,418** — *Cathair mhòr's fisher-towns pay their share in fish* (Cathair mhòr). The granary raised within Cathair mhòr's old wall, the first anywhere behind a town wall, draws its share from the southern fishing strands in dried fish rather than grain, packed in baskets as the old toll fish once were packed for the Hall at Dùn iséal.
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,420** — *Death of Raonaid Dhubh* (Cathair dhearg). Raonaid Dhubh, Keeper of the flame at Dùn iséal for the better part of forty years and the woman who set the shared-meal law beside Lachlann Bàn, dies in her own eightieth year, having seen the law hold unbroken through two poor seasons.⁸
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,422** — *Ruairidh mac Nèill burns the raiders' boats at Seann Tarr* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Ruairidh mac Nèill of Sliochd Raghnaill⁹ catches the eastern raiders at their own anchorage with the tide against them and burns two of their low black boats. Asked why he let the rest escape, he says a boat burned at its own anchorage teaches the strand's watch more than a raider hanged at Seann Tarr.
- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,425** — *The granary of Cnoc mhòr* (Cnoc mhòr). Cnoc mhòr builds its common granary under the new law before any other district, and sends word of it to Cathair dhearg. Lachlann Bàn sends back a silver ring for the reeve.¹⁰
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,435** — *The common granaries of the mountain* (Muileann chiar). Common granaries are raised under the new law in the mountain districts round Muileann chiar, where the households live by cutting and carrying and grow little of their own. The lowland districts grumble at filling them.¹¹
- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,444** — *The Four Houses begin their quiet counting* (Cathair dhearg). With Oighrig nic Lachlainn newly widowed and childless, Sliochd Ìomhair¹², Sliochd Thormoid¹³ and Sliochd Raghnaill¹⁴ each begin, without speaking of it before her, to reckon what it might claim of the red hall should she die without an heir; Sliochd Mhuirich¹⁵, holding the Keeper's own office, makes no claim at all.

7. ← Follows from *Lachlann Bàn and Raonaid Dhubh swear the shared-meal law*, 29 an Cèitean, FE 2,412.

8. ← Follows from *The shared-meal law written*, 14 an Gearran, FE 2,411.

9. the house of Raghnaill

10. ← Leads to *The reeve of Cnoc mhòr's silver ring*, 26 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,408.

11. ← Leads to *A reeve of the plain protests the mountain's granaries*, 27 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,415.

12. the house of Ìomhar

13. the house of Tormod

14. the house of Raghnaill

15. the house of Muireach

- 12 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,445** — *The granary at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). A common granary is built within the old wall at Cathair mhòr, the first behind a town wall. The southern fishing towns, having no grain, send dried fish to it for their share.¹⁶
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,455** — *Raiders in the eastern waters* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Outlaws in boats raid the eastern fishing strands from the islets offshore, taking dried fish and nets. Sliochd Raghnaill¹⁷ arms its boats at Seann Tarr and burns two of the raiders' boats. The rest escape.¹⁸
- 15 AM MÀRT, FE 2,461** — *Oighrig nic Lachlainn* (Cathair dhearg). Oighrig nic Lachlainn, daughter of Lachlann Bàn, takes the hall at Cathair dhearg. She has no children, and before her reign is half done the houses begin to count their claims.¹⁹
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,461** — *Death of Lachlann Bàn* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann Bàn dies in his own bed at one-and-eighty, five-and-fifty years after his crowning, mourned chiefly by the reeves whose granaries he built and the carriers of the mountain roads, who never once in his reign went a whole winter without knowing where the next grain was coming from.²⁰
- 1 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,461** — *Oighrig nic Lachlainn takes the hall at one-and-twenty* (Cathair dhearg). On her father's death Oighrig nic Lachlainn takes the red hall in her one-and-twentieth year. She will hold it the better part of fifty years and bear no child.²¹
- 19 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,465** — *Calum Ruadh tells his son of the old want* (Àth dhìreach). With the passes above Cnoc ghlas still white with late snow and the mountain households eating their seed, Calum Ruadh tells his son Iain Caol, a boy of fifteen, of the very want he carried through as a young man, and doubts aloud whether the new law will hold where the old custom never had to be tried.
- 21 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,466** — *Calum Ruadh and Iain Caol carry grain to Àth dhìreach* (Dùn dhearg). Calum Ruadh, past his own heaviest carrying, walks down for the grain Dùn dhearg has sent unasked, and his son Iain Caol, too young by the town's reckoning to carry a full load, carries half of one beside him, the boy's first sight of what the shared-meal law meant in a true want.²²
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,466** — *Àth dhìreach grants the carriers the right to rest* (Àth dhìreach). The reeve of Àth dhìreach calls the town together and grants every carrier who walked the famine road that winter the right to rest, for life, in any house of the town without payment; the households swear to keep it as their own word rather than write it into any roll at Cathair dhearg.²³

16. ← Leads to *Cathair mhòr's fisher-towns pay their share in fish*, 1 an Giblean, FE 2,418.

17. the house of Raghnaill

18. ← Leads to *Ruairidh mac Nèill burns the raiders' boats at Seann Tarr*, 26 an Dàmhair, FE 2,422.

19. ← Leads to *The Four Houses begin their quiet counting*, 27 an t-Sultain, FE 2,444.

20. ← Follows from *Oighrig nic Lachlainn*, 15 am Màrt, FE 2,461.

21. ← Follows from *Oighrig nic Lachlainn*, 15 am Màrt, FE 2,461.

- 20 AM MÀRT, FE 2,470** — *Gilleasbuig born to a copying clerk of Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). Gilleasbuig is born at Seann Dunn to Tormod Beag, a copying clerk of Sliochd Thormoid²⁴ who puts down on scraped hide, in the house's small square hand, whatever the red hall sends him to copy. The boy grows up under his father's bench.
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,472** — *The late snow on the high passes* (Cnoc ghlas). The weather-watchers on the cairns above Cnoc ghlas see snow lying on the high passes long past the opening of the galleries. The Hall keeps the galleries shut for the cutters' safety, and the mountain households wait.
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,472** — *The poor season in the mountain* (Muileann chiar). The galleries open late and close early, and the coal carried down is a third of a common season's. The mountain households of Muileann gheal, Doire uaine and Àth dhìreach, who trade their carrying for grain, have nothing to trade, and by the season's end they are eating their seed.²⁵
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,473** — *The first recorded famine averted*. A poor mining season brings three settlements near to starving. The shared-meal law, made in the reign before, holds and saves them. It is the first true trial of the custom.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,473** — *The granaries opened* (Muileann gheal). Under the shared-meal law the common granaries of the mountain districts are opened at Muileann gheal. When they run low the granaries of Dùn dhearg and the southern coast send grain up the carriers' roads without being asked twice, and the carriers bear it for no fee. None in the three settlements is known to die of hunger that winter.²⁶
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,473** — *Iain Caol's first load up* (Àth dhìreach). Iain Caol, grown to a man's height, takes up his first load as a carrier proper, walking the same track his father Calum Ruadh had walked before him, with a company of four other young men of Àth dhìreach carrying their first working loads that same season.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,474** — *Àth dhìreach after the poor season* (Àth dhìreach). At Àth dhìreach, one of the three settlements the granaries fed, the carriers who brought up the grain are given the right to rest in any house of the town without payment for as long as they live. The last of them dies old, and the right with him.²⁷
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,474** — *The reeves of Dùn dhearg send the grain* (Dùn dhearg). The reeves of Dùn dhearg, who had withheld their accounts from Cathair dhearg for generations, open the old granaries of the house of Ìomhar to the mountain without waiting for an order. Oighrig nic Lachlainn writes that she would have given the order had they waited. The successor of Peigi nic Tormoid notes that they did not.²⁸

22. ← Follows from *Calum Ruadh tells his son of the old want*, 19 an Gearran, FE 2,465.

23. ← Follows from *Calum Ruadh and Iain Caol carry grain to Àth dhìreach*, 21 am Faoilleach, FE 2,466.

24. the house of Tormod

25. ← Leads to *Calum Ruadh tells his son of the old want*, 19 an Gearran, FE 2,465.

26. ← Leads to *Calum Ruadh and Iain Caol carry grain to Àth dhìreach*, 21 am Faoilleach, FE 2,466.

27. ← Leads to *Àth dhìreach grants the carriers the right to rest*, 18 an Giblean, FE 2,466; ← Leads to *Iain Caol's first load up*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,473.

28. ← Leads to *Calum Ruadh and Iain Caol carry grain to Àth dhìreach*, 21 am Faoilleach, FE 2,466.

- 17 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,475** — *Why the king-list is kept in six copies* (Seann Dunn). Asked by his small son why the king-list needs six copies where a tithe needs one, Tormod Beag answers that a tithe is true for a year and a king-list must be true for longer than any man who writes it, so that if fire takes one house the rest will still agree.²⁹
- 19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,481** — *A tithe-roll scraped clean for one wrong stroke* (Seann Dunn). Tormod Beag, a copying clerk of Sliochd Thormoid³⁰ at Seann Dunn, scrapes clean a province's tithe-roll his young son Gilleasbuig has copied with a single stroke too many in it, and makes the boy write the whole roll again from the beginning rather than mend the one line, so that he learns early a mistake quietly mended teaches a clerk less than a roll done wholly over.³¹
- 18 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,484** — *Gilleasbuig rides alone to Cathair dhearg with the rolls* (Seann Dunn). At fourteen Gilleasbuig first rides the day and a half from Seann Dunn to the red hall alone, the rolls in a satchel on his back and a hearth-sign token that lets him sleep free at any waypoint house. He learns every waypoint keeper's name before he knows half the great families.³²
- 16 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,486** — *Oighrig nic Lachlainn's word to a clerk's son* (Cathair dhearg). A young Gilleasbuig, carrying his father's rolls to Cathair dhearg at sixteen, is asked by Oighrig nic Lachlainn whose son he is; told his father's name, she says only that the hand is known to her, the one exchange of the whole reign between the woman who holds the red hall and the clerk who will one day fill it.³³
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,511** — *Death of Oighrig nic Lachlainn* (Cathair dhearg). Oighrig nic Lachlainn dies at Cathair dhearg with no heir of her body, and with her ends the line of Go-raidh Mòr, as the list reckons it. The red hall is shut, and its clerks keep it.
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,512** — *The clerks keep the shut hall's tallies* (Cathair dhearg). Gilleasbuig Mòr, sent down from Seann Dunn the winter after Oighrig nic Lachlainn's death, spends a season sealing rolls and answering reeves at the shut red hall who no longer know whose name to render account to, keeping every tally true on the plain reasoning that whoever fills the hall next will want them so.³⁴

29. ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig born to a copying clerk of Seann Dunn*, 20 am Màrt, FE 2,470.

30. the house of Tormod

31. ← Follows from *Oighrig nic Lachlainn*, 15 am Màrt, FE 2,461; ← Follows from *Why the king-list is kept in six copies*, 17 an Cèitean, FE 2,475.

32. ← Follows from *A tithe-roll scraped clean for one wrong stroke*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,481.

33. ← Follows from *Oighrig nic Lachlainn*, 15 am Màrt, FE 2,461; ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig rides alone to Cathair dhearg with the rolls*, 18 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,484.

34. ← Follows from *Death of Oighrig nic Lachlainn*, 19 an t-Sultain, FE 2,511; ← Follows from *Oighrig nic Lachlainn's word to a clerk's son*, 16 an Lùnastal, FE 2,486.

- 10 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,513** — *The four houses meet* (Dùn ìseal). The Four Houses of custody meet at Dùn ìseal to choose a ruler, for no custom covers a hall without an heir. Sliochd Ìomhair³⁵ claims it by blood, Sliochd Thormoid³⁶ by the clerks, Sliochd Raghnaill³⁷ by its boats. Sliochd Mhuirich³⁸, holding the Keeper's office, makes no claim.
- 4 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,513** — *Sliochd Mhuirich³⁹ makes no claim to the empty hall* (Dùn ìseal). At the Four Houses' meeting at Dùn ìseal, Sliochd Ìomhair⁴⁰ claims the red hall by blood, Sliochd Thormoid⁴¹ by the unbroken rolls, Sliochd Raghnaill⁴² by its boats and silver. Sliochd Mhuirich, which holds the Keeper's office, makes no claim and says the vein has not asked it to judge.⁴³
- 24 AM MÀRT, FE 2,514** — *Gilleasbuig watches the Four Houses argue* (Dùn ìseal). Called down from Cathair dhearg twice a year to lay the shut hall's own rolls before whichever house asks to see them, Gilleasbuig Mòr sits at the edge of the Four Houses' long sitting at Dùn ìseal, and hears blood, boats and silence argued past each other for three years without once being asked his own mind on the matter.⁴⁴
- 26 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,516** — *Sliochd Ìomhair⁴⁵'s condition of the graves* (Dùn ìseal). Sliochd Ìomhair consents to the clerk's choosing on one condition: that whoever takes the red hall, the graves at Dùn dhearg remain the kings' burying-place. Gilleasbuig answers that he never expected to be buried anywhere else, and the condition is sworn on the spot.⁴⁶
- 12 AM MÀRT, FE 2,516** — *The election of Gilleasbuig Mòr* (Seann Dunn). The houses choose Gilleasbuig Mòr mac Tormoid of Seann Dunn, a grandson of the clerks' line, to hold the red hall. The Keeper sets the stone cup in his hands before the council, and so for the first time a ruler is made at Dùn ìseal. Sliochd Ìomhair⁴⁷ consents, on condition that its graves at Dùn dhearg remain the burying-place of the kings.⁴⁸

35. the house of Ìomhar

36. the house of Tormod

37. the house of Raghnaill

38. the house of Muireach

39. the house of Muireach

40. the house of Ìomhar

41. the house of Tormod

42. the house of Raghnaill

43. ← Follows from *The four houses meet*, 10 an Giblean, FE 2,513; ← Follows from *The clerks keep the shut hall's tallies*, 14 an t-Sultain, FE 2,512.

44. ← Follows from *The four houses meet*, 10 an Giblean, FE 2,513.

45. the house of Ìomhar

46. ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig watches the Four Houses argue*, 24 am Màrt, FE 2,514.

47. the house of Ìomhar

48. → Caused by *Sliochd Ìomhair's condition of the graves*, 26 an Gearran, FE 2,516.

- 16 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,516** — *Sliochd Raghnaill*⁴⁹ first names the clerk of the shut hall (Dùn iséal). Sliochd Raghnaill is the first of the Four Houses to put Gilleasbuig Mòr's own name forward for the red hall, on the reasoning that a clerk who kept the shut hall's rolls straight three years running, favouring no house's claim over the work, has already shown the hand a red hall wants at its head.⁵⁰
- 16 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,516** — *Tormod mac Gilleasbuig sits at the rolls* (Cathair dhearg). Gilleasbuig Mòr sends for his son Tormod, already taught the clerks' bench at Seann Dunn at sixteen, to sit beside him at Cathair dhearg and learn the red hall's own rolls before he is taught anything else of ruling, the same order his own father once taught him a road in.⁵¹
- 11 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,517** — *Gilleasbuig Mòr at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Gilleasbuig Mòr takes the red hall. He keeps the clerks' office in the hands of his own house and has the king-list copied again from the beginning, with a line drawn beneath Oighrig nic Lachlainn. The line is in every later copy.⁵²
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,517** — *The line drawn beneath a queen's name* (Cathair dhearg). In the year after the cup is set in his hands, Gilleasbuig Mòr has the king-list copied again from its beginning in his own house's hand, with a single line drawn beneath the name of Oighrig nic Lachlainn to mark the ending of Goraidh Mòr's whole line, so that no clerk after him need hunt a kinship no longer there.⁵³
- 31 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,517** — *Gilleasbuig sleeps in the clerks' room of the red hall* (Cathair dhearg). Coming to Cathair dhearg by the lowland road, the new rìgh sleeps his first night in the small room off the rolls-chamber where the clerks keep their beds, the queen's chambers having stood empty five years and no one having thought to air them. He keeps that room to his death.⁵⁴
- 11 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,524** — *The meadow of Muileann àrsaidh and Ceann àrsaidh* (Muileann àrsaidh). Gilleasbuig Mòr judges the one dispute of his reign the rolls set down whole, a water-meadow claimed whole by two households on notched sticks that agree for forty years and then part company; he sends a clerk to copy both sticks stroke for stroke and gives the meadow to both households at once, with a boundary stone cut down its centre for the first time in living memory.⁵⁵

49. the house of Raghnaill

50. ← Follows from *The election of Gilleasbuig Mòr*, 12 an Màrt, FE 2,516; ← Follows from *Sliochd Ìomhair's condition of the graves*, 26 an Gearran, FE 2,516.

51. ← Follows from *Sliochd Raghnaill first names the clerk of the shut hall*, 16 an Cèitean, FE 2,516.

52. ← Leads to *Tormod mac Gilleasbuig sits at the rolls*, 16 an t-Sultain, FE 2,516.

53. ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig Mòr at Cathair dhearg*, 11 an Gearran, FE 2,517; ← Follows from *Tormod mac Gilleasbuig sits at the rolls*, 16 an t-Sultain, FE 2,516.

54. ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig Mòr at Cathair dhearg*, 11 an Gearran, FE 2,517; ← Follows from *The line drawn beneath a queen's name*, 21 an Giblean, FE 2,517.

55. ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig Mòr at Cathair dhearg*, 11 an Gearran, FE 2,517; ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig sleeps in the clerks' room of the red hall*, 31 an Cèitean, FE 2,517.

- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,537** — *The shrine at Seann Dunn enlarged* (Seann Dunn). Gilleasbuig Mòr enlarges his house's shrine at Seann Dunn into a temple with a court for pilgrims. The other houses say still that its coal-lamp burns fuller than the measure, and every season a Keeper's cutter is sent to try it.
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,538** — *The Keeper's cutter tries Seann Dunn's lamp* (Seann Dunn). The other three houses say the enlarged temple at Seann Dunn burns fuller than the Law allows. A Keeper's cutter is sent every season to try its measure by the island's common weights, and every season finds the measure kept, which changes nobody's mind.⁵⁶
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,540** — *Death of Iain Caol, the last of the grain-carriers* (Àth dhìreach). Iain Caol dies at Àth dhìreach in his ninetieth year, the last living of any who could say he had carried the road when the famine and the right to rest were both still new. The right the town kept for its carriers dies with him, though the town still sets out, at the turn of every year, the one bowl he had kept for whichever carrier walked the road that night.⁵⁷
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,541** — *Death of Gilleasbuig Mòr* (Dùn dhearg). Gilleasbuig Mòr dies at Cathair dhearg and is buried among the house of Ìomhar at Dùn dhearg, as was agreed. His son Tormod Òg follows him without a meeting of the houses, and none asks for one.
- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,541** — *Gilleasbuig Mòr carried five days to Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Gilleasbuig Mòr's bier is carried the five days' road from Cathair dhearg to Dùn dhearg, stopping each night at a waypoint house whose keeper had known him first as a boy with a satchel of rolls, to be buried among the house of Ìomhar as Sliochd Ìomhair⁵⁸ had sworn at his choosing.⁵⁹
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,541** — *Tormod Òg follows his father without a meeting of the houses* (Cathair dhearg). Gilleasbuig's son Tormod takes the red hall in his one-and-fortieth year without any meeting of the Four Houses, and none asks for one; a son following a father now seems to every house the plainer course.⁶⁰
- 29 AM MÀRT, FE 2,558** — *The gap in the list* (Cathair dhearg). Nine rulers of the house of Tormod reign between Tormod Òg and Anna Ruadh, and the king-list at Cathair dhearg gives their names and years and little else. The successors of Peigi nic Tormoid were diligent and brief; for these reigns the rolls tell mostly of harvests, tolls and the mending of bridges.

56. ← Follows from *The shrine at Seann Dunn enlarged*, 13 am Faoilleach, FE 2,537.

57. ← Follows from *Àth dhìreach after the poor season*, 18 an Dàmhair, FE 2,474; ← Follows from *Iain Caol's first load up*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,473.

58. the house of Ìomhar

59. ← Follows from *Death of Gilleasbuig Mòr*, 27 an Giblean, FE 2,541.

60. ← Follows from *Death of Gilleasbuig Mòr*, 27 an Giblean, FE 2,541.

- 19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,559** — *The bridge at Cathair dhearg is widened a third time* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg⁶¹). The masons' fellowship widens the old bridge at Cathair dhearg a third time on Mòrag nan Rathad's own piers, broad enough now for two carts to pass abreast. The old keystone, carrying the fourth hearth's sign, is set into the new parapet rather than broken for rubble.
- 21 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,561** — *The road-guards first ride the lowland roads* (Dùn dhearg). The road-guards of Dùn dhearg take to the small tough horses of the southern grass country rather than walking their circuits, and can reach a waypoint house before a night's quarrel has cooled into a grievance. Theirs are the first riders' names the road-guard's own roll keeps.
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,562** — *The road-guards' roll first names its riders* (Dùn dhearg). The first mounted company of the road-guards of Dùn dhearg, riding the small tough horses of the southern grass country, are the earliest guards whose names the road-guards' own roll troubles to keep.
- I AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,567** — *The flood takes the eastern approach at Ros fhionn* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). A wet spring swells the river at Ros fhionn past every bank built to hold it, carrying off the eastern approach of Ailean Clachair's span and three households built too near the water. The span itself, and Ailean's own hearth-sign in its keystone, stand untouched.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,568** — *The fellowship mends Ros fhionn on deeper footings* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). Masons called down from Cathair dhearg lay a new causeway on stone footings deep enough to outlast the flood that took the old one, and leave Ailean Clachair's hearth-sign untouched, cutting their own new work a course below it rather than over it.⁶²
- I AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,569** — *The masons leave Ailean's sign standing at Ros fhionn* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). Clearing the old approach at Ros fhionn, the masons find the keystone Ailean Clachair cut with the fourth hearth's sign and leave it as it is, cutting their own work a course below. The fellowship keeps the custom after: old signs are left standing wherever the stone beneath them stands.⁶³
- 24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,571** — *The bridge at Cathair dhearg widened* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg⁶⁴). The bridge at Cathair dhearg is rebuilt a third time, wide enough now for a cart, for carts have come onto the lowland roads. The hearth-sign is cut again in the keystone. The span stands on the piers of Mòrag nan Rathad.⁶⁵

61. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

62. ← Follows from *The flood takes the eastern approach at Ros fhionn*, 1 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,567.

63. ← Follows from *The fellowship mends Ros fhionn on deeper footings*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,568.

64. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

65. ← Leads to *The bridge at Cathair dhearg is widened a third time*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,559.

19 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,578 — *The bridge at Dùn chrom is built at half toll* (Dùn chrom).

The fellowship bridges the river below Dùn chrom, joining the southern road to the western without the long way round by Cathair dhearg, and sets its own toll at half the capital's. Cathair dhearg's reeves complain in letters the rolls still keep; none takes up the fellowship's offer to hand the crossing to the crown.⁶⁶

20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,580 — *Cathair dhearg's reeves complain of the half-toll at Dùn chrom* (Dùn chrom).

The reeves of Cathair dhearg protest that a toll set by anyone but the crown will in time be set anywhere by anyone. The fellowship offers to hand the crossing to the crown, tolls and upkeep together. No reeve takes up the offer, and the half-toll stands.⁶⁷

24 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,583 — *Riders on the lowland roads* (Dùn dhearg).

The road-guards of Dùn dhearg begin to ride the lowland roads on the small horses of the southern grass country, and a guard can now reach a waypoint house before a quarrel there has cooled. They are the first riders whose names are kept, and for long the only ones.⁶⁸

22 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,591 — *The fisher-kin of Sliochd Raghnaill⁶⁹ bridge Ceann àrsaidh*

(Ceann àrsaidh). Forty of the fisher-kin of Sliochd Raghnaill, taught the mason's craft in an idle season after the burning at Seann Tarr, build the fourth stone bridge of the lowlands at the river town of Ceann àrsaidh. The fellowship's roll names all forty, a courtesy not always given to borrowed hands.⁷⁰

II AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,592 — *The forty fisher-masons named on the fellowship's roll*

(Ceann àrsaidh). The masons' roll at Cathair dhearg names all forty fisher-kin of Sliochd Raghnaill⁷¹ who built the bridge at Ceann àrsaidh, on the reasoning that people who learned a new trade rather than sit idle deserve to be named among the masons.⁷²

23 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,598 — *The crossing at Ros fhionn repaired* (Drochaid Ros fhionn).

A flood takes the eastern approach of Ailean Clachair's span above Ros fhionn, and it is mended. The masons find their founder's hearth-sign still sharp in the keystone, and leave it untouched.⁷³

12 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,600 — *Caol mhòr gathers under its own headman* (Caol mhòr).

The fisher-families of Caol mhòr on the north-western coast gather under a headman of their own choosing and send tolls to Cathair dhearg only in the years a road-guard comes so far to collect them. A reeve of Ros dhomhain writes that the coast might as well keep its own law for all the crown's writ reaches it.

66. ← Follows from *The masons leave Ailean's sign standing at Ros fhionn*, 1 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,569.

67. ← Follows from *The bridge at Dùn chrom is built at half toll*, 19 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,578.

68. ← Leads to *The road-guards first ride the lowland roads*, 21 an Cèitean, FE 2,561.

69. the house of Raghnaill

70. ← Follows from *Cathair dhearg's reeves complain of the half-toll at Dùn chrom*, 20 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,580.

71. the house of Raghnaill

72. ← Follows from *The fisher-kin of Sliochd Raghnaill bridge Ceann àrsaidh*, 22 an Cèitean, FE 2,591.

73. ← Leads to *The flood takes the eastern approach at Ros fhionn*, 1 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,567; ← Leads to *The fellowship mends Ros fhionn on deeper footings*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,568.

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- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,605** — *A reeve of Ros dhomhain writes of Caol mhòr* (Ros dhomhain). A reeve of Ros dhomhain writes more than once to the red hall that Caol mhòr pays what it pleases and answers to whom it pleases. The red hall mostly sends no answer; the north-west's tolls are not worth a road-guard's season.
- 15 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,610** — *Beathag Clachair is born at Doire mhin* (Doire mhin). Beathag Clachair is born to a family of cutters at Doire mhin on the southern road, three generations deep in boundary-stones and byre-lintels, and is quicker than her father's other apprentices at reading a stone's grain before she has seen twenty summers.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,613** — *The bridge at Dùn chrom* (Dùn chrom). The masons' fellowship bridges the river below Dùn chrom, joining the southern road to the western without the long way round by Cathair dhearg. The toll is set at half the road-toll, and Cathair dhearg complains.¹
- 6 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,615** — *Ceann mhòr begins the seal-oil trade* (Ceann mhòr). Ceann mhòr on the north-western coast begins rendering seal-oil from the northern rocks and carrying it down to Ros bheag for silver rings. From then on the seal-oil lamps of the western harbours burn the brightest light on Dia-thìr.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,628** — *The bridge at Ceann àrsaidh* (Ceann àrsaidh). A bridge is built at the river town of Ceann àrsaidh, the fourth stone crossing of the lowlands. The masons' roll names the forty who built it, all of the fisher-kin of Sliochd Raghnaill², who had learned the craft while the boats lay idle.³
- 8 AM MÀRT, FE 2,630** — *Herders take the high pastures above Muileann leathan* (Muileann leathan). Herding families take the summer pastures above Muileann leathan for the wool the weavers of Inis mhòr prize above any other, holding no right to the handful and never counted in any census, their pastures too high and too far for a road-guard to trouble reckoning them.
- 1 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,635** — *Inis mhin's headman walks to the wool-fair with a complaint* (Inis mhin). The headman of the small northern harbour of Inis mhin walks the whole distance to the wool-fair at Inis mhòr to lay a complaint against the road-guard's toll, the only time the harbour comes into the rolls this age, and the complaint kept in fuller telling than the harbour otherwise earns.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,643** — *The bridge at Doire mhin* (Doire mhin). The masons' fellowship builds a small bridge at Doire mhin to carry the southern road over a stream that floods each spring. Beside the hearth-sign in the keystone is cut the name of Beathag Clachair, who cut it: the first mason's mark known.⁴

1. ← Leads to *The bridge at Dùn chrom is built at half toll*, 19 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,578.

2. the house of Raghnaill

3. ← Leads to *The fisher-kin of Sliochd Raghnaill bridge Ceann àrsaidh*, 22 an Cèitean, FE 2,591.

4. ← Leads to *Beathag Clachair is born at Doire mhin*, 15 an t-Sultain, FE 2,610.

9 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,643 — *Beathag Clachair cuts the first mason's mark* (Doire mhin).

Leading her own crossing for the first time, Beathag Clachair cuts her own name beneath the fourth hearth's sign at the small bridge over the stream at Doire mhin: Beathag the mason set this. No mason before her had ever cut a name of his own beside the hearth's, and within two seasons every hearth on the island follows her.⁵

29 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,645 — *Masons of every hearth cut their names beside the sign* (Doire mhin). Within two seasons of Beathag Clachair's bridge at Doire mhin, masons of every hearth begin cutting their own names beside the fourth hearth's sign wherever a fellowship crew finishes a crossing. The masons call it Beathag's mark.⁶

27 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,650 — *The far-off house is rebuilt in stone* (An Sligeanach Fad' às⁷).

The waypoint house the carriers call the far-off house, so distant from any town that a traveller is never nearer to it than halfway, is rebuilt in stone after its old timber and turf give out to a western storm, keeping the name a hundred years of true telling had earned it.

16 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,658 — *The far-off house* (An Sligeanach Fad' às⁸). The waypoint house on the site of An Sligeanach Fad' às, the oldest house under the road-peace, is rebuilt in stone. It lies so far from any town that the carriers say one is never nearer to it than halfway, and from the saying it takes its name.⁹

26 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,660 — *A waypoint keeper of the northern road begins serving fire-water* (An Leòmhann Buidhe¹⁰). A new keeper of the waypoint house the carriers call a waypoint house on the northern road, on the northern road, begins serving a spirit distilled from barley stronger than any small beer sold on that road before. The carriers name it fire-water for the way of it going down and the way of it sitting after.

15 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,672 — *Fire-water on the northern road* (An Leòmhann Buidhe¹¹).

The house on the northern road, on the site of An Leòmhann Buidhe, begins to serve a spirit distilled from barley that the carriers call fire-water. The Keepers rule that it is not a burning and no concern of theirs. The house's trade doubles.¹²

24 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,673 — *The Keeper rules fire-water no burning of the Law* (An Leòmhann Buidhe¹³). Asked by troubled reeves of the northern road to rule on fire-water under the Small-Burning Law, the Keeper of that generation answers that a fire kept in a man's own belly is no burning the Law was written to answer for, and that the Hall will rule on drink the day it rules on food. The waypoint house's trade doubles within the season.¹⁴

5. ← Follows from *The bridge at Doire mhin*, 18 an Dàmhair, FE 2,643.

6. ← Follows from *Beathag Clachair cuts the first mason's mark*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,643.

7. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

8. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

9. ← Leads to *The far-off house is rebuilt in stone*, 27 an t-Samhain, FE 2,650.

10. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

11. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

12. ← Leads to *A waypoint keeper of the northern road begins serving fire-water*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,660.

13. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

14. ← Follows from *Fire-water on the northern road*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,672.

- 22 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,680** — *Beathag Clachair dies at Doire mhin* (Doire mhin). Beathag Clachair dies at seventy at Doire mhin, having cut her mark on four further crossings, and is buried at her own asking at the foot of the bridge that carries her name. Masons of the fellowship keep, for a long while after, the habit of laying a chip of grey stone on her grave in passing.¹⁵
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,687** — *Caol mhòr in the north-west* (Caol mhòr). The fisher-families of the north-west gather at Caol mhòr under a headman of their own, and send tolls to Cathair dhearg only in the years the road-guard comes to take them. Little is written of the north-west in this age, and most of it is complaint of that.¹⁶
- 23 AM MÀRT, FE 2,695** — *Ros bheag's merchants arm two boats against raiders* (Spùinneadairan-mara). The sting-sworn merchants of Ros bheag pay from their own purses to arm and crew two boats against raiders taking dried fish from the western strands. The raiders move north before either boat catches one at sea, and the coast keeps a wariness it had not kept before.
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,702** — *Seal-oil from Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). Ceann mhòr on the north-west coast begins to trade seal-oil down the western coast to Ros bheag for silver rings, and its beacons burn it. For many generations the seal-oil lamps of the western harbours are the brightest light on Dia-thìr.¹⁷
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,717** — *The high pastures of Muileann leathan* (Muileann leathan). Herding families take the high pastures above Muileann leathan in the north and keep sheep there for the wool of Inis mhòr. They hold no right to the handful, have never held one, and are not counted in the census of hands.¹⁸
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,720** — *The second sighting off Baile chrom* (Uilebheist na Mara¹⁹). Two boats of Baile chrom tell of something vast moving beneath their keels in the north-western water, the second such telling the coast remembers since Ruairidh Liath's reign. One boat does not come home, and Baile chrom keeps its old wake for both losses together.
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,721** — *Baile chrom keeps one wake for both lost boats* (Baile chrom). One of the two boats of Baile chrom that felt the sea breathe under them does not come home, nor is any wreck found. The harbour keeps the wake it kept for the earlier loss for both losses together.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,732** — *Inis mhin on the northern shore* (Inis mhin). Inis mhin, a fishing harbour on the northern shore, comes into the rolls for the first time when its headman goes to the wool-fair of Inis mhòr to complain of the road-guard's toll. The complaint is written down in full, and it is all that is written of the town in this age.²⁰

15. ← Follows from *The bridge at Doire mhin*, 18 an Dàmhair, FE 2,643.

16. ← Leads to *Caol mhòr gathers under its own headman*, 12 an t-Samhain, FE 2,600.

17. ← Leads to *Ceann mhòr begins the seal-oil trade*, 6 an Giblean, FE 2,615.

18. ← Leads to *Herders take the high pastures above Muileann leathan*, 8 am Màrt, FE 2,630.

19. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

20. ← Leads to *Inis mhin's headman walks to the wool-fair with a complaint*, 1 an t-Sultain, FE 2,635.

- 31 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,735** — *Sliochd Raghnaill*²¹ sails the round of the offshore islands (Seann Tarr). Boats of Sliochd Raghnaill sail from Seann Tarr round the whole ring of the offshore islands, Eilean ruadh, Eilean dhearg and Eilean fhada among them, and come home within one season, the first crew of the age known to have made the whole round.
- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,740** — *Families take sheep to summer on Eilean ruadh* (Eilean ruadh). Coastal families begin carrying sheep over to Eilean ruadh each summer for its grazing, building turf shelters against the weather and bringing the flocks home before the autumn storms. Later herders keep patching the same shelters rather than building anew.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,747** — *The raid on the western strands* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Raiders from the north-western waters take a season's dried fish from the strands of the north-western coast. The sting-sworn merchants of Ros bheag pay for two armed boats to watch the strands, and the raiders move north.²²
- 29 AM MÀRT, FE 2,761** — *The second sighting* (Uilebheist na Mara²³). Two boats of Baile chrom tell of something vast moving beneath them in the north-western water, the second such sighting remembered. One boat does not come home. The wake that Baile chrom keeps for the first loss is kept now for both.²⁴
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,776** — *Round the islands* (Seann Tarr). Boats of Sliochd Raghnaill²⁵ sail from Seann Tarr round the offshore islands, Eilean ruadh, Eilean dhearg and Eilean fhada among them, and come home in one season. No crew of the age goes further from the coast than the islands, and none is known to have wished to.²⁶
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,791** — *Summer herders on Eilean ruadh* (Eilean ruadh). Families from the coast take sheep over to Eilean ruadh for the summer grazing and bring them back before the storms. They build turf shelters there, which later herders use again.²⁷

21. the house of Raghnaill

22. ← Leads to *Ros bheag's merchants arm two boats against raiders*, 23 am Màrt, FE 2,695.

23. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

24. ← Leads to *The second sighting off Baile chrom*, 21 an Giblean, FE 2,720.

25. the house of Raghnaill

26. ← Leads to *Sliochd Raghnaill sails the round of the offshore islands*, 31 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,735.

27. ← Leads to *Families take sheep to summer on Eilean ruadh*, 2 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,740.

THE YEARS FE 2,801 – 2,960

- 24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,806** — *Anna Ruadh* (Cathair dhearg). Anna Ruadh of the house of Tormod takes the red hall at Cathair dhearg. She walks the whole circuit of the roads, the first ruler to do so since Mòrag nan Rathad, and she walks it twice.
- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,807** — *Anna Ruadh asks the reeves how the roads stand* (Cathair dhearg). At her first councils Anna Ruadh asks the reeves how the roads stand between one seat and the next. When none can tell her past his own district, she says she will go and see. The reeve of Cathair dhomhain tells her a hall is better kept from a hall.¹
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,808** — *Anna Ruadh sets out with a dozen of her household* (Cathair dhearg). Anna Ruadh leaves the red hall in spring with a dozen of her household and no more baggage than a carrier takes, no litter and no guard beyond a well-off traveller's, the first ruler to walk the whole circuit since Mòrag nan Rathad.²
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,809** — *Anna Ruadh at Am Buabhall Fortanach*³ (Am Buabhall Fortanach). On her first circuit Anna Ruadh stops at the house on the site of Am Buabhall Fortanach, where the War of the Roads was ended, and eats the jugged buffalo like a carrier. The keepers of the house tell of it still.⁴
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,811** — *Anna Ruadh's second circuit*. Anna Ruadh walks the whole road circuit a second time in her middle years, slower than her first walking, stopping longest where keepers who fed her as a young queen feed her again grey-haired; at Am Buabhall Fortanach⁵ she sleeps a night under the same roof for the only time in either circuit.⁶
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,813** — *Anna Ruadh at the sunny house* (An Taigh-òsta Grianach⁷). On the eastern road Anna Ruadh lodges at the house on the site of An Taigh-òsta Grianach and grants its keepers a toll of their own for the upkeep of the road to Cnoc leathan, Slighe Cnoc leathan. No other waypoint house on the island holds a royal charter.
- 22 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,813** — *Anna Ruadh takes the sunny house's charter to stone* (Cathair dhearg). The keeper of the sunny house on the road to Cnoc leathan, who has mended the stretch out of her own household's stores for three generations, asks Anna Ruadh that the new charter be cut in stone rather than skin, since a fire can lose a skin but never a stone, and the queen has it cut before she leaves the district.⁸

1. ← Follows from *Anna Ruadh*, 24 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,806.

2. ← Follows from *Anna Ruadh asks the reeves how the roads stand*, 27 an t-Sultain, FE 2,807.

3. the first waypoint house, kept by Mòr nic Dhùghaill above Doire shean

4. → Caused by *Anna Ruadh sets out with a dozen of her household*, 29 an Lùnastal, FE 2,808.

5. the first waypoint house, kept by Mòr nic Dhùghaill above Doire shean

6. ← Follows from *Anna Ruadh*, 24 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,806; ← Follows from *Anna Ruadh sets out with a dozen of her household*, 29 an Lùnastal, FE 2,808.

7. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

8. ← Follows from *Anna Ruadh at the sunny house*, 21 an Lùnastal, FE 2,813.

- 12 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,816** — *Anna Ruadh at Ceann mhin* (Ceann mhin). At Ceann mhin on the south-eastern coast Anna Ruadh hears the quarrel of the fishers and the carriers over who may carry dried fish up to the mountain, and rules that both may. The fish going inland is doubled, and its price at Dùn ìseal halved.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,816** — *An old fisher of Ceann mhin judges the queen fair to the fish* (Ceann mhin). Years after Anna Ruadh's ruling that both fishers and carriers might carry the dried catch inland, an old fisher of the strand, asked which side the queen had truly favoured, answers that she had favoured the fish, which was more than either household carrying it had thought to do.⁹
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,818** — *Dried fish doubles inland after the ruling at Ceann mhin* (Ceann mhin). Two years after Anna Ruadh ruled that fishers and carriers alike might carry dried fish up-country, the fish going inland has doubled and its price at Dùn ìseal has fallen by half. Both sides claim the doubling as proof they were right.¹⁰
- 11 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,819** — *The contest at Ceann leathan in stone* (Ceann leathan). Anna Ruadh gives the road-guards' contest at Ceann leathan a stone-walled field, and for its prize a silver ring from the red hall. Fighters come to it from all the south, and the losers are fed at the crown's cost.
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,819** — *Fearchar Ruadh wins the stone field at Ceann leathan* (Ceann leathan). A mason's apprentice named Fearchar Ruadh of Doire mhin takes the silver ring at Anna Ruadh's new stone-walled contest field, and eats the crown's meal at the same board as every man he beat under the queen's own new law, a custom he is said never afterward to have forgotten at any table.¹¹
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,822** — *A wood-watcher in the red hall* (Cathair dhearg). Anna Ruadh keeps a wood-watcher from Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹² in her household at Cathair dhearg to read the omens of the hall. So the rite of the wood-watchers, the rite of Macha, goddess of sovereignty and of horses, first comes to the capital. The Keeper sends a protest from Dùn ìseal, and the rolls give no answer.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,822** — *The wood-watcher reads a message home before it comes* (Cathair dhearg). In Anna Ruadh's household at Cathair dhearg the wood-watcher out of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹³ reads the crossing of three geese and tells the queen, unasked, that a message she had given up waiting for will come within the week; an answer to a year-old letter reaches her on the sixth day, and no one in the household troubles him with idle questions after.¹⁴

9. ← Follows from *Anna Ruadh at Ceann mhin*, 12 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,816.

10. ← Follows from *Anna Ruadh at Ceann mhin*, 12 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,816.

11. ← Follows from *The contest at Ceann leathan in stone*, 11 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,819.

12. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

13. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

14. ← Follows from *A wood-watcher in the red hall*, 23 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,822.

- 7 **AN GEARRAN, FE 2,823** — *The Keeper protests the wood-watcher in the red hall* (Dùn iséal). The Keeper at Dùn iséal sends a protest up the road Anna Ruadh walked, asking by what right a hall built on the Binding keeps an omen-reader who answers to no measure of the vein. No answer is remembered.¹⁵
- 24 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,826** — *Cathair dhombain and the wood-watchers* (Cathair dhomhain). The shrine at Cathair dhomhain, proud of its strict keeping of the Law, will take no wood-watcher, and its people say that the capital has given its omens to folk who sit in trees. From this the rivalry of the two towns takes a turn in matters of faith that it never loses.
- 14 **AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,826** — *Cathair dhombain doubles its own strictness in answer* (Cathair dhomhain). Cathair dhomhain's shrine, stung by the capital's wood-watcher, doubles its own cutter's visits to the Keeper's measure without being asked, and for a hundred years after a Cathair dhomhain man swearing an oath is known on the roads by how exactly he keeps to its letter.¹⁶
- 11 **AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,828** — *Anna Ruadh has the toll rolls read at her bedside* (Cathair dhearg). In her last winter Anna Ruadh has the toll rolls of the sunny house and of Slighe Cnoc leathan read aloud to her twice, as if to be sure the charter still stands as she had it cut, and asks after no other matter of state.
- 26 **AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,829** — *Death of Anna Ruadh* (Cathair dhearg). Anna Ruadh dies at Cathair dhearg and is buried at Dùn dhearg among the house of Ìomhar and the kings of her own house. Her son Coinneach Bàn takes the hall.¹⁷
- 4 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,829** — *The council keeps the hall in Coinneach Bàn's name* (Cathair dhearg). After Anna Ruadh's death the council at Cathair dhearg keeps the red hall three years in her son's name before Coinneach Bàn, at seven-and-twenty, takes it in his own.¹⁸
- 27 **AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,832** — *Coinneach Bàn* (Cathair dhearg). Coinneach Bàn rules long and quietly from Cathair dhearg. In his reign the clerks of the hall begin to copy the rolls for the provinces, so that each province seat has its own copy of the laws. Several of those copies survive where the first writings are lost.¹⁹
- 23 **AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,832** — *Coinneach Bàn begins the copying of the provincial rolls* (Cathair dhearg). Coinneach Bàn, choosing a clerk's work over his mother's roads, has every province seat send its own laws to Cathair dhearg to be copied fresh, and reads each copy through himself before it is shelved, so that within a decade a province's own clerks trust the capital's copy of their rolls sooner than the damp-spoiled skins in their own keeping.²⁰

15. ← Follows from *A wood-watcher in the red hall*, 23 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,822; ← Follows from *The wood-watcher reads a message home before it comes*, 16 an t-Samhain, FE 2,822.

16. ← Follows from *Cathair dhombain and the wood-watchers*, 24 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,826; ← Follows from *The Keeper protests the wood-watcher in the red hall*, 7 an Gearran, FE 2,823.

17. → Caused by *Anna Ruadh has the toll rolls read at her bedside*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,828.

18. ← Follows from *Death of Anna Ruadh*, 26 an Cèitean, FE 2,829.

19. → Caused by *The council keeps the hall in Coinneach Bàn's name*, 4 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,829.

20. ← Follows from *Coinneach Bàn*, 27 an Giblean, FE 2,832; ← Follows from *The council keeps the hall in Coinneach Bàn's name*, 4 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,829.

- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,832** — *A second clerk keeps the unstruck preface* (Dùn ìseal). Before the knife reaches the Keepers' roll, the clerk Seumas Bàn sends for has already made a copy of the count of his own house for his own hand; it is that unstruck copy, kept quietly through the rest of the age, and not the scraped preface, that answers for the fact today.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,835** — *Seumas Bàn keeps the flame* (Dùn ìseal). Seumas Bàn of Sliochd Mhuirich²¹ is chosen Keeper. Reading the Hall's roll at Dùn ìseal he finds that more than half the Keepers of the age were of his own house, and has the fact struck from the preface. The unstruck copy survives.²²
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,836** — *Seumas Bàn reckons two Keepers in three of his house* (Dùn ìseal). Going beyond the count of names, Seumas Bàn reckons how many of the remaining Keepers married into Sliochd Mhuirich²³ or fostered a child of it, and finds the true share near two in every three.²⁴
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,838** — *The rites counted at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Seumas Bàn has the clerks of the Hall list every rite on the island that burns the handful and every one that lays claim to the vein, that the council may know what it keeps. The list holds the Hall's own rite, the ancestor-keeping of the old folk, the dawn-hawk of the north coast, the wood-watchers of the west, the wolf-sworn, the sting-oath, and both schools of the stag. The clerks write that a thousand years before no such list would have been needed.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,840** — *The hawk-keepers refuse the Hall's cutter* (Seann Skell). The hawk-keepers of Seann Skell turn away the Hall's cutter who comes to try their measure, saying their measure is the hawk's, and the hawk is not the Keeper's. The cutter goes home with the refusal in writing. No rite had refused the trial of the measure outright before.
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,840** — *Ealasaid Bhàn writes the hawk-keepers' refusal into hide* (Seann Skell). Ealasaid Bhàn, eldest of the fowler households of Seann Skell, meets the Hall's cutter Ruairidh Òg at her own door and tells him the dawn measure is the hawk's and not the Keeper's, allowing him only to watch from the yard as any neighbour might, and setting the answer down in a strip of hide so that no cutter after him could mistake it.²⁵
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,840** — *A guard swears the Fianna's new oath at Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). A young road-guard swears the first of the graver oaths at Caol leathan's new hall, hand flat on the white stone in a room still smelling of fresh mortar, and tells his own household after that the stone had felt warm under his palm, though the mason who set it swears he cut and laid nothing but plain grey rock from the town's own quarry.²⁶

21. the house of Muireach

22. ← Leads to *A second clerk keeps the unstruck preface*, 8 an Lùnastal, FE 2,832.

23. the house of Muireach

24. ← Follows from *Seumas Bàn keeps the flame*, 16 an t-Samhain, FE 2,835; ← Follows from *A second clerk keeps the unstruck preface*, 8 an Lùnastal, FE 2,832.

25. ← Follows from *The hawk-keepers refuse the Hall's cutter*, 19 an t-Sultain, FE 2,840.

26. ← Follows from *Ealasaid Bhàn writes the hawk-keepers' refusal into hide*, 17 an Dàmhair, FE 2,840.

- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,842** — *The province seats send their laws to Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Seat after seat sends its clerk down to Cathair dhearg with the district's laws copied fresh, and Coinneach Bàn reads every copy himself before it is shelved. Within a decade the seats send to the capital for copies of their own rolls, their own skins having gone to the damp.²⁷
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,843** — *The wolf-sworn build a hall* (Caol leathan). The wolf-sworn of Caol leathan build a hall of their own about the white wolf-stone at the town gate, and swear oaths there that are no longer road-guards' oaths. The stone, they say, watches the whole island as the guard watches the road, and will cry out beneath the rightful king. From this hall comes Òrd na Cloiche²⁸, the order of the Stone, and the wolf-sworn begin to be called the Fianna.²⁹
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,846** — *The sting-oath at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). At Seann Skell in the west the sting-oath of the harbour court becomes a creed. Its keepers hold that one power stings the liar wherever he may be, Manannan mac Lir, lord of the sea, and that the scorpion is but his sign; theirs is the first teaching on the island to call itself the only true one, and the Hall's roll sets it down as new. Thereafter the oath is sworn over a cup marked with the scorpion, Manannan's Cup of Truth, which is said to break in three at three lies spoken over it and to be made whole by three truths. Òrd Mhanannain³⁰ dates itself from this court.
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,849** — *Seann Vell swears on the sting* (Seann Vell). Seann Vell, on the western coast below Cuan shean, takes up the sting-oath of its neighbours. Its shrine keeps a scorpion carved in yellow stone, the first image of the creature made for worship and not for swearing on.
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,849** — *A gravestone-cutter carves Seann Vell's scorpion from a fisherman's telling* (Seann Vell). The stonecutter who carves Seann Vell's yellow scorpion, better known till then for gravestones than for shrines, works from a fisherman's account of one washed up dead on the strand, having no living creature shown to her, so that the image every child of the town learns to fear owes as much to a fisher's memory as to the god it serves.³¹
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,852** — *The dark wood keeps its own rite* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag³²). The wood-watchers of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag cease to send to the Hall for judgement of their quarrels, and judge them under the trees. They hold that the black beast has two natures, one that keeps and one that devours, and that the vein has the same. The order of Macha afterwards tells of the two horses that drew one chariot, the black Dubh Sainglenn and the grey Liath Macha: two horses, one yoke.

27. ← Follows from *Coinneach Bàn*, 27 an Giblean, FE 2,832.

28. the order of the Stone

29. ← Leads to *A guard swears the Fianna's new oath at Caol leathan*, 14 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,840.

30. the order of Manannan

31. ← Follows from *Seann Vell swears on the sting*, 4 an t-Samhain, FE 2,849.

32. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

19 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,852 — *The wood-watchers judge a boundary quarrel under the trees.*

A cutter of Cnoc bhàn and a fowler of the Abhainn íseal bring a boundary quarrel to the wood-watchers of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag³³ rather than to Dùn íseal, and both accept a judgement neither asked for: that the disputed scrub belongs to whoever feeds it through a hard winter, and to no one in an easy one.³⁴

5 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,852 — *The council's carpenters set the hawk-keepers nearest the door* (Dùn íseal). The carpenters who build the council's new benches at Dùn íseal, told only the number of heads for each company, set the hawk-keepers' bench nearest the door for no reason any clerk troubles to record, so that latecomers of every company after sit longest among strangers before reaching their own.

11 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,855 — *The common root of the orders.* The one folk-faith of the island begins plainly to divide into the several ways that later ages name apart: the orders of An Creideamh Sean³⁵, the Old Faith, and the hearth-keeping of Na Seann Spioradan³⁶, the Old Spirits. From this time the belief of the Dia-thírich is no longer one.

16 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,858 — *The council divided by rite* (Dùn íseal). The council at Dùn íseal, which had sat by hearth and by house, begins to sit in companies by rite. Seumas Bàn complains that he keeps the flame now for eight peoples, each of whom thinks itself its only keeper. The seating holds for the rest of the age.³⁷

15 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,860 — *Allt an Àigh³⁸ keeps its pilgrims* (Allt an Àigh). Pilgrims of every rite go on walking to Allt an Àigh in the right quarter of the moon; it is the one custom of the island that the Hall's list sets under no company. In one season the path from Caol shean is paved anew by pilgrims of four rites.

20 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,860 — *Pilgrims of four rites mend the path to Allt an Àigh³⁹* (Allt an Àigh). Pilgrims of four rites, meeting on the path from Caol shean by no arrangement, fall to mending its worn stones together, hawk-keeper beside wolf-sworn beside a stag scholar, and finish the work before any asks whether the others belong there.⁴⁰

19 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,863 — *The springs at Muileann ruadh common to all* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh⁴¹). The keeper of the springs at Muileann ruadh rules that the sick of every rite shall be bathed without asking which. Her ruling is copied into the rolls of the provinces. It is the last ruling of the age on which every company of the council agrees.

33. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

34. ← Follows from *The dark wood keeps its own rite*, 13 am Faoilleach, FE 2,852; ← Follows from *A gravestone-cutter carves Seann Vell's scorpion from a fisherman's telling*, 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,849.

35. the Old Faith

36. the Old Spirits

37. ← Leads to *The council's carpenters set the hawk-keepers nearest the door*, 5 an t-Samhain, FE 2,852.

38. the stream of the healing water

39. the stream of the healing water

40. ← Follows from *Allt an Àigh keeps its pilgrims*, 15 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,860.

- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,863** — *Beathag Fhionn rules the springs open to every company* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh⁴²). Beathag Fhionn, keeper of the bath-house over the warm springs at Muileann ruadh, rules that the sick of every rite shall be carried up and bathed at dawn without being asked first which company they keep, and every province seat with a copy of anything at all copies her ruling into its own rolls that same season.⁴³
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,866** — *Cnoc dhìreach's weavers* (Cnoc dhìreach). The town of Cnoc dhìreach in the east, on the carriers' road south of the springs, becomes known for a heavy undyed cloth that the carriers wear on the high passes. It is not the grave-keepers' village by the old tombs, and the rolls tell the two Cnoc dhìreachs apart by that cloth.
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,869** — *The dyers of Muileann bhàn* (Muileann bhàn). The dyers of Muileann bhàn in the eastern hills learn to fix a pale blue from a hill plant, and the carriers' cloth of all the mountain country is dyed there. The Keepers wear it undyed, and say so.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,872** — *Muileann dhombhain's mill* (Muileann dhomhain). A water-mill is built at Muileann dhomhain in the eastern hills to grind the grain of the common granaries of the mountain districts. The miller keeps one measure in sixteen, and the rolls call it fair.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,875** — *The flood at Àth chiar* (Àth chiar). Rain on the eastern hills brings the river over the ford at Àth chiar, and it carries off the carriers' shelter and six of the townfolk. The common granary of the district stands on a rise, is untouched, and feeds the town through the winter.
- 24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,878** — *The oyster-beds of Seann Bhral* (Seann Bhral). The people of Seann Bhral on the south-eastern coast begin to lay oyster-beds in the shallows, a craft that came, they say, with the name of their town. The Library's copy of the provincial roll sets down the claim and marks it doubtful.
- 20 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,880** — *Seann Vell's harbour* (Seann Vell). Seann Vell on the south-eastern coast grows into a city on the southern fishing and the silver of Muileann chiar brought down the eastern road. Its harbour is the first on the island with a stone quay.
- 19 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,880** — *Death of Seumas Bàn* (Dùn ìseal). Seumas Bàn dies at Dùn ìseal in his eightieth year, having kept the flame five-and-forty years, and in all that time seen none of the eight companies sit again by hearth and house.⁴⁴

41. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

42. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

43. ← Follows from *The springs at Muileann ruadh common to all*, 19 an t-Sultain, FE 2,863; ← Follows from *Pilgrims of four rites mend the path to Allt an Àigh*, 20 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,860.

44. ← Follows from *The council divided by rite*, 16 an t-Samhain, FE 2,858; ← Follows from *Beathag Fhionn rules the springs open to every company*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,863.

- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,883** — *The light at Tobar dhearg rebuilt* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg⁴⁵). The old beacon at Tobar dhearg on the southern cape is rebuilt as a stone tower with the fire on its top, the first sea-light raised above the ground. It burns seal-oil of the north-west, carried the whole length of the island.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,886** — *Muileann naomh's mill-shrine* (Muileann naomh). At Muileann naomh on the southern coast a mill and a shrine share one roof, and the miller keeps the shrine's handful beside his millstones. The Keeper's cutter who comes to try it finds the measure kept and the flour good.
- 21 AM MÀRT, FE 2,889** — *Dùn thais walled* (Dùn thais). Dùn thais in the eastern hills is walled, and a temple of the stag's people is raised within it, the first of theirs built in stone and not kept in a grove. The elder school at Cnoc bhàn sends it teachers.
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,892** — *The wool-fair of Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). Inis mhòr holds a wool-fair at every shearing, and buyers come to it from all the northern coast and some from Cathair dhearg. Its silver is weighed on the Muileann chiar weights sent to the northern road.
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,895** — *Baile Mòr mhòr on the northern coast* (Baile Mòr mhòr). Baile Mòr mhòr, on the northern coast west of Seann Toll, grows great enough on the fishing to send its own member to the council at Dùn ìseal. The Four Houses dislike it, and seat its member at the foot of the hall.
- 23 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,896** — *Coinneach Bàn dies at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Coinneach Bàn, who had copied the laws for every province, dies in his own bed at the red hall in the ninety-first year of his life. His son Coinneach Donn takes up the cup without any meeting of the Four Houses being called.
- 24 AM MÀRT, FE 2,896** — *Coinneach Donn takes the red hall without a meeting* (Cathair dhearg). Coinneach Bàn's son Coinneach Donn takes the red hall as sons of that house always have, with no meeting of the Four Houses; outlying reeves learn of one rìgh's death and the next rìgh's holding from the same line of a roll.⁴⁶
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,898** — *The northern boats at Seann Toll* (Seann Toll). The harbour at Seann Toll becomes the home of the northern fishing fleet. Its boatbuilders make the longest craft on the island, built for a day's run along the coast and never for open water.
- 15 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,900** — *Drought at Achadh shean* (Achadh shean). A dry summer burns the pastures round Achadh shean in the east, and by spring the district's common granary is empty. Grain is sent from Baile chaol and Cuan ruadh under the shared-meal law, and the district repays it over the harvests after.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,903** — *Baile chaol's repayment* (Baile chaol). The rolls at Baile chaol set down the repayment of the drought grain by Achadh shean, measure by measure, to the last. The clerk adds that no such debt in the rolls was repaid in full before.

45. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

46. ← Follows from *Coinneach Bàn dies at Cathair dhearg*, 23 an Gearran, FE 2,896.

- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,906** — *The panthers late* (Imrich nam Pantar⁴⁷). The great cats cross the southern road late, and fewer than the carriers remember. The weather-watchers read it for a hard winter, and are right. The Keepers note it without remark.
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,909** — *The watch-tower at Baile ruadh* (Baile ruadh). A timber watch-tower is raised at Baile ruadh on the north-eastern coast to look out for raiders from the islands, manned by turns by the fisher-kin of Sliochd Raghnaill⁴⁸. It is the only tower of war the age builds.
- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,912** — *Cuan ruadh's boats* (Cuan ruadh). The fishers of Cuan ruadh on the eastern coast give boats and men to the watch against the island raiders. In return Sliochd Raghnaill⁴⁹ gives the town a place on the council at Dùn iséal beside its own seat.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,915** — *The drowned-feast at Inis chrom* (Inis chrom). At Inis chrom on the western coast the families of the drowned hold a feast on the shore each year and set an empty place for each of the lost. The custom spreads to the harbours northward as far as Seann Warr⁵⁰.
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,918** — *The potters of Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). Potters at Baile ghorm on the south-western coast begin to fire a hard red ware of the local clay, and their jars carry the oil and grain of the western road. Sherds of it lie on every waypoint-house site the Library's surveyors have walked.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,920** — *Cnoc àrsaidh's kilns* (Cnoc àrsaidh). Potters of Baile ghorm set up new kilns at Cnoc àrsaidh in the south-west, where the clay is better and the wood nearer. There the red ware of the western road is made for the rest of the age.
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,923** — *Cathair fhada grows* (Cathair fhada). Families leaving the crowded harbours about Cathair dhearg settle at Cathair fhada on the southern coast and raise its long street along the ridge. They bring a wood-watcher with them, and a copy of the laws.
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,926** — *Cnoc naomh's ancestor-shrine* (Cnoc naomh). The people of Cnoc naomh keep a shrine to the ancestors and to the sith of the hill in the old folk way, with no hawk, wolf, sting or stag in it. The Hall's list of rites names them among the keepers of the old reverence, which by now is a company of its own.
- 25 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,927** — *Coinneach Donn dies* (Cathair dhearg). Coinneach Donn, who has held the cup thirty years and more since his father's death, dies in the eighty-seventh year of his own life at Cathair dhearg, leaving a daughter, Mòr, not yet twenty-three, and a younger brother, Tormod Donn.⁵¹

47. the panthers' crossing

48. the house of Raghnaill

49. the house of Raghnaill

50. a harbour beside Seann Mhorn on Loch chrom, resettled with its old name kept

51. ← Follows from *Coinneach Donn takes the red ball without a meeting*, 24 am Màrt, FE 2,896.

27 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,928 — *Tormod Donn's claim before the Four Houses* (Dùn ìseal).

Tormod Donn brings a claim to the Four Houses at Dùn ìseal against his niece Mòr, arguing that a man of the same blood and twice her years stands the plainer heir. The Houses split, two benches for Mòr and two for neither.⁵²

5 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,929 — *Catrìona nic Mhuirich speaks for Mòr before the Four Houses*

(Dùn ìseal). With the houses split and the winter spent, the Keeper Catrìona nic Mhuirich tells them the red hall is no business of the Hall's to give, but that she will set the stone cup in Mòr's hands, as once in Gilleasbuig Mòr's, if they ask it, and in no one else's.⁵³

15 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,929 — *Mòr nic Coinnich crowned* (Cathair dhearg).

Mòr nic Coinnich, granddaughter of Coinneach Bàn, takes the red hall at Cathair dhearg. The Keeper Catrìona nic Mhuirich sets the stone cup in her hands at Dùn ìseal, as the houses had done for Gilleasbuig Mòr. Hers is the last name written in the king-list of the Holy Age.⁵⁴

8 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,929 — *Tormod Donn yields* (Cuan ruadh).

Tormod Donn withdraws his claim by his own steward's word, sent from his house at Cuan ruadh, after Catrìona nic Mhuirich tells the Four Houses she will set the cup in no hand but Mòr's. It is the last such claim the house of Tormod contests.⁵⁵

30 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,929 — *Mòr asks the Keeper whether her uncle's claim was wicked*

(Dùn ìseal). Taking the cup at Dùn ìseal, Mòr asks Catrìona low whether her uncle's claim was wicked or only foolish. The Keeper answers that few claims are purely either, and that Mòr should spend her reckoning on the hall's keeping, not her uncle's punishing. Mòr brings no charge.⁵⁶

18 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,931 — *Mòr weds Dòmhnall Dubh* (Cathair dhearg).

Mòr nic Coinnich weds Dòmhnall Dubh of Sliochd Raghnaill⁵⁷, whose kin keep the watch-tower at Baile ruadh. He holds no office at the red hall and keeps, through her reign, to his own house's trade of boats and coastwatch.⁵⁸

2 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,939 — *The Hall's roll at the close of the age* (Dùn ìseal).

At the close of the age the Keepers' roll holds one hundred and forty names, from Beathag Bhàn to Catrìona nic Mhuirich, and the king-list more than ninety, from Goraidh Mòr to Mòr nic Coinnich. The Small-Burning Law is unchanged in any word since the stone cup of Fionnlagh Dall, and the cup stands yet on the threshold of Talla na Lasrach⁵⁹ at Dùn ìseal.

52. ← Follows from *Coinneach Donn dies*, 25 am Faoilleach, FE 2,927.

53. ← Follows from *Tormod Donn's claim before the Four Houses*, 27 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,928.

54. → Caused by *Catrìona nic Mhuirich speaks for Mòr before the Four Houses*, 5 an Gearran, FE 2,929.

55. ← Follows from *Mòr nic Coinnich crowned*, 15 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,929; ← Follows from *Catrìona nic Mhuirich speaks for Mòr before the Four Houses*, 5 an Gearran, FE 2,929.

56. ← Follows from *Mòr nic Coinnich crowned*, 15 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,929; ← Follows from *Tormod Donn yields*, 8 an Lùnastal, FE 2,929.

57. the house of Raghnaill

58. ← Follows from *Mòr asks the Keeper whether her uncle's claim was wicked*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,929.

59. the Hall of the Flame

- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,940** — *Death of Tormod Donn* (Cuan ruadh). Tormod Donn, who once claimed the red hall against his niece, dies at Cuan ruadh, and his line ends with him, leaving no son to trouble the succession after.
- I AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,949** — *The last age of even population*. So ends the Holy Age. The long years had gone out of the king's kin many generations before its end, and the chroniclers of after days look back on its later centuries with some unease: they are the last time in the history of Dia-thìr that no family's lives ran longer than any other's.
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,950** — *Dòmhnall Dubh dies at Baile ruadh* (Baile ruadh). Dòmhnall Dubh dies in the fiftieth year of his own life among his own kin at Baile ruadh rather than at Cathair dhearg. Mòr goes north herself to see him buried beside the watch-tower his house has kept three generations.
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,950** — *Mòr goes north to bury Dòmhnall Dubh* (Baile ruadh). Mòr nic Coinnich goes north herself to see her husband buried beside the watch-tower at Baile ruadh that his house has kept three generations, a journey no rìgh has made in living memory for a husband's burying.⁶⁰
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,953** — *Mòr nic Coinnich dies* (Cathair dhearg). Mòr nic Coinnich dies at Cathair dhearg, leaving two daughters, Beathag and Mòrag, and no brother, uncle or cousin near enough in blood to raise a claim. Hers is the last name the Holy Age itself sets down in the king-list.⁶¹
- II AN GEARRAN, FE 2,953** — *Beathag crowned at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag nic Dhòmhnail, not yet sixteen, is crowned at Cathair dhearg within the month of her mother's death, by her own house's word and the Four Houses' assent, rather than by a winter journey to Dùn ìseal for the stone cup.⁶²
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,953** — *Ruairidh Clèireach begins the new roll* (Cathair dhearg). Finding the old skin of the king-list and the Keepers' roll filled to its last line with Mòr's name, the clerk Ruairidh Clèireach begins a new skin and sets Beathag's name at its head, so that no name later than Mòr's stands in the old roll.⁶³
- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,953** — *Catriona offers to receive the young rìgh at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Catriona nic Mhuirich, past threescore, sends word that she stands ready to receive the young Beathag at Dùn ìseal whenever the roads and season allow. The journey is not made in Beathag's first year, nor troubled over again while the roll of the age is kept.⁶⁴

60. ↓ Legacy *The watch-tower at Baile ruadh*, 13 an Lùnastal, FE 2,909; ← Follows from *Dòmhnall Dubh dies at Baile ruadh*, 26 an Dàmhair, FE 2,950.

61. ← Follows from *The Hall's roll at the close of the age*, 2 an Giblean, FE 2,939; ← Follows from *Mòr goes north to bury Dòmhnall Dubh*, 24 an t-Samhain, FE 2,950.

62. ← Follows from *Mòr nic Coinnich dies*, 13 am Faoilleach, FE 2,953.

63. ← Follows from *The Hall's roll at the close of the age*, 2 an Giblean, FE 2,939; ← Follows from *Beathag crowned at Cathair dhearg*, 11 an Gearran, FE 2,953.

64. ← Follows from *Ruairidh Clèireach begins the new roll*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,953.

23 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,953 — *The old roll closed on Mòr's name* (Cathair dhearg). The skin of the king-list and the Keepers' roll kept since Coinneach Bàn's day is full to its last line with Mòr's name and her count. Ruairidh Clèireach closes it and lays it in the chest with every roll of the Hall before it, so that no name later than Mòr's stands on it.⁶⁵

65. ← Follows from *The Hall's roll at the close of the age*, 2 an Giblean, FE 2,939; ← Follows from *Catriona offers to receive the young rìgh at Dùn ìseal*, 2 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,953.